THE SORCERER'S CROWN

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Book Four of The Lattice Chronicles

THE SKILL JUNKY

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First edition.

For everyone who sat with someone at the end,
and for everyone who left a light on.

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If the dark comes calling, love, don't you fear.
There's a light in the window, and I'm right here.

— The Lantern Song

PROLOGUE

The Thorn-Crowned

SHE HAD BEEN DREAMING of roses for nine hundred years.

Not the same rose. Never the same one. That was the mercy of it. Her dreams had always been gardens, ever since she was a girl, and the gardens in them grew. A red rose by a white wall. A yellow one climbing an apple tree. A dark one, nearly black, that smelled of cloves and rain, in a stone trough by a kitchen door. A bed of small pink ones in a cabbage patch, where a girl in a grey dress sat with her knees up, talking to a puddle.

She dreamed them all. One after another. Down the long years. Down in the warm close silk-dark of the cocoon, where there was no light and no time and no hunger, or not much, or not enough to wake for.

She dreamed them and they bloomed and she was happy.

And then she woke up, and they were thorns.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WOKE BECAUSE SOMEONE had put a hand on her.

She felt it through the silk. Big. Heavy. Hot. Flat on the cocoon over her breastbone, the way you'd lay a hand on a door to feel if there was a fire behind it.

She knew that hand.

She'd known it all her life. It had lifted her onto a pony when she was four. It had slapped her once, when she was twelve and had said something about their father. It had held a gold cup to her lips on the last evening, in the hall, by the pool, and tipped it, gently, and said *drink, Rosie, it's only water*.

"*Wake*," said her brother. "*Rhosyn. Wake up.*"

His voice was rough. Rough as a road. She'd never heard it rough before. It had always been warm and deep and easy, a voice that filled a room the way a fire fills a grate.

It filled this one too. But it had broken something on the way.

"*Our sister is dead*," said the Gilded King.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME OUT OF the silk slowly.

Not like him. She could tell he'd come out all at once; she could smell it on the air, torn silk, a great sour rip of it. That was Oszric. He'd always got out of bed like a man leaping off a cart.

She came out like a seed comes out of the ground. Slowly. A crack of grey-gold light. A seam opening. Her hands first, pushing. Then her face. Dust everywhere. Her own dust. Nine hundred years of it, pouring off her shoulders onto the glass floor with a sound like a long sigh.

She knelt on the floor of the hall in the dust and breathed.

It hurt.

Everything hurt. Her joints. Her skin. Her eyes, which had been closed so long they had forgotten how to see anything but dark. And under it all, low and slow and steady, the thing that had hurt the whole time and that she had slept through by going down very deep.

The hunger.

It woke when she did. It always had. It stretched in her like a cat on a hearth and opened its eyes and looked about for something to drink.

There was nothing.

There had been nothing for nine hundred years.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Up*," said Oszric. "*Come on. Up.*"

His hand under her elbow. Hot. Lifting. She let him lift her. She'd always let him. She stood in the dust with her knees shaking and looked at him.

He was the same. That was the terrible thing. Nine hundred years and he was exactly the same. Tall. Huge. A great gold beard to the middle of his chest and gold hair to his shoulders and skin like old ivory. His gold crown of leaves on his head, a little crooked, the way he'd always worn it, as if he'd put it on in a hurry on his way to somewhere more important.

Only his eyes had changed.

She remembered them brown. Warm brown. Their mother's eyes. Laughing at her over the rim of a cup.

They were furnaces now. White and gold and roaring. Like looking into the mouth of a forge. She had to look away.

"*Mae's dead*?" she whispered.

"*Yes*."

"*How*?"

He didn't answer. He held out his other hand.

There was a crown in it.

Silver wire. Fine as frost. Shaped like a pair of folded wings.

Rhosyn looked at it for a long time.

She remembered it on a head of silver hair, bending over a sickbed. Over a little girl with a fever, in the dark, in a room with a toy bear on the windowsill. She remembered Maelis's voice, low and kind, telling a story about a girl who married a bear.

She remembered her standing at the edge of the pool on the last evening with her cupped hands full of light, saying *it isn't wrong, Rosie. It's just a spring.*

"*Oh*," said Rhosyn. "*Oh, Mae.*"

And she began to cry.

◆ ◆ ◆

OSZRIC LET HER.

He stood in the dust with the silver crown in his hand and watched her cry, the way he'd watched her cry over dead birds when she was small. Not unkindly. Not kindly either. Patiently. The way a man waits for rain to stop before he goes out.

When she'd finished he put the crown back inside his robe. Against his chest. Over his heart.

"*Better*?"

"*No*."

"*No*," he agreed. "*Nor me.*" His furnace eyes moved down the hall. "*Come. The others are up. Orrin's going to tell you all of it, and then I'm going to tell you what we're going to do.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE OTHERS WERE UP.

She saw them as she came down the hall behind her brother, her bare feet in the dust, her thin legs shaking.

Four cocoons. Torn, all four. Hanging from the high glass rafters like empty sacks. And a fifth at the end, split from top to bottom, long empty. Hers, Oszric's, Ysenne's, Caddoc's. Maelis's. Under each one a dark place on the floor where a crown had lain in the dust for nine centuries and left its shape.

And at the end of the hall, by the tall glass doors, in the grey-gold light that came from nowhere, her brother and her sister. Waiting.

Ysenne first.

She was sitting on the floor. Of course she was. Sitting on the floor of the hall in her long white gown with her knees drawn up and her face bent down, close to the glass, looking at herself.

The floor was dusty. There was nothing to see. She'd wiped a patch clean with her sleeve. A small round patch, like a hand-mirror. And she was looking into it.

She was beautiful. She'd always been the beautiful one. Maelis had been lovely, and Rhosyn had been pretty, once, when she was young and pink and smelled of roses. But Ysenne was *beautiful* the way a cut stone is beautiful. Sharp-cheeked. Long-necked. Her skin so pale it was nearly clear, with a faint cold glitter in it, like frost on a window. Her hair white. Her eyes the pale grey of ice over deep water. Her crown a narrow band of glass, perfectly clear, so you could only see it when the light caught it.

She didn't look up.

"*Rosie*," she said to her reflection. "*You've got thin.*"

"*So have you*."

"*I know*." Ysenne turned her face, a little. Studied the line of her jaw in the cleaned glass. "*It suits me. It doesn't suit you. You look like a broom.*"

And beside her, standing, with his arms crossed over his chest—

Caddoc.

He hadn't changed either. He'd never changed. Not since they were children. He'd been born looking forty, their nurse used to say, and he'd stayed looking forty ever after. Square and dark and heavy. A face like a closed door. Black hair cut short as a soldier's. And his crown, which was not a crown at all, but a plain band of black iron, a hand wide and a finger thick, with no ornament on it of any kind. Like a manacle. Like the iron ring of a gate.

He looked at Rhosyn as she came down the hall.

He nodded. Once.

He'd always done that. He'd nodded at her when she was born, their mother said. Just looked into the cradle and nodded, as if confirming that a delivery had arrived as ordered.

"*Sister*," said Caddoc.

"*Brother*."

That was all. That was Caddoc. He'd said perhaps four thousand words to her in their whole lives before the drinking, and perhaps four hundred since, and every one of them had been exactly what he meant.

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AND KNEELING ON THE glass at their feet, in the dust, with his brow nearly touching the floor—

Orrin.

She hardly knew him. She remembered a steward. A tall thin careful man in grey with a gold chain, who walked half a step behind Oszric everywhere and carried a ledger and never smiled. Who'd held the cup for the servants, on the last night, after the Ten had finished. Who'd drunk the dregs.

This wasn't a man.

It was the shape of one. Grey. Thin as a rake. Bent. Its skin like old paper, its hands like bundles of twigs. The gold chain gone black round its neck. And its eyes—two dim sparks, barely lit, like the ends of pipes glowing in a dark room.

He'd been awake the whole time. She realized it, looking at him. Nine hundred years. Not in a cocoon. Not asleep. Awake. Kneeling. Waiting on the King.

"*Majesty*," whispered Orrin. To her. "*Majesty. You wake.*"

She didn't know what to say to that.

So she said, "*Thank you, Orrin*," the way she'd said it to the gardeners when they brought her the first buds of spring.

The dim sparks of his eyes flickered.

She thought, for a moment, he might cry.

He didn't. He had nothing left to cry with. He bowed his head lower, and the dust slid off his shoulders, and he began to tell her how her sister had died.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK A LONG time.

Orrin told it the way stewards tell things. In order. Plainly. With dates.

The Veil loosening. A light lit before a door, far away. Maelis waking, and going through, alone, and some of her household coming apart against the edge as they followed. The young Well. Full again. Rising. The smith. The warden. The Harrow woman, coming up out of the dark.

Maelis drinking, once, in the deep. Growing bright. *Sovereign*. Their sister, Sovereign, in a world with no Ceiling.

And then the room. A hundred miles of it. Cut into the ground by people with spades. The Well coming up into it. The hewer's pick. The smith's little hammer. The flaw.

Everything she'd ever drunk, nine hundred years of it, pouring out of her down the point of a pick.

And then—

Orrin stopped.

"*Say it*," said Oszric. Very quietly. He'd heard it already. He wanted to hear it again. Rhosyn could see it in his face, in the white roar of his eyes. He wanted to hear it every time someone told it, the way you press on a bruise.

"*And then a Harrow woman knelt down in front of her*," whispered Orrin. "*And gave her a lamp.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*And she took it*," said Orrin. "*And it stayed. In the middle of her. Where she was always cold.*" He was shaking. "*And she was warm. And she came apart into light.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN STOOD IN THE dust with her hands pressed together under her chin.

A Harrow woman.

She didn't hear the rest. She heard Ysenne say something sharp about lamps. She heard Caddoc say nothing at all. She heard Oszric's breath go in and out, slow, like a bellows.

She heard only the name.

Harrow.

She didn't know it. It wasn't a name from home. But Orrin had said *Hesper's line*, and *the tenth*, and *the sister who wouldn't drink*, and Rhosyn had felt something in her chest she had not felt for nine hundred years.

Not hunger.

Something older.

Oh, Hes, she thought. *You had children. You had a line. You had daughters, and they had daughters.*

You lived.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*So*," said Oszric.

He turned round. Away from the doors. Toward them. The four of them. The last four of the Ten. In the dust, in the hall, under the empty cocoons, in the grey-gold light.

He looked enormous. He always had. When he stood in a room the room arranged itself round him, like iron filings round a lodestone. He'd been like that at nine years old.

"*Our sister went first*," said the Gilded King. "*As she always did. She went toward the light and she drank it and they killed her for it.*" His voice was very even. "*A smith. A warden. A hewer. A Harrow woman with a lamp.*"

"*And three hundred and fourteen miles of people with spades*," murmured Ysenne. To her reflection.

"*And them*."

He looked at each of them in turn.

"*There's a crack in the Veil*," said Oszric. "*Low down. A finger wide. Our sister's last moth brought Harrow blood to it. Hesper's blood. The blood the Veil never learned.*" His eyes burned. "*It opened. A little. Not enough. Not for us. Not yet.*"

"*Then what's the use of it*?" said Ysenne.

"*It's a beginning*."

"*It's a crack*." She looked up from the floor at last. Her ice-grey eyes on her brother. "*I can't get through a crack, Oz. None of us can. Mae could squeeze through when the knot was loose. Mae was always thin.*" She smiled. Faintly. "*You're not thin.*"

"*No*," said Oszric. "*But you don't need to be thin, sister. You only need to be seen.*"

Ysenne went very still.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Go and look*," said the Gilded King.

Ysenne looked at him for a long moment.

Then she bent her head back down to the small round patch of clean glass on the floor. To her own face in it.

And went in.

That was the only way Rhosyn could ever describe it, after. Ysenne didn't move. She didn't lean forward. She didn't change. She simply looked into her own reflection, close, closer, and then her reflection was looking back out at her, and then it was the reflection that was real and the woman on the floor that was the picture. And then neither of them was there at all, and the patch of glass on the floor was empty.

And then, far away, as if from the bottom of a well, Ysenne laughed.

It was a small, surprised, delighted laugh. Rhosyn hadn't heard it in nine hundred years. She'd forgotten it. A girl's laugh. A girl in a room full of mirrors trying on her mother's earrings.

"*Oh*," said Ysenne's voice. From the glass. From nowhere. "*Oh, Oz. Oh, look.*"

"*Tell us*."

"*Glass*," breathed the Glass Queen. "*So much glass. They have glass now. All of them. Not just palaces. Not just kings. Every house. Every cottage. Every inn. Windows. Little ones and big ones. Lanterns with glass in them. Bottles on shelves. Spectacles on old men's noses.*" Her voice was rapt. "*There's a girl in a kitchen in a town called*

Fenmoor holding up a pan to see if her hair's straight. I can see her. I can see right up her nose."

Caddoc grunted.

"*I can go anywhere*," said Ysenne. "*Through the crack. A finger's width. That's all a reflection needs. Oh, Oz. I can go everywhere.*"

"*Then go*," said Oszric. "*Look. Find them. The Harrow woman. Her sons. The child.*"

A pause. Far away, in the glass.

"*And then*?" said Ysenne.

"*And then come back and tell me what you saw*," said the Gilded King. "*And we'll decide what to take.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Caddoc.*"

Their brother uncrossed his arms.

"*The Key*," said Oszric.

Caddoc nodded.

He'd known. He'd been waiting. Rhosyn saw it in the set of his heavy shoulders. He'd been awake perhaps an hour longer than she had, and in that hour he'd worked it all out, the way he'd always worked things out, slowly and completely, like a man laying a stone wall.

"*The Veil's woven into their net*," said Caddoc. His voice was low and flat and rough with disuse, like a cart going over gravel. "*I felt it when I woke. Under the floor. Under the Court.*" He looked down. At the glass. At the dust. "*A thread.*"

"*One thread*?"

"*The last one*." Caddoc looked up. "*The little man with the hammer tied it last. When he was done. To hold the edge. It runs from here—*" he stamped one heavy foot on the glass "*—to the middle of their net. All the way down. To the knot at the bottom.*"

"*And the Key*?"

"*In the knot*." Caddoc's dark face didn't change. "*Barred. Someone's holding it. A man. Mostly thread now. Tired.*" He was quiet. "*I can feel him. On the other end. Like feeling a fish on a line.*"

Oszric's furnace eyes burned very bright.

"*Can you climb it*?"

"*Yes*."

"*How long*?"

Caddoc thought about it. He always thought before he answered. Even when they were children and their father asked him a sum. He'd stand there with his heavy

face screwed up while the others shouted out guesses, and then he'd say the right number, and their father would ruffle his hair, and he'd nod.

"*The world's wide*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown. "*And the thread goes down as well as across. And I'll have to ring it as I go, or it'll throw me off.*" He looked at his hands. Square. Heavy. "*Their autumn. The end of it. They light lanterns then. Orrin says.*"

"*Lantern Night*," murmured Orrin from the floor.

"*Then*," said Caddoc.

"*And when you get there*?"

"*I take the bar out*," said Caddoc. "*I take the Key. I bring it to you.*" He shrugged. A small heavy movement, like a boulder settling. "*And you turn it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN FOUND SHE WAS holding her breath.

She knew about the Key. They all did. The little man with the hammer had made it, the night he wove the world. Bow, bit and blade. A key that could undo anything it was turned against. Their father's scholars had whispered about it in the last days. *He's made a key. He can unlock the pool. He can unlock anything.*

"*Oz*," she said.

Her voice was very small. She hadn't meant it to come out at all.

He looked at her.

"*If you turn it*," said Rhosyn. "*The Key. In their net.*" She swallowed. "*What happens?*"

Her brother smiled.

It was the old smile. The warm one. The one from the pony and the gold cup and the hall. Their mother's smile, in a gold beard.

"*Ysenne*," he said. Not looking away from Rhosyn. "*Tell her what you told me. About their net.*"

From the glass, from very far away, the Glass Queen laughed.

"*It hasn't got a king*," she said.

Rhosyn stared.

"*It had one*," said Ysenne's voice. "*The little man with the hammer. And then his line, for a while. Vey. The smith is one. He held it.*" A pause. Delicious. "*And he gave it away, Rosie. Two years ago. He wove the whole net new and then he just took his hands off it and walked away.*"

"*Walked away—*"

"*It's lying there*," said Oszric softly. "*The whole thing. Every thread. Every knot. Every Ceiling and every level and every Stone. With nobody's hand on it.*" His furnace

eyes were very bright. "*A crown, Rosie. Lying in the road. And whoever turns that Key in the knot at the bottom—*"

He opened his great golden hand. Slowly. Palm up. Empty.

And closed it.

"*Picks it up*," said the Gilded King.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

She looked at her brother's closed hand. At the gold in it. At the gold in everything he'd ever touched.

She thought about the household. Theirs. Hers. His. The cooks and the grooms and the gardeners and the nurses and the stewards and the little scullery girls with red hands. Nine thousand people. Who'd come with them, on the boat, across the grey water, because they were the Ten's people, and where else would they go.

Who'd started to come apart, in the first years. When there was nothing left to drink.

And Oszric had gone out among them. Down the white road. With his hands.

And kept them.

She could see them from here. Through the tall glass doors. Along the road. Standing in the dust in their thousands, in rows, all the way to the edge of the sky. Gold.

She didn't look.

She never looked.

"*And Orrin*," said Oszric.

The steward lifted his head.

"*You'll go through*," said the Gilded King. "*You're dust, mostly. Dust goes through cracks. Take this.*" He reached into a fold of his robe and brought out something small. A pouch. Silk. Tied with a gold cord. It chimed faintly as it moved, like sand made of bells. "*A pinch of mine. For anyone who wants it.*"

Orrin took it in his twig-hands as if it were a sleeping bird.

"*Who'll want it, Majesty*?"

"*Everyone*," said Oszric. "*In the end. Everyone who's ever sat by a bed.*" He smiled. "*They die there, Orrin. In their world. Did you know? Our sister's moth saw it. They grow old and their hands shake and they die. All of them. Even the strong ones. Even the kings.*" His voice was very gentle. "*Offer them what I offered ours. They'll come. They always come.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And me*?" said Rhosyn.

They all looked at her.

Even Orrin. Even Caddoc. Even, far away, in the glass, she felt Ysenne look.

She hadn't meant to ask. It had come out of her the way the crying had. Small and stupid and unasked for.

Oszric looked down at her for a long moment.

"*You grow, sister*," he said. "*As you always did.*"

"*Grow—*"

"*Into the crack*." He nodded west. Toward the doors. Toward the white road and the plain and the edge of the world. "*Send your thorns into it. Into the stone. Push. Thorns are good at that. They get into a wall and they break it, slowly, from inside. Every gardener knows.*" His furnace eyes didn't blink. "*Widen it. For me. Make it wide enough for a king.*"

She looked at him.

"*And the child*?" she said. "*The smith's child. What will you do with her?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T ANSWER AT once.

He turned. Away from her. Toward the doors. And stood looking out at the white road, at the plain of grey-gold dust, at the far rows of his golden people. His back very broad. His hands at his sides.

"*Nine hundred years*," said the Gilded King.

Nobody spoke.

"*Nine hundred years, Rosie. And not one child.*" He didn't turn round. "*Not one. Not among us. Not among the household. Not among anyone who drank.*" His voice was quiet. "*We drank the thing that makes room. And there's been no room in us since. Not for anything new. Not for a child. Not for a thought we haven't had before. Not for a rose.*"

He looked back over his shoulder. At her. At her crown.

At the black thorns. Twisted. Dry. That had been roses once. Red ones. On a white wall.

She flinched.

"*She was born the night our sister died*," said Oszric. "*The smith's child. On the rubble. While the Well came home. I could smell her, when the crack opened. Through the crack. Like bread.*" He turned all the way round. "*Something new. Something that's never been anyone's. Full of room.*"

"*Oz—*"

"*I'll put a crown on her*," said the Gilded King. "*And I'll keep her. And she'll be ours. Forever. Just as she is. And the Court will have something in it, at last, that we didn't have before.*"

He smiled at his sister.

"*An heir, Rosie*," he said. "*Wouldn't that be nice?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LEFT THEM IN the hall.

She didn't ask permission. She'd never needed to. Nobody had ever cared very much where Rhosyn went, or what she did, so long as she came when she was called.

She went out through the tall glass doors. Onto the white road. Into the grey-gold light.

The road ran west. Straight as a ruler. Across the plain. Toward the edge of everything. White stone, the white of old bone, laid down nine hundred years ago by people who were still alive and still had hands.

They lined it now. On both sides. In rows.

She didn't look. She walked down the middle of the road with her eyes on her bare feet and her hands pressed together under her chin and she did not look.

But she heard them.

You couldn't not hear them. Not if you'd been a gardener. Not if you'd spent your whole girlhood listening for the small sounds things make when they're growing.

They didn't make those sounds.

That was what she heard. Nine thousand people standing in the dust in rows, gold from crown to heel, still as statues, still as stones. And not one of them breathing. Not one heart. Not one small shifting foot. The silence of nine thousand people who had been *kept*.

And under it, faint, so faint it was barely there at all—

Something like a hum. A held note. Like a finger run round the rim of a glass. Nine thousand voices that couldn't speak, all saying the same thing.

She'd heard it for nine hundred years. In her sleep. In her dreams of gardens.

She didn't know what it was saying.

She'd never let herself listen hard enough to find out.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THORNS BEGAN A mile off the road.

She'd grown them herself. Of course she had. Nobody else in the Court could grow anything. Thirty-two years ago, by the steward's reckoning. In the one hour she had been awake, between one long sleep and the next.

She didn't let herself think about that hour. Not yet.

She came off the white road onto the dust, and walked north, and the thorns rose up in front of her.

Black. Dry. Taller than the palace doors. Thick as a forest, thick as a wall, a great twisted tangle of hooked black stems running east and west as far as she could see and curling round in a ring a mile across. Every stem as thick as her wrist. Every thorn as long as her finger. Not a leaf on any of them. Not a bud.

They knew her.

They leaned toward her as she came. Very slightly. The way plants lean toward a window. And then, at her touch, they drew back. Creaking. Unhooking from one another. Opening a way.

She walked into the dark of them. And they closed again behind her.

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IN THE MIDDLE OF the ring, there was a tower.

A small one. Slender. No higher than a tall tree. Made of wood. Not cut wood. *Grown*. The living trunk of something that had been a great white-barked tree once, coaxed up and up and round on itself, twisted into the shape of a tower, with a door at the bottom and a window at the top and a little peaked roof of woven branches.

It was dead now. Grey. Cracked. The bark peeling. It had been dead for nine hundred years.

She'd grown it in the first year.

The first year of the exile. When they still had power to spare, and the drinking was still warm in them, and the household still had faces. Ysenne had built her palace of glass that year. Caddoc his of iron. Oszric his of gold. Maelis hadn't built anything at all; she'd sat at the window of the hall and looked west, toward the grey, toward the world, toward a light that wasn't there.

And Rhosyn had come out here. To the edge of the plain. And knelt in the dust. And put her hands flat on the ground.

And grown a tower for her little sister.

In case, she'd said. When the others found out and laughed. *In case she changes her mind. In case she comes. She'll want somewhere to sleep.*

Ysenne had laughed hardest.

Hesper never came.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN SAT DOWN IN the dust in front of the door.

She didn't try to open it. She never had. Not in nine hundred years. And not in that one hour, thirty-two years ago, when she'd stood here with her heart going like a bird's and her hands full of new thorns and watched someone else come out of it.

She just sat. With her thin knees drawn up and her arms round them. Like a girl on the edge of a cabbage bed.

And talked to the door.

"*Hes*," she said.

Nothing. The tower stood grey and cracked and silent. The thorns creaked faintly overhead.

"*Hes. They're awake.*" Her voice was very small. "*All of them. Oz and Ysy and Cad. Mae's dead. Did you know? Somebody gave her a lamp.*" She pressed her chin on her knees. "*Somebody from your line. A Harrow. I don't know that name. Is it yours? Did you take it?*"

The door didn't answer.

"*I didn't tell them*," whispered Rhosyn. "*About this. About what's in here.*" She looked up. At the little window at the top of the tower. Dark. "*I never will. I promise. I know I promised things before. I know I said I heard you and then I went down to the hall and drank anyway.*" Her eyes were stinging. She didn't know she still had tears. She'd thought the hunger had drunk them all. "*But I won't tell them about this. Not ever. Not if Oz asks. Not if he holds my hand in the fire.*"

The thorns creaked.

"*He wants the child*," said Rhosyn. "*The smith's child. A little girl. One of yours, Hes. Your line. He wants to put a crown on her and keep her.*" Her voice cracked. "*He's going to make me help.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAT THERE FOR a long time.

There was no time, in the Court. But she sat there for what would have been a long time, if there had been.

Up in the tower, behind the dark little window, something sat on a chair.

She'd never seen it. Not properly. Only once, for a moment, thirty-two years ago, carried past her in a long grey hand.

Small. Silver. A circle a little bigger than a man's hand could span. With points on it. Seven. Rising from the rim at even spaces. Like the tines of a fork.

She couldn't go near it. None of them could. She'd tried, in that hour. She'd stood at the foot of the stair and put her foot on the first step and felt it.

No.

Not a word. Not a voice. A *refusal*. Coming down the stair like cold air down a chimney. Pushing. Gently. Firmly. The way the Veil pushed. *Not you. Not ever. You drank.*

So she'd grown the thorns instead. A mile of them. Round and round. So nobody else would ever find the stair. So Oz would never send anyone. So Ysenne would never look. So it could sit up there, on the little chair Rhosyn had grown for a girl who never came, and say *no* to all of them, in the dark, forever.

And they'd slept.

That was the thing she'd never told anyone. For thirty-two years, ever since it came, they had all slept more soundly than they had in nine hundred. Even Oszric. Even Mae. She'd felt it in her cocoon. A quiet. A stillness. Like a hand laid on a fevered forehead.

Someone in the Court, at last, saying no.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'm sorry*," said Rhosyn. To the door. To the dark window. To the thing on the chair. "*I'm sorry, Hes. I heard you. I should have listened.*"

She'd said it on the shingle. Nine hundred years ago. Over and over. Holding her little sister's hands while the Ferryman waited.

It hadn't been enough then.

It wasn't now.

She looked down at her own hands. Thin. Grey-green. The fingers long and knotted, like twigs. The nails black. She'd had beautiful hands once. Gardener's hands. Pink and strong and always a little dirty. Their mother used to scold her for it at dinner.

She hadn't grown a living thing since the night she drank.

Only thorns. Only dry black thorns, with no leaves and no buds and no flowers. Nine hundred years of them. As if whatever she put her hands to remembered the pool and grew hungry and hooked.

She turned her hands over in her lap.

And thought, for no reason at all, of a cabbage bed. A girl in a grey dress sitting on the edge of it with her knees up. Saying, very seriously, to a boy with bare feet, *I always could. Since I was four. I thought I was mad.*

You're not mad, the boy had said. *You're a Listener.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMETHING MOVED IN HER hands.

She looked down.

There was a stem there. A new one. Thin and black and hooked, like all the others, coming up out of the dust between her bare feet. Curling up round her wrist. Seeking.

She'd grown it without meaning to. She did that sometimes. Thorns came up wherever she sat.

She looked at it.

And then, very slowly, the way you'd reach out to a bird on a windowsill, she put the tip of one finger on the very end of it.

And thought of her sister.

Not Mae. Not Ysy. *Hes*. Hes on the edge of the cabbage bed. Hes in the doorway of the hall. Hes on the shingle in the grey light, saying *not me, not ever*, with her voice shaking and not letting it stop her.

Hes, who'd lived. Who'd walked off east into the world with no light and a crown in a bundle and somehow, somewhere, had daughters.

Who'd had a *line*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TIP OF THE stem swelled.

Rhosyn stopped breathing.

It was very small. A knot. A bump. Hard and green. Green. Not black. *Green*, the colour of a pea, the colour of a new leaf, a colour she had not seen in nine hundred years and had stopped dreaming of somewhere around the five-hundredth.

It split.

A thread of red.

She made a sound. She didn't know what sound. Something small and cracked and wordless, like a hinge.

The red unfolded. Slowly. Petal by petal. Five of them. Then ten. Curling outward. Soft. Damp. Dark as wine, dark as blood, dark as the rose by the white wall in her mother's garden when she was four years old.

A rose.

In the Outer Court. In the dust. In the grey-gold light that came from nowhere.

A rose.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HELD IT FOR a long time.

She didn't dare move. She was afraid if she breathed on it, it would go. It would curl up and blacken and drop, the way her roses had dropped on the shingle, one by one, onto the grey stones while the Ferryman waited.

It didn't.

It stayed. Red. Open. Alive. On the end of a black thorny stem curled round her thin grey wrist.

And it smelled.

Faintly. Very faintly. Of summer. Of rain on a white wall. Of a garden full of bees. Of the world.

Rhosyn of the Crowned, the Thorn-Crowned, whose name the others didn't say, sat in the dust at the foot of an empty tower and cried over a single rose until she had no more tears left in her at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN SHE WIPED HER face.

And reached into the sleeve of her robe. Grey-gold silk. Rotten with age. She tore a strip from the hem. Narrow. No longer than her finger.

She had no ink. She had no pen. She had a thorn.

She broke one off the stem by her foot and scratched, very slowly, very carefully, on the grey silk, three letters. The way she'd learned to write them as a girl, at her mother's knee, in a language with eleven words for *crown* and none for *enough*.

It wasn't the old language she wrote in. She didn't know why. It came out of her in the shapes Orrin had used, when he spoke of the world on the other side. The world's letters. Plain ones. Square.

HES

And after it, a little hook. A curl. A question.

?

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TIED THE SCRAP to the stem, under the rose. With a thread pulled from her sleeve.

Then she knelt. And put her hands flat on the dust. The way she had in the first year, when she grew a tower.

And sent the stem west.

Not up. *Down*. Into the ground. Under the dust. Under the stone. A root, travelling. Through the dark under the Outer Court, under the plain, under the white road and the nine thousand gold people and the glass palaces and the hall. West. Toward the edge of the world. Toward the place where a finger's depth of

Harrow blood had run across frozen ground, and the Veil had not known it, and had opened.

Oz had told her to grow into the crack.

She would.

She'd send her thorns. As many as he wanted. Into the stone. To push. To widen. To make it wide enough for a king.

But the first thing she sent through it would be this.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK THE REST of the night that wasn't night.

She felt it go. All the way. Like feeling a thread run out through her fingers. Under the plain. Under the edge. Into the place where the crack was, a dark seam low down at the foot of the grey, smelling of dust on this side and, on the other, of something else.

Something green.

She felt it push.

She felt it come up.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE OTHER SIDE of the world, at the foot of the Veil, in the last cold dark before a winter dawn, the ground was gold.

Not frost. Not sunrise. *Gold*. Flat and hard and shining. For a mile round the crack. Grass, gold. Stones, gold. A beetle, gold, halfway across a gold stone, one leg raised. A hawk hanging in the air above a field, gold, its wings half folded, in the very act of dropping onto something that was no longer there.

And in the middle of the field, a flock of sheep.

Forty of them. Standing in the gold grass. Gold. Every one. Heads down, grazing, the way they'd been grazing when the dust came on the wind. Still as a carving.

And among them, a boy.

Twelve, perhaps. Thin. In a shepherd's smock and a felt cap. Gold. From the cap to the soles of his gold boots. Caught halfway through a step, one foot lifted, one arm out, his crook in his hand. His mouth open, as if he'd been about to call his dog.

His eyes were moving.

Slowly. In his gold face. Left. Right. Down.

Down at the gold ground by his lifted foot.

Where something was pushing up.

Black. Thin. Hooked. Splitting the gold like a crack in ice. Curling up out of the ground into the cold dawn air. Unfolding.

And at the end of it, red. Soft. Damp. Dark as wine. Open.

A rose.

The only living, moving thing for a mile.

And tied to the stem beneath it, fluttering, very faintly, in a wind that had come all the way from the east and smelled of rain—

A scrap of grey silk.

HES?

PART ONE

THE LAST THREAD

CHAPTER 1

The Bell That Rang Flat

THE BELL HAD RUNG once, flat, in the middle of winter. It hadn't rung since.

Lex knew. He'd been listening for it every day.

It hung on a cord round his neck, under his shirt, against his breastbone, where it had hung for two years. Small. Silver. The kind of bell you'd tie round a goat's neck so you'd know which hedge she was in. With a clapper inside that was bent a little, crooked, so that when it rang it rang very slightly off.

Malachi's bell. Hesper's before that. It rang when someone was sad.

It had rung in tune, once, on the rubble of Duskhold, when an old man and a little brother sat down together in the middle of a Well that had come home.

And then it had rung flat. In the night. In a chair by the east window, with his daughter asleep on his chest and his wife asleep against his shoulder and a voice in the dark, out of nowhere, out of the bottom of the world, saying his name.

Lex. Lad. Wake up.

They're coming for the Key.

He'd opened his eyes. He'd sat very still in the chair with Lark's warm weight on his chest and listened to the house. The fire ticking. The stream outside. Wren breathing. Nothing else.

He'd told himself it was a dream.

He'd told himself that every night since.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Good morning*," said Lex to the fire.

It was banked down to a heap of grey ash with a red eye in the middle. He knelt and blew on it, gently, the way you'd wake someone who'd been up all night.

It woke. Flickered. Caught the kindling. Climbed.

Good morning, said the fire. Not in words. Just a warmth. A lift. A small bright gladness. The way a dog is glad when you come down the stairs.

[Good morning,] said Ember.

Lex sat back on his heels.

You're up early.

[I'm always up. I don't sleep. I'm a piece of your father pressed into your blood like a maker's mark on a horseshoe. Horseshoes don't sleep.] A pause. *[You're up early. You were up at two. And at four. And at a quarter past five.]*

She was hungry.

[She was hungry at two,] said Ember. *[At four she was wet. At a quarter past five she was neither. At a quarter past five she was asleep, and you were lying in the dark looking at the ceiling with your hand on the bell.]*

Lex didn't answer.

He fed the fire another stick. It took it gladly.

[You dreamed it again,] said Ember. Quietly.

Yes.

[The same?]

The same, thought Lex. *Dark. Something wound round something. A voice.* He watched the flames climb. *He said my name. He said wake up. That's all. That's all it ever is.*

[Elric.]

Yes.

Ember was quiet for a while.

[I don't like it,] it said at last. *[I want to put that on the record. In the second volume. In a footnote. "Ember did not like it."]*

Noted.

[Underlined,] said Ember.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COTTAGE AT HARROW was four rooms and a loft. Grey Vale stone and new oak beams. A door that stuck in wet weather. A window on the east side, deep and wide, with a sill broad enough to sit on.

And in the window, a small iron lantern. Plain. With one word cut into the base, where only someone who picked it up would see it.

HERE.

It was still lit. It was always lit. Lex had lit it with his own fire on the first night home from the Blightmarch, and it had never gone out. It wasn't waiting for anyone. It was just there. For whoever was in the room.

This morning, that was Lex. And the porridge pot. And, upstairs in the loft, his wife. And, beside her, in a cradle he'd made out of ash and iron with *KNIT* on the rockers so it would never come apart, his daughter.

She was three months old.

He still didn't believe it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD HER BEFORE he saw her.

Not crying. Lark didn't cry much. She'd cried on the rubble on the night she was born, one long furious howl, and then stopped, as if she'd made her point. Since then she mostly *talked*. In a language of her own that seemed to be made entirely of vowels and indignation.

"*Aaah*," said the loft.

Lex looked up.

"*Aaah. Ah. Eh*."

"*She's awake*," said Wren's voice. Muffled. Into a pillow. "*She's your daughter. Go and get her*."

"*She's your daughter too*."

"*Not before porridge she isn't*."

He went up the ladder.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LOFT WAS DIM. Grey light coming in through the little window under the slope of the roof. Wren was a heap under the quilt, with a fox-red tangle of hair on the pillow and one bare arm flung out across the place where he'd been.

The cradle was on the other side of the bed. Under the window.

He looked in.

His daughter looked back.

She was lying on her back, kicking. Small. Pink. Round in the face, like Wren. Dark-haired, like him. With a fluff of it standing up on top of her head like the crest of a bird. Her eyes had been dark when she was born. Dark grey, like a storm. They were going green now. Wren's green. Slowly. From the edges in. Like a field going from frost to grass.

And her hands.

They were too big. Everyone said so. Brannoc had said so on the first day, holding her by the pool. Square hands. Broad in the palm. Short strong fingers. A smith's hands. Too big for the rest of her, the way a puppy's paws are too big. As if

she'd been made in the wrong order, hands first, and the rest of her was still catching up.

They were reaching for him now. Both of them. Opening and closing. Grabbing at the air.

"*Morning*," said Lex.

"*Aah*," said Lark. Severely.

He picked her up.

She grabbed his nose.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HAD A GRIP like a vice. Everyone said that too. Hedda had said it. Old Mag had said it, cackling, when Lark got hold of her one bright black eye's worth of spectacles and wouldn't let go. Tilda said she'd seen dogs with weaker jaws.

She had his nose now, in one square fist, and his collar in the other, and she was hanging on with an expression of fierce satisfaction, like someone who has caught a fish and has no intention of letting it back in the river.

"*Ow*," said Lex.

"*Eh*," said Lark.

"*That's my nose*."

She pulled it.

"*She knows it's your nose*," said Wren. From the pillow. Not moving. "*That's why she's pulling it. She's got good taste.*"

"*She's got good grip*."

"*She gets that from you*." Wren rolled over. Looked at them. Her green eyes half shut. Her face soft and creased with sleep. "*Everything awkward she gets from you. Her hands. Her hair. Her temper. The way she glares at porridge.*"

"*She doesn't eat porridge*."

"*She glares at yours*," said Wren. "*Every morning. Like you glare at the bellows when they won't catch.*" She yawned. Enormously. "*It's very funny. You have exactly the same face.*"

Lark let go of his nose.

And reached up. Past his face. Over his shoulder. Toward the window. Toward the beam above it.

Where a thing hung on a red ribbon, turning slowly in the grey light.

Old. Black. Square-headed. Small.

A horseshoe nail.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY'D HUNG IT THERE on the first night home. Wren's idea.

She is not chewing on a nail, Wren had said. Holding it up between finger and thumb. Looking at it the way she'd look at a dead mouse the cat had brought in. *I don't care if it's from Brannoc. I don't care if it's a family tradition. I don't care if every smith since the beginning of the world has given his apprentice's baby a nail. She is three weeks old. She is not having a nail.*

She held it, Lex had said. *By the pool. She wouldn't let go.*

She'd hold a live coal if you gave it to her, said Wren. *That's not an argument. That's a warning.*

So they'd tied it to a red ribbon. And hung it from the beam over the cradle. Where Lark could see it.

She'd looked at it every morning since. First thing. Before she looked at either of them. Reaching. Opening and closing her square hands.

As if she was saying good morning to it.

[She does it every morning,] said Ember. Very softly. *[Without fail.]*

I know.

[You do it to the fire.]

Lex looked at his daughter. Reaching for a horseshoe nail on a ribbon in the grey morning light.

I know, he thought.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE THE PORRIDGE one-handed, with Lark on his hip.

It was a skill. He'd had to learn it. In the first weeks he'd tried putting her down, in the cradle, in a basket by the fire, on a sheepskin on the floor, and every time she'd looked at him with her round grey-green eyes and said, quite clearly, in her language of vowels, that this was unacceptable. So now he made the porridge with one hand and held her with the other and she watched the spoon go round and round in the pot with the grave interest of a master inspecting an apprentice's weld.

"*It's porridge*," Lex told her.

"*Ah*."

"*You'll like it. When you've got teeth.*"

"*Eh*."

"*Your mam likes it with honey*."

"*Your mam likes it with honey and that's not a joke*," said Wren, coming down the ladder. In one of his shirts. In thick wool socks. With her hair everywhere. "*Your mam likes it with honey because your da can't cook anything else. Isn't that right?*"

"*I can cook eggs*."

"*He can burn eggs*," Wren told Lark. Taking her. Settling her on her own hip, the way she did, easily, like a girl who'd carried two little brothers about on a farm. "*He can burn eggs very well. He's a Worldforger. He can burn anything.*"

Lark grabbed her braid.

"*Ow*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY ATE AT THE table by the east window, with the lantern between them.

Outside, the birch wood was grey and wet and dripping. The snow had gone a week ago, all at once, in a warm wind from the south. The stream was loud. The track down to the Ashbourne road was mud. On the far side of the stream, a hundred paces off, through the bare white trunks of the birches, Lex could see the other cottage.

Small. Stone. One storey. With a blue door.

And a ramp up to it. Of oak planks. Gentle. Wide enough for a wheeled chair.

The chimney was smoking.

"*They're up*," said Wren.

"*She's always up*." Lex looked at the smoke. "*She says she's been getting up at dawn for thirteen years. She says she doesn't know how to stop.*"

"*And him*?"

Lex didn't answer straight away.

"*Depends on the day*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC HAD BUILT IT.

In a fortnight. In the first two weeks of winter, after they all came home from the Blightmarch. He'd brought twelve of the older students from the Forge and Hedda and Tilda and a cart full of stone, and they'd come up the track through the birch wood in the snow, and he'd stood in the clearing on the far side of the stream with his hands on his hips and his breath smoking and said, *Here*.

Here what? Lex had said.

Here's where it goes, said Brannoc. *A house. For your mam and your da. Across the water. Near enough to shout. Far enough you don't have to listen to each other snore.* He'd looked at Lex. *They can't live with you, lad. You've a wife and a baby and four rooms. And they can't live in Ashbourne, not with him the way he is. People would come by. People would want to look.*

He'd turned back to the clearing.

And he can't do ladders, said Brannoc Holt. *So it'll be one floor. And it'll have a ramp. And the door will be wide.*

They'd built it in fourteen days. In the snow. With Brannoc swearing at the mortar and Hedda swearing at Brannoc and Tilda making the hinges and Seren, on the last day, coming across the stream barefoot in the snow with a pot of blue paint she'd found God knew where and painting the door.

Blue? Brannoc had said.

Blue, said Seren. *Every house I ever lived in, somebody else chose the door. My mam. My mam's landlords. A Warden-Architect with no taste. I want a blue one.*

It's very blue.

Good, said Seren Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT ACROSS AFTER breakfast.

Over the stream on the stepping stones. Through the birches. Up the oak ramp. He knocked on the blue door, and didn't wait, and went in.

It was one room, mostly. A big one. Low-beamed. With a hearth at one end and a bed at the other behind a curtain, and in between, a long table under a window that faced west, so they'd have the sunset.

His father was at the window.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS IN THE chair.

The wheeled one. Ash and iron. Brannoc had made it in a night, on Lantern Night, on the rubble of Duskhold, out of a broken cart and a good deal of swearing. It had big wheels at the sides and a little one at the back and a footboard, and on the arms, where his father's hands rested, Brannoc had cut two words. One on each side. In his big careful hand.

STEADY, on the left.

HOME, on the right.

His father sat in it with a blanket over his knees and another round his shoulders, looking out of the window at the birch wood and the grey sky.

He was very old.

Lex had stopped being shocked by it. Mostly. He'd had a winter to get used to it. But every morning, coming in through the blue door, there was still a moment, a half-breath, before he got used to it again.

His father had been forty-five when Lex met him. To look at. Silver at the temples. Straight-backed. A quiet voice. A face like a closed book.

He'd aged a year a week, all last spring and summer, as two hundred years came due. And then ten in one night. And then, on Lantern Night, pouring the stolen light back out of himself in a dark room at the top of the Spire, he'd gone past old. Past counting. Past anything.

Mal had made room for him, after. A little. A year. Perhaps two. *Ordinary time*, Seraphine said. *The kind everyone gets. He'll age now the way anyone does. Day by day. Not a year a week. Just a day a day.*

But he'd started it from here.

His face was a walnut. Brown and creased and folded in on itself. His hair a white wisp, thin as smoke, that stood up off his skull when the door opened and let in a draught. His hands on the arms of the chair were spotted and thin and twisted at the knuckles, the skin over them as fine as old paper. His shoulders were narrow under the blanket. He was small. He'd been tall once. He was small now. A little bent old man in a chair at a window, like a heron in winter.

His eyes were the same.

Grey. Clear. Sharp. Turning from the window as the door opened.

Seeing him.

"*Good morning*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Good morning*," said Lex.

"*You're late*."

"*I'm not late. It's barely light.*"

"*Your mother's been up since dawn*," said his father. "*She's been reading to me for an hour. I'm on volume two. I've reached the part where I'm sixty-one and having trouble with my knees.*" His mouth twitched. "*It's riveting.*"

"*It's not*," said Seren.

She was at the hearth. Kneeling. Small and square and barefoot, with her sleeves pushed up and her greying hair tied back in a knot, poking at the fire with a stick. She looked round at Lex and smiled. The smile went all the way up into her eyes. It always did. It was the most Harrow thing about her.

"*It's not riveting*," said his mother. "*It's a list. He wrote down his blood pressure every morning for forty weeks. In a column.*"

"*It was a careful record*."

"*It was a column*," said Seren. "*Your father is the only man in the history of the world who could make his own death boring.*" She stood up. Dusted her hands off on her skirt. Came over and kissed Lex on the cheek. The left one. The one with the mark on it. She always kissed that one. "*Morning, love.*"

"*Morning, Mam.*"

"*Did she sleep?*"

"*Twice.*"

"*Twice is good.*" Seren went back to the fire. "*You slept twice. Antho slept never. Not once. For a year. I used to walk him up and down the cottage singing every verse I knew until I'd run out and then I'd start making them up.*" She poked the fire. "*Your father used to come home from the Spire and find me asleep standing up in the doorway with a baby on my shoulder.*"

She stopped.

Lex saw her stop. A small hitch. A half-breath. Her hand with the stick, held still above the fire.

"*I don't remember that,*" said Seren. Quietly. "*I just said it. But I don't remember it. I remember Antho. I remember the doorway. I remember the singing.*" She was looking into the fire. "*There's nobody there. Coming home. There's just—a space. The shape of somebody.*"

Nobody said anything.

His father didn't move. He sat in the chair with his spotted hands on the arms, on *STEADY* and *HOME*, and looked at his wife's back. His face very still.

"*Page two hundred and four,*" said Arion Vey. Gently. "*Of the letter. The forty-page one.*" His voice was a thread. "*I came home at midnight in the rain. You were asleep in the doorway. I took him off your shoulder and you didn't wake up. I carried you both to bed.*"

Seren didn't turn round.

"*I'll read it again,*" she said. "*Tonight.*"

"*You've read it eleven times.*"

"*Then it'll be twelve,*" said his mother. And went on poking the fire.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN HAD GIVEN her one memory back.

Just one. As a gift. Not a refund. On the grass beside the pool at the Blightmarch, at dawn, in the first week of winter. The first one. The steps of the Spire, in the rain. A young man in a grey coat coming round the corner, very casually, as if he just happened to be passing. Turning back. Twice.

She had that now. She'd had it all winter.

The rest of him was still in the river.

Thirty years. Every day. The courtship and the wedding and the cottage and the boys. The doorways and the midnights and the rain. All of it paid to a tall grey

eyeless man on a shingle shore thirteen years ago, as the price of crossing. *The memory you would least wish to lose.*

She didn't remember marrying him.

She'd married him again anyway. Sort of. In her way. In the only way she could. She'd come home to an old man she didn't know and looked at him in a cold room at the Lantern Keep and said *you have a nice voice*, and then she'd stayed.

She read him his own letters at night. And his grey book in the mornings. And she laughed at his jokes, which were terrible, and he laughed at hers, which were worse. And when people came up the track and saw them sitting together at the west window in the evening, a little old man in a chair and a square barefoot woman twenty years younger than his face and two hundred younger than his bones, with their heads bent together over a book, they stopped. And went quietly away again.

[She's courting him,] Ember had said once. In the first week. Amazed. *[Lex. She's courting him. She doesn't remember being married to him so she's courting him. She brought him a pie.]*

It was a good pie.

[That's not the point,] said Ember. *[The point is it's the most extraordinary thing I've ever seen. And I've seen a dragon hatch.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT DOWN AT the long table, across from his father, under the window.

His father looked at him.

He'd always been able to do that. Even before. Even when his face was forty-five and closed like a book. He'd look at you with his grey eyes, steady, patient, and wait, and you'd find you were telling him things you hadn't meant to tell anyone.

"*You're not sleeping*," said Arion.

"*There's a baby*."

"*There's a baby*," agreed his father. "*And there's something else.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*You've had your hand on that bell*," said his father, "*every time you've come in this door for six weeks. You put it there when you think I'm not looking.*" He tilted his head. A small movement. Like a bird. "*Has it rung?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HADN'T MEANT TO tell him.

He'd decided that. In the night. Lying in the loft with his hand on the bell. *Don't tell him. Don't put this on him. He's got a year. Maybe two. He's sitting in a chair by a*

window with a woman reading him his own letters and he's happy. For the first time in two hundred years he's happy.

Don't put Elric on him.

"*Once*," said Lex. "*In the winter. In the night.*"

"*Flat*?"

"*Flat*."

His father's hands didn't move on the arms of the chair.

"*And*?" he said.

Lex looked at the table. At the grain of the wood. At the pale ring where his mother's teacup stood every evening.

"*And I heard a voice*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD THEM.

All of it. It didn't take long. There wasn't much. The dark. The thing wound round the other thing. The voice. The same three sentences, over and over, every few nights, for six weeks.

Lex. Lad. Wake up.

They're coming for the Key.

When he said the name, his mother turned round from the fire.

His father didn't move at all.

That was the thing Lex would remember, after. Not that his father flinched. Not that his face changed. That it *didn't*. That it went perfectly, utterly still, the way water goes still in a bucket when you stop carrying it. The way his face had gone still, two years ago, in the gold room at Avaloria, when Lex had said, *Elric opened the wards.*

His grey eyes didn't blink.

"*Elric*," said Arion Vey.

"*Yes*."

"*Elric Thorne*."

"*He's the only one who calls me lad*."

His father didn't say anything for a long time.

Then he looked out of the window. At the birch wood. At the grey sky. At nothing.

"*He's in the Knot*," said Arion. Very quietly. "*He's been in the Knot for three years. Holding the Lockward. He gave back his threads at the lid and went in and wrapped himself round the Key and he hasn't said a word since.*" His voice didn't change. "*Not*

one. Not to anyone. I asked. Seraphine asked. We tried to reach him. The first winter." A pause. "*He doesn't talk."*

"*He talked*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER CAME AND sat down.

At the end of the table. Between them. Her hands flat on the wood. Her square freckled hands. She looked from one of them to the other.

"*The Key*," she said. "*The Key of Shadows. The one that opened the lid."*

"*Yes*."

"*And someone's coming for it*." She looked at Lex. "*Did he say who?*"

"*No*."

"*He didn't have to*." Seren's voice was very level. She'd grown up in a dozen cottages before she was nine, with a mother who kept her voice level when the moths came, and she'd learned. "*Oszric. The Gilded King. He's awake. We know he's awake."* She turned her hands over on the table. Palms up. "*Mam used to say it in the songs. The old verses. The ones she only sang at the end of summer."* She half-closed her eyes. "*Gold for the eldest. Glass for the vain. Iron for the one who never laughed. Thorns for the one who listened."*

"*And silver for the moth*," said Arion. Not looking away from the window.

"*And silver for the moth*," said Seren. "*Five. Five went through. The moth's dead."* She looked at Lex. "*Four left."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What does the Key do*?" said Lex.

He knew. He'd held it. He'd watched Elric turn it, on the black glass at the lid of the world, and felt the lid lift. But he wanted to hear his father say it. His father, who'd been Warden-Architect of the Spire for two hundred years. Who'd known the net better than anyone alive.

His father turned from the window.

"*It unwrites*," said Arion. "*Whatever it's turned against. That's what Aurelian made it for. He wove the net, and then he made a key to unweave it. In case."* His mouth twisted a little. "*He always made a key. He made a lock with a slot for a ward in it, because he was afraid someone would need to bar it. He made a key to undo his own net, because he was afraid he'd got it wrong."*

"*He did get it wrong*."

"*He got it wrong in a great many ways*," said his father. "*And then you wove a new one."* He looked at Lex. Steadily. "*And then you gave it away."*

Lex didn't say anything.

He remembered it. In the gold. At the Heart. The whole net in his hands, every thread, every knot, every Ceiling and every Stone, new-woven, shining. And the Root. The place where a hand went. The place where Aurelian's hand had been for nine hundred years, and then his father's, and then his.

And he'd taken his hand off it.

It isn't mine, he'd said. *It isn't anyone's. That's the point.*

"*There's nobody holding it*," said his father. Very quietly. "*The net. There's been nobody holding it for two years. It runs on its own now. The way a river does. It doesn't need a hand on it.*" His spotted fingers moved on the arm of the chair. On *STEADY*. "*But it could take one.*"

Lex went cold.

"*If someone turned the Key*," said Arion Vey. "*In the Knot. With the bar out. With nobody's hand on the net.*" He looked at his son. "*I don't know what would happen, Lex. I don't think anyone does. Aurelian might have. He's not here to ask.*"

"*Guess*."

His father was quiet for a long moment.

"*I think the net would ask them what they wanted*," he said. "*And I think it would give it to them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[I don't like this either,] said Ember. In the back of Lex's head. Very small. *[Another footnote.]*

Nobody else heard it. Nobody else ever did, except, sometimes, his mother, when she was close. She'd heard it in the deep. *Hello, Seren*, it had said. And she'd known it. Known its voice. Known whose voice it was.

She looked at Lex now. At his face. And he saw her hear it.

She didn't say anything. She just reached across the table and put her hand on his.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why now*?" said Lex. "*Why's he talking now? After three years?*"

"*Because they're awake*," said his mother.

"*Because he can feel them*," said his father.

They'd said it together. They looked at each other. A little startled. The way people look when they've finished each other's sentences for the first time.

Seren looked away first. A little pink.

"*He's at the bottom of the net*," said Arion. "*In the middle. Everything runs through the Knot. Every thread. If something's pulling on the edge, he'd feel it there first.*" He

looked down at his hands. "*Like a spider. In the middle of a web. Feeling a fly land at the edge.*"

"*A big fly*," said Seren.

"*A gold one*," said Arion. "*With a crown.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STAYED UNTIL THE light was full.

They talked about other things. They made themselves. His mother made tea. His father told a story about a Warden in the year eleven-forty who'd tried to arrest a goat for unlatticed sorcery, which might have been true and might not; his father's stories were like that. Seren laughed at it. Arion laughed at her laughing. Lex sat at the long table under the west window and watched them and drank his tea.

And all the while his father's hands didn't leave the arms of the chair.

STEADY, on the left. *HOME*, on the right.

His knuckles were white.

◆ ◆ ◆

WHEN LEX GOT UP to go, his father caught his sleeve.

His grip was weak now. Lex could have pulled away without noticing. He didn't. He stood by the chair and looked down.

"*If he talks again*," said Arion. "*If he says anything. Anything at all.*"

"*I'll tell you*."

"*Tell me exactly*." His father's grey eyes were very bright. "*The words. How he said them. Whether he sounded—*" He stopped.

"*Whether he sounded what*?"

His father let go of his sleeve.

"*Nothing*," said Arion Vey. And turned back to the window. To the birch wood. To the grey. "*It doesn't matter. Go home. Kiss your daughter. Tell Wren the pie was excellent.*"

"*What pie*?"

"*Your mother's taking you a pie*," said his father. "*This afternoon. It's a surprise. Act surprised.*"

"*Arion*," said Seren.

"*He'd have found out*."

"*That's not the point of a surprise*."

"*I've been alive two hundred and thirty-four years*," said Arion Vey. "*I've had a great many surprises. I've found I prefer them with a little warning.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WALKED HIM to the door.

She stood on the oak ramp in her bare feet, in the wet, with her arms folded. Looking out at the birch wood. At the stream. At the other cottage, across the water, with the lantern in its east window.

"*They were friends*," she said. "*Him and Elric. Forty years.*"

"*I know*."

"*He told me*." She didn't look at him. "*In the letter. The forty-page one. Page thirty. About Elric. About the night at Caldris.*" She was quiet. "*It's the only page in the whole letter where his hand shakes.*"

Lex didn't know what to say.

"*He doesn't talk about him*," said his mother. "*He talks about everything. About Aurelian. About the Spire. About the price of bread in twelve-ninety. He doesn't talk about Elric.*" She turned and looked at him. With her Harrow eyes. Brown and warm and very steady. "*I think he's the only person in the world your father hasn't forgiven.*"

"*He betrayed him*."

"*So did you*," said Seren. "*Once. You told me. At Avaloria. You said you hated him. You said you'd never forgive him for sealing you.*" Her mouth twitched. "*He's forgiven you.*"

"*That's different*."

"*Is it*?"

She didn't wait for an answer. She went back in. And closed the blue door behind her.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS HALFWAY ACROSS the stepping stones when the raven came.

He heard it before he saw it. Everyone always did. A great harsh croak out of the grey sky, and then the beat of wings, heavy and close, and then it was coming down through the birches in a tumble of black feathers and landing on the stone in front of him so hard it nearly went in the stream.

It wasn't Quill.

Quill was at the Forge. Quill lived on the chimney in a nest of stolen spoons and had opinions about everyone. This was bigger. Older. Its feathers ragged. One eye milky. A thin silver ring round its leg, and a scrap of paper rolled tight and tied with grey thread.

One of Roole's.

Commander Daxian Roole of the Keepers, who had taken Fenn's staff to the grave and dug it in with one arm. Who lived at Greyfall now. At the western edge. At

the last fort before the Veil. With his Keepers and his ravens and the wind that never stopped.

The raven looked at Lex with its one good eye.

"*Smith*," it croaked.

It always said that. Roole had taught it. Lex suspected Roole thought it was funny.

He knelt on the stepping stone. Untied the paper. Unrolled it.

It was Roole's hand. Small. Square. Plain. The hand of a man who wrote reports.

It was very short.

◆ ◆ ◆

Vey,

The ground at the foot of the Veil has gone gold. For about a mile round. Grass, stones, everything. We found it four days ago. It's spreading. Slowly. A few feet a day.

There was a flock on it. Forty head. Gold. Standing.

There was a boy with them. Col Ashby, twelve, from the croft at Westerling. Gold. Standing. Mid-step.

He's not dead.

His eyes are moving.

Come.

— R.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX READ IT TWICE.

Then he stood up. On the stepping stone. In the middle of the stream. With the water running loud and brown and cold round his boots, and the paper in his hand.

Behind him, through the birches, a blue door. An old man at a west window, with his knuckles white on the arms of his chair.

In front of him, through the birches, a small stone cottage. A lantern in the east window, lit. Not waiting for anyone.

And upstairs, in a cradle under a slanting roof, his daughter. Reaching up, with her too-big square hands, for a horseshoe nail on a red ribbon.

He wants the smith's child.

He didn't know where that thought came from. Nobody had said it. Not his father. Not his mother. Not the voice in the dark.

But he knew it. The way you know iron's hot before you touch it.

[Lex,] said Ember.

The bell on the cord round his neck didn't ring.

It didn't have to.

CHAPTER 2

GILT

"*You're going*," said Wren.

It wasn't a question. She was standing in the kitchen with Lark on her hip and Roole's note in her other hand, reading it for the third time. Her face had gone very still. The way it went still on a rooftop when she'd seen something move in the street below.

"*I'm going*," said Lex.

"*Today*."

"*Now*."

She looked up from the paper.

"*I'm coming*."

"*Wren—*"

"*Don't*." She didn't raise her voice. She never did, when it mattered. "*Don't you dare. Don't you dare say I can't. I've tracked Mothwing across the Sundered Lands. I've stood at the Veil. I was there when Fenn—*" She stopped. Swallowed. Looked down at the baby on her hip. Who was looking up at her with round grey-green eyes and one square fist wound tight in the end of her braid.

Lark said, "*Ah*."

Wren closed her eyes.

"*She eats every three hours*," she said. Very quietly. To the ceiling. "*Every three hours. Sometimes two. I can't—*" She opened her eyes again. "*It's a day's flight. Each way. Even on Vharuun. I can't take her to the Veil. And I can't leave her for two days. Not yet. Not now.*" Her voice cracked. Just a little. Just at the edge. "*I can't.*"

"*I know*."

"*I hate it*."

"*I know*."

"I hate it so much." She glared at him. Her eyes were wet. *"You go and look at gold sheep and I sit here and—and—"*

"Feed our daughter."

"Don't make it sound noble," said Wren. *"It's not noble. It's milk."* She wiped her face with the back of the hand holding the note. Fiercely. *"Go. Go on. Come back tomorrow night or I'll come and find you and I'll bring her and she'll scream the whole way and it'll be your fault."*

He kissed her.

She let him. She held on to his collar with her free hand. Hard. The way Lark held on to things.

"If it's him," she said into his shoulder. *"The gold one. The King."*

"It won't be him. He's on the other side."

"If it is." She pulled back. Looked at him. *"You don't go near it. You don't touch anything. You don't do anything brave and stupid. You look, and you come home, and you tell me, and then we decide."*

"Together."

"Together," said Wren Ashdown. *"Or I'll break your nose again. And it won't be a Moth Queen doing it this time."*

◆ ◆ ◆

VHARUUN WAS IN THE high pasture above the birch wood, where he slept most days now, curled round a boulder like a cat round a warm stone.

He was enormous. He'd always been enormous. Bronze and copper and old gold, with a ridge of horns down his back like a mountain range and eyes the colour of a forge at full heat. He'd been asleep under the Greyspine for four hundred years before Lex woke him, and he'd made it clear, since, that he considered the waking a favour he was still deciding whether to forgive.

He opened one eye as Lex came up the hill.

[You want something,] said Ember. *[He can tell. He has that look. The look of a dragon who's been asked to do something before breakfast.]*

It's after breakfast.

[Not his.]

Lex stopped in front of the great bronze head. Laid his hand flat on the warm scales between the nostrils. The way he always did. A greeting. A question.

West, he thought. *To the Veil. To Greyfall. Today. Please.*

The eye looked at him. Molten gold. Ancient.

Then a picture. Not words. Vharuun didn't do words. Just a picture, very clear, very sharp, dropped into Lex's head like a stone into a well.

A sheep. Roasting.

Fine, thought Lex. *Two sheep. When we get there. Roole will pay.*

Vharuun considered this.

Then he uncurled, all of him, all at once, with a sound like a mountainside settling. And lowered one great wing to the grass.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FLEW ALL DAY.

West over the Vale. Over Ashbourne, small and grey and smoking far below, with the long roof of the Forge and the chimneys at each end and the tiny black dot of Quill on his nest of spoons. Over the downs. Over the fields of the western shires, brown and wet and waiting for the plough.

Over the Blightmarch.

Lex looked down. He couldn't not.

A hundred miles of soft green. Where a year ago there had been grey. Dead grass, dead trees, the long scar of the Gloam. Green now. All of it. Pale and new, like the first growth on a burned hillside. And in the middle, far off, a glint. A small dark round glint, like an eye.

The pool.

And beside it, smaller still, a little black house on the slope. With a window. With something in the window, so small at this height it was only a spark.

A lantern. *HOME.*

[You're smiling again,] said Ember.

I'm allowed.

[I didn't say you weren't. I'm just noting it. For the record.] A pause. *[It's very green.]*

It's very green, Lex agreed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THE BARE LANDS.

The Sundered Lands began a little way past the Blightmarch's western edge. He knew them. He'd crossed them twice. Grey cracked ground. Black stumps of trees that had died nine hundred years ago and never fallen, because nothing out here rotted. Broken roads that went nowhere. The bones of villages. And the wind, coming always from the west, always cold, never stopping.

Vharuun flew lower. He didn't like the bare lands. He said so, in pictures. A picture of a fire going out. A picture of a cave with nothing in it.

I know, thought Lex. *I don't like them either.*

They flew on. Into the wind. Toward the edge of the world.

◆ ◆ ◆

GREYFALL STOOD ON A low ridge at the very end of everything.

It had been a Warden fort once. Then a Keepers' post. Then, briefly, last spring, a ruin, its lanterns eaten, its people dimmed, its gates hanging open in the wind. Roole had rebuilt it in the summer. Stone on stone. With his one good arm and two hundred Keepers.

There were lanterns on the walls again. Lit. Even in the daytime. Roole said he didn't care what it cost in oil.

And beyond the fort, two miles off across the bare grey ground—

The Veil.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT NEVER GOT EASIER to look at.

Lex had seen it twice before. He'd thought he was ready. He wasn't. You couldn't be.

It was grey. That was all. Just grey. A wall of grey, hanging from nowhere, falling to nowhere, stretching north and south as far as the eye could follow and then further. Not mist. Not cloth. Not stone. Something that the eye couldn't settle on, that kept sliding off, the way your tongue slides off a loose tooth. It moved, very slightly, all the time. Rippling. Like a curtain in a room where someone has left a window open.

The edge of the world.

On the other side, nine hundred years ago, nine people in chains had been rowed across a grey river by a man with no eyes.

On the other side, now, four of them were awake.

[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[Look at the ground.]*

He looked.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT THE FOOT OF the Veil, the world was gold.

He saw it from a mile off. From the air. A great soft blot of it, spreading out from one point at the very bottom of the grey like spilled paint. Shining. Even in the flat grey light of the Sundered Lands, under the flat grey sky, it shone. Dully. Like old brass. Like a coin at the bottom of a well.

It was round. Roughly. A mile across. Perhaps more.

And it wasn't a colour.

He understood that as Vharuun came down. It wasn't paint. It wasn't light. It wasn't the way the grass looks at sunset. The grass there *was* gold. The stones were gold. The black stumps of the dead trees were gold, every crack in their bark, every splinter. A broken wall of an old farmstead. Gold. A cart-track with ruts in it. Gold ruts.

And in the middle of it, a field.

And in the field, forty small round gold shapes. Heads down. Grazing.

And among them, one tall thin one. Standing.

◆ ◆ ◆

ROOLE MET HIM AT the edge.

He was standing on the grey ground twenty paces back from the line where the gold began, with three Keepers and a woman Lex knew. Ada Fell. Grey cloak. Iron-grey hair. A Keeper's staff. She'd been at the Ashbourne Stone the day Ivy Moss was Kindled.

Roole's arm was out of its sling. He held it a little stiffly, a little close to his side, like a man carrying something he didn't want to drop. His hatchet face was the same as ever. Hard. Plain. Lined. His eyes went to the dragon, and then to Lex, and didn't change at all.

"*Vey*," he said.

"*Roole*."

"*You came fast*."

"*You said come*."

"*I did*." Roole looked past him. At the gold. "*I didn't know who else to say it to.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED TO THE edge together.

Not to it. Near it. Roole stopped two paces back and put out his stiff arm, not touching Lex, just there, the way you'd put an arm out in front of a child at the edge of a road.

"*Don't step on it*," he said. "*We don't know what it does. We lost a dog the first day. Ran straight onto it after a hare.*" His jaw tightened. "*It's there. Over by the wall. Gold. With the hare.*"

Lex looked.

There. By the broken farmstead wall. Two small gold shapes. One long and low, mid-leap. One small and round, a yard in front of it, ears flat, also mid-leap.

Both of them stopped. In the air. Just above the ground. Like a carving of a chase.

"*It's moving*," said Ada Fell. Quietly. "*The edge. Not fast. A few feet a day. We've been marking it.*" She pointed with her staff. A line of small white stones on the grey ground, laid out in a curve. And another line, a few feet in from it, gold. And another, a few feet further in, gold.

"*It's coming out of there*," said Roole. And nodded. West. Toward the Veil. Toward the foot of the grey, where the gold was brightest. "*There's a crack. You'll want to see it. After.*"

"*After what*?"

Roole didn't answer.

He just looked out across the gold. At the field. At the forty sheep. At the one tall thin shape among them.

And at the other shape. On the near side of the gold. On the grey. Sitting on the ground. A woman.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS SITTING VERY close to the line. Closer than Roole would let anyone stand. Her knees drawn up under her skirt. A shawl round her shoulders. A basket beside her, covered with a cloth.

She was talking.

Lex couldn't hear what she was saying. The wind took it. But he could see her mouth moving. Steadily. Patiently. The way you talk to someone who's sick in bed, when you don't know if they can hear you and you talk anyway, just in case.

She was talking to the boy.

"*Nan Ashby*," said Roole. Very quietly. "*His mother. From the croft at Westerling. It's eight miles.*" He didn't look at Lex. "*She walks it every morning. She sits there all day. She brings him his supper. She leaves it on the line.*" His voice didn't change. It never did. "*She says he's always hungry after a day with the flock.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WALKED OUT TO her.

Not onto the gold. Along the edge of it. On the grey. Roole didn't stop him. Roole stood with his stiff arm at his side and watched.

The woman looked up as Lex came. She was younger than he'd thought. Thirty, perhaps. Thin. Brown-haired. With a farm woman's red hands and a face that had cried itself out a long time ago and was now only very, very tired.

She looked at the mark on his cheek. The grey-gold handprint. Everybody did.

Then at his face.

"*You're the smith*," she said. "*The one from the songs. With the little hammer.*"

"Yes."

"Can you get him out?"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T ANSWER.

He couldn't. He didn't know. He stood on the grey ground beside her and looked across the gold at her son.

Twelve. Thin. In a shepherd's smock and a felt cap. Caught in the middle of a step. One foot lifted. One arm flung out. His crook in his fist. His mouth open, as if he'd just that moment opened it to whistle for his dog.

Gold.

All of him. Cap to boots. His smock, every fold of it. His hair, where it stuck out from under the cap. His eyelashes. The dirt under his fingernails. A scab on his knee where the smock had ridden up. A little hole in the toe of one boot. All of it gold. All of it perfect. Like a statue made by someone who loved him very much and had looked at him for a very long time and got every detail exactly right.

And his eyes.

Lex was close enough now. Thirty paces. He could see them.

They were gold too. Iris and white and pupil, all the same dull shining gold.

And they were looking at him.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY MOVED.

Slowly. So slowly. The way the hand of a clock moves. You couldn't see it move. You could only see that it had moved. That a moment ago it had been looking at his mother and now it was looking at Lex.

At Lex's face.

At the mark on his cheek.

And then back. Slowly. To his mother.

Lex felt something go out of his chest. All the air. All at once. As if he'd been kicked.

[He's awake,] said Ember. Very small. *[Lex. He's awake in there.]*

I know.

[He can see us.]

I know.

[How long has he—]

"Nine days," said Nan Ashby. She wasn't looking at Lex. She was looking at her son. *"Nine days, today. It was a Tuesday. He went out with the flock at dawn. There*

was a wind from the west. Mad Annie at the next croft said it was full of sparks." She was very calm. Terribly calm. *"He didn't come home for his supper. So I came out to look."*

She stopped.

"His eyes move," she said. *"Every day. A little. I watch them. I talk to him and I watch them."* She swallowed. *"They follow me. When I go along the line. They follow me."*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TRIED.

He'd known he would. He'd known from the moment he read the note, standing on the stepping stone in the stream. He'd tried to talk himself out of it all the way across the bare lands. He'd promised Wren.

You don't touch anything.

He knelt down on the grey ground at the edge of the gold. Close to the line. Close to Nan Ashby. Close enough that he could have reached out and laid his hand on it.

He didn't. Not yet.

He opened himself. Carefully. The way Malachi had taught him, years ago, in a cave in the Wastes. *Listen first. Listen before you ask.*

He listened.

◆ ◆ ◆

FLAME FIRST.

He held his hand out over the gold. Not touching. A finger's width above. And let the fire come up in him. Not much. A warmth. The way you'd hold your hand over a pan to see if it was hot.

He let it out.

Heat poured down off his palm onto the gold grass. He could feel it. Could feel the air between them go thick and shimmering. Enough to warm iron. Enough to soften lead. Enough to make gold, real gold, the gold in a ring or a coin, go soft as butter and run.

Nothing happened.

Not *nothing*. Worse than nothing. The heat went down into the gold grass and *stopped*. Didn't sink in. Didn't spread. Didn't warm it at all. As if he'd poured water onto glass. It just sat on the surface, and then slid off, and was gone into the cold air.

He pressed harder. More heat. Real heat. Forge heat. White.

The gold grass didn't change. It stayed exactly the temperature it had been. A cold morning in late winter. A Tuesday. Nine days ago.

[It's not taking it,] said Ember. *[Lex. It's not—it won't take heat. It's not hotter or colder. It's just the same. It's the same as it was.]*

I know.

[Gold takes heat. Every metal takes heat. That's what metal is. That's the whole point of metal.]

I know, thought Lex. *It's not metal.*

◆ ◆ ◆

STONE NEXT.

He put his palm flat on the grey ground beside the gold. Not on it. Beside it. And reached down. Into the earth. The way he did every morning, half without thinking, the way you'd reach out in the dark for a wall you knew was there.

The Stone answered. It always did. Grey. Old. Patient. The cracked dead ground of the Sundered Lands, which had been dead for nine hundred years and was used to it.

He reached sideways. Under the line. Into the ground under the gold.

And felt nothing.

Not stone. Not soil. Not anything. Not even absence. He knew absence. He knew the Hollow, the room, the space where new things came in. This wasn't that. This was the opposite of that.

This was *full*.

Full the way a block of iron is full. Solid all the way through. No gaps. No cracks. No grain. No room for anything. Not a breath. Not a seed. Not a thought.

He reached for the Hollow. The new one. The seventh. The thing he'd only learned that autumn, kneeling by his wife with his hand on her belly, feeling his daughter turn over inside her.

Make room, he asked it. Very gently. *Here. Just a little.*

And the Hollow, which made room in everything, which had made room for a starving Well and a Moth Queen and an old man's last year, put out its hand.

And found nowhere to put it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT BACK ON his heels.

He was shaking. He didn't know when he'd started. His hands. His knees. A deep cold tremor, coming up from somewhere in his middle.

"*It's not metal*," he said. Out loud. To nobody. To Roole, who'd come up behind him. To Nan Ashby, who hadn't moved. "*It's not anything. It's just—*"

He didn't have the word.

[Kept,] said Ember.

He looked up.

[It's kept,] said Ember. Very softly. *[Like a thing in a jar. Like a fly in amber. Like a flower pressed in a book. It's not dead. It's not changed. It's just kept. Exactly as it was. The moment the dust touched it.]* A pause. *[Forever.]*

Lex looked at the boy. At the gold eyes in the gold face. Slowly. Slowly. Turning to look at his mother.

He's not dead, he thought.

[No.]

He's not hurt.

[No. Nothing can hurt him. Nothing can touch him. He'll never be hungry. He'll never be cold. He'll never get old. He'll never die.] Ember's voice was very quiet. *[He'll never take that step, Lex. Or whistle for his dog. Or go home for his supper.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Can you get him out*?" said Nan Ashby again.

Lex looked at her.

She'd turned her face from her son at last. She was looking at Lex. With her tired, cried-out eyes. Not hoping. She'd stopped hoping somewhere around the fourth day. Lex could see it. Just asking. Because she had to ask. Because someone had to, and there was nobody else.

"*I don't know*," said Lex.

She nodded. Slowly. As if that was the answer she'd expected.

"*I'll find out*," said Lex.

She looked at him for a long moment.

"*Everyone says that*," said Nan Ashby.

And turned back to her son. And went on talking. About the hens. About the leak in the byre roof. About Mad Annie, and her cat, and the price of wool in Westerling market. In a low, steady, patient voice. The way you talk to someone who's sick in bed.

Just in case.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

Roole was beside him. Not looking at him. Looking at the boy.

"*There's something else*," said Roole. "*Next to him. By his foot. You'll want to see it before you see the crack.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A ROSE.

Lex saw it as he came along the edge of the gold. Saw it and stopped dead. Because it was the only thing for a mile in any direction that wasn't gold or grey.

It was red.

It was growing out of the gold ground beside the boy's lifted foot. Close. So close it almost touched his boot. A thin black stem, hooked with thorns, splitting the gold like a crack splits ice. Curling up into the cold air. Three leaves on it. Green. Actual green. And at the top, open, a single flower.

Dark red. Velvet. Damp. As if it had rained on it. It had not rained in the Sundered Lands for nine hundred years.

"*It came up the first morning*," said Roole. "*The morning we found him. Ada saw it. It's the only thing that's moved, out there. Apart from his eyes.*"

Lex stared at it.

And then he saw the thing tied to the stem. Under the flower. A scrap of something. Grey. Ragged. Fluttering a little in the wind.

"*Has anyone touched it*?"

"*No*," said Roole. "*Nobody's been on the gold.*"

"*Then how—*"

"*I don't know*," said Roole. "*That's why I wrote to you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T REACH IT.

It was thirty paces in. On the gold. Beside the boy. He stood at the edge and looked at it and couldn't reach it.

He could have stepped on the gold. Maybe. He didn't know what it would do. Maybe nothing. Maybe it only kept things when the dust was fresh. Maybe it was only the dust on the wind that did it, not the ground it left behind.

Maybe he'd step on it, and stop, and stand there forever with one foot lifted beside a shepherd boy, and Wren would come and find him with Lark screaming the whole way.

He didn't step on it.

He called the wind instead.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WASN'T GOOD WITH wind. He never had been. Wren was good with wind. Wren could stand on a rooftop and lean into a gale and walk across it like a bridge. Lex was a smith. He liked things you could hit.

But he'd been Answering the Gale for two years now. It knew him. It humoured him. The way a big dog humours a child.

Please, he asked it. *Just a little. Just there. Gently. Like a hand.*

The wind came. Off the Veil. Cold. Thin. Curling round in a little eddy, low over the gold ground. Round the boy's lifted foot. Round the black stem.

And plucked the grey scrap off it.

It came fluttering. Across the gold. Tumbling. Turning over and over in the air, light as a moth, and Lex put out his hand and it landed in his palm.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILK.

Old silk. Grey-gold. So old it was coming apart in his fingers, threads unravelling from the edges. Soft. Dry. It smelled of dust. Old dust. The dust of a closed room.

And of something else. Very faint. Underneath.

Roses.

There were marks on it. Scratched. Not ink. Scratched into the weave with something sharp, so that the threads had been pushed aside to make the lines. Three letters. Square. Plain. Crooked, as if whoever made them had learned their letters a very long time ago and in a different shape.

And a fourth mark after them. A little hook. A curl.

HES?

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT IT for a long time.

Roole was looking over his shoulder. Ada Fell beside him. Nobody said anything.

[Hes,] said Ember.

Hesper.

[Lex—]

I know.

[That's her name. The tenth sister. The one who wouldn't drink. Your mother's—] It stopped. *[Your—]*

My grandmother's grandmother's grandmother, thought Lex. *Something like that. Twenty times over.*

[Someone on the other side is asking for her.]

Lex turned the scrap of grey silk over in his hand. Very carefully. So it wouldn't fall apart.

Someone on the other side, he thought, *is asking if she's still here*.

He looked up. At the rose. At the red of it. The only living colour for a mile. Growing out of gold beside a boy who couldn't move.

And they sent a flower to ask.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROSE CAME AWAY when he called it.

He hadn't meant to. He'd only meant to look. He'd reached out with the Stone, with the ground, very gently, toward the place where the black stem went down into the gold. To feel where it went. To feel what it was rooted in.

And the stem let go.

Just like that. As if it had been waiting. As if it had only been holding on until someone came. The roots slid up out of the gold, clean, with a soft dry whisper, and the wind he'd called curled round under it and lifted it, and it came across the gold to him the way the silk had come. Turning. Slowly. And he put out his hand.

He caught it by the stem. Below the thorns.

It was warm.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Given,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[Lex. That was given. It wanted to come.]*

Who to?

[I don't know,] said Ember. *[Not to you. I don't think it was meant for you.]* A pause. *[I think it was meant for her.]*

He looked at the rose in his hand. Dark red. Warm. Smelling, very faintly, of summer.

[Your mother,] said Ember. *[I think someone sent your mother a rose.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The crack*," said Roole. Behind him. Quietly. "*Come on. While there's light.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT ROUND.

The long way. Along the edge of the gold, north, then west, keeping to the grey. Two miles. Roole first, with his stiff arm. Then Lex, with the rose in one hand and the scrap of silk folded inside his shirt against the bell. Then Ada Fell. The other Keepers stayed with Nan Ashby. Roole said someone always did.

The gold was narrower here. A tongue of it running west, toward the Veil, a hundred yards wide. And at the end of the tongue, at the very foot of the grey, where the gold was brightest—

The crack.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS SMALL.

That was the first thing. He'd imagined it, all the way across the bare lands, and he'd imagined something big. A tear. A rent. A great black wound in the edge of the world.

It wasn't. It was a line. A dark seam, low down, right at the bottom of the Veil where the grey met the ground. No longer than he was tall. No wider than his finger.

You could have missed it. If you didn't know where to look. If it wasn't for the gold.

The gold came out of it.

Slowly. Like sand in an hourglass. A thin trickle of grey-gold dust, sifting out of the dark seam onto the ground in a soft little heap, and the wind picking it up, a few grains at a time, and carrying them east. Lex watched a grain land on a grey stone at the edge of the tongue. Watched the stone go gold. Not all at once. From the point where the grain landed, outward. Like a drop of ink in water. In the time it took to draw a breath.

And then it was a gold stone. And it would be a gold stone forever.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THERE WAS SOMETHING else.

In the crack. In the dark of it. Pushing.

Black. Hooked. Thin as wire. Stems. Dozens of them. Curling out of the seam, lying along the foot of the grey, digging into the cold ground with their hooked thorns. As he watched, one of them moved. Slowly. Pushing deeper into the edge of the crack. Like a root pushing into a crack in a wall.

Widening it.

He couldn't see it widen. It was too slow. But he could feel it. Through the Stone. A tiny groan in the ground. A creak. Like a door being pushed on its hinges by a draught.

[Thorns,] said Ember. *[The Thorn-Crowned. Lex. Thorns for the one who listened.]*

Lex looked down at the rose in his hand. At the black stem. At the thorns on it.

The same thorns.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Don't go closer*," said Roole.

Lex went closer.

Not onto the gold. The gold was thinner here, near the seam; the wind carried most of the dust away east before it settled. There was a strip of grey ground running right up to the foot of the Veil, a few feet from the crack. Lex walked along it. Slowly. Carefully. Until he was standing at the foot of the edge of the world.

The Veil hung in front of him. Grey. Moving. Close enough to touch.

He'd been this close once before. Last spring. With Wren. Looking for Fenn. He'd put his hand out then, the way you put your hand out to a fire, without thinking, and the Veil had pushed. Gently. Firmly. *Not you. Not ever.* The way it pushed everyone.

He put his hand out now.

It didn't push.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD THERE WITH his hand an inch from the grey.

Nothing. No push. No pressure. No *not you*. It hung there in front of his palm, rippling slightly, and did nothing at all. As if he wasn't there. As if he was air.

[It doesn't know you,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[Lex. It's not pushing. It doesn't know you.]*

It pushed me last spring.

[Last spring you were the Worldforger. Last spring you'd woven the net. It knew you by that. By the Vey. By the net in you.] A pause. *[It's looking at the other half now. Since the crack. Since the blood. It's looking at the Harrow.]*

And it doesn't know the Harrow.

[Nobody does,] said Ember. *[That was the whole point. Nine hundred years of never staying anywhere long enough to be looked at.]*

Lex looked at his hand. An inch from the grey.

He could put it through. He knew it. He could put his hand through the edge of the world the way you put your hand through a curtain. And on the other side—

"*Vey*," said Roole. Behind him. Very sharp. "*Step back.*"

He stepped back.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS GLAD, LATER, that he had.

Because as he stepped back, the dust at the mouth of the crack *moved*.

Not the trickle. Not the slow sifting heap. The heap itself. All at once. As if someone had breathed on it from inside. It lifted. It rose up off the ground in a little cloud, grey-gold, glittering, no bigger than a man's head.

And didn't blow away.

The wind was blowing east. Hard. Cold. Off the Veil. The dust should have gone with it. It didn't. It hung in the air in front of the crack, turning slowly, holding together, against the wind.

And then it rose.

And grew.

And became a shape.

◆ ◆ ◆

THIN.

That was all he could think. Thin. Thin as a rake. Thin as a gallows. A tall bent grey shape made of dust, standing in the air at the foot of the Veil, its edges shifting and smoking, its arms like bundles of dead twigs. A long narrow head. A suggestion of a coat. Of a chain round the neck, gone black.

And two eyes.

Dim. Barely lit. Two tiny sparks in the dust. Like the ends of pipes glowing in a dark room.

They looked at Lex.

At his face. At the mark on his cheek.

And the dust-shape bowed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A VERY good bow.

Low. Courteous. Old-fashioned. One twig-arm folded across its middle and the other held out to the side, the way servants bowed in old paintings when the king came into the room. It held it for a long moment.

Then it straightened.

"*Smith*," it whispered.

Its voice was dust. Dry and soft and hissing, like sand poured slowly out of a sack. It came from everywhere and nowhere.

"*His Majesty sends his greetings*," whispered the dust. "*And his condolences.*"

Lex didn't move.

"*For your father*," said the dust. "*He hears your father is very old. He hears it won't be long.*" The dim sparks of its eyes flickered. "*His Majesty is very sorry. He knows what it is to sit by a bed.*"

"*Who are you*?"

"*Nobody*," whispered the dust. "*A steward. A servant. Dust.*" It bowed again. Shorter. "*My name is Orrin. I carry His Majesty's gifts.*"

"*What gifts*?"

The dust-shape didn't answer.

It looked past Lex. East. Toward the gold. Toward the field. Toward the forty gold sheep, and the one tall thin gold shape among them, and the woman sitting on the grey ground beside the line with a basket, talking.

And Lex understood.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MOVED BEFORE HE'D decided to.

Fire. All of it. Not the careful heat he'd poured on the gold grass. Not the little warmth over a pan. The real thing. The Flame, Commanding, the way he'd called it on the rubble of Duskhold on Lantern Night, up out of his chest and down his arm and out of his hand in a roar of white and gold.

It hit the dust-shape full in the middle.

And went through it.

The dust scattered. Of course it did. It was dust. It blew apart in a burst of glittering grey-gold, like a dandelion clock under a child's breath, and the fire went on through the place where it had been and hit the Veil behind it.

The Veil didn't care. It took the fire the way a lake takes a dropped stone. A ripple. Then nothing.

And the dust—

The dust came back together.

Ten paces east. On the wind. Laughing.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A HORRIBLE laugh. Dry. Soft. Hissing. Like the sound of a sack of sand being dragged across a floor.

"*Oh, smith*," it whispered. "*Fire. Of course. You're the smith.*" The dim sparks of its eyes were very bright. "*You can't burn dust, smith. You can only make more of it.*"

It bowed one more time. Very low. Very courteous.

"*Give my regards to your mother*," said Orrin. "*And to the child.*"

And let go.

The dust came apart. All of it. All at once. Into a thin glittering stream that went up into the grey sky, high, higher, and caught the wind, and went east. Over the gold. Over the field. Over Roole and Ada Fell standing frozen on the grey ground, and

Nan Ashby, who looked up, and the boy, whose gold eyes moved, slowly, to follow it.

East.

Toward the Blightmarch. Toward the shires. Toward the Vale.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE CORD ROUND Lex's neck, against his breastbone, under the folded scrap of grey silk—

The little silver bell with the crooked clapper rang.

Once.

Flat.

Ting.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD AT THE foot of the Veil with a rose in his hand and listened to it fade.

[Lex,] said Ember.

I know.

[He said the child.]

I know.

[He's going east. He's going toward—]

"*I know*," said Lex. Out loud.

And turned. And ran. Back along the strip of grey. Past Roole. Past Ada Fell. Toward Greyfall. Toward the high pasture behind the fort where a bronze dragon lay curled round a boulder, waiting for two sheep.

He didn't stop for the sheep.

Vharuun forgave him, eventually.

CHAPTER 3

The First Knot

HE GOT HOME IN the dark.

Vharuun came down in the high pasture above the birch wood at the end of a long cold day's flight, all the way from the Veil without stopping, and lay down on the wet grass and put his great head on his forelegs and closed his eyes and sent Lex a picture so clear and so sulky that Lex almost laughed out loud. A sheep. A whole flock of sheep. Running away over a hill. Uneaten.

"*Tomorrow*," Lex told him. "*I promise. Two. Three.*"

The eye opened. A slit of molten gold.

"*Four*," said Lex.

The eye closed.

He ran down the hill through the birches.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WINDOW WAS LIT.

He saw it from the top of the wood. A small gold square in the dark. The east window. The lantern. *HERE*.

And on the step below it, a shape.

He knew it before he was close enough to see. The way she sat. Knees drawn up. Something in her arms. Something else across her knees, catching the lantern-light. Long. Thin. Steel.

He came out of the trees into the clearing and stopped.

Wren looked up at him.

She was sitting on the doorstep in the cold with Lark asleep inside her coat, against her chest, wrapped in a shawl, only the dark fluff of her hair showing. And across her knees, unsheathed, one of her long knives. The leaf-blade one. The one he'd forged for her years ago with *TRUE* on the steel.

Her face was very white.

"*You're early*," she said.

"*Has anything come*?"

"*No*." She didn't move. "*Nothing. Nobody. It's been quiet all day.*" She looked at his face. "*What happened?*"

He sat down on the step beside her. Close. So their shoulders touched. And looked at his daughter's hair. At the dark fluff of it. At the small warm bulge of her under the shawl, rising and falling.

"*Something came through*," he said. "*At the crack. Dust. It said it was a steward. It said—*" He stopped.

"*Said what*?"

"*It said give my regards to the child*," said Lex.

Wren's hand tightened on the knife.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT THERE A long time.

He told her all of it. The gold. The boy. Nan Ashby with her basket. The heat that wouldn't sink in and the Hollow that had nowhere to put its hand. The crack, and the thorns, and the dust that hung in the air against the wind and bowed.

He told her about the Veil not pushing.

She didn't say anything to that. She just looked at him. For a long time. With her green eyes very steady. And then looked away, out across the dark clearing, at nothing.

"*You could have gone through*," she said.

"*I didn't*."

"*But you could have*."

"*Yes*."

She was quiet.

"*Don't*," said Wren. Very softly. "*Not without me. Not without telling me. Not ever.*"

"*I won't*."

"*Promise*."

"*I promise*."

She leaned her head on his shoulder. Lark stirred inside her coat. Made a small sound. A small creaking complaint. And settled again.

"*Your mam came over*," said Wren after a while. "*This afternoon. With a pie.*"

"*I know*."

"*How do you know*?"

"*Father told me*," said Lex. "*He said act surprised.*"

Wren laughed. It came out of her cracked and tired and sudden, like a laugh out of someone who hadn't expected to laugh again that day.

"*It was a good pie*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK THE ROSE across in the morning.

He'd kept it in a jug of water on the table overnight. It hadn't wilted. It hadn't dropped a petal. It stood in the jug in the grey light by the east window, dark red, velvet, as fresh as when he'd caught it, and the whole kitchen smelled faintly of summer.

Lark had looked at it for a long time from Wren's lap. Very seriously. With her square fists opening and closing.

"*No*," Wren had told her. "*It's got thorns. It's not for you.*"

"*Ah*," said Lark. Disapprovingly.

"*It's not for any of us*," said Lex. "*Ember thinks it's for Mam.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WAS AT the hearth again. Kneeling. Poking the fire. She looked round as the blue door opened.

She saw the rose.

And went white.

Not slowly. All at once. The colour went out of her face the way water goes out of a basin when you pull the plug. She knelt at the hearth with the stick in her hand and stared at the rose in Lex's hand and didn't move.

"*Where did you get that*?" she said.

"*At the Veil*."

"*Where at the Veil*?"

"*Growing*," said Lex. "*Out of the gold. Next to a boy who's been kept.*" He held it out. "*There was this on it.*"

He unfolded the grey silk. Carefully. On his palm.

HES?

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER STOOD UP.

Slowly. Like an old woman. Like someone much older than she was. She came across the room, past the long table, past his father in his chair at the west window, who had turned his head and was watching, very still.

She stopped in front of Lex.

She didn't take the rose. She looked at it. At the dark red of it. At the black stem. At the thorns.

Then at the scrap of grey silk.

She put out one finger. Square. Freckled. And touched the scratched letters. Very lightly. As if they might burn.

"*Rosie*," said Seren Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Who's Rosie*?" said Lex.

His mother didn't answer.

She took the rose. At last. Out of his hand. By the stem. Below the thorns. She held it the way you'd hold something very old and very fragile, a bird's egg, a letter from the dead.

"*Thorns for the one who listened*," she said. Quietly. Not to him. To the rose. "*Mam sang it. At the end of summer. In the old verses. The ones she said I wasn't to sing to anyone, not ever, not even to my own babies.*" She swallowed. "*Gold for the eldest. Glass for the vain. Iron for the one who never laughed.*"

"*Thorns for the one who listened*," said his father. From the window. Very quietly.

His mother looked round at him.

"*She listened*," said Seren. "*To Hesper. When nobody else would. She listened and she said oh, Hes, are you sure. And she said oh.*" Her voice shook. "*And then she went down to the hall that night and drank anyway.*"

She looked back at the rose.

"*Rhosyn*," she said. "*That was her name. The fourth heir. Hesper used to call her Rosie.*" She touched the silk again. "*She had a garden. Roses on a white wall. Mam said they all died on the shingle. One petal at a time. While the Ferryman waited.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The fire ticked. Outside, the stream ran. His father sat at the window with his hands on the arms of his chair.

"*She's asking for Hesper*," said Lex at last.

"*Yes*."

"*Hesper's been dead for nine hundred years*."

"*Rosie doesn't know that*," said his mother. "*Or she does, and she's asking anyway.*" She looked down at the rose in her hand. "*Or she's not asking for Hesper at all.*"

"*Then who*?"

His mother looked at him. With her Harrow eyes. Brown and steady and very tired.

"*Us*," said Seren Harrow. "*She's asking if anyone's still here. Anyone of Hesper's. She's asking if we lived.*" Her mouth twisted. "*She's knocking on the door, love. From the other side. And asking, very politely, if anybody's home.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It could be a trap*," said his father.

They both looked at him.

He hadn't moved. He sat in the wheeled chair at the west window with the blanket over his knees and his spotted hands on *STEADY* and *HOME*, and looked at the rose in his wife's hand with his grey eyes very sharp.

"*It could be*," he said again. "*A rose. For a Harrow woman. With her sister's name on it. Sent through a crack in the Veil by one of the four people who most want Harrow blood.*" His voice was very gentle. "*If I were Oszric, I'd send a rose.*"

Seren looked at him for a long moment.

"*You would*," she said. "*You'd send a rose. You'd write a letter forty pages long and leave it with your son for thirteen years.*" She turned the rose in her fingers. "*You're very clever, Warden. You're very good at traps.*"

"*I'm only saying—*"

"*I know what you're saying.*" She came across the room. To the window. To his chair. And knelt down beside it, on the floor, and laid the rose across his knees. On the blanket. "*Smell it.*"

He looked at her.

"*Go on*," said his wife. "*Smell it.*"

He bent his white head. Slowly. Stiffly. Over the rose on his knees. And breathed in.

Lex saw his face change.

"*Summer*," said Arion Vey. Very quietly.

"*Summer*," said Seren. "*Nine hundred years in a grey country with no sun and no rain and nothing growing, and she grew that.*" She put her hand over his, on the blanket, beside the rose. "*You can't trap anyone with summer, love. It's not the kind of thing you can fake.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LEFT THEM LIKE that.

His father with the rose on his knees. His mother kneeling beside the chair with her hand on his. Both of them looking at it. Not talking.

He went out of the blue door and down the ramp and across the stepping stones and up the hill to the high pasture, where a bronze dragon was waiting with an expression of infinite, ancient, sheep-related patience.

"*Four*," Lex promised him. "*At the Blightmarch. Hask's people will find them.*"

Vharuun opened his eyes.

[He doesn't believe you,] said Ember.

He'll get them.

[He knows. He's just making a point.] A pause. *[So am I. You're going down. To the Knot. Aren't you.]*

Lex didn't answer.

[I don't like it,] said Ember. *[Footnote three. Underlined twice.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POOL LAY IN the middle of the green.

It was smaller than he remembered. It always was. In his head it was enormous, the size of a lake, the size of the hole in the world it had been on Lantern Night when a starving Well came up out of the deep with its whole vast soft heart. But it was a pool. Round. Grey-rimmed. Thirty paces across. Perhaps less. Lying in the long new grass at the bottom of a shallow slope like water in a cupped hand.

Except it wasn't water.

You couldn't see into it. That was the first thing everyone noticed. It wasn't dark the way water is dark at night. It wasn't still the way a pond is still. It was *deep*. That was the only word. You looked into it and your eye just went down. And down. And kept going. And never found a bottom. Like looking up at a clear night sky, except down.

And very far down, so far you could only see them out of the corner of your eye, three small lights.

Gold. Warm. Curled together. Like three people sitting round a fire.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A STICK on the rim.

Long. Plain. Dark. Like a shepherd's crook without the crook. Lying on the grey stone at the edge of the pool, beside a square black stone with two words cut into it in Brannoc's big careful hand.

ISAURA KELL She held on

And standing beside the stick, between it and the pool, a man.

Big. Bigger than Brannoc, almost. Broad as a door. In a leather miner's jerkin with two long scars down the back of it where something had once torn through. A

shaved head. A face like a slab of Coldwater coal. Big scarred hands, folded on top of the stick, which he held upright now, the end planted on the grass.

He was coughing.

Not badly. Not like last year. Not the long wet tearing cough that used to bend him double. A short dry one. A rattle. Twice. Then a breath. In. Slow. Careful. Further than halfway.

Then out.

"*Smith*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hask*."

"*You've come to look at it*."

"*I've come to go down*."

Hask looked at him for a long moment. With his ordinary brown eyes. Not gold anymore. Not moth-lit. Just brown. Just a man's.

"*Down*," he said.

"*Down*."

The big man didn't move out of the way. He stood between Lex and the pool with Kell's stick in his hands and his feet planted and looked at Lex the way a hewer looks at a seam he isn't sure of.

"*Why*?" he said.

Lex told him.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T TAKE LONG. Hask didn't need much. He'd been a Coldwater hewer for twenty-six years and a Delvebreaker for one and Maelis's champion for a season and he'd learned, somewhere in all that, to listen to the short version and fill in the rest himself.

When Lex had finished, he was quiet for a long time.

"*The King*," he said.

"*The King*."

"*She talked about him*." Hask looked down at the pool. "*Maelis. When I was hers. Not much. Once or twice. She said he was the eldest. She said he always went first.*" His big hands shifted on the stick. "*She said he kept things.*"

"*He does*."

"*I didn't know what she meant*," said Hask.

"*Neither did I*," said Lex. "*Until yesterday.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You'll want Ivy*," said Hask at last.

And turned his head. Toward the far side of the pool.

There was a girl there. Sitting on the grey rim. Small. Pale. Fourteen. Fifteen, now, perhaps. Thin as a stick. With a crutch lying on the stone beside her, and one foot, the twisted one, tucked up under her skirt, and the other dangling over the edge of the pool, over the dark, swinging a little.

She was talking.

Not loudly. Not to anyone Lex could see. Just talking. Steadily. Quietly. Looking down into the deep. The way Nan Ashby had talked to her son.

"*She does that every morning*," said Hask. "*Since before dawn. Tells it things.*" A thin smile. Barely there. "*What the sheep are doing. What Kit burned for breakfast. What Brigid said to Absalom about his helmet-lamp. It likes the stupid things best.*"

"*It always did*," said Lex.

He went round the rim.

◆ ◆ ◆

IVY MOSS LOOKED UP as he came.

She had very light eyes. Grey, almost colourless, like water in a tin cup. They looked at him and through him and somewhere slightly behind him, the way they always did, as if she were listening to something just over his shoulder.

"*Good morning, Master Lex*," she said.

"*Good morning, Ivy*."

"*It knew you were coming*." She turned back to the pool. "*It said the smith's coming. It said the smith's got a question in him like a stone in a shoe.*"

"*It said that*?"

"*Not in words*." Ivy swung her foot over the deep. "*It doesn't really do words. Not yet. It does—*" she frowned, searching "*—shapes. Feelings. A sort of leaning. It leans toward things.*" She tilted her head. "*It's leaning toward you now. Can you feel it?*"

He could.

He'd felt it since he came over the rise. A soft pull. A tilt. Like the whole green slope was very slightly downhill toward him, the way a bed slopes toward someone heavy sitting on the edge of it.

[...smith...]

It came up out of the pool. Out of the ground. Out of everywhere. Small and soft and young. Not loud. Not in his ears. Somewhere behind them. The way the Murmur had once come to Antho, all those years, through a crack.

But not hungry now. Not broken.

Just glad.

[...smith...you came...]

"*Hello, Mal*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNELT ON THE rim beside Ivy.

He told it. Not out loud. He didn't need to. He just thought it, looking down into the deep, and felt the pool listen. The way the fire listened in the morning. The way Vharuun listened, with his hand on the warm scales.

The Knot. The Key. The man who'd been holding it for three years at the bottom of the world.

I need to go down, he thought. *To where you used to be. Under the lid. Before you came up. The Knot was right there. Beside you.*

The pool was quiet for a long moment.

[...down...]

Down.

[...where I was HUNGRY...]

Lex felt it flinch. Very slightly. Like a child flinching from the memory of a burn.

I know, he thought. *I'm sorry. I wouldn't ask. Only there's someone down there. Holding something. And something's coming for him.*

[...the grey one...]

Lex went still.

[...the grey one...wound round the cold thing...] The voice was very small. *[...I used to feel him...when I was coming up...he was very tired...]* A pause. *[...he said sorry to me once...when he first went in...he said sorry I didn't know you were a person...]*

He said that?

[...nobody ever...] The pool tilted. Softly. *[...except the old man who sang...and the Warden...and the big one with the stick...and the grey one...]*

A long silence.

[...all right, smith...] said Mal. *[...I remember where I used to sit...I'll make you a room...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's going to do it*," said Ivy Moss.

She'd gone very still. Her colourless eyes fixed on the pool. Her dangling foot stopped swinging.

"*Do what*?" said Hask. He'd come round the rim behind them. Kell's stick in his fist.

"*Make room*," said Ivy. "*Down. All the way down.*" She looked at Lex. "*It's going to make a room for you to go in. Like a bubble. Like a hand cupped round you. It's going to carry you down to where it used to be and hold you there.*" She swallowed. "*It says it'll bring you back. It promises. It says it's not hungry anymore and it won't keep you.*"

"*Do you believe it*?"

Ivy Moss looked at him with her strange light eyes.

"*It's never told me a lie*," she said. "*Not once. It doesn't know how. It's too young.*" She turned back to the pool. "*But it's frightened, Master Lex. It's frightened of the place it used to be. It's going to go there anyway. For you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK OFF HIS boots.

He didn't know why. It seemed right. His mother went barefoot everywhere now. She said she liked to feel the ground.

He took off his coat and folded it on the grass. He kept the bell. He kept Aurelian's little hammer, in its loop on his belt, where it always was. He kept the grey book, in its oilcloth, inside his shirt, because he'd promised.

He sat on the rim with his bare feet over the deep.

[I want it noted,] said Ember, *[that I am extremely, comprehensively, footnote-four-in-red-ink against this.]*

Noted.

[If you die down there your wife will kill me.]

You're a voice in my head.

[She'll find a way,] said Ember. *[She's very resourceful.]*

Lex almost smiled.

Then he slid off the rim.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T FEEL LIKE falling.

It felt like being held.

He went into the dark the way you go into warm water. Slowly. Softly. The deep closing over his feet, his knees, his chest, his head. Not wet. Not cold. Not anything. Just—there. All round him. Close. Like a hand closing round a moth. Like a cupped palm.

And then going down.

He couldn't tell how fast. He couldn't tell how far. There was nothing to see. Dark above. Dark below. Dark all round, soft and close and warm, and in the middle

of it, a space. A small round room of nothing, just big enough for a man sitting with his knees drawn up.

Him.

He sat in it. In the dark. In the room Mal had made. And went down.

[...don't be frightened...] said Mal. Very close now. All round him. *[...I've got you...]*

I'm not frightened.

[...I am...] said Mal.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT WHEN they got there.

A change. In the dark. A pressure, all at once, from every side. Not pushing in. Pushing *against*. The way the air feels before a storm. The way a forge feels when you open the door and the heat comes out at you like a hand.

Threads.

He couldn't see them. He'd lost that. He'd lost it two years ago when he took his hand off the net, and he'd missed it every day since the way you'd miss a sense. Like going deaf. Like losing the taste of bread.

But he could feel them. Down here. So many of them. So thick. So close. Running past him in the dark on every side, above and below, in every direction, more of them than there were stars, all humming. All singing. All pulling in toward one point. Like the spokes of a wheel pulling in toward the hub.

And at the hub—

The room Mal had made opened.

Just a little. A crack. Like an eye.

And there was light.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS ON BLACK glass.

He knew it. He'd knelt on it before. A disc of it, smooth and dark and cold, a mile across, at the bottom of the world. The lid. The great black seal Aurelian had put over the starving Well nine hundred years ago, which Lex had watched tilt and lift and crack open, with gold pouring up out of it, on the worst night of his life.

It was closed now. Healed. Smooth. The Well that had been under it was a pool in a green field three hundred miles away with a girl on a crutch telling it about sheep.

But the glass was still here. And in the middle of the glass—

The Key.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT STOOD UP OUT of the black like a sword out of a stone.

A key. Taller than a man's forearm. Black iron. In three pieces, fitted together, so cleanly you couldn't see the joins unless you knew where to look. The bow at the top, a broad open loop. The bit in the middle, notched and toothed. The blade below, sunk into the glass. Into the Lock.

Turned closed.

And beside it, in the glass, a second slot. Narrow. Jagged. And in the slot, a second thing. Dark grey. Almost black. Notched like a mountain range. With a thin line of gold runes down its face.

The Lockward.

He'd been there when it was forged. At the Hollowmaw, with the whole world coming apart. Dorran Vask striking. Wren's breath in the fire. Hedda's runes. His father's Wellscript. His own blood in the quench. And a rune at the very end, near the hilt, that meant only one thing. *STAY*.

And round both of them—round the Key and the Lockward together, binding them, holding them, wound so tight you couldn't see the black iron through it in places—

A thread.

Grey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULD SEE IT.

He didn't know how. He couldn't see the others. The thousand thousand threads pulling in all round him, singing in the dark. He could feel them, but he couldn't see them.

He could see this one.

Thin. Grey. Not silver. Not gold. *Grey*. The grey of an old man's hair. The grey of a cloak sewn with tiny brass storm-charms. Wound round and round the Key and the Lockward, tight, tighter, a hundred times, a thousand, until it was more like a cocoon than a thread. A grey cocoon on a black iron key, at the bottom of the world, at the centre of everything.

And at the top of it, where the thread ran up out of the binding and away into the dark—

A shape.

Not a man. A suggestion of one. A long grey smudge on the air, like smoke. Like the ghost of a figure in a misted mirror. A head, maybe. Shoulders, maybe. Hunched. Bent over the thing it held.

Very still.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Elric*," said Lex.

The shape didn't move.

He stood on the black glass in his bare feet with the threads singing all round him and the room Mal had made still open at his back, a soft dark round mouth in the air, waiting.

"*Elric*," he said again. "*It's Lex.*"

Nothing.

He came closer. Across the glass. Slowly. The way you'd come up on a sleeping animal.

"*You called me*," he said. "*You said wake up. You said they're coming for the Key.*" He stopped. A few paces off. Close enough now to see the grey thread clearly. How fine it was. How tight. How in places, where it was wound thickest, it had worn thin. Frayed. Like an old rope on a well-winch. "*I'm awake. I'm here.*"

The shape didn't move.

And then it did.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT LIFTED ITS HEAD.

That was all. The smudge on the air that might have been a head came up. Slowly. Very slowly. The way an old man lifts his head from a book when someone says his name, and has to come back from a long way off to remember where he is.

And looked at him.

There was no face. There was nothing that could have been a face. Just grey. Just smoke.

But it looked at him. He felt it.

"*Well*," said a voice.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T LOUD. IT wasn't anything. It was a voice made of thread, if a thread could talk. Thin. Dry. Rasping. Like wind through a gap in a wall.

But Lex knew it.

He'd have known it anywhere. He'd heard it on the first day. In the Ashbourne forge, with the smoke and the anvil and Brannoc swearing, and a tall grey man with

an ash staff and a raven on his shoulder ducking under the door, smiling, saying *you must be the smith*.

He'd heard it lie to him for a year.

He'd heard it, at the end, on the black glass, with old hands on the Lockward's hilt, say *tell him*.

"*Well*," said Elric Thorne. "*Took you long enough, lad.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T KNOW WHAT to say.

He stood on the black glass and looked at the grey smudge on the air and all the things he'd thought about on the way down went out of his head. All the questions. All the careful words.

"*Three years*," he said.

"*Three years*," agreed Elric. "*Nearly. Give or take. It's hard to tell, down here. There's no sun. There's no dinner.*" A faint dry sound. A rasp. It might have been a laugh. "*I've been counting threads. It passes the time. There are four million, one hundred and six thousand and some. I keep losing count around the eight-hundred-thousandth.*"

"*You never said anything*."

"*There was nothing to say*." The grey smudge tilted. "*I was holding a key. That's all. It doesn't take conversation. It takes—*" A pause. "*—stubbornness. Mostly. And not thinking about it too much.*"

"*Arion tried to reach you. And Seraphine. The first winter.*"

The smudge went still.

"*I know*," said Elric. Very quietly. "*I heard them.*"

"*Then why didn't you—*"

"*Because I didn't know what to say to him, lad*," said Elric Thorne. "*Not then. I still don't.*" A long dry silence. "*I've had three years. And I still don't.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember. Very small. *[Ask him. Ask him what's coming.]*

Lex swallowed.

"*You said they're coming for the Key*."

"*I did*."

"*Who*?"

The grey smudge didn't answer at once.

It turned. Slowly. Away from him. Toward the edge of the black glass. Toward the dark beyond, where the threads came pouring in from every direction, thousands upon thousands of them, singing.

"*Look*," said Elric. "*There. You can't see them, can you. Any of them. You gave that up.*" A pause. "*But you can see me. Because I'm one. And you can see that.*"

Lex looked.

And saw it.

◆ ◆ ◆

ONE THREAD.

Among the thousands. Among the millions. Running away from the Key. From the Knot. From the black glass. Out into the dark, sideways, away, so long and so straight that it seemed to go on forever. Silver. Bright. Brighter than the others. Thicker. Tauter. Like the top string of a harp, tuned higher than all the rest.

He could see it. Like the grey one. Because something was on it.

Far away. So far it was only a speck. A pinprick. At the very edge of seeing.

A ring.

Black. Small. Round. Closed round the silver thread like a bead on a wire.

And beyond it, further, another. And beyond that another. And another. A line of them. Black rings on a silver thread. Strung out into the dark. Coming closer.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The last thread*," said Elric.

Lex didn't speak.

"*Aurelian tied it last*," said the voice of thread. "*When he'd finished. When the whole net was woven and the lid was on and the Nine were rowed out. He came down here, to the Knot, and he tied one more thread. Out to the edge. To hold it.*" A pause. "*The Veil, lad. That's what the Veil is. It's not a wall. It's not a curtain. It's a thread. The last one. Stretched out at the edge of the net to keep the world in and the grey out.*"

"*And it ties in here*."

"*Right here*." The smudge tilted toward the Key. "*Into the Knot. Into the middle. Same as every other thread.*" A dry rasp. "*Which means, if you were on the other end of it. Out at the edge. And you wanted to come in.*"

"*You could climb it*," said Lex.

"*You could climb it*," agreed Elric.

◆ ◆ ◆

Clink.

Lex heard it.

Far off. So far it was barely a sound. Down the long silver line of the last thread, out in the dark, at the very edge of hearing. A small hard sharp sound. Like a link of chain closing. Like a hammer on cold iron. Like a smith, a very long way off, striking one blow.

Clink.

And a new ring. Black. Small. Round. Closing round the silver thread. A little closer than the last.

"*That's him*," said Elric. Quietly. "*Every few hours. I can feel it, every one. Like a stitch in my side.*" The grey smudge didn't move. "*He's ringing it as he comes. With iron. So it won't throw him off.*"

"*Who*?"

"*I don't know his name*," said Elric. "*I know what he feels like. Heavy. Patient. Cold. Like an anvil. Like a gaol door.*" A pause. "*He's very sure of himself. He's not in a hurry. He knows exactly how long it'll take and he's going to take exactly that long.*"

Iron for the one who never laughed.

"*Caddoc*," said Lex.

"*Is that his name*?" said Elric. "*Huh.*" A rasp. "*It suits him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*How long*?"

The grey smudge was quiet for a moment.

"*I've been working it out*," it said. "*I've had time. Six weeks of it. Counting rings. Counting the gaps.*" A pause. "*He's slow, at the edge. The thread goes down there, steep, through the grey. He's faster now. He'll be faster again when he's under the world, where it runs flat.*" The smudge tilted. "*The end of autumn, lad. Give or take a day. The night you light your lanterns.*"

"*Lantern Night*."

"*Lantern Night*," said Elric Thorne. "*He'll come down that thread and onto this glass. And he'll take the Lockward out, because I'm three years old in here and very tired and he's an anvil. And he'll take the Key.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And then*?"

"*And then he'll take it to the one who wants it*," said Elric. "*And they'll turn it.*"

"*Arion says the net would ask them what they wanted*."

The grey smudge went very still.

"*Does he*," said Elric. Very quietly.

"*He says nobody's holding it. Since I let go. He says it would take a hand.*" Lex swallowed. "*He says it would give them what they asked for.*"

A long silence.

"*He's right*," said Elric Thorne. "*He was always right. That was the worst thing about him.*" A dry rasp. Not a laugh. "*I've been reading, lad. Down here. Three years. There's nothing else to do. Aurelian left notes. He always left notes. In the knots. In the way the threads cross. You can read them if you've got long enough and nothing else to look at.*"

"*What do they say*?"

"*They say the Key unwrites*," said Elric. "*Whatever it's turned against. And they say that when it's turned in the Knot, the net feels it. All of it. Every thread. And the net, being a net, and having nobody's hand on it, does what nets do when someone picks up the end.*"

He paused.

"*It goes where the hand goes*," said Elric. "*Whoever turns the Key, lad, the net offers them everything. Every thread. Every knot. Every Ceiling. Every Stone. The Root. The whole of it.*" A rasp. "*You left a crown lying in the road. And they're coming to pick it up.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX COULDN'T BREATHE.

He stood on the black glass in his bare feet and thought of a boy in a field. Gold. Mid-step. His eyes moving.

He thought of a net with a crown on it. A gold crown. Every thread kept. Every level fixed. Every Ceiling back, and never, ever lifting. Every child Kindled into the same class as their mother and their grandmother and their grandmother's grandmother, forever, no growth, no change, nothing new.

Kept.

[Lex,] said Ember. *[Lex, breathe.]*

He breathed.

"*Can we stop him*?" he said. "*On the thread. Before he gets here.*"

"*I don't know*," said Elric. "*You can try. I'd try.*" A pause. "*He's very heavy, lad. And very sure.*"

"*Can we move the Key*?"

"*It's in the Lock. The Lockward's in it. I'm in it.*" The smudge didn't move. "*If you take the Lockward out to move the Key, the Key's free. If the Key's free, he can feel it. All the way down the thread.*" A rasp. "*And so can anyone else who wants it.*"

"*Then what—*"

"*Then there's only one other thing the Key can do*," said Elric Thorne.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAID IT VERY quietly.

"*It could be turned against the last thread. Before he gets here. Unwrite it.*" A pause. "*No thread, no climbing. He'd just—drop. Wherever he was. Back into the grey. Or into nothing.*"

Lex stared at him.

"*Unwrite the Veil*," he said.

"*Unwrite the Veil*."

"*Then the Veil's gone*."

"*Then the Veil's gone*," said Elric. "*And the grey country's on the other side of nothing at all. And they walk in.*" The smudge tilted. "*On foot. Like anyone. No road to the Key. No crown in the road.*" A dry rasp. "*Just four very old, very hungry people, and a country full of gold, walking into your world across the Sundered Lands.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And whoever turns it*," said Lex slowly.

"*Gets offered the crown*," said Elric. "*Same as anyone. The net doesn't care why you're turning it. It just feels a hand.*"

"*So if I turned it—*"

"*You'd be Root again*," said Elric. "*Crowned. Whether you wanted it or not. With every thread in your hands and nobody to give it back to.*" A pause. "*And then you'd be the thing they're coming for, lad. You. Not the Key. You.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*There's a way round it*," said Elric. "*Aurelian thought of it. He always thought of everything, damn him. It's in the knots. Down there, by the Lockward. In the last crossing he made before he went up.*" The smudge was very still. "*Only a hand that's already refused a crown can turn it and stay itself.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[Lex. The crown. The seven-pointed one. The hollow in the box.]*

He knew.

He'd known since the word *crown*. He'd known since a cellar at Harrow, a box with a moth carved in its lid and crossed out, a hollow pressed into the oak at the bottom. A circle. Seven points.

I've taken the crown where it belongs.

"*Hesper's*," he said.

The grey smudge looked at him for a long moment.

"*Is that her name*?" said Elric. "*Aurelian didn't write it. He just wrote—*" a dry rasp "*—the tenth. The one that never touched the pool. The only crown that can say no.*" A pause. "*He wrote, if it must be turned again, let the hand wear the tenth crown.*"

"*It's gone*," said Lex. "*Wenna took it. My grandmother. My mother's mother. Thirty years ago. She left a letter. She said she'd taken it where it belongs.*"

"*Then ask your mother where it belongs*," said Elric Thorne.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM BEHIND HIM moved.

Lex felt it. The soft dark mouth Mal had made, open in the air at his back. Tilting. Leaning. A small anxious pull.

[...smith...] Very faint. Very small. *[...smith, I can't stay...it's the HUNGRY place...I can feel it in the glass...]*

A moment, thought Lex. *Just a moment more.*

[...smith...]

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's calling you*," said Elric. "*The little one. Isn't it.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Go on, then*." The grey smudge bent back over the Key. Over the Lockward. Over the thread wound round them, frayed and worn and tight. "*Don't keep it waiting. It's frightened of this place. It's right to be.*"

Lex didn't move.

"*Elric*."

"*Lad*."

"*Is there anything you want*?" He didn't know why he said it. It came out of him. "*Anything I can—bring. Or tell anyone. Or—*"

The smudge was still for a long time.

"*Quill*," said Elric at last. "*Is he—*"

"*He's at the Forge*," said Lex. "*On the chimney. He's got a nest. Made of spoons.*"

A sound. Dry. Rasping. Very soft.

"*He always liked spoons*," said Elric Thorne.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And your father*," said Elric.

Lex waited.

"*Is he—*" The voice stopped. Tried again. "*I felt something. A year ago. On the threads. Something very old going very fast. Like a candle burning down from both ends.*"

"*He's old*," said Lex. "*Older than anyone. He's got a year. Maybe two.*" He swallowed. "*He's happy. My mother's home. She doesn't remember him. She's courting him. She brought him a pie.*"

The grey smudge didn't move. Didn't speak. For so long that Lex thought it had gone back into its silence. Into its three years. Into its counting.

And then, very quietly—

"*Don't tell him*," said Elric. "*That I asked.*"

"*He asked about you*."

The smudge went very still.

"*He asked how you sounded*," said Lex. "*He asked me to tell him exactly. The words. How you said them.*"

A long, long silence.

"*Then bring him*," said Elric Thorne. Very quietly. Not looking up. Bent over the Key, over the Lockward, over his own frayed grey thread. "*Before he goes. If he'll come. If the little one can carry him.*" A pause. "*I'd like to say it to his face. Whatever it is. I've had three years. I'll have worked it out by then.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[...SMITH...]

The room pulled. Hard. Lex felt it take hold of him. Soft. Warm. Frightened. Like a hand round a moth.

"*Go*," said Elric.

Lex went.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT THE DARK close round him. Felt the black glass go out from under his bare feet. Felt himself lift. Rising. Fast now. Faster than coming down. Mal pulling him up and away from the hungry place as fast as it could go.

And behind him, below him, far down at the bottom of the world, at the centre of everything, on a long silver thread that ran out into the dark—

Clink.

A ring of black iron. Closing. One more.

He counted, all the way up. He couldn't help it.

By Lantern Night, give or take a day, there would be a great many more.

CHAPTER 4

The Kept

ANTHO COUNTED THE LANTERNS every night.

He'd done it for three years. Since before Lex wove the net. Since before the door at the bottom of the passage was a door at all, when it was only a black glass seal at the end of a long cold tunnel in the mountain, with his mother on the other side of it.

He walked down the passage at dusk with the Keeper's Lantern in his hand and counted.

One. Two. Three. All the way down. Iron lanterns and tin ones and clay ones and one made out of a turnip that a child from Millbridge had carved and filled with tallow and that Seraphine re-carved every autumn when the old one rotted. On shelves cut into the rock. On hooks. On the floor, in rows, along both walls. Each one lit. Each one for someone. Someone's daughter. Someone's father. Someone who'd gone into the dark and not come back, or come back changed, or come back and gone again.

One thousand, one hundred and thirteen.

He'd stopped at the last one. At the bottom of the passage. In front of the door. A black door of glass, set in the rock, with nothing behind it now but the dark of the mountain and, far down, the place where a Well had once lain starving.

There was a small brown clay lamp on the floor in front of it. Chipped at the spout. With a thumbprint in the base.

He didn't count that one. It wasn't for anyone. It was just his.

"*One thousand, one hundred and thirteen*," said Antho Vey. To the door. To the dark. To nobody.

And turned round. And went back up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE WAS WAITING AT the top.

She was sitting on the step where the passage came up into the great hall of the Keep, with her knees pulled up and a book open on them and an ink-pot balanced on the stone beside her, writing. She didn't look up as he came.

"*How many*?" she said.

"*One thousand, one hundred and thirteen*."

"*Same as yesterday*."

"*Same as yesterday*."

She wrote something. A short line. At the bottom of the page.

"*What's that*?"

"*Reason five hundred and sixty-two*," said Seraphine Ilvane. Not looking up. "*He counts the lanterns every night even though he knows exactly how many there are, because he says if he ever stops counting he'll stop seeing them, and if he stops seeing them he'll stop seeing the people they're for.*"

He sat down on the step beside her.

"*I never said that*."

"*You said it to Pim*," said Seraphine. "*Last week. When he asked why. I was on the stairs.*" She blotted the line. Carefully. With a corner of her sleeve. "*You were very wise and very boring about it. It was extremely attractive.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D BEEN KEEPING THE list for three years. Since before the wedding. Since before he'd asked her, at the bottom of the world, with his voice shaking, whether she'd marry a man who'd been mad for eight years and might go mad again.

Reasons, she'd said. *To marry you. In case I ever forget. In case you ever ask me why.*

There had been four hundred and twelve on the wedding day. She'd read some of them out. In the middle of the vows. In front of the black door, in front of the Queen, in front of everyone. Number one hundred and six had been *he plays the flute badly but he plays it anyway, every night, so the dark will know someone's listening*. Number three hundred and forty had been *he once spent six hours trying to get a goat out of a well and when he got it out it bit him and he apologized to it*.

Lex had laughed so hard he'd had to sit down.

The list had gone past five hundred on Lantern Night. On the rubble. While Antho held a door open for a Well with his whole heart and very nearly didn't come back.

She'd never told him what number five hundred was.

He'd never asked.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You've got that look*," said Seraphine.

"*What look*?"

"*The one where you're listening to something I can't hear*." She closed the book. Turned on the step to face him. Her spectacles had slid down her nose. She pushed them up. "*Is it Mal?*"

"*No*." He looked out across the hall. At the long tables. At the great fire. At the students eating their supper. Odile at the head of one table, cutting bread with a Shade-knife she wasn't supposed to use for bread. Teo dripping on the end of another, the way he always dripped, because he was a Tide Speaker and water followed him round like a dog. The Millbridge twins arguing about something. Pim, at the end of the bench by the fire, alone, small, silent, eating his soup. "*It's not anything. It's just—*"

He didn't know what it was.

It had been there all day. Since the morning. A pressure. Faint. At the very edge of him. Not a sound. Not a voice. A *draught*. The feeling you get in a big old house when somebody, somewhere, has left a door open, and the air is moving in a way it shouldn't, and you can't tell where it's coming from.

He was a Threshold Warden. He felt doors. That was what he was.

And somewhere, a long way off, a door had opened that shouldn't have.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*How's Bet*?" he said.

Seraphine's face changed.

"*Not long*," she said. Quietly. "*Tonight. Tomorrow. I sat with her this afternoon. She asked me to read to her and she fell asleep in the middle of a sentence and I sat there and listened to her breathe.*" She looked down at the closed book on her knees. "*It catches. Every few breaths. And then it starts again.*"

"*And Fennick*?"

"*Won't leave her*." Seraphine's mouth twisted. "*He hasn't slept for three days. He sits by the bed and holds her hand and talks. About the sheep. About their boy. About the first time he saw her, at a hiring fair in Thistledown, forty-one years ago, in a yellow dress.*" She swallowed. "*He's told me about the yellow dress four times. He doesn't know he's told me.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

They'd come up the mountain a week ago. An old shepherd and his wife. From the high crofts above Thistledown. On foot, the last of it, because the cart couldn't manage the path. She'd been walking with a stick, slowly, leaning on him. They'd come to light a lantern for their son. Wat Dale. Twenty-two. Who'd gone down to

work the Coldwater seams eleven years ago for the money and come up grey and coughing and died in the spring.

She'd lit it herself. Her hands shaking. On a shelf a third of the way down the passage. *For Wat. From his mam.*

And then she'd sat down on the step at the top of the passage, very carefully, and said, *I don't think I can go down again, love*.

She hadn't been able to. They'd given her the little room off the east stair. With the window. Where you could see the mountains.

She'd been dying ever since.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'll go and sit with them*," said Antho. "*Later. When the students are in bed.*"

"*Take your flute*."

"*She doesn't like my flute*."

"*Nobody likes your flute*," said Seraphine. "*That's not the point. Fennick likes it. He told me. He said it makes him feel like someone's keeping watch.*" She stood up. Gathered her book and her ink-pot. Looked down at him. "*Reason five hundred and sixty-three. He goes and sits with dying strangers in the middle of the night and plays them a song they don't like because it's better than silence.*"

"*That's two in one night*."

"*It's been a good night*," said Seraphine.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD THE KNOCK at midnight.

He was in the little room off the east stair. Sitting on the floor with his back to the wall, under the window, with his bone flute in his lap. Not playing. He'd played. An hour of it. The Lantern Song, every verse, slowly, the way his mother used to sing it. Bet had slept through it. Fennick hadn't. Fennick had sat by the bed with his wife's hand in both of his and his eyes shut, listening, and when Antho stopped, he'd said, very quietly, *thank you, Master Vey*.

Now it was quiet.

Bet's breathing. In. Catch. Silence. In again.

Fennick's. Slow. Heavy. The breathing of a man who has been awake for three days and is very nearly not.

And then the knock.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME FROM BELOW. From the great door of the Keep. The outer one. Oak and iron, three hands thick, that opened onto the mountain path and the long drop to the valley.

Knock.

Not loud. Not hard. Three soft taps. Courteous. Patient. The way a well-brought-up visitor knocks at a house where they know someone is ill.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

Antho was on his feet before the third.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT ON the stairs.

The draught. The one he'd felt all day. Not far off now. Not at the edge of him. *Here*. On the other side of the great door. Pressing on it. Not hard. Just leaning. The way a cat leans on a door it wants to come through.

He'd felt a lot of things on the other side of doors.

He'd felt the hunger at the bottom of the world. He'd felt his mother. He'd felt a Moth Queen, tall and grey-gold and courteous, standing in the snow outside this very door last spring, asking very politely if she might come in.

This wasn't any of those.

This was *thin*. That was all he could think. Thin and dry and old. Not a person. Not quite. Not a thing. A shape, held together by something that wasn't flesh. Like smoke that had decided to stand up. Like a draught that had learned to knock.

He stopped at the bottom of the stair. In the great hall. In the dark. The fire was down to embers. The tables were empty. The students were asleep.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

"*Who's there*?" said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*A servant*," said a voice.

It came through the oak. Through the iron. Through the three hands' thickness of door. Dry. Soft. Hissing. Like sand poured slowly out of a sack.

"*Only a servant, master*," it said. "*A steward. My name is Orrin. I have a gift.*"

"*I don't want it*."

"*It isn't for you*," said the voice. Gently. "*Forgive me. It isn't for anyone in particular. I carry it from house to house. I knock. I ask.*" A pause. "*May I come in?*"

Antho didn't move.

He knew that question. He'd heard it before. In the snow. In a voice like warm honey. *May I come in?*

Don't ever let a moth in, his mother had said. Through the door. A year ago. *Don't ever.*

"*No*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE VOICE ON THE other side of the door laughed.

Softly. Not unkindly. Like an old man laughing at a child who has said something very serious and very sweet.

"*Of course not*," it said. "*Of course. You're a Harrow. I forgot. She warned us. Hesper. Nine hundred years ago. On the shingle.*" A sigh, like dust settling. "*No light in any window. No moth through any door.*"

"*You're not a moth.*"

"*No*," agreed Orrin. "*I'm dust. Mostly. Dust doesn't need to be let in.*"

And came in.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THROUGH THE DOOR.

Under it.

Antho saw it. In the dark. In the faint red light of the embers. A thin grey line of dust, sifting in under the great oak door the way snow sifts in under a door in a blizzard. Soft. Silent. Spreading across the flagstones in a thin pale fan.

And then rising.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT STOOD UP IN the middle of the great hall like smoke rising off a doused fire.

Tall. Thin. Bent. A shape made of grey-gold dust, its edges smoking, shifting, never quite still. Arms like bundles of dead twigs. A long narrow head. A suggestion of a coat. A chain round its neck, black. And two eyes. Dim. Barely lit. Two sparks in the dust, like the ends of pipes in a dark room.

It bowed.

Low. Courteous. Old-fashioned. One twig-arm folded across its middle and the other held out to the side.

"*Master Vey*," whispered Orrin. "*The warden. The door. His Majesty has heard of you.*"

Antho threw a Void Bolt at it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T THINK ABOUT it. He didn't plan it. His hand came up and the dark came out of it, the way it had come out of him ten thousand times, a fist of black nothing hurled across the hall at the shape in the dust.

It went through.

Of course it did. The dust scattered. Blew apart round the bolt in a glittering cloud, like flour thrown in the air. The bolt went on and hit the far wall and left a scorch on the stone the size of a dinner plate.

And the dust came back together.

Slowly. Unhurried. Grain by grain. Settling back into the thin bent shape, the long head, the twig arms, the two dim sparks.

"*Oh, master*," it whispered. Sadly. "*Your brother tried that too. With fire. This morning. At the edge of the world.*" The sparks flickered. "*I'm only dust. You can't hurt dust. You can only move it about.*"

"*Then I'll move it*," said Antho.

And called the wind.

◆ ◆ ◆

GALE CAME TO HIM easier than it came to Lex. It always had. He'd been Speaking it for a year. He didn't have to ask. He just had to open his hand.

He opened his hand.

The air in the great hall moved. All of it. All at once. A gust, out of nowhere, out of everywhere, sweeping across the flagstones, through the tables, up into the high dark beams. The embers in the hearth flared bright red and roared. Papers flew off the long tables. A chair went over.

The dust went with it.

Up. Away. Whirling into the beams like smoke up a chimney. Scattering into every corner of the hall. Spreading thin. Thinner. Until there was nothing left of the shape at all, just a faint grey haze in the air, glittering in the red of the embers.

Antho stood in the middle of the hall with his hand open and his breath going hard.

And from everywhere—from the beams, from the corners, from the haze in the air—very soft, very patient, like sand sifting through the cracks of a floor—

"*That's better*," whispered Orrin. "*Now everyone can hear me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE UNDERSTOOD TOO LATE.

The dust was everywhere. He'd put it everywhere. He'd blown it up into the beams and the corners and the cracks in the stone, and the beams ran into the walls, and the walls ran up into the floors above, into the stairwells and the corridors and the rooms.

Into every room in the Keep.

And from every room, at once, very softly, the voice began to speak.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Forgive me*," it said.

Antho heard it. In the hall. In the stairwell behind him. In the corridors above, faint, echoing. He heard a door open somewhere on the second floor. A student's voice, sleepy, frightened. *Who's there?*

"*Forgive me for waking you*," whispered Orrin. To everyone. To the whole Keep. Gently. So gently. "*I won't stay long. I only want to say one thing. I carry a gift from my master, and I offer it to anyone who wants it.*"

"*Stop*," said Antho.

"*My master is very old*," said the voice. "*Older than your world. He has sat by a great many beds. He has watched a great many people he loved grow thin, and grey, and slow. He has held their hands while their breath caught. And caught. And stopped.*"

"*Stop it*."

"*And he could not bear it*," whispered Orrin. "*So he found a way. So that nobody he loved would ever have to go. So nobody would ever have to sit by a bed again.*" A pause. Soft as dust settling. "*He keeps them.*"

Antho ran for the stairs.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT UP THEM three at a time. The Keeper's Lantern in his fist, blazing. The voice coming out of the walls all round him, soft and kind and patient.

"*Not dead*," it said. "*Not changed. Not hurt. Kept. Exactly as they are. Exactly as you love them. Forever.*" A sigh. "*No more fear. No more pain. No more wasting. No more watching the breath catch.*"

He was on the second floor. The students were in the corridor. Half a dozen of them. In their nightshirts. White-faced. Odile at the front, with her Shade-knife in her hand and her jaw set. The Millbridge twins clinging to each other. Teo dripping.

"*Master Antho—*"

"*Back in your rooms*," said Antho. "*Shut the doors. Don't listen.*"

"*It's in the walls—*"

"*I know where it is. Don't listen to it.*"

"*I carry a pinch of my master's gold*," whispered the voice. From the walls. From the ceiling. From the cracks round the doors. "*Only a pinch. On the tongue. That's all it takes.*" Gently. "*For anyone who's sitting by a bed tonight. For anyone who's holding*

a hand and listening to the breath catch. You need only come down to the courtyard and ask."

He was past the students. Running. Up again. To the third floor. To the east stair.

To the little room with the window.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DOOR WAS OPEN.

He stopped in it.

Bet was asleep. In the bed under the window. Her thin face grey on the pillow. Her breathing slow. In. Catch. Silence.

In again.

Fennick was awake.

He was sitting by the bed. Where he'd been sitting for three days. With his wife's hand in both of his. His big shepherd's hands, brown and cracked and gentle, wrapped round her thin white one. He was looking at the wall.

At a crack in the wall. Beside the window. A thin dark line in the old stone, where the mortar had worn.

A little grey dust was sifting out of it. Very slowly. Like sand in an hourglass.

"*Forever*," the crack was saying. Softly. Only to him. "*She'd never have to go, old man. You'd never have to watch.*"

Fennick's face was wet.

"*Fennick*," said Antho.

The old shepherd didn't look round.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Don't listen to it*," said Antho. From the doorway. Very quietly. "*Please. Fennick. It's not what it sounds like.*"

"*What does it sound like*?" said Fennick Dale.

His voice was hoarse. Three days of not sleeping. Three days of talking about sheep and a yellow dress.

"*It sounds like she wouldn't die*," he said.

"*I know*."

"*It sounds like I wouldn't have to sit here and listen to her stop*." He was still looking at the crack. At the dust. "*I've been listening for three days, Master Vey. Every breath. Waiting for the one that doesn't start again.*" He swallowed. "*Do you know what that's like?*"

Antho didn't answer.

He did know. He'd sat on a rubble-heap a few months ago with an old man's hand in his and felt it go slack.

"*It's a lie*," he said. "*Whatever it is. Whatever it does. It's not what it sounds like.*"

"*How do you know*?"

"*Because it came in under the door*," said Antho Vey. "*Things that tell the truth knock and wait.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

FENNICK LOOKED AT HIM then.

For a long moment. With his red tired eyes. The eyes of a man who has been very kind his whole life to sheep and dogs and a wife in a yellow dress, and has been given nothing back for it, in the end, but a dead son and a dying wife and a narrow bed in a cold stone room on a mountain.

"*No*," said a voice from the bed.

They both turned.

◆ ◆ ◆

BET WAS AWAKE.

Her eyes were open. Pale blue. Faded. Clouded at the edges. Looking at the crack in the wall. At the dust.

She'd heard.

"*No*," said Bet Dale. Very faintly. A whisper. Barely a breath. "*No, thank you.*"

The crack went quiet.

"*Bet—*" Fennick's voice broke. "*Bet, love, you heard—*"

"*I heard*." Her hand moved, very slightly, in both of his. "*I'm not deaf, Fen. I'm dying. It's different.*" A ghost of a smile. Her lips were grey. "*No, thank you. Tell it.*"

"*It says you'd never—*"

"*I know what it says*." Her eyes went to his face. Slowly. As if it took all the strength she had left. "*I've had sixty-three years, Fen. I've had you. I've had Wat. I've had the high crofts and the sheep and that yellow dress.*" Another breath. Catch. Silence. In again. "*I'm not greedy.*"

He was crying. Openly. His head bent over her hand.

"*I don't want to be kept*," said Bet Dale. To the crack in the wall. To the dust. To whatever was listening. "*I want to go and see my boy.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CLOSED HER EYES.

Fennick held her hand.

And the crack in the wall, very softly, very patiently, like sand settling, said nothing at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STAYED TILL DAWN.

He sat on the floor with his back to the wall and the Keeper's Lantern beside him, blazing, and his bone flute in his lap, and watched the crack. Nothing came out of it. Nothing moved.

The voice in the walls had gone quiet.

He'd gone down once, in the dark hours, to check the courtyard. Seraphine had come with him. White-faced, with her spectacles crooked and a Hush-cup in her hand. They'd stood in the door of the great hall and looked out at the courtyard under the cold stars. Empty. The flagstones grey. The well-head. The mounting block. The gate.

Nothing.

No thin grey shape. No dim sparks. Nobody waiting.

"*It's gone*," said Seraphine.

"*It's not gone*," said Antho. "*It's waiting.*"

He went back up to the little room with the window. And sat down. And watched the crack.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MUST HAVE SLEPT.

He didn't mean to. He'd been awake since the knock. He'd been awake, mostly, for a long time before that. He closed his eyes for a moment, just a moment, with the lantern beside him and the flute in his lap and the slow sound of Bet's breathing.

In. Catch. Silence. In again.

And when he opened them, it was grey light. And the breathing had stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNEW BEFORE HE looked.

Not because it was quiet. It wasn't the kind of quiet he'd been waiting for. The quiet after the last breath, when the room changes. When something goes out of it. When there's one fewer person in it than there was.

He knew that quiet. He'd been in a lot of rooms.

This wasn't that.

This was *full*.

◆ ◆ ◆

FENNICK WAS STANDING BY the window.

He'd got up. He was standing with his back to the bed and his hands at his sides, looking out at the mountains in the grey dawn. Very still. His shoulders very straight.

There was a small silk pouch on the windowsill. Open. Tied with a gold cord. Empty.

And on the bed—

◆ ◆ ◆

BET DALE WAS GOLD.

She lay on her back under the grey wool blanket with her head on the pillow and her hands folded on her chest, the way Fennick must have folded them. Her thin face turned a little toward the window. Her mouth a little open. Caught in the middle of a breath.

Gold.

All of her. Her grey hair on the pillow, every strand of it, gold. Her eyelashes. Her eyebrows. The fine lines round her eyes and her mouth. The liver-spots on the backs of her folded hands. The thin gold chain of her wedding ring, which had been gold already, and now was simply part of her finger, part of her hand, part of the rest of her.

The blanket where it touched her was gold. Up to the line of her shoulders. As if the gold had crept a little way out of her and stopped.

And her eyes.

They were open.

They were looking at the window.

At the old man standing in it with his back to her.

And as Antho stood up, slowly, with his heart going like a hammer, they moved.

Slowly. So slowly. The way the hand of a clock moves. Across. Down. To him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She was going*," said Fennick Dale.

He didn't turn round. He spoke to the window. To the mountains.

"*An hour ago. Before the light. Her breath went and it didn't come back for a long time. Longer than ever.*" His voice was very calm. "*And then it came back. And then it went again. And I thought, this is it. This is the one.*" He swallowed. "*And I couldn't.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

"*It was on the windowsill*," said Fennick. "*When I looked up. Just sitting there. Like it had been waiting.*" His hands at his sides opened and closed. "*She said no. I know she said no. I heard her.*" A long silence. "*I just couldn't, Master Vey. I couldn't sit there and listen to her stop.*"

He turned round.

He looked at the bed. At his wife. At the gold face on the pillow, mid-breath.

At her eyes. Which moved. Slowly. To him.

"*She's not dead*," said Fennick Dale. "*Is she.*"

"*No.*"

"*She'll never die.*"

"*No.*"

The old shepherd came and knelt by the bed. And reached out. And took her hand. Her folded gold hand. In both of his.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAW HIS FACE.

Saw it understand. All at once. The way a man understands, stepping off a ledge in the dark, that there was no step there.

The hand was cold.

Not dead-cold. Not the cold of a body. The cold of *metal*. Of a coin. Of a gold ring left on a windowsill in winter. Hard. Smooth. Perfect. It didn't move in his. It didn't give. It didn't curl round his fingers the way it had for forty-one years, since a hiring fair in Thistledown, since a yellow dress.

It was just a gold hand. Folded. Kept.

Fennick held it.

And his wife's eyes, on the pillow, in her gold face, looked at him.

And couldn't blink.

And couldn't cry.

And couldn't say anything at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Bet*," said Fennick Dale. "*Bet, love.*"

Nothing.

"*Bet, say something. Please. Bet.*" His voice was going. Breaking up. Like ice on a pond. "*I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I'll—I'll take it back, I'll find him, I'll make him take it back, I'll—*"

Antho knelt down beside him.

He didn't know what else to do. He knelt down on the cold stone floor beside the old shepherd and put his hand on the bed. On the blanket. On the gold edge of it, where it touched her shoulder.

And reached.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS A THRESHOLD Warden.

That was what he was. It was the only thing the net had ever called him that felt true. He felt doors. Every door. Not just the oak-and-iron kind. The other kinds. The door between waking and sleeping. The door between one breath and the next. The door at the back of a person's eyes, where they keep the things they don't say.

And the last one.

Everyone had it. He'd felt it in every dying person he'd ever sat with. In the old woman at the bottom of the passage last winter. In the miner from Coldwater, in the summer. In the old man on the rubble with his hand going slack in Antho's.

A door. At the very end. Open a crack. With light coming round it. Not frightening. Just—*there*. Waiting. The way a door at the end of a hall waits, at night, with a lamp lit behind it, for whoever's coming home.

He'd felt it in Bet. Last night. Clearer than he'd ever felt it in anyone. Wide open. Warm. With a young man's voice on the other side of it, very faint, saying *Mam*.

He reached for it now.

And it wasn't there.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT CLOSED. NOT LOCKED. Not barred. Not anything he could knock on, or open, or ask.

Gone.

As if it had never been. As if someone had come in the night with a trowel and a hod of gold and bricked it up, so smooth and so perfect you couldn't even see where it had been. There was no seam. No crack. No keyhole. Just gold. Solid. All the way through.

No door.

No way out.

He knelt by the bed with his hand on the blanket and felt the Clarity in him drop. Not far. Not dangerously. A tremor. A lurch. The way a floor lurches under your feet when you realize the stair you were reaching for in the dark isn't there.

He'd never felt anything like it.

Not in the Hollow. Not at the bottom of the world. Not in eight mad years with a hunger whispering in the back of his head.

He's taken her door, he thought. *Her last one. The one everyone gets. The one her boy is waiting behind.*

He's taken it and he's bricked it up and she'll never, ever, ever get through.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM WAS IN THE doorway.

Antho didn't know how long he'd been there. Nobody ever did, with Pim. He was just there. Small. Thin. Fourteen, now, or near it, with his hair sticking up and his nightshirt on and his bare feet on the cold stone. Looking at the bed.

At the gold woman on it.

He didn't say anything. He hardly ever did. He'd been silent for twelve years and talking for three and he still said as little as he could, as if words were coins and he'd been poor too long to spend them easily.

He came into the room.

He knelt down on Fennick's other side. By the bed. And looked at Bet's gold face for a long time.

And then he did the thing.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO HAD SEEN HIM do it before.

In the snow, outside the Keep, last spring, when the moths came and Odile went dim and cold and empty. On the rubble on Lantern Night. A dozen times since. In small ways. A frightened student. A crying child at the door.

Pim got quiet.

Not just not-talking. That was always. Something *more*. Something that came out of him like warmth comes out of a hearth. A stillness. A hush. Spreading. Out of his small thin body into the room. Into the air. Into the cold stone and the grey light and the old man kneeling by the bed with his face in his hands.

A *room*. That was what Seraphine called it. *He makes room. With his silence. Like the Hollow does. He's got a little piece of it in him. He made it himself, out of being hurt, a long time ago.*

He made one now.

Round the bed. Round the gold woman on it. Soft. Quiet. Small. Pim's whole self, poured out into the air like water poured round a stone.

Asking.

Is there anywhere, the silence said. *Is there any room. Anywhere at all. Just a little. Just enough.*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FOR A MOMENT—

For one moment—

Antho felt it give.

Not the door. The door was gone. But *something*. Somewhere deep in the gold. A hair's-breadth. A crack too small to see. As if the gold, solid all the way through, perfect, full, had been asked very gently by a quiet boy if it could spare just the tiniest space.

And had found, somewhere, that it could.

◆ ◆ ◆

A TEAR RAN OUT of Bet Dale's eye.

Out of the corner of it. Out of the gold. Slowly. So slowly. Not gold. *Wet*. A real tear. Clear. Salt. Catching the grey dawn light from the window.

It ran down her gold cheek.

It fell onto the pillow. And soaked in. A small dark spot on the gold-edged wool.

And that was all.

The crack closed. Whatever it had been. Antho felt it close. Felt the gold settle back. Perfect. Full. Solid all the way through.

Pim knelt by the bed with his small face very white and his thin hands flat on the blanket.

"*She's crying*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

FENNICK LOOKED UP.

He saw the tear. The dark spot on the pillow. The wet track down his wife's gold cheek.

And made a sound Antho would hear for a long time afterward. In the night. In the passage. Every time he counted the lanterns.

Not a sob. Not a word.

The sound a man makes when he understands exactly what he's done.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO FOUND THE DUST on the wall at sunrise.

He went up. Onto the battlements. Above the great door. Where the wind came off the mountains, cold and clean. He didn't know why. He just needed to be outside. Away from the little room with the window. Away from the gold.

It was there.

Sitting on the parapet. Thin. Grey. Bent. Its twig-legs dangling over the drop. Its dim sparks of eyes looking out at the sunrise over the Greyspine, pink and gold and cold.

"*Beautiful*," whispered Orrin. "*Isn't it. We don't have those. In the Court. No sun.*" The sparks flickered. "*I'd forgotten.*"

Antho didn't throw anything at it.

He stood on the battlements with the wind in his face and his hands shaking at his sides.

"*She said no*," he said.

"*She did*." The dust didn't look round. "*He said yes. For her.*" A soft sound, like a sigh. "*They usually do. In the end. The ones by the bed. It's not the dying who want to be kept, Master Vey. It's the ones who have to watch.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why*?" said Antho.

The dust turned its head. The long narrow shape. The two sparks.

"*Why what*?"

"*Why her. Why here. Why any of it.*" His voice was shaking. He didn't let it stop him. "*You want Harrow blood. You want the Key. You want—whatever you want. Why come up a mountain and take an old woman's door?*"

Orrin looked at him for a long moment.

"*Because he asked me to*," it said simply. "*His Majesty. He said, offer it. Everyone who's ever sat by a bed. He said, they'll come. They always come.*" The sparks dimmed. Brightened. "*He wants your world to know, master. Before he comes. He wants every old man holding his wife's hand in the night to know there's another way.*"

"*It's not a way. It's a—*"

"*It's a kindness*," whispered Orrin. "*To him. It's the only kindness he knows.*"

It stood up. On the parapet. Thin and tall and bent against the pink sky.

"*He kept us all*," it said. "*Nine thousand. In the first years. When we started to come apart. He walked out among us with his hands and he kept us.*" The sparks were very dim now. "*He didn't keep me. I asked him not to. I wanted to keep serving.*" A pause. "*Sometimes I'm sorry.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT BOWED.

The old bow. Low. Courteous. One twig-arm across its middle.

"*His Majesty sends his regards to your mother*," whispered Orrin. "*And asks after the child. Your brother's child. Born on the rubble. On the night his sister died.*"

Antho went cold all the way through.

"*He'd like to meet her*," said the dust. "*Very much.*"

And let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT UP OFF the parapet like smoke off a snuffed candle. A thin grey stream. Glittering in the dawn. Up into the cold clean wind off the mountains.

And east.

Down the valley. Over the foothills. Toward the low country, toward the shires, toward a long green fold in the hills where a river ran through a village with a forge in it, and beyond the village a birch wood, and beyond the birch wood a clearing by a stream.

Antho stood on the battlements and watched it go until he couldn't see it anymore.

Then he went down. Fast. Three steps at a time. Shouting for Ashka.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE CAUGHT HIM AT the bottom of the passage stair.

She was white. Her spectacles crooked. She had her book in her hand, and her pen, and she wasn't writing. She caught his arm as he came past.

"*Antho*."

"*I have to go. Lex. The baby. It's going east—*"

"*Antho, look*."

She pointed. Down the passage. Down the long cold tunnel in the mountain. At the lanterns.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE ALL LIT.

One thousand, one hundred and thirteen. Iron and tin and clay and one carved out of a turnip. On shelves and on hooks and in rows along the floor. All burning. All flickering. Small gold flames, moving the way flames move, alive, in the draught that always came up the passage from the dark below.

All but one.

A third of the way down. On a shelf cut into the rock.

It was still lit. It was still burning. Its flame was still there, small and bright, inside the little tin lantern.

But it wasn't moving.

It stood perfectly still inside the glass. Not flickering. Not bending in the draught. A small gold teardrop of flame, every edge of it sharp and clear and fixed, like a flame in a painting. Like a flame carved out of metal.

And the lantern round it was gold. And the shelf under it. And a hand's breadth of the rock.

Antho walked down the passage toward it. Slowly. His heart going.

He didn't need to read the tag tied to the handle. He knew whose it was. He'd watched an old woman light it, a week ago, with her hands shaking.

For Wat. From his mam.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FLAME DIDN'T MOVE.

It would never move. It would never go out. It would burn there, gold and still and perfect, a third of the way down the passage at the Lantern Keep, for as long as there was a passage, and a Keep, and a world.

Kept.

Antho stood in front of it for a long time.

Then he turned round and went back up the passage. Past one thousand, one hundred and twelve small flames, flickering in the draught.

He didn't count them.

He'd count them tonight. When he got back. If he got back.

He'd count the gold one too.

CHAPTER 5

The Harrow Songs

SEREN VEY HAD BEEN courting her husband for three months, and she was fairly sure he'd noticed.

She'd brought him pies. Six. One a fortnight, more or less, depending on whether the apples held out. She'd brought him a blanket she'd knitted herself, badly, in a blue that didn't match the door. She'd read him his own grey book every morning and his own forty-page letter every night, and laughed at the right places, and some of the wrong ones. She'd sat with him at the west window at sunset with her hand on the arm of his chair, next to his, not quite touching.

She'd done all the things her mother told her never to do.

Don't stay, Wenna used to say. At the end of every summer. Packing. *Don't let them get used to you. Don't let them learn your face.*

She'd let him learn her face. She'd let him learn it twice.

The first time, she didn't remember.

This time she was paying attention.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS AT THE window when the dragon came.

She was always at the window in the mornings. After the porridge and before the reading. He liked to sit and look at the birch wood for a while when he woke, before he could talk properly, and she liked to sit beside him and look at it too. It was a quiet time. A grey time. The stream running. The birches dripping. Her hand on the arm of his chair, on *HOME*, next to his.

She saw it first. A shape in the grey sky to the north. Small and dark and coming fast. Blue-grey. Long-winged.

"*Ashka*," said Arion.

He'd seen it too. He didn't miss much. Even now. Even with his eyes in a face that was a hundred years in a drawer.

"*Antho*," said Seren.

She was up and out of the blue door before the dragon landed.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME DOWN OFF Ashka's neck in the clearing before the dragon had properly stopped, and stumbled, and caught himself, and stood there.

He was white. His black hair wild. His eyes very dark. He looked the way he'd looked at the bottom of the world, coming up out of the Hollow with a door held open behind him. The way he'd looked at nineteen, at sixteen, at every age she'd never seen him and had dreamed about in the dark for thirteen years.

"*Mam*," he said.

"*What's happened*?"

"*Where's Lark*?"

"*With Wren. In the house. They're fine. What's happened?*"

He shut his eyes. Just for a moment. Standing in the wet clearing with his dragon steaming behind him.

Then he opened them.

"*There's a man made of dust*," said Antho. "*He knocked on the Keep door last night. He took an old woman's door.*" His voice cracked. "*And then he asked after the baby.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY BROUGHT EVERYONE INTO the blue-door cottage.

She didn't decide it. It just happened. Antho went across the stream to the other house and came back with Wren, and Wren had Lark in a sling against her chest and a knife on her belt and a look on her face like a hawk on a fence post. And Seren put the kettle on, because that was what you did, and Arion moved his chair back from the window a little so there was room at the table, and they all sat down.

And Antho told them.

About the knock. About the dust under the door. About the voice in the walls. About an old shepherd and his wife and a little silk pouch on a windowsill. About a gold face on a pillow. About a tear.

About a door that wasn't there anymore.

Seren listened with her hands flat on the table.

She didn't say anything until he'd finished. Then she got up. And went to the hearth. And knelt down in front of it. And poked the fire with a stick, for a long time, very hard, until the sparks went up the chimney in a roar.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mam*," said Antho. Behind her.

"*I'm fine*."

"*You're not*."

"*No*." She poked the fire. "*No. I'm not.*"

She sat back on her heels. Looked at the flames.

"*My mother used to tell a story*," she said. "*At the end of summer. When we were packing. About a king who couldn't bear to lose anything. Who kept everything he ever loved in a gold room with no doors.*" She swallowed. "*I thought it was a story. I thought it was just a story to frighten children into not being greedy.*"

"*It was him*," said Wren.

"*It was him*." Seren turned round. On her knees. On the hearthstone. And looked at them all. Her son. Her son's wife. Her granddaughter, asleep in a sling, one square fist curled against Wren's collarbone. Her husband, in his chair, with his hands on the arms. "*It was always him. All of it. Every story she ever told. I just didn't know they were true.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WOKE UP AT noon and wanted feeding, and Wren took her into the curtained corner by the bed, and Antho went out to see to Ashka, and for a little while it was just the two of them again.

Seren and the old man at the window.

She sat down in her chair beside his. She didn't pick up the grey book. She just sat.

He didn't say anything either. He was good at that. She'd noticed it in the first week. Most people, when you were sad, talked at you. Filled up the quiet. As if quiet were a hole they had to stop up before you fell in.

He didn't. He just sat in his chair with his spotted hands on the arms and let the quiet be quiet. And waited. As if he had all the time in the world.

He hadn't. They both knew he hadn't.

He waited anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Sing me the old verses*," he said.

She looked at him.

"*The ones your mother sang*," said Arion. "*At the end of summer. You said them this morning. Gold for the eldest. Glass for the vain.*" His grey eyes were very steady. "*I've never heard them. Not all of them. I heard you sing the Lantern Song a thousand*

times, at the cottage, to the boys." A pause. *"I'm told I did. I'm told it was every night. But never those."*

"I wasn't allowed."

"I know."

"She said never. Not to anyone. Not even my own babies." Seren looked out of the window. At the birch wood. *"She said they were the kind of thing that got you found."*

He didn't say anything.

He just waited.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SANG THEM.

Quietly. Barely above a whisper. The way her mother had sung them, the last night of summer, every summer, with the cottage half packed round them and the fire low and a little girl sitting on the floor with her knees pulled up, listening.

Gold for the eldest, who feared to grow old, Glass for the vain one, who loved to be told, Iron for the soldier who never once laughed, Thorns for the gardener who listened—and drank.

She stopped.

"It doesn't rhyme," said Arion. Softly.

"It's not supposed to." She was looking at the birch wood. *"I asked Mam. When I was seven. I said, laughed and drank don't rhyme, Mam, you've got it wrong."* Her mouth twisted. *"She said it was meant to go wrong there. Right there. On that word. So you'd always remember. So you'd never forget that's where it went wrong."*

"She listened," said Arion. *"Rhosyn."*

"She listened. And she drank anyway." Seren looked down at her hands. *"And the song breaks, every time. Every time you sing it. Right in the middle. Like a dropped stitch."*

She sang the rest.

Silver for the moth, who went toward the light, And nothing, nothing, for the tenth, who stood in the door all night.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE TICKED.

From behind the curtain, faint, the small wet sounds of a baby feeding. Wren's voice, low, murmuring something.

Arion didn't say anything for a long time.

"Nothing for the tenth," he said at last.

"*She didn't take a crown*." Seren turned her hands over in her lap. Square. Freckled. Strong. "*She put it down. On the stone. At the edge of the pool. And poured back. Mam said that was the whole point of the song. Nine of them got something. Gold and glass and iron and thorns and silver.*" She was quiet. "*And she got nothing. And she was the only one who got to keep being a person.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*But there was a crown*," said Arion.

She looked at him.

"*In the box*," he said. "*In the cellar. Lex told me. The moth carved in the lid and crossed out. And the hollow in the bottom. Seven points.*" His grey eyes were very sharp. "*Your mother had it. Your mother's mother had it. All the way back. Twenty generations of women who never took the crown, carrying a crown about in a box.*"

"*Hesper's*," said Seren. "*Malachi went back for it. He gave it to her on the shingle. He said someone had to keep it. He said it was the only one that could say no.*"

"*And then*?"

"*And then they kept it*," said Seren. "*For nine hundred years. In a box. Under the floor. Moving it from cottage to cottage. Never wearing it. Never showing it to anyone. Never—*"

She stopped.

"*And then your mother took it somewhere*," said Arion. Very gently.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T ANSWER.

She sat in her chair and looked out at the birch wood and felt something move in her. Deep down. Under thirteen years of dark and three months of pies. Something she hadn't let herself look at for a long time.

I've taken the crown where it belongs.

"*She went away*," said Seren.

Arion waited.

"*The last summer*," said Seren. "*The summer before she died. I was nineteen. I'd just come back from Highcrest. With—*" She stopped. Looked at him. At his walnut face. At the grey eyes in it. "*With rain in my hair. Mam said. In the letter. With my face lit up like a Lantern Night window.*"

"*You'd met me*," said Arion. Very quietly.

"*I'd met you*." She swallowed. "*I don't remember it. I remember the steps. The rain. You coming round the corner. I remember that now. But I don't remember coming home. I don't remember telling her.*"

"*You told her*," said Arion. "*She let me in the first night without a word. She watched me for a month, from the fire, with her mending. And then one evening I stood up at her table and asked her, very formally, if I might marry you.*" A pause. "*And she picked up a frying pan and threw it at my head.*" A ghost of a smile. "*She missed. I think she meant to.*"

Seren stared at him.

Then she laughed. Despite herself. It came out of her cracked and wet and sudden.

"*That sounds like Mam*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She went away*," she said again. When she'd stopped. "*That summer. After the pan. For a month. Alone.*" She frowned. Reaching. Down into the dark. Into the places the Ferryman hadn't taken, because they weren't his. "*She said she had to see someone. She said she'd be back before the apples. She took the box.*"

"*Which way*?"

Seren closed her eyes.

She could see it. She could see it clearly. Not him. Not the Warden-Architect who must have been there, in the background, coming and going, a tall young man in a grey coat with ink on his cuff. He was a shape. A blank. A space with nobody in it.

But her mother she could see.

Standing at the door of the cottage. At Harrow. In the grey of an early morning at the end of summer. With a bundle on her back and a stick in her hand and her square face set.

Turning. Not toward the Vale. Not toward the road to Ashbourne and the east.

West.

"*West*," said Seren. Opening her eyes. "*She went west.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION'S HANDS MOVED ON the arms of his chair.

"*And she came back*," he said.

"*She came back*." Seren looked at the birch wood. "*Before the apples. Like she said. She was thin. Thinner than I'd ever seen her. And she didn't have the box.*"

"*Did you ask her*?"

"*No*." Seren's mouth twisted. "*You didn't ask Mam things. Not about the box. Not about the rule. Not about anything.*" She was quiet. "*But there was something else.*"

She hadn't thought about it in thirty years.

She thought about it now.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I asked her about my father*," said Seren.

Arion went very still.

"*When I was small*," said Seren. "*Once or twice. Who was he. Where was he. Was he dead.*" She looked at her hands. "*Harrow women don't marry. They don't stay. You know that. But there was always someone. For a summer. For a season. Mam never pretended there wasn't.*"

"*What did she say*?"

"*She said he was a whistler*." Seren smiled. A small sad crooked smile. "*That's all. She said he whistled. Better than anyone she ever knew. She said he could whistle a blackbird down out of a tree. She said I had his ears.*" She touched one. Absently. "*She'd smile, when she said it. Every time. A little private smile. Like she was remembering a tune.*"

She stopped.

"*And after*?" said Arion.

"*After that summer*," said Seren, "*I asked her again. Just once. I don't know why. I think—I think I was thinking about you. About staying. About whether she'd ever wanted to stay, for him.*" She swallowed. "*I said, Mam, tell me about the whistler again.*"

She looked at her husband.

"*And she looked at me*," said Seren Harrow, "*like I'd spoken in another language. She said, what whistler, love? And I said, my da. The one with the ears. And she just—*" Her voice broke. "*She just looked at me. For a long time. And then she said, I don't know. I don't know who you mean.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE TICKED.

Neither of them said anything.

Behind the curtain, Lark had stopped feeding. Wren was singing to her. Very softly. Not the Lantern Song. Something else. A Thistledown song. About a hare in the snow.

"*She paid him*," said Arion at last.

Seren didn't answer.

"*The Ferryman*," said Arion. "*She went west. To the river. To the shore. And she paid him to take something across.*" His voice was very gentle. "*The memory you would least wish to lose.*"

"*A whistler*," said Seren.

"*A whistler*."

She put her hands over her face.

She didn't cry. She'd done all her crying in the dark. She just sat there with her hands over her face and breathed. In. Out. In. The way you breathe when something you've been carrying for thirty years without knowing it is suddenly lifted off you, and you find out how heavy it was.

"*She did the same thing*," she said through her fingers. "*She did exactly the same thing I did*."

"*Yes*."

"*She forgot him for a crown*." Seren took her hands away. Her face was dry. White. "*I forgot you for a door*."

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CAME HOME AT dusk.

They heard Vharuun first. The great slow beat of wings over the birch wood. And then he came across the stepping stones and up the oak ramp and in through the blue door, barefoot, with his boots in one hand and his coat over his arm and a look on his face that Seren didn't like at all.

He'd been down.

She could see it. The way he moved. The way he looked at the room, at all of them, as if he'd come back from a long way off and wasn't quite sure they were still there.

"*Well*?" said Wren.

Lex sat down at the table.

He looked at his father.

"*He talked*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD IT. ALL of it.

The pool. The room Mal made. The black glass. The Key and the Lockward and a grey thread wound round them, frayed and worn and tight. The last thread, running out into the dark. The black iron rings coming closer.

Clink.

Lantern Night.

The crown in the road.

And then the other part. The quiet part. That Lex told looking at the table and not at anyone. Quill and his spoons. *Don't tell him I asked.*

Then bring him. Before he goes. I'd like to say it to his face.

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION DIDN'T MOVE.

He sat in his chair by the west window with the last of the sunset coming in red behind him and his hands on the arms. On *STEADY* and *HOME*.

Seren watched his face.

She'd been watching it for three months. She'd learned it. The way you learn a new path through a wood. Every fold of it. Every crease. The way his mouth went when he was trying not to laugh. The way his eyes went when he was tired, and pretending not to be. The way the whole of it went still, perfectly still, like water in a bucket, when something hurt him.

It was still now.

"*He said that*," said Arion. "*Exactly that.*"

"*Exactly that*."

"*Bring him*."

"*If he'll come. If the little one can carry him.*"

His father looked out of the window. At the birch wood. At the red light going down behind it.

"*I'll go*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You will not*," said Seren.

They all looked at her.

She hadn't known she was going to say it. It came out of her the way the old verses had come out of her mother. Sharp. Certain. From somewhere very deep.

"*You will not*," she said again. "*You can't go down a ladder. You can't go up a hill. Last Tuesday you couldn't lift the teapot.*" Her voice was shaking. She didn't let it stop her. "*You are not going to the bottom of the world in a bubble to say sorry to a man who betrayed you.*"

"*He's not the one who needs to say sorry*," said Arion. Quietly.

She stared at him.

"*Or he is*," said her husband. "*Both of us are. I don't know.*" He looked down at his hands. "*I've had three years too, Seren. I've had two hundred. And I still don't know what I'd say to him.*" A pause. "*I'd like to find out. Before I can't.*"

"*You'll die*."

"*I'm dying anyway*," said Arion Vey. Very gently. "*That's rather the point.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

Seren stood by the hearth with the poker in her hand. She didn't remember picking it up.

"*Not now*," said Lex. Into the silence. "*Not yet. Elric said Lantern Night. That's months.*" He looked at his father. "*We'll work out how. Mal can do it. I think. If we're careful.*" He looked at his mother. "*If you come.*"

Seren looked at him.

"*Mal likes you*," said Lex. "*It calls you the lamp-lady. It'll carry him gentler if you're there.*"

She didn't answer for a long moment.

Then she put the poker down.

"*If I come*," she said.

"*If you come*."

"*If it's careful*."

"*Very careful*."

She looked at her husband. At the old man in the chair. At the face she'd been learning for three months.

"*I'm coming*," said Seren Harrow. "*And if he says one wrong word to you down there I'll throw a pan at him.*"

Arion's mouth twitched.

"*Your mother's daughter*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And the crown*," said Lex.

He was looking at her now. Steadily. With his father's grey eyes, in a face that was more and more hers.

"*Elric said ask your mother where it went*," he said.

Seren didn't answer straight away.

She looked at Arion. And he looked back at her. And something passed between them, across the table, across the last red light from the window. Something she'd told him that afternoon, and he'd held for her, and was giving back now, so she could say it herself.

"*West*," said Seren. "*She went west. To the Ferryman. With the box. The summer before she died.*"

Lex stared at her.

"*She paid him*," said Seren. "*I don't know what for. To take it somewhere. To put it somewhere.*" She swallowed. "*She paid him with my father. She paid him the only thing she had that she'd have least wanted to lose.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[Seren,] said a voice.

She went still.

She knew it. She'd known it in the dark. In the deep. In a room the little one had folded her into, with a boy who was her son standing in front of her with gold in his eyes, and a voice in the air round him that wasn't his.

Hello, Seren, it had said.

She'd known it then. She'd known it before she knew anything. Before she knew the old man in the chair. Before she knew she had a husband at all.

Dry. Gentle. Precise. With an old-fashioned courtesy. And underneath it, faint as a watermark in paper, another voice entirely.

[Seren,] said Ember. *[May I say something?]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE OTHERS COULDN'T HEAR it.

She could tell. Wren was looking at Lex. Antho was looking at the fire. Arion was looking at her. Only Lex had gone still, the way he always went still when the voice in his head spoke, his eyes going a little unfocused, as if he were listening to someone in another room.

And she could hear it. Because she was close. Because she was his mother. Because she'd heard it in the dark.

Yes, she thought. Not out loud. She didn't know if it could hear her thinking. It seemed to.

[I have them,] said Ember. *[You know I do. I told you in the deep. Everything he was. Up to the night he sealed the boys. Everything he remembered.]* A pause. *[The steps. The rain. The cottage. The pan your mother threw. His side of it. All of it.]*

I know.

[I could give them to you,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[Not yours. I don't have yours. Yours are in the river. But his. His side of it. Every day of it, up to the night he sealed the boys. You'd know what he saw. What he felt. When he looked at you.]*

She couldn't breathe.

[I gave you the steps,] said Ember. *[In the deep. Just that one. You were frightened. You needed something. And then the Ferryman gave you yours, the same day, the same memory, from the other side.]* A pause. *[You have it twice now. His and yours. The only one you have twice.]*

Yes.

[I could give you the rest,] said Ember. *[Tonight. Now. All of it.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED ACROSS THE table at her husband.

He was watching her. He couldn't hear Ember. He'd never been able to; Ember was a piece of him, pressed into his son's blood twenty years ago, and you can't hear your own voice in someone else's head. But he could see her face.

He'd always been able to see her face.

"*It's talking to you*," said Arion. Quietly. "*Isn't it.*"

"*Yes*."

"*It's offering*."

"*Yes*."

He looked at her for a long moment. And then he looked at Lex. At his son. At the place behind his son's eyes where a piece of himself lived.

"*Not yet*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

[He can't hear me,] said Ember. Startled. *[How did he—*]

"*Because I know what I'd say*," said Arion. To Lex. To the voice in Lex. "*If I were you. Which I was. Once.*" His mouth twitched. "*You'd offer her everything. You'd want to. You'd want her to have it all at once. So she'd know. So she wouldn't have to guess.*"

Lex's face had gone very strange.

[...yes,] said Ember. Faintly.

"*Not yet*," said Arion. "*Please.*"

Seren stared at him.

"*Why*?" she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED IN HIS chair. Slowly. Stiffly. To face her.

The sunset was gone. The window behind him was grey. The fire lit his face from the side, red and gold, every fold of it, every crease. A hundred years in a drawer.

"*Because if it gives you mine*," said Arion, "*you'll know what I felt. On the steps. In the rain. Every day after.*" His voice was a thread. "*And you'll love me because you remember.*"

She didn't say anything.

"*And that would be lovely*," said her husband. "*It would. I've waited thirteen years for you to remember me.*" He looked down at his spotted hands. "*But I've only got a year, love. Perhaps two. And for three months you've been bringing me pies.*"

"*Arion—*"

"*I'd like you to love me because of the pies*," said Arion Vey. "*For a little while. Just a little. Because of the old man in the chair. Not because of the young one on the steps.*" His mouth twisted. "*He had everything. He had you, and the boys, and the cottage, and thirty years. He doesn't need any more.*" He looked up at her. "*I'd like something that's just mine. Just this. Just you, now, choosing. Before it's all memory again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE COULDN'T SPEAK.

She sat at the table with her hands flat on the wood and looked at him. At the old man in the chair. At the face she'd been learning.

[...I understand,] said Ember. Very quietly. In the back of Lex's head. In the back of hers. *[I understand. I'll wait.]* A pause. *[I'm good at waiting. I learned it from him.]*

"*It says it'll wait*," said Lex. Hoarsely.

"*Thank you*," said Arion. To his son. To the voice in his son. Very formally. The way you'd thank a colleague. "*I appreciate it.*"

[He's welcome,] said Ember.

And then, so faint Seren almost didn't hear it, so faint she thought afterward she might have imagined it—

[Lex. I don't know how long I'll be able to.]

Lex's face went white.

[He's going,] said Ember. *[I can feel it. Every day. Like a draught. Like a tide going out.]* A pause. *[I'm a piece of him. I don't know what happens to the piece when the rest of it goes.]*

Seren looked at her son.

He didn't say anything. He sat at the table with his hands round his cup and his face white and didn't say anything at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KNOCK CAME AT midnight.

Seren was awake. She was always awake at midnight. Thirteen years in the dark had taught her that the hour after midnight was the hour things came to doors.

She was sitting in the chair by the hearth. In the blue-door cottage. With the fire banked and a single candle on the table and her husband asleep behind the curtain, breathing. Slow. Even. Every breath starting again.

Lex and Wren and the baby were across the stream. Antho was asleep on the floor by the door, rolled in a blanket, with his Lantern beside him. He'd insisted.

Knock.

Soft. Courteous. Three times.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WAS ON HIS feet. His Lantern in his hand. Blazing.

Seren was already at the door.

"*Mam—*"

"*Hush*."

She didn't open it. She stood in front of it. Barefoot. In her nightdress. With her hand flat on the blue-painted wood. The way her mother used to stand at the end of every summer, at the door of every cottage, with her hand flat on the wood, listening.

"*Who's there*?" said Seren Harrow.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*A servant*," said the voice.

Dry. Soft. Hissing. Like sand poured out of a sack. Coming through the wood. Through the gap under the door.

"*Only a servant, mistress*," it said. "*A steward. My name is Orrin. I have a gift.*"

"*I know who you are*."

"*Of course you do*." A pause. Soft as settling dust. "*Your son told you. The warden. I knocked at his door last night.*" Another pause. "*I'm sorry about the old woman. Truly. It was her husband who chose.*"

"*She said no*."

"*She did*," agreed Orrin. "*So many of them do. And then someone else says yes.*" A faint dry sigh. "*That's the trouble with a gift, mistress. It's never only for one person.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS DUST COMING in under the door.

Seren saw it. A thin pale line of it. Grey-gold. Sifting across the floor.

She didn't step back.

"*What do you want*?" she said.

"*To offer*," whispered Orrin. "*Only to offer. His Majesty sends me with it. To the Warden-Architect.*" The voice grew softer. Gentler. Almost tender. "*He has heard about him. The old man in the chair. He has heard how old. How little time.*"

Behind her, behind the curtain, Seren heard the breathing change.

Arion was awake.

"*His Majesty would consider it an honour*," whispered Orrin, "*to keep him. As he is. Exactly as you love him.*" The dust was spreading across the floor. Slowly. Toward

her bare feet. "*You'd never lose him, mistress. Never. Not this year. Not next. Not ever. You could sit beside him at the window every evening for a thousand years.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T MOVE.

She stood at the blue door with her hand flat on the wood and the dust coming toward her bare feet across the floor, and she thought about it.

She let herself. Just for a moment. Just for one breath.

A thousand years. At the window. Every evening. His hands on the arms of the chair. His grey eyes looking out at the birch wood. Never getting older. Never getting slower. Never one morning not waking up.

Never one morning not being there.

She thought about it.

And then she thought about a gold woman on a pillow. With a tear on her cheek. And a door that wasn't there anymore. And a young man's voice on the other side of it, saying *Mam*.

"*No*," said Seren Harrow.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," she said again. Louder. To the door. To the dust. To whatever was on the other side. "*Not him. Not me. Not anyone in this house. Not ever.*"

The dust stopped.

"*He's mine*," said Seren. "*For a year. Maybe two. Every day of it. Every slow cold morning. Every time he can't lift the teapot. Every time his breath catches and I lie there in the dark waiting for it to start again.*" Her voice was shaking. She didn't let it stop her. "*That's mine. All of it. You don't get to keep it. Nobody does.*"

Silence.

"*And when he goes*," said Seren Vey, "*I'll be there. Holding his hand. And I'll let him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND THE CURTAIN, VERY faintly, an old man said, "*Thank you.*"

She didn't turn round.

The dust on the floor lay very still.

And then, from under the door, from the gap, from everywhere, soft and dry and almost sad—

"*Hesper said that*," whispered Orrin. "*On the shingle. To her sister. Not me. Not ever.*" A pause. "*I was there. I held the cup for the servants that night. I watched her say*

it." Another pause. *"You have her voice, mistress. Exactly. I'd forgotten what it sounded like."*

Seren didn't answer.

"His Majesty asks after the child," said Orrin.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO MOVED.

She heard him. Behind her. The Lantern flaring. The dark gathering in his other hand.

"Don't," said Seren. Not turning round. *"It's dust, love. It wants you to."*

He stopped.

"The child's across the water," said Orrin. Gently. *"I know. In the little house with the lantern. With her mother, who has a knife, and her father, who has a fire."* The dust stirred on the floor. *"I won't go there tonight. His Majesty doesn't want her frightened. He wants her well. He wants her whole."*

"He can't have her."

"He'd like to meet her," said Orrin. As if she hadn't spoken. *"That's all. For now. When the crack is wider. When the King can come."* A sigh. *"Tell her father that. The smith. Tell him His Majesty would very much like to meet his daughter."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST WENT BACK under the door.

All of it. All at once. Sliding back across the floor like water draining out of a basin. Under the blue wood. Out into the night.

Seren stood with her hand on the door.

Outside, faintly, she heard it go. A soft dry hiss, like wind through grass. Rising. Going east. Not toward the stream. Not toward the other house. East. Down the track. Toward the Ashbourne road.

Toward the village.

"There are so many beds in a village," she heard it whisper. Very faint. Very far. Fading. *"So many old men. So many hands."*

And then it was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOOD THERE A long time.

Antho put the Lantern down. Came and stood beside her. Put his hand on her shoulder. He didn't say anything. He was his father's son. He knew when to let the quiet be quiet.

"Seren," said a voice from behind the curtain.

She went.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS LYING ON his back in the narrow bed under the window, with the blankets up to his chin and his white wisp of hair on the pillow and his grey eyes open in the dark. Looking at her.

She sat down on the edge of the bed.

He took her hand. His was cold. Thin. Spotted. It shook a little.

"*You said no*," said Arion.

"*Of course I said no*."

"*Not of course*." His thumb moved on the back of her hand. Very slowly. "*Fennick Dale said yes. Last night. For a woman he'd loved for forty-one years. Because he couldn't bear to listen to her stop.*" His voice was a thread. "*You've loved me for three months, love. You'd have had every excuse.*"

She looked at him. At his face in the dark. At the shape of it. At the eyes.

"*Not three months*," said Seren.

He went still.

"*I don't remember*," she said. "*I know I don't. I know it's all in the river. Thirty years.*" She swallowed. "*But I said no to him for you, Warden. Just now. At that door. Without thinking.*" She held his hand very tight. "*I'd never have done that in three months. Not for anyone. Not even for pies.*"

Arion didn't say anything.

He lay in the narrow bed and held her hand and looked at her, and his face did something she'd never seen it do. Not still. Not like water in a bucket.

It came apart. Softly. Like a dandelion.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LAY DOWN BESIDE him. On top of the blankets. In her nightdress. With her bare feet cold and her head on the edge of his pillow and his hand in hers.

She didn't mean to sleep.

She slept.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND DREAMED.

For the first time since the dark. For the first time in thirteen years. The way Harrow women dreamed. At the end of summer. With the cottage half packed and the fire low.

She dreamed of a country with no sun.

Grey-gold dust. A white road running straight as a ruler across a plain. Gold people standing in rows along it, in their thousands, very still.

And a long way off the road, at the edge of everything, a forest of black thorns.

Miles of it. Round and round. Hooked and dry and taller than a house.

And in the middle of the thorns, a tower.

Small. Slender. Grown, not built. Grey and cracked and dead.

With a door at the bottom. Shut.

And a window at the top. Dark.

And through the window, very faint, so faint she could barely see it, so faint she might have been imagining it—

A chair.

And on the chair, something small. Something silver. A circle, a little bigger than a man's hand could span.

With seven points.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WOKE WITH A start.

It was grey light. The fire was out. Arion was asleep beside her, breathing. Slow. Even. Every breath starting again.

She lay there with her heart going.

I've taken the crown where it belongs. Where it was always meant to go.

She knew where it was.

She didn't know how. She'd never been there. She'd never seen it. She'd never heard anyone describe it, not once, not in any song or any story at the end of any summer.

But she knew.

It was in a tower that a girl's sister had grown for her, in a country at the end of the world, in case she ever changed her mind.

And somebody was sitting outside the door of it. In the thorns. Asking.

Hes?

CHAPTER 6

Glass

WREN ASHDOWN HAD NEVER been any good at sitting still.

She'd been a tracker at fourteen. Out on the high moors above Thistledown before dawn with a bow and a bag and a hollow belly, reading the ground for hare-tracks because if she didn't find one there'd be no supper for Tam and Robbie that night. She'd been a Pathfinder at twenty. Running rooftops in Highcrest in the rain. A Mistwalker at twenty-two, stepping off the top of the Spire into a gale and walking down it like a staircase.

She'd stood on the wind above the Blightmarch on Lantern Night, eight months gone, with her belly out in front of her like a drum, and held a hundred miles of air still while a Well came home.

And now she sat in a chair in the dark at three in the morning with a baby on her chest. And didn't move. For an hour. Every night.

She'd never been so tired in her life.

She'd never been so happy.

She hadn't known you could be both at once.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LOFT WAS COLD. The fire downstairs had burned low hours ago and the heat didn't rise this far when it was banked. She'd pulled the quilt off the bed and wrapped it round both of them, her and Lark, and sat in the old chair under the little window with her feet up on the end of the bed and her head tipped back against the wall.

Lark was feeding. Steadily. Seriously. With her eyes shut and one square fist clamped round a handful of Wren's shirt and the other flung out sideways, opening and closing on nothing. She fed the way she did everything. With total concentration. As if it were a job and she meant to do it properly.

Smith's hands, Brannoc had said. *Smith's grip*.

Smith's appetite, Wren had said, the first week. Raw. Aching. Sitting up in the tent by the pool at three in the morning, the way she sat now. *She eats like a blacksmith after a double shift. She's going to eat me alive.*

Lex had laughed. Sleepily. From the blankets.

He was asleep now. On the bed. On his back. With one arm flung over his face and his mouth open.

Snoring.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T USUALLY SNORE. He didn't usually sleep. Not properly. Not since the bell rang in the winter. She'd lain beside him for six weeks and felt him lie awake. Staring at the ceiling. His hand on the bell. Listening.

He'd slept tonight.

He'd come back from the pool two days ago with his feet bare and a look on his face she'd never seen before, and told them about Elric and the Key and the iron coming down the thread. And then there'd been the dust at Seren's door. And the next night, Orrin in the village, knocking. Brannoc and Lex had stood in the street outside the Crooked Kettle till dawn with lanterns, and in the morning old Gaffer Wim's daughter had come out of their cottage by the mill white-faced and silent and wouldn't let anyone in. And the morning after that, the widow Tobbin.

Two of them. In Ashbourne. Gold. In their chairs.

He'd come home tonight grey with tired and lain down on the bed in his clothes and been asleep before she got his boots off.

She'd let him.

She'd sat in the chair with Lark and listened to him snore and thought, *good. Good. Sleep. One of us should.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS LOOKING AT the window when she saw it.

She hadn't meant to look. She'd been looking at nothing. At the dark. At the little square of the loft window under the slope of the roof, black, with the night outside and the cold coming off the glass.

You could see yourself in it. At night. With the candle lit. The way you can in any window when it's darker outside than in.

She could see herself. A pale smudge of a face. A wild red tangle of hair. The quilt round her shoulders. The dark shape of the baby at her breast. The candle-flame, small and gold, doubled in the glass.

She looked at herself.

And her reflection looked back.

And smiled.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T MOVE.

She didn't breathe. She sat in the chair with the baby feeding at her breast and her feet on the end of the bed and looked at the window.

Her reflection was smiling.

She wasn't.

She knew she wasn't. She could feel her own face. Stiff. Cold. Her mouth shut.

The face in the glass had its mouth open. A little. Smiling. Curious. Tilting its head, very slightly, the way you'd tilt your head to look at a bird on a branch.

And it wasn't her face.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HAD BEEN, FOR a moment. It had been her outline. Her hair. Her shoulders.

It wasn't now.

It was changing. Slowly. Like frost spreading on a pane. The red tangle of her hair going pale. Paler. White. The freckles fading off the cheeks. The cheeks sharpening. The jaw lengthening. The skin going so pale it was almost clear, with a faint cold glitter in it, like frost. Like ice.

And the eyes.

Grey. Pale grey. The grey of ice over deep water.

Looking at her.

Looking at the baby.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said the face in the window. "*Is that how you do it?*"

Its voice was very small. Very far away. As if it came from the bottom of a well. Or from inside a wine glass, when someone runs a wet finger round the rim and it sings.

"*I'd always wondered*," said the face. "*We had nurses. Wet-nurses. For the household. I never watched.*" It tilted its head the other way. "*Does it hurt?*"

Wren couldn't speak.

"*It looks like it hurts*," said the Glass Queen. Interested. "*Your face does a little thing. Every time she pulls.*" A pause. "*There. Just then. You did it again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FOUND HER VOICE.

It came out of her very low. Very flat. The voice she used on rooftops, in the rain, when she'd seen something in the street below and didn't want it to know she'd seen.

"*Get out of my window*," said Wren.

The face smiled.

"*I'm not in your window*," it said. "*I'm in the glass. It's different.*" It looked round. At the dark loft. At the bed. At the snoring shape on it. "*I'm in all the glass. All of it. Everywhere. Do you know how much glass you have, in your world? You have so much glass.*"

"*Get out*."

"*I can't*," said Ysenne. "*Not without a door. I'm only a reflection, down here. A finger's width. That's all that fits through a crack.*" She looked back at Wren. "*But a reflection's all I need. To look.*"

She looked at the baby.

Wren's arms tightened round her.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK DIDN'T NOTICE. SHE went on feeding. Steadily. With her eyes shut.

The face in the window watched her.

For a long time. Its pale eyes very still. Its sharp face very still. Like something in a jeweller's window. Like a carving in ice.

"*So that's her*," said Ysenne at last.

Wren didn't answer.

"*Oz can smell her*," said the Glass Queen. "*All the way across the world. Through the crack. He says she smells like bread.*" A pause. "*She doesn't look like much. Does she? She looks like all the other ones. Small. Pink. Cross.*"

"*Don't look at her*."

"*Why not*?"

"*Because I'll kill you*."

The face in the window laughed. The small surprised delighted laugh of a girl in a room full of mirrors.

"*Oh, I like you*," said Ysenne. "*You're like Hes. She said things like that. She said them to Oz once, at dinner, when she was twelve, and he laughed so hard he fell off his chair.*" Her pale eyes glittered. "*He stopped laughing later.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T MOVE.

She sat in the chair with her daughter at her breast and her heart going like a hare's and thought. Fast. The way she thought on rooftops.

It's glass. It's in the glass. It can see me. It can talk. Can it touch?

It says it's only a reflection. It says it can only look.

Do I believe it?

No.

"*What do you want*?" she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*To look*," said Ysenne.

"*At what*?"

"*At everything*." The face in the window tipped back. As if looking up at a ceiling only it could see. "*Do you know how long it's been? Nine hundred years. Nine hundred years in a country with no sun, where the only glass was the glass I made myself, and the only thing in it was me.*" A sigh. Like breath on a cold pane. "*I made a palace of it. A whole palace. Every wall a mirror. And every mirror had me in it. Nine hundred years of my own face.*"

She looked back down.

"*I used to love my face*," said the Glass Queen. "*I don't anymore. I've seen it too much.*" Her pale eyes went to Wren. "*I'd like to see yours for a while. I'd like to see everyone's.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There's a girl in Fenmoor*," said Ysenne. "*Who holds up a pan every morning to see if her hair's straight. It never is. She cries sometimes.*" A small smile. "*There's an old man in Highcrest who talks to himself in his shaving mirror. He tells himself he's handsome. He isn't. He's very kind, though. He gives his crusts to the pigeons.*"

Wren said nothing.

"*Your Queen*," said Ysenne. "*She has a mirror in her bedchamber. Silver-backed. Very old. She looks into it every night and practices being stern.*" The face glittered with amusement. "*She's not very good at it. She has a soft mouth. She keeps having to bite it.*"

"*Stop*."

"*Your husband's mother*," said the Glass Queen. Softly. "*Across the water. She hasn't got a mirror. She's never had one. Did you know? Harrow women don't keep mirrors. They don't like to be looked at.*" A pause. "*But her husband wears spectacles. To read. He leaves them on the table at night, folded, beside the bed.*"

Wren went cold.

"*She sleeps beside him on top of the blankets*," said Ysenne. "*With her bare feet cold. And watches him breathe. She lies awake for hours. Counting. Every breath.*" Her

voice was very gentle. "*She's so frightened, your husband's mother. Of one morning. Of one breath that doesn't start again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why are you telling me this*?" said Wren.

"*Because it's true*," said Ysenne.

She said it simply. As if it were the only answer anyone could possibly want.

"*That's what I am*," she said. "*That's what glass is. It shows you what's there. Exactly what's there. No more. No less.*" The pale face leaned closer. To the pane. Until Wren could see the faint cold glitter in the skin, like frost, like snow under a moon. "*Oz keeps things. Cad binds them. Rosie grows them. Mae ate them.*" A smile. "*I just look. I've always just looked. Nobody ever liked it much.*"

She looked at Wren.

Really looked. Wren felt it. Like a hand laid flat on her chest. Cold. Light. Curious.

"*You're afraid*," said the Glass Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

"*Not of me*," said Ysenne. Thoughtfully. "*Well. A little of me. But not mostly.*" Her pale eyes moved. Down Wren's face. Her shoulders. The quilt. The baby. "*You're afraid you've stopped.*"

"*Stopped what*?"

"*Being you*."

Wren's hands went still on the baby's back.

"*You used to run*," said the face in the window. Softly. "*On roofs. In the rain. You used to step off the top of towers into the wind. I can see it. In you. Like a picture in a locket.*" The ice-grey eyes didn't blink. "*And now you sit in a chair. In the dark. Every night. With her pulling at you. Not moving. Not running. Just sitting.*"

"*Shut up*."

"*And you love her*," said Ysenne. "*You love her so much it frightens you. And you're so tired. And you think, in the dark, at three in the morning, when he's asleep and snoring and you're not—*" A pause. "*You think, what if this is all I am now. What if the girl on the roof is gone. What if I never run again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T MOVE.

She sat in the old chair with the quilt round her shoulders and the baby at her breast and her face burning and stared at the woman in the window.

It was true.

That was the thing. That was the worst thing. Every word of it. She'd never said it. Not to Lex. Not to her mother. Not to anyone. She'd barely said it to herself. In the dark. At three in the morning. When he was asleep and snoring and she wasn't.

What if I never run again.

"*You see*?" said the Glass Queen. Gently. Almost kindly. "*I only show you what's there.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK LET GO.

She did it all at once, the way she always did. Finished. Done. Her mouth coming off with a small wet pop and her square fist letting go of Wren's shirt and her face screwing up, red and furious, the way it screwed up every time, because she didn't like being finished. She liked the doing.

She opened her eyes.

Grey-green. Round. Not quite focused. Looking up past Wren's face. At the window. At the pale glittering woman in the glass.

And looked at her.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE WENT VERY STILL.

Wren felt it. The cold curious hand on her chest went away. All of it. All at once. Turned elsewhere.

The baby looked at the face in the window.

And the face in the window looked back.

For a long moment, neither of them moved. A three-month-old girl in a quilt, with milk on her chin and her hair standing up like a bird's crest. And a Queen nine hundred years old, made of glass, in a pane at the end of the world.

Then Lark frowned.

A deep, fierce, furious frown. Exactly like her father's. Exactly like the frown Lex gave the bellows when they wouldn't catch, or the porridge when it stuck, or a bad weld.

And put out one square fist. Toward the window. And opened it. And closed it.

As if she were reaching for a nail.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said Ysenne. Very quietly.

Something had changed in her voice. Wren didn't know what. It had gone smaller. Further off. As if she'd stepped back from the glass.

"*She looked at me*," said the Glass Queen.

"*She looks at everything*."

"*No*." The pale face in the window was very still. "*No. She looked at me. Not at the glass. Not at the reflection. At* me." *A pause.* "*Nobody does that. They look at what they see. They look at themselves. They look at me and they see themselves.*"

Lark frowned harder.

"*She saw me*," said Ysenne. Wonderingly. Almost to herself.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND WREN BREATHED ON the window.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T DECIDE IT. Her body did it. The way her body did things on rooftops, before her head had caught up. She leaned forward in the chair, with the baby against her shoulder, and breathed out. Long. Slow. Warm. Onto the cold black glass of the little loft window.

The way you breathe on a window on a winter morning to draw a face in it.

And the glass fogged.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FACE IN IT went blurry.

All at once. The sharp cheekbones. The ice-grey eyes. The frost-glitter of the skin. Smearing. Softening. Going grey and milky and indistinct, like a face seen through a steamed-up window in a bathhouse.

"*Oh, don't—*" said Ysenne. Sharply. Far off. "*Oh, don't do that, I can't—*"

Wren breathed again.

And this time, she didn't just breathe.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS A MISTWALKER.

That was what the net called her. She'd never much liked the name. It sounded like something from a song. Like a ghost in a story who walks on the moors in the fog and leads travellers astray.

But it was true. It had always been true. Long before the net called it anything. On the high moors above Thistledown at dawn, with the mist lying in the hollows like milk in a bowl. She'd always known where it was. She'd always been able to walk in it without getting lost. She'd always felt it, the way other people feel cold or heat. Wet air. Waiting. Wanting to be breath.

She called it.

Not much. Not the great grey wall of it she could call over a battlefield. Just a little. Just a breath. Just the wet in the air of a cold loft at three in the morning, the damp off the stream outside, the steam off a baby's warm head.

Here, she told it. *On the glass. All of it. Please.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WINDOW WENT WHITE.

Completely. In one breath. The little black pane under the slope of the roof went grey, then milky, then white as a winter sky. Frosted. Fogged. Every inch of it. Thick as fleece.

And there was nothing in it at all.

No face. No ice-grey eyes. No glitter. Just white. Just mist on glass. The way every window in the world looks on a cold morning before the sun gets to it.

Wren sat in the chair and breathed hard.

From very far away, from inside the white, so faint she barely heard it, so faint it might have been the wind—

"...I can't see..."

And then nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T STOP.

She stood up. With the baby on her shoulder, wailing now, because she'd been finished and then jolted and then nobody was paying attention to her, which was the worst thing of all. Wren held her and stood in the middle of the loft and turned. Slowly. Looking.

The candle. On the shelf by the bed. Its flame doubled in the brass dish under it.

She breathed. The brass went dull with mist.

The water jug on the floor. A circle of black water in it, with the candle in it, small and gold.

She breathed. The water went cloudy. Grey.

The little hand-mirror on the windowsill. Her mother's. That Maren had given her on her wedding day, so she could see her hair was straight before she went out to the black door. Wren had laughed at her. *Mam. It's never straight.*

She picked it up. Turned it face down on the sill.

And breathed on the back of it anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WOKE UP.

He came awake the way he always did now. All at once. Bolt upright. One hand going to the bell on the cord round his neck. The other going to the little hammer on his belt.

"*What—*"

"*Don't look at the window*," said Wren.

He looked at the window.

It was white. Fogged. Thick as fleece.

"*What—*"

"*There was a woman in it*," said Wren. She was jiggling the baby on her shoulder. Up and down. Up and down. The way you do without thinking. Her voice was very calm. She didn't feel calm. She felt like the inside of a struck bell. "*In the glass. A woman made of glass. With white hair and grey eyes and a face like a knife.*" She swallowed. "*She talked to me. She talked to me for a long time.*"

Lex was on his feet.

"*Ysenne*," he said.

"*She said everything's glass*," said Wren. "*She said she's in all of it. Every window. Every mirror. Every jug of water.*" Lark was screaming now. Properly. Furiously. Wren held her tighter. "*She said she could see the Queen practicing being stern in her mirror.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT THROUGH THE house.

Every room. Every window. Lex with the little hammer in his hand and his fire burning low and gold in the other, the way it burned when he was afraid and didn't want to show it. Wren behind him with the baby, breathing.

The kitchen window. The east one. The big deep one, with the sill broad enough to sit on.

And the lantern in it.

They both stopped.

It was lit. Of course it was. It was always lit. A small iron lantern. Plain. With *HERE* cut in the base. And on the side facing the room, and the side facing the road, and the two sides between, four small square panes.

Of glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN BREATHED ON IT.

The panes fogged. The little gold flame inside went soft and blurry. A smudge of light behind milk.

Lex stood looking at it.

"*I made it*," he said. Very quietly. "*I made it with glass. So you could see the flame.*"

"*I know*."

"*I put it in the window. Facing out. So anyone on the road could see.*" His voice was very strange. "*So it'd be the first thing anyone saw.*"

"*Lex*."

"*She could look out of it*," said Lex. "*Couldn't she. She could look out of our lantern. At the road. At the house. At us.*"

Wren didn't answer.

She didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T SLEEP AGAIN that night.

They hung blankets over the windows. All of them. The loft window and the kitchen window and the little one by the door. Lex nailed them up, swearing. Wren held the lantern so he could see. The lantern with its four fogged panes, the flame inside it soft and smudged, and every few minutes she breathed on it again, because the mist kept clearing and she kept being afraid that when it cleared, there'd be a face.

There wasn't.

They emptied the water jug out of the loft window into the night. And the bucket by the door. And the big copper by the hearth that Wren had filled to wash the baby's things.

They turned the brass dishes upside down. They put the mirror in a drawer. They found a polished pewter cup on the shelf that Brannoc had given them for the wedding and Lex wrapped it in a cloth and put it in the drawer with the mirror, and then stood looking at the drawer for a long time.

"*She could be in there*," he said.

"*She can't see in the dark*," said Wren. "*I don't think. A reflection needs light.*"

"*You don't think*."

"*I don't know*." She sat down at the table. Suddenly. All the tired of three months coming down on her at once like a dropped sack. "*I don't know anything. I don't know what she can do. I don't know what she can't.*"

Lark had gone quiet at last. Asleep. Screamed out. Hot and damp and heavy on Wren's shoulder, with one square fist wound in her hair.

"*She said she can only look*," said Wren. "*She said she's only a reflection. A finger's width. That's all that fits through.*" She looked at the blanket over the kitchen window. "*She said she can't touch.*"

"*Do you believe her*?"

Wren looked at him.

"*She told me the truth about everything else*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T TELL HIM the rest.

Not then. Not that night. Not the thing about the roofs. About running. About sitting in a chair in the dark every night and being afraid she'd never move again.

She sat at the table with the baby on her shoulder and didn't tell him.

But he looked at her. Across the table. In the light of the fogged lantern.

And she thought he knew anyway. She thought he'd always known. He was a smith. He knew what it looked like when something was cooling in the wrong shape.

He didn't say anything.

He reached across the table and put his big scarred hand over hers. On the wood. And kept it there.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE THE HORNLIGHT at dawn.

She watched him from the doorway of the lean-to. With the baby, asleep, in the sling. With the grey light coming up over the birch wood and the stream running loud and the blankets still nailed over every window of the cottage behind her, so that the house looked blind.

He'd lit the little forge. He'd taken the *HERE* lantern apart on the anvil. Carefully. Pane by pane. The four little squares of glass laid out on a cloth on the bench, fogged, the way she'd left them.

And he'd found horn.

Old horn. From somewhere. From a cow, from a ram, from the back of Brannoc's store-shed where Brannoc kept everything anyone had ever given him, in case. He'd boiled it. He'd split it. He'd scraped it, with the edge of a knife, thinner and thinner, until it was pale and cloudy and you could see light through it but nothing else. Not shapes. Not faces. Just light.

The way lanterns were made in the old days. Before glass. Before anyone had windows. Before there was enough glass in the world for a Queen to live in.

He fitted it. Four panes. Into the iron frame. Where the glass had been.

And then he took the little flame—the flame that had burned in the *HERE* lantern every night since the Blightmarch, the flame he'd lit with his own fire—and lifted it out on the end of a taper, and set it in the hornlight.

And it burned.

Soft. Gold. Blurred. A warm cloudy glow behind four panes of pale horn. You couldn't see the flame anymore. You could only see that it was there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's not as pretty*," said Lex.

He was standing at the anvil looking at it. His face grey with tired. His hands black with horn-dust.

"*No*," said Wren.

"*You can't see the flame*."

"*No*."

"*It'll look like a lantern in a fog*," said Lex. "*From the road. Like someone's left a light on in a mist.*"

Wren looked at it.

At the soft gold blur behind the horn. Warm. Steady. Not showing anything. Not reflecting anything. Just there. Just lit.

"*Good*," she said.

He looked at her.

"*I like fog*," said Wren Ashdown. "*I'm a Mistwalker. It's my favourite weather.*" She came across the lean-to. And stood beside him. And looked at the hornlight on the anvil. "*Put it in the window. I'll be able to find it in the dark.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT IT IN the window.

They took the blanket down off the kitchen window, the east one, and he set the hornlight on the sill where the glass lantern had been. Facing out. Facing the road.

And then they stood back and looked at the window itself.

The big deep east window. Twelve panes of glass in a wooden frame. Grey with the dawn. Showing the birch wood. Showing the stream. Showing, faintly, the two of them standing in the kitchen with a baby between them.

Showing everything.

"*I'll soap it*," said Wren. "*All of them. Every window. Like a shop that's closed. Mam used to do it at the farm when the hay-dust got bad.*" She looked at the window. "*We won't be able to see out.*"

"*She won't be able to see in*," said Lex.

"*No*."

They stood there a moment longer.

Then Wren went to get the soap.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOPPED IN THE doorway.

She didn't know why. Something. A feeling. A cold one. The same feeling she'd had on the roof at three in the morning, looking at a window, seeing her own face smile.

She turned round.

And looked at the east window.

At the twelve grey panes. At the hornlight on the sill, glowing soft and gold behind its horn. At the birch wood beyond, grey. At the stream.

At the pane in the bottom corner. The left one. Low down. Just above the sill. Just beside where the glass lantern had stood.

There was a mark on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT CLOSER.

Slowly. With the baby asleep against her chest. With Lex behind her, saying *what*, and then not saying anything, because he'd seen it too.

A handprint.

Small. Narrow. Long-fingered. Pressed flat against the glass. Not dirt. Not soot. *Frost*. A handprint made of frost. Delicate. Feathery. Every line of the palm picked out in tiny white crystals, the way frost picks out the veins in a leaf. Every finger long and fine and perfect. Five of them. Spread.

As if someone had stood in the kitchen in the night and laid their hand flat on the window. To feel how cold it was. Or to look out.

Wren put her own hand up beside it. Not touching. An inch from the glass.

Hers was bigger. Broader. A tracker's hand. A farm girl's.

The frost hand was smaller. Thinner. Finer. A lady's hand. A queen's.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's on the outside*," said Lex. Hoarsely. "*It must be. It's frost. It's cold out. Something out there—*"

Wren didn't answer.

She moved her hand. The inch. And touched the glass. Beside the frost. With one finger.

And drew it across. Slowly. Across the palm of the frost hand.

And the frost smeared.

Under her finger. On her side. On the *inside*. The crystals melting. Running. A thin wet line through the middle of the palm, where her warm finger had passed.

The handprint was on the inside of the glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

NEITHER OF THEM SAID anything for a long time.

Wren stood at the window with her wet finger and the baby asleep against her chest. Lex stood behind her. She could hear him breathing.

She said she can only look, Wren thought. *She said she's only a reflection. She said she can't touch.*

She looked at the small cold hand on the inside of her kitchen window. Spread. Delicate. Perfect.

She told me the truth about everything else.

"*Lex*," she said.

"*I know*."

"*She lied*."

"*Or she didn't know*," said Lex. Very quietly. "*Not yet. Not till she tried.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WOKE UP.

She did it all at once, the way she always did. Eyes open. Fists going. Looking round with the deep fierce frown of someone who has woken up somewhere she didn't fall asleep and would like an explanation.

She saw the window.

She saw the hand on it.

And she reached for it.

One square fist. Out of the sling. Toward the glass. Opening and closing.

Wren caught it. Gently. And held it. And folded it back against her chest.

"*No*," she said. Very softly. Into her daughter's hair. "*No, love. Not that one. That one's not for you.*"

And went to get the soap.

CHAPTER 7

The Council of Lanterns

HIGHCREST HAD GONE BLIND.

Lex saw it from the air. Coming in on Vharuun's neck over the downs at noon, with his father in Brannoc's chair strapped in front of him and his mother behind him with her arms round his waist, and the golden city rising on its hill in the spring sun the way it always did. Tier on tier. Roof on roof. The white towers. The Spire.

It didn't shine.

That was what he noticed. Highcrest always shone. In the morning, in the afternoon, at sunset. A thousand windows catching the light and throwing it back. You could see it from twenty miles off on a clear day. A city made of sparks.

It was dull now. Grey-white. Flat. Every window on every tier blank and milky, like a blind man's eyes.

Soaped.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*All of them*," said Elowen Dunmore.

She met them on the landing field below the Crown Terrace, with Oathkeeper on her hip and two knights behind her and her face set in the expression of a woman who had not slept properly in a week and was not going to discuss it. She looked at the dragon. At the old man in the chair. At Seren. At Lex.

"*Every window in the city*," she said. "*The Queen's order. Six days ago. After Seraphine's letter.*" She turned and began to walk. Fast. They followed. Lex pushing his father's chair over the cobbles. "*Soap. Chalk. Whitewash, where people didn't have soap. Paper pasted over, where they didn't have whitewash.*" She glanced back. "*The Spire took three days. It's got four thousand panes. They had to do it from ropes.*"

"*And mirrors*?"

"*Covered. Turned to the wall. Broken, some of them, by people who were frightened.*" Elowen's mouth was very tight. "*There were three sightings in the first*

two days. A woman in the glass. White hair. Grey eyes. Smiling." She walked faster. "*One was in the bathhouse on Copper Street. There was a riot."*

"*Was anyone hurt*?"

"*A man broke his nose running out of the steam-room with no towel*," said Elowen. "*Otherwise no."* A pause. "*He's very embarrassed."*

[I'd be embarrassed,] said Ember.

You don't have a nose.

[Hypothetically,] said Ember. *[If I had a nose. And a towel. And had lost the towel.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT UP THROUGH the city.

It was strange. Lex had walked these streets a hundred times. He'd run across these roofs with Wren in the rain. He'd seen the city dimmed, last autumn, every warm thing gone out of it and the people standing in the street like scarecrows.

This was different.

The people were all right. They were out. Busy. Shouting at each other across the market squares. Hollis Penn's bakery on the corner of Fennel Street had its door propped open and its window chalked white, and someone had written on the chalk in big letters, with a wet finger: *NO GLAZE TODAY. UNGLAZED BUNS 2 FOR A COPPER*.

"*He thinks he's very funny*," said Elowen.

"*He is very funny*," said Seren.

"*He's been doing it for six days. Glaze is a reflective surface. Did you know that? I didn't. I do now."* Elowen's jaw tightened. "*He came up to the palace on the second day to tell us. He'd seen her in a tray of iced cakes."*

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY COULD SEE THEMSELVES.

That was the strange thing. That was what Lex kept noticing, all the way up through the tiers. Men coming out of barbers' shops with odd tufts sticking up at the back where the barber couldn't check. Women with their hair pinned crooked. A girl at a fountain with her hands cupped, about to drink, who looked down into the water and saw it was covered with a sheet of oiled cloth and laughed and made a face.

A whole city that couldn't see its own face.

[It's oddly freeing,] said Ember. *[Don't you think? Look at that man. His collar's inside out. He has no idea. He's whistling.]*

It's frightening.

[It's both,] said Ember. *[Most things are.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL OF LANTERNS was the oldest room in the palace.

It had been a chapel once, before the palace grew round it. A long low stone room with a vaulted roof and narrow windows set high in the walls. And everywhere, on every surface—hanging from the vault on chains, standing in rows along the walls, set into niches in the stone—lanterns.

Hundreds of them. Iron and brass and copper and silver. Old. Some of them very old. Every king and queen of Caldor for eight hundred years had hung a lantern here on their crowning day. And every one of them had glass.

They were lit.

And every pane was soaped.

The light in the hall was strange. Soft. Clouded. A warm gold fog. Like being inside a lantern yourself. Lex stood in the doorway with his hands on his father's chair and looked up at the vault, at the hundreds of milky gold blurs hanging from it, and felt something in his chest go quiet.

"*Aldric's*," said his father softly. Looking up. At one lantern in particular. A plain iron one, near the door. "*I stood here when he hung it. I was standing right there. By that pillar.*" A pause. "*He was nineteen. He dropped it.*"

"*Dropped it*?"

"*On his foot*," said Arion Vey. "*He swore so loudly the Archbishop fainted.*" His mouth twitched. "*It's still dented. Look. There. On the bottom.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE ALL THERE.

Lex hadn't been sure they'd come. He'd sent ravens. His mother had sent Correspondence, with a note tied to her collar, which seemed to have worked, since the goat was standing in the corner of the hall eating a tapestry.

The Queen, at the head of the long table. In a plain blue dress, with her silver circlet. Small and sharp-eyed and twenty-four, with a soft mouth she kept biting.

Roole, in his Keepers' grey. Three days on the road from Greyfall. His stiff arm held close.

Antho and Seraphine. Antho grey with tired. Seraphine with a stack of books in front of her a foot high and ink on her fingers.

Brannoc. Enormous. Bald. Soot-bearded. Standing behind the end of the table with his arms folded because he said the chairs weren't made for men his size and he'd break one.

And Kestrel Varn, with her red hair cropped short and her amber eyes bright and her feet up on the table. Unlatticed. Untitled. The only living person who could command Flame without ever having touched a Stone.

And at the far end, on a stool that someone had found for her, very small, very old, in red robes, with a face like a dried apple and two black eyes like a crow's—

Grandmother Asha of the Ashari.

"*Smith*," she said. As Lex came in. Grinning her toothless grin. "*I came on a camel. A camel. Two hundred miles. At my age. You'd better have something worth hearing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WASN'T THERE.

She was on Fennel Street. At her mother's. With Lark.

I'm not bringing her into a room full of lanterns, she'd said. On the landing field. With the baby in the sling against her chest and her face set. *Not with that woman in the glass. Not with everyone looking. Mam's got no mirrors and she's soaped her windows and she's been waiting three months to hold her granddaughter without a hundred people round.*

Wren—

Tell me after, Wren had said. *Tell me everything. Every word.* She'd kissed him. Hard. *I'll be on the roof if you need me.*

He'd watched her go. Down the steps from the landing field. Into the city. A small figure with red hair and a baby on her chest.

She'd been walking fast. Almost running.

He'd noticed that. He didn't know why.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT DOWN.

His father at the Queen's right hand, in the wheeled chair, with a blanket over his knees. His mother beside him. Then Lex. Then the others. The goat went on eating the tapestry. Nobody stopped her.

"*Well*," said Lysandra. "*Tell me.*"

So he told her.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK A LONG time.

He told it the way his father had taught him, years ago, in a cold room at the top of the Spire. *Start at the beginning. Go to the end. Then stop. And don't leave anything out because you think it's too small.*

The bell. The voice. The gold at the Veil. A boy in a field, mid-step, his eyes moving. A rose. *HES?* The crack, with dust coming out of it and thorns going in.

The pool. The black glass. The Key, and the Lockward, and a grey thread wound round them, frayed and tight. The last thread. Running out into the dark. Black iron rings coming closer.

Clink.

Lantern Night.

The net with nobody's hand on it. The crown in the road.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO TOLD THE NEXT part.

The knock. The dust. The voice in the walls. An old woman who said no, and an old man who said yes for her. A gold face on a pillow. A tear.

A door that wasn't there anymore.

He told it very quietly. Looking at the table. When he got to the part about the door, his voice stopped. Just for a moment. And Seraphine, beside him, put her hand on his under the table, and he went on.

When he'd finished, nobody said anything for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Two in Ashbourne*," said Brannoc. Into the silence. His voice was very rough. "*Old Wim. And the widow Tobbin.*" He looked at his enormous hands. "*Both of them in their chairs by the fire. Both of them gold.*"

"*Who chose*?" said the Queen.

"*Wim's daughter. And the widow's son.*" Brannoc's jaw worked. "*Neither of them will talk about it. Wim's daughter won't let anyone in the house. The Tobbin boy sits outside his mother's door all day and won't eat.*" He looked up. "*He's twenty-six. He's a Brawler now. Level forty. He cleared the rock-wyrms out of the Greyspine last month with his bare hands.*"

He swallowed.

"*He sits outside the door*," said Brannoc Holt, "*and cries like a child.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's spreading*," said Roole. "*The gold at the edge. Not just from the crack. From him too. From the dust-man.*" He shifted his stiff arm. "*There are reports from Westerling. From the crofts out past it. From two villages in the western shires.*" His hatchet face didn't change. "*Old people. Gold. In their beds. Their chairs.*" A pause. "*A baby. In Marrowby. Sick with the croup. Her mother couldn't bear the coughing.*"

The Queen's mouth went very tight.

"*How many*?"

"*Thirty-one*," said Roole. "*That we know of. In three weeks.*"

"*And every one of them chose*?"

"*Someone chose*," said Antho quietly. "*Every time. Someone at the bedside. Never the one in the bed.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Can they be brought back*?" said Lysandra.

She looked at Lex.

They all looked at Lex.

He didn't answer straight away. He sat at the long table in the soft gold fog of a hundred soaped lanterns and thought about a field. About heat that wouldn't sink in. About the Hollow putting out its hand and finding nowhere to put it.

"*I don't know*," he said. "*I tried. With the boy. Fire won't touch it. Stone can't feel it. The Hollow—*" He stopped. "*There's no room in it. That's what it is. It's full. All the way through. It's not that it's hard. It's that it's finished.*"

"*Pim made room*," said Antho.

They looked at him.

"*In Bet*," said Antho. "*For a moment. Just a breath. A crack too small to see. And she cried.*" He looked at Lex. "*It closed again. But it opened. It opened, Lex.*"

Lex looked at his brother for a long moment.

"*Then there's a way*," he said.

"*There's a crack*," said Antho. "*It's not the same thing.*"

"*Everything's a crack first*," said Lex Vey. "*Ask any smith.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I don't understand*," said Kestrel.

Everyone looked at her. She'd taken her feet off the table. She was leaning forward on her elbows, her amber eyes very bright, frowning.

"*Why*?" she said. "*Why does he want to? Why go round the world turning grandmothers into statues? What does he get?*"

"*Nothing*," said Seren.

Kestrel looked at her.

"*He doesn't get anything*," said Seren. Quietly. "*That's not what it's for. It's not a weapon. It's not a trick.*" She looked down at her hands. "*He thinks it's a kindness.*"

"*A kindness*."

"*My mother used to tell a story*," said Seren. "*About a king who couldn't bear to lose anything. Who kept everything he ever loved in a gold room with no doors. His dog. His*

horse. His wife. His children." She was quiet. *"She said he walked through it every evening. Talking to them. And they couldn't answer. And he never noticed."*

Nobody spoke.

"He's not cruel," said Seren Harrow. *"He's frightened. He's the most frightened man who ever lived. And he wants everyone else to be safe from the thing that frightens him."*

"Which is what?" said Kestrel.

"Endings," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

"And the Key," said Lysandra.

She'd been quiet a long time. Listening. Biting her soft mouth. She looked at Arion now. Down the table. At the old man in the wheeled chair at her right hand.

"You were Warden-Architect," she said. *"For two hundred years. You knew the net better than anyone alive."*

"I knew the old one," said Arion. *"Lex wove the new one."*

"The edge didn't change," said Lysandra. *"Did it? The Veil. That's still Aurelian's."*

His father was quiet for a moment.

"No," he said. *"The edge didn't change. Lex wove from the middle out. The Veil was there before he started and it was there when he finished."* His spotted hands moved on the arms of the chair. *"He tied his new threads into it. The same way Aurelian did. The Veil's the last thread. Everything else hangs from it, at the edge, like a net hangs from its top rope."*

"And it runs all the way to the Knot."

"All the way down."

"Where?" said the Queen. *"Where does it run? Under what?"*

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER DIDN'T ANSWER straight away.

He looked up. At the vault. At the hundreds of soaped lanterns hanging there, gold and blurred.

"There's a map," he said. *"In the Spire. In my old rooms. Behind the bookcase."* A faint smile. *"I drew it a hundred and forty years ago. When I was young and arrogant and thought I could understand everything if I just measured it carefully enough."* He looked down. *"The great threads. The main ones. Where they ran under the world. I followed them with a pendulum and a compass for eleven years."*

"And the last thread?"

"*The deepest*," said Arion. "*And the straightest. It comes in from the edge under the Sundered Lands. Very deep. Too deep to feel, most of the way.*" He closed his eyes. "*And then it rises. It comes up under the Greyspine. Under the old mountains. Under the coal country.*"

Lex went very still.

"*Under Coldwater*," said his father. "*Right under it. Two hundred fathoms. Closer to the surface there than anywhere else in the world.*" He opened his eyes. "*The miners used to say the deep seams sang. They said if you put your ear to the rock at the bottom of the Old Gallery you could hear a note. One note. Very high. Like a harp-string.*"

"*The last thread*," said Lex.

"*Wound tight*," said Arion. "*Humming.*" He looked at his son. "*If Caddoc is climbing it, he'll come under Coldwater on his way to the Knot. And if there's anywhere in the world you could reach him, Lex—*"

"*It's there*."

"*It's there*," said his father.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Then we stop him there*," said Kestrel. "*We go down and we break the iron and we cut him off.*"

"*Perhaps*," said Arion.

"*Perhaps*?"

"*He's ringing the thread as he comes*," said his father. "*With iron. So it won't throw him off. If you break a ring, he'll make another.*" He looked at Kestrel. "*Iron for the one who never laughed. He's the most patient of them. He'll have thought of it.*"

"*So we try anyway*," said Lex.

"*You try anyway*," agreed Arion. "*And if it doesn't work—*"

He stopped.

"*Then there's the crown*," said Seraphine.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D BEEN WRITING ALL through it. In a book. In her small neat hand. She stopped now and looked up and pushed her spectacles up her nose.

"*Only a hand that's refused a crown can turn the Key and stay itself*," she said. "*That's what Elric said. That's what Aurelian left in the knots.*" She tapped the page. "*Hesper's crown. The tenth. The only one that never touched the pool.*" She looked down the table. At Seren. "*If we had it. If someone wore it. They could turn the Key. Against the last thread. Before Caddoc gets to the Knot.*"

"*And unwrite the Veil*," said Lex.

"*And unwrite the Veil*."

"*And the net would offer them the crown*," said Lex. "*And they'd say no.*"

"*Because they'd already be wearing one that said it for them*," said Seraphine. "*Yes.*"

"*And then the Veil's gone*," said Lysandra.

Her voice was very quiet.

Everyone looked at her.

"*And then there's nothing between us and them*," said the Queen of Caldor. "*No wall. No edge. Nothing. A country full of gold and four Crowned walking out of it across the Sundered Lands toward us.*" She looked round the table. "*Am I right?*"

Nobody answered.

"*Am I right*?" said Lysandra.

"*Yes*," said Arion Vey. "*You're right.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE QUEEN SAT BACK in her chair.

She looked up at the vault. At the hundreds of lanterns. At her grandfather's, by the door, with the dent in the bottom.

"*So we have three roads*," she said. "*All of them bad.*"

"*All of them bad*," agreed Roole.

"*We can try to stop him on the thread. At Coldwater. And he'll probably just make another ring.*" She held up one finger. "*We can find Hesper's crown and turn the Key and bring the Veil down ourselves. And they walk in.*" A second finger. "*Or we do nothing. And on Lantern Night Caddoc comes down into the Knot and takes the Key to his brother. And his brother turns it. And picks up the net.*" A third finger. "*And keeps it.*"

She looked at the three fingers.

"*And then every Ceiling comes back*," said Lysandra. "*And every child is Kindled into the same class as her mother. And nothing ever changes again. Ever. Anywhere.*" She lowered her hand. "*Forever.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*I was a princess in a world like that*," said the Queen. Quietly. "*For twenty years. I'm not going back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Then we do all of it*," said Lex.

She looked at him.

"*Coldwater first*," said Lex. "*Now. This week. I'll take Hask. He knows the seams. He knows the Old Gallery. If there's anything to break, his pick will find the flaw in it.*" He looked down the table. "*And we look for the crown. At the same time. In case.*"

"*And the third road*?"

"*Last*," said Lex. "*Only if the others don't work. Only if there's nothing else.*" He swallowed. "*Only if it's that or the crown in the road.*"

The Queen looked at him for a long moment.

"*Agreed*," said Lysandra.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And where*," said Roole, "*is the crown*?"

Everyone looked at Seren.

She hadn't said anything for a long time. She'd sat at the long table beside her husband's chair with her square hands folded on the wood and listened. Lex had watched her listen. She did it the way she did everything. Completely. Without moving. The way you'd listen for a moth at a window.

"*West*," she said.

The hall was very quiet.

"*My mother took it west*," said Seren Harrow. "*The summer before she died. To the Ferryman. She paid him with the memory of the man she loved.*" Her voice was very steady. "*And she wrote, after, I've taken it where it belongs.*"

"*Where does it belong*?" said Lysandra.

"*I dreamed it*."

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD THEM.

The dream. The country with no sun. The white road. The gold people in rows. The thorns, miles of them, round and round.

The tower in the middle. Grown, not built. Grey and dead.

The chair in the window.

"*It's on the other side*," said Seren. "*Beyond the Veil. In the Court.*" She looked down the table at Seraphine. "*In a tower in the middle of the thorns.*"

"*Rhosyn's thorns*," said Seraphine. Very quietly.

"*Rosie's thorns*."

"*She grew them round it*," said Seraphine. "*To hide it. From the others.*"

"*Or to keep it*," said Arion.

They looked at him.

"*I only say it*," said his father mildly. "*Someone should. She sent a rose to a Harrow woman with her sister's name on it. And now the Harrow woman dreams of a crown in her thorns.*" His grey eyes were very steady. "*If I wanted the only crown in the world that could stop my brother's plan, and I couldn't touch it myself, and I needed someone with Hesper's blood to come and fetch it for me—*"

"*Summer*," said Seren.

He looked at her.

"*You smelled it*," said his wife. "*You said it yourself. You can't fake summer.*"

"*No*," said Arion Vey. "*But you can grow it in the middle of a trap.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE LANTERNS flickered.

All of them. All at once. Every lantern in the hall. Hanging from the vault. Standing along the walls. In the niches in the stone. Hundreds of them. Their soft gold blurs behind the soaped glass going dim. Bright. Dim.

As if a wind had come through the hall.

There was no wind.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh, Arion*," said a voice. "*You always were the clever one.*"

It came from the lanterns.

From all of them. From every soaped pane. Small and far and singing, like a wet finger round the rim of a glass. A hundred tiny voices, all the same voice, all speaking at once.

The goat stopped eating the tapestry.

"*Mae said so*," said the voice. "*She said you were the cleverest man in that world. She said it was a shame you were so honest. She said it was very inconvenient.*"

Lex was on his feet. They were all on their feet. Elowen's sword was out. Kestrel's hands were burning. Brannoc had picked up a chair.

"*Oh, sit down*," said the Glass Queen. "*I can't come through. I'm only looking.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULD SEE HER.

Not clearly. Not in any one lantern. The soap was thick. But in every one of them, behind the milky glass, very faint, there was a shape. Pale. Narrow. A long face. White hair. And two pale points of light, very faint, like stars seen through cloud.

Hundreds of her. Hanging from the vault. Looking down.

"*You soaped them*," said Ysenne. Amused. "*How clever. Who thought of that? It was you, wasn't it, Arion? Or your scribe. The one with the spectacles.*" The hundred

faint faces turned. All together. Toward Seraphine. "*I like your spectacles. I sat in them for a whole evening last week while you were reading. You read very fast. I couldn't keep up.*"

Seraphine went white.

"*But it's only soap*," said the Glass Queen. Gently. "*And soap is thin. And I'm very, very patient.*" A pause. "*Like a frost.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What do you want*?" said Lysandra.

The Queen of Caldor didn't sit down. She stood at the head of the long table in her plain blue dress with her silver circlet and looked up at the vault. At the hundred faint faces. Her soft mouth very straight.

"*Oh*," said Ysenne. "*You're the one who practices being stern. In the mirror. With the silver back.*" The faint faces tilted. "*You've got much better at it. I've been watching. You bite your lip less.*"

Lysandra's face didn't move.

"*What*," she said, "*do you want*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I've come with terms*," said Ysenne.

She said it lightly. Pleasantly. Like a girl announcing that she'd brought a cake.

"*From Oz. He asked me to say them. He's very good at terms. He always was. When we were children he used to draw up treaties with Cad over the last biscuit.*" A small laugh. "*Cad always got it. Cad's very stubborn. But Oz always made him sign.*"

"*Say them*."

"*The smith's child*," said the Glass Queen.

Lex's hands closed.

"*Freely given*," said Ysenne. "*That's important. Oz was very particular. He says he doesn't want her taken. He says he doesn't want her frightened. He wants her brought to him by someone who loves her. And set down in his arms.*" A pause. "*And then he'll put a crown on her.*"

"*No*," said Lex.

"*Let me finish*," said Ysenne. Mildly. "*It's rude to interrupt. Didn't Arion teach you that? He taught Mae. She said he made her wait until he'd finished a whole page.*" The hundred faint faces turned toward him. "*She'll be a queen, smith. Not a princess. A queen. Of everything. A whole country of gold. Nine thousand people. Four palaces. And all of us.*" Her voice was very soft. "*She'll never be cold. She'll never be hungry. She'll never be sick, or old, or frightened. She'll never die.*"

"*She'll never grow up*," said Wren's voice.

◆ ◆ ◆

EVERYONE TURNED.

She was in the doorway. Wren. With her red hair wild and her face white and her breath going hard, as if she'd run all the way up from Fennel Street. Which she had. Lex could see it in the way she stood.

She didn't have the baby.

"*Mam's got her*," said Wren. Before he could ask. "*In the cellar. With the door shut and no light.*" Her green eyes went up. To the vault. To the hundred faint faces. "*I saw the lanterns flicker from the roof. Every lantern on the palace. All at once.*" Her jaw set. "*I thought I'd come and hear the terms.*"

"*Oh*," said Ysenne. Delighted. "*It's you. The one who breathes on things.*"

"*She'll never grow up*," said Wren again. Very flat. "*That's what you meant. Isn't it. She'll be three months old forever. With milk on her chin. Kept.*"

The faint faces didn't answer for a moment.

"*She'll be perfect*," said the Glass Queen. "*Forever. Exactly as she is.*"

"*She's not finished*," said Wren Ashdown. "*She's not supposed to be perfect. She's supposed to grow.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And the rest of you*," said Ysenne. Lightly. As if Wren hadn't spoken. "*Oz says you can have your world. Just as it is. He'll turn the Key and he'll pick up the net and he'll leave it exactly as you made it, smith. No Ceilings. If you like. Levels. Classes. All of it.*" A pause. "*He doesn't care about any of that. He never did. He only wants the child. And the blood. And the Key. And then he'll leave you alone.*"

"*He'll keep everything*," said Antho. Quietly. "*Every thread. Every knot. He'll keep the net exactly as it is.*"

"*Yes. Isn't that what I said?*"

"*Nothing new*," said Antho. "*Ever again. Nothing different. Nothing growing. Nothing changing. A net that never moves.*"

"*Safe*," said Ysenne.

"*Kept*," said Antho Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And you can die*," said the Glass Queen. Softly. "*All of you. In your own time. In your beds. The way you seem to like it so much.*" A sigh, like breath on a cold pane. "*He won't stop you. He won't come round with his pouches. He'll leave you to your endings, since you're so fond of them.*"

The hundred faint faces turned. Slowly. All together.

Toward the old man in the wheeled chair at the Queen's right hand.

"*Even you, Arion*," said Ysenne. Very gently. "*He'll let you go. If that's what you want. He says he'll even send flowers.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said Lex.

He said it before anyone else could. He said it standing up at the long table in the Hall of Lanterns with his hands burning and his voice very quiet.

"*No*," he said again. "*Not her. Not freely. Not any other way. Not for the net. Not for the world. Not for anything.*" He looked up at the vault. At the hundred faces. "*Tell him no.*"

The Glass Queen was silent for a moment.

Then she laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS THE SMALL, surprised, delighted laugh. A girl's laugh. In a room full of mirrors.

"*Oh, smith*," she said. "*That's what Hesper said. Exactly that. In exactly that voice.*" The faint faces glittered. "*Not me. Not ever.*"

"*Good*."

"*Is it*?" Ysenne's voice was very soft. "*Look where it got her. A hedge. Nine hundred years of hedges. Running from cottage to cottage with a crown in a box. Never staying. Never Kindling. Never letting anyone learn her face.*" A pause. "*Her daughters died in ditches, smith. Some of them. In the snow. In the night. Running.*"

"*Twenty generations*," said Seren.

The hundred faces turned.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WAS STANDING. Beside his father's chair. With one hand on his shoulder. Small and square and barefoot on the stone floor of the Hall of Lanterns, looking up.

"*Twenty generations*," said Seren Harrow. "*Of women who never took the crown. Who never let a moth in. Who kept the rule. In ditches and hedges and cottages and snow.*" Her voice was shaking. She didn't let it stop her. "*Twenty generations, from her to me. Twenty women who stayed people.*"

The faces didn't answer.

"*You've been nine hundred years in a palace of mirrors*," said Seren. "*Looking at your own face.*" She tilted her head. "*How's that been?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN WAS silent.

For a long time. So long Lex thought she'd gone. The lanterns still flickered. Dim. Bright. Dim. The faint faces still hung there behind the soap.

And then, very quietly, almost too quietly to hear—

"*Lonely*," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX MOVED.

Not with fire. Not the white and gold roar of it. He'd learned that much. You can't burn a reflection any more than you can burn dust.

With the other thing.

He'd learned it on a rubble-heap in the dark, a year ago, from an old smith with a bald head who'd told him, *fire's not about light, lad. Light's just what fire gives away. Fire's about heat.*

Black heat.

Fire with no light.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LET IT GO up.

Out of his hands. Out of his chest. Into the air of the Hall of Lanterns. Not a flame. Not a glow. A *heat*. Pouring off him like the heat off a forge when you open the door. Rising into the vault. Spreading. Filling the hall.

And as it rose, it ate the light.

Not put it out. *Ate* it. The way black heat did. The soft gold blurs of the lanterns, hanging from the vault, going dim. Dimmer. Not because the flames died. The flames were still there. Lex could feel them. Burning hotter than ever. But the light coming off them was going into the black heat like water going into sand. Swallowed. Drunk.

Until the hundreds of lanterns in the Hall of Lanterns were burning hot and bright and *dark*. Every one. Glowing in the vault like coals in a banked fire. Heat without light. Fire without a face.

And in the glass, behind the soap, there was nothing.

No light. No reflection.

No Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

GRANDMOTHER ASHA CACKLED.

She was sitting on her stool at the end of the table with her red robes round her and her toothless mouth wide open, laughing so hard she had to hold her knees.

"*Sand*," she said. "*Smith. Sand.*"

"*It worked*," said Lex.

"*Of course it worked*." The old fire-woman wiped her eyes. "*Fire with no light casts no shadow. Shows no face. Makes no picture in any glass.*" She grinned at him. "*Every Ashari girl knows that. We used to frighten the Wardens with it. They'd come into our tents with their lamps and their mirrors and we'd sit round the fire in the dark and they couldn't see a thing.*"

"*You might have mentioned it*," said Lex.

"*You might have asked*," said Grandmother Asha.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LET THE BLACK heat go.

Slowly. Carefully. The light came back into the lanterns one by one. Soft gold blurs behind the soap. Hundreds of them. Hanging from the vault.

Empty.

Nobody in them. No faint pale faces. No points of light.

The hall was very quiet.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

Then the Queen of Caldor sat down. Slowly. In her chair at the head of the long table. And put her hands flat on the wood. And looked at them.

"*Lonely*," she said.

Nobody answered.

"*She said lonely*." Lysandra didn't look up. "*Nine hundred years in a palace of mirrors and she said lonely.*" She bit her soft mouth. Hard. "*I didn't want to feel sorry for her.*"

"*Nor did I*," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN CAME ACROSS THE hall.

She came round the table to where Lex was standing and stood in front of him. Close. She was still breathing hard. Her face was white.

"*You said no*," she said.

"*Of course I said no*."

"*Not of course*." She looked up at him. Her green eyes very bright. "*She offered everything, Lex. The net as it is. No Ceilings. All of it. Everything you ever fought for.*" She swallowed. "*For one baby. For our baby.*"

"*No*," said Lex.

She looked at him for a long moment.

Then she put her forehead against his chest. In the middle of the Hall of Lanterns. In front of the Queen and the Keepers and the old fire-woman and the goat.

"*I ran*," she said into his shirt. "*Do you know that? All the way up from Fennel Street. Over the roofs. I haven't run like that since—*" She stopped. "*I didn't even think about it. I just ran.*"

He put his arms round her.

"*I know*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FOUND THE FROST at the end.

When the others had gone. When the council was over and the decisions were made and Roole had gone to write his reports and Kestrel had gone to find something to eat and Grandmother Asha had gone to shout at her camel.

Seraphine found it.

On the lantern by the door. King Aldric's. The plain iron one, with the dent in the bottom where he'd dropped it on his foot at nineteen.

On the inside of the soaped glass. On one pane. In the fog of soap.

Letters.

Not written. Not scratched. *Frost*. Fine white crystals, feathery, delicate, picked out on the inside of the pane in a narrow slanting hand. The way frost writes on a window on a winter morning, if frost could write.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE READ THEM OUT loud.

Her voice was very quiet.

"*Smith*," she read. "*Cad says to tell you. He's under your mountains now. The black ones. With the coal in.*" She swallowed. "*He says he can hear men singing above him in the dark.*"

Lex went cold.

"*He says*," read Seraphine Ilvane, "*don't bother.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FROST FADED.

Slowly. As they watched. The fine white crystals going soft. Melting. Running down the inside of King Aldric's lantern-pane in thin wet lines, like tears.

Until there was nothing there but soap.

Lex stood in front of it for a long time.

"*Coldwater*," he said.

"*Coldwater*," said his father. Behind him. Very quietly. From the wheeled chair. "*He's early.*"

CHAPTER 8

The Ferryman's Fare

HIS MOTHER HAD NEVER flown on a dragon by choice.

She'd flown on Vharuun to Highcrest because there was no other way to get an old man in a wheeled chair a hundred miles in a morning. She'd sat behind Lex with her arms locked round his waist and her eyes shut and her face pressed into his back, and when they landed she'd climbed down very carefully onto the grass and stood there for a while with her hand on the dragon's flank, breathing.

I'm a hedge-witch, she'd said. When Antho asked if she was all right. *We walk. We've always walked. Twenty generations of walking. My feet know where they are. My feet don't know where they are up there.*

She was sitting behind him on Ashka now. Her arms round his waist. Her eyes open.

She'd said she was going to keep them open.

"*It's beautiful*," she said. Into the wind. Into his ear. Her voice tight. "*Isn't it. Everyone keeps saying it's beautiful.*"

"*It is beautiful*."

"*I'm sure it is*." Her arms tightened. "*I'm going to look at it now. Any moment.*"

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THEY'D LEFT AT DAWN.

From the clearing at Harrow. Ashka standing in the wet grass by the stream, steaming, impatient, her blue-grey scales beaded with dew. Antho on her neck. His mother on the oak ramp of the blue-door cottage, barefoot, with a bundle in her arms and her face very still.

And in the doorway behind her, in his chair, with a blanket round his shoulders and his white wisp of hair standing up in the morning draught—

"*Go*," said Arion.

"*Four days*," said Seren. "*Maybe five.*"

"*I know.*"

"*Lex will come across. Every morning. And Wren. And Brannoc said he'd come up from the village every evening to—*"

"*I know,*" said Arion. "*I was there when you arranged it. I was there when you arranged it again. I believe I was there the third time.*" His mouth twitched. "*Go, love. It's your mother.*"

She didn't move.

She stood on the ramp with her bundle and looked at him. At the old man in the chair. And Antho, on the dragon, saw her face do the thing it did sometimes now. The thing it hadn't done in the first months. A kind of flinch. A kind of catch. As if she were looking at something she'd just noticed was very fragile, and had been holding very carelessly.

"*Don't die while I'm gone,*" said Seren Harrow.

"*I'll try very hard not to,*" said his father.

"*Promise.*"

"*I don't make promises I can't keep,*" said Arion Vey. "*You taught me that. Page nine.*" He looked at her. "*I'll be at the window. Every evening. Looking west.*"

She came back up the ramp. And bent. And kissed him. On the forehead. Quickly. Fiercely. Like someone stamping a seal.

"*Bring me back a stone,*" said his father. Into her hair. "*From the river. A flat one. For skipping.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WEST OVER THE VALE. Over the Greyspine. Over the Teeth.

The great white jagged peaks at the western end of the mountains rose up ahead of them in the morning and Ashka climbed to meet them, beating hard, higher and higher, into the thin cold air where the wind came off the snowfields like knives. His mother made a sound into his back. A small sharp sound. Not a scream. A Harrow woman's sound. The sound of someone who has decided not to scream and is holding it in with her teeth.

And then they were over. And the land fell away on the other side, long and low and grey-green, toward the west.

"*Oh,*" said Seren.

He felt her lift her head.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THINNED LANDS HAD changed again.

He'd been this way a year ago. With Pim. Looking for the same river. It had been coming back then. A faint patchy green on the hills, like wishful thinking. Streams beginning to talk.

It was greener now. Not lush. Not the deep wet green of the Vale. But *green*. Unmistakably. A pale spring green on every hill, in every hollow. Grass. Real grass. And here and there, in the lee of a slope, something darker. Gorse. Heather. A thorn tree, low and twisted, with white blossom on it.

And the streams were singing.

You could hear them from the air. Faint. Silver. Running down off the hills into the long valleys.

"*It's alive*," said his mother. Into his ear. Wondering.

"*It's coming back*," said Antho. "*Since the Tithe stopped. Since the net was rewoven.*" He looked down at the green. "*It was grey for nine hundred years. All of it. The world was worn through here. Like the elbow of a coat.*"

"*And now it's mending*."

"*And now it's mending*."

She was quiet for a while. Her arms round his waist. Her chin on his shoulder. Looking down.

"*I walked through here*," she said. "*Thirteen years ago. To the river. I don't remember it being grey.*" A pause. "*I don't remember it being anything. I don't remember anything about that walk at all.*"

He didn't say anything.

"*I remember the river*," said Seren. "*And the boat. And the price.*" She was very quiet. "*And then I remember turning round.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN AT dusk in a fold of the hills, by a stream.

Ashka found a warm hollow out of the wind and curled up in it like a cat and was asleep before they'd got the packs off her. Antho made a fire. His mother made supper. Bread and cheese and two apples and a little flask of something Brannoc had pressed on her at the last moment, which turned out to be Mother Orla's plum brandy and which she took one sip of and then put away, coughing.

They sat by the fire in the dark.

The stream ran. Ashka snored. Overhead, the stars came out. More of them than he ever saw in the Vale. Hard and white and close.

"*You came this way*," said his mother. "*Didn't you. To the river. Before.*"

"*Twice. Three times now.*"

"*Lex told me*." She didn't look at him. She was looking at the fire. "*He said you paid. The first time. To cross.*"

Antho didn't answer for a moment.

"*A stone*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD HER.

He'd never told anyone, really. Not all of it. He'd told Lex the truth of it, once, under the stars, on the way back from the Heart. Lex had been there; Lex had been the other half of it. But he'd never told it from the beginning.

A summer evening. A riverbank below the mill at Harrow. A boy of fifteen and a boy of ten. A flat grey stone.

Low, low, like you're trying to make it fly under a door.

Five skips. He'd told his brother it was four. Because he was fifteen and Lex was ten and he'd wanted, for once, just once, to be the one who was better at something.

And then the Kindling. And the fire. And eight years of madness. And a grey river and a man with no eyes asking for the memory he'd least wish to lose.

"*It wasn't the fire*," said Antho. "*Or the Kindling. Or Mam going into the dark.*" He looked at his hands. "*I'd have paid any of those gladly. I'd have paid every one.*" He swallowed. "*It was the stone. It was the one good thing I had from before. The last time I was just his brother.*"

His mother didn't say anything.

"*It's a hollow*," said Antho. "*Where it used to be. Warm. Empty. Like a bed someone's just got out of.*" He looked at the fire. "*I can tell you about it. I know what happened. Lex told me, and I've told it back to him a hundred times. But I can't*—" He stopped. "*I can't* see *it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS QUIET FOR a long time.

Then she reached across. And took his hand. His scarred hand, with the old burns on it from the night of the fire, from the night of the Kindling, from eight years of a hunger burning through it.

"*Same*," said Seren Harrow.

He looked at her.

"*Same*," she said again. Very softly. "*A warm hollow. Like a bed someone's just got out of.*" She held his hand. "*I lie in it every night, love. Next to him. I lie in the hollow where thirty years of him used to be. And I know he was there. I know it was warm. I can feel the shape of it.*" Her voice cracked. "*And I can't see a single thing.*"

They sat by the fire with their hands together.

Neither of them said anything else for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RIVER WAS SILVER.

They saw it at noon on the second day. From the top of the last hill. A line across the bottom of the long valley, wide and flat and slow, running north to south. Catching the light. With the sky in it.

And on the near bank, on the grey shingle, a long flat boat. Grey. Low.

And beside it, leaning on a long pole with a lit lantern on the top of it, a tall thin figure in grey robes.

Waiting.

"*He knows we're coming*," said his mother.

"*He always knows*."

"*How*?"

"*All rivers are his water*," said Antho. "*A little. He says.*" He looked down at the figure on the shingle. "*We crossed six streams yesterday.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN TURNED HIS head as they came down the shingle.

His mother stopped.

Antho felt her stop. Felt her go still behind him, on the stones, the way she'd gone still on the oak ramp at Harrow. A hedge-witch's stillness. The stillness of a woman listening at a door.

She'd been here before. Thirteen years ago. She'd stood on this shingle and looked at this face. She didn't remember the walk. She didn't remember the land. But she remembered this.

The long thin grey face. Smooth. Old as river-stones. The mouth. The nose.

And where the eyes should be, nothing. Smooth grey skin. As if they'd never been.

"*Seren Vey*," said the Ferryman.

"*Ferryman*."

"*You have the steps*." The eyeless face tilted. Slowly. "*I can feel them in you. Twice. His and yours. Two halves of the same rain.*" A pause. "*It suits you.*"

His mother didn't say anything.

"*Anthoren Vey*," said the Ferryman.

"*Ferryman*."

"*You have come about her mother*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT ON THE shingle.

The Ferryman didn't sit. He never did. He stood beside his boat leaning on his long pole with the lantern on top of it, lit, swaying very slightly in a wind that wasn't there, and turned his eyeless face toward the water.

"*Thirty-two summers*," he said. "*By your counting.*"

His mother went still.

"*She came down that hill*," said the Ferryman. "*There. Where you came. On foot. At the end of summer. With a stick, and a bundle on her back, and her feet bleeding through her boots.*" His long grey hand moved on his pole. "*She had walked three hundred miles. She had not stopped. She said, when she reached the shingle, that if she stopped she would turn round.*"

"*Mam*," said Seren. Very quietly.

"*Wenna Harrow*," said the Ferryman. "*She did not tell me her name. I knew it. I have known all of them. Every Harrow woman who ever lived. They never came to my shore, not in life. Not one of them, in nine hundred years.*" A pause. "*Except her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What did she want*?" said Seren.

The eyeless face turned toward her.

"*She had a box*," said the Ferryman. "*Oak. Old. With a moth carved in the lid and crossed out.*" A pause. "*She opened it on the shingle. There. Where you're sitting. And she took out a crown.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*Small*," said the Ferryman. "*Plain. Silver. Seven points.*" His voice was very quiet. "*I knew it. I had seen it before. On the head of a girl of seventeen, standing on this shingle, watching me row her brothers and sisters into the grey.*" He was quiet. "*She was not wearing it then. She was holding it. The boy with the bare feet had just given it back to her.*"

"*Malachi*," said Antho.

"*Malachi*," agreed the Ferryman. "*He sat with her here till dark.*" The eyeless face turned toward the water. "*And nine hundred years later, her daughter's daughter's daughter, twenty times over, came down that hill with the same crown in a box, and stood where she stood, and asked me to take it across.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Across*," said Seren.

"*To the grey country*," said the Ferryman. "*To the Court. Where I took them.*"

"*Why*?"

The Ferryman didn't answer for a long time.

"*She had dreamed*," he said at last. "*Harrow women dream. At the end of summer. Through the grey. Through the edge. They always have. They see the Court. They see the cocoons. They see the five of them, hanging in the hall, asleep.*" His long grey hand was still on his pole. "*She had dreamed that summer that the cocoons were moving. Turning. In their sleep. The way a sleeper turns when a dream is going bad.*"

"*They were waking*," said Antho.

"*They were stirring*," said the Ferryman. "*Nine hundred years is a long time. Even for those who drank. The hunger was getting sharper. The sleep was getting thinner.*" He was quiet. "*And she had a daughter, that summer, who had come home from the city with rain in her hair. Who had met a man. Who was going to stay.*"

His mother made a small sound.

"*She knew*," said the Ferryman. Very gently. "*She knew you would stay. She knew the line would stop running. After twenty generations. She knew that the next Harrow woman would put down roots, and Kindle her sons, and let the net learn their faces.*" A pause. "*And she knew that if the Crowned woke, and came looking, a family that stayed would be very easy to find.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*So she sent it across*," said Seren.

"*She asked me to put it where it belonged*," said the Ferryman.

"*Where*?"

"*She did not know. Not exactly.*" The eyeless face turned toward her. "*She said, the chair of the one who refused it. She said, there must be a place for her there. For the tenth. Even if she never came. Somebody must have kept a place.*" A pause. "*She said, put it there. Put it in the middle of them. So there's one crown in that Court that says no. So every night, in the dark, while they sleep, something in that country is saying no to them.*"

Antho stared at him.

"*She thought it would keep them asleep*," he said.

"*She hoped it would*," said the Ferryman. "*She was not sure. She had only a dream and a song and a crown in a box.*" He was quiet. "*She was right. They slept. Thirty years. More soundly than they had in nine hundred.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And was there*?" said Seren. "*A place?*"

The Ferryman was quiet for a long moment.

"*There was a tower*," he said.

His mother's breath went out of her.

"*Small*," said the Ferryman. "*Grown, not built. Out of a white tree, coaxed up and round on itself. At the edge of the plain, far from the palaces. Dead. Grey. Empty.*" A pause. "*The fourth sister grew it. In the first year. When they still had power. For the tenth. In case she changed her mind.*"

"*Rosie*," whispered Seren.

"*Rhosyn*," said the Ferryman. "*Yes.*" He turned his face toward the water. "*There was a room at the top. A girl's room. Grown out of the wood. A bed. A shelf. A window. A chair.*" A long silence. "*I put it on the chair.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She woke*," he said.

They waited.

"*The fourth sister. As I came down the stair. She was standing in the doorway at the bottom. Thin. Grey. In her rotten silk. With her crown of thorns.*" His voice was very quiet. "*She had felt it. Through her sleep. Through the silk. A crown that had never touched the pool, carried into the Court by a man she had last seen nine hundred years ago, on a shingle, rowing her away from her sister.*"

"*What did she do*?" said Antho.

"*She looked at me*," said the Ferryman. "*For a long time. And then she looked up the stair.*" A pause. "*And she wept.*"

His mother had her hands over her mouth.

"*She asked me, is it hers. And I said, it is. And she asked me, is she coming. And I said, no. She has been dead eight hundred and seventy years. A Harrow woman sent it. One of her line.*" The eyeless face turned. "*And the fourth sister said, she had a line? And I said, twenty generations. And she sat down on the step at the bottom of the tower and put her face in her hands.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*When I left*," said the Ferryman, "*she was growing thorns. Round the tower. Round and round. As fast as she could. Her hands in the dust.*" A pause. "*I asked her why. She said, so Oz never finds it. So nobody ever finds it. So it can sit there and say no forever.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RIVER RAN.

Silver. Slow. With the sky in it.

His mother sat on the shingle with her hands over her mouth and looked at the water.

"*And Mam paid you*," she said at last. Through her fingers.

"*She paid me*."

"*With what*?"

The Ferryman turned his eyeless face toward her.

"*You know with what*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Tell me anyway*."

He was quiet for a long moment.

"*The price is the same for everyone*," said the Ferryman. "*To cross, or to carry. The memory you would least wish to lose.*" His long grey hand was still on his pole. "*She stood on the shingle with the crown in her hands and I asked her. And she did not answer for a long time. And then she said—*"

He stopped.

"*Said what*?"

"*She said, I'll pay you the whistler*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER DIDN'T MOVE.

She sat on the grey stones with her hands pressed over her mouth and her eyes wide and wet, looking at the eyeless face.

"*A summer*," said the Ferryman. Very quietly. "*Twenty years before. A tinker. On the road. Who came to the cottage door to mend a pan.*" A pause. "*Who could whistle a blackbird down out of a tree. Who stayed for a season, the way men sometimes did, for Harrow women. Who went on down the road at the end of summer, whistling.*" The eyeless face was very still. "*Who never knew he'd left a daughter behind.*"

Seren made a sound.

"*She loved him*," said the Ferryman. "*Not for long. A summer. But all the way down.*" A pause. "*She had loved him every day for twenty years. Quietly. The way Harrow women love. Without ever saying.*" His long grey hand moved on his pole. "*She would have least wished to lose him. So that was the price.*"

"*What was his name*?" said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN DIDN'T ANSWER.

"*Please*," said his mother. Her voice was breaking. "*Please. You know it. You have it. It's in your river. His name. His face. His whistle.*" She took her hands away from

her mouth. Her face was wet. "*He was my father. I never knew him. Mam never—she couldn't—she didn't—*"

"*I cannot*," said the Ferryman.

"*Please*."

"*I cannot*, *Seren Vey.*" His voice was very gentle. "*It was hers. She paid it. It is mine now. It is not yours to ask for and it is not mine to give.*" A pause. "*The river takes what it is owed. I do not give refunds.*"

She bent her head.

"*But I will tell you one thing*," said the Ferryman.

She looked up.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I rowed her*," he said. "*Your mother. A year later. When she died. In a cottage in your Vale, with you holding her hand.*"

Seren went very still.

"*She came down to my shore*," said the Ferryman. "*The way they all do, in the end. Old men. Young women. Everyone.*" His eyeless face turned toward the boat. "*And she got in. And sat in the bow. Facing back. Toward the world. The way they all do.*" A pause. "*And I pushed off.*"

He was quiet for a moment.

"*And all the way across*," said the Ferryman, "*she whistled.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER'S FACE BROKE.

Antho saw it. Saw it go. Not like water in a bucket. Not like a dandelion. Like ice on a pond in spring. All at once. Cracking. From the middle out.

"*She did not know the tune*," said the Ferryman. "*She said so. Halfway across. She stopped whistling and she said, I don't know what this is. I don't know where I learned it.*" He was quiet. "*And then she started again. And she whistled it all the way to the far shore.*"

He turned his eyeless face toward Seren.

"*It was a very good whistle*," said the Ferryman. "*It could have whistled a blackbird down out of a tree.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

His mother sat on the shingle and cried. Not loudly. Not the way she'd cried in the dark, which Antho had heard, once, through a black glass door, and never wanted to hear again. Quietly. Steadily. With her face in her hands and her shoulders

shaking. The way you cry when something you've been carrying for a long time is finally put down.

Antho put his arm round her. She leaned into him. Small. Square. Shaking.

The Ferryman stood beside his boat and waited.

He was very patient. He had been here since before the world was made.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Can you take us across*?" said Antho at last.

The eyeless face turned toward him.

"*To the Court*," said Antho. "*To the tower. To fetch it.*"

"*No*," said the Ferryman.

"*We'd pay*."

"*It is not the price*." The Ferryman's voice was very quiet. "*I told the tenth sister the same thing. On this shingle. Nine hundred years ago.*" His long grey hand moved on his pole. "*My boat carries two kinds of passenger to the grey country. Those whose time is done. And those who drank.*" A pause. "*You are neither.*"

"*You carried a crown*."

"*A crown is not a person*," said the Ferryman. "*A crown has no time to be done. A crown has no room in it to be pushed against.*" The eyeless face tilted. "*The grey country is the country of those who drank, Anthoren Vey. It was made of their drinking. It is full. All the way through. Like the gold your brother found at the edge.*" A pause. "*Anyone with room in them, it pushes. Slowly. Firmly. The way the edge pushed the four who came apart.*"

"*Hesper would have come apart*," said Antho.

"*She would have. In a day. Perhaps two.*" The Ferryman was quiet. "*She was full of room. She was the only one of the Ten who was.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Then how*," said Antho.

The Ferryman turned his eyeless face toward the west. Toward the far side of the river. Toward the grey.

"*There is a crack in the edge*," he said. "*You know there is. Your brother has seen it. A finger wide. Opened by Harrow blood.*" A pause. "*Harrow blood would open it further. The edge does not know it. The edge does not push it.*"

"*And on the other side*?"

"*On the other side, the country pushes*," said the Ferryman. "*As I said. You would come apart. Slowly. Unless—*"

He stopped.

"*Unless*?" said Antho.

The eyeless face turned back toward him.

"*Unless you carried room with you*," said the Ferryman. "*Your own. Enough to stand in. Enough to breathe.*" A pause. "*There is a pool in a green field three hundred miles east of here, Anthoren Vey. Full of room. The fullest room in the world. With a girl on a crutch who keeps it.*" The long grey face was very still. "*Room can be carried. In a cup. Someone once made cups for carrying silence. Horseshoe iron, with a word inside. I believe you know them.*"

Antho stared at him.

"*Hush-cups*," he said.

"*I do not know what you call them*," said the Ferryman. "*I know what they are.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER HAD LIFTED her head.

Her face was wet. Her eyes were red. She looked at the Ferryman for a long time.

"*If I go*," she said. "*Across. Through the crack. To fetch it.*"

"*Mam—*"

"*If I go*," said Seren Harrow. Not looking at Antho. Looking at the Ferryman. "*Will I come back?*"

The Ferryman turned his face toward her.

"*You will not go*," he said.

She stared at him.

"*You will not go*," said the Ferryman again. Very gently. "*Not across. Not this year.*" A pause. "*You will be at a window. Every evening. Looking west.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO FELT HIS MOTHER go still.

All of her. All at once. The way she went still at doors.

"*Why*?" she said.

The Ferryman didn't answer for a long time.

He stood beside his boat with his long grey hand on his pole and his eyeless face turned toward her, and the lantern on the top of the pole swayed, very slightly, in a wind that wasn't there.

"*I told your son*," he said at last. "*Last winter. At the pool. That I would wait.*" A pause. "*I am very patient. I have been here since before the world was made.*"

"*Arion*," said Seren.

"*I will come for your husband*," said the Ferryman, "*before the year turns.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY MOVED.

The river ran. Silver. Slow. A long way off, on the hill behind them, Ashka shifted in her sleep, and grumbled, and was still.

"*When*?" said Seren. Her voice was barely there.

"*I do not know*," said the Ferryman. "*I never know. Not exactly. I only know before.*" His long grey hand moved on his pole. "*The little one gave him room. Ordinary room. A year. Perhaps two.*" A pause. "*It is not two.*"

His mother put her hand flat on the shingle.

As if the ground had moved. As if she needed something to hold on to.

"*Before the year turns*," she said.

"*Before the year turns*."

"*Before Lantern Night*?"

The Ferryman didn't answer.

He didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Can I pay*?" said Seren.

The eyeless face turned toward her.

"*For my memories*," she said. Very fast. As if she had to get it all out before she lost her nerve. "*Of him. The ones I paid you. Thirty years. Before he goes.*" Her hand was flat on the stones. White at the knuckles. "*You said a love for a love. You said that was the price. You told Antho. Last spring.*"

"*I did*."

"*Then I'll pay it*," said Seren Harrow. "*Tell me what. Tell me whose. I'll pay it.*"

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THE FERRYMAN WAS QUIET for a long time.

"*A love*," he said at last. "*Not yours for him. That is what you would be buying.*" A pause. "*Another love. Whole. Given freely. By the one who holds it.*"

"*Mine*," said Seren. "*For—for my sons. For—*"

"*Would you*?" said the Ferryman.

She stopped.

"*Would you give me your love for your sons*," said the Ferryman. Very gently. "*All of it. To have him back. For a few months. Before he goes.*" A pause. "*You would not remember loving them. You would look at them the way you looked at him in the cold room at the Keep. Kindly. Politely. As strangers with nice voices.*"

His mother's face was white.

"*Would you*?" said the Ferryman.

She didn't answer.

She couldn't. He watched her try. Her mouth opened. Closed. She looked at Antho. At her son, sitting beside her on the shingle, with his arm round her. With his father's eyes and his mother's face.

And she couldn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mine*," said Antho.

They both looked at him.

"*Mine*," he said again. His voice was shaking. He didn't let it stop him. "*For—*" He didn't know. He didn't know what to say. He thought of Seraphine. Of her spectacles. Of a list five hundred and sixty-three reasons long. "*For anything. For anyone. Whatever you want. So she can have him back.*"

"*Antho, no—*"

"*Yours is for a woman with ink on her fingers*," said the Ferryman. "*Is it not. And a list.*" The eyeless face turned toward him. "*Would you give me that, Anthoren Vey? Would you go home to her and look at her across the kitchen table and not know why she was smiling at you?*"

Antho opened his mouth.

And couldn't.

He sat on the shingle and thought of Seraphine, at the top of the passage stair, writing in her book. *Reason five hundred and sixty-two. He counts the lanterns every night.*

And couldn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It cannot be taken*," said the Ferryman. Very gently. To both of them. "*It must be given. And it must be the giver's to give.*" A pause. "*And it must be someone who could bear to give it.*"

He looked at them both. With no eyes.

"*Think carefully*," said the Ferryman. "*Both of you. When I come for him, someone will ask me for a price. Someone always does. At the very end, at the edge of the water, someone always asks.*" His long grey hand was still on his pole. "*And I always collect.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS GONE WHEN they looked up.

Of course he was. Antho had stopped expecting anything else. There was the boat on the shingle. There was the river. There was the long valley and the green hills and the sky.

No Ferryman. No lantern.

Just a flat grey stone. On the shingle. Where he'd been standing.

His mother picked it up.

It was very smooth. River-smooth. Flat as a coin. Exactly the right size to fit between your finger and your thumb.

The kind of stone you'd skip.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FLEW HOME.

Two days. Over the green hills. Over the Teeth. His mother behind him with her arms round his waist and her eyes open, all the way. She didn't say much. Neither did he.

On the second evening, over the Greyspine, with the sun going down red behind them and the Vale opening up below, long and green and gold, she started whistling.

Very softly. Into the wind. So softly Antho barely heard it.

She'd never been able to whistle. She'd told him that. When he was small. *Your da whistles*, she used to say. *Not me. Harrow women can't. We don't have the lips for it.*

She was whistling now.

Badly. Breathily. Missing notes. A tune he didn't know. Slow, and a little sad, and somehow very old. Like a song you'd hear a tinker whistle on a road at the end of summer.

He didn't ask her what it was.

He didn't think she knew.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN IN the clearing at Harrow at dusk.

The stream was running. The birches were green, just, with the first leaves of spring. Across the water, in the east window of the other cottage, a hornlight glowed soft and gold behind its horn.

And in the west window of the blue-door cottage, a shape. Small. Bent. In a chair. With a blanket round its shoulders and a white wisp of hair.

Looking west.

His mother was off the dragon before Ashka had folded her wings.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WATCHED HER GO.

Across the clearing. Up the oak ramp. Barefoot. Fast. Almost running. With a flat grey stone in her fist.

He watched her stop in the doorway. And stand there.

He watched his father turn his head. Slowly. From the window.

He couldn't hear what either of them said.

He didn't need to.

He sat on the dragon in the dusk and watched his mother walk across the room and kneel down by the wheeled chair and put the stone in his father's hand and close his spotted fingers round it, one by one, the way you'd close a child's fingers round a coin.

And put her head down on his knees.

And stay there.

◆ ◆ ◆

Before the year turns.

Antho sat on Ashka in the clearing until it was dark.

He thought about a love, whole, given freely, by the one who holds it.

He thought about who in the world could possibly bear to give one.

He didn't know.

He went home to the Keep the next morning and counted the lanterns. One thousand, one hundred and thirteen. One of them gold.

And then he went and found Seraphine in the library and sat down beside her and didn't say anything at all, for an hour, while she wrote. Just to be sure he still knew why she was smiling.

He did.

He was very, very glad.

CHAPTER 9

Iron in the Deep

SILAS HASK DIDN'T WANT to leave the pool.

He didn't say so. He wasn't a man who said things. He stood on the grey rim in the early light with Kell's stick in his fist and his pick on his back and his face like a slab of coal, and looked at Lex, and didn't move.

"*It's two days*," said Lex. "*Three at the most. There and back.*"

Hask didn't answer.

"*Kit's here. And Brigid. And the Tulls. And Absalom.*"

Nothing.

"*And Ivy*," said Lex. "*She's its keeper. The net says so.*"

"*She's fifteen*," said Hask. "*And she can't walk without a crutch.*" He looked down at the stick in his hand. Plain. Dark. "*The Queen said stand in front of it. Every day. Till I can't.*"

"*I know what she said*."

"*Then you know I can't go*."

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Big one*," said a voice.

They both turned.

Ivy Moss was sitting on the far side of the rim, where she always sat, with her bad foot tucked under her and her good one dangling over the deep. She wasn't looking at them. She was looking down. Listening.

"*It says go*," said Ivy.

Hask's face didn't change.

"*It says—*" She frowned. Tilted her head. "*It says, the big one knows the dark. It says, the big one's been in the deep places with a lamp on his head his whole life.*" She looked up. Across the pool. At Hask. With her strange light eyes. "*It says the smith needs someone who can hear rock settling.*"

Silas Hask stood on the rim for a long time.

Then he turned. And walked round the pool, slowly, to where Kit was sitting on the grass by the black stone. Seventeen. Lanky. With a burned hand from the forge and his helmet-lamp in his lap.

He held out the stick.

Kit looked at it. Then up at him.

"*Stand in front of it*," said Hask. "*Every day. Till I'm back.*"

"*Silas—*"

"*Nobody kneels at its edge*," said Silas Hask. "*Nobody cups their hands. Not while you're breathing.*"

Kit took the stick.

His hands were shaking. Hask's weren't. Hask let go of it slowly, one finger at a time, the way you'd let go of a rope you weren't sure would hold.

Then he turned round. And came back to Lex.

"*Coldwater*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

VHARUUN DIDN'T LIKE COLDWATER either.

He said so. All the way there. A picture of black smoke. A picture of a hole in a hill with nothing in it. A picture of a dragon with soot on its nose, sneezing.

Two days, Lex told him. *Then the pool. Then sheep.*

The picture of the sneezing dragon came back. Larger.

Four sheep.

A pause.

The picture went away.

[You're going to bankrupt Roole,] said Ember.

Roole can afford it.

[Roole's paying for six already. He wrote to you. He says the Keepers' quartermaster is threatening to resign.]

◆ ◆ ◆

COLDWATER SAT IN THE bottom of a long black valley at the eastern end of the Greyspine, where the mountains came down to the coal.

Lex had been here before. Two summers ago. To Unbind them. He'd stood by the Coldwater Stone in the square with his hand on it and his Root open and four thousand people in front of him, grey with coal-damp and Gloam, coughing. And he'd taken their Ceilings off. Every one. And watched them go up like mine-damp. Like a pit going up. Four thousand people levelling at once.

He remembered the coughing best.

It was quieter now.

He heard it as Vharuun came down over the lip of the valley. Not gone. Never gone. A dry rattle from a doorway. A wet hack from a man sitting on a step. But fewer of them. Much fewer. And the ones there were sounded different. Shorter. Lighter. As if something in the chests they came out of had more room round it.

"*Mal*," said Hask.

He'd heard it too. He was sitting behind Lex on the dragon's neck, enormous, his pick across his knees. Looking down at the black valley where he'd been born.

"*Since Lantern Night*," he said. "*It made room. In me. In all of us.*" His voice was very rough. "*Not a cure. It doesn't cure. But you can breathe further.*" He was quiet. "*My da never breathed further than halfway in his life.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TOWN WAS HALF empty.

That was the other thing. Half the houses shuttered. Half the chimneys cold. The long grey terraces climbing the valley sides in rows, and every second door shut, with grass coming up through the step.

"*They went*," said Hask. When Lex looked. "*After you. After the Ceilings came off.*" He shrugged. A small heavy movement. "*Hewers who'd been capped at nineteen all their lives. Level forty in a year. Level fifty. Why would they go back down a hole?*"

"*And the rest*?"

"*The rest stayed*," said Hask. "*Because it's ours.*" He looked at the pithead. At the great black wheel of it, turning slowly against the grey sky. "*Because somebody has to dig the coal or the whole of Caldor goes cold in the winter.*" He climbed down off the dragon. Heavily. "*And because some of us like it. Down there. In the dark. It's quiet.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT TO THE Crown and Pick first.

Hask said they had to. He said you didn't go down a Coldwater pit without asking at the Crown and Pick, not if you wanted to come back up. He said it the way a sailor would say you didn't sail without throwing a coin in the harbour.

It was a low dark room with a fire at one end and a bar at the other and old men in between. Six of them. Sitting at a long table with their pots of ale. Grey-faced. Coal in the lines of their hands. Every one of them coughing, a little. Every one of them going quiet when Hask ducked in under the lintel.

They looked at him.

Then at Lex. At the mark on his cheek.

Then back at Hask.

"*Silas*," said one of them. The oldest. White-haired. With one eye clouded and a hand missing two fingers. "*Thought you were dead.*"

"*Not yet*, *Ned*."

"*Thought you'd gone off with a moth-woman and got yourself wings*."

"*I did*," said Hask. "*They fell off.*"

The old man looked at him for a long time.

Then he pushed a pot of ale across the table.

"*Sit down, lad*," said Old Ned. "*Your da would want to know you're breathing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY ASKED ABOUT THE Old Gallery.

Hask asked. Lex let him. He sat at the end of the long table with a pot of ale he didn't drink and listened.

The old men went quiet.

"*Nobody goes down the Old Gallery*," said Ned at last. "*You know that, Silas. Been sealed since my da's time.*"

"*I know*."

"*Then you know why*."

"*Tell him*," said Hask. And nodded at Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

NED LOOKED AT LEX for a long moment with his one good eye.

"*It sings*," he said.

Lex waited.

"*Bottom of the Old Gallery*," said Ned. "*Two hundred fathom. Deepest working in the Greyspine. Deeper than anyone's dug since.*" He turned his ale pot round on the table. Slowly. "*My granda worked it. And his. And they all said the same. You put your ear to the rock down there, at the very bottom, at the end of the last seam, and you can hear it.*" He tapped the table with his three-fingered hand. Once. "*A note. One note. High. Like a harp-string. Like a wet finger round a glass.*"

"*Like the whole mountain was humming one thing*," said another old man. Quietly. "*Over and over. Forever.*"

"*Men went down there and came up singing it*," said Ned. "*Couldn't stop. My granda's brother. Hummed it for thirty years. In his sleep. At his own wedding. Hummed it on his deathbed.*" He drank. "*So they sealed it. Bricked up the head of the gallery. Put a stone over it with a hammer cut in it, the old way, so nobody'd ever go down.*"

He looked at Hask.

"*And now you want to*," said Old Ned.

"*Now I want to*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why*?"

Hask didn't answer. He looked at Lex.

Lex put down his ale pot.

"*Because something's coming along it*," he said. "*The note. The thing that hums. It's a thread. The deepest one in the world.*" He looked round the table. At the old grey faces. "*And something's climbing it. Iron. From the edge of the world. It'll pass under here.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*It might be under here now*," said Lex.

Old Ned put his pot down. Very slowly.

"*That's why*," he said.

"*Why what*?"

"*Why it changed*," said the old man. "*The note.*" He looked at the others. They didn't look back. They were looking at their ale. "*We hear it, sometimes. Up here. If the wind's right and the house is quiet. Faint. Through the floor. Through the rock.*" He swallowed. "*Always the same. One note. My whole life.*"

"*And now*?"

"*Now there's another sound*," said Ned. "*Under it. These three weeks.*" He looked at Lex with his one good eye. "*Like a hammer. A long way off. Every few hours.*"

He tapped the table. Once. Sharp.

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STONE WITH THE hammer cut in it was still there.

At the end of a side-gallery a mile into the mountain. Down three shafts, by cage and by ladder. Through tunnels where Lex had to walk bent double and Hask had to walk on his knees. In the dark, with the lamps on their heads throwing small yellow circles on the black walls, and the air going thick and warm and close, and the sound of water dripping somewhere far off.

A wall. Brick. Old. Black with coal-dust. And set into it, at head height, a slab of grey stone with a hammer cut in it. Crossed out.

"*Like the moth*," said Lex. Very quietly. "*On the box. In the cellar.*"

[People cross things out,] said Ember. *[When they want to say don't. It's very old. It's older than letters.]*

Hask put his hand flat on the bricks.

He stood like that for a long time. His eyes shut. His big scarred palm on the black wall.

Then he took it away.

"*Hollow behind*," he said. "*Ten foot of brick. Then a drop. Long one.*" He opened his eyes. "*And something under the drop.*" His face was very strange. "*Something heavy, smith. Heavier than rock.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED THE WALL in four blows.

Lex watched him do it. He'd seen Hask break things before. He'd seen him break a Delve core and the Well scream. He'd seen him break the Moth Queen's wing on Lantern Night with one swing.

This was different.

Hask didn't swing hard. He hardly swung at all. He put the point of his pick against the bricks, here, there, very lightly, the way you'd touch a sleeping animal to see if it was breathing. Listening. With his head cocked.

Fault-Finder, the net called it. *He hears where things want to come apart.*

And then he leaned on the pick. Just a little. In one place.

And the wall fell down.

Not crashed. *Fell*. All of it. All at once. Ten feet of old brick sliding down into a heap of rubble at their feet in a soft dry roar, like a man sitting down who's been standing too long.

The dust came up round them. Black. Thick.

And through it, from the dark beyond, faint, so faint it was barely there at all—

A note.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX FELT IT BEFORE he heard it.

In his teeth. In his breastbone. In the bell on the cord round his neck, which didn't ring, but *shivered*, very slightly, the way a glass shivers on a shelf when someone sings near it.

A note. High. Clear. Thin. Like a harp-string. Like a wet finger round the rim of a glass. Going on and on and on. Never rising. Never falling. Never stopping. One note.

And under it—

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE OLD GALLERY WENT down at a slant.

Steep. Steeper than any working Lex had ever seen. Cut straight into the rock by men who'd been following a seam with picks and lamps, hundreds of years ago, and hadn't cared how steep it went so long as the coal kept coming. There were steps, in places. Hacked into the floor. Worn smooth. And an old iron chain pinned to the wall to hold on to, rusted almost through.

They went down.

Hask first. With his pick. With his head cocked. Listening. Lex behind, with his fire burning low and gold in one hand and the other on the rusted chain.

The note got louder.

Not louder. *Closer*. The way a sound gets closer when you're inside the thing that's making it. It wasn't in his ears anymore. It was in the rock. In the air. In him. Every step down, it went deeper into his chest, until he felt it humming in his ribs like a struck bell.

[It's beautiful,] said Ember. Very quietly. Wondering. *[Lex. Isn't it.]*

It was.

That was the worst thing. It was the most beautiful sound he'd ever heard. Pure and clear and patient. Like the world holding its breath.

He understood, going down, why old men's brothers came up humming it and never stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GALLERY ENDED IN a crack.

Two hundred fathoms. Lex didn't need Hask to tell him. He could feel it. The weight of the mountain over his head. The whole Greyspine, pressing down.

The old men had cut the gallery down and down, following the coal, until the coal ran out. And then they'd stopped. Lex could see the marks of their last picks on the rock. Old. Rounded. Black.

And then, after they'd gone, something had come up from underneath.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FLOOR OF THE gallery was broken.

Split. Torn open. A crack, running across the bottom of the working from wall to wall, a yard wide. Its edges jagged and fresh and sharp, the rock round them shattered like glass. Not old. Not rounded. *New*. Weeks old. Days.

And coming up out of the crack, through the broken floor, like the rim of a great buried wheel—

Iron.

◆ ◆ ◆

BLACK. PLAIN. HEAVY. A curve of it. Rising up out of the crack at a slant and going back down into the rock on the far side. As thick as a man's thigh. Smooth. Perfectly smooth. No rust. No pitting. No hammer-marks. As if it hadn't been forged at all, but had simply *decided* to be iron, all at once, and been iron ever since.

A ring.

Lex could see that. Even though only the top of it showed. Even though the rest of it was buried in the rock, in the dark, two hundred fathoms down. He could feel the shape of it. Through the Stone. A great black circle, ten feet across, standing on its edge in the heart of the mountain.

And through the middle of it—

He didn't have to see that either. He could hear it.

The note.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNELT AT THE edge of the crack.

He put his lamp down on the rock beside him and looked over. Down. Into the dark.

And saw it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS VERY THIN. Thinner than a hair. Thinner than a thought. Running across the bottom of the crack, far down, straight as a ruler, from the dark on one side to the dark on the other. Silver. Bright. Brighter than anything had a right to be at the bottom of a coal mine two hundred fathoms under the Greyspine.

Humming.

The last thread.

He could see it because something was on it. The way he'd seen it at the Knot. The way he'd seen Elric's grey one.

Iron.

The great black ring stood round it. Closed. Tight. And beyond it, further west, deeper in the rock, another. And another. Going back into the dark under the mountains, toward the edge of the world. A line of black rings strung on a silver thread. Like beads on a wire.

And on the other side, east, toward the Knot—

Nothing. Yet.

Just the thread. Silver. Bare. Humming. Running off into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

Clink.

He felt it this time. Not just heard. Felt it come up through the rock and into his knees. A shock. A jolt. Like standing on an anvil when someone strikes it.

And east of the great ring—just past it, just a little way along the thread, in the dark—

Another one closed.

Small, at first. A hoop of black. Snapping shut round the silver like a bracelet. And then *growing*. Swelling. Fattening. Spreading out into the rock round it with a sound like a slow groan, a creak, the sound of stone giving way. The new ring getting thicker. Heavier. Ten feet across.

The rock round it cracked.

Lex felt the whole floor of the gallery shudder.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He's here*," said Hask. Behind him. Very quietly. "*Isn't he.*"

"*He's here*."

"*Under us*."

"*Right under us*."

Hask came and knelt beside him. At the edge of the crack. And looked down at the silver thread and the black iron and the dark.

"*How do we stop him*?"

Lex didn't answer straight away.

He looked at the great black ring. At the iron. Smooth and perfect and finished.

He thought about a field of gold. About heat that wouldn't sink in.

[It's not the same,] said Ember. Quietly. *[Lex. It's not gold. It's not kept. It's iron. It's made.]*

Everything made has a flaw, Lex thought.

[Yes.]

Everything.

[Yes,] said Ember. *[Even crowns. Even queens. Even the Moth Queen had one.]*

He looked at Silas Hask.

"*Find it*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK DIDN'T ASK WHAT. He didn't need to.

He climbed down into the crack.

Slowly. Carefully. His big hands finding holds in the shattered rock. His boots on the edges. Down, a yard, two yards, until he was crouched on a shelf of broken stone beside the great black ring, with the silver thread humming below him and his lamp throwing a small yellow circle on the iron.

He put his hand on it.

Lex saw his face change.

"*Cold*," said Hask. Very quietly. "*Smith. It's so cold.*"

"*Can you hear it*?"

Hask didn't answer.

He took his hand away. And took his pick off his back. The pick he'd swung at Delve cores, and at the Moth Queen's wing, and then held out, on a rubble-heap, on Lantern Night, for a moth to fly onto.

He put the point of it against the iron.

And listened.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK A LONG time.

Lex knelt at the top of the crack and waited. He held his fire low and steady so Hask could see. The note hummed in his ribs. His knees ached on the rock.

Hask moved the point of the pick. A finger's width. Listened. Moved it again. Up the curve of the ring. Down. Round. Very slowly. Very patiently. The way a hewer works a seam he doesn't trust.

Clink.

Another ring. Further east. The floor shuddered. Dust came down from the roof of the gallery in a fine black rain.

Hask didn't look up. He moved the pick.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There*," he said.

Lex leaned over.

He couldn't see anything. Just iron. Black. Smooth. Perfect. Where the point of Hask's pick rested, a little below the top of the curve, on the eastern side.

"*There*," said Hask again. His voice was very strange. "*It's thin. Here. Just here. Like a—like a place where whoever made it stopped for a breath.*" He looked up. His face in the lamplight was grey and wet. "*It's not much, smith. It's the size of a fingernail. It's the only one.*"

"*It's enough*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT DOWN.

Into the crack. Onto the shelf of broken stone. Beside Hask. Beside the ring. So close to the silver thread that the note wasn't in his ribs anymore, it *was* his ribs, it was his teeth, it was the blood going round in him.

He took Aurelian's hammer out of the loop on his belt.

Small. Old. Plain. A smith's hammer, the kind you'd use for fine work. For setting rivets. For tapping a rune into a blade. Nine hundred years old. The hammer that had woven the world.

He'd tapped a Moth Queen's flaw with it.

He looked at the place where Hask's pick rested. At the black iron. At the spot the size of a fingernail where someone, nine hundred years ago, or nine weeks ago, had stopped for a breath.

"*Ready*," said Hask.

Lex lifted the hammer.

Tink.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A VERY small sound.

Smaller than *clink*. Higher. Lighter. A sound like a spoon on a cup. Like a fingernail on a bell.

For a moment nothing happened.

And then the ring cracked.

◆ ◆ ◆

FROM THE POINT WHERE the hammer touched. Outward. A thin bright line, running through the black iron like a crack running through ice. Up the curve. Down the curve. Round. All the way round. Faster than he could follow it. Through the iron and down into the rock where the rest of the ring was buried and on round and back up the other side.

The whole ring rang.

Not *clink*. Not *tink*. A great deep groaning boom, like a bell the size of a mountain being struck once. It went through the rock. Through the gallery. Through Lex. He felt his teeth jar in his head.

And the ring fell apart.

Into pieces. Into black shards. Sliding off the silver thread and falling away into the dark of the crack, ringing as they fell, clattering, chiming, down and down and down.

And the thread, where it had been, was bare.

◆ ◆ ◆

The thread *sang*.

The note changed. For the first time. For the first time in nine hundred years, in the whole history of the Old Gallery, in every story every old man in the Crown and Pick had ever told. It went up. Just a little. A half-step. Like a string that's been held down suddenly let go.

And far off, along it, east, in the dark, somebody grunted.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HEARD IT.

It came up the thread. Up through the rock. Up through the iron rings that were still there, east of the broken one. A sound. A voice. Low. Heavy. Rough. Like a cart going over gravel.

Not words.

Just a grunt. The sound a man makes when someone steps on his foot.

And then, after it—

"*Huh*."

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*," said a voice.

It came out of the iron.

Out of all of it. Out of the rings still standing to the east, out of the shards still falling into the dark below, out of the rock itself. Low. Flat. Heavy. A voice that had said perhaps four thousand words in its whole life before the drinking and perhaps four hundred since, and meant every one.

"*You broke it*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown.

Lex didn't answer.

"*Nobody's broken one of my rings*," said the voice. "*Not in nine hundred years. Not ever.*" A pause. "*Huh.*"

He didn't sound angry. That was the strange thing. He sounded *interested*. The way a mason sounds when someone shows him a crack in a wall he built.

"*How*?" said Caddoc.

"*It had a flaw*," said Lex.

A long silence.

"*Yes*," said Caddoc. "*It would have. I was tired, there. Just there. I'd been climbing a long time.*" Another pause. "*I stopped for a breath.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Go back*," said Lex.

He said it to the iron. To the thread. To the voice. Crouched on a shelf of broken rock two hundred fathoms under the Greyspine with a nine-hundred-year-old hammer in his hand.

"*Go back*," he said again. "*Down the thread. To the grey. To your brother. Tell him no.*"

The iron was silent.

"*I can't*," said Caddoc.

"*You can*."

"*No*." The voice was very flat. Very patient. "*I gave my word. To my brother. Nine hundred years ago. On the shingle. In chains. I said I'd go where he went and do what he asked.*" A pause. "*I don't break my word, smith. I'm not like the rest of them. I've never broken it once.*"

"*He's going to keep the world*," said Lex. "*All of it. Every thread. Every child.*"

"*I know*."

"*And you don't care*?"

Another silence.

"*I care*," said Caddoc. "*I'm not cruel, smith. I'm only certain.*" A pause. "*I'm certain I gave my word. I'm certain I'll keep it. I'm certain I'll come down this thread and into your knot on the night you light your lanterns and take your Key to my brother.*" The voice didn't change. "*Those are the things I'm certain of. The rest I leave to him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

Clink.

Lex felt it.

Not east. Not along the thread toward the Knot. *Here*. Right here. On the bare stretch of silver where the broken ring had been.

A hoop of black. Snapping shut round the thread. Exactly where the old one had stood.

And growing.

Fast. Faster than the others. Swelling. Fattening. Out. The iron spreading through the rock like ink through water, like frost across a pane. A foot thick. Two. Ten feet across.

Whole. Smooth. Perfect.

No flaw.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's my road*, *smith*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown. "*And I'm on it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROCK MOVED.

Not the ring. The *rock*. All round them. The walls of the crack. The floor of the gallery above. Lex felt it go. Through the Stone. A great slow shudder, running up through the mountain from below, from the thread, from the iron.

And the iron came up.

Not rings. *Spikes*. Black. Sharp. Thrusting up out of the broken floor of the crack like the teeth of a trap. Out of the walls. Out of the rock all round them. Slowly. Inexorably. Growing toward each other. Closing.

Like a fist.

"*Out*," said Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CLIMBED.

Lex didn't remember most of it. He remembered his hands on the broken rock. He remembered the iron coming up beside his face, black and cold and smooth, so close he could feel the cold coming off it. He remembered Hask above him, reaching down, his big scarred hand closing round Lex's wrist like a vice, hauling.

He remembered the gallery floor bucking under them as they came up out of the crack.

He remembered running. Up the steep slant of the Old Gallery. In the dark. With the lamp on his head swinging and the rusted chain under his hand and the note screaming in his ribs, not humming now, *screaming*, high and wild and wrong, and the iron coming up through the floor behind them, *clink, clink, clink*, spike after spike after spike.

He remembered Hask stopping.

◆ ◆ ◆

HALFWAY UP THE GALLERY.

Just stopping. Turning round. In the narrow dark. With his back to the slope and his face to the iron coming up the gallery behind them.

"*Hask—*"

"*Go*," said Silas Hask.

"*Hask*, *come on—*"

"*It's following the thread*," said Hask. "*Not us. The thread runs under the gallery. All the way up. It's going to come up under the whole mountain.*" He hefted his pick. "*Go. I'll find the faults. Slow it.*"

"*You can't—*"

"*I'm a Coldwater hewer*," said Silas Hask. "*I've been listening to rock settle my whole life.*"

And turned his back on Lex. And put his pick to the floor of the gallery. And listened.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T GO.

He stood behind him in the dark with his fire in his hand and watched.

The iron came up the slope. A spike. Black. Sharp. Bursting up through the floor five yards below them. Then another. Four yards. Three.

And Hask's pick touched the rock in front of the spike.

Lightly. Very lightly. Listening.

And then he leaned on it.

And the floor of the gallery fell in.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT ALL OF IT. One slab. A great wedge of rock between Hask's boots and the oncoming iron. It cracked along a line Lex couldn't see and slid away, down, into the dark, taking the spike with it. Carrying it down. Crashing into the crack below.

The next spike came up. Further back. Slower.

Hask found the fault in front of it.

Another slab went.

"*It's following the grain*," said Hask. Very quietly. Not looking round. "*The iron. It grows along the lines in the rock. Where the rock's already weak. So I break the rock first.*" He moved the pick. Listened. "*And it has to go round.*"

Another slab.

The iron came on. Slower now. Much slower. Having to go round. Having to find another way.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAUGHT HIM ON the fifth one.

Lex saw it happen. Saw the spike come up out of the wall of the gallery, not the floor, sideways, fast, where Hask wasn't looking. Black. Thin as a blade. And Hask's arm was in the way.

His right arm. His pick-arm. Holding the pick out to the rock.

The spike went past it.

Not through. Past. Along the outside of the forearm, from the wrist to the elbow. Fast. Clean. The way a knife goes past an apple when you're peeling it.

Hask made a sound.

Not a scream. A hewer's sound. A grunt. The sound a man makes when the cage-chain slips and catches his hand.

And kept working.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX BURNED IT.

Not with fire. He'd learned that. You couldn't burn Caddoc's iron any more than you could burn the Moth Queen's light or a dust-man made of grey. He'd tried, at the crack, and it had done nothing.

He used the Stone.

He put his hand flat on the wall of the gallery beside the spike and *asked*. Not the iron. The rock round it. *Please. Hold it. Just here. Just for a moment.*

And the old rock of the Greyspine, which had been here long before any Crowned king drank from any pool, which had been here before the world was woven and would be here after, closed round the spike like a fist.

And held it.

Not for long. Lex felt the iron push. Felt it grow. Felt the rock groan and crack and begin to give.

Long enough.

Hask turned round.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Go*," said Lex.

This time Hask went.

They went up the rest of the Old Gallery together. Hask first, with his pick in his left hand now and his right arm held against his chest, the blood running black down it in the lamplight. Lex behind, with his hand on the wall, asking the rock to hold, and hold, and hold.

They came out through the broken wall at the top. Past the stone with the hammer cut in it and crossed out.

And behind them, from the bottom of the gallery, from two hundred fathoms down, from the iron—

Clink.

And then nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE IRON HAD STOPPED.

Lex felt it stop. Through the Stone. All at once. As if someone had put down a tool.

It didn't come up any further. It didn't come after them. It stood in the bottom of the Old Gallery in a forest of black spikes, the way it had stood in the crack round the thread. Finished. Perfect. Still.

And far down, under it, the thread hummed.

One note. The old one. The half-step gone. As if it had never been.

"*He's not following*," said Hask. Panting. Leaning against the wall of the side-gallery with his arm against his chest.

"*No*."

"*Why not*?"

"*Because he doesn't need to*," said Lex. "*We're not on his road*."

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T TALK ON the way up.

Three shafts. Ladder and cage. Through the tunnels, bent double, on their knees. Hask's blood dripping on the black floor. Lex holding his fire up so they could see.

When they came out of the pithead into the evening, the whole of Coldwater was standing in the yard.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T KNOW HOW they knew.

The note, maybe. They'd all heard the note, all their lives. Faint. Through the floor. On quiet nights. And today it had changed. Gone up a half-step, for the first time in nine hundred years, and then come down again.

And then the mountain had shuddered.

They were standing in the pithead yard in the grey evening light. Hundreds of them. Men in their pit-clothes. Women with their shawls over their heads. Children. Old men from the Crown and Pick. Old Ned at the front, with his one good eye and his hand with two fingers missing.

Silent.

Looking at the cage as it came up.

At Silas Hask, stepping out of it. With his arm against his chest and his pick in his left hand and the blood running black down his sleeve.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

Hask stood in front of the cage and looked at them. At the town he'd been born in. That had coughed his father to death, and his mother, and his sister. That he'd left to go and break cores and get himself wings.

A woman came out of the crowd.

Old. Small. Bent. With a shawl over her head and a basin in her hands. She came across the black yard to Hask and stopped in front of him and looked up. A long way up.

"*Give it here*," she said.

He looked at her.

"*Your arm*," said the old woman. "*Give it here, Silas Hask. I've been binding hewers' arms since before your mam was born. I bound your da's when the cage-chain took the skin off it.*" She set the basin down on the ground. "*I'll bind yours.*"

He held it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CUT HIS SLEEVE away.

The wound was long. Wrist to elbow. Clean-edged. Deep. Not bleeding as much now. And round it, along both edges, the skin was strange. Darkened. Grey-black. As if the cold of the iron had gone into it and stayed.

The old woman looked at it for a long time.

"*That'll scar*," she said.

"*I know*."

"*That'll scar black*," she said. "*Like the blue scars. Like coal-tattoos. Like the miners get when the dust goes in a cut and the skin closes over it.*" She looked up at him. "*Only that's not coal.*"

"*No*," said Hask. "*It's iron.*"

She washed it. She bound it. She tied off the bandage with a knot Lex didn't know, a miner's knot, quick and hard.

Then she patted his arm. Once. Gently. On the bandage.

"*Your da'd be proud*," she said. "*Going down the Old Gallery.*" She picked up her basin. "*Daft. But proud.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CROWD DIDN'T GO home.

They stood in the pithead yard in the falling dark, hundreds of them, quiet. Waiting. Lex didn't know for what.

And then somebody started to sing.

He didn't see who. Somewhere in the middle of the crowd. A man's voice. Low. Rough. Cracked with coal-damp. Singing something slow. A hymn. A miners' hymn. The kind they sang going down at the start of a shift and coming up at the end of it, to count each other.

Another voice joined it. A woman's.

Then another.

Then all of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD NEVER HEARD anything like it.

Hundreds of voices. In a black valley at the end of the Greyspine, in the dark, under the great slow-turning wheel of the pithead. Rough voices. Cracked voices. Voices that coughed between lines and came back in. Voices that had breathed coal-dust and Gloam for generations and only lately, since Lantern Night, since a Well came home and made room, been able to breathe further than halfway.

Singing.

Not loud. Not beautiful, the way the note was beautiful. But *more*. More than one note. More than one voice. A hundred notes, and none of them quite the same, and all of them going the same way.

Hask was standing by the cage with his bandaged arm against his chest. His face in the dusk was grey and wet.

He was singing too.

◆ ◆ ◆

[He heard this,] said Ember. Very quietly.

Who?

[Caddoc. In the frost. In the message. He said he could hear men singing above him in the dark.] A pause. *[This is what he heard.]*

Lex stood in the pithead yard and listened.

To the hymn. To the hundreds of rough cracked voices. And under it, faint, through the ground, through the black rock, through two hundred fathoms of mountain—

One note. Pure. Clear. Patient. The last thread, humming, the way it always had.

And every few hours, far off, a hammer.

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

[It broke,] said Ember.

Lex didn't answer.

[Lex. It broke. The ring. You broke it.] A pause. *[He grew it back. But it broke. Nobody's ever broken one of his rings. He said so.]*

He grew it back.

[Everything's a crack first,] said Ember. Very softly. *[Ask any smith.]*

Lex stood in the dark with the hymn going up round him and his hand on the bell, which wasn't ringing, and thought about that.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Level 97 → 98
"He broke a crown's iron. It grew back.
 He will remember that it broke."
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◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FLEW BACK TO the pool in the morning.

Hask didn't say much. He sat behind Lex on Vharuun's neck with his bandaged arm across his knees and looked down at the green of the Blightmarch coming up under them. At the pool. At the small black house on the slope with the lantern in its window.

At the boy standing on the grey rim beside a square black stone. Seventeen. Lanky. With a long plain stick in his fist. Standing in front of the pool.

He'd been standing there for two days, Ivy said, when they landed. He'd slept sitting up against the black stone. He hadn't let go of the stick once.

Hask walked down the slope to him.

Kit looked at the bandaged arm. At the black at the edges of it.

He held out the stick.

Hask took it. In his left hand. The good one.

"*Nobody knelt*," said Kit.

"*Good lad*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT HOME.

To Harrow. Over the downs. Over the Vale. He came down in the high pasture at noon and ran down through the birches toward the stream and the two cottages and the hornlight in the east window.

Brannoc was standing on the oak ramp of the blue-door cottage.

He was standing very still. Enormous. Bald. With his arms at his sides and his soot-stained beard and his face like a block of grey stone.

Lex stopped running.

"*What*," he said.

Brannoc looked at him.

"*Your da's had a fall*," he said.

CHAPTER 10

The Old Man's Year

ARION VEY HAD BEEN careful for two hundred years, and he fell over reaching for a cup.

It wasn't even a good cup. It was the chipped blue one with the crack down the handle that Seren used for her tea because she said the crack made it taste of the sea. It was on the shelf above the hearth. Not high. A man of ordinary height could have reached it without thinking.

He'd been a man of ordinary height once. Taller than ordinary. He'd had to stoop under the arch of the Spire steps, the day he met her, in the rain.

He'd stood up out of the chair. Slowly. Carefully. With his hands on the arms. On *STEADY* and *HOME*. He'd done it a hundred times. He'd stood, and found his balance, and taken one step toward the hearth, and reached.

And the floor had come up and hit him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAY ON IT for a long time.

He wasn't hurt. That was his first thought. Not badly. His hip had struck the hearthstone and his elbow had struck the floor and his head, thank God, had struck nothing at all. He lay on his side on the flags between the chair and the fire with his cheek on the cold stone and took stock, the way he'd taken stock of a thousand things in two hundred years. Methodically. In order. As if he were writing it in a ledger.

Hip: bruised. Not broken. I think not broken.

Elbow: skinned.

Head: intact. Relatively.

Dignity—

He'd laughed then. A little. On the floor. It hurt his hip.

Dignity: not recorded.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T GET UP.

He tried. He got his hands under him and pushed, and his arms shook, and nothing happened. He tried again. He got as far as his elbow and the elbow gave and he was back on the floor with his cheek on the stone.

He lay there and thought, *well*.

He'd been Warden-Architect of the Spire. He'd held the Root of the whole net in his hands for two centuries. He'd walked into the gold room at Avaloria and sealed himself in crystal for sixteen years to hold the breaches shut from inside. He'd ridden a dragon to the top of the world.

He couldn't get up off his own kitchen floor.

Well, he thought again. *There it is. There's the year.*

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS QUIET.

Seren was across the stream. At the other cottage. With Wren and the baby. She'd gone over after breakfast with a basket of something, and she'd kissed him on the forehead on the way out, the way she always did now, quick and fierce, like stamping a seal, and said *back by noon, don't do anything foolish*.

He'd said, *I never do anything foolish*.

She'd said, *you married a hedge-witch*.

It was a little after ten, he thought. By the light. By the angle of the sun on the floor. He'd always been good at telling the time by the sun on the floor. He'd sat in a lot of rooms in two hundred years, watching the sun move across the floor.

He'd never sat on one before.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE TICKED.

He could see it from where he lay. Close. A yard from his face. The flames small and gold and steady behind the iron grate. He watched them.

Good morning, he thought. Without meaning to.

He didn't know where it came from. Lex said it. Every morning. To the hearth at the other cottage. Seren had told him. *He kneels down and says good morning to the fire. Every day. Like it's a dog.*

He'd laughed.

He wasn't laughing now. He lay on the cold flags with his cheek on the stone and his hip aching and looked at the fire, and thought, *good morning*. And felt, very faintly, the way you feel the warmth of a hand held near your face—

Something glad.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAY THERE AN hour.

Perhaps a little more. He counted it by the sun on the floor. It moved across the flags from the window toward the table leg, slowly, the way the hand of a clock moves.

He thought about a great many things.

He thought about Seren's face when she came back and found him. He thought about it very carefully, from several angles, the way he'd once thought about the structure of a ward. And decided he would very much like her not to see him like this, and that there was nothing at all he could do about it, and that this was, perhaps, the first lesson of the year.

You can't plan the end, he thought. *You can only be in it.*

He thought about Elric.

He hadn't meant to. He'd been trying not to, for weeks. Since Lex came back from the pool with his feet bare and said *bring him*. He'd been not-thinking about Elric so hard that it had worn a groove in him, like a cart-track worn in a road.

On the floor, he couldn't stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

FORTY YEARS.

He'd met him at the Spire. In the library. Elric had been twenty-one. Tall and sharp and laughing, with a raven on his shoulder and a stolen book under his arm. A Stormcaller. Tier II. Brilliant. Poor. From a fishing village on the Saltreach coast that nobody had ever heard of.

He'd looked at Arion across the library table and said, *you're the Warden-Architect*.

And Arion had said, *yes*.

And Elric had said, *you're younger than I thought*.

And Arion, who had been a hundred and eighty-eight years old and looked thirty-five, had said, *I'm older than you think*. And something in his voice must have given it away, because Elric had looked at him for a long time, very sharply, with his storm-grey eyes. And then laughed. And sat down. And said, *tell me*.

Nobody had ever said that to him before.

Not *tell me what to do*. Not *tell me how*. Just *tell me*.

He'd told him. Not everything. Not then. Some of it. Over forty years, most of it.

Almost all of it.

◆ ◆ ◆

You aren't ready, old friend.

He'd said that. In the gold room at Avaloria. Through the crystal. As a ghost. With his body sealed and his sons in front of him and Elric standing behind them in his grey cloak with the brass charms, waiting. Hoping. After forty years.

You aren't ready.

He'd been right. He knew he'd been right. Elric hadn't been ready. Elric had never been ready. Elric had wanted it too much to be ready.

He'd been right, and he'd said it gently, and he'd meant it kindly.

And that night Elric had opened the wards of Fort Caldris to the Pale Warden and carried Arion's body out of the crystal in a sack.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAY ON THE floor and thought, *I was right.*

And then he thought, *I was always right. That was the worst thing about me. Elric said so. In the Knot. Lex told me.*

He was right. He was always right. That was the worst thing about him.

He lay on the floor with the sun moving across the flags and his hip aching and thought about a young man with a stolen book saying *tell me*.

And about how, in forty years, he had never once said it back.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN FOUND HIM AT a quarter past eleven.

He heard her on the ramp. Bare feet on oak. Fast. She always came back faster than she went. And then the door. And then nothing.

He didn't turn his head. He couldn't, very well.

"*Good morning*," he said to the fire. "*I seem to have misplaced the floor.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T SCREAM.

He'd known she wouldn't. Harrow women don't. She dropped the basket. He heard it hit the flags and something in it break. And then she was on her knees beside him, her hands on him, on his shoulder, on his face, on his hip, fast and sure and shaking.

"*Where*," she said. "*Where does it hurt. Tell me. Tell me where.*"

"*My dignity.*"

"*Arion.*"

"*Hip*," he said. "*Left. Bruised, I think. Not broken. Elbow. Skinned. Head—*" He considered. "*Fine. I think. Though I've been talking to the fire, which may be a symptom.*"

She didn't laugh.

He'd thought she might. He'd hoped she might. He'd been lying on the floor for an hour composing the line.

She didn't laugh. She knelt on the flags with her hands on him and looked at his face. And he saw hers.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D SEEN IT DO a great many things.

He'd seen it laugh at the lanterns in the rain at nineteen. He'd seen it at the bottom of the Spire steps, turning round. He'd seen it across a table at a cottage at the end of the Vale, while her mother threw a frying pan at his head. He'd seen it at a wedding. At two births. At a thousand breakfasts. He'd seen it, in the gold room at Avaloria, looking at him through crystal for the last time before she walked into the dark.

He'd seen it in a cold room at the Lantern Keep, a year ago, looking at an old man she didn't know.

He'd never seen it like this.

Not frightened. She'd been frightened before. *Found*. As if she'd been looking for something for a long time without knowing she was looking, and had just this moment found it, and found it on the floor, and broken.

"*How long*," she said.

"*An hour*."

"*An hour*." Her voice cracked. "*On the floor. On your own. For an hour.*"

"*The sun was very interesting*."

"*Don't*," said Seren Harrow. "*Don't you dare. Don't you make a joke out of it. Not this.*" Her hands were very tight on his shoulder. "*I was across the stream. I was laughing. Lark got hold of Wren's nose and wouldn't let go and I was laughing. And you were here. On the floor. For an hour.*"

He didn't say anything.

There wasn't anything to say.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC CARRIED HIM TO bed.

Seren went for him. Down the track to the Ashbourne road at a run, barefoot, and came back twenty minutes later with the old smith thundering up behind her

like a landslide. He came in through the blue door and stopped and looked at Arion on the floor.

Then he bent down. And slid his enormous arms under him. And lifted.

Arion felt himself go up off the flags the way a child goes up. As if he weighed nothing. As if he were a sack of feathers. As if two hundred and thirty-four years and a Warden-Architect's ledgers and a whole net's worth of Root had all burned off him somewhere along the way and left only this. A small old man in a big man's arms.

"*Mind the hip*," he said.

"*I'm minding it*," said Brannoc.

"*You're very careful*."

"*I've carried a lot of things*," said Brannoc Holt. "*Anvils. Horses' legs. Your boy, once, when he was eleven, out of the ashes.*" He laid Arion down on the narrow bed under the window. Very gently. As if he were laying down something that might break. "*I've never dropped one yet.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HEALER CAME FROM Ashbourne in the afternoon.

Ilsa Brand. Twenty-two. Plump and freckled and brisk, with a basket of salves and a [Healer] class she'd got at sixteen, in Fenmoor, on the day Lex Unbound a whole town. She'd been levelling ever since. She was Level fifty-eight now, and she ran the Ashbourne infirmary out of the old chapel vestry, and Sister Agathe said she had hands like warm bread.

She put them on his hip. On his elbow. On his head.

She was quiet for a long time.

"*Not broken*," she said at last.

"*I told them*."

"*You did*." She took her hands away. Sat back on her heels by the bed. Looked at him. With her brisk freckled face not brisk at all. "*Master Vey. I can heal bruises. I can heal a skinned elbow.*" She swallowed. "*I can't heal the other thing.*"

"*I know*."

"*It's not an illness*," said Ilsa. "*There's nothing wrong. Nothing broken. Nothing sick. It's just—*" She stopped. "*It's just everything wearing out at once.*"

"*Like a coat*," said Arion.

"*Like a coat*."

"*Worn through at the elbows*," said Arion Vey. "*Thin at the collar. Still a good coat. Just old.*" He smiled at her. "*I know, Ilsa. Thank you. It's very good of you to say it plainly.*"

She looked at him for a long moment.

"*You should stay in bed*," she said. "*A few days. A week. Let the hip mend.*"

"*And then*?"

"*And then the chair*," said Ilsa Brand. "*But not for long. A few hours. Not all day.*" She stood up. Gathered her basket. "*And don't reach for cups.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CAME AT NOON the next day.

Arion heard the dragon. Then the stepping stones. Then the ramp. Then the door, and his son in it, stopping. Barefoot. With his boots in one hand and black coal-dust on his clothes and his face grey.

Seren was sitting by the bed. She didn't get up.

"*He fell*," she said.

"*Brannoc told me*."

"*He was on the floor for an hour*."

Lex looked at his father.

Arion looked back. From the narrow bed under the window. With his white wisp of hair on the pillow and his hip aching under the blankets and his skinned elbow bandaged in clean linen.

"*I'm told I misplaced the floor*," he said.

Lex didn't laugh either.

Arion was beginning to think the line wasn't as good as he'd thought.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS SON SAT DOWN on the end of the bed. Heavily. And looked at him.

"*How was Coldwater*?" said Arion.

"*Don't*."

"*Don't what*?"

"*Don't change the subject*."

"*I'm not changing it*," said Arion mildly. "*I'm choosing it. It's different. I've been in bed for a day and a half with nothing to think about but my hip. I'd very much like to think about something else.*" He looked at his son. "*Please.*"

Lex looked at him for a long moment.

Then he told him.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CROWN AND PICK. The old men. The stone with a hammer cut in it and crossed out. The Old Gallery going down and down. The note.

The crack. The iron. The great black ring, ten feet across, standing on its edge in the heart of the mountain with the silver thread through it.

Hask's pick finding the flaw. The size of a fingernail.

Tink.

The ring breaking. Falling away into the dark in black shards, ringing. The thread going up a half-step.

The voice. *You broke it. Nobody's broken one of my rings.*

The new ring growing back. Whole. Perfect. No flaw.

It's my road, smith. And I'm on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION LAY ON THE pillow and listened.

He listened the way he'd listened to reports for two hundred years. With his eyes half shut. Without moving. Fitting each piece into place as it came, like stones into a wall.

When Lex had finished, he didn't say anything for a while.

"*It broke*," he said at last.

"*It grew back*."

"*It broke first*." Arion opened his eyes. "*Nobody's broken one in nine hundred years. He told you so himself. And you broke it with a hammer the size of a spoon.*"

"*And he grew it back in the time it takes to breathe*."

"*Yes*," said his father. "*Because he could. Because he was there. Because you broke it on his road, with him standing on it.*" His spotted fingers moved on the blanket. "*So the thread can't be cut by force. Not while he's on it. We know that now.*"

"*That's not much*."

"*It's one road closed*," said Arion. "*Lysandra gave us three. Now we have two.*" He looked at his son. "*That's not nothing, Lex. That's a third of the problem. Solved. By walking down a hole and finding out.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*Finding out is never nothing*," said Arion Vey. "*I spent two hundred years finding out things. Most of them were things that didn't work.*" A faint smile. "*It's how you find the ones that do.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT THE floor.

"*Hask got cut*," he said. "*His arm. The iron. It'll scar black.*"

"*Is he all right*?"

"*He's standing in front of the pool with a stick*." Lex's mouth twisted. "*He's always all right. He'd say he was all right with his arm off.*"

"*He's a Coldwater hewer*," said Arion. "*They're like Harrow women. They don't scream.*"

Seren, by the bed, made a small sound.

Arion looked at her.

"*I didn't scream*," said Seren. Very quietly. "*Yesterday. When I came in.*"

"*No*," said Arion. "*You didn't.*" He reached out. Slowly. Across the blanket. And found her hand. "*I'd have liked it if you had. Just a little. So I'd know.*"

She looked at him.

"*So I'd know what*?"

"*How much*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT VERY RED and found something interesting to look at out of the window.

◆ ◆ ◆

WHEN SEREN HAD GONE to make tea—she'd made a great deal of tea in the last day and a half; Arion suspected she made it so she'd have somewhere to put her hands—his father said, "*There's a box under the bed.*"

Lex looked at him.

"*A box*," said Arion. "*Wooden. Under the bed. On this side. Would you?*"

His son bent down. Felt under the bed. Came up with it.

It was a small box. Plain. Oak. Brannoc had made it for him in the winter, without asking what it was for. With a lid that fitted so well it sighed when you opened it.

"*Open it*," said Arion.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WERE LETTERS IN it.

Three of them. Folded. Sealed with plain grey wax. Each one with a single line written on the outside, in a small neat hand. The hand of a man who'd written ledgers for two hundred years.

Lex took them out. One by one. And read the lines.

For Lark. On her first birthday.

For Lark. On her second birthday.

For Lark. On her third birthday.

He didn't say anything.

He sat on the end of the bed with the three letters in his hands, and his face did something Arion had never seen it do. Not even in the gold room. Not even at the bottom of the world.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There'll be more*," said Arion. "*I'm doing one a week. More, if my hand holds.*" He looked at the letters in his son's hands. "*Twenty-one. One for every birthday till she's grown.*"

"*Father—*"

"*It's practical*," said Arion. "*It's simply practical. I'm a Warden-Architect. I plan for contingencies.*" His voice was quite steady. "*She won't remember me. She can't. She's four months old. By the time she's old enough to remember anything, I'll be—*"

He stopped.

"*Gone*," said Lex.

"*Gone*," agreed his father.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D THOUGHT ABOUT IT a great deal. On the floor. Before that. In the long nights, with Seren asleep beside him on top of the blankets and her bare feet cold.

He'd been a grandfather for four months. He'd held Lark three times. She'd grabbed his nose once and wouldn't let go, and he'd laughed so hard his hip had ached for a day.

She'd never know.

She'd grow up with a story. *Your grandfather. He was very old. He was Warden-Architect. He loved your grandmother. He died when you were small.*

She'd never know his voice.

"*So I'm writing it down*," said Arion. "*What I'd tell her. If I could. One for every year.*" He looked at the box. "*What it was like to be one. What it was like to be two. What I thought about when I was ten. What I wish someone had told me at sixteen, at my Kindling, before I knew what I was.*" A pause. "*What her father was like at her age. What her grandmother was like. What the Spire looked like in the rain.*"

"*She'll have that*," said Lex hoarsely. "*She'll have us. Mam and me and Wren. We'll tell her.*"

"*You'll tell her your side*," said his father. "*I want her to have mine.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT THE LETTERS back in the box.

Very carefully. One by one. In order. And closed the lid. And it sighed.

He sat holding it on his knees.

"*Give it to Wren*," said Arion. "*When the time comes. She'll keep it safe. She's very good at keeping things.*"

"*Why not me*?"

"*Because you'll read them*," said his father. Mildly. "*All of them. The first night. You won't be able to help it.*" A faint smile. "*You're my son. I'd have read them.*"

Lex laughed.

It came out of him cracked and wet and sudden. He sat on the end of the bed with the box on his knees and laughed with tears running down his face, and his father lay on the pillow and watched him, and smiled.

There, thought Arion. *There. That one landed.*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I want to talk to it*," said Arion.

Lex wiped his face. Looked at him.

"*Ember*," said his father. "*I want to talk to it. Properly. Not through you. Not with you passing messages like a schoolboy.*" He looked at the hearth. "*It talked to me once. On the rubble. At the Blightmarch. In a coal, in a fire. Hello, old man.*" A pause. "*Can it do that again?*"

Lex looked at the fire for a long moment.

[Yes,] said a voice in the back of his head. Very quiet. *[If he wants. If he really wants.]*

"*It says yes*," said Lex.

"*Then let it*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX KNELT AT THE hearth.

Arion watched him from the bed. Watched his son put his big scarred hand out to the fire, flat, palm down, the way you'd put your hand on the neck of a horse. Watched the flames lean toward it. Rise. Brighten.

And a coal in the middle of them began to glow.

Not red. Not orange. *Gold*. A deep warm gold, brighter than the rest, pulsing very slightly, like a heart. Like something breathing.

And out of it, small and clear and dry, came a voice.

[Hello, old man.]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D HEARD IT ONCE before. On the rubble. In the dark. With his hand going slack in Antho's.

He'd thought he'd dreamed it.

He hadn't.

It was his voice.

Not his voice now. Not this thin dry thread of an old man's voice that came out of him like wind through a cracked door. His voice from *before*. From twenty-two years ago. From the night he'd stood over a cot in a cottage at Harrow with his Root open and his hands on a sleeping boy and pressed a piece of himself into the boy's blood like a maker's mark.

Steady. Low. Precise. With an old-fashioned courtesy he'd forgotten he ever had.

"*Hello*," said Arion. "*Young man.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COAL PULSED.

[I'm not young,] said Ember. *[I'm twenty-two years old and two hundred and thirteen, depending how you count. I'm older than Lex.]*

"*You're younger than me*."

[Everyone's younger than you,] said Ember. *[That's not a fair measure.]*

Arion laughed.

The real laugh. Startled out of him. It hurt his hip. He didn't care.

"*Lex says you write*," he said. "*A book.*"

[The Book of What Was. Volume Two.] A pause. *[Volume One was mostly Aurelian's notes. Volume Two is mine. It's mostly footnotes.]*

"*Footnotes*."

[About things I don't like,] said Ember. *[There are a great many. Lex keeps doing things I don't like. Going down holes. Talking to Crowned. Falling in love with Mistwalkers who break his nose.]*

"*That was a Moth Queen*."

[It was both. On separate occasions.]

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN CAME BACK IN with the tea.

She stopped in the doorway. With a cup in each hand. Looking at Lex, kneeling at the hearth. At the gold coal. At the old man in the bed, laughing.

"*Is that—*"

[Hello, Seren,] said Ember.

She put the cups down. Very slowly. On the table.

"*Hello*," she said.

[Please don't drop the tea,] said Ember. *[He's been asking for it for ten minutes. He's very particular about his tea. He was particular about it two hundred years ago. It's in Volume One.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAT DOWN ON the edge of the bed.

She didn't say anything for a while. She listened. Arion watched her listen. She did it the way she'd done it at the table when Lex told them about Elric. Completely. Without moving. Her face turned toward the gold coal in the fire as if it were a window.

Ember told him things.

Small things. Things he'd forgotten. That he'd liked his eggs runny at thirty and hard at sixty. That he'd once spent a whole winter trying to teach a Spire cat to fetch and the cat had taught him to throw things instead. That he'd been afraid of horses until he was ninety. That the first time he saw the Vale, he'd stood at the top of the Ashbourne road and said, out loud, to nobody, *oh*.

[You said it again,] said Ember. *[Forty years later. The first time you came to the cottage. You stood at the edge of the birch wood and looked at it and said oh.]*

Arion didn't say anything.

[You'd brought Seren home,] said Ember. *[To meet her mother. She was walking ahead. She turned round and saw your face and laughed at you.]*

Seren made a small sound.

[She said, you look like you've never seen a tree before,] said Ember. *[And you said, I've never seen this one.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SPOKE.

The fire ticked. The coal pulsed. Gold. Steady. Like a heart.

"*I don't remember that*," said Arion. Very quietly.

[I know,] said Ember. *[That's why I told you. It's the kind of thing you'd want to remember. So I kept it.]* A pause. *[I keep everything. That's what I'm for.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ember*," said Arion.

[Old man.]

"*Lex says you're frightened*."

The coal went still.

Not dark. Still. The pulse stopping. The gold holding steady. The way a breath holds.

[Lex talks too much,] said Ember.

"*Lex never talks*," said Arion. "*Lex is the least talkative person I've ever met. It took him two years to tell me he loved Wren and he only told me then because she'd broken his nose and he needed me to explain it to the healer.*" He looked at the coal. "*He told me you were frightened. So you must be very frightened indeed.*"

Silence.

Lex, kneeling at the hearth, had his eyes shut.

[I'm a piece of you,] said Ember at last. Very quietly. *[From before the seal. Everything you were. Pressed into him. Like a maker's mark.]* A pause. *[When you go—*]

It stopped.

[When you go,] said Ember again, *[I don't know what happens to me.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION LAY ON THE pillow and looked at the coal.

He'd thought about this. Of course he'd thought about it. He'd been thinking about it since the Blightmarch. Since a gold coal in a fire on the rubble said *hello, old man* in his own voice from twenty years ago.

He hadn't found an answer.

"*You're not mine*," he said.

The coal pulsed. Once.

"*You haven't been mine*," said Arion, "*since the night I made you. I gave you away. To a little boy asleep in a cot.*" He was quiet. "*At Avaloria I offered to take you back. Do you remember? You said no. You said you'd rather stay.*" A faint smile. "*I said it was always a gift.*"

[I remember.]

"*A gift doesn't go back*," said Arion Vey. "*When the giver dies. It doesn't. If I give Lark a nail, and I die, she still has the nail. If I give Seren a stone, she still has the stone.*" He looked at the coal. "*I gave you to Lex. You're his. You've been his for twenty-two years.*"

[But I'm made *of you*,] said Ember. *[The nail isn't made of you. The stone isn't. I'm made of you. I'm your voice. I'm your memories. I'm the way you tap two fingers on a table.]* The coal flickered. *[When you go, the thing I'm made of goes. How can I stay?]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex is made of me too*," said Arion.

The coal went still.

"*He's made of me*," said Arion. "*Half of him. My blood. My eyes. The way he holds a pen. The way he goes still when he's angry.*" He looked at his son. Kneeling. With his eyes shut. "*When I go, he won't stop. He'll still be made of me. He'll go on being made of me. And of his mother. And of Brannoc, and Wren, and everyone who ever taught him anything.*"

[Lex is made of you and Seren,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[And Brannoc and Wren and everyone. He's made of a lot of things.]* A pause. *[I'm only made of you.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION DIDN'T ANSWER.

He lay on the pillow and looked at the gold coal pulsing in the fire. His own voice. His own memories. The way he used to tap two fingers on a table, before his fingers got too stiff to tap.

He didn't have an answer.

For the first time in a very long time, he didn't have an answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Twenty-two years*," said Seren.

They both turned to her. The old man and the coal.

She was sitting on the edge of the bed with her hands in her lap. Looking at the fire.

"*Twenty-two years in Lex*," she said. "*Watching him. Talking to him. Writing footnotes about him.*" She looked at the coal. "*You said it yourself. You keep everything. Everything about him. Every hole he went down. Every Crowned he talked to.*" A small crooked smile. "*Every nose that got broken.*"

The coal was very still.

"*You're not only made of Arion*," said Seren Harrow. "*Not anymore. You haven't been for twenty-two years.*" She leaned forward. Toward the fire. "*You're made of every morning Lex said good morning to a fire. You're made of every time he did something stupid and you didn't like it. You're made of his whole life.*"

The coal didn't move.

"*Arion made you*," said Seren. "*Lex grew you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A LONG silence.

Then the coal pulsed. Once. Brighter than before.

[...that's very kind,] said Ember. Very small. *[I'll put it in a footnote.]*

"*Not a footnote*," said Seren. "*Put it in the main text.*"

[...all right,] said Ember.

And then, after a moment, so faint Arion barely heard it—

[I'm still frightened.]

"*I know*," said Arion. "*So am I.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LET THE FIRE go.

The gold coal dimmed. Slowly. Went red. Went orange. Went back to being a coal among other coals. The voice went with it.

His son knelt at the hearth for a long time with his hand still out, flat, over the flames. As if he'd forgotten to take it back.

Then he stood up. And came and sat on the end of the bed. And didn't say anything.

"*Lex*," said Arion.

"*Father.*"

"*Take me down.*"

Lex looked at him.

"*To Elric*," said Arion. "*Not at Lantern Night. Not when it's convenient. Now. Next week. As soon as Ilsa says I can sit in the chair.*" His voice was very steady. "*The floor was a reminder. I'd like to not need another one.*"

His son didn't answer for a long time.

Then he nodded.

"*Next week*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN STAYED WHEN LEX had gone.

She sat on the edge of the bed in the grey afternoon light with the tea going cold on the table and didn't say anything. She just sat. With her hands in her lap. Looking at him.

He looked back.

"*Seren*," he said.

"*Hush.*"

He hushed.

She looked at him for a long time. At his face on the pillow. At the white wisp of his hair. At the walnut of his skin, every fold. At his eyes.

"*I'm going to kiss you*," said Seren Harrow.

He didn't say anything.

"*I've been working up to it*," she said. "*For three months. More. Since the cold room at the Keep. Since you said good evening and I said you have a nice voice.*" She

swallowed. "*I bring you pies. I read you letters. I sit beside you at the window with my hand next to yours. I've been courting you like a farm lad at a hiring fair.*" Her mouth twisted. "*And I've kissed you on the forehead. Every morning. Like you're my grandfather.*"

"*I'm old enough to be your grandfather's grandfather's—*"

"*Don't say anything clever*," said Seren.

He didn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE BENT DOWN.

And kissed him.

Not on the forehead. Not quick and fierce, like a seal stamped. Slowly. Carefully. On the mouth. The way you'd drink from a cup you were afraid of spilling.

He'd been kissed by her before. Thousands of times. In thirty years. Ember had told him about some of them. He remembered some himself. On the Spire steps, in the rain, the first time, when she'd laughed and pulled his head down because he was too tall. At their wedding. In a doorway at midnight with a baby asleep on her shoulder. In the gold room at Avaloria, through crystal, the last time, before she walked into the dark.

She didn't remember any of them.

This was the first one she remembered.

◆ ◆ ◆

WHEN SHE SAT BACK, her face was wet.

So was his.

"*Well*," said Seren. Wiping her eyes with the heel of her hand. "*That's done, then.*"

"*That's done*," agreed Arion.

"*Was it all right*?"

"*It was—*" He stopped. He was a Warden-Architect. He had written ledgers for two hundred years. He had a word for everything. "*It was all right*," he said.

She laughed.

"*All right*," she said. "*Thirty years and I get all right.*"

"*You asked me not to say anything clever.*"

"*I didn't mean that. I meant—*" She stopped. Looked at him. "*Say something clever now. Go on. You're allowed now.*"

He looked at her. At her square face. At her brown eyes, wet. At the flour on her cheek, because there was always flour on her cheek.

"*I turned back twice*," said Arion Vey. "*On the steps. In the rain. The first time I saw you.*" His voice was a thread. "*I've been trying to work out why. For thirty-two years. Why I turned back. Why I nearly didn't come round the corner at all.*"

"*Why*?"

"*Because I knew*," said Arion. "*Even then. Even before I'd seen your face. I knew if I came round that corner I'd never be able to go back.*" He looked at her. "*I was right. I was always right. It's the worst thing about me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LAY DOWN BESIDE him.

On top of the blankets. In her skirt. With her bare feet cold and her head on the edge of his pillow and her hand on his chest. Over his heart. Where she could feel it.

She didn't say anything.

She didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WROTE THE FIRST line that night.

She was asleep. Beside him. Breathing slow. Her hand still on his chest. He didn't want to move it. He moved anyway. Very carefully. An inch at a time. Until he could reach the table by the bed.

The grey book was there. Where Lex had left it. On the table. With its pencil tucked into the binding.

He'd given it to Lex a year ago. With the Vhessan names in it, the eleven thousand. And Kell, after. And the twenty-three from the rim.

And a blank page at the end. For later.

Write me last, he'd said. On Lantern Night. *After everyone. When it's time.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED IT.

Slowly. In the dark. By the light of the fire, banked low. To the last page. The blank one. Clean. Waiting.

He took the pencil out of the binding.

His hand shook. It always shook now. The letters came out crooked. Wavering. An old man's hand. Nothing like the small neat hand that had written ledgers for two hundred years.

He wrote anyway.

Arion Vey. Of the Spire. And of Harrow.

He stopped.

He looked at it for a long time. The two lines. Crooked. Shaking.

And then he wrote one more.

He turned back twice. And then he didn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT THE PENCIL back in the binding. And closed the book. And put it back on the table.

The rest was for Lex.

He'd promised.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE REACHED FOR HIS spectacles.

He didn't know why. He couldn't read in this light. He didn't want to read. He just reached for them, the way he'd reached for them every night for a hundred years, the way you reach for a familiar thing in the dark to make sure it's there.

They were folded on the table. Beside the grey book. Where he always left them.

He picked them up.

And looked at the lens.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A FACE in it.

Tiny. Pale. No bigger than his thumbnail. White hair. Grey eyes. Cheekbones like the edge of a knife.

Looking at him.

He didn't drop them.

He'd known she might come. Wren had told them. *She said, her husband wears spectacles. He leaves them on the table at night, folded, beside the bed.*

He held the spectacles in his shaking fingers and looked at the tiny pale face in the lens.

"*Good evening*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're not afraid*," said the face.

Its voice was so small he could barely hear it. Like a finger round the rim of a very small glass. Like a fly at a window.

"*I'm too old to be afraid of much*," said Arion. Very quietly. So as not to wake his wife. "*And you can't come through. Not in my spectacles. They're too small.*"

"*No*," agreed Ysenne. "*I'm only looking.*"

"*What at*?"

The tiny face was quiet for a moment.

"*At you*," said the Glass Queen. "*Mae talked about you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HADN'T EXPECTED THAT.

"*Did she*," he said.

"*In her letters. Through the crack. Last year. Before.*" The tiny face tilted. "*She sent them back with her moths. To Orrin. To read to us in our sleep. She knew we couldn't answer. She sent them anyway.*" A pause. "*She said there was a man in that world who was the cleverest she'd ever met. And very old. And very honest. And very sad.*" The pale eyes glittered. "*She said she liked you.*"

"*She tried to eat my wife.*"

"*She liked you anyway*," said Ysenne. "*Mae liked a great many things she tried to eat.*"

He didn't answer that.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What's it like*?" said the Glass Queen.

He looked at her.

"*Dying*," said Ysenne. Simply. Curiously. The way a child asks what the sea is like, having never seen it. "*I've never done it. None of us have. Not properly. Four came apart against the edge. That's not the same.*" The tiny face was very still. "*Mae did it. At the end. She came apart into light. Orrin says she smiled.*" A pause. "*I'd like to know. Before. What it's like.*"

Arion lay in the dark with the spectacles in his shaking fingers and his wife asleep beside him with her hand on his chest.

He thought about it.

He thought about it very carefully. From several angles. The way he'd once thought about the structure of a ward.

"*It's like being very tired*," he said at last. "*At the end of a very good day.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TINY FACE DIDN'T say anything.

For a long time. So long he thought she'd gone.

"*We don't have those*," said Ysenne. Very quietly. "*Days.*"

"*No*," said Arion. "*I don't suppose you do.*"

"*Or tired. Not that kind.*" The tiny pale face looked at him. "*Or good.*"

He didn't answer.

He looked at her. At the tiny face in his spectacle-lens, no bigger than his thumbnail, white and cold and glittering.

And felt sorry for her.

He didn't want to. He'd been feeling sorry for things he didn't want to feel sorry for all his life. Morvane, at the end. Elric, sometimes, in the long nights. A Moth Queen on a hill.

He felt sorry for her anyway.

"*Good night, Ysenne*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FOLDED THE SPECTACLES.

Gently. Carefully. The way you'd close a door on a sleeping child.

And put them face down on the table. Beside the grey book. With the lenses against the wood.

And lay back on the pillow. In the dark. With his wife's hand on his chest. Over his heart. Where she could feel it.

It was beating.

Slowly. Steadily. A little tired.

At the end of a very good day.

CHAPTER 11

Two Old Men

THEY WENT ON THE ninth day after the fall.

Ilsa said the eighth. Arion said the seventh. Seren said not until the hip was properly mended and she didn't care what anybody said. They settled on the ninth, which nobody liked, which Brannoc said was how you could tell it was the right answer.

Vharuun carried them.

He didn't complain. Lex had expected him to. He'd expected a picture of sheep, or a cave with nothing in it, or a dragon with a sore back. But when he led the great bronze head down to the clearing and showed him the old man in the wheeled chair on the oak ramp, wrapped in two blankets, with his white hair standing up in the morning wind, Vharuun only looked.

For a long time. With one molten eye.

And then lowered his wing to the grass. All the way. Flat. So the chair could be wheeled straight up onto it.

[He's never done that,] said Ember. Very quietly.

No.

[Not for you. Not for anyone.]

Lex didn't answer. He pushed his father's chair up the dragon's wing, slowly, carefully, onto the broad bronze back, and Brannoc lashed it there with ropes and leather and a great deal of swearing, and his mother climbed up behind with her bare feet on the scales and sat down beside the chair with her hand on its arm.

On *HOME*.

Vharuun lifted off so gently the chair didn't move at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WATCHED HIS FATHER on the way.

He couldn't help it. He sat in front of the chair, on the dragon's neck, and kept turning round. He told himself he was checking the ropes.

His father wasn't looking at him. His father was looking down.

At the Vale, going away below them. At Ashbourne. At the downs. At the long green of the western shires in the spring sun, every field and hedge and copse sharp and bright and new. He sat in the wheeled chair lashed to a dragon's back with the wind in his white hair and his spotted hands on the arms and looked down at the world going by under him, and his face—

His face was the face Ember had described. At the top of the Ashbourne road. Forty years ago. Seeing the Vale for the first time.

Oh.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POOL LAY IN the green.

Hask was standing on the rim. With Kell's stick in his left hand and his right arm in a sling, bandaged from wrist to elbow, with a line of grey-black showing at the edges where the iron had gone in. He watched the dragon come down. He watched the chair come off the wing.

He didn't say anything when Lex wheeled it across the grass toward the pool. He just stepped aside. Out of the way. And then, after a moment, came round behind the chair and put his good hand on the back of it beside Lex's, and helped push it over the uneven ground.

Ivy Moss was sitting on the rim. Where she always sat. She looked up as they came.

At the chair. At the old man in it.

Her strange light eyes went very wide.

"*Oh*," she said. "*It knows you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[...the old man...]

Lex felt it before he heard it. The pull. The tilt. The whole green slope leaning, very slightly, toward the chair.

[...the old man who poured back...]

His father went still.

[...in the dark room...at the top of the tower...he drank from HER hands and he was young...and then he poured it all back...into me...] The voice was very small. Very soft. Wondering. *[...I felt it...it was warm...]*

"*It remembers you*," said Ivy. Quietly. "*It says you're the one it made room for. After. When you were so old you nearly fell out.*" She tilted her head. Listening. "*It says you're smaller.*"

"*I am smaller*," said Arion Vey.

He said it out loud. To the pool. To the deep. As if it were a person.

[...you got OLDER...]

"*I did*."

[...I gave you room...I gave you ROOM...] A small anxious tilt. *[...wasn't it enough...]*

His father looked down into the pool. Into the dark. At the three small gold lights at the bottom of it, curled together like people round a fire.

"*It was plenty*," he said. Very gently. "*It was more than I'd any right to. A whole spring. A wife who brings me pies.*" He smiled. "*Thank you.*"

The pool was quiet for a long moment.

[...pies...] said Mal. Doubtfully.

"*I'll explain later*," said Arion.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...lamp-lady...]

His mother was kneeling at the rim.

She'd gone down on her knees on the grey stone beside the chair as soon as they reached the pool, the way she always did, and put her bare hands flat on the rim. She'd walked under the world beside this thing for thirteen years. She'd been folded up inside it. She'd told it the one about the miller's cat four hundred and eleven times.

"*Hello, little one*," she said.

[...lamp-lady you came...] The pull went soft. Warm. Like a dog leaning against your legs. *[...you brought the old man...]*

"*I did*."

[...why...]

His mother looked at Lex.

Lex knelt down beside her. At the rim. With his hand on the stone.

He wants to go down, he told it. *To the Knot. To the grey one. To where you used to be.*

The pool went still.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...no...]

Very small. Very quiet. Frightened.

[...not the old man...he's too OLD...he's like glass...]

I know.

[...the hungry place...it's COLD there...it's where I was when I was the other thing...] The voice trembled. *[...I'll break him...]*

You won't, thought Lex. *You carried me. You were so careful.*

[...you're not glass...]

"*Little one*," said his mother.

The pool went quiet.

"*He wants to say sorry*," said Seren Harrow. "*To someone. Before he goes.*" Her hands were flat on the rim. "*You know about sorry. You know how big it is. How long you can carry it. The big one said sorry to you. Here. At this edge. With the Warden's stick.*"

Hask, behind the chair, went very still.

"*And the grey one said sorry to you*," said Seren. "*When he first went in. You told Lex. Sorry I didn't know you were a person.*" She leaned forward over the deep. "*Now the old man wants to say it. To the grey one. And the grey one wants to say it back.*" She was quiet. "*They've been carrying it for three years. Both of them. Like a stone in a shoe.*"

[...like the smith's question...]

"*Like that*," said Seren. "*But heavier.*"

The pool was silent for a long time.

[...I'll be careful...] said Mal at last. Very small. *[...I'll be SO careful...I'll make it soft...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

IT MADE THE ROOM bigger this time.

Lex felt it. When he slid off the rim into the deep and it closed round him, warm and close and dark. It wasn't a small round space for a man sitting with his knees drawn up. It was larger. Wider. Soft at the edges, like a feather bed. Like a cupped hand big enough to hold three people and a wheeled chair.

His mother came down beside him. Barefoot. Into the dark. Into the soft.

And then the chair.

Hask lowered it. From the rim. Slowly. With his good arm and Ivy's directions and Kit holding the ropes. Lex reached up out of the dark and took the wheels and guided it down, and the deep took it, and held it, and his father came down into the room in his wheeled chair with his blankets round him and his hands on *STEADY* and *HOME*.

And the dark closed over all three of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said Arion. Very quietly. In the dark.

"*Are you all right*?"

"*I'm—*" His father's voice stopped. Started again. "*It's warm.*"

"*It's always warm*."

"*I thought it would be cold*." The chair didn't move. Lex couldn't see his father's face. He could only hear him breathe. Slow. Careful. Further than halfway. "*I've spent two hundred years studying this. Did you know? The Hollow. The thing under the lid. What it was. What it wanted.*" A pause. "*I wrote eleven volumes. I thought it was cold. I thought it was hungry.*"

[...I WAS...] said Mal. Very softly. All round them. *[...I was cold...I was hungry...]*

"*And now*?"

[...now I'm carrying you...]

His father didn't say anything else for a long time.

Lex heard him breathe in the dark. And then he heard something else. Very faint. Very soft.

His father was crying.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN.

Slowly. Much more slowly than before. Lex felt it. Mal was being careful. Mal was being so careful. Going down through the dark the way you'd carry a full bowl down a flight of stairs. A step. Wait. A step.

[...all right...] it kept saying. *[...all right...all right...I've got you...]*

His mother was humming.

Not the Lantern Song. The other one. The one with the broken rhyme. *Gold for the eldest, who feared to grow old.* Very softly. In the dark. And when she got to the line that went wrong—*thorns for the gardener who listened, and drank*—she stopped, and waited, and then went on.

"*Why do you stop*?" said his father. In the dark.

"*Because it's where it went wrong*," said Seren. "*So you always remember.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT THE THREADS.

The way he had before. All round. On every side. More of them than stars. Pulling in toward one point. Humming. Singing.

His father felt them too.

Lex knew because the breathing in the dark changed. Caught. Stopped. And then went on, very slow, very deep.

"*Lex*," said Arion.

"*Father*."

"*Can you see them*?"

"*No. I lost that.*"

"*So did I*," said his father. "*When I gave you the Root. When you gave it away.*" A long breath. "*But I can feel them. I'd forgotten. I'd forgotten what they felt like. All of them. All at once.*" His voice was very strange. "*I measured them with a pendulum for eleven years. I drew a map. I thought I understood.*"

"*And*?"

"*I understood nothing*," said Arion Vey. "*Nothing at all.*" A pause. "*It's beautiful, Lex. It's so beautiful. I never knew.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM OPENED.

Light. Grey. Cold. The black glass.

Mal didn't let go. Lex felt it hold. The soft dark room stayed round them, open at the front, like the mouth of a cave, like a hand held cupped with the fingers parted. They sat in it at the edge of the black glass and looked out.

At the lid. A mile of black. Smooth. Cold.

At the Key in the middle of it. Standing up out of the glass like a sword out of a stone. The Lockward beside it.

At the grey thread wound round both of them. Tight. Frayed. A grey cocoon on black iron.

And at the shape above it. A smudge on the air. Bent. Still.

His father didn't move.

He sat in his wheeled chair in the mouth of Mal's room with his blankets round him and his spotted hands on the arms and looked across the black glass at the grey shape on the Key.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SHAPE LIFTED ITS head.

Slowly. The way it had before. Like an old man looking up from a book. Coming back from a long way off.

And looked across the black glass.

At the cave of soft dark at the edge of the lid. At the smith sitting in it. At the barefoot woman.

At the old man in the chair.

Lex felt the threads go still.

All of them. All four million, one hundred and six thousand and some. For one breath. As if the whole net had stopped humming to listen.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Arion*," said Elric Thorne.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER DIDN'T ANSWER.

Not straight away. He sat in his chair. Looking. And Lex, beside him, could see his face now. In the grey light off the glass.

It wasn't still.

That was the thing. It wasn't still like water in a bucket. It wasn't arranged. It wasn't closed like a book. It was open. All of it. Every fold and crease. As open as a door with the wind blowing through it.

"*Elric*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

The grey smudge on the Key didn't move. The old man in the chair didn't move. Lex didn't move. His mother sat on the soft dark floor of Mal's room with her knees drawn up and her arms round them and didn't move either.

The threads hummed.

Far off, very far, down a long silver line running out into the dark—

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You got old*," said Elric.

"*You got thin*," said Arion.

A sound. Dry. Rasping. From the grey smudge. Like wind through a gap in a wall.

It was a laugh.

"*I've been trying to think what to say*," said Elric. "*For three years. Ever since I came down here. Every day. I'd think, if he ever comes. If he ever stands there. What do I say.*" The smudge tilted. "*I had it all worked out. A speech. Very good one. Very moving.*"

"*So did I*," said Arion. "*I wrote it down. Last night. Three pages.*"

"*And?*"

"*I left it on the table*," said Arion Vey.

The dry sound came again. Louder.

"*Of course you did*," said Elric Thorne.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX'S MOTHER STOOD UP.

She did it suddenly. All at once. The way she did things. She stood up in the mouth of Mal's room, barefoot, on the soft dark, and took two steps out onto the black glass, and stopped. In front of the chair. Between her husband and the grey thread on the Key.

And put her hands on her hips.

"*You*," said Seren Harrow.

The smudge looked at her.

"*You opened the wards*," said Seren. "*At Caldris. You let the Pale Warden in. You carried my husband out of a crystal in a sack.*" Her voice was very steady. "*I don't remember him. I don't remember any of it. I don't remember thirty years.*" She tilted her head. "*But I've read the letter. Page thirty. The only page where his hand shakes.*"

The smudge didn't move.

"*So before you say anything to him*," said Seren Vey, "*anything at all, you should know that I've brought a pan.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A LONG silence.

"*You haven't*," said Elric.

"*I have.*" His mother reached into the bundle at her hip and brought it out. Small. Iron. A frying pan. The little one from the blue-door cottage, the one she did eggs in. She held it up. "*My mother threw one at him when he asked if he could marry me. She missed. I won't.*"

The smudge stared at her.

And then the grey thread round the Key shook. All of it. All at once. The whole cocoon of it trembling on the black iron like a struck harp.

Elric was laughing.

Properly. For the first time. Not a rasp. Not a dry sound like wind through a wall. A laugh. Thin and cracked and strange, coming out of a thread that hadn't laughed in three years, but a laugh.

"*Oh*," he said. "*Oh, Arion. She's exactly like you said.*"

His father was smiling.

"*She's worse*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER PUT THE pan away.

She didn't sit down. She stood on the black glass in front of the chair a moment longer. Looking at the grey smudge. With her square face very straight.

"*One more thing*," she said.

The smudge waited.

"*At the end*," said Seren. "*At the lid. On the night you went in. You said something.*" She swallowed. "*Lex told me. You were holding the Lockward. Your hands were old. And you looked at him. And you said, tell him.*"

The smudge went very still.

"*You meant Arion*," said Seren. "*Tell Arion. You didn't say what.*" Her voice cracked. Just a little. "*I've been wondering what. For a year. I think he has too. For three.*" She looked at the grey shape on the Key. "*So I'm going to go and sit down now. And you're going to tell him yourself.*"

She went back into Mal's room. And sat down on the soft dark floor beside the chair. And put her hand on the arm of it. On *HOME*.

And didn't say anything else.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SMUDGE DIDN'T SPEAK for a long time.

The threads hummed. *Clink*, far off. Lex sat beside his father's chair in the mouth of Mal's room and didn't move.

"*Can you come closer*?" said Elric at last. Very quietly. "*I can't. I'd like to see your face.*"

His father looked at Lex.

Lex stood up. And took the handles of the chair. And looked back into the room, at the soft dark.

Can I take him out? he asked it. *Onto the glass. Just a little way.*

[...it's COLD out there...]

I know.

[...I'll come too...] said Mal. *[...I'll make it soft...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUSHED THE CHAIR out onto the black glass.

And the room came with them.

Not all of it. A little. A softness. Spreading out round the wheels of the chair as Lex pushed it, across the black, like a rug unrolling. Warm. Dark. A small moving circle of room, round an old man in a chair, crossing the lid of the world.

He stopped a few paces from the Key.

Close enough to see the grey thread clearly. Every turn of it. Every fray. Close enough to see how thin it was worn in places. Like an old rope.

Close enough to see the shape above it lean down.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There you are*," said Elric.

Arion didn't say anything.

"*You look terrible*," said Elric.

"*Thank you*."

"*You look about four hundred*."

"*I'm two hundred and thirty-four*."

"*You look about four hundred*," said Elric Thorne. "*You look like a walnut someone left in a drawer. You look like a heron in winter.*" The smudge leaned closer. "*I've never seen you look anything but forty-five. In forty years. Not once.*" A pause. "*It suits you. Being old. It suits you better than being forty-five ever did.*"

His father looked up at the grey shape.

"*Does it*?"

"*You look like someone*," said Elric. "*Finally. You always looked like a portrait of someone. Now you look like a person.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Elric*," said his father.

The smudge waited.

"*You were right*," said Arion.

Lex felt the threads go still again.

"*At the lid*," said his father. "*Lex told me. You said, he was always right. That was the worst thing about him.*" His spotted hands were very still on the arms of the chair. "*You were right. It was. It is.*"

The smudge didn't move.

"*I was right at Avaloria*," said Arion Vey. "*You weren't ready. You weren't. I was right to say so.*" He looked up. "*And I said it gently. And I meant it kindly. And it was the cruellest thing I've ever said to anyone in two hundred years.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said Elric.

"Yes."

"No. I opened the wards. I carried you out in a sack. I sold you to a man with black veins for a shard of your own Root." The smudge was shaking. *"That's cruel. That's what cruel is. You saying I wasn't ready isn't—"*

"Forty years," said Arion.

The smudge stopped.

"Forty years," said his father again. *"The first day. In the library. You were twenty-one. You had a stolen book under your arm and a raven on your shoulder. And you looked at me across the table and said, you're younger than I thought."* His voice was very quiet. *"And I said, I'm older than you think. And you looked at me. And you sat down. And you said, tell me."*

The grey thread round the Key was trembling.

"Nobody had ever said that to me," said Arion. *"Not in a hundred and eighty-eight years. Not Aurelian. Not anyone. Tell me. Not tell me what to do. Just tell me."* He swallowed. *"So I did. For forty years. I told you everything. Almost everything."*

"Arion—"

"And I never once said it back," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILENCE.

Total silence. The threads. The glass. Even the iron, far off, down the long silver line. For one moment, nothing at all.

"Not once," said his father. *"In forty years. I never once said to you, tell me. I never asked about the village. About your mother. About why you stole the book. About what you wanted."* His hands were shaking on the arms of the chair. *"I knew you wanted something. I could see it. Every day. Forty years. I could see it in you like a fire behind a door."* A pause. *"And I never asked what it was. Because I was afraid if I asked, you'd tell me. And then I'd have to do something about it."*

The smudge didn't speak.

"So I said you weren't ready," said Arion. *"Instead. Gently. Kindly. Because I was right, and it was easier to be right than to ask."*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX COULDN'T BREATHE.

He stood behind his father's chair with his hands on the handles and couldn't breathe. Behind him, in the mouth of Mal's room, he heard his mother make a small sound. Very small.

"*So*," said his father. Very quietly. To the grey shape on the Key. "*I've come a long way. In a bubble. To the bottom of the world. On a dragon. With a broken hip.*" A ghost of a smile. "*To say it. Finally. Forty-three years late.*"

He looked up.

"*Tell me*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SMUDGE DIDN'T MOVE for a long time.

And then it bent. Lower. Over the Key. Over the Lockward. Over its own grey thread, wound tight. The way a man bends over something when he's trying very hard not to let you see his face.

"*Tell you what*," said Elric. His voice was barely a voice at all.

"*Anything. Everything.*" His father leaned forward in the chair. As far as he could. "*The village. Your mother. The book. What you wanted.*" A pause. "*What you've been doing down here for three years. What it's like. Whether you're frightened.*"

"*I'm a thread, Arion.*"

"*Threads can be frightened*," said his father. "*I've got one in my son's head that's terrified.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC TOLD HIM.

Lex didn't hear all of it. He didn't try to. He stood behind the chair with his hands on the handles and let it go past him. It wasn't his. It was theirs.

But he heard some.

A fishing village on the Saltreach coast. Herring boats. A mother who mended nets and sang to them while she did it, so the fish would come. A boy who wanted to be someone. Anyone. Anyone but a herring-fisher's son with salt-cracked hands and nothing to his name.

A book in a Warden's saddlebag. Stolen. The first book he ever read. About the Spire. About the Root. About a family called Vey who were born holding what everyone else had to earn.

I wanted to be first. Lex heard that. Heard it clearly. *Just once. Just once in my life, I wanted to be the one who went first. Not behind. Not second. Not the one who held the other man's coat.*

And Arion, very quietly: *You were first.*

The smudge stopped.

You were the first, said his father. *The first friend I had in two hundred years. The first person who ever sat down across a table from me and said tell me. Before Seren. Before anyone.*

A long silence.

You were first, Elric. I just never told you.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREY THREAD ROUND the Key was very still.

Lex looked up at it. At the smudge on the air. Bent. Shaking, a little.

He couldn't see a face. There was no face. Just grey. Just smoke.

But he thought, if there had been one, it would have been wet.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Tell him*," said Elric at last.

His voice was very rough.

"*That's what I meant*," he said. "*At the lid. On the night I went in. Tell him.*" The smudge lifted. A little. Toward the chair. "*Tell him I'm sorry. Tell him I'd do it differently. Tell him I knew he was right and I hated him for it and I loved him anyway, for forty years, every day.*" A pause. "*Tell him I was always his friend. Even in the sack. Even at Caldris.*"

"*Even then*?" said Arion. Very quietly.

"*Especially then*," said Elric Thorne. "*Why do you think it hurt so much?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER PUT OUT his hand.

Slowly. Shaking. Across the last pace of black glass between the chair and the Key. Toward the grey thread wound round the black iron.

He couldn't reach it. His arm wasn't long enough. His hip wouldn't let him lean.

He held his hand out anyway. In the air. Open. A foot from the thread.

And the thread moved.

A strand of it. Just one. Unwinding from the cocoon on the Key. Slowly. Carefully. The way you'd let out a fishing line. Grey. Thin. Frayed at the end.

Reaching across the foot of air between them.

And touching his father's fingers.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAW HIS FATHER'S face.

He'd seen it at the window at Harrow, looking west. He'd seen it on the dragon's back that morning, looking down at the world.

He'd never seen it like this.

Neither of them said anything. There was nothing to say. They'd said it.

An old man in a wheeled chair at the bottom of the world with his hand held out. And a thread. Grey. Frayed. Wound round his fingers. Like a hand round a hand.

Forty-three years.

◆ ◆ ◆

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THREAD JERKED.

All of it. The whole grey cocoon on the Key. Tightening. Like a man flinching from a blow. The strand round his father's fingers pulled back. Fast. Winding itself back onto the Key and the Lockward, tight, tighter.

"*Damn*," said Elric.

"*What is it*?"

"*Him*." The smudge had lifted its head. Turned. Away from them. Toward the dark at the edge of the glass. Toward the one bright silver line running out into it. "*He's closer than he was. He's speeding up.*"

And down the silver line, from the dark, came a voice.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Thorne*," it said.

Low. Flat. Heavy. Rough as gravel. Coming up the last thread from very far away, through the black rings, through the rock under the world, through the dark.

"*I can feel you*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown. "*You've let some of your thread go. I felt it slack.*" A pause. "*You're tired.*"

"*I'm busy*," said Elric. Sharply. "*I've got company. Go away.*"

"*I'll be there by the lanterns*," said the voice. As if he hadn't spoken. "*I told the smith. I'll tell you. I'm not going to hurry. I'm not going to be late.*" A pause. "*When I get there, I'll take the bar out. I'll be quick. You won't feel much.*" Another pause. "*I'm not cruel.*"

"*You keep saying that*," said Elric Thorne. "*Nobody who isn't cruel keeps saying it.*"

The silver line was silent for a moment.

"*Huh*," said Caddoc.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Caddoc of the Iron Crown*," said Arion.

The line went still.

His father had turned his chair. Not much. Lex had felt him do it, felt the wheels shift under his hands. He was facing the dark now. The edge of the glass. The silver line.

"*Who's that*?" said the voice.

"*Arion Vey*," said his father. "*I was Warden-Architect. I knew your sister. A little. At the end.*"

Silence.

"*The old man*," said Caddoc at last. "*Mae's letters. The clever one.*"

"*That's me*."

"*She said you were dying*."

"*I am*," said Arion Vey. "*That's why I came down. To say something to my friend before I can't.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SILVER LINE WAS quiet for a long time.

Clink didn't come.

"*My father died slowly*," said Caddoc.

Lex went very still.

"*Before the pool*," said the voice. Low. Flat. As if it were reporting the weather. "*Before any of it. A wasting thing. In his chest. It took a year.*" A pause. "*Oz couldn't bear it. He couldn't go in the room. He'd stand outside the door. Shaking. Then go and find the scholars and shout at them. Find a cure. Find something.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*Mae sat with him sometimes*," said Caddoc. "*Rosie brought him flowers. Ysy looked at him and cried and went away. Hes was too little. She sat on the floor by the bed and played with a toy bear.*" Another pause. "*I sat with him. Every night. At the end. I held his hand. I didn't say anything. He didn't want anything said.*"

His father didn't speak.

"*And then he went*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown. "*In the night. With his hand in mine.*" The voice didn't change at all. "*And Oz found the pool the next week.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You understand it*," said Arion. Very quietly. "*Don't you. An ending.*"

"*I sat with one*."

"*Then why—*"

"*Because I gave my word*," said Caddoc. "*On the shingle. To my brother. Who couldn't go in the room.*" A pause. "*He's frightened, old man. He's been frightened for nine hundred years. Since that door. Somebody has to go in the room for him.*"

The silver line went quiet.

"*I'm sorry you're dying*," said Caddoc. "*It's a hard thing. I hope someone holds your hand.*"

"*Someone will*," said Arion.

"*Good*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown.

And then, far off, down the long silver line—

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a while.

The threads hummed. The grey cocoon on the Key loosened, a little. Breathed.

"*Well*," said Elric at last. "*That was strange.*"

"*Yes*."

"*I've been listening to him for six weeks. He's never said more than twenty words together.*" The smudge turned back toward the chair. "*He likes you.*"

"*He's frightened too*," said Arion. "*In a different way. He's frightened of breaking a promise.*"

"*That's not frightened. That's stubborn.*"

"*Sometimes there isn't much difference*," said his father. "*I should know. I've been both for two hundred years.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Show me*," said Arion.

The smudge tilted.

"*The knots*," said his father. "*Aurelian's notes. The ones you've been reading. Lex told me. Only a hand that's refused a crown.*" His grey eyes were very sharp. "*I'd like to see them. Before I go. I spent eleven years with a pendulum trying to read the net from the outside. I'd like to read it once from the inside.*"

Elric was quiet for a moment.

"*You can't see threads*," he said. "*Neither of you can. You gave it up.*"

"*No*," agreed Arion. "*But you can.*" He leaned forward in the chair. "*Tell me what they say. Read them to me. Like Seren reads me my letters.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SO ELRIC READ THEM.

Lex listened. He stood behind the chair and listened to a thread read a dead man's notes to a dying one, at the bottom of the world, in a voice like wind through a wall.

The Key unwrites. Whatever it is turned against.

Turned in the Knot, the net feels it. All of it. And the net, being a net, and having nobody's hand on it, goes where the hand goes.

Only a hand that has already refused a crown may turn it and remain itself.

If it must be turned again, let the hand wear the tenth crown.

"*There's more*," said Elric. And stopped.

His father went still.

"*Read it*," said Arion.

"*Arion—*"

"*Read it, Elric.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SMUDGE DIDN'T SPEAK for a moment.

Then, very quietly—

"*The Veil was tied last*," read Elric. "*It is the last knot. It holds the whole edge. If it is ever unwritten, the Key must be turned all the way. Past closed. Past open. Into the place where it was made.*" A pause. "*A key turned that far does not come back. And neither does the hand that turns it.*"

Lex went cold.

"*Whoever turns it last*," said Elric Thorne, "*goes with what it unwrites.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SPOKE.

Lex stood behind his father's chair and felt the cold go all the way through him. Down through his chest. Down through his arms. Into his hands on the handles of the chair.

Whoever turns it last goes with what it unwrites.

"*You didn't tell me*," he said. "*Last time. You told me the rest. You didn't tell me that.*"

The smudge turned toward him.

"*No*," said Elric.

"*Why not*?"

"*Because you've got a baby*," said Elric Thorne. "*And a wife who breaks noses. And a dragon who wants sheep.*" A pause. "*And you'd have started working out how it could be you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER WAS LOOKING at the Key.

At the black iron. At the Lockward. At the grey thread wound round them both, frayed and tight.

"*It won't be him*," said Arion. Very quietly.

The smudge looked at him.

"*It won't be Lex*," said his father. "*Will it.*" He wasn't asking. "*You've worked it out. You've had three years. You've had nothing else to do.*" His spotted hands were very still on the arms of the chair. "*You're already in the Knot. You're already wound round the Key. You're already mostly thread.*"

Elric didn't answer.

"*You're already holding it*," said Arion Vey.

"*It's the only thing I'm good for now*," said Elric Thorne. Very gently. "*Arion. Let me be good for something.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER DIDN'T SAY anything for a long time.

He sat in the chair with Mal's soft dark spread out round its wheels and his blankets round his shoulders and looked at his friend. At the grey shape on the Key.

And then he nodded.

Once. Slowly. The way a man nods when he's been shown a thing he already knew and hoped wasn't true.

"*First*," he said.

The smudge went still.

"*You'd go first*," said Arion. "*Wouldn't you. Ahead. Before anyone. Into whatever's on the other side.*" A ghost of a smile. "*Before me. Before Caddoc. Before the Veil.*"

"*I hadn't thought of it like that*."

"*Yes you had*," said his father. "*You've had three years.*"

A dry sound from the smudge. A rasp.

"*All right*," said Elric. "*I had.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[...smith...]

Lex felt the room pull.

Behind them. Mal. The soft dark round the wheels of the chair shivering. Drawing in.

[...smith...the old man...he's getting COLD...]

He looked down.

His father's hands on the arms of the chair were white. Not pale. *White*. The knuckles blue. His breath, Lex realised, was coming short. Shallow. Not further than halfway. Not even halfway.

"*Father—*"

"*I know*," said Arion. "*I know. It's time.*"

He looked up at the grey shape on the Key.

"*I won't come back*," he said. "*This is the only time.*"

"*I know.*"

"*I'd like to say something clever.*"

"*Don't*," said Elric Thorne. "*You'll only get it wrong. You always get the clever ones wrong. You're much better at the plain ones.*"

His father smiled.

"*Goodbye, Elric*," he said.

"*Goodbye, old friend*," said Elric. "*Tell me. When you get there. Whatever it's like on the other side.*" A pause. "*I'd like to know, before I go.*"

"*I'll try*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TURNED THE CHAIR.

Back across the black glass. Toward the mouth of Mal's room, open at the edge of the lid, soft and dark. His mother was standing in it. Waiting. With her arms out.

Behind them, he heard Elric say one more thing.

Very quietly. So quietly Lex wasn't sure, afterward, if he'd heard it at all, or only felt it, the way you feel the threads.

Thank you for coming down.

His father didn't turn round.

But Lex, pushing the chair, saw his spotted hand lift. Just a little. From the arm of the chair. From *STEADY*. And open. And close.

As if he were letting go of a thread.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME UP INTO a grey afternoon.

Mal brought them up so slowly that Lex thought it would never end. A step. Wait. A step. *All right. All right. I've got you.* His mother had her arms round his father in the chair, holding him. Warming him. Her whole body curled round the old man in his blankets like a cat round a hearth.

They came up out of the pool onto the grass.

Hask was there. And Kit. And Ivy, on her crutch, white-faced. They took the chair. They lifted it out onto the green. Hask with his good arm. Kit with both. Lex climbing out after.

His father sat in the chair on the grass in the grey light with his eyes shut.

Breathing.

Short. Shallow. But breathing.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Is he—*" said Ivy.

"*He's all right*," said his mother. Kneeling on the grass by the chair. Rubbing his white hands between hers, hard, the way you'd rub warmth back into a child who'd been out in the snow. "*He's cold. He's tired. He's all right.*"

His father opened his eyes.

He looked at the sky. Grey. At the green slope. At the black house above it with the lantern in the window. At the pool.

"*Thank you*," he said. To the pool.

[...was it...was it enough...] said Mal. Very small.

"*It was everything*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT LEX.

"*That's done*," he said.

Lex knelt down by the chair. And took one of his father's hands from his mother. And held it.

It was so cold.

"*That was the last thing*," said his father. Very quietly. "*The last thing I needed to do. I wrote a list. In the winter. In the grey book. Things to do before.*" He smiled. Faintly. "*That was the last thing on it.*"

"*What else was on it*?"

His father looked at Seren. Kneeling on the other side of the chair, rubbing his other hand. Her face white. Her eyes wet.

"*Be kissed*," said Arion Vey. "*Properly. By someone who remembers it.*"

Seren made a sound.

"*Done*," said his father. "*Last week.*" He closed his eyes again. "*Everything after this is just—extra.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RAVEN CAME WHILE they were still on the grass.

Lex heard it first. A harsh croak out of the grey sky. And then the beat of wings. Not Roole's. Smaller. Black. Glossy. With something glittering clamped in its beak.

It came down on the grey rim of the pool beside Kell's stone and dropped the glittering thing. It rang on the stone. A spoon. A silver one.

Quill.

He looked at Lex with one black bead of an eye.

"*Smith*," he croaked. Then, after a moment, as if remembering something else. "*Brannoc. Brannoc says.*"

"*Brannoc says what*?"

The raven cocked his head.

"*Dust*," he croaked. "*Dust. Over Ashbourne.*" He shook his feathers. "*A cloud. Gold. Coming.*"

CHAPTER 12

Gold Dust

OLD MAG SAID THE baby had the look of a woman who'd been cheated at market.

"*There*," she said. Cackling. "*There. See it? Just there. Round the mouth.*" She leaned forward in her chair by the fire, with her shawl round her shoulders and her cat in her lap and her one bright black eye fixed on Lark. "*That's a face that's been sold a lame horse and knows it.*"

Lark, on Wren's knee, glared at her.

"*She's not cheated*," said Wren. "*She's just like that.*"

"*She's like her father*," said Old Mag. "*He had that face at four. Stood in my doorway with his thumb in his mouth glaring at my cat like it owed him money.*" She stroked the cat. "*Now look at him. Worldforger. Weaves the whole world new.*" She grinned. Toothless. "*Still glares at my cat.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A GOOD morning.

Wren would think that, after. Over and over. That it had been a good morning. That she'd come down the river path from Harrow with Lark in the sling in the spring sunshine, three miles, walking, because Lex was at the pool with his father and Seren and the cottage was too quiet. That she'd stopped at the Forge first, and Brannoc had come out of the long hall with soot to his elbows and seen the baby and stopped dead in the doorway, the way he always did, as if he'd forgotten for a moment that she existed and then remembered all at once.

Give her here, he'd said.

You're covered in soot.

She's a smith's daughter, said Brannoc Holt. *She'd better get used to it*.

And Lark had grabbed his beard. And hung on. And Brannoc had stood in the doorway of the Forge with forty students watching and a baby hanging off his beard by both fists and laughed till he cried.

And then she'd come on to Old Mag's. The cottage by the chapel. With the apple tree in the garden behind it in full white bloom, the way it had been every spring since the little one began to rise, every branch so heavy with blossom it bent down to brush the grass.

A good morning.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Two of them*," said Old Mag.

She said it quietly. Out of nowhere. With her black eye on the fire.

Wren didn't need to ask what she meant.

"*Wim*," said Old Mag. "*And Edda Tobbin. Edda and I were girls together. We used to steal plums off the old Reeve's wall and he'd set his dog on us.*" She stroked the cat. "*She had a bad heart. She'd had it for ten years. She was ninety.*"

"*I'm sorry*."

"*Don't be sorry for her*," said Old Mag. "*She's not sorry. She's not anything. She's sitting in her chair by her fire, gold, looking at her son.*" The black eye glittered. "*Be sorry for him. Rafe. Sitting outside her door every day. Twenty-six years old. Level forty. Big as a barn.*" She shook her head. "*Weeping like a child. Because he couldn't bear to hear her heart stop. And now he has to look at her eyes.*"

Wren held Lark tighter.

"*It came to me*," said Old Mag. "*Did you know?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN LOOKED UP.

"*Two nights after*," said Old Mag. "*At the window. That one.*" She nodded at it. The little window by the fire, with its soaped panes, and the apple tree white beyond it. "*Tapped on the glass. Very polite. Asked to come in.*"

"*What did you say*?"

"*I said, you can't, dear, the window doesn't open, it's been painted shut since the old king died*." Old Mag cackled. "*So it talked through the crack. Lovely voice. Like an old man reading a book in a library. Said it had a gift. Said I'd never have to be afraid.*"

"*And*?"

Old Mag stroked her cat.

"*I said, I'm not afraid now, dear*," she said. "*I'm ninety-six. I've been afraid of a great many things. Wolves. The Gloam. My husband's mother. I haven't got room to*

be afraid of dying. There's too much else in here." She tapped her chest. *"And then I said, you sound very tired. Have you eaten?"*

Wren stared at her.

"It didn't answer that," said Old Mag. *"It went away. Quite quickly."* She looked at the window. *"I think I upset it."*

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK HAD GONE QUIET.

Wren noticed it. The way you notice a sound stopping. The baby on her knee had stopped glaring at Old Mag and was looking at the window instead. At the soaped panes. At the apple tree beyond.

Frowning.

"What is it, love?"

Lark didn't answer. Of course she didn't. She was five months old. She only had vowels.

But she was frowning. Deeply. Fiercely. At the window. And her square fists were opening and closing.

The way they did when she reached for the nail.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN STOOD UP.

She didn't know why. Something. A feeling. The rooftop feeling. The one that ran down the back of her neck like cold water when she'd seen something move in the street below before she knew what it was.

She went to the window. And breathed on the soap, so it went clear for a moment, the way soap does when it's damp.

And looked out.

At the apple tree. White. Heavy with blossom.

At the garden wall. At the chapel beyond it. At the green, and the well, and the long low roofs of the village, and the river, and the fields going up toward the downs in the spring sun.

At the sky.

In the west, low down, over the downs, the sky was gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT SUNSET. IT WAS ten in the morning. Not cloud. Not dust from a road. A haze. A shimmer. Low. Wide. Spreading across the whole of the western sky like a stain spreading through a cloth. Glittering.

Coming.

She could see it move. That was the thing. She could see it come over the brow of the downs and pour down the slope toward the Vale. Slowly. Like smoke from a burning field. Like a great soft gold blanket being drawn across the land.

And everything it passed over, it left behind it shining.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mag*," said Wren. Very quietly. "*Do you have any wet cloths?*"

The old woman looked at her.

"*Wet cloths*," said Wren. "*As many as you can find. Sheets. Towels. Anything. Wet them in the bucket. Stuff them under the door. Round the window.*" She was already moving. Settling Lark in the sling against her chest. Pulling the straps tight. "*Don't open the door. Don't open it for anyone. Not for me. Not for the King of Caldor.*"

"*Wren—*"

"*It's dust*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Gold dust. On the wind.*" She looked at the old woman. "*It's him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT OUT THE back.

Through the kitchen. Through the little door into the garden. Into the spring sunshine and the white blossom and the smell of apples that weren't there yet.

The sky over the downs was gold.

She could hear it now. Not a roar. Not a wind. A *hiss*. Faint. Dry. Like sand poured slowly out of a sack. Coming from everywhere at once. From the whole western sky.

She climbed the apple tree.

She didn't think about it. Her body did it. The way her body had always done things, before she was a mother, before she sat in chairs at three in the morning. Her hands found the branches and her feet found the crook of the trunk and she went up, through the blossom, with the baby strapped to her chest, petals falling round her like snow.

From the top she could see the whole Vale.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GOLD WAS ON the downs.

It had come over the brow and was pouring down the long slope toward the village. Wren could see it settle. On the fields. On the hedges. On a flock of sheep in a high pasture that didn't run, that didn't even look up, that went on grazing in the spring grass until the gold came down on them and they were gold sheep in a gold field, heads down, still.

On a cart on the Thistledown road. A man on the seat. A horse in the shafts. Gold.

On the mill at the top of the village. On its wheel, turning. Turning slower. Slower.

Stopped.

Gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IN THE MIDDLE of it, in the middle of the great soft glittering cloud as it came down the hill toward the village—

A shape.

Thin. Tall. Bent. Made of the same gold as the cloud, so you could only see it because it was thicker there. Darker. A gallows of dust with two dim sparks for eyes. Walking. Not hurrying. Walking down the slope in the middle of his storm with his twig-arms held out to either side.

Like a man scattering seed.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Forgive me*," said a voice.

It came out of the cloud. Out of the hiss. Out of every grain of gold in the air. Soft. Dry. Kind. Like an old man reading a book in a library.

It came across the whole Vale.

"*Forgive me*," said Orrin. "*Good people of Ashbourne. I'm sorry for this. Truly.*" The cloud came on. Down the hill. Over the top fields. "*His Majesty asked me to come. He said they don't understand, Orrin. They keep saying no. They say no to the gift because they can't see it.*" A sigh. Like dust settling. "*He said, show them.*"

The cloud reached the first house.

"*So I'm showing you*," said the voice. "*I'm so sorry. It won't hurt.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN HEARD THE SCREAMING start.

At the top of the village. By the mill. Somebody had been outside. Somebody had looked up and seen the gold coming and not understood, and not run, and not gone in. A woman's scream. High. Short.

Cut off.

Not stopped. *Cut off*. In the middle. Like a candle snuffed.

Wren stood at the top of the apple tree with petals falling round her and her daughter strapped to her chest and her heart going like a hare's.

And then she did the thing she hadn't done in five months.

She stepped off.

◆ ◆ ◆

INTO THE WIND.

There wasn't one. Not a real one. It was a still spring morning and the gold was coming on its own, the way smoke comes, the way fog comes, drifting.

She didn't need there to be one.

She was a Mistwalker. She'd stood on the wind above the Blightmarch on Lantern Night and held a hundred miles of air still. She'd stepped off the top of the Spire into a gale and walked down it like a staircase. She'd carried the First Breath in her lungs for three days.

She called the wind.

And it came.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME UP UNDER her feet like a hand. Like a step. Like the first stair of a staircase made of air. And she stood on it. Above the apple tree. Above the garden. Above the white blossom, with the petals swirling round her in the sudden gust.

And Lark, strapped to her chest, laughed.

Wren looked down.

Her daughter's face was turned up to the sky. Her eyes wide. Her mouth open. Her square fists flung out to either side, opening and closing on the moving air.

Laughing.

Not a giggle. Not the small surprised hiccup of a baby who's been tickled. A *laugh*. Loud and delighted and astonished, the laugh of someone who has just discovered the best thing in the world and can't believe nobody told her about it before.

The wind took the laugh and carried it away over the roofs.

Wren felt something crack open in her chest.

"*You like it*," she said. Out loud. In the air. Over Ashbourne. With the gold coming down the hill. "*Oh, love. You like it.*"

Lark laughed harder.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOOK THE WIND and spun it.

Round. Round her. Round the baby. A tight bright fast whirl of moving air, a yard thick, spinning like a top. Like the eye of a storm. Like the inside of a shell.

Dust can't land on what's moving, she thought. *It can't settle. It can't stick. It needs still air. Still ground. Still skin.*

So I won't be still.

She ran.

◆ ◆ ◆

ACROSS THE ROOFS.

She hadn't done it in a year. More. Not since before her belly got too big to balance. Not since Highcrest, in the rain, with Lex behind her, laughing, the two of them leaping from tile to tile across the city while the Wardens shouted in the street below.

She did it now.

With her daughter on her chest and a whirlwind round her and the gold coming down into the top of the village like snow. From Old Mag's roof to the chapel's. From the chapel to the long low thatch of the Crooked Kettle. Her feet barely touching. The wind lifting her across the gaps.

Every window she passed, she shouted.

"*In! Get in! Shut the doors! Wet cloths! Under the doors! Round the windows! Don't go out! Don't go out!*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GOLD REACHED THE green.

She saw it come. Down the main street from the mill. A soft glittering wave, rolling, no higher than a man, settling on everything it touched. On the cobbles. On the cart standing outside the chandler's. On a dog, asleep in a doorway, that lifted its head as the gold came and was a gold dog lifting its head, forever.

On the well.

On the Ashbourne Stone.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN STOPPED.

On the roof of the Crooked Kettle. In the middle of her whirlwind. With the baby laughing on her chest.

The Stone stood on the green where it had always stood. Grey. Ancient. Taller than a man. The Lattice Stone of Ashbourne, where every child in the Vale had put their hand for their Kindling for nine hundred years. Where she'd watched Lex Unbind the whole village, two summers ago, with his hand on it and gold in his eyes. Where Ivy Moss had been Kindled with an unrecognized class, beside a hole in the ground that breathed.

The gold came down on it.

And it was gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FELT IT.

Not in her head. Not in her ears. Somewhere else. Somewhere deep. The way you feel a bell stop ringing in another room.

The Stone had been humming. She'd never noticed. Nobody ever noticed. A faint deep note, under everything, under the whole village, all her life. The net, running through it. The threads, passing.

It stopped.

Not broken. Not cut. *Stopped*. Kept. A Stone that would never Kindle another child. A knot in the net, gold, still, finished, with the threads running into it and not coming out the other side.

◆ ◆ ◆

Oh no, she thought. *Oh no. Oh no.*

And then, *Lex. Lex. Where are you*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WERE PEOPLE ON the green.

Three of them. Caught. They'd been at the well when the gold came down the street. Two women with buckets and a girl. They'd seen it coming. They'd run. Not fast enough.

One of the women was gold. Mid-stride. Her bucket swinging out from her hand, a gold bucket, a gold arc of water frozen in the air as it slopped over the rim.

The other woman was on her knees. Screaming. Her arm out in front of her. Her hand gold to the wrist. The gold creeping. Up her forearm. Slowly. Like frost up a window.

And the girl.

Twenty. Broad-shouldered. Square-jawed. With a blacksmith's apron on and burn-scars on her forearms.

Tilda.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN CAME DOWN OFF the roof.

On the wind. Fast. Hard. Hitting the cobbles of the green in a burst of moving air that blew the gold dust back off them in a ring. Spinning her whirlwind out. Wider. A yard. Two. Five. Round her and round the girl.

Tilda looked up at her.

Her face was white. Her eyes were huge. She was standing very still in the middle of the green with her left hand held out in front of her.

It was gold.

The fingers. The palm. Gold. Shining. And the gold was moving. Up. Past the wrist. Slowly. A line of it. Creeping up the girl's arm under the skin like a tide coming in over sand.

"*Mistress Wren*," said Tilda Crane. Very quietly. "*I can't feel it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T KNOW WHAT to do.

She stood in the middle of her whirlwind on the green with her baby on her chest and Tilda in front of her, and the gold creeping up the girl's arm, and she didn't know what to do.

She couldn't blow it off. It wasn't on her. It was *in* her. Under the skin. Spreading.

She couldn't fog it. It wasn't glass.

She couldn't do anything.

"*Hold still*," she said. Uselessly. "*Hold still, Tilda, hold still, don't move, Lex is coming, he'll know what to do—*"

"*He's not here*," said Tilda.

"*He's coming*."

"*Mistress Wren*." The girl's voice was shaking now. "*It's past my elbow.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE SKY roared.

Not the hiss. Not the soft dry whisper of the cloud. A *roar*. Deep. Vast. Like a mountainside coming down. Like the forge at Ashbourne when Brannoc opened the great bellows. From the east. From the sky over the river.

Wren looked up.

Bronze. Copper. Old gold. Wings like the sails of a ship. Coming down out of the clear spring sky over the river at a speed that shouldn't have been possible for something that size, with its great jaws open and fire pouring out of them.

Not at the cloud.

Above it. Over it. A sheet of flame laid across the sky over Ashbourne like a blanket, so hot the air went white.

And the gold dust, caught in the rising heat, went *up*.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T BURN. LEX had said it wouldn't. Nothing burned it.

But it *rose*. Lifted. Swirling up off the roofs in a great glittering column, carried on the hot air like sparks up a chimney. Up. Away. Out of the street. Into the sky.

Vharuun came down on the green like a landslide.

And Lex came off his back before he'd landed. Barefoot. With coal-dust on his clothes. With his face white.

He saw Wren.

He saw the baby.

He saw Tilda.

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"*It's in her*," said Wren. "*It's in her arm. It's spreading. I can't—*"

Lex was already on his knees.

On the green. In front of the girl. In the middle of Wren's whirlwind, with the gold dust swirling up past them into the column of Vharuun's heat. He took Tilda's arm in both his hands. Her gold hand. Her wrist. The skin above the wrist, where the gold was creeping.

"*Tilda*," he said.

"*Master Lex*." She was crying. "*I can't feel my hand. I can't feel it. I'll never—I can't work, I can't hold the tongs, I'll never—*"

"*Hold still*."

"*It's past my elbow—*"

"*Hold still*," said Lex Vey. "*It hasn't set yet.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T UNDERSTAND.

Not then. Later, he told her. Lying in the dark at Harrow with his hand on the bell and his voice hoarse.

It's like a quench, he said. *Like tempering. When you heat steel and plunge it, there's a moment. A breath. Before it sets. Before the grain locks. You can still change it then. If you're quick. If you know where to touch.*

The boy at the Veil was set. Bet Dale was set. Wim and Edda were set. They were finished. Full. There was no room.

But Tilda wasn't. Not yet. The gold was still moving in her. Still spreading. It hadn't filled her up.

And where it hadn't filled her up, there was still room.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WATCHED HIM DO it.

She watched him kneel on the green with Tilda's arm in his hands and shut his eyes. She watched his face change. Not the gold-eyed look he got when he used the Root, before he gave it away. Not the fierce bright look he got when he called fire.

Something quieter.

The look he'd had in the autumn, kneeling by her, with his hand on her belly, feeling their daughter turn over inside her for the first time.

Listening.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LISTENED TO THE Hollow.

Not in the gold. There was no room in the gold. He'd found that out at the Veil. He listened to the place *just ahead* of it. In the girl's arm. Above the elbow. Where the gold hadn't reached yet. Where there was still flesh and blood and bone and room.

He asked the Hollow to make more.

Not to take the gold out. It couldn't. Nothing could. He asked it to make room *ahead* of the gold. In front of it. Between the edge of the gold and the rest of her.

A gap. A space. An emptiness, just a hair wide. A room with nothing in it.

And the gold, creeping up the girl's arm like a tide over sand—

Came to the room.

And didn't know what to do.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN SAW IT STOP.

Just above the elbow. The creeping line of gold under Tilda's skin. Moving. Moving.

Stopping.

Hesitating. The way water hesitates at the edge of a step. As if it had come to the edge of something and didn't know how to go on. Because there was nothing to go on *into*. Because the gold could only fill things, and the room in front of it was the one thing in the world that couldn't be filled.

Because it was already empty on purpose.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN IT WENT back.

Slowly. So slowly. Down. From above the elbow. To the elbow. Past it. The gold under the skin draining back down the forearm like a tide going out. The skin behind it pale and pink and freckled. Flesh again.

Down to the wrist.

And stopped.

The hand stayed gold. The fingers. The palm. Set. Finished. Full. Too far gone for room.

But the arm was hers.

◆ ◆ ◆

TILDA STARED AT IT.

At her arm. Pink. Freckled. Scarred with old burns. Ending in a hand of gold.

She moved her elbow. It bent. She moved her shoulder. It turned. She tried to move her fingers.

They didn't.

"*I'm sorry*," said Lex. He was still on his knees. Still holding her arm. His face grey. "*I'm sorry, Tilda. The hand was set. I couldn't—*"

"*I can feel my arm*," said Tilda Crane.

She was crying. She didn't stop. She looked at her arm. At the line where pink met gold, at the wrist, sharp as a seam.

"*I can feel it*," she said again. "*I can feel all of it. Up to the wrist.*" She looked at him. At her master. At the man who'd taught her to call fire into a forge. "*I've got another hand, Master Lex. I can learn to hold the tongs in the other hand.*"

Lex looked at her for a long moment.

Then he put his head down. On her shoulder. On the leather of her blacksmith's apron.

And Wren, standing over them in the middle of her whirlwind with their daughter laughing at the wind, saw his shoulders shake.

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LEX VEY
ATTUNEMENT
  Hollow ..... ANSWERING → SPEAKING
"He found the room in front of the gold.
 The gold did not know what to do there.
 Neither did he, until he did."
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◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THEY WENT TO work.

There was no time for anything else. The gold was still coming down. Vharuun had lifted most of it, but not all. It was still sifting down out of the sky over the village, still drifting down the side streets, still settling on anything left still.

And there were people in it.

Wren went over the roofs. With her whirlwind. With Lark. She found them. In doorways. In yards. On the riverbank. People who'd been outside when the cloud

came and hadn't got in. Some of them gold. Finished. Set. Standing in their gardens with their hoes raised, their washing half pegged, their children's hands in theirs.

Some of them not.

Some of them on their knees, screaming, with the gold creeping up from their hands, their feet, their faces.

Those she shouted for.

"*LEX*!"

And he came. On the wind she made for him. Across the roofs. Badly. Landing in a hedge twice. Getting up. Coming. Kneeling. Listening. Finding the room in front of the gold.

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THEY SAVED ELEVEN.

Wren counted. She couldn't help it. She'd been a tracker. You counted.

Eleven people with gold hands, gold feet, a gold ear, a gold patch across the cheek like a birthmark. Eleven people who'd keep a little of it forever. Who'd live.

Seven they didn't.

Seven people who'd been caught too far from a door, too long in the open, too slow. Who were standing in the streets and yards and doorways of Ashbourne, gold, finished, with their eyes moving.

And the dog in the doorway of the chandler's.

And the sheep in the high pasture.

And the man on the cart on the Thistledown road, and his horse.

And the mill-wheel.

And the Stone.

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BRANNOC'S HANDS WERE GOLD at the tips.

Wren found him at the Forge. In the yard. Standing by the pump with forty students huddled in the long hall behind him and the great doors shut and wet sacking stuffed in every crack.

He was holding his hands out in front of him. Looking at them.

The ends of his fingers were gold. All ten. To the first knuckle. Shining. Like he'd dipped them in a pot of gilt.

"*Brannoc—*"

"*There was a lad*," said Brannoc. Very quietly. "*Little Dunny Tobbin's brother. Six. Outside. By the woodpile. When it came.*" He didn't look up from his hands. "*I put my hands over his head. Over his face.*" He turned them over. Slowly. The gold

tips catching the light. "*It came down on the backs of my hands. And ran down. To the fingers.*"

"*And the boy*?"

"*Inside. With Hedda. Not a speck on him.*" Brannoc looked up. His face under the soot was grey. "*I can't feel the ends of them, lass. I can't feel the hammer.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CAME.

He knelt in the forge-yard in front of the old smith and took his enormous hands in his and shut his eyes and listened.

It took a long time.

Wren stood by the pump with Lark asleep at last on her chest, worn out from laughing, and watched. Watched Lex's face. Watched Brannoc's. Watched the old smith look down at the boy he'd pulled out of the ashes fourteen years ago, kneeling in front of him in the yard, holding his hands.

"*It's set*," said Lex at last. Hoarsely. Not opening his eyes. "*The tips. To the first knuckle. It's set.*" He swallowed. "*I can stop it. It's not going further. But I can't take back what's—*"

"*Lad*."

Lex opened his eyes.

"*I've been a smith fifty years*," said Brannoc Holt. "*I've got calluses on these hands thicker than boot-leather. I couldn't feel the ends of my fingers anyway. Not properly. Not since I was thirty.*" He turned his hands over in Lex's. Looked at the gold. "*Now I've got an excuse.*"

"*Brannoc—*"

"*And they'll never get burned*," said the old smith. "*Will they. Gold doesn't burn. I'll be able to pick up a bar straight out of the fire.*" He looked at Lex. His eyes were wet. His mouth was twitching. "*Every smith in Caldor's going to be jealous.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

OLD MAG WAS SITTING in her chair by the fire with her cat in her lap.

Wren found her last. When the gold had stopped falling. When Vharuun had lifted the last of it and Wren's wind had carried it east, out of the Vale, over the downs, scattering it so thin across a hundred miles of empty moor that it settled on nothing but heather. When the village had gone quiet. When people were coming out of their doors, slowly, with wet cloths over their mouths, to look.

She went in the back way. Through the garden.

The apple tree was half gold.

One side of it. The west side. The side the cloud came from. Every branch, every leaf, every blossom. Gold. Still. Shining. A gold half-tree, with gold petals that would never fall.

And the other side white. Moving. The petals still dropping, one by one, onto the grass, in the little breeze that was coming up now, off the river.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS SOMEONE IN the kitchen.

Wren stopped in the back door.

A shape. By the fire. Thin. Tall. Bent. Grey-gold. With two dim sparks for eyes.

Sitting on the other chair. Opposite Old Mag. With its twig-hands folded on its knees.

And Old Mag was pouring it tea.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Come in, dear*," said Old Mag. Not looking round. "*Shut the door. There's a draught.*"

Wren didn't move.

"*It's all right*," said the old woman. "*He came in under the door after the storm. I told him he might as well sit down.*" She set the teapot down. "*He looked so tired.*"

The dust-man turned its long head toward Wren. The dim sparks of its eyes flickered.

It didn't move toward her. It didn't move at all. It sat in the chair by Old Mag's fire with its twig-hands folded, and there was a cup of tea on the hob beside it, steaming, that it hadn't touched.

That it couldn't touch.

"*Mistress*," whispered Orrin.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Get out*," said Wren.

"*Hush*," said Old Mag. Mildly. "*He's a guest.*"

"*He's turned seven people to gold. He's turned the Stone. Brannoc's hands. Tilda—*"

"*I know what he's done*," said Old Mag. "*I watched from the window. Before the cloths went up.*" She picked up her own cup. Sipped. "*And now he's sitting in my kitchen, and I've asked him why, and he was just about to tell me.*" Her one black eye went to the dust-man. "*Weren't you, dear?*"

The sparks flickered.

"*I'm sorry*," whispered Orrin.

"*You keep saying that*," said Old Mag. "*I want to know why.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST-MAN WAS QUIET for a long time.

"*Because he asked me*," it said at last.

"*The King*."

"*His Majesty. Yes.*" The long head bowed. "*He said they don't understand. He said show them.*"

"*Show them what*?"

"*How easy it is*," whispered Orrin. "*How quick. How it doesn't hurt.*" The sparks dimmed. "*How you never have to be afraid again.*"

Old Mag looked at him over the rim of her cup.

"*Are you afraid*?" she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST-MAN DIDN'T ANSWER.

"*You came in under my door*," said Old Mag. "*Two nights ago. And talked to me through a crack in the window. And offered me forever.*" She put her cup down. "*And I said, you sound very tired, dear. Have you eaten.*" She tilted her head. Like a bird. "*And you went away very fast.*"

"*Mistress—*"

"*You're not kept*," said Old Mag. "*Are you. You're not gold. You're grey. You're dust. You're falling apart.*" Her one black eye was very bright. "*He keeps everyone. Every old woman in every chair. But he didn't keep you.*"

"*I asked him not to*," whispered Orrin.

"*Why*?"

The dust-man was silent for a long time.

"*Because someone had to be awake*," it said. "*To serve him. To bring the cup. To tell him the hour.*" The sparks flickered. "*Nine hundred years. Kneeling. In the dust. Waiting on the King.*" A pause. "*Everyone else is kept. Everyone. Nine thousand of them. Along the road. I walk past them every day.*"

"*And you're tired*," said Old Mag.

"*I'm so tired*," said Orrin.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN STOOD IN THE back door with her baby asleep on her chest and didn't move.

She didn't want to feel sorry for it. She'd watched it walk down a hill scattering gold like seed. She'd watched a woman's scream cut off. She'd watched the Ashbourne Stone go still.

She felt sorry for it anyway.

"*I'm ninety-six*," said Old Mag.

The dust-man looked at her.

"*I've had ninety-six years*," said the old woman. "*I've had a husband and two daughters and a son who went to sea and never came back. I've had this cottage and that tree and eleven cats, one after another, all called Biscuit.*" She stroked the cat in her lap. "*This one's Biscuit too. He doesn't mind.*"

"*Mistress—*"

"*I'm not greedy*," said Old Mag. "*I've had my share. More than my share. When it's done, it's done, and I'll go and see my boy at the bottom of the sea and tell him off for not writing.*" She looked at the dust-man with her one bright eye. "*I don't want to be kept, dear. I want to be finished. There's a difference.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST-MAN LOOKED AT her for a long, long time.

Then it stood up.

Slowly. Its twig-joints creaking. Dust sifting off it onto the hearth. It stood in Old Mag's kitchen, thin and tall and bent, with its head nearly touching the low beams.

And bowed to her.

The old bow. Low. Courteous. One twig-arm folded across its middle.

"*Thank you for the tea*," whispered Orrin.

"*You didn't drink it*."

"*No*," said the dust-man. "*But it was very kind.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TURNED TOWARD WREN.

She didn't step back. She stood in the doorway with her hand on her knife and her baby on her chest and her whirlwind ready in her lungs.

The dim sparks looked at the baby.

For a long time. Very still.

"*She laughed*," said Orrin. "*In the wind. I heard her. Over the whole village.*" A pause. "*I haven't heard a child laugh in nine hundred years.*"

Wren didn't say anything.

"*His Majesty will want to hear it*," whispered Orrin.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Tell your husband*," said the dust-man. "*Tell the smith.*"

"*Tell him what*?"

"*At midsummer*," said Orrin. "*On the shortest night. When the windows are open for the heat.*" The sparks flickered. "*His Majesty's sister will come. In every window. In every glass. For the child.*"

Wren's hand closed on her knife.

"*I'm sorry*," said Orrin. "*I'm only the steward. I carry the messages.*"

And let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT OUT UNDER the door.

All of it. All at once. A thin grey stream across the flags of the kitchen floor and out through the gap under the back door, past Wren's feet, into the garden.

She turned. Watched it go. Up. Into the air. Past the apple tree. Past the gold half and the white half. Up into the clearing spring sky.

West.

Not east this time. Not toward the downs. West. Back toward the edge of the world. Toward the Veil. Toward the crack.

Going home.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Well*," said Old Mag. Behind her. "*That's done.*"

Wren turned round.

The old woman was sitting in her chair by the fire. Stroking her cat. Looking at the untouched cup of tea on the hob.

"*Poor thing*," she said.

"*Mag—*"

"*I know*," said Old Mag. "*I know what it did. I'm not daft.*" She stroked the cat. "*But somebody should feel sorry for it, dear. It's been nine hundred years and nobody has. Not even itself.*" She picked up the untouched cup. Looked at it. "*It'll go cold now. What a waste.*"

And drank it.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WENT HOME AT dusk.

Along the river path. Three miles. Walking. With Lark asleep in the sling and Lex beside her and Vharuun overhead, circling slowly, low, in the red light.

They didn't talk much.

At the place where the path came out of the alders and you could see the Vale behind you, she stopped. And turned. And looked back.

Ashbourne. Small and grey in the dusk. Smoke going up from the chimneys. Lights coming on in the windows, soaped and blurred.

And here and there, catching the last of the sun—shining.

The mill-wheel. Stopped. Gold.

The top field. Gold.

A cart on the Thistledown road. Gold.

The Stone on the green. Gold.

And behind a cottage by the chapel, half an apple tree. Gold on one side. White on the other.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I ran*," said Wren.

Lex looked at her.

"*Over the roofs*," she said. "*With her. On the wind.*" She looked down at the baby asleep on her chest. "*I haven't done that since before. I thought—*" She stopped. "*That woman in the glass. She said I'd stopped. She said I was afraid I'd never run again.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*I ran*," said Wren Ashdown. "*And she laughed. All the way across the village. She laughed at the wind like it was the best thing she'd ever seen.*" Her voice cracked. "*She's a Mistwalker's daughter, Lex. She likes the wind.*"

He put his arm round her.

"*She's a smith's daughter*," he said. "*She grabbed the nail.*"

"*She can be both*," said Wren. Fiercely. Into his shoulder. "*She can be anything. She can be everything. That's the whole point. That's the whole—*"

She stopped.

She'll never grow up. That was what she'd said, in the Hall of Lanterns. To a hundred faint faces behind soaped glass. *She'll be five months old forever.*

"*Midsummer*," she said.

"*I know*."

"*In every window*."

"*I know*," said Lex. "*I heard.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED HOME.

Over the stepping stones. Up through the birches. Past the blue-door cottage, dark and empty. His father and mother were still at the pool, in the little black house on the slope, where Brigid had put the old man to bed under three blankets with a hot brick at his feet. Vharuun would fetch them in the morning.

To their own.

The hornlight was lit in the east window. Soft. Gold. Blurred behind its four panes of scraped horn. Like a lantern in a fog.

Wren stood in front of it for a long time.

Then she went in. And put the baby in her cradle. And climbed up to the loft. And lay down on the bed in her clothes.

And slept.

For the first time in five months, she slept the whole night through.

Lex sat up with the baby.

He said, in the morning, that Lark had woken at three. And looked at the window. And frowned.

And then laughed. In her sleep. Out loud.

As if she were dreaming of the wind.

CHAPTER 13

Room to Breathe

SERAPHINE ILVANE HAD SAID good morning to the Glass Queen every day for a month, and on the thirty-first morning, the Glass Queen said it back.

"*Good morning*," said Seraphine. To her spectacles. Holding them up to the window of the library at the Lantern Keep in the grey dawn light, the way she did every morning before she put them on. Checking the lenses for smears. "*Your Majesty.*"

And from the left lens, very small, very far, like a fly at a window—

"*You read too fast*."

Seraphine nearly dropped them.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T, THOUGH. SHE held them very still, at arm's length, and looked at the tiny pale face in the left lens. No bigger than her smallest fingernail. White hair. Grey eyes. Watching her.

"*I'm sorry*," said Seraphine.

"*You're always sorry*," said Ysenne. "*You say sorry to doors when you bump into them. You said sorry to a book yesterday when you turned two pages at once.*" The tiny face tilted. "*Why do you say good morning to me?*"

"*It seemed rude not to*."

"*Rude*."

"*You're in my spectacles*," said Seraphine. "*Every day. You sit in them while I read. You said so. In the Hall of Lanterns.*" She swallowed. "*If someone's going to sit in my spectacles every day I ought to at least say good morning. It's only manners.*"

The tiny face was quiet for a long moment.

"*Nobody's ever said good morning to me*," said the Glass Queen. "*Not in nine hundred years. Not once.*"

"*Well*," said Seraphine. "*Now someone has.*"

She put the spectacles on.

The world went sharp. The library. The long tables. The shelves. The window, soaped white. And at the very edge of her left eye, if she didn't look straight at it, a faint pale shimmer. Like a reflection in a pane.

"*I'm going to read now*," said Seraphine. "*I'll try to go slower.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T TELL ANTHO.

Not that morning. She'd tell him later. She'd tell him everything later. That was how they did it. But not that morning. That morning she had a map to find.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SPIRE WAS SOAPED.

All four thousand panes. From the ropes. She came up the long stair from the Crown Terrace in the middle of the morning, two days after the gold came down on Ashbourne, and the great white tower rose above her blind and milky against the spring sky like a candle with a cloth over it.

Inside, it was dim. Lamplit. The lamps were all horn now. Lex had shown the Spire's smiths how, and they'd spent a week scraping cow-horn thin as paper and fitting it into every lantern in the building. The light was soft and gold and blurred. Like being inside a cloud at sunset.

She went up.

Six floors in the clanking brass lift. Then a corridor. Then a door. Plain. Oak. With a brass plate on it that still said, in small neat letters, *WARDEN-ARCHITECT*.

Nobody had taken it down.

She didn't think anybody ever would.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOMS WERE COLD.

Nobody had lit a fire in them since the autumn. Since an old man in a wheeled chair had come up here in the night on Lantern Night with a boy and a dragon and drunk twenty years from a Moth Queen's hands, and stood up, and walked across the floor, and poured it all back.

The desk was still there. Under the long window. With the pale ring in the wood where a teacup had stood for two hundred years. A grey book open on it, at a page about the price of bread.

The bookcase.

Tall. Dark. Full. She knew which book to pull. Lex had told her. Arion had told Lex. A thin red one, on the fourth shelf, between a history of the Saltreach fisheries and a treatise on drainage. *Notes on the Stability of Load-Bearing Arches*. Volume Three.

She pulled it.

And the bookcase swung open.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SECRET ROOM WAS small.

She'd expected more. She'd built it up in her head, over a year of hearing about it. A hidden library. A vault. A cabinet of wonders.

It was a cupboard.

A narrow room, no wider than a corridor, with a window at the end. Shelves on both walls. Papers. Rolled. Folded. Stacked. Hundreds of them. Tied with string. Labelled in a small neat hand.

And on the floor, rolled in oilcloth, leaning in the corner like a carpet nobody had got round to laying—

The map.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE UNROLLED IT ON the floor of the Warden-Architect's study.

It took up most of the room. She had to move the chair. She had to weigh the corners with books. It kept trying to roll itself back up, the way old maps do, as if it were tired of being looked at.

It was the world.

Not the world as it looked from above. Not hills and rivers and roads. The world as it looked from *inside*. From underneath. The great threads of the net, running under the land like veins under skin. Drawn in ink. Hundreds of them. Thousands. Fine lines and thick ones, crossing and recrossing, knotting and unknotting, all of them running in, in, in, toward one point. Near the middle. Under the Drowned Country.

The First Knot, it said there. In tiny letters. *(Approx.)*

She sat back on her heels.

"*Oh*," she said. Out loud. To nobody. "*Oh, Arion.*"

He'd done this with a pendulum. With a compass. Eleven years. Walking. Every thread. Following each one with a weight on a string, watching it swing, marking where it pulled. Eleven years of walking the world with his eyes on a pendulum. Drawing it. Line by line.

He'd said he understood nothing.

She looked at the map spread out across the floor of his cold study, every line of it drawn by hand, and thought he'd understood a great deal more than he knew.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LAST THREAD WAS easy to find.

It was the thickest line on the map. Drawn darker than the rest. Running in from the very edge, from the left side of the paper, from a long grey band he'd shaded in pencil and labelled *THE VEIL (EDGE)*. Straight as a ruler. Under the Sundered Lands. Under the grey country west of the Teeth. Rising, where it came under the Greyspine. A little circle drawn there, and a note: *Coldwater. ~200 fath. Audible?*

And then on. Under the mountains. Under the Drowned Country. Down. Into the Knot.

Beside it, all the way along, in tiny letters, he'd written a single word. Over and over.

Last. Last. Last. Last.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND TUCKED INTO THE oilcloth, at the very end of the roll, where it would have been the last thing you saw when you unrolled the map—

A paper.

Small. Old. Folded twice. Not his hand. Not small and neat. Large. Square. Slanting. Pressed so hard into the paper that the pen had nearly gone through.

She knew that hand.

She'd seen it on a vellum in a box carried by a goat. *The one they drank. The one we caged. Forgive us.* She'd seen it in the margins of the Listeners' Codex. She'd seen it carved into the walls of a tomb at the Heart.

Aurelian.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T HIS PAPER. Not the original. She could see that at once. It was a copy. Made by someone who'd been very careful to copy the hand exactly, the slant of it, the weight, even a blot. A young man, perhaps. A long time ago. Copying something he'd found in a vault and didn't understand, so he'd have it. So he could look at it later.

There was a note in the corner. In the small neat hand.

Copied from the third vault, Founders' level. Year 1101. Original crumbling. I do not understand this. Keeping it in case I ever do. — A.V.

A hundred and forty years.

He'd kept it a hundred and forty years. In case.

She unfolded it.

◆ ◆ ◆

I have woven the edge last, it said. *The Veil. It is the final knot and it holds all the rest. It holds them out.*

I do not want to hold them out forever.

They are not all crowned. There are nine thousand with them who did not choose. Cooks and grooms and nurses and children. There are the dead who will come. There will be more dead, every year, in a country where no one is allowed to die properly.

I cannot help them. There is no room. The room is what I have caged, and it is starving, and if I let it near them it will eat them.

So I have left the Veil one last turn.

When there is someone on this side who can make room for what is on the other, unwrite it.

Not before.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE READ IT FOUR times.

She sat on the cold floor of the Warden-Architect's study with the great map spread round her like a sea and read it four times. Her lips moving.

And then she took off her spectacles. And held them up. To the soaped window.

"*Did you read that*?" she said.

The tiny face in the left lens didn't answer for a long time.

"*Yes*," said Ysenne.

"*Did you know*?"

"*No*." The voice was very small. Smaller than usual. "*Nine thousand. He counted them. The little man with the hammer. He counted our household.*" A pause. "*Nobody ever counts the household.*"

"*He wanted to bring them home*," said Seraphine.

"*He wanted to bring them home*," said the Glass Queen. Slowly. As if trying the words to see if they fit. "*When there was room.*"

She didn't say anything else.

When Seraphine looked again, the lens was empty.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE RODE ASHKA TO the Blightmarch the next morning.

Antho flew her. He didn't ask why. He'd taken one look at her face when she came back from the Spire with the paper in her hand and her spectacles in her pocket, and gone to get the dragon.

She read it to him on the way. Shouting into the wind. On Ashka's neck. With his arms round her and the green of the western shires going by underneath.

He didn't say anything.

When she'd finished, he tightened his arms round her. And put his chin on her shoulder. And they flew the rest of the way like that.

◆ ◆ ◆

IVY MOSS WAS SITTING on the rim.

Where she always sat. With her bad foot tucked under her and her good one dangling over the deep. And beside her, on the grey stone, his small thin legs dangling too, his blue coat with the brass buttons buttoned to the chin—

Pim.

He'd come with them. On Ashka. Behind Antho. He hadn't asked. He'd just been in the stable when they went out, sitting on the mounting block, waiting.

He'd got off the dragon at the pool and walked straight to the rim and sat down beside Ivy. And neither of them had said anything. And they'd been sitting there ever since. Two quiet children with their feet over the dark.

"*They're friends*," said Antho. Quietly. Watching them. "*Did you know?*"

"*Since when*?"

"*Since the autumn. Since he came here with the stick for Kell.*" Antho's mouth twisted. "*They write to each other. Letters. Through Quill.*" A pause. "*I've seen one. It was a drawing of a cat. With no words.*"

"*And her reply*?"

"*A drawing of a cat*," said Antho. "*With no words. Slightly bigger.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE KNELT ON THE rim.

She took a Hush-cup out of her satchel. One of the old ones. From the spring. Horseshoe iron, shaped by Lex's thumbs into the space inside a pair of cupped hands. The broken circle of the Hollow cut on the inside of the curve. Seven Hush-runes round the rim.

Empty.

"*Ivy*," she said.

The girl looked up. With her strange light eyes.

"*I need to ask it something*," said Seraphine. "*Mal. And I need you to tell me if it hurts.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD IVY FIRST. Out loud. On the rim. With Antho behind her and Hask leaning on Kell's stick a few paces off and Pim on the other side of Ivy, listening.

The grey country. The Court. The pushing.

Anyone with room in them, it pushes. Slowly. Firmly. The way the edge pushed the four who came apart.

The Ferryman's words. *Unless you carried room with you. Your own. Enough to stand in. Enough to breathe.*

Room can be carried. In a cup.

Ivy listened. Her colourless eyes on Seraphine's face. When it was finished, she was quiet for a long time.

Then she turned. And looked down into the pool. And Seraphine felt her listen.

Not with her ears. Seraphine had never heard anything with her ears, not the way the others did. She heard the gaps. The spaces between letters. The silence round a sound. She'd been the first living person in nine hundred years to hear the Hollow, and she'd heard it the way you hear a held breath.

She heard Ivy listen now. Felt it. A small quiet opening in the air beside her. A girl leaning into a room.

[...room...]

There it was. Soft. Young. All round. Not in the ears.

[...they want to carry ROOM...]

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It wants to know why*," said Ivy.

"*Because the place they're going hasn't got any*," said Seraphine. "*None at all. Not a breath. Not a crack.*" She looked down into the pool. At the three small gold lights far down. "*They'll come apart there. Unless they bring some of yours.*"

[...where...]

"*Beyond the edge*," said Seraphine. "*Where the ones who drank you went.*"

The pool went very still.

[...THEM...]

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE FELT IT FLINCH.

All of it. The whole pool. The whole green slope. Every blade of grass in a hundred miles. Flinching. The way a child flinches when you say the name of the man who used to beat it.

[...the ones who DRANK me...]

"Yes."

[...they drank and drank...I cried and they drank...the tenth one heard...she was the only one who heard...]

"I know."

[...they're the reason I was HUNGRY...]

"I know," said Seraphine. Very gently. *"I know, little one. I'm not asking you to go there. I'm not asking you to give them anything."* She held up the Hush-cup. Empty. *"Just a little. For the smith. For his brother. For a boy who makes rooms like you do."* She glanced at Pim. *"So they can go into the place with no room, and fetch something, and come back."*

[...fetch what...]

"A crown," said Seraphine. *"The tenth one's crown. The one she put down on the stone. The one that never touched you."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POOL WAS SILENT for a long time.

Seraphine knelt on the rim with the cup in her hands and waited. She was good at waiting. She'd waited at the bottom of a library for twenty years for someone to tell her she was clever. She'd waited for Antho to come back from the Hollow. She'd waited for him to ask.

[...hers...] said Mal at last. Very small. *[...the one who heard...]*

"Hers."

[...she poured back...] The voice was very soft. Wondering. *[...a cupful...of what she was born with...she poured it into me when I was nearly empty...it was warm...]*

"Yes."

[...it was the first thing anyone ever GAVE me...]

◆ ◆ ◆

"It says yes," said Ivy Moss.

Seraphine looked at her.

"It says yes," said Ivy again. Her strange eyes were wet. *"It says for her. For the tenth. It says it'll give room for her crown."* She swallowed. *"It says it'll hurt a little. Not much. Like giving blood. It says it can't give much at once. It's still little. It's only just home."*

"*How much*?"

Ivy tilted her head. Listening.

"*A cup*," she said. "*Every few days. That's all. Any more and it starts to feel thin. Like when you're hungry.*" She looked at Seraphine. "*It doesn't want to be hungry again. Not ever.*"

"*No*," said Seraphine. "*Of course not.*" She turned the cup in her hands. "*How long till midsummer?*"

"*Forty days*," said Antho. Behind her.

"*Twelve cups*," said Seraphine. "*Maybe thirteen.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IVY FILLED THE FIRST one.

She took the Hush-cup from Seraphine's hands. Carefully. With both of hers. And leaned out over the rim. Over the deep. Over the dark that went down forever. And dipped it.

Not into water. There was no water. Into the *room*.

And lifted it out.

Seraphine had expected—she didn't know what she'd expected. Dark. Something dark in the cup, like ink. Like the pool itself.

It looked empty.

The iron cup in Ivy's hands, with the broken circle cut inside it and the seven runes round its rim. Empty. Nothing in it at all. You could see the bottom. You could see the glyph.

But it was *heavy*.

Ivy's arms dipped as she brought it back over the rim. As if it were full to the brim with something. As if she were carrying a bowl of soup up a flight of stairs.

"*Oh*," said Ivy. Startled. "*Oh, it's heavy.*"

"*What does it feel like*?"

The girl looked down at the empty cup in her hands.

"*Like holding your breath*," said Ivy Moss. "*Right before you laugh.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[...there...] said Mal. Faintly. *[...that's a bit of me...be careful with it...]*

"*I will*," said Seraphine.

[...it's not a FILL...] said Mal. Anxiously. *[...it's not something to fill UP with...it's room...it's for having room IN...]*

"*I understand*."

[...if they drink it they'll have room inside...where the grey can't press...] A pause. *[...for a while...]*

"*How long a while*?"

The pool was quiet.

[...three days...] said Mal. *[...a cup is three days...for one...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE DID THE SUMS on the rim.

She didn't need paper. She'd been doing sums in her head since she was four. She did them now, sitting on the grey stone with the Hush-cup in her lap, heavy with nothing.

Twelve cups. Thirteen if they were lucky. Three days each, for one person.

Lex needed room. Antho needed room. Pim—

She looked at Pim.

He was looking back at her. With his grey-violet eyes. Very steady.

Pim had room already. A little piece of the seventh. Made himself, out of being hurt, a long time ago. Moths couldn't drink from him. Maybe the grey couldn't press him.

Maybe it could. He was a boy. He was fourteen. Nobody knew.

Hask had drunk the Moth Queen's light once. Hask had worn wings. Maybe the grey would know him a little. Maybe it wouldn't push.

Maybe it would.

"*Thirty-six days*," she said. Quietly. "*Of room. If it's only Lex and Antho, that's eighteen each.*" She swallowed. "*If Pim needs it too, that's twelve. If Hask needs it, nine.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*Nine days*," said Antho. "*To walk into a country with no sun and find a tower in a forest of thorns and get a crown off a chair and walk out again.*"

"*If Hask needs it*."

"*And if he doesn't*?"

"*Twelve*," said Seraphine.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK CAME ACROSS THE grass.

Slowly. With his bandaged arm in its sling and Kell's stick in his good hand. He stood over them at the rim and looked down at the empty iron cup in Seraphine's lap.

"*I won't need it*," he said.

They looked up at him.

"*She was in me*," said Silas Hask. "*Maelis. For a whole season. Her light. In my chest. In my eyes. I had her wings.*" He looked at the cup. "*I know what it feels like to have no room. I had no room for months. She filled it all up.*" His face didn't change. "*I don't think their country will push me much. I think it'll know me.*"

"*You don't know that*."

"*No*," agreed Hask. "*But I'm going. And I'm not drinking the little one's room. Not after what I did to it.*" He turned. And went back to his place by the black stone. And stood there. In front of the pool. With the stick.

Nobody argued.

You didn't argue with Silas Hask. Not when he'd decided.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Twelve days*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*If Pim needs it.*"

Pim, on the rim, said nothing.

He looked at the cup in Seraphine's lap for a long time. And then he looked at Ivy. And Ivy looked back.

And something passed between them. Something Seraphine couldn't hear. Not in words. In the gap. In the space where the words would have been.

Ivy nodded.

Pim turned to Seraphine.

"*Fourteen*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STARED AT HIM.

"*Fourteen*," said Pim again. He hardly ever said anything. Two words in a row was a speech. "*Not twelve.*" He pointed. At the cup. Then at himself. Then at the pool. "*I can make room. In the grey. Like I do. For sleeping.*" He looked at Antho. "*Then you don't drink at night. Only in the day.*"

Antho's face went very still.

"*At night you sleep in my room*," said Pim. "*Not the cup's room.*" He spread his small thin hands. "*Saves two days.*"

"*Pim—*"

"*I can do it*," said Pim. "*Ivy says.*"

They looked at Ivy.

"*It says he can*," said Ivy Moss. "*Mal. It says the boy makes rooms like it does. It says he made one for the moths and they couldn't drink. It says he'll make one in the grey*

and it won't be able to push." She looked at Pim. "*For a while. Not forever. He'll get tired.*" A pause. "*It says, tell him to be careful. It says, he's only little too.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

He knelt on the rim beside Seraphine and looked at the boy. At Pim. Who had been silent for twelve years and talking for three. Who had come up a mountain once in the snow, beaten and thin and starved, and stood outside the door of the Lantern Keep and said nothing at all. And Antho had opened the door and said, *come in*.

"*You're not coming*," said Antho.

Pim looked at him.

"*It's too dangerous*," said Antho. "*It's beyond the edge of the world. It's the Crowned. It's the gold. It's—*"

"*I'm coming*," said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE HAD HEARD HIM say perhaps four hundred words in three years.

She'd never heard him say anything like that. Not in that voice. Not flat and quiet and absolutely certain, like a door closing.

"*You need me*," said Pim. "*Fourteen days.*" He looked at Antho. "*Not twelve.*"

Antho opened his mouth.

And Seraphine put her hand on his arm.

He looked at her.

She didn't say anything. She didn't need to. She just looked at him. And then at Pim. At the small thin boy in the blue coat with the brass buttons, sitting on the rim of the seventh Well with his feet over the dark, who had decided.

Antho looked at her for a long moment.

Then he closed his mouth.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC MADE THE LIDS.

He came up to the pool three days later on a cart, with Hedda driving and a box of iron in the back and his fingertips shining gold. He set up his little travelling forge on the grass below the Coldwater crew's house and lit it and didn't ask anyone for help.

Seraphine watched him work.

He picked up a bar of iron out of the fire with his bare hand.

She made a sound. Everyone did. Hedda swore. Kit, at the black stone, dropped Kell's stick and had to pick it up again.

Brannoc stood at the anvil with a bar of white-hot iron in his gold-tipped fingers and grinned through his beard.

"*Told you*," he said. "*Every smith in Caldor's going to be jealous.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE TWELVE LIDS. Round. Flat. Iron. Each one fitted to a Hush-cup so well it sighed when you set it on. And on the underside of each one, where it would face the room inside, he cut a single rune. In his big careful hand. The first rune he'd ever learned. The one Lex had shown him in the Ashbourne forge six years ago, the night before Thornhollow, the night Brannoc Unbound.

KNIT.

"*So it holds*," he said. When Seraphine asked. "*So nothing gets out that shouldn't. So nothing comes apart.*" He looked at the cups lined up on the grass. "*That's all a lid's for, lass. To keep a thing whole till you need it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD ANTHO THAT night.

Not the paper. He knew the paper. She'd shouted it into the wind on Ashka's neck. The rest. The part she'd been carrying since the Spire.

They were in the little black house on the slope above the pool. The Coldwater crew's house. Brigid had given them the back room. There was a window. Facing the pool. With the *HOME* lantern in it, glass, soaped.

He was sitting on the bed with his back to the wall. She was sitting beside him with her knees drawn up and her spectacles off, folded, face down on the sill.

"*He meant them*," she said.

Antho waited.

"*Aurelian*," she said. "*When he wrote it. When he said, unwrite it when there's someone who can make room for what's on the other side.*" She looked at her hands. "*I thought he meant the Crowned. At first. Bring the Crowned home.*" She shook her head. "*He didn't. He meant the household. The nine thousand. The ones who didn't choose.*"

"*The kept*."

"*The kept. And the dead.*" She swallowed. "*He wrote, there will be more dead, every year, in a country where no one is allowed to die properly. He knew, Antho. Nine hundred years ago. He knew what it would become. A country full of people who can't get to the door.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

He'd stood by a bed in the Lantern Keep and felt for a door that wasn't there anymore.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He left it for Mal*," said Seraphine. "*Do you see? The last turn. He left it for when the Hollow was healed. When it could make room for them. When it could let them come home and not eat them.*" Her voice cracked. "*He left it for a pool in a green field that's still so little it can only give one cup every three days.*"

"*It's not ready*."

"*It's not ready*." She looked at him. "*He said not before. He underlined it. Not before.*"

"*And we're going to do it anyway*."

"*We're going to do it anyway*," said Seraphine Ilvane. "*Because if we don't, Caddoc comes down the thread on Lantern Night and the Gilded King picks up the net. And then there's no Mal. No room. No door. Not for anyone.*" She put her face in her hands. "*We're not ready. We'll have to do it anyway. And the Veil comes down. And nine thousand gold people and four Crowned and every dead thing that's drifted in that country for nine hundred years comes walking across the Sundered Lands toward a pool that can only spare one cup at a time.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT HIS ARM round her.

She leaned into him. She didn't cry. She'd done her crying in libraries, a long time ago, alone. She just leaned. And breathed.

"*There's something else*," she said. Into his shoulder.

"*Tell me*."

"*The crack*," said Seraphine. "*To get through it. To cross. You'll need Harrow blood. Yours. And Lex's.*" She swallowed. "*On the Veil. Enough to open it wider. Wide enough for four people to go through.*"

"*I know*."

"*It'll stay open*," said Seraphine. "*Antho. Once it's wider, it'll stay wider. That's what blood does to the Veil. That's what the first finger's depth did. It doesn't close again.*" She lifted her head. Looked at him. "*To fetch the only thing in the world that can stop them, you have to open the door for them first.*"

He didn't say anything for a long time.

"*I know*," he said at last.

"*You've thought about it*."

"*I've thought about nothing else*," said Antho Vey. "*Since the Ferryman.*" He looked out of the window. At the soaped *HOME* lantern. At the pool below, dark, with three small gold lights at the bottom of it. "*Every way through it ends with us opening a door we don't want opened. Every single one.*" A pause. "*I'm a Threshold Warden, Seraphine. I'm the door. That's the whole of what I am.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE PICKED UP HER book.

She didn't know why. It was in her satchel, on the floor by the bed. She leaned down and got it out and opened it on her knees to the last page with writing on it. And took her pen out of the binding.

Antho watched her.

She wrote. In her small neat hand. By the light of the soaped lantern.

Reason six hundred and four, she wrote. *He was offered a love for a love, on a shingle, to buy back his mother's thirty years. He couldn't give me up. He was ashamed of it.*

She stopped.

He shouldn't be, she wrote.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS READING OVER her shoulder.

He didn't say anything. He sat on the bed beside her with his arm round her and read it twice.

"*How did you know*?" he said at last. Very quietly. "*About the shingle. I never told you.*"

"*You came home*," said Seraphine. "*From the river. And you didn't say anything. You came into the library and sat down beside me and didn't say anything at all, for an hour. You just watched me write.*" She looked at him. "*You've never done that before. Not once. You always talk.*"

"*I was checking*," said Antho.

"*Checking what*?"

"*That I still knew why you were smiling*."

She looked at him for a long moment.

Then she wrote one more line.

Reason six hundred and five. He checks.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FROST CAME AT dawn.

She woke to grey light through the soaped window and Antho asleep beside her with one arm flung over his face. She sat up. Reached for her spectacles. Folded on the sill. Face down. Where she'd left them.

She turned them over.

And there was frost on the left lens.

Not a face. Not the tiny pale shimmer. *Frost*. On the inside of the glass. Fine and white and feathery. Letters. In a narrow slanting hand.

She held them up to the grey light and read them.

◆ ◆ ◆

Scribe.

Good morning.

She stopped. Read it again. Her heart going.

Good morning, the frost said. *I've never said it before. I'm told it's manners.*

Something else, since you're always saying sorry to things.

Rosie's been sending more roses. Through the crack. Every night since the first one. Little ones. Red. With no notes.

Oz has noticed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FROST FADED.

As she watched. The fine white letters going soft at the edges. Melting. Running. A thin wet line down the inside of the lens, like a tear.

And then nothing. Just glass.

Seraphine sat on the edge of the bed in the grey dawn with her spectacles in her hand and Antho asleep beside her and the pool below the window, dark, with three gold lights at the bottom.

Oz has noticed.

She put the spectacles on.

At the very edge of her left eye, if she didn't look straight at it, a faint pale shimmer. Watching.

"*Thank you*," said Seraphine. Out loud. Very quietly.

The shimmer didn't answer.

But it didn't go away, either.

CHAPTER 14

The Rose

THE ROSE HADN'T WILTED.

Seren checked it every morning. She couldn't help it. She came out from behind the curtain at dawn, barefoot, with her hair down and her shawl round her shoulders, and went to the table under the west window where the jug stood. And looked.

It was the same. Dark red. Velvet. Every petal where it had been the day Lex brought it across the stream. Not a curl at the edge. Not a brown spot. Not one fallen leaf.

Seven weeks.

"*It's watching you*," said Arion. From the bed. Behind the curtain. He was always awake before her now. He said he didn't sleep much anymore. He said there wasn't time.

"*It's a rose*."

"*It's watching you*," said her husband. "*I've been lying here for an hour watching it watch you. It turns. Very slightly. When you come out.*" A pause. "*Toward you. Like a sunflower.*"

Seren looked at the rose.

It was facing her.

She was almost sure it had been facing the window when she went to bed.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D STARTED TALKING TO it.

She didn't tell anyone. Not Lex. Not Wren. Arion knew, because Arion knew everything that happened in the room, lying behind his curtain with his grey eyes half shut. But he didn't say anything. He just listened.

She talked to it the way Ivy talked to the pool. The way her mother used to talk to the fire, at the end of summer, in twenty-two cottages. Not expecting an answer. Just talking. Because something was listening, and it seemed rude not to.

Good morning, she'd say. *It's raining.*

Or, *Lark has a tooth coming. She bit Wren.*

Or, *He's tired today. He couldn't finish his letter. It's the ninth one. Her ninth birthday. He says he can't think what to tell a nine-year-old because he can't remember being nine.*

The rose didn't answer.

But it turned. Very slightly. Toward her voice.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's her*," said Arion. That evening. From the chair. She'd got him up for an hour, the way Ilsa said. He was sitting at the west window with a blanket over his knees and his spectacles on and a letter in his lap that he wasn't writing. Looking at the rose in its jug on the table beside him.

"*Rosie*."

"*It must be*." He took his spectacles off. Folded them. Put them face down on the table. He always put them face down now. "*Ysenne looks out of glass. Why shouldn't Rhosyn look out of roses?*"

"*Then why doesn't she say anything*?"

His mouth twitched.

"*Perhaps she's shy*," said Arion Vey. "*Perhaps she's been asleep in a cocoon for nine hundred years and has forgotten how to start a conversation.*" He looked at the rose. "*I'd sympathise. I was a hundred and eighty-eight before anyone taught me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK CAME OVER IN the afternoon.

Wren brought her. Across the stepping stones with the baby on her hip and a basket on her arm and a look on her face Seren had started to see more often lately. Lighter. Looser. Like a girl who'd remembered something she used to be good at.

She ran, Lex had told her. *Over the roofs. With the baby. In the gold.* And then, quieter. *She's been sleeping, Mam. Right through. For the first time since Lantern Night.*

Wren put the baby on the floor on a sheepskin by the hearth and sat down at the table and ate an apple and talked about nothing. About the cottage. About the soap on the windows. About Correspondence, who'd got into the lean-to that morning and eaten half a bridle.

Lark lay on her back on the sheepskin and kicked.

And then she rolled over.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN SAW IT HAPPEN.

One moment the baby was on her back. Kicking. Glaring at the ceiling. The next she'd flung one square fist across her body, and her knee after it, and heaved, with a grunt like a smith lifting an anvil—

And was on her front.

Her face in the sheepskin. Her bottom in the air. Her fists on either side of her head, flat on the fleece.

She lifted her head. Wobbling. Furious. Triumphant.

And looked straight across the room at the table under the west window. At the jug. At the rose.

"*Aah*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She rolled*," said Wren. Very quietly. The apple halfway to her mouth. "*She's never rolled. She's been trying for a week.*"

"*She rolled to look at it*," said Arion.

They both looked at him.

He was sitting in the chair by the window with his blanket and his letter and his spectacles face down on the table. Watching his granddaughter. Watching her watch the rose.

"*She's been trying to see it*," he said. "*All week. Every time Wren brings her over. She lies on her back and she can't see the table. So she tries to turn over. And she can't.*" A faint smile. "*And today she did.*"

Lark, on her front on the sheepskin, reached out one square fist. Toward the table. Toward the jug. Opening. Closing.

"*She can't have it*," said Wren. "*It's got thorns.*"

"*She knows*," said Arion. "*She's not reaching for it. Look.*" He leaned forward. Stiffly. "*She's just reaching.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN KNELT DOWN ON the sheepskin beside her granddaughter.

She'd never done this before. Not with Lark. She'd held her. She'd fed her porridge, once, which had gone everywhere. She'd sung her the Lantern Song a dozen times.

She'd never knelt beside her and told her anything.

"*That's a rose*," said Seren. Very quietly. Into the baby's ear. Into the dark fluff of her hair. "*A long way away, there's a lady who grows them. She grew that one for her sister.*"

Lark reached for it.

"*Her sister's dead*," said Seren. "*A long time ago. Nine hundred years. She was your grandmother's grandmother's grandmother. Twenty times over.*" She swallowed. "*Her name was Hesper. She said no. When everybody else said yes. She said no and she put down her crown and she walked away.*"

The baby frowned at the rose.

"*And she taught her daughter a rule*," said Seren Harrow. "*And her daughter taught hers. All the way down. To me.*" She put her hand on Lark's back. Small. Warm. Rising and falling. "*And now I'm going to teach you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D NEVER SAID IT out loud. Not to anyone. Not even to her boys. Her mother had made her promise. *Never. Not to anyone. Not even to your own babies.*

Her mother was dead. Her mother had paid a whistler to send a crown across a river so that her daughter could stay. So that her daughter could put down roots, and Kindle her sons, and let the net learn their faces.

The rule was meant for women who ran.

Seren had stopped running.

"*We break the ground*," she said. Into her granddaughter's hair. "*We never take the crown. We never let a moth in.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK DIDN'T UNDERSTAND. OF course she didn't. She was five months old. She had vowels and a grip like a vice and she'd just rolled over for the first time in her life.

But she turned her head. Wobbling. Away from the rose. And looked up at Seren.

With her grey-green eyes. Not quite focused. Frowning.

As if she were trying very hard to remember it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You've never told the boys that*," said Arion. Later. When Wren had gone home with the baby. When it was dusk, and the fire was low, and Seren was sitting on the floor by his chair with her back against it and her head against his knee.

"*No.*"

"*Why her*?"

Seren didn't answer for a long time.

"*Because she's a girl*," she said at last. "*It was always mother to daughter. Mam never had a son. Her mam never had a son. Not once. Twenty generations. All girls.*" She looked at the fire. "*And then I had two boys. And I didn't know what to do. I didn't know if it was meant for boys. So I didn't tell them. And then I went into the dark.*"

"*And now there's Lark*."

"*And now there's Lark*," said Seren. "*The first Harrow girl since me.*" She tipped her head back against his knee. "*She ought to have it. Even if she can't remember. Even if she's too little. She ought to have heard it once. From someone who knew what it meant.*"

Her husband's hand came down. Slowly. Onto her hair. And stayed there.

"*She'll remember*," said Arion.

"*She's five months old*."

"*She'll remember*," said Arion Vey. "*Not the words. The voice. The way you said it.*" His thumb moved in her hair. "*That's how rules go down, love. Not in words. In voices.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROSE SPOKE AT midnight.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS AWAKE. SHE was always awake at midnight. She was lying on top of the blankets beside him behind the curtain, with her hand on his chest and her bare feet cold, counting his breaths.

In. Out. In. A little catch. Out.

In.

And from the table under the west window, very faint, very soft, like the rustle of leaves in a garden at night when there's no wind—

"*...Hes?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T MOVE.

She lay very still. On top of the blankets. Her hand on Arion's chest.

He'd stopped breathing.

No. He hadn't. He was holding it. She felt him hold it. Under her palm. The way you hold your breath in the dark when you've heard a step on the stair.

"*...Hes?*" said the voice again.

Thin. Papery. Green. If a voice could be green. Like a stem bending. Like a leaf unfolding very slowly. Like a girl who hasn't spoken to anyone in a very long time, and isn't sure she still knows how.

"*...is someone there?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN SAT UP.

Slowly. Carefully. Arion's hand found her wrist in the dark and held it. Not stopping her. Just there.

She slid off the bed. Pushed back the curtain. Stood up in the dark room in her nightdress with her bare feet on the cold flags.

The fire was down to embers. Red. Faint. Enough to see by.

The rose was on the table. In its jug. Under the window.

It had turned all the way round. Facing the curtain. Facing her.

And it was moving.

Very slightly. The petals. Lifting. Falling. Lifting. Like breath. Like something breathing.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said Seren. Very quietly. "*Not Hes.*"

The rose went still.

"*I'm sorry*," said Seren. "*She's gone. A long time ago.*" She swallowed. "*I'm one of hers. Her girl. Twenty times down.*"

Silence.

Then the petals moved. Lifted. Fell.

"*...you sound like her*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN SAT DOWN AT the table.

She didn't light a candle. She didn't know why. It seemed wrong, somehow. To bring a light. She sat down in the dark, in her chair under the west window, across the table from the rose in its jug, and put her hands flat on the wood.

Behind her, she heard the curtain move. Heard the bed creak. Heard Arion sit up. Slowly. With a small sharp breath when his hip caught.

He didn't come out. He couldn't, without help. He sat on the edge of the bed behind the curtain in the dark and listened.

"*My name's Seren*," said Seren. "*Seren Harrow. Seren Vey, now. I married.*"

"*...Harrow...*"

"That's what she called herself. Hesper. After. When she walked away from the shingle. To harrow. To break the ground before sowing."

"...Harrow..." The petals trembled. *"...she named herself..."*

"She named herself."

"...she never named anything..." The voice was barely there. *"...when we were girls...she wouldn't name her pony...she said it had a name already and nobody had asked it..."*

Seren laughed.

She didn't mean to. It came out of her in the dark. Small. Startled.

"That sounds like her," she said. *"That sounds like every Harrow woman who ever lived."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"...is it you?" said the rose. *"...who gave Mae the lamp..."*

Seren went still.

"...Orrin told us," whispered Rhosyn. *"...a Harrow woman knelt down in front of her and gave her a lamp...and she took it...and she was warm..."* The petals were shaking. *"...was it you..."*

"Yes," said Seren.

The rose didn't speak for a long time.

"...thank you," it said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN HADN'T EXPECTED THAT.

She sat in the dark with her hands flat on the table and felt something come up in her throat she didn't have a name for.

"She tried to take my sons," she said. *"She tried to take my granddaughter. She dimmed a whole city. She drank a thousand lights. She—"*

"...I know."

"Then why—"

"...because she was cold," said Rhosyn. *"...her whole life...right in the middle...she never knew why..."* The voice was very small. *"...she brushed Hes's hair when the nurses were too busy...she sat up all night with her when she had the fever...she told her a story about a girl who married a bear..."* The petals trembled. *"...she was the kindest of us...before...and the coldest...and nobody ever gave her anything...not once...not in nine hundred years..."*

Seren didn't say anything.

"...and you did," said the rose. *"...at the end..."* A long silence. *"...so thank you..."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Did she have a good life*?" said Rhosyn.

Seren looked at the rose.

"*Hes*," said the voice. "*...after...in your world...did she...was she...*"

It couldn't finish.

Seren sat in the dark and thought about it.

She didn't know. Not really. Nobody did. Hesper had been dead for nearly nine hundred years, and the Harrow women didn't write things down, and the songs only told you the rule and where it went wrong.

But she knew some things. The things you know about the women in your line, the way you know the shape of your own hands.

"*She walked east*," said Seren. "*From the shingle. With the crown in a bundle on her back and a pair of boots she stole from the kitchen.*"

"*...the kitchen boots...*" A sound. Almost a laugh. "*...Cook's...Cook was so angry...*"

"*She found a valley*," said Seren. "*In the hills. Where nobody had ever heard of the Crowned. She built a cottage with her own hands. She never Kindled. She never let the net look at her.*" She swallowed. "*She had a daughter. I don't know who the father was. Harrow women never say.*"

"*...a daughter...*"

"*And she taught her the rule. We break the ground. We never take the crown. We never let a moth in.*" Seren looked at the rose. "*And when the daughter was grown, Hesper packed up and moved on. To another valley. Another cottage. And another, after that. All her life.*"

"*...she never stayed...*"

"*She never stayed*," said Seren. "*Thirty houses, Mam said. Maybe more. She never stayed anywhere long enough for anyone to learn her face.*" She was quiet. "*And she never left a light on. Not in any window. Not once. Not in her whole life.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROSE DIDN'T SPEAK.

Seren waited. In the dark. With her hands on the table.

"*...was she happy*?" said Rhosyn at last. So faint it was barely a rustle.

Seren closed her eyes.

Was she happy.

She thought about her mother. At the end of summer. Packing. Twenty-two cottages. Thirty years. Singing the old verses with the fire low and the cottage half bare round them. Throwing a frying pan at a Warden-Architect's head. Walking

three hundred miles west with her feet bleeding through her boots to pay a whistler to a river for a crown.

Whistling all the way across.

"*Mam used to say*," said Seren slowly, "*that Harrow women are happy the way hedges are.*"

The rose waited.

"*Not showy*," said Seren. "*Not like roses. Not like gardens. Nobody plants a hedge to look at it.*" She opened her eyes. "*But they're there. Every season. In the snow and the rain and the wind. Full of birds. Full of nests. Keeping the field.*" She looked at the rose. "*Mam said that's the best kind of happy there is. The kind that keeps something.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROSE WAS CRYING.

Seren knew. She didn't know how. Roses can't cry. They haven't got eyes. But the petals were moving, very slightly, trembling, and there was a sound in the dark like rain on leaves.

"*...a hedge...*" whispered Rhosyn. "*...she was always going to be a hedge...even when we were girls...she was the one who sat at the edge of things...*"

"*She kept the field*," said Seren. "*For nine hundred years. Her and all her girls. Keeping something.*"

"*...keeping what...*"

Seren didn't answer.

She didn't need to. She knew. And so did the rose.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's on the chair*," said Seren.

The rose went still.

"*The crown*," said Seren. "*Her crown. My mother sent it to you. Through the Ferryman. Thirty-two years ago.*" She leaned forward. Over the table. Toward the jug. "*It's in a tower. In the middle of your thorns. On a chair you grew for her.*"

Silence.

"*...how do you know*?" whispered Rhosyn.

"*I dreamed it*."

"*...Harrow women dream...*" The petals shivered. "*...Hes did...she used to dream of the pool...before...she'd wake up crying...*"

"*Is it there*?"

The rose was silent for a long time.

"*...yes*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

"...I grew it for her," said the rose. *"...the tower...in the first year...when we still had something left..."* A small sound. *"...the others laughed...Ysy laughed hardest...she said Hes would never come...she said Hes had made her choice..."* The petals trembled. *"...I said, in case..."*

"In case she changed her mind."

"...in case she wanted somewhere to sleep..." A long silence. *"...she never came..."*

"But the crown did."

"...the crown did..." whispered Rhosyn. *"...the grey man brought it...carried it up the stair...I felt it come into the Court...like a cold hand...like a no..."* The voice was very small. *"...I woke...I hadn't woken in four hundred years...I went to the tower and I stood at the bottom of the stair and I couldn't go up..."*

"Because it said no."

"...because it said no...to me..." The rose was shaking. *"...because I drank..."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"...so I grew thorns," said Rhosyn. *"...round and round...a mile...so nobody would find the stair...so Oz would never..."* A pause. *"...he thinks it's lost...he thinks Hes took it into your world and it's gone...rotted...buried...he's never once thought of my tower...he never thinks of anything of mine..."*

"And it kept you asleep."

The rose went very still.

"...how do you know that?"

"The Ferryman told us. My mother hoped it would. A crown that says no. In the middle of the Court. Every night. While you slept." Seren looked at the rose. *"She thought, maybe they'll sleep more soundly. Maybe they won't wake."*

"...we did," said Rhosyn. Very softly. *"...sleep more soundly...thirty years...it was like...like a hand on a forehead..."* A long silence. *"...like Mae's hand...when Hes had the fever..."*

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND SEREN, BEHIND THE curtain, the bed creaked.

"Why the roses?" said Arion.

The rose went still.

His voice came out of the dark behind the curtain. Thin. Dry. A thread. But very clear. The voice of a man who'd questioned ten thousand witnesses in two hundred years and knew which question to ask.

"*Every night*," said Arion. "*Since the first one. Little ones. Red. Through the crack. With no notes.*" A pause. "*If you're hiding your sister's crown from your brother, why send roses through a crack he can see? Why let him notice?*"

The rose didn't answer for a long time.

"*...who's that*?" it whispered.

"*My husband*," said Seren.

"*...the old man...*" The petals lifted. "*...Mae's letters...the clever one...*"

"*Everyone keeps saying that*," said Arion. "*Answer the question.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*...because I can't stop*," said Rhosyn.

Seren went still.

"*...nine hundred years*," whispered the rose. "*...nothing but thorns...everything I touched...everything I grew...black...hooked...dry...hungry...*" The petals were trembling. "*...and then I sat outside her tower...and I thought about her...on the edge of the cabbage bed...with her knees up...talking to a puddle...*" A small sound. "*...and a rose came...*"

Nobody spoke.

"*...the first one in nine hundred years*," said Rhosyn. "*...and I sent it to you...to whoever was there...to ask...*" The voice cracked. "*...and then there was another one...the next night...I didn't mean it...I was just sitting...thinking about her...*" A long silence. "*...and another...and another...every night...I can't make them stop...every time I think of her a rose comes...*"

"*So you send them through*," said Arion.

"*...where else would I send them*?" said the Thorn-Crowned. "*...there's no one here to give them to...*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN HEARD HER HUSBAND breathe out.

Slowly. Behind the curtain. In the dark. The way he breathed out when a ledger finally balanced.

"*Thank you*," he said. Very quietly. "*That's all I needed to know.*"

"*...is it*?"

"*You can't fake summer*," said Arion Vey. "*And you can't stop it, either. Not once it starts.*" A pause. "*That's the trouble with it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*If one of hers came*," said Seren. "*Through the crack. Into your country.*"

The rose went very still.

"*To fetch it*," said Seren. "*The crown. Off the chair. If one of Hesper's came. Could they reach it?*"

"*...it wouldn't say no to them*," said Rhosyn slowly. "*...not to her blood...her blood never drank...*" A pause. "*...but they'd never find it...the thorns...a mile of them...they'd tear anyone to pieces...*"

"*Unless you opened them*."

Silence.

"*Would you*?" said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROSE DIDN'T ANSWER for a long, long time.

Seren sat in the dark. Behind her, she could hear Arion's breathing. In. Out. Catch. Out. Outside, the stream. An owl in the birch wood. Across the water, faint, a baby crying, once, and stopping.

"*...why do you want it*?" said Rhosyn at last.

Seren told her.

The Key. The last thread. Caddoc climbing it, with his iron, toward the Knot. Lantern Night. The net with nobody's hand on it. *Only a hand that has refused a crown*.

The Veil.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*...you'd bring it down*," whispered Rhosyn. When she'd finished. "*...the edge...the Veil...*"

"*If we have to*."

"*...and we'd come through...*" The petals trembled. "*...all of us...Oz and Ysy and Cad...and me...and the household...nine thousand...gold...*" A long silence. "*...and the dead...*"

"*Yes*."

"*...you'd let us in*."

"*We'd stop him picking up the net*," said Seren. "*Your brother. We'd stop him keeping the whole world. Every thread. Every child.*" Her voice was shaking. She didn't let it stop her. "*And then we'd have to deal with the rest. On the ground. Like anyone.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*...he wants your girl's baby*," said Rhosyn.

Seren didn't answer.

"...he told us," whispered the rose. *"...in the hall...when we woke...he said, I'll put a crown on her and keep her and she'll be ours forever..."* The petals were very still. *"...he said, an heir, Rosie...wouldn't that be nice..."*

"He can't have her."

"...I know..." A pause. *"...I've seen forever..."* Another pause. Longer. *"...there are nine thousand of them on the white road...my gardeners are there...Tam and old Wyn and little Bess who used to carry the watering cans...I walk past them...every time I leave the hall...I don't look...I haven't looked in nine hundred years..."*

Seren closed her eyes.

"...they hum," whispered Rhosyn. *"...did you know...the kept...they hum...one note...all of them...I've never let myself listen long enough to hear what it's saying..."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"...I'll open them," said the rose.

Seren opened her eyes.

"...my thorns," said Rhosyn. *"...if one of hers comes...I'll open them...I'll take them to the door..."* The petals lifted. *"...I can't open the door...I can't go up the stair...it says no to me..."* A pause. *"...but I can take them to the bottom of it..."*

"Why?"

"...because I listened," said the Thorn-Crowned. *"...and then I drank anyway..."* The voice was barely there. *"...and the song breaks there...doesn't it...your song...the one Hes's girls sing...I heard it in my sleep sometimes...in the dreams..."* A long silence. *"...gold for the eldest...glass for the vain...iron for the one who never laughed..."*

"Thorns for the gardener who listened," said Seren. Very quietly. *"And drank."*

"...it doesn't rhyme," whispered Rhosyn.

"No."

"...it's meant not to..."

"Yes."

"...I'd like it to rhyme," said the rose. *"...just once...before the end..."*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE ROOM went warm.

Not warm like a fire. Warm like a forge. Like an oven door opened. A heat, rolling across the dark room from the table under the west window, from the jug, from the rose. Heavy. Golden. Seren felt it on her face. On her hands on the table.

The rose went rigid.

Every petal. Every leaf. Stiff. Still.

"...no," whispered Rhosyn. *"...oh, no..."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Rosie*," said a voice.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME OUT OF the rose.

Not the papery green whisper. Something else. Something *deep*. Like a bell. Like a mountain. Like a great warm voice that filled a room the way a fire fills a grate. Rough. Rough as a road. As if it had been asleep for nine hundred years and had only lately remembered how to use itself.

"*Who are you talking to*, *Rosie*?" said the Gilded King.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T MOVE.

She sat in the dark at the table with her hands flat on the wood and the heat rolling over her and looked at the rose.

It wasn't moving anymore. Not breathing. Not trembling. Rigid. Every petal stiff.

And it was glowing.

Very faintly. Very deep. A gold light, coming up from somewhere inside it. From the stem. From the heart of the flower. Like a coal at the bottom of a grate.

"*Oz*," whispered Rhosyn. Very small. Very far. "*...Oz, I wasn't...I was only...*"

"*I know what you were only*," said Oszric. Warmly. Gently. "*You were only sending flowers. Every night. Through my crack. To nobody.*" A pause. "*I've been counting them, Rosie. Forty-nine. Did you think I wouldn't count?*"

"*...Oz—*"

"*Hush*," said the Gilded King. "*Let me talk to her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HEAT TURNED.

Seren felt it. Felt it turn toward her. Like a great warm face leaning close across the table. Like the open mouth of a forge.

"*Hesper's girl*," said Oszric of the Crowned.

She didn't answer.

"*You have her voice*," said the voice in the rose. Wondering. Warm. "*Rosie's right. Exactly her voice. I'd know it anywhere. She used to argue with me at dinner when she was twelve and I'd laugh so hard I fell off my chair.*" A pause. "*She stopped arguing with me later. She stopped speaking to me at all.*"

"*She said no to you*," said Seren.

"*She said no to all of us.*" The voice was gentle. "*She was very good at it. It was the only thing she was ever good at. She couldn't ride. She couldn't dance. She couldn't sit still through a whole dinner.*" A pause. "*But she could say no.*"

"*So can I.*"

"*I know*," said the Gilded King. "*You said it to my steward. At your door. And to my sister, in the hall, through a hundred lanterns.*" The heat leaned closer. "*And you said it to my other sister. On a hill. With a lamp in your hands.*"

Seren's hands were flat on the table. White at the knuckles.

"*You gave Mae a lamp*," said Oszric. "*And she was warm. Orrin says. For the first time.*" The voice didn't change. Didn't harden. Didn't break. "*And then she came apart.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'm sorry*," said Seren.

She didn't know she was going to say it. It came out of her in the dark. Small. True.

The heat went still.

"*Are you*?" said Oszric.

"*Yes*," said Seren. "*I'm sorry she's dead. I'm sorry she was cold. I'm sorry nobody gave her anything for nine hundred years.*" She swallowed. "*I'm not sorry I gave her the lamp. I'd do it again.*"

The Gilded King was silent for a long time.

"*So would she*," he said at last. Very quietly. "*Hesper. Exactly that. She'd say exactly that.*" A pause. "*I find I don't know what to do with it. I never did.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Your husband*," said Oszric.

Behind the curtain, the bed creaked.

"*The old man*," said the voice in the rose. "*The clever one. Mae's letters.*" The heat turned. Toward the curtain. "*He's very old. I can feel it from here. Like a candle at the end of its wick.*"

"*He's mine*," said Seren.

"*Of course he is. I'm not trying to take him.*" The voice was very gentle. "*I'm trying to give him to you. Forever. Exactly as he is.*" A pause. "*I could. You know I could. One pinch. On the tongue. And he'd be at your window every evening for a thousand years.*"

"*No.*"

"*You said that to Orrin*," said the Gilded King. "*At your door. I heard.*" The heat leaned closer. "*You'll change your mind. They all do. At the bedside. At the very end.*

When his breath catches and doesn't start again. When you're holding his hand and you feel it go slack." A pause. *"They all say yes, then. Every one. I've never known anyone who didn't."*

"Then you've never known a Harrow," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HEAT DIDN'T MOVE.

And then it laughed.

Deep. Warm. Delighted. Like a bell. Like a great warm fire roaring up a chimney. The whole room shook with it. The jug rattled on the table.

"Oh," said Oszric of the Crowned. *"Oh, I'm going to like you. I'm going to like you so much."* The laughter faded. *"I'll come and see you. Soon. When the crack's wider. When my sister's been through your windows and brought me back what I need."* A pause. *"I'll come to your door. I'll knock, the way my steward does. And you'll say no. And I'll come in anyway."* The heat was very close now. *"And we'll have tea."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"And Rosie," said the Gilded King.

The rose had gone very still. Not rigid now. *Still*. The way a thing goes still when it's waiting to be hit.

"Come home," said Oszric. Very gently. *"Come back to the hall. Stop sending flowers."* A pause. *"You were always sending flowers to people who didn't want them, Rosie. Even when we were little. Even to Father, at the end, when he couldn't smell anymore."*

"...he could smell them," whispered Rhosyn. *"...he told me...he said they were the last thing..."*

"Come home," said the Gilded King.

And the rose turned gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WATCHED IT HAPPEN.

From the heart. From the centre of the flower, where the glow had been. Outward. Petal by petal. The dark wine-red going to gold. Not fading. Not dying. *Turning*. Like a drop of ink in water. Like frost across a pane. The petals. The leaves. The black hooked stem. Down. Into the jug. Into the water in the jug, which went gold too, and stopped, a gold disc of water with a gold stem standing in it.

It took the time of a breath.

And then there was a gold rose in a jug on the table under the west window. Every petal perfect. Every leaf. Every thorn. Shining dully in the red light of the embers.

Still.

Kept.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HEAT WAS GONE.

The room was cold. Colder than it had been. The fire was down to a few red coals.

Seren sat at the table and looked at the gold rose.

"*Rosie*," she said. Very quietly.

Nothing.

"*Rosie. Are you there?*"

Nothing.

The rose didn't turn. It would never turn again.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT BEHIND THE curtain.

Arion was sitting on the edge of the bed. Where he'd been sitting for an hour, in the dark, with his hands on his knees. He looked up at her as she came.

She sat down beside him.

Neither of them said anything for a long time.

"*He kept it*," she said at last. "*The rose. Her rose. The one she grew for Hes.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*He keeps everything. Even his sister's flowers.*"

"*Especially his sister's flowers*," said Arion. Very quietly. "*Those most of all.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Will she be all right*?" said Seren.

He didn't answer straight away.

"*He loves her*," he said at last.

Seren put her face in her hands.

"*I know*," she said. Through her fingers. "*That's what frightens me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LAY DOWN BESIDE him.

On top of the blankets. With her hand on his chest. Over his heart. Counting.

In. Out. In. A little catch.

Out.

She didn't sleep.

At dawn she got up and went to the table and picked up the jug.

It was heavy. The water was gold. The rose was gold. Everything was gold, all the way through, and cold. Cold as a coin. Cold as a ring left on a windowsill in winter.

She held it for a long time.

Then she took it to the shelf above the hearth. The one Arion had reached for, the morning he fell. And set it there. At the back. Behind the chipped blue cup with the crack down the handle.

Where she'd see it every time she made tea.

Where she'd remember.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Seren*," said Arion. From the bed. Behind the curtain.

"*I know*."

"*He said—*"

"*I know what he said*." She stood at the hearth with her back to the room and her hands on the shelf. "*He said when the crack's wider. He said when his sister's brought him back what he needs.*" Her voice was very steady. "*He said he'd come to my door.*"

"*For tea*."

"*For tea*," said Seren Harrow.

She turned round.

"*Then I'd better make sure there's some*," she said.

And went to put the kettle on.

CHAPTER 15

Midsummer Eve

LARK GOT HER FIRST tooth on the ninth day before midsummer, and the first thing she did with it was bite her father.

"*Ow*," said Lex.

"*Ah*," said Lark. With great satisfaction.

She'd been chewing on his knuckle. She'd been chewing on everything for a fortnight. Her fists, his fingers, Wren's braid, the edge of the table, the horseshoe nail on its red ribbon, which Wren had had to lower within reach because Lark had screamed at it for an hour. Chewing and drooling and glaring and chewing.

And then, on the ninth morning before midsummer, sitting on his knee at the table by the east window while he ate his porridge, she'd clamped down on his knuckle with her gums, the way she did, and there'd been something in them.

Small. Sharp. Hard as a nail-point.

He held up his hand. There was a mark on the knuckle. A tiny white dent.

"*She bit me*," he said.

"*She's a smith's daughter*," said Wren. From the other side of the table. Not looking up from her own porridge. "*She's testing your temper.*"

"*She drew blood*."

"*She did not draw blood*."

"*Nearly*."

Wren looked up. At the knuckle. At the baby, sitting on Lex's knee with drool on her chin and a look on her face like a cat that has just knocked something off a shelf and is waiting to see what you'll do about it.

Wren started to laugh.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A GOOD morning.

He'd think that, later. Over and over. The way Wren thought it about the morning at Old Mag's. That it had been a good morning. Grey. Warm. The windows soaped white and the hornlight glowing soft and gold on the sill behind its four panes of horn. The stream loud outside. Wren laughing. Lark with drool on her chin and a new tooth and a look of triumph.

Nine days.

At midsummer, Orrin had said. In Old Mag's kitchen. *On the shortest night. When the windows are open for the heat.*

His Majesty's sister will come. In every window. In every glass. For the child.

◆ ◆ ◆

[You're doing it again,] said Ember.

Doing what?

[Counting.] A pause. *[Nine days. You've been counting since she said it. Nine. Ten. Eleven. Twelve. You count when you're frightened. You counted iron rings down a gallery.]*

I'm not frightened.

[You're a smith with a tooth-mark in his knuckle and a Glass Queen coming through his windows in nine days,] said Ember. *[If you're not frightened I'm going to start worrying about you.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HORNLIGHT WENT OUT on the eighth day.

Lex came down the ladder from the loft at dawn and it was dark. The east window. The sill. The little iron lantern with its four panes of scraped horn, that he'd lit with his own fire on the first night home from the Blightmarch and that had never once gone out.

Dark.

He stood at the bottom of the ladder and stared at it.

Then he heard the chewing.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GOAT WAS UNDER the table.

Correspondence. Malachi's goat. White and brown and bony, with yellow eyes and a beard and a bell on her collar that didn't ring, because she'd eaten the clapper years ago. She'd come to Harrow with Seren in the winter, from the Keep, and lived in the lean-to, and roamed. She roamed everywhere. She'd eaten half a bridle. She'd eaten a tapestry in the Hall of Lanterns. She'd eaten, Antho swore, a whole volume of Founders' records at the Keep, including the index.

She was under the table now. Chewing. Thoughtfully. With her yellow eyes half shut.

There was a little bit of something hanging out of the corner of her mouth. Pale. Fibrous. Charred at the end.

Lex looked at the hornlight.

The little iron door on the side was open. The goat must have nosed it. And inside, where the wick should have been, the wick he'd twisted himself from cotton and soaked in tallow and lit with his own fire on the first night home—

Nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She ate the wick*," said Wren.

She'd come down the ladder behind him. She was standing on the bottom rung in his shirt with Lark on her hip, looking at the goat.

"*She ate the wick*," said Lex. "*While it was lit.*"

"*How do you eat a wick while it's lit*?"

"*Ask her*."

Correspondence opened one yellow eye. Looked at them. Chewed.

"*She's Malachi's goat*," said Wren. Slowly. "*He had her for fifty years. In the Wastes. In a cave. With a fire in it.*" She looked at the goat. "*She's probably eaten worse.*"

"*She's eaten my lantern*."

"*She's eaten the wick of your lantern*," said Wren. "*You've got more wick. You've got more fire.*" She shifted Lark on her hip. "*You're a Worldforger. Light it again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LIT IT AGAIN.

New wick. Twisted cotton. Soaked in tallow. He set it in the hornlight and held his hand over it and let the fire come up, small, gold, the way it came every morning when he said good morning to the hearth.

It caught.

It burned. Soft. Gold. Blurred behind the horn.

It was the same. It looked the same. A little gold glow in the east window, like a lantern in a fog.

He knew it wasn't.

He stood in front of it for a long time.

[It's just a wick,] said Ember. Quietly.

It's the first one. The one from the Blightmarch. The one I lit the first night home.

[It's a wick, Lex. It's twisted cotton and tallow. It's been burning for six months. It was going to go out eventually.] A pause. *[Things do.]*

He looked at the little gold glow.

[That's not an omen,] said Ember. *[It's a goat.]*

I know.

[You don't believe in omens.]

I know.

[Then stop looking at it like it's one,] said Ember. Gently.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T TELL HIS father.

He went across the stream that afternoon and sat by the bed and his father asked him about the preparations, and he told him. The boards for the windows. The black heat. The cellar.

He didn't tell him about the wick.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER WAS IN bed most days now.

Ilsa said that was all right. Ilsa said it was the hip, still, and the tiredness, and he'd be up again soon. For an hour. In the chair. At the window.

Lex didn't believe her.

He didn't think she believed herself.

His father lay on the narrow bed under the west window with the curtain drawn back and his white wisp of hair on the pillow and the grey book on the blanket by his hand. He was thinner. Lex could see it in his wrists. In his neck. In the way the bones of his face stood out, sharp, under the walnut skin, like the frame of a house when the plaster's coming off.

His eyes were the same.

Grey. Sharp. Turning from the window as Lex came in.

"*Good afternoon*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There's a box under the bed*," said his father. When Lex had told him about the boards and the black heat and the cellar.

Lex looked at him.

"*You know the one*," said Arion. "*Would you?*"

Lex reached under the bed.

The box came out heavier than before. He could feel it. He set it on his knees and opened the lid, and it sighed.

Letters. Folded. Sealed with grey wax. A line on each.

He counted them. He couldn't help it.

Eleven.

For Lark. On her eleventh birthday.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Eleven*," said Lex.

"*My hand's been bad*," said his father. "*I'd hoped for more by now.*" He looked at the box. "*Ten more. I'll try. One a week, if I can manage.*"

"*It's nine days to midsummer*."

"*I know*."

"*And then we're going. Across. Through the crack.*"

"*I know*," said his father. "*I've been counting too.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CLOSED THE BOX.

It sighed. He sat with it on his knees and didn't say anything.

"*You want to ask me something*," said his father.

"*No*."

"*You've wanted to ask me something since the pool*," said Arion. "*Since the Knot. Since Elric read the last of the notes.*" His grey eyes were very steady. "*You've been sitting on it for weeks. Like a hen on an egg.*"

Lex looked at the box.

"*Whoever turns it last*," he said.

"*Goes with what it unwrites*."

"*Elric's going to do it*."

"*Yes*."

"*You knew. You worked it out. Before he said.*"

"*I worked it out*," said his father. "*He's my friend. I know how he thinks. I know how he's always thought.*" A faint smile. "*First, Lex. He wants to go first. He's wanted to go first his whole life.*"

"*And you're going to let him*."

His father didn't answer for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's not mine to let*," said Arion at last.

Lex looked up.

"*It's not mine*," said his father again. "*It's not yours. It's his.*" He turned his head on the pillow. Toward the window. Toward the birch wood. "*He gave back his threads*

at the lid and went into the Knot and wrapped himself round the Key, and he's been holding it for three years in the dark, alone, counting threads, so nobody could ever turn it again." His voice was very quiet. *"If he wants to be the one who turns it the last time, that's his. He's paid for it. He's paid for it ten times over."*

"He'll die."

"He's already dead, Lex." His father looked back at him. *"Mostly. He's been dead for three years. He's a thread. He said so himself."* A pause. *"He's asking to finish. That's all. To be good for something."*

Lex didn't say anything.

"I've been asking the same thing," said Arion Vey. *"All year."*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT THE BOX back under the bed.

Carefully. On this side. Where his father could reach it if he leaned. He sat back up and looked at the old man on the pillow and found he couldn't say anything at all.

"When we come back," he said at last. Hoarsely. *"From across. With the crown."*

"Yes."

"Be here."

His father looked at him.

"I'll try," said Arion.

"Don't try. Be here."

"Lex." His father's voice was very gentle. *"I don't make promises I can't keep. Your mother taught me that. Page nine."* He reached out. Slowly. Across the blanket. And found his son's hand. *"I'll try. I'll try very hard. I'll be at the window every evening, looking west, the way I was when your mother went to the river."* His grip was so weak. *"That's all I can promise. Trying."*

Lex held his hand.

"It's not enough," he said.

"No," agreed his father. *"It never is."*

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WANTED TO GO.

She told him that night. In the loft. In the dark. With the baby asleep in her cradle under the window and the new wick burning in the hornlight downstairs, and the stream loud outside.

"I'm coming," she said.

He'd known she would say it. He'd been waiting for it for weeks.

"*Across*," she said. "*Through the crack. With you.*"

"*Wren—*"

"*Don't*." She was sitting up in the bed with her knees drawn up and her arms round them. He couldn't see her face. Just the shape of her against the soaped grey of the little window. "*Don't you dare say I can't. I can. I'm a Mistwalker. I'm Level sixty-nine. I tracked Mothwing across the Sundered Lands while I was carrying her. I stood on the wind for a hundred miles on Lantern Night while she was trying to get out.*"

"*I know*."

"*I can run again*," said Wren. Very quietly. "*I ran. At Ashbourne. Over the roofs. With the gold coming down.*" Her voice cracked. "*I can do it, Lex. I can do it again. I can go.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

He lay on his back in the dark beside her and looked at the slope of the roof and thought about it.

He thought about her on the roofs at Ashbourne, with the baby on her chest, laughing. With a whirlwind round her. With the gold coming down. Running.

He thought about her on the wind above the Blightmarch on Lantern Night, holding a hundred miles of air still.

He thought about her in a chair in the dark at three in the morning, not moving, with a Glass Queen in the window telling her she'd stopped.

"*I know you can*," he said.

She went still.

"*I know you can go*," said Lex. "*I know you can run. I know you'd be better at it than me. You'd find the tower in a day. You'd find the stair. You'd carry the crown back over your head on the wind.*" He swallowed. "*I know.*"

"*Then—*"

"*Who fogs the glass*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T ANSWER.

"*She's coming*," said Lex. "*At midsummer. In every window. In every glass. For Lark.*" He turned his head on the pillow. Toward her. Toward the shape of her in the dark. "*And then we cross. And then she'll still be there. In every window. For as long as we're gone.*"

"*Lex—*"

"*Fog stops her*," he said. "*Your fog. Your breath. You stopped her the first night. You stopped her in the Hall of Lanterns. You're the only one who can stop her without burning the house down.*" His voice was shaking. "*Black heat works, but Kestrel can't hold it all night. I can't. Asha's two hundred and eleven.*"

Wren was very still.

"*If you come*," said Lex, "*who's here when she comes through the window for our daughter?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

He heard her breathing. In the dark. Fast. Then slower. Then very slow.

"*I hate you*," said Wren.

"*I know*."

"*I hate you so much*."

"*I know*."

"*You're right*," said Wren Ashdown. "*And I hate you.*" She put her face down on her knees. "*I hate that you're right. I hate that it's me. I hate that I'm the one who has to stay and breathe on windows while you go and walk into a country with no sun and find a crown in a forest of thorns.*"

"*It's not breathing on windows*."

"*It is*," said Wren. Into her knees. "*It's exactly breathing on windows. It's the most boring heroic thing anyone's ever done.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT UP.

He put his arms round her. She let him. She was shaking. Not crying. Shaking. The way she shook on rooftops before a jump, sometimes, when she'd measured the gap and knew she could make it and was afraid anyway.

"*I'd swap*," he said. Into her hair.

She lifted her head.

"*If I could*," said Lex. "*If I could fog glass. I'd stay. I'd stay and breathe on windows every night and you could go.*" He swallowed. "*I'd rather. I'd rather stay here with her than go anywhere.*"

She looked at him in the dark.

"*Liar*," she said.

"*I'm not*."

"*You want to see it*," said Wren. "*The country. The tower. The thorns. You want to see what's on the other side. You've always wanted to see what's on the other side of*

everything." Her hands were in his shirt. Holding on. *"You went down a hole under a coal mine because you wanted to see what was at the bottom."*

"That's not—"

"I know you," said Wren. *"I married you. I know exactly what you want."* She pulled his head down. Her forehead against his. *"And I want you to want it. I want you to go and see. I want you to come back and tell me."* Her voice cracked. *"I just wanted to be the one who went, for once."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T SLEEP MUCH.

They lay in the dark with the baby breathing in her cradle and the stream running and talked. About nothing. About everything. About the first time they met, on the moors above Thistledown, when she'd laughed at him for not knowing what a hare-track looked like. About the rooftops at Highcrest. About the black iron ring on her finger, which he'd forged from a nail of the old Ashbourne forge.

About Lark.

About what she'd be like. At one. At two. At eleven. At twenty-one.

"She'll be a smith," said Lex.

"She'll be a Mistwalker."

"She bit me. With her first tooth."

"She laughed at the wind," said Wren. *"In the gold. Over the whole village."*

"She can be both," said Lex.

Wren was quiet for a moment.

"She can be anything," she said. *"That's the point. That's the whole point."* She turned her face into his shoulder. *"That's what you made, Lex. When you took the Ceilings off. That's what you made for her. She can be anything she likes."*

He didn't answer.

He was thinking about a gold crown on a small dark head. About a child who'd be five months old forever.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME ON THE seventh day.

All of them. To Harrow. Up the track through the birch wood. Lex hadn't asked them. He hadn't had to.

Antho first. On Ashka. With Seraphine behind him, her spectacles on, and Pim behind her, small and silent in his blue coat with the brass buttons. And a basket strapped to Ashka's side, wrapped in straw, that Pim wouldn't let anyone else touch.

Twelve Hush-cups. Each with an iron lid that sighed when you set it on. Each one heavy with nothing.

Hask next. On foot, from the Blightmarch, two days' walk, because he said he didn't trust dragons and he wanted to see the country. With his pick on his back and his right arm out of its sling now, bandaged, with a line of grey-black showing at the wrist where the iron had gone in. He came up the track at dusk and stood at the edge of the clearing and looked at the two cottages and the stream and the hornlight in the window, and didn't say anything.

"*Kit's got the stick*," he said, when Lex asked. "*And Ivy's got the pool. And Brigid's got Kit.*" He shrugged. "*Nobody kneels.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL CAME ON THE sixth day. On a borrowed horse. With her red hair cropped short and her amber eyes bright and a sack over her shoulder that clanked.

"*Mirrors*," she said. When Wren asked. "*Every mirror between here and Highcrest I could find. I broke them all.*" She dumped the sack on the grass. It clanked again. "*I thought you could use the frames. For something. I don't know. Lex'll think of something.*"

"*Why did you break them*?"

"*Because I could*," said Kestrel Varn. "*Because she's in them.*" She grinned. A wild bright grin. "*And because it was very, very satisfying.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

GRANDMOTHER ASHA CAME ON the fifth day. On a camel. With two more old women in red behind her, on two more camels, and a look on her dried-apple face like a general reviewing troops.

"*Sand*," she said. Climbing down. Slowly. Swearing in a language Lex didn't know. "*Three of us. That's six hours of sand a night, smith. Maybe seven. If nobody falls asleep.*" She looked at the cottages. At the birch wood. At the soaped windows. "*It's not a very big house. We can cover it.*"

"*Thank you*."

"*Don't thank me*," said Grandmother Asha. "*Thank the camels. I hate camels. They hate me. We've come two hundred miles hating each other.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC AND HEDDA CAME on the fourth day. In the cart. With the travelling forge in the back and a load of oak planks and a box of nails and Teo Brask, dripping, on the seat between them.

"*Boards*," said Brannoc. Climbing down. Looking at the windows. "*For every pane. Inside and out. Nailed.*" He held up his hands. The fingertips shone gold in the evening light. "*And I'll hold the nails. I can't hit my thumb anymore. Can't feel it if I do.*"

Teo slid off the cart. He was seventeen now. Tall and gangling and always, always wet. Water followed him. It dripped off his hair and his sleeves and his nose. It pooled round his boots. It came up out of the ground where he stood.

"*Water reflects*," said Teo. When Lex looked at him. "*Barrels. Buckets. The stream. Puddles. Dew.*" He wiped his nose on his sleeve. It didn't help. "*I can keep it moving. All of it. All night. Ripples. So it never goes still enough to show anything.*" He shrugged. "*Seraphine says a reflection needs still water. So I won't let it be still.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND LYSANDRA SENT ELOWEN.

On the third day. On a grey warhorse. With Oathkeeper on her hip and four knights behind her and a letter from the Queen sealed in blue wax.

Lex opened it on the step.

It was very short.

Vey. I'd come myself. They won't let me. I'm practicing being stern about it in a mirror with no glass in it. — L.

And under it, smaller, in a different ink, as if added at the last moment—

Bring her home safe. All of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE NIGHT BEFORE MIDSUMMER eve, they sat outside.

All of them. In the clearing. Between the two cottages. On the grass by the stream. With a fire Lex lit with his own hands, and food Seren and Hedda had been cooking all afternoon, and Mother Orla's plum brandy, which Brannoc had brought a whole cask of and which nobody but Brannoc and Grandmother Asha could drink without coughing.

Lex sat with his back against the oak ramp of the blue-door cottage and looked at them.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO, WITH SERAPHINE LEANING against his shoulder. Her spectacles off, folded, face down on her knee. His bone flute in his lap. He wasn't playing. He was looking at the fire.

Pim, beside them, cross-legged on the grass. Small. Silent. With the basket of Hush-cups beside him and one hand resting on its lid. He hadn't let go of it all evening.

Hask, a little apart, on a stump at the edge of the firelight. Enormous. Quiet. With his pick across his knees and his bandaged arm resting on it, looking at the stream.

Kestrel, flat on her back on the grass with her hands behind her head, telling Teo a story about a Warden she'd set on fire in the Sunreach, which might have been true.

Teo, dripping, listening, laughing.

Grandmother Asha and her two old women in red, sitting in a row on a log with their hands folded in their laps, like crows on a fence. Passing the plum brandy between them. Arguing in their own language.

Brannoc and Hedda, side by side on the cart's tailboard. Brannoc's arm round Hedda's shoulders. His gold fingertips catching the firelight.

Elowen, standing. Even now. At the edge of the clearing. With Oathkeeper on her hip. Watching the dark.

And Wren.

Sitting on the grass beside him. With Lark asleep in her lap. Her red hair in a braid over one shoulder. Her face in the firelight very still.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND BEHIND HIM, THROUGH the blue door, through the open curtain, his father.

In bed. Under the west window. Propped on three pillows so he could see. His mother sitting on the edge of the bed beside him with her hand in his.

The door was open. So he could hear.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Look at them,] said Ember. Very quietly.

I'm looking.

[All of them.] A pause. *[Do you remember when it was just you? In the Ashbourne forge? At nineteen? With a Common class and a Ceiling of twenty-four and nobody but Brannoc?]*

I remember.

[And me,] said Ember. *[You had me. From the first day. From the moment the seal cracked.]* Another pause. *[I was the first one. Before any of them.]*

Lex looked at the fire.

[I wanted to say that,] said Ember. *[Before. I don't know why. I just wanted to say it.]*

Before what?

Ember didn't answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STARTED PLAYING.

Lex didn't see him decide to. He just looked up and his brother had the bone flute to his lips, and the first notes were coming out of it, thin and breathy and a little off, the way they always were. Antho had played it every night for eight years in a cave in the Greyspine to hold the dark off, and he still couldn't play it very well.

The Lantern Song.

Slowly. The way their mother used to sing it.

Nobody said anything.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HIS MOTHER started to sing.

From the bed. Behind the curtain. Through the open door. Very softly. Barely above a whisper. The words to the tune his brother was playing.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you fear. There's a light in the window, and I'm right here—

And Wren joined her. On the grass. With the baby in her lap. Very quietly.

And then Seraphine. Who couldn't sing. Who sang anyway.

And then, from the cart's tailboard, in a voice like a landslide, off-key, Brannoc.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T SING.

He sat with his back against the oak ramp and listened. To his brother's flute. To his mother's voice from the bed. To his wife, and his brother's wife, and the old smith who'd pulled him out of the ashes. To Kestrel, who didn't know the words and hummed. To Teo, dripping. To three old women in red on a log, who didn't know the song at all and were singing something else entirely, in their own language, in harmony, and it somehow fitted.

To Hask, on his stump. Who wasn't singing. Whose lips were moving.

He looked at the fire. At the faces round it. At the baby asleep in Wren's lap with drool on her chin and one square fist curled against her mouth.

And thought, *this*. *This is what he wants to keep*.

This is what he'd keep, if he could. Exactly like this. Forever. Every face. Every voice. The fire. The song.

And it would never be sung again.

◆ ◆ ◆

WHEN THE SONG WAS done, nobody said anything for a long time.

Then his father spoke. From the bed. Through the open door. Thin. Dry. A thread.

"*Thank you*," said Arion Vey. "*That was the best I've ever heard it.*"

"*You've heard it a thousand times*," said Seren. Softly.

"*Yes*," said his father. "*And that was the best.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

MIDSUMMER EVE CAME GREY and hot.

They boarded the windows in the morning. Brannoc and Hask and Lex. Every pane. Inside and out. Oak planks, nailed tight, with Brannoc holding the nails in his gold fingers and Hask driving them with his pick-hammer in two blows each, and Lex sealing the cracks between the planks with black heat so not a sliver of light got through.

Both cottages. Every window.

Teo walked the clearing with his hands out. The stream. The water butt by the lean-to. The trough. A bucket someone had left by the woodpile. Every surface of every still water rippling as he passed. Shivering. Never quite still.

Kestrel and the three old women in red walked the edges of the clearing. Slowly. In a circle. With their hands out. Laying down sand. Black heat. A ring of it, round both cottages, round the stream, invisible, a hand's width above the grass. Lex could feel it. Like walking past an oven.

Elowen and her knights took the track.

Wren stood in the middle of the clearing with her eyes shut and her hands open and breathed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FOG CAME UP at dusk.

Out of the stream. Out of the grass. Out of the birch wood. Soft and white and thick. Rolling across the clearing in slow waves, the way it rolled across the high moors above Thistledown at dawn. Swallowing the cottages. Swallowing the woodpile and the lean-to and the cart. Swallowing everyone.

Wren's fog.

Lex stood in it and could barely see his own hand.

"*Can you see*?" he said.

"*Yes*," said Wren. Somewhere close. Somewhere in the white. "*I can always see in mine.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WENT INTO THE cellar at dark.

Under the cottage. Under the kitchen floor. Through the trapdoor and down the ladder. The cellar where they'd found Wenna's box, a year and a half ago, with a moth carved in the lid and crossed out.

No windows. No glass. No water. No light.

Wren took her down. And Seren. They'd decided that together. Two women. One who could fog glass and one who could say no. In the dark, with the baby, with the trapdoor shut over their heads and Hask sitting on it.

His father wouldn't go.

"*I can't do ladders*," he said. From the bed in the blue-door cottage. With the windows boarded and the fog pressing against the planks outside. "*And somebody has to be in this house. Somebody has to keep it.*"

"*You can't keep anything*," said Seren. "*You can't get out of bed.*"

"*I've kept a great many things from a great many beds*," said Arion Vey. "*I held the whole net from a crystal for sixteen years. I can hold a cottage for one night.*" He looked at her. "*Go, love. Go with the baby. That's where you need to be.*"

She didn't move.

"*Seren*," said her husband. Very gently. "*Go.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STAYED WITH HIM.

With his Lantern. With Pim. In the blue-door cottage, in the dark, with the windows boarded and his father in the bed and the black heat in the walls.

Lex went across the stream.

To his own cottage. To the kitchen. To the trapdoor in the floor with Silas Hask sitting on it like a boulder. To the east window, boarded. To the hornlight on the sill, unlit now, because Grandmother Asha had said *no light, smith, not one, not even a horn one, not tonight*.

He stood in the dark kitchen.

He could hear the fog against the planks. A soft wet pressing. He could hear the stream, rippling, never quite still. He could hear, faint, under the floor, his wife's voice. Singing. Very low. To the baby.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you fear.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAITED.

They all waited. In the dark. In the fog. In the heat.

It was very hot. Midsummer. The shortest night. The windows would have been open, in any other year. Every window in Caldor would be open tonight. People sleeping on top of their blankets. Children on the floor by the door for the draught.

Every window in Caldor.

In every window, Orrin had said. *In every glass*.

◆ ◆ ◆

MIDNIGHT.

He felt it. Through the Stone. A shift. A change. The way you feel the air change before a storm breaks.

Then nothing.

Then—

Tap.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE WINDOW.

The east window. The boarded one. Behind him. On the glass, behind the planks.

Tap.

Small. Light. Like a fingernail.

Tap. Tap.

He turned round.

The planks were dark. Black heat in every crack. Not a sliver of light. He couldn't see the glass behind them. He couldn't see anything.

Tap.

And then a sound he'd never heard before.

◆ ◆ ◆

A HISS.

Soft. Wet. Everywhere. From the window behind the planks. From the window in the loft above his head. From the little window by the door. From across the stream, faint, from the windows of the blue-door cottage.

From every pane of glass at Harrow. All at once.

The sound of soap running.

Of something on the inside of the glass going wet. Going soft. Melting. Running down the panes in thin streams, the way frost runs down a window when the sun

gets to it. As if a hand were pressed against every pane at once, from the other side, cold, and the soap was thawing under it.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE HISS stopped.

And from behind the planks of the east window, from the glass, clear now, black now, washed clean—

A voice.

Small. Far. Like a wet finger round the rim of a glass.

"*Smith*," said Ysenne. "*You boarded them. How sweet.*" A pause. "*Did you think I needed the windows?*"

Lex didn't move.

"*Look down*," said the Glass Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED DOWN.

At the floor. At the dark kitchen floor. At the flags, grey, in the black.

And at the thing that was shining on them.

A fleck. A speck. A single grain of something. Gold. Lying on the flagstone by his bare foot. Catching what little light there was. Gleaming.

And beside it, another.

And another.

Coming in under the door. A thin gold line of them. Sifting. Glittering. Spreading across the floor like sand across a beach. Grain after grain after grain.

Gold dust.

And in every grain, if he looked closely, if he bent down—

A tiny pale face.

CHAPTER 16

The Night of Glass

THE CELLAR SMELLED OF apples and earth and old stone.

Wren sat on the floor in the dark with her back against the cold wall and her daughter on her chest and listened.

She couldn't see anything. Not her hand. Not the baby. Not Seren, a yard away, sitting against the barrel where the apples used to be. Black. Total. The kind of dark you only get underground, the kind that presses on your open eyes like a hand.

She could hear.

Lark breathing. Small. Fast. Warm against her collarbone. Asleep. She'd gone down the ladder fussing and Wren had fed her in the dark and she'd gone quiet and heavy and slept.

Seren breathing. Slower. Steadier. A hedge-witch's breathing. In for four, out for four, the way you breathe at a door when you're listening for what's on the other side of it.

Above them, the trapdoor. And on the trapdoor, a weight. Enormous. Still. The boards creaking a little every time it shifted.

Hask.

And above Hask, very faint, through the floor, through the boards, through the black heat Lex had poured into every crack—

Nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Tell her a story*," said Wren. Very quietly. Into the dark.

"*She's asleep*."

"*Tell it anyway*."

A pause. Then Seren's voice. Low. Just above a whisper.

"*There was a miller*," said Seren Harrow, "*who had a cat.*"

Wren closed her eyes. It made no difference.

"*And the cat was very lazy*," said Seren. "*It slept all day in the flour sacks. It never caught a single mouse. The miller's wife said get rid of it. The miller said, it's a good cat, it just hasn't found its mouse yet.*"

"*I don't know this one.*"

"*Nobody does. I made it up. In the dark. For the little one.*" A breath. "*I told it four hundred and eleven times. It liked the bit where the cat falls in the millpond.*"

Wren almost laughed.

"*Go on, then*," she said. "*Get to the millpond.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN GOT TO THE millpond.

And then past it. The cat climbing out, wet and furious. The miller laughing. The wife saying I told you so. The cat sulking in the flour sacks for a week and coming out white from nose to tail like a ghost and frightening every mouse in the mill so badly they all moved to the next village.

So the cat found its mouse after all, said Seren. *It just had to be a ghost first.*

Wren didn't know when she'd started crying. In the dark. Silently. With her daughter asleep on her chest.

She didn't stop.

"*It's a terrible story*," she said.

"*I know*," said Seren. "*It's the best one I've got.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN LARK WOKE up.

All at once. The way she always did. A jerk against Wren's chest. A small sharp intake of breath.

Wren felt her lift her head. Wobbling. In the dark.

And look.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T KNOW HOW she knew. She couldn't see. But she felt it. Felt the baby's head turn, slowly, against her collarbone. Away from Wren. Away from Seren. Up.

Toward the trapdoor.

Toward the cracks round the edges of it. The thin lines where the boards didn't quite meet the frame. Black. Sealed with black heat.

And in one of them—

A glint.

◆ ◆ ◆

SO SMALL. SO FAINT. A single point of light. Gold. No bigger than a grain of sand. Caught in the crack between the trapdoor and the frame, high up, by the hinge.

Glowing.

Not reflecting. There was nothing to reflect. There was no light in the cellar. It was *glowing*. On its own. Faint and gold and warm, like the last spark in a dead fire.

"*Seren*," said Wren.

"*I see it*."

The glint moved.

It slid. Out of the crack. Fell. Turning over and over in the dark, glittering, a tiny gold spark drifting down through the black air of the cellar the way a snowflake drifts down past a window.

It landed on the earth floor between them.

And lay there. Glowing.

And in it—

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN LEANED FORWARD.

She didn't mean to. She couldn't help it. She leaned forward in the dark with the baby on her chest until her face was a foot from the floor, from the glowing grain, and looked.

There was a face in it.

Tiny. So tiny she could barely see it. Pale. White hair. Grey eyes. A face like the edge of a knife.

Looking up at her.

Smiling.

"*There you are*," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER VOICE CAME OUT of the grain. So small it was barely a sound. Like a fly at a window. Like a wet finger round the rim of a thimble.

"*In the dark*," said the Glass Queen. "*Under the floor. With the apples.*" The tiny face tilted. "*Did you think I needed light, Mistwalker? I don't need light. I only need something that shines.*" A pause. "*Oz's gold shines on its own. Did you know? It always has. Even in the dark. Even at the bottom of a cellar.*"

Wren didn't move.

"*Every grain*," said Ysenne. Softly. "*Every single grain of my brother's gold. A little mirror. A little window. A little door.*" The tiny face glittered. "*And Orrin's brought so many.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ABOVE THEM, THE TRAPDOOR creaked.

Hask. Shifting. And then a sound. A grunt. Short. Hard. The sound a man makes when something lands on the back of his neck.

"*Hask—*"

"*It's coming through*." His voice. Through the boards. Rough. Tight. "*The floor. Up here. It's coming in under the door. Through the cracks. It's everywhere.*" A pause. "*It's on me.*"

"*Get off the trapdoor—*"

"*No*."

"*Hask, it's on you—*"

"*I said no*." The boards creaked. "*Nobody comes down this ladder. Not while I'm—*"

He stopped.

Wren heard him stop. Heard the silence where the rest of the sentence should have been.

And then, very quietly, through the boards—

"*Huh*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What*?" said Wren. "*What is it? Hask, what—*"

"*It won't stick*."

She stared up into the dark.

"*It's landing on me*," said Hask. Slowly. Wonderingly. "*On my neck. My arms. My back. I can feel it. Little cold specks.*" A pause. "*And then it slides off. Like rain off oilcloth.*"

"*Why*?"

"*I don't know*." The boards creaked. "*I think—*" Another pause. Longer. "*I think it knows me. I think it remembers.*"

She was in me, he'd said. At the pool. *For a whole season. Her light. In my chest. I had her wings.*

"*It thinks I'm one of theirs*," said Silas Hask. Very quietly. "*It won't keep what it thinks it's already got.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

MORE GRAINS WERE FALLING.

Wren saw them. Glowing. Drifting down out of the cracks round the trapdoor like gold snow. Two. Five. Ten. A dozen. Turning over and over in the black air. Landing on the earth floor. On the old apple barrel. On the bottom rung of the ladder.

And where they landed, the gold spread.

Slowly. From each grain. Outward. Like ink in water. The earth floor round each grain going gold. Hard. Shining. The barrel-staves. The ladder rung. Little pools of gold, spreading, meeting, joining.

Glowing.

And in every one of them, a face.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Wren*," said Seren.

Wren was already moving.

She stood up. With the baby on her chest. In the black cellar with the gold falling round her like snow and the faces looking up out of the floor.

And breathed.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT FOG. FOG WOULDN'T help. Fog was for glass, for windows, for still surfaces you could breathe on and blur.

This was dust.

Dust can't land on what's moving, she thought. She'd thought it on the roofs at Ashbourne, with the gold coming down. *It can't settle. It can't stick. It needs still air.*

So I won't be still.

She called the wind.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WASN'T ROOM FOR it. That was the trouble. The cellar was small. Low-roofed. Ten feet by twelve. The wind came when she called it, it always came, but it came into a box. It hit the walls and the ceiling and the floor and came back at her. Tumbling. Confused. Like a bird caught in a room.

She held it anyway.

She spun it. Round her. Round the baby. Round Seren, who'd come and pressed close against her side. A tight fast whirl of air, filling the cellar from wall to wall. Lifting the dust off the floor. Lifting the grains out of the air before they could land. Spinning them.

And the cellar *lit up*.

◆ ◆ ◆

GOLD.

Thousands of grains. Tens of thousands. Lifted off the floor, off the barrel, off the ladder, out of the air. Whirling round them in the dark. Glowing. Every one of them. A storm of tiny gold sparks, spinning, turning, lit from inside, filling the black cellar with light.

And in every spark, a face.

Tens of thousands of faces. Tiny. Pale. White-haired. Grey-eyed. Whirling round them in a golden storm. All of them looking at the baby.

All of them laughing.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND LARK LAUGHED BACK.

Wren felt it before she heard it. Felt the baby on her chest go stiff with delight. Felt her square fists fly out. And then the laugh. Loud. Astonished. Delighted. The laugh from the roofs at Ashbourne. The laugh of someone who has just found the best thing in the world.

Wind. Gold. Lights. Spinning.

Lark laughed at the storm like it was a toy someone had hung over her cradle.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FACES STOPPED LAUGHING.

Wren saw it. All of them. All at once. Tens of thousands of tiny pale faces in the whirling gold going still.

Looking at the baby.

"*Oh*," said Ysenne. From everywhere. From every spark. A hundred thousand tiny voices, all the same. Very small. Very quiet. "*Oh, she's laughing.*"

"*She likes the wind*," said Wren. Through her teeth. Holding it. Holding the whirl. Her arms shaking.

"*She's laughing at me*," said the Glass Queen. Wondering. "*Nobody's ever—*" She stopped. "*She's not afraid. Why isn't she afraid?*"

"*Because she's five months old*," said Seren. Pressed against Wren's side. Her voice very steady. "*And you're very pretty. And very shiny. And spinning.*" A pause. "*You're the best thing she's ever seen.*"

The sparks went very still in the air. Just for a moment. Hanging. Not spinning.

And then Wren lost the wind.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS TOO MUCH. Too small a room. Too long. Her arms were shaking and her lungs were burning and the wind had been bouncing off the walls for two minutes like a bird in a box and it got away from her.

Not all at once. A gust. Sideways. Out of the whirl. Slamming into the cellar wall and coming back wrong.

And the gold came through the gap.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT LANDED ON HER arm.

Her left. The one holding the baby. On the back of her hand. A spatter of it. Ten grains. Twenty.

She felt it. Cold. Like sleet.

And then she felt it *go in*.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D WATCHED IT HAPPEN to Tilda. On the green. She'd watched the gold creep up a girl's arm under the skin like a tide over sand.

She hadn't known what it felt like.

It felt like nothing.

That was the worst thing. It didn't hurt. It didn't burn. It was cold for a moment, and then it wasn't anything at all. A patch on the back of her hand that just—stopped. Stopped being cold. Stopped being warm. Stopped being hers.

She looked down.

In the glow of the whirling gold she could see it. The back of her hand. Gold. A patch the size of a coin. Spreading. Slowly. Toward her knuckles. Toward her wrist.

Toward the baby's back, where her hand lay flat.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*OUT*," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D NEVER HEARD HER mother-in-law shout. Not once. Seren didn't shout. Harrow women didn't.

She shouted now.

"*HASK. OPEN IT. NOW.*"

The trapdoor flew up.

Light. Not much. Grey. The faint red of the banked fire in the kitchen above, smothered in black heat. And dust. Gold dust. Pouring down through the open trapdoor like sand through the neck of an hourglass.

And Hask's face in the square of it. His head. His shoulders. Covered in gold. Glittering. Sliding off him. Like rain off oilcloth.

His hand came down. Enormous. Scarred. With a line of grey-black at the wrist.

"*Give her to me*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T THINK.

She held the baby up.

Her daughter. Five months old. Laughing. With her fists out and her face lit gold by the storm. She held her up through the whirling dust toward the hand of a man who'd once stood on Fennel Street in Highcrest and tried to carry her to the Moth Queen.

Who'd broken the cores. Who'd made the holes. Who'd worn the wings.

Whose skin the gold slid off like rain.

His hand closed round the baby.

Gently. So gently. The way he'd closed it round Kell's stick. One finger at a time.

And lifted her up. Out of the cellar. Out of the storm.

Into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WENT NEXT.

Up the ladder. Fast. Barefoot. Her hands on the rungs, which were gold now, some of them, hard and cold and shining. She didn't stop. She didn't look down.

Wren went last.

With her hand.

She didn't look at it. She climbed with it. It didn't hurt. It didn't feel like anything. It was just there, at the end of her arm, cold and stiff and wrong, and she gripped the rungs with it anyway and climbed.

She came up out of the cellar into the kitchen.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS DARK.

Black heat. She could feel it. Rolling off the walls. Pressing on her face like the heat from an oven. Lex's black heat, in every crack, in every board, eating every scrap of light.

And in it, the dust.

Glittering. Everywhere. In the air. On the floor. On the table. Glowing faint and gold in the black, because Oszric's gold glowed on its own. Swirling. Drifting. Settling.

Wherever it settled, the gold spread.

The table was gold. Half of it. The near end. The chairs. A gold cup on the gold table. The bench by the hearth. The edge of the hearthstone.

The hornlight.

On the sill of the boarded east window. The little iron lantern with its four panes of scraped horn. Unlit. Gold. All of it. The iron, the horn, the new wick inside. Gold. Shining. Still.

Kept.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IN THE MIDDLE of the kitchen, in the black, with his hands out and his face lit from below by a faint red glow that didn't give off any light—

Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS HOLDING IT.

All of it. The whole kitchen. The black heat rolling off him in waves, the air round him so hot it shimmered. Eating the light. Keeping the dust dark. Every grain that came near him going dim, going black, its little face going out like a candle snuffed.

But only near him.

Only in a ring round him, a few yards across. Beyond that, the dust glittered. Glowed. Settled. Spread.

His face was grey. His hands were shaking. His eyes, in the faint red not-light, were very bright.

He saw her come up out of the trapdoor.

He saw her hand.

"*Go*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex—*"

"*Across*." His voice was hoarse. "*To Father's. Antho's there. The Lantern. Pim.*" His hands were shaking harder. "*Pim makes rooms. The dust can't get into his rooms.*"

"*Your hand—*"

"*Your hand*," said Lex. "*Wren. Your hand.*"

She held it up.

She hadn't meant to. She held it up in the faint gold glow of the dust, and they both looked at it.

The gold had reached her knuckles. It was creeping down her fingers. Toward the nails. And back. Toward the wrist.

"*It hasn't set*," said Lex.

He took one hand off the black heat.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RING ROUND HIM shrank.

Wren felt it. The dark pulling in. The glittering dust pressing closer. Settling on the floor a yard from his feet. Spreading.

He didn't look at it.

He took her hand. Her gold hand. In his. And shut his eyes.

And listened.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FELT IT.

Not in the gold. There was nothing in the gold. Above it. Past it. At the wrist. At the edge, where the gold met her skin, where it was still moving, still creeping, still filling.

A *gap*.

Small. A hair. A breath. Opening. Just ahead of the gold. Between the edge of it and the rest of her. A space with nothing in it. A room.

And the gold came to the room.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FELT IT STOP. Felt it hesitate. Felt it sit at the edge of the room in her wrist and not know what to do. Like water at the edge of a step. Like a tide that has come up to a wall.

And then go back.

Slowly. From the wrist. Down the back of her hand. Toward the knuckles. Draining. Pink coming back behind it. Freckled. Hers.

And stopping.

At the knuckles.

The backs of her fingers stayed gold. From the knuckle to the nail. All four. Set. Finished. Full.

Her thumb was pink.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'm sorry*," said Lex. Hoarsely. Letting go. "*I'm sorry. The fingers were—*"

"*It's my left*," said Wren.

He looked at her.

"*I'm right-handed*," said Wren Ashdown. "*I draw the bow with my right. I throw the knife with my right. I hold her with my left.*" She looked at her hand. At the four gold fingers. "*I can still hold her.*"

She could. She flexed it. The thumb moved. The palm moved. The fingers didn't. They stayed curled, gold, stiff, like the fingers of a statue. But the hand was a hand. It could cup. It could hold.

It could hold a baby's back.

"*Go*," said Lex. "*Wren. Please. Go.*"

She went.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK HAD THE BABY.

He was standing by the door. The kitchen door. With Lark in the crook of his good arm, held against his chest, against the scarred leather of his jerkin. The gold sliding off his shoulders. Off his head. Pooling round his boots.

Not touching her.

He'd curled himself round her. His enormous shoulders hunched. His head bent. His bandaged arm up over her like a roof. The dust came down on him and slid off and fell to the floor and didn't touch the baby at all.

She was looking up at him. In the gold glow. With her grey-green eyes wide.

Not laughing now. Not crying. Just looking. At the great scarred grey face bent over her. With wet on its cheeks.

"*She's all right*," said Hask. Hoarsely. "*Not a speck. Not one.*" He looked at Wren. "*I've got her.*"

Wren held out her arms.

He gave her back. Slowly. One finger at a time.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN OPENED THE DOOR.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CLEARING WAS GOLD.

Wren stood in the doorway and couldn't breathe.

The fog was there. Her fog. White. Thick. Rolling. She'd laid it down at dusk and held it all night from the cellar without even thinking, the way you hold your breath. It was still there. Pressing against the cottage. Swallowing the birch wood.

But the dust was in it.

Glittering. Glowing. Hanging in the white like sparks in smoke. Billions of them. The whole clearing full of tiny gold lights, drifting, turning, settling.

And where they'd settled—

The grass was gold. In patches. Spreading. Joining. Gold grass, every blade. The woodpile was gold. The lean-to. The cart, with its tailboard down, where Brannoc and Hedda had sat the night before with their arms round each other. Gold.

A birch tree at the edge of the clearing was gold. The whole of it. Trunk and branches and every new leaf, shining in the fog like a thing made by a jeweller.

And every leaf a mirror.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAW THEM.

In the gold. In every leaf of the gold birch. In every blade of the gold grass. In the gold wood of the cart and the gold boards of the lean-to.

Faces.

Pale. Tiny. Thousands. Turning. Watching.

"*There*," said Ysenne. From everywhere. "*There. You see? Everything shines, in the end. Everything.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THERE WAS A voice under hers.

Dry. Soft. Hissing. Like sand poured slowly out of a sack. Coming out of the fog. Out of the dust. Out of every grain.

"*Forgive me*," said Orrin. "*I'm sorry. I'm so sorry.*"

He was in the fog. Somewhere. Everywhere. A thin bent shape made of dust, walking through the white in the middle of his own storm with his twig-arms held out to either side.

Scattering.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE OTHERS WERE FIGHTING.

She saw them in flashes. Through the fog. Through the gold.

Kestrel. At the edge of the clearing. On her knees. With her hands flat on the ground and her red hair wild and her face white. Holding her part of the ring of sand. The black heat rolling off her in waves. The dust round her going dark.

But only round her.

Grandmother Asha and her two old women in red. Further round. In a row. Holding hands. Singing in their own language. The sand round them so hot the fog boiled off it in steam.

But the gold was coming over the ring. Between them. Where the heat was thinnest.

Elowen and her knights. On the track. Swords out. Swinging at nothing. At the dust. At the faces in the gold leaves. Because there was nothing else to swing at.

And Teo.

◆ ◆ ◆

TEO WAS IN THE stream.

Up to his knees. In the water. With his arms out and his head thrown back and his whole gangling dripping body shaking.

Keeping it moving.

The whole stream. From the birch wood to the bend. Rippling. Churning. Splashing. Never still. Never still enough to show a face. The dust landing on it and being swept away. Carried off downstream. Tumbled. Broken up. Never settling.

Wren could see it costing him. His face was grey. His lips were blue. Water was running off him in sheets.

He wasn't stopping.

"*GO*," he shouted. At them. Across the gold clearing. Through the fog. "*CROSS. NOW. I CAN'T HOLD IT MUCH—*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY RAN.

Seren first. Barefoot. Across the gold grass. Wren didn't know if it would keep her. She didn't stop to find out. She ran behind her mother-in-law with her daughter clutched to her chest in her gold-fingered hand and her other hand out, calling the wind, spinning it round them, round the baby, a tight bright whirl that blew the dust away before it could land.

Hask behind. With his pick out. With the gold sliding off him.

To the stream.

To the stepping stones.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WAS ON THE first stone.

The second.

Wren was on the first. With the baby. The water rushing round the stones. Rippling. Churning. Teo's water. Never still.

The third.

And Teo fell.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T SEE IT. She heard it. A cry. Short. Cut off. And then a splash. And then—

Nothing.

No splash. No rush. No churn.

Silence.

The stream stopped moving.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED DOWN.

The water round the stepping stones. Under her feet. All along the stream. From the birch wood to the bend. Black. Smooth. Still.

Perfectly still.

And the dust came down on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T SINK. IT didn't get carried away. It landed on the still black water like snow on a pond. And spread. From every grain. Outward. Gold. Joining. Meeting. A skin of gold across the surface of the stream. Hard. Smooth.

Shining.

A mirror.

A mirror the length of the stream, gold, flat, still, perfect.

And in it—

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT TINY.

Not a thousand faces in a thousand leaves.

One face. One figure. Huge. Filling the whole gold length of the stream. Lying in it the way a reflection lies in a pond. Long. Pale. White-gowned. White-haired. With a narrow band of glass on her brow.

Looking up at Wren.

From under her feet.

Smiling.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said Ysenne. "*Oh, that's better.*"

And sat up.

◆ ◆ ◆

OUT OF THE STREAM.

Out of the gold. Out of the mirror. The way a woman sits up out of a bath. Her head first. Her white hair streaming, not wet, glittering. Her shoulders. Her arms. Her long white gown pouring off her like water and not like water.

Glass.

All of her. Not flesh. Not a reflection anymore. *Glass*. Clear and cold and faintly glittering, like frost on a window, like ice over deep water. You could see through her. You could see the fog behind her, the gold birch, the far bank. Bent. Distorted. As if through a lens.

She was half out of the stream. From the waist up. Her lower half still in the gold, still a reflection, still flat.

She looked at her hands.

Long. Clear. Glittering. Real.

"*Hands*," said the Glass Queen. Wonderingly. "*Oh, I've got hands. In the air. In the world.*" She turned them over. "*It's been so long. Nine hundred years. Nothing but glass.*" She breathed in. Wren saw her breathe in. Saw her glass chest rise. "*Oh. Oh, the air. It smells of something. What does it smell of?*"

"*Rain*," said Seren.

She was on the third stone. Turned round. Facing the Glass Queen across the gold water.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE LOOKED AT HER.

"*Rain*," she said. Slowly. "*Yes. I remember rain.*" She tilted her head. Her glass crown caught the gold glow. "*Hesper's girl. Hello.*"

"*Go back*," said Seren.

"*I've only just come out*."

"*Go back*," said Seren Harrow. "*Into the glass. Into the stream. Into the gold. Go back to your brother and tell him no.*"

"*Everyone keeps telling me to tell him no*," said Ysenne. "*Nobody ever tells him themselves.*" She smiled. "*Except you. You told him. Through Rosie's rose. He laughed so hard, Orrin said, the cocoons shook.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND SHE TURNED HER head.

Slowly. Her long glass neck turning. Her ice-grey eyes moving.

To Wren.

On the first stone. With the wind round her. With the baby on her chest. With her gold-fingered hand on the baby's back.

"*And there she is*," said the Glass Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T MOVE.

She stood on the stepping stone with the gold water round her feet and the Glass Queen sitting up out of it two yards away, and didn't move.

Lark was looking at her.

At Ysenne. With her grey-green eyes. Wide. Not laughing. Not afraid. Looking.

The way she'd looked at her in the loft window. The first night. With milk on her chin.

The way nobody looked at the Glass Queen. Not at the glass. Not at the reflection. At *her*.

"*Hello*," said Ysenne. To the baby. Very softly. "*Hello. You looked at me. Do you remember? In the window. You were the first one in nine hundred years.*"

Lark frowned at her.

"*He wants you*," said the Glass Queen. "*My brother. He wants to put a crown on you and keep you. Forever.*" Her glass face was very still. "*He thinks it would be nice. He thinks it would be good for the Court. Something new.*"

She held out her hand.

Long. Clear. Glittering. Real.

"*Come here*," said Ysenne. "*Just to look. I won't hurt you. I only want to look.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND LARK REACHED BACK.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FELT IT. THE baby's arm, coming out of the sling. Her square fist. Opening. Toward the glass hand. Toward the glittering. Toward the long clear fingers reaching out of the gold water.

Opening and closing.

The way she reached for the nail.

"*No*," said Wren.

She stepped back.

On the stepping stone. One step. Backward. Toward the bank. Away from the glass hand.

And her heel came down on gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE EDGE OF THE stone. Where the dust had settled. Where the gold had spread. Smooth. Hard. Slick as ice.

Her foot went.

She felt it go. Felt the stone slide out from under her. Felt her weight go back. Felt the baby on her chest lurch.

Felt herself fall.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIND CAUGHT HER.

Not her wind. She'd lost hers. She'd lost it the moment her foot went. It wasn't hers.

It came from behind. From the bank. From the cottage. A gust. Hard. Sudden. Cold. Slamming into her back and holding her. Holding her up. Like a hand. Like a wall.

And a voice.

"*Not today*."

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO.

On the bank. Behind her. In the doorway of the blue-door cottage, at the top of the oak ramp. With his Lantern in one hand, blazing, and his other hand out. Open. The wind pouring out of it.

Gale. Speaking.

His black hair wild. His face white. His eyes—

His eyes were the eyes of the man who'd stood in every kind of door.

"*Wren*," said Antho Vey. "*Come here.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME.

Off the stepping stone. Not onto the next one. Onto the wind. Antho's wind. It caught her and carried her. Across the gold water. Over the last two stones. Up the bank. She hit the oak ramp running with the baby against her chest and Seren beside her and Hask behind, and Antho stepped back from the door, and they went through it.

Into the blue-door cottage.

Into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SLAMMED THE DOOR.

Wren stood in the middle of the room and breathed.

It was dark. Black heat. Boards over every window. And in the middle of it, Antho's Lantern. The Keeper's Lantern. On the table. Blazing. Gold. The only light.

And round the Lantern, round the table, round the bed under the west window—

Quiet.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FELT IT. THE moment she came through the door. Like stepping into a room where someone has been sleeping. Like walking into the hush of a chapel. Soft. Still. Close. A *room*. Inside the room.

Pim.

He was sitting on the floor by the bed. Cross-legged. With his small thin hands open on his knees and his eyes shut and his face very white.

Making room.

The dust didn't come in. Wren could see it. Through the cracks round the door, round the boarded windows. Glittering. Sifting. Drifting into the dark of the cottage.

And stopping.

At the edge of Pim's room. A yard from the walls. Hanging in the air like flies at a pane. Unable to come further. Unable to settle. Because there was nothing to settle *on*. Because the room Pim made was the one thing in the world the gold couldn't fill.

Because it was empty on purpose.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Is she—*" said a voice. From the bed. Thin. Dry. A thread.

Arion.

Propped on his pillows. Under the boarded west window. His white hair wild. His grey eyes very bright in the Lantern-light.

"*She's all right*," said Seren. Kneeling by the bed. Taking his hand. "*She's all right. Not a speck. Hask had her.*"

"*Wren's hand—*"

"*It's my left*," said Wren. From the middle of the room. With the baby. Breathing. "*I hold her with my left.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WAS AT THE door.

With his back against it. With his hand flat on the wood. Listening. The way his mother listened at doors.

"*She's still out there*," he said. Very quietly.

Nobody answered.

"*In the stream*," said Antho. "*In the gold. Half out. I can feel her.*" He shut his eyes. "*She's not trying the door. She's not trying anything.*" A pause. "*She's waiting.*"

"*For what*?" said Hask.

Antho opened his eyes.

He was looking at the table. At the Lantern.

The Keeper's Lantern. That Lex had forged for him six years ago in Malachi's valley, with HUSH ×12 and SHELTER cut into its iron. That he'd carried every day since. That had held the Murmur off for six years. That burned now on the table in the middle of Pim's room, gold, blazing, the only light.

Glass.

Four panes. Clear. Clean. Shining in its own light.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN SAW IT.

They all saw it.

In the pane facing the bed. Small. Pale. Growing.

A face.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh, warden*," said Ysenne. From the glass of the Lantern. From inside Pim's room. From the one thing in the cottage that shone. "*You brought a light.*"

Antho went white.

"*Every room needs a light*," said the Glass Queen. Softly. "*Doesn't it. Even his.*" The tiny face in the pane tilted toward Pim. Toward the boy on the floor with his eyes shut. "*Even the quiet ones. Even the empty ones.*" A smile. "*Especially those.*"

Pim didn't open his eyes.

But Wren saw his hands shake. On his knees.

"*He can keep the dust out*," said Ysenne. "*He's very good. He's the best I've ever seen. Better than Hes.*" The face in the glass was growing. Filling the pane. "*But he can't keep me out. Not if you've brought me in yourselves.*"

And a hand came out of the Lantern.

◆ ◆ ◆

LONG. CLEAR. GLITTERING. GLASS.

Reaching out of the pane the way a hand reaches out of water. Fingers first. Then the wrist. Then the forearm. Thin. Fine. Impossible. Coming out of a pane of glass no bigger than a playing card.

Into the room.

Toward the bed.

Toward the old man on the pillows, and the woman kneeling beside him, and—behind them, against the wall, where Wren had backed without knowing she'd moved—

The baby.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*," said Arion.

Very quietly. From the pillows. Not frightened. Not loud.

The voice of a man who had been Warden-Architect of the Spire for two hundred years and had designed every mirror-ward in it.

"*Put the Lantern down on the floor*," said Arion Vey. "*Glass side up. And then hand me my stick.*"

CHAPTER 17

What the Old Man Did

THE FIRST MIRROR-WARD ARION Vey ever built was for a cat.

He'd been sixty-one. A junior Architect, with ink on his cuffs and opinions about load-bearing arches. There was a cat in the Spire library that kept getting into the copying-room and sitting on the wet manuscripts, and the Archivist had asked him, very politely, if he could do anything about it.

He'd built a ward on the copying-room door. Two mirrors. Facing each other. Small. Silver-backed. Angled very precisely, so that anything that came through the door saw itself, and then itself again, and again, and again, a corridor of cats going on forever into the glass.

The cat had stopped in the doorway. Stared. And sat down. And stayed there for an hour, looking at itself, utterly still, until the Archivist came and picked it up and carried it away.

It's not a trap, he'd told her. When she asked how it worked. *Not really. It just shows a thing what it is. Over and over. Until it can't look away.*

That sounds like a trap, said the Archivist.

Most things that show you what you are, he'd said, *are*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D BUILT A GREAT many after that.

The Spire was full of them. Every door to the Root-chamber. Every window of the vaults. Every stair to the Warden-Architect's rooms. Two hundred years of mirror-wards, each one cleverer than the last, each one angled more precisely. Built against Gloam and shades and the reflection-spirits that drifted in sometimes off the Sundered Lands and tried to look out of the Spire's four thousand windows.

He'd never thought of them as weapons.

He'd thought of them as manners. A way of saying, at a door, *are you sure? Look at yourself first.*

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"*Put the Lantern down on the floor*," he said. "*Glass side up. And then hand me my stick.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO DIDN'T ASK WHY.

That was the thing Arion would remember. Later. In the long nights, when he couldn't sleep and couldn't move and lay on his back under the west window counting his own breaths.

His son didn't ask.

His son, who had asked *why* about everything his whole life. Who had asked it of the Murmur and the Ferryman and the dark at the bottom of the world. Who had been mad for eight years and was still, even now, the most stubborn questioner Arion had ever met.

He didn't ask.

He picked up the Keeper's Lantern off the table. With a glass hand still reaching out of one of its panes. Long. Clear. Glittering. Groping at the air of the cottage like a blind thing.

And set it on the floor.

Glass side up.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HAND WENT UP.

Of course it did. A hand coming out of a pane comes out at right angles to the pane. Arion had known it would. He'd known it the way he knew the angle of the sun on a floor. With the Lantern on its side on the flags, the pane facing the ceiling, the hand came out of it *upward*. Straight up. Toward the dark beams. Toward the black heat.

Toward nothing.

Away from the bed. Away from the baby. Away from all of them.

It stopped.

Hung there. A glass arm sticking up out of a Lantern on a cottage floor like a reed out of a pond. Fingers spread. Feeling the air.

"*Oh*," said Ysenne. From the pane. Puzzled. "*What did you—*"

"*Stick*," said Arion.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO PUT IT IN his hand.

His stick. Plain ash. Brannoc had cut it for him in the winter, when he first started needing the chair, and he'd used it to get from the chair to the bed and the bed to the chair and, once, the morning he fell, to reach for a cup he shouldn't have reached for.

It was heavy. It had never felt heavy before.

He held it across his knees.

"*Seren*," he said.

"*I'm here*."

"*Help me sit up*."

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T ARGUE EITHER.

She put her arm behind his back and lifted. And he felt his hip catch and his breath catch and something in his chest turn over like a fish. And then he was sitting. On the edge of the bed. With his bare feet on the cold flags and his wife's arm round him and his stick across his knees.

Looking down at the Lantern on the floor.

At the glass arm reaching up out of it.

At the face in the pane below it. Tiny. Pale. Turning. Looking up at him through her own arm.

"*Arion*," said the Glass Queen. "*What are you doing?*"

"*Talking to you*," said Arion Vey. "*Before I do anything else. It's manners.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ARM WENT STILL.

He watched it. He watched her. He'd been watching people for two hundred years, across tables, across courtrooms, across the long desk under the window in the Warden-Architect's study. He knew what it looked like when someone stopped to listen.

"*I knew your sister*," he said.

The face in the pane didn't move.

"*Not well*," he said. "*Not long. At the end.*" He shifted his grip on the stick. "*She sat on the floor of the Hall of Lanterns and told the Queen of Caldor the truest lie I ever heard. Every word true. Every word arranged.*" A faint smile. "*She came to my rooms in the Spire one night and offered me twenty years from her hands. And I took them. For an hour. And then I gave them back.*"

"*I know*," whispered Ysenne. "*Orrin told us. In the hall. When we woke.*"

"*She was very lonely*," said Arion. "*Your sister. Did you know?*"

The face in the pane didn't answer.

"*She was the loneliest person I've ever met*," said Arion. "*Two hundred and thirty-four years. Wardens and kings and Crowned. She was the loneliest of all of them. She told me so. In my study. With her lit eyes. She said, I've been cold my whole life, old man, right in the middle, and I've never known why.*"

"*She was always cold*," said Ysenne. Very quietly.

"*Yes*."

"*Even when we were girls. Even in summer.*" The tiny face tilted. "*She used to sit at the windows. Every window. Any window. Looking out.*" A pause. "*I used to sit at the mirrors. Looking in.*"

"*I know*," said Arion. "*You told Seren. In the Hall of Lanterns. Nine hundred years in a palace of mirrors. And she asked you how it had been.*"

The glass arm trembled. Just slightly. In the air.

"*And you said lonely*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COTTAGE WAS VERY quiet.

Pim on the floor by the bed, cross-legged, with his eyes shut and his hands open and his face white, making room. Antho at the door, his hand flat on the wood. Hask behind him, enormous, with gold dust sliding off his shoulders onto the flags. Wren against the far wall with the baby on her chest and her gold-fingered hand flat on the baby's back.

Seren beside him. With her arm round him. Holding him up.

The Lantern on the floor. Blazing. Gold. With a glass arm sticking up out of it.

And the face in the pane. Looking up at him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The child looked at you*," said Arion.

The face went still.

"*In the loft*," he said. "*In the window. The first night. Wren told us.*" He leaned forward. A little. On his stick. It hurt. "*And on the stepping stones. Just now. I heard it through the door. You said, you were the first one in nine hundred years.*"

"*She looked at me*," whispered the Glass Queen. "*Not at the glass. At me.*"

"*Why do you think that is*?"

The face didn't answer.

"*I'll tell you*," said Arion. "*Since I'm old and there isn't much time and I may as well be useful.*" He shifted his weight. His hip screamed. He ignored it. "*Everyone who looks into glass sees themselves. That's what glass is for. That's what you've always been.*

A thing people look into to see their own faces." He looked down at the tiny pale face in the pane. *"Nobody looks at the glass. Not ever. They look through it. Past it. At themselves."*

The arm was very still.

"She's five months old," said Arion Vey. *"She doesn't know what she looks like. She's never seen herself. She hasn't got a self yet, not really. Not the kind you see in a mirror."* A faint smile. *"So when she looks into glass, there's nobody there for her to see."*

The face in the pane didn't move.

"Except you," said Arion.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD SEREN'S BREATH catch beside him.

He didn't look at her. He looked at the pane.

"She's the only person in the world who can see you," he said. *"Because she's the only person in the world who isn't looking for herself."* He leaned on the stick. *"And you want to take her to your brother. So he can put a crown on her. And keep her."*

"Arion—"

"And then she'll be gold," said Arion. Very gently. *"Five months old forever. With her eyes open. Looking at nothing."* He tilted his head. *"Kept things can't see, Ysenne. You know that. You've walked past nine thousand of them. Their eyes move. They follow you. But they don't* see.*"

The arm trembled.

"If he keeps her," said Arion Vey, *"you'll never be looked at again."*

◆ ◆ ◆

SILENCE.

Total. The fire. The dust at the edge of Pim's room, hanging in the air, glittering. The baby breathing against Wren's chest.

And the glass arm, sticking up out of the Lantern on the floor. Trembling.

And then pulling back.

◆ ◆ ◆

SLOWLY. AN INCH. TWO. Down. Into the pane. The way a hand draws back from a stove.

"I'm only looking," whispered Ysenne. Very small. *"I told her. I only wanted to look."*

"I know," said Arion.

"Oz wants her. Not me. I don't want anything. I just look." The arm was half in the pane now. The fingers still out, spread. Still reaching. *"I'm supposed to bring him*

something. The child. Or the blood. Something. He sent me. I'm supposed to bring him back what he needs."

"*Then go home*," said Arion. "*Tell him you couldn't. Tell him the old man stopped you.*" A faint smile. "*He won't believe you. He'll think it's very funny. But tell him.*"

The fingers hung in the air above the pane.

"*I can't*," said Ysenne.

"*Why not*?"

"*Because he's my brother*," said the Glass Queen. "*And I've never once told him no.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE ARM CAME out again.

Fast. All at once. Not reaching up. *Bending*. At the elbow. At the wrist. The glass arm curling over like a striking snake, turning, the fingers swinging round toward the bed. Toward him. Toward the woman beside him.

Toward the baby, against the wall, behind them both.

Seren moved.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T THINK. ARION knew she didn't. He'd known her for thirty-two years, twice, and she'd never once thought before she moved toward something that was trying to hurt someone she loved.

She let go of him.

And put out her hand.

And caught the glass wrist as it came round.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD IT. A small sound. Sharp. Like a nail scraping a pane.

He saw her face.

Not pain. Harrow women don't show pain. *Surprise*. The face of a woman who has grabbed a bramble without looking and only now feels the thorns.

The glass fingers had closed on her palm.

Five of them. Long. Fine. Clear. Edged like broken glass, because they *were* glass, because that was all the Glass Queen was. Closed round Seren's square freckled hand.

And red was running into them.

◆ ◆ ◆

Not dripping. *Running in*. Up. Into the glass. Into the fingers. The way water runs up into a dry cloth. Seren's blood, from the cuts in her palm, running up into the glass hand like dye into a lens.

The fingers went red.

Then the hand.

Then the wrist.

A glass arm filling with blood. Red. Dark. Swirling. Like wine poured slowly into a goblet.

And the face in the pane below it—

Arion saw it.

It closed its eyes.

The way you close your eyes when you taste something you've been hungry for for a very long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," whispered Ysenne. "*Oh. Hesper's.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

He didn't know he was going to. He'd known for a month that he couldn't. Ilsa had told him. *Not without help. Not without the chair. Not with that hip.*

He stood up.

Off the edge of the bed. Onto the cold flags. With his bare feet and his bad hip and his wife's blood running up into a glass arm a yard from his face.

Something in his chest turned over. Hard. Like a fish on a line. Like a fist closing.

He didn't care.

He'd been careful for two hundred years. He'd been careful for so long. He'd sealed his sons in the dark and himself in crystal and written forty pages instead of saying a single word out loud, because it was careful, because it was right, because he was always right.

He wasn't careful now.

He took off his spectacles.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D PUT THEM ON without thinking, when Antho put the Lantern down. The way he always did when something needed looking at. Folded on the table by the bed. He'd unfolded them and put them on.

He took them off now. In one hand. The left. And held them out.

Over the Lantern. Over the pane. Lens down.

Facing the glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

A MIRROR-WARD NEEDS TWO mirrors.

That was the whole of it. That was all it had ever been, since the first one, since the cat. Two pieces of glass, facing. Each one showing the other. Each one showing the other showing it. Over and over. A corridor. Going on forever into the glass.

The Lantern's pane, facing up.

His spectacle lens, facing down.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND YSENNE LOOKED.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW HER LOOK. In the pane. Her eyes snapping open. Her tiny pale face turning. Up. Toward the lens. Toward the thing hanging above her that shone.

Because she couldn't not look. Because she never had. Because she was the Glass Queen, and glass was a thing that showed you your face, and she'd sat in front of it for nine hundred years and looked.

And in the lens she saw herself.

And in the pane, under her, herself again. Seeing herself in the lens.

And in the lens, herself in the pane, seeing herself in the lens.

And again.

And again.

A corridor of Ysennes. Pale. White-haired. Grey-eyed. Glass-crowned. Going down into the pane and up into the lens, smaller and smaller, further and further, forever. Every one of them looking at the next one. Every one of them alone.

Nine hundred years of her own face.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ARM STOPPED.

In the air. Halfway out of the pane. Red to the elbow with Seren's blood. Its fingers still closed round Seren's hand.

Stopped.

"*Oh*," whispered the face in the pane. In the lens. In every pane and every lens, all the way down the corridor. A hundred thousand voices. All the same. All very small. "*Oh, no. No. Not this. Not again.*"

"*I'm sorry*," said Arion.

He was. He'd never meant anything more in his life.

"*Please*," said the Glass Queen. "*Please. Arion. Not this. I can't—I can't look away—I've been looking at it for nine hundred years, please, I'll go, I'll go home, I'll tell him no, please—*"

"*Let go of her hand*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FINGERS OPENED.

All five. All at once. The way a hand opens when it's been burned. Seren's hand came free. Red. Cut across the palm in five fine lines. Bleeding.

She didn't make a sound. She pulled her hand back against her chest and held it there with the other one and didn't make a sound.

The glass arm hung in the air above the Lantern. Red to the elbow. Swirling. Full.

And the face in the pane below it looked up into the lens above it, and down into the pane below it, and up, and down, and couldn't stop.

"*Please*," it whispered.

"*Antho*," said Arion.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS SON WAS BESIDE him.

Arion didn't know when he'd moved. He was just there. At his elbow. Holding him up. The way Seren had been.

"*The stick*," said Arion. "*I can't lift it. You'll have to help.*"

Antho didn't ask why.

He put his hand over Arion's on the stick. Young hand. Scarred. Burned across the knuckles from eight years of a hunger burning through it. Over old hand. Spotted. Thin. Shaking.

"*The pane*," said Arion.

"*It's my Lantern*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*You made it. Lex made it. In Malachi's valley. With HUSH twelve times and SHELTER.*" His voice didn't shake. "*It held the Murmur off for six years.*"

"*I know.*"

"*I haven't needed it in three*," said Antho Vey.

And they brought the stick down together.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PANE BROKE.

Not loudly. A crack. Sharp. Bright. Like ice on a pond in the first frost, when a child stamps on it to see if it'll hold. The Lantern's pane, the one facing up, starring under the end of the ash stick. Splitting. Splintering into a hundred pieces.

And the corridor broke with it.

Every Ysenne. All the way down. All the way up. Gone. Shattered. A hundred thousand tiny pale faces flying apart into a hundred thousand splinters of light.

And the arm—

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ARM CAME APART.

From the elbow down. Where it met the pane. Into shards. Clear. Glittering. Falling. Raining down onto the flags round the Lantern with a sound like a handful of coins thrown on a stone floor.

All except one.

The hand. The red one. The one that had held Seren's. Full of her blood. Swirling.

It didn't fall.

It *dropped*. Straight down. Into the broken pane. Through it. Into the Lantern. Into the flame. Into the light.

And was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD HER.

Very far away. Very small. Going down. Down through the glass. Through the light. Through every pane and every reflection between Harrow and the edge of the world, down, away, west, a thin high sound fading like a finger lifted off the rim of a glass.

Not a scream.

A laugh.

Small. Surprised. Delighted. A girl's laugh. In a room full of mirrors.

"...I've got it..." whispered Ysenne. Fading. *"...a little...enough...oh, Arion...I'm sorry...I've got it..."*

And then nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT DOWN.

He didn't decide to. His legs decided. They went out from under him the way they'd gone out from under him the morning he reached for the cup, and he sat down hard on the edge of the bed, and Antho's arm caught him, and Seren's.

The thing in his chest that had turned over like a fish closed like a fist.

He couldn't breathe.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT FURTHER THAN HALFWAY. Not even halfway. A quarter. Less. A breath that went in and caught and stopped and wouldn't go any further. Like a door jammed. Like a drawer that sticks.

He sat on the edge of the bed with his son on one side and his wife on the other and tried to breathe and couldn't.

"*Arion*," said Seren. Very close. Her hand on his face. Her cut hand. Wet. "*Arion. Breathe. Breathe. Look at me. Breathe.*"

He looked at her.

Her face. Square. Freckled. Flour on the cheek, because there was always flour on her cheek, even now, even here, even with her blood on her hand and gold dust drifting at the edge of a boy's silence.

I turned back twice, he thought. *And then I didn't.*

He breathed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT PAST THE place where it stuck.

Not far. A little. Just past. Like a cart wheel jolting over a stone. And then out. And then in again. Shallow. Short. But in.

He sat on the edge of the bed and breathed. In. Catch. Out. In.

"*There*," said Seren. Her voice was breaking up. Like ice. "*There. There you are. There.*"

"*Here*," said Arion Vey.

He didn't know why he said it. It came out of him. A word. The word on the base of a little iron lantern across the stream, gold now, kept, on a sill.

"*Here*," he said again.

"*I know*," said his wife. "*I know you are.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LAID HIM DOWN.

He felt them do it. Antho's arms under his shoulders. Seren's under his knees. Lifting him. Laying him back on the pillows. Pulling the blanket up. Very carefully. As if he were made of glass.

He supposed he was, now. A little.

He lay on his back under the boarded west window and looked at the dark beams and breathed. In. Catch. Out. And felt something he'd never felt before in two hundred and thirty-four years.

He felt *finished*.

Not dying. Not yet. He could tell. He'd sat by enough beds. He knew what it looked like from the outside, and he was beginning to learn what it felt like from inside. It wasn't that. Not tonight.

But finished. Like a ledger with the last column added. Like a letter with the last line written. Like a wall with the last stone set. Nothing else would go on it now. Nothing else would be built. It would stand, for a while. And then it wouldn't.

It's like being very tired, he'd told her. In his spectacles. In the dark. *At the end of a very good day.*

He'd been right. He was always right.

It was the worst thing about him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Did she get it*?" he said. To the beams. Very quietly.

Nobody answered.

"*The blood*," said Arion. "*Seren's. In the hand. Did she get it?*"

"*Yes*," said Antho.

He was sitting on the floor by the bed. Arion could hear him. Could hear him breathing. Hear him picking up the shards of glass round the Lantern, one by one, very carefully, the way you'd pick up the pieces of something that mattered.

"*She got it*," said his son. "*The hand went into the Lantern. Into the light. West.*" A pause. "*She got enough.*"

"*Enough for what*?" said Wren. From the wall.

Nobody answered that either.

They didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST STOPPED FALLING at dawn.

He heard it stop. Lying on his back with his eyes shut, breathing. He heard the soft dry hiss of it outside the boarded windows go quiet. Heard the wind change. Heard, far off, very faint, a voice like sand poured from a sack.

Forgive me.

Going west.

And then the birds.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CAME ACROSS AT sunrise.

Arion heard him. The stepping stones. The ramp. The door. And then his son in the doorway, stopping. With his hands black and his face grey and his eyes red-rimmed, as if he'd been holding black heat all night with no light at all.

Which he had.

He looked at the room.

At Pim, asleep on the floor by the bed, curled on his side like a cat, his small face white with exhaustion. At Hask, sitting against the wall with his eyes shut and gold dust round him on the flags in a ring, untouched. At Wren, on the floor beside Hask, with the baby asleep on her chest and her left hand flat on the baby's back, four fingers shining gold.

At Antho, cross-legged by the Lantern, with a little heap of glass shards in his lap.

At Seren, sitting on the edge of the bed, with her right hand wrapped in a clean strip of linen, already spotted red through. Holding his hand with her left.

At him.

"*Father*," said Lex.

"*Good morning*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS SON CAME AND knelt by the bed.

He didn't say anything. He took his father's other hand. The one Seren wasn't holding. In both of his. And held it.

It was so cold. Arion could tell. He could see it in his son's face.

"*I stood up*," said Arion.

Lex looked at him.

"*Ilsa said I couldn't*," said his father. "*Without help. Without the chair. She was very clear about it.*" A faint smile. "*I stood up anyway. I was very careful about not being careful.*" He breathed. In. Catch. Out. "*I've been careful for two hundred years, Lex. I'd forgotten what it felt like not to be.*"

"*What did it feel like*?"

Arion thought about it.

"*Like coming round a corner*," he said. "*In the rain.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*How long*?" said Lex.

He didn't say it to his father. He said it to the room. To his mother. To Antho. To nobody.

Nobody answered.

"*How long*," said Lex again. "*Ilsa will know. She'll come and put her hands on him and she'll know.*" His voice was shaking. "*Before I go. Before we cross. I need to know how long.*"

"*Before the year turns*," said Antho.

Lex looked at him.

"*The Ferryman said*," said his brother. Very quietly. Holding the glass shards in his lap. "*On the shingle. To Mam and me. Before the year turns.*" A pause. "*Before Lantern Night.*"

"*That's four months*."

"*Less*," said Arion.

They looked at him.

"*It's less*," he said. To the beams. "*I can feel it. I don't know how much less. I'm not the Ferryman.*" He breathed. "*But I was very old before tonight. And tonight I stood up.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

Seren held his hand. Lex held the other. The baby breathed against Wren's chest. Pim slept. Outside, the birds.

"*Go*," said Arion.

Lex's grip tightened.

"*Go*," said his father again. "*Both of you. Across. Through the crack. Get the crown. Bring it back.*" He turned his head on the pillow. Slowly. To look at his sons. One kneeling by the bed. One on the floor with a lap full of glass. "*She's got your mother's blood now. Ysenne. She'll take it to the Veil. To the crack. And the crack will open wider.*"

"*Wide enough for him*," said Antho.

"*Wide enough for him*," agreed Arion. "*Not yet. Not quite. But soon.*" He looked at Lex. "*He said he'd come to the door. For tea. Seren told me. Through the rose.*" A ghost of a smile. "*I'd like to be here when he does.*"

"*Father—*"

"*And I'd like you to be back by then*," said Arion Vey. "*With the crown. So when he knocks, there's someone at the door who can say no and mean it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I won't go*," said Lex.

His father looked at him.

"*I won't*," said his son. "*Not now. Not like this. You can't*—you stood up. You stood up and you can't breathe and you might*—"

"*I might*," agreed Arion. "*I might tomorrow. I might next week. I might on Lantern Night with a gold king at the table.*" His voice was very gentle. "*I might whether you're here or not, Lex. That's the thing about it. You can't stop it by staying.*"

"*I can be here*."

"*You can*," said his father. "*And Caddoc comes down the thread. And the Gilded King turns the Key. And picks up the net. And keeps it.*" He looked at his son. "*And Lark grows up in a world where she's whatever the Stone says she is. Forever. With a Ceiling. With nothing new.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*Or he comes here*," said Arion. "*Through the crack. When it's wide enough. And puts a crown on her. And she's five months old for a thousand years.*"

His son's face broke.

"*Go*," said Arion Vey. "*Please. Go and get the crown. It's the only thing left that can say no.*" His hand tightened. As much as it could. Which wasn't much. "*And then come home. And tell me about it. I'll be at the window. Every evening. Looking west.*"

"*You can't get to the window*."

"*Then I'll be in the bed*," said his father. "*Looking at the boards over the window. Imagining west.*" A faint smile. "*I've got a very good imagination. I drew a map of the whole world from the inside with a pendulum.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT HIS HEAD down.

On the blanket. On his father's chest. The way a child puts his head down at the end of a long day.

Arion lifted his hand. Slowly. It took a long time. And put it on his son's hair. Dark. Curly. Cut badly, because he cut it himself, because he always had.

And left it there.

"*I'll try*," he said. "*To be here. I'll try very hard.*"

"*It's not enough*," said Lex. Into the blanket.

"*No*," said Arion Vey. "*It never is.*"

He stroked his son's hair. Very slowly. The way Seren used to, Ember said. Twenty-two years ago. In a cottage. In the night. When the boys were small and frightened of the noises in the walls.

"*But it's all anyone's got*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO MENDED THE LANTERN that afternoon.

Arion watched him. From the bed. Through the open curtain. His son at the table with the Keeper's Lantern in front of him and a little heap of glass shards and a strip of scraped horn that Lex had brought across from his own cottage.

He didn't throw the shards away. He laid them out on a cloth. Every one. Very carefully. In a pattern Arion couldn't see.

Then he fitted the horn into the empty frame where the pane had been.

He held it up. To the light from the open door.

Three panes of glass. Clear. And one of horn. Pale. Cloudy. You could see light through it. Nothing else.

"*It doesn't match*," said Antho.

"*No*," said Arion.

"*It'll never match*." His son turned the Lantern in his hands. Slowly. Looking at it. "*Three that show everything. One that shows nothing.*" A pause. "*I don't mind. I like it. It looks like it's been somewhere.*"

"*It has*," said Arion.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO PUT THE LANTERN down. On the table. By the bed. Where his father could see it.

And lit it.

The flame came up. Gold. Steady. Behind three panes of glass and one of horn. Throwing three clear squares of light on the walls of the cottage, and one soft gold blur.

"*Keep it*," said Antho.

Arion looked at him.

"*While we're gone*," said his son. "*Keep it lit. By the bed.*" He didn't look at his father. He looked at the Lantern. "*It held the dark off me for six years. In the cave. In the Keep. At the bottom of the world.*" His voice was very quiet. "*I thought it might hold it off you. For a few weeks. Till we're home.*"

Arion didn't say anything for a long time.

Then he reached out. Slowly. Across the blanket. And put his spotted hand flat on the iron of the Lantern. On the side with the horn. Warm.

"*Thank you*," he said.

"*It's yours*," said Antho Vey. "*It always was. You were the one who taught Lex the runes.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LEFT ON THE third day.

Arion didn't see them go. He couldn't get to the window. He heard it. The dragons in the clearing. Vharuun's great slow wingbeats. Ashka's quicker ones. Voices. Wren's, sharp, saying something to Lex that made him laugh, cracked and sudden. Seren's, from the doorway, saying something he couldn't hear.

Lark. Crying. Once. And stopping.

And then the wings. Lifting. Going.

West.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN CAME BACK IN.

She shut the blue door behind her. And stood with her back against it. The way she stood at doors.

Then she came across the room. And sat down on the edge of the bed. With her bandaged hand in her lap.

"*They've gone*," she said.

"*I know*."

"*Lex said tell you—*" She stopped. "*He said tell you he'll be back before the year turns.*"

"*He doesn't make promises he can't keep either*," said Arion. "*Does he.*"

"*No*." Seren looked at the Lantern. At the three clear panes and the one of horn. "*He said tell you he'll try.*"

Arion closed his eyes.

"*Good*," he said. "*That's all anyone's got.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LAY DOWN BESIDE him.

On top of the blankets. With her bare feet cold and her head on the edge of his pillow and her bandaged hand on his chest. Over his heart. Counting.

In. Catch. Out.

In.

The Lantern burned on the table. Three clear squares of light on the walls. One soft blur.

"*Arion*," said Seren. Very quietly.

"*Mm*."

"*What you said to her. To Ysenne. About the baby.*" She was quiet. "*That Lark's the only one who can see her. Because she isn't looking for herself.*"

"*Mm*."

"*Was it true*?"

He thought about it. With his eyes shut. In the dark. Breathing.

"*I don't know*," he said at last. "*I think so. I hope so.*"

"*You don't know*?"

"*I'm two hundred and thirty-four*," said Arion Vey. "*I've just found out I don't know a great many things.*" A faint smile. "*It's very restful.*"

She laughed. Into his pillow. Cracked. Wet.

"*You were right, though*," she said. "*It worked. She let go.*"

"*I'm always right*," said her husband. "*It's the worst thing about me.*"

"*No*," said Seren Harrow. "*It's not.*"

He opened his eyes.

She was looking at him. In the Lantern-light. With her brown eyes very steady.

"*The worst thing about you*," said his wife, "*is that you stood up.*"

He didn't answer.

"*And it's the best thing too*," she said. "*I want that noted. In the grey book. Somewhere. Both.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WROTE IT THAT night.

Under the first two lines. In the dark. By the light of the Lantern with one horn pane. In a hand so shaking it was barely writing at all.

Arion Vey. Of the Spire. And of Harrow.

He turned back twice. And then he didn't.

And under that—

He stood up.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT THE PENCIL back in the binding. And closed the book.

And lay back on the pillow with his wife asleep beside him and her hand on his chest, and the Lantern burning on the table, and the boards over the west window.

And imagined west.

He had a very good imagination.

He could see it all.

CHAPTER 18

Blood on the Glass

ANTHO HAD NEVER LEFT anyone behind on purpose before.

He'd been left. He'd been left at sixteen, in a burning cottage, with his mother walking into the dark and his brother screaming in the yard. He'd left, at sixteen, running into the Greyspine with a hunger in his head. But he'd never stood in a doorway and looked at someone he loved and decided, with his whole heart, to go.

He did it at Harrow on the third morning after midsummer.

His father was in the bed. Propped on three pillows. With the Lantern on the table beside him, three panes of glass and one of horn, burning. His face on the pillow was a walnut. His hair a white wisp. His breath short. In. Catch. Out.

His eyes the same.

"*Go on*," said Arion. "*You're letting the draught in.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO DIDN'T GO.

He stood in the doorway of the blue-door cottage with his pack on his back and Ashka steaming in the clearing behind him and looked at his father.

He'd known him for four years.

That was the thing. That was the thing that kept catching in his chest like a fishbone. Four years. Since Avaloria. Since a gold room and a man in crystal and a voice saying *my sons*. Four years, out of thirty. And for the first twenty-six he'd thought his father was a story. A Warden who'd gone away. A name his mother wouldn't say.

And for three of the four, his father had lived at the Lantern Keep. With him. Keeping the door. Reading in the library while Antho counted the lanterns. Sitting at the long table at breakfast with his porridge going cold while he argued with Seraphine about the Founders.

Antho had never said anything.

Not *thank you*. Not *I'm glad*. Not *I used to lie awake in the cave and wonder what you sounded like*.

He'd thought there'd be time.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*," said his father.

"*I know*."

"*You've got the face*," said Arion. "*The one your brother gets. Like someone's handed you a bill you can't pay.*" A faint smile. "*You're both very bad at hiding it. You get it from me.*"

"*I never—*"

"*I know*," said his father.

Antho stopped.

"*I know*," said Arion again. Very gently. From the pillow. "*You never said. Any of it. Three years at the Keep and you never said a word.*" His grey eyes were very steady. "*Neither did I. I'm your father. I'm the one who's meant to.*" A pause. "*I wrote it all down instead. Forty pages. For your mother. I never wrote a single page for you.*"

"*You didn't have to*."

"*No*," agreed Arion. "*You were right there. Every morning. Across the table.*" He breathed. In. Catch. Out. "*I used to watch you count the lanterns, Antho. Every night. From the top of the passage stair. You never knew I was there.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

"*One thousand, one hundred and thirteen*," said his father. "*Every night. Out loud. To the door.*" A ghost of a smile. "*I used to count with you. Under my breath. I never lost count once.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO CAME BACK INTO the room.

He didn't decide to. His feet did it. They took him back across the flags to the bed, and he knelt down beside it, with his pack still on his back, and took his father's hand.

It was so cold.

"*I used to lie awake*," said Antho. "*In the cave. In the Greyspine. With the Murmur in my head.*" He didn't look up. "*And I used to wonder what you sounded like. Mam never said. Nobody did. I used to make up voices. Lying in the dark. Trying to hear it.*"

His father didn't move.

"*None of them were right*," said Antho Vey. "*When I heard it. At Avaloria. In the gold room.*" His voice cracked. "*None of them were anywhere near.*"

"*What did you make up*?"

"*Deep*," said Antho. "*Like a bell. Like a mountain. Like a king in a story.*" A wet sound that might have been a laugh. "*And then you opened your mouth and you sounded like a librarian telling off a choir.*"

His father laughed.

The real laugh. The wide startled one. It came out of him short and cracked and broken off in the middle by the catch in his chest, and he coughed, and Antho held his hand through it, and when it was over his father was still smiling.

"*Your mother said that*," said Arion. "*On the steps. In the rain. The first time.*"

"*I know. She told me.*"

"*Page four*," said his father.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Go*," said Arion. "*Please. I'll be here.*"

"*You'll try*."

"*I'll try*," agreed his father. "*Very hard. I've never tried so hard at anything in my life. Not the Root. Not the crystal. Not the map.*" His hand tightened. As much as it could. "*I'll be in this bed with that Lantern burning and I'll breathe in and out until you walk back through that door. That's all I'm going to do. That's my whole job now.*"

Antho bent his head.

And put his forehead down on his father's hand. On the blanket. And stayed there.

"*Thank you*," he said. Into the blanket. Very quietly. "*For counting.*"

His father's other hand came down. Onto his hair. Black. Long. Wild. The way it had always been.

"*Thank you for letting me*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WALKED HIM to the door.

She stood on the oak ramp in her bare feet with her bandaged hand held against her chest and looked at him. At Ashka. At the clearing, gold in patches, the birch tree at the edge of it standing shining in the morning sun like a thing made by a jeweller.

"*Bring your brother back*," she said.

"*I will*."

"*Bring yourself back*." She reached up. With her good hand. And put it on his face. His thin face. His wild beard. "*I lost you once. For thirteen years. On the other side of a door.*" Her eyes were very bright. "*Don't you dare make me do it again.*"

"*I won't*."

"*You'll try*," said Seren.

"*I'll try*," said Antho. "*Very hard.*"

She looked at him for a long moment.

"*You get that from him*," she said. And kissed him. On the forehead. Quickly. Fiercely. Like a seal stamped.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOPPED AT THE pool on the way.

They had to. For the last cups. Ivy had filled two more since midsummer. That made fourteen. Fourteen Hush-cups, each with an iron lid that sighed, each one heavy with nothing, wrapped in straw in a basket on Pim's back.

Pim wouldn't let anyone else carry it.

"*It's mine*," he said. When Lex offered. Three words. A speech. "*Ivy gave them to me.*"

Ivy Moss was sitting on the rim. Where she always sat. She didn't get up when they came. She looked at Pim for a long time with her strange light eyes.

Then she held out her hand.

There was something in it. Small. Folded. A piece of paper.

Pim took it. Unfolded it. Looked at it.

Antho saw over his shoulder. A drawing. In pencil. Of a cat. A small one. Sitting very straight. With its tail curled round its feet. Looking out of the paper with a fierce determined expression.

No words.

Pim folded it up again. Very carefully. And put it inside his blue coat. In the pocket over his heart. And buttoned the pocket.

He didn't say anything.

He reached into his other pocket. And took out a piece of paper. Folded. And held it out.

Ivy took it. Unfolded it.

A cat. In pencil. A little bigger. Sitting on the rim of a pool. With its feet over the edge.

No words.

Ivy looked at it for a long time.

Then she folded it up. And held it against her chest. And looked back at the pool.

"*It says come back*," she said. Not to anyone. To the deep. "*Mal. It says, little room-maker, come back.*"

"*I will*," said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK CAME WITH THEM.

He didn't trust dragons. He'd said so. Twice. He'd walked two days to Harrow so he wouldn't have to fly.

He got on Vharuun's back behind Lex at the pool without a word, and sat there with his pick across his knees and his hands white on the haft, and his eyes shut.

"*It's three days to the Veil on foot*," said Lex. Turning round. "*Less than one on Vharuun.*"

"*I know*," said Silas Hask. Not opening his eyes.

"*You could walk. We'd wait.*"

"*I know.*"

"*Then why—*"

"*Because the old man's got four months*," said Hask. "*Less. He said so.*" His jaw was very tight. "*I'm not wasting three days of them because I don't like heights.*"

Lex looked at him for a long moment.

Then he turned round. And laid his hand on the dragon's neck.

Gently, he thought. *Please. Very gently.*

Vharuun went up so smoothly that Hask didn't open his eyes until they were over the downs.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO FLEW WITH PIM.

On Ashka. With the boy in front of him, small and thin in his blue coat, and the basket of Hush-cups strapped between them. With his arms round Pim and the basket both.

Pim didn't say anything. For hours. He looked down. At the green of the Blightmarch going away behind them. At the western shires. At the bare grey of the Sundered Lands coming up ahead, cracked and dead and endless, with the wind coming off it cold.

And then, somewhere over the bare lands, with the Veil a grey smudge on the edge of the world ahead—

"*Antho.*"

"*Pim.*"

"*What's it like*?"

Antho didn't need to ask what.

"*I don't know*," he said. "*Nobody does. Nobody living.*" He looked ahead. At the grey. "*The Ferryman's been. Hesper never went. Maelis came out of it.*" A pause. "*Ysenne says it's dust and glass and no sun.*"

Pim was quiet for a while.

"*Is it like the Hollow*?" he said. "*Before. When it was hungry.*"

Antho thought about it.

He thought about eight years in a cave with a voice in his head. About a crack in him, opening onto a dark that wanted. About the cold. About the *need*.

"*No*," he said slowly. "*The Hollow was empty. It wanted to be filled.*" He looked at the grey smudge on the horizon. "*I think the Court's the opposite. I think it's full. All the way. And it doesn't want anything at all.*"

Pim didn't say anything.

But Antho felt him lean back. Just a little. Against his chest.

◆ ◆ ◆

GREYFALL AT DUSK.

Roole met them on the landing field below the walls with a lantern in his good hand and his stiff arm held close. He watched the dragons come down. He watched Hask climb off Vharuun's back, grey-faced, and stand on the grass with his hand on the dragon's flank, breathing.

"*You came*," said Roole.

"*We said we would*."

"*People say a great many things*," said Commander Roole. He looked at them. All four. Lex and Antho and Pim and Hask. "*Come and see it. While there's light.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GOLD HAD GROWN.

Antho saw it from the walls of Greyfall in the last red light of the sun. A great soft stain spreading out from the foot of the Veil across the bare grey ground. Not a mile across now. Five. Six. Reaching almost to the fort. Shining dully in the dusk like a lake of old brass.

The tongue of it running west to the crack was wider. Much wider. And at the end of it—

"*It's bigger*," said Lex. Very quietly. Beside him. "*Isn't it.*"

"*Since midsummer*," said Roole. "*Three nights ago. We felt it from here.*" His hatchet face was very still. "*Something came out of the west on the wind. In the middle*

of the night. A light. Like a falling star going the wrong way. Up off the ground and into the crack." A pause. *"And the crack opened."*

"How wide?"

Roole looked at him.

"Come and see," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

NAN ASHBY WAS STILL there.

Antho saw her as they came down off the walls and out across the bare ground toward the gold. Sitting on the grey at the very edge of it. Where she'd sat every day since the spring. With her shawl round her shoulders and her basket beside her.

Talking.

She looked up as they came. At Lex. At the mark on his cheek.

"You came back," she said.

"I said I'd find out," said Lex.

"And did you?"

He knelt down beside her. On the grey. At the edge of the gold. And looked across it. At the field. At the forty gold sheep, heads down, grazing. At the one tall thin gold shape among them. Mid-step. Mid-whistle. His crook in his hand.

His eyes moving.

"There's a way," said Lex. *"Not with him. Not yet. He's set. He's finished."* He swallowed. *"But I found the room in front of it. In a girl. In Ashbourne. Before it set."* He looked at Nan Ashby. *"So there's a way. Somewhere. There has to be. Everything's a crack first."*

She looked at him for a long time.

"That's more than anyone else has said," said Nan Ashby. And turned back to her son. And went on talking. About the hens. About the byre roof. About the smith who'd come back.

The gold boy's eyes moved. Slowly. From his mother. To Lex.

And stayed there.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CRACK WAS A door.

Not a door like a door. Not oak and iron. But a *door*. Antho felt it as soon as they came round the end of the tongue of gold and saw it. A Threshold Warden feels doors. That was what he was.

It was taller than a man now. As tall as two men. A dark seam at the foot of the grey, running up from the ground like a tear in a curtain. And wide. Not a finger.

Not a hand. Wide enough for a man to turn sideways and squeeze through. Wide enough for a thin man to walk.

Dark.

Grey-gold dust sifting out of it. Not a trickle now. A *flow*. Like sand out of a sack with a slit in it. Pouring out onto the ground in a soft glittering heap and the wind picking it up and carrying it east.

And thorns.

Black. Hooked. Thick as a man's wrist. Dozens of them. Hundreds. Growing out of the dark of the crack and down into the ground on either side and up the edges of it like ivy up a wall. Gripping. Pushing. Widening.

And on the edges of the crack, on the grey of the Veil itself, where the thorns gripped it—

Red.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WENT CLOSER.

He couldn't help it. He was a Threshold Warden. He went up to the door.

The red was on the edge. On the lip of the crack, where the grey of the Veil met the dark. A stain. Dark. Dried. A hand's breadth across. As if someone had reached through the crack from the other side and laid a hand there. A wet red hand. And held it against the edge of the world until the edge gave.

Glass-shards glittered in it. Tiny. Clear. Like frost in a bloodstain.

I've got it, Ysenne had said. Fading. Laughing. *A little. Enough.*

His mother's blood.

On the edge of the world.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT HIS HAND out.

Not to the stain. To the Veil beside it. The grey. The edge.

It didn't push.

He'd known it wouldn't. Lex had told him. But knowing and feeling were different things, and he stood at the foot of the edge of the world with his hand an inch from the grey and felt nothing. No push. No *not you*. Nothing.

And on the other side of the crack, through the dark, faint—

He felt it.

◆ ◆ ◆

DOORS.

Not this one. Others. Beyond. On the far side. In the grey country.

A great many doors. Thousands. Standing open. Every one. Wide open. Hanging on their hinges in a country where there had been no one to keep out and no one to keep in for nine hundred years.

And behind them—

Nothing. No rooms. No hallways. No warmth. No one coming home.

Just *full*. Like the gold. Like Bet Dale's door, bricked up so smooth you couldn't see where it had been.

A country of open doors with nowhere to go.

He took his hand back.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*," said Lex. Behind him.

"*I know*."

"*It's big*."

"*It's big enough for a thin man*," said Antho. He didn't turn round. He was looking at the crack. At the thorns. At the red. "*Not big enough for a king. Not yet. Not quite.*"

"*He's big*," said Lex. "*Mam says. Ysenne said. Taller than Brannoc. Broader.*"

"*He's not coming through that*," said Antho. "*Not yet.*"

"*And when we open it*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The wind blew. Off the Veil. Cold. Carrying gold.

They stood at the foot of the edge of the world in the last of the dusk. Four of them. Two brothers. A boy with a basket on his back. A hewer with a pick. And behind them, Roole, with his lantern, with his stiff arm, with his face like a hatchet.

"*It's Harrow blood that opens it*," said Antho at last. Slowly. "*A finger's depth did that.*" He nodded at the crack. "*Mam's blood. In a glass hand. Did this.*" He looked at his own hand. "*Ours. On the edge. To get four people through.*"

"*It'll widen*," said Lex.

"*It'll widen*."

"*Wide enough for him*."

"*I don't know*," said Antho. "*Maybe. Probably.*" He looked at his brother. "*It doesn't close, Lex. Seraphine said. Once blood's opened it, it stays.*"

"*So we go through*," said Lex. Very quietly. "*To get the one thing that can stop him. And the door we go through is the door he comes through after us.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Into the world. While we're gone.*" Lex's voice was very flat. "*Toward Harrow. Toward Father. Toward Wren and Lark.*"

Antho didn't answer.

He didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Don't go*," said Roole.

They turned.

The Keeper-Commander was standing on the grey with his lantern held up. His face in its light was hard and plain and lined, the way it always was. His voice didn't change. It never did.

"*Don't go*," he said again. "*That's what I'd say. If I were you. If I were sensible.*" He lowered the lantern a little. "*Stay. Sit tight. Wait for him to come down the thread on Lantern Night. And fight him in the Knot. On your own ground. With the door shut.*"

"*And if we lose*?" said Lex.

"*Then you lose*," said Roole. "*And he picks up the net. And keeps it.*" He looked at the crack. "*And we go back to what we were. Ceilings and Wardens and children Kindled into the same class as their mothers.*" A pause. "*I was a Warden in that world for twenty-six years. I know how to live in it.*"

"*Do you want to*?"

The hatchet face didn't change.

"*No*," said Daxian Roole. "*I don't.*" He looked at the crack for a long time. At the thorns. At the red. "*Fenn didn't either. He straightened every leaning Stone in the west because he didn't want to.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*If he comes through*," said Antho. "*After us. When it's wider.*"

Roole looked at him.

"*Greyfall's the first thing he'll see*," said Antho. "*You'll be the first.*"

"*I know*."

"*Get out*," said Antho. "*When he comes. Don't stand in front of him. Don't fight him. You can't.*" He looked at the gold, spreading. At the field. At the boy. "*Get your Keepers out. Get Nan Ashby out. Get everyone out. And send a raven to Harrow.*"

Roole didn't answer for a long moment.

"*Fenn stood in front of the Mothwing*," he said at last. "*At the south edge. All night. With his staff held crosswise.*" His voice didn't change. "*I said the same thing to him. Get out. Don't stand in front of them. You can't.*"

"*And*?"

"*And he said, somebody has to stand somewhere, Dax,*" said Roole. "*And then he died.*" He looked at Antho. "*I'll get them out. I promise. I'll send the raven.*" A pause. "*And then I'll stand somewhere.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAMPED AT THE foot of the Veil.

Not inside the gold. On the grey. In a hollow out of the wind, a hundred yards from the crack. Roole went back to Greyfall. He said someone should be on the walls. He said he'd come back at dawn.

They didn't light a fire.

There was no wood. There was nothing to burn in the Sundered Lands. Lex sat with his hand open on the ground and let a little heat come up out of it, black, no light, so they were warm without anything to see by.

They ate cold bread. They didn't talk much.

Pim sat with the basket of Hush-cups in his lap and his hand on the lid.

Hask sat a little apart. On a stone. With his pick across his knees. Looking at the crack. Gold dust drifting past him on the wind, catching on his sleeve, his hair, his scarred bandaged arm. Sliding off.

Lex lay on his back on the grey with his hands behind his head and looked up at the sky.

Antho sat beside him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You could stay*," said Antho.

Lex didn't move.

"*I mean it*," said Antho. "*You've got a wife. A daughter. A father who might not—*" He stopped. "*I can go. With Pim. With Hask. We can get it. You don't have to come.*"

"*You need Harrow blood*," said Lex. "*Two of us. Seraphine said.*"

"*Seraphine said more blood. She didn't say two people.*" Antho looked at the crack. "*I can bleed for both of us. I've got plenty. I'm very tall.*"

Lex laughed. Short. Cracked.

"*You're not that tall.*"

"*I'm taller than you.*"

"*You're not*," said Lex. "*We measured. At Ashbourne. Against the forge door. When you came back from the Hollowmaw.*" He turned his head. "*I'm half an inch taller. Brannoc marked it with a nail.*"

"*Brannoc cheated.*"

"*Brannoc's never cheated in his life.*"

They looked at each other in the dark.

"*I'm coming*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why*?" said Antho.

His brother didn't answer for a long time.

He lay on his back on the cold grey ground at the edge of the world and looked up at the sky. The stars were out. Hard. White. Close. Fewer than over the Vale. Much fewer. As if the edge of the world thinned them out.

"*Because you went alone*," said Lex at last. "*At sixteen. Into the Greyspine. With the Murmur.*" His voice was very quiet. "*And then again. Into the Hollow. To keep the door. Into the Drowned Country. Down to the Heart.*" He swallowed. "*You always went alone. Every time. You said it was yours. You said nobody else could.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

"*And I went alone*," said Lex. "*Up the Spire. Into the Wellworlds. To the Knot. Down the Old Gallery.*" He laughed. Short. "*We're both terrible at it. Going with people. We're the worst. Wren says.*"

"*Wren's right*."

"*Wren's always right. It's very annoying.*" Lex turned his head. "*I'm not letting you go into a country with no sun and no room on your own, Antho. I'm not letting you open a door at the edge of the world and walk through it without me.*" He looked at his brother. "*Not this time. Not ever again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

He sat on the grey with his knees drawn up and his arms round them. The way his mother sat. The way Hesper had sat on the edge of a cabbage bed, nine hundred years ago, talking to a puddle.

"*Brannoc cheated*," he said at last.

Lex laughed.

Properly. On his back on the cold ground at the edge of the world. With his hands over his face. Laughing.

And Antho, after a moment, did too.

◆ ◆ ◆

[I'm going to put that in the main text,] said Ember. Very quietly. In the back of Lex's head. Antho didn't hear it. Lex told him, later. *[Not a footnote. The main text. Chapter forty. "The brothers argued about who was taller at the edge of the world, and laughed, and it was the last time either of them laughed for a while."]*

That's very cheerful, thought Lex.

[I'm a historian,] said Ember. *[I write what happens.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

DAWN CAME GREY.

Roole came with it. On foot, from Greyfall, with his lantern unlit and three Keepers behind him and a raven on his shoulder. One of the old ones. One-eyed. Ragged.

"*He'll stay*," said Roole. Nodding at the raven. "*On the walls. Watching. If anything comes through after you, he'll go east. To Harrow. Fast.*"

"*Thank you*."

"*Don't thank me*," said Daxian Roole. "*Come back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOOD AT THE foot of the crack.

The four of them. In the grey light. In the cold wind off the edge of the world. With the gold dust pouring out of the dark past their boots and the thorns gripping the edges of the Veil on either side and the red stain on the lip of it, dark, glittering with glass.

Pim with the basket on his back. Fourteen cups. Fourteen days.

Hask with his pick.

Lex with Aurelian's hammer on his belt, and Malachi's bell on its cord, and the grey book in oilcloth inside his shirt.

Antho with nothing. No Lantern. He'd left it by his father's bed. Three panes of glass and one of horn.

"*How much*?" said Lex.

Antho looked at the crack. At the stain. At the edge.

"*I don't know*," he said. "*Enough.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK OUT HIS knife.

A plain one. Short. The one he used for bread. He'd thought about using something else. Something grander. Something with a rune on it.

He'd decided against it.

It's just blood, he'd thought. In the night. On the grey. *It's just Harrow blood. Mam's blood. Hesper's. Twenty generations of it. It doesn't need a rune. It never did.*

He drew the blade across his palm.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T HURT MUCH. It stung. A thin line of fire across the middle of his left hand. And then the red came up. Welling. Bright.

He held his hand out.

He handed Lex the knife.

His brother looked at it. Then at Antho's palm. Then at his own.

He drew the blade across his palm. Not flinching. A smith's hand. Calloused. Scarred. A thin line of red welling up across the old burns.

They looked at each other.

"*Together*," said Lex.

"*Together*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY PUT THEIR HANDS on the Veil.

Either side of the crack. On the grey. Flat. Palms open. Bleeding.

And the edge of the world didn't know them.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO FELT IT.

Felt it the way he felt every door. Felt the grey under his palm, the edge, the last thread, stretched tight across the end of everything for nine hundred years. Felt it *look* at him. The way the net had always looked at him. The way it had read him at his Kindling and called him ERROR.

Felt it look at the blood on his hand.

And not know.

Hesper's line. The tenth. The sister who wouldn't drink. Who poured back instead. Whose daughters had never Kindled and never stayed and never let a moth in, for nine hundred years, so that the net never once got a proper look at them.

The edge didn't know.

And so the edge did the only thing a door can do, when a hand it has never seen before is laid on it, and there is no reason in the world to keep that hand out.

◆ ◆ ◆

It *opened*.

Not like the crack. Not a seam. Not a tear.

Like a door.

Antho felt it go. Under his hand. Under Lex's. The grey on either side of the crack *drawing back*. Folding. Parting. Like a curtain drawn by a hand. Like a door swinging on its hinges, slowly, silently, inward, into the dark.

The crack widened.

A man's width. Two. Three. The thorns on the edges creaking, stretching, snapping, as the grey drew back from them. The dust pouring out faster. Faster. A flood of it. A river of gold glittering past their boots, past their knees, and the wind taking it, and the sun coming up behind them over the bare lands and catching it, so that for one moment the whole edge of the world was a wall of grey with a great tall gold-lit door in it, pouring light.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IT WAS WIDE.

As wide as a cart. As wide as a barn door. As wide as the great doors of the Hall of Lanterns, where every king of Caldor had hung a lantern on their crowning day.

Wide enough for four people to walk through side by side.

Wide enough for a king.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO TOOK HIS HAND off the Veil.

He looked at his palm. Red. Cut. Bleeding. A thin line of fire.

He looked at the door.

Dark. Tall. Wide. The grey drawn back on either side of it like curtains. The thorns hanging off the edges, snapped, broken, dangling. And beyond it, through it, in the dark—

Light.

Grey-gold. Dim. Coming from nowhere. The colour of a candle seen through a dirty window.

And a smell.

Dust. Old dust. The dust of a closed room. Of a hall nobody has walked through in nine hundred years.

And under it, very faint—

Roses.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Well*," said Lex. Beside him. Very quietly. Looking at the door. With his bleeding hand held against his chest. "*That's done.*"

"*That's done*," said Antho.

They looked at each other.

Behind them, Roole made a sound. Small. Not a word.

Pim shifted the basket on his back.

Hask lifted his pick.

And the four of them walked through the door at the edge of the world.

CHAPTER 19

The Crossing

THE VEIL WAS THICK.

Lex hadn't known that. Nobody had. Nobody living had ever walked into it. You stood at the foot of the edge of the world and looked at the grey and it looked like a curtain. A wall. A sheet of something hanging from nowhere.

It wasn't a sheet.

It was a *weave*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS INSIDE IT before he understood.

Three steps through the door. Four. The bare grey ground of the Sundered Lands under his boots and the cold wind at his back and Roole's lantern behind him, and then the grey closed in on either side and above, and the wind stopped.

Not died. *Stopped*. As if a door had shut on it.

And he was in a corridor.

Grey. All round. Soft. Close. Not stone. Not cloth. *Thread*. He could see it. Even without the Root. Even without the gold in his eyes that let him see the net, that he'd given up two years ago and missed every day since. He could see this.

Threads. Grey. Thousands of them. Millions. Woven so close together they made a wall. Running up and down and across and through each other in patterns too fine to follow. On either side of him. Above. Below his boots. A great soft grey corridor of thread, going on ahead of him into a dim grey light.

And all of them humming.

One note. High. Clear. Like a harp-string.

The last thread.

He was walking through the inside of it.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Oh,] said Ember.

Very quiet. Very small. In the back of his head.

Ember?

[I'm here.] A pause. *[It's—Lex. It's very loud. In here. The note.]*

I can hear it.

[No. You can hear it with your ears. I can hear it with—] It stopped. *[I'm made of him. Of your father. He held the net for two hundred years. I'm made of someone who held the net.]* A pause. *[It's all round me. In here. It's like standing inside a bell.]*

Are you all right?

[I'll put it in a footnote,] said Ember. Faintly. *[A long one.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED.

Single file. The corridor wasn't wide. Lex first. Then Antho. Then Pim, with the basket on his back. Then Hask, at the end, with his pick, ducking because the grey came down low in places and he was very tall.

The light didn't change. Grey. Dim. Coming from nowhere. From everywhere. From the threads themselves.

The floor didn't change. Grey. Soft. Thread underfoot like moss.

The note didn't change.

He didn't know how long they walked. He tried to count steps and lost count somewhere past six hundred. He tried to count breaths. He tried to count anything.

Everything in the corridor was the same. Every step. Every breath. Every thread.

[It's the last one,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[The last thread. Aurelian tied it. It's—Lex, it's as wide as the world. It's as long as the edge. We're walking through the thickness of it.]*

How thick?

[I don't know,] said Ember. *[I don't think anyone's ever measured.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE PANEL came up.

He didn't call it. He hadn't called his panel in months. He didn't need to. He knew what was on it.

It came up anyway. On its own. Hanging in the grey air in front of his face, in the gold letters it always used. Flickering.

```
LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
Level 98
LOCATION: ▓▓▓▓▓▓▓▓
WARNING: LEAVING THE NET
WARNING: LEAVING THE NET
WARNING: L▓▓V▓NG T▓▓ N▓T
```

He stopped walking.

The letters were breaking up. As he watched. The gold going thin. Grainy. Like sand. Like letters written on a beach with a stick, and the tide coming in.

```
L▓X V▓Y
▓▓▓▓▓▓: ▓▓▓▓▓▓▓▓▓
NOT OF THIS NET
```

And then it was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," said Antho. Behind him. Very quietly. "*Did yours—*"

"*Yes*."

"*Mine said ERROR*," said Antho. "*At the end. Before it went.*" A short sound. Not quite a laugh. "*Like my Kindling. ERROR. Like it didn't know what I was.*"

"*Mine said not of this net*."

"*That's what it said about her*," said Antho. "*Maelis. When she came through. Last spring. UNKNOWN ENTITY. NOT OF THIS NET.*" He was quiet for a moment. "*We're the unknown ones now.*"

Lex looked at the grey corridor going on ahead.

"*Pim*?" he said.

"*Nothing*," said Pim. From behind Antho. "*Mine didn't come.*"

"*Hask*?"

A long silence from the back.

"*Mine came*," said Silas Hask.

They all turned round.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS STANDING AT the end of the line. Ducking under the low grey. With his pick in his good hand and his bandaged arm against his chest. His face very strange.

"*What did it say*?" said Lex.

Hask didn't answer for a moment.

"*It said, welcome back*," he said.

Nobody spoke.

"*Not in gold*," said Hask. "*Not like the others. Grey. Grey-gold.*" He swallowed. "*Like her wings. Like the dust off them.*" His big scarred hand tightened on the pick. "*It said, welcome back, champion.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CORRIDOR ENDED.

Lex didn't see it end. One moment there was grey ahead. Grey threads, humming. The next, the grey was thinning. Going pale. Going soft. Like mist burning off a field. And there was light beyond it.

Not daylight. Not sun.

Grey-gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STEPPED OUT OF the Veil.

And the world pushed.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D BEEN WARNED. THE Ferryman had warned them. Seraphine had warned them. *Anyone with room in them, it pushes. Slowly. Firmly.*

He'd imagined a wind. A weight. A hand on his chest.

It wasn't any of those.

It was like stepping into deep water.

All at once. All over. From every side. Pressure. Not hard. Not crushing. *Full*. As if the air itself were thicker. Heavier. As if there were no space in it. As if every breath he took was a breath into a room already full of something, and he had to push the something aside to fit his breath in.

His ears popped.

His chest went tight. He breathed in and the breath stopped halfway. Not because it hurt. Because there wasn't *room*. Because his lungs pushed out and the air pushed back.

He staggered.

Antho caught him. From behind. A hand on his shoulder. And Lex heard his brother gasp, the same gasp, the same stopped breath, as he stepped out of the grey into the light.

"*Oh*," said Antho. "*Oh. That's—*"

He didn't finish.

He didn't have the breath.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM STEPPED OUT BEHIND them.

And didn't stagger.

Lex saw it. Saw the boy step out of the thinning grey with the basket on his back and stop. And stand there. Small. Thin. In his blue coat with the brass buttons. With his eyes shut and his face very white.

And round him—

Lex felt it. The way you feel a draught from an open door. A *space*. Round the boy. A small round room of quiet. Pushing back. Not hard. Just—holding. A yard wide. Two. Spreading out from him the way warmth spreads out from a hearth.

The pressure stopped at the edge of it.

Lex felt it stop. Felt the full heavy air of the grey country press against the edge of Pim's room and not come in. Felt his own chest, inside the edge, loosen. Felt his breath go past halfway. Further.

He breathed.

"*Pim*," said Antho. Hoarsely. Breathing too.

The boy didn't open his eyes.

"*Not long*," said Pim. Very quietly. "*Can't hold it walking. Only sitting.*" His small face was screwed up with effort. "*Drink.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX REACHED INTO THE basket.

His hands were shaking. He took out a cup. Horseshoe iron. Heavy with nothing. With an iron lid on it that sighed when he lifted it.

Empty. He could see the bottom. The broken circle of the Hollow cut on the inside of the curve.

He lifted it to his mouth.

And drank.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS NOTHING IN it.

There was nothing in it at all. He tipped the cup and nothing came out. No water. No taste. No weight on his tongue.

And then he felt it go in.

Not down his throat. *In*. Into his chest. Into the tight full space where his breath had stopped. Spreading. Like warmth from a hearth. Like light coming into a room when someone opens the shutters.

Room.

He felt it open. In him. A space. Small. Round. Quiet. Pushing back against the full heavy air from the inside. Not hard. Just holding. Making room for his breath. For his heartbeat. For the blood in his veins.

He breathed in.

All the way. All the way down. Further than he had since he stepped out of the grey.

Like holding your breath, Ivy had said. *Right before you laugh*.

It was exactly like that.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...that's Mal,] said Ember. Very faintly. Wondering. *[Lex. That's a bit of Mal. In you.]*

I know.

[It's warm.]

I know.

[It's like being home,] said Ember. Very small. *[In the middle of here.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HELD THE CUP out to Antho.

His brother took it. Drank. Lex watched his face. Watched it go from grey and tight to something else. Something softer. Watched his shoulders come down from round his ears.

"*Oh*," said Antho. "*Oh, Mal.*"

He put the lid back on the cup. Carefully. It sighed.

"*Three days*," he said. "*One cup. Three days for one person.*" He looked at the basket. "*We've drunk one cup between us. Two people. A day and a half each.*"

"*Thirteen left*," said Lex.

"*Thirteen left*," said Antho. "*Thirty-nine days for one. Nineteen for two.*" He looked at Pim. "*If Pim holds the nights.*"

Pim opened his eyes.

The room round him faded. Lex felt it go. Felt the full heavy air of the grey country press in again, all round, from every side.

But it didn't press *him*. Not now. Not inside. Inside him there was room. A small round space, warm and quiet, that the pressure pushed against and couldn't get into.

"*Fourteen days*," said Pim. "*Not twelve.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK WAS STANDING APART.

He'd stepped out of the Veil last. Ducking. And he hadn't staggered either.

He was standing on the grey-gold ground with his pick in his good hand and his face turned up to the dim light. Breathing.

All the way down.

"*Hask*," said Lex.

"*It doesn't push*," said Silas Hask. Not looking round. "*Not me.*" He breathed in. Out. In. Slow. Deep. "*It's like the mine. Like the bottom of the Old Gallery. Close. Heavy. Full.*" He looked down at his hands. "*I know this. I know what this feels like. I had it in my chest for a season.*"

He turned round.

His face was grey. Wet.

"*I could breathe here*," said Hask. Very quietly. "*Smith. I could breathe here all the way down.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*No grey-lung*," said Silas Hask. "*No catch. No rattle. Nothing.*" He breathed again. All the way down. "*It's the first time since I was nine.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HIM for a long time.

He thought about a pithead yard at dusk. Hundreds of rough voices. Coughing between the lines. Singing anyway.

He thought about a man who'd broken twenty-nine cores and made twenty-nine holes because every level eased the cough.

He thought about the Moth Queen. Who'd found a dying hewer and filled his chest with light so he could breathe.

"*Hask*," he said.

"*I know*," said Silas Hask. "*I know what it is. I know what it costs.*" He looked at the grey-gold country. At the dust. At the dim light that came from nowhere. "*I'm not staying.*"

He shouldered his pick.

"*I'm just saying*," he said. "*It's very nice. Breathing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT THE Court.

He hadn't. Not yet. He'd been breathing. He'd been drinking. He'd been watching his brother and Pim and Hask. He hadn't looked.

He looked now.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS FLAT.

That was the first thing. Flat as a table. Flat as a frozen lake. A plain of grey-gold dust running away from the foot of the Veil in every direction as far as he could see, without a hill, without a fold, without a tree. Grey-gold. Soft. Fine as flour. Lying in drifts and ripples the way snow lies, the way sand lies in the bottom of a riverbed, undisturbed.

Nothing had disturbed it. Not for nine hundred years.

No wind. That was the second thing. No wind at all. Not the faintest breath of air. The dust lay where it had fallen and stayed there.

And the light.

Grey-gold. Dim. Coming from nowhere. Not from the sky; there was no sky, not really, just a paler grey-gold overhead, like the inside of a shell. Not from a sun; there was no sun. From everywhere. From the air. From the dust itself. The colour of a candle seen through a dirty window.

It didn't change. He could tell, somehow, that it never had. Not in nine hundred years. No morning. No evening. No night.

Just this.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND A ROAD.

It started at his feet. Right at the foot of the Veil. Where the crack had been. Where the door was now. A road. White. The white of old bone. Broad. Paved with great flat slabs of stone, laid edge to edge, without a crack between them.

Running away from the Veil. Straight. Straight as a ruler. Across the grey-gold plain. Toward the far edge of everything.

And at the far edge, where the plain met the paler grey-gold of the sky—

Towers.

Small, at this distance. Very far. But towers. Spires. Domes. Glittering. Some of them clear, catching the dim light like ice. Some of them dark. Some of them gold, shining dully even from here. Some of them white, like the road. Like bone.

Palaces.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Glass*," said Antho. Very quietly. Beside him. "*And iron. And gold.*"

"*And bone*," said Hask.

"*Ysenne's*," said Antho. "*Caddoc's. Oszric's.*" He looked at the white towers. "*And the hall. The one in the middle. With the cocoons.*"

"*How far*?"

Antho looked at the road. At the white line running away across the plain.

"*I don't know*," he said. "*There's nothing to measure by.*" He shaded his eyes, though there was no sun to shade them from. "*Days. Several.*"

"*And the thorns*?"

His brother didn't answer for a moment.

"*I can't see them*," he said. "*Not from here.*" He looked north. Along the plain. Flat. Grey-gold. Empty. "*Mam dreamed them off the road. Near the palaces. A mile off. North.*"

"*Days*," said Lex.

"*Days*."

He looked at the basket on Pim's back. Thirteen cups.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS SOMETHING ON the road.

At his feet. On the first slab. Right at the foot of the Veil. Where the door was.

Small. Grey-gold. Lying in the dust that had drifted over the edge of the white stone.

He knelt down.

It was a moth.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS DEAD. IT had been dead a long time. Months. It lay on its back on the white stone with its legs folded up and its wings spread out on either side of it, shredded, torn, most of the dust gone off them. The painted eyes on the wings faded almost to nothing.

It was very small. Smaller than the ones that had come to the Keep. Smaller than the one that had darkened the lantern at the wedding.

Beside it, a glass bottle.

Small. The size of a thumb. Lying on its side on the white stone. Empty. Its cork gone. A crust of something dark round the neck of it.

Red-dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Oh,] said Ember. Very softly. *[Oh, Lex. That's the one.]*

The one?

[The last one. The one she left on the desk. In the Spire. With your mother's blood.] A pause. *[It carried it all the way here. Forty nights. Over every village between Highcrest and the edge.]* Another pause. *[And then it died. On the road. On the other side.]*

Lex looked at the little dead moth for a long time.

It went past the lanterns, he thought. *Every one. Every window. Every village. It went past them all.*

[It had been told to take it home,] said Ember.

He reached out.

And picked it up.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WEIGHED NOTHING. LESS than nothing. A scrap of dry dust and silk in his palm. It didn't come apart. He'd thought it might. It lay in his hand on its back with its legs folded and its shredded wings spread and its faded painted eyes looking up at nothing.

Antho was watching him.

"*What are you doing*?"

"*I don't know*," said Lex.

He didn't. He knelt on the white road at the foot of the Veil with the little dead moth in his hand and didn't know what he was doing.

Then he did.

He took the grey book out of his shirt. Out of its oilcloth. And opened it. To the back. Past the eleven thousand Vhessans. Past Kell. Past the twenty-three from the rim. Past a blank page with three lines on it in a shaking hand he didn't read, because they weren't for him yet.

To the inside of the back cover.

And laid the moth there. On the leather. With its wings spread.

And closed the book.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," said Antho.

"*It brought her blood here*," said Lex. "*Mam's blood. All the way. It's the reason the crack opened. It's the reason they woke. It's the reason any of this.*" He put the book back in its oilcloth. Back in his shirt. Against the bell. "*I know.*"

"*Then why—*"

"*Because it went past the lanterns*," said Lex Vey. "*Every one. It wanted them so much. And it went past.*" He stood up. "*Somebody should write that down.*"

His brother looked at him for a long moment.

Then he nodded.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STARTED WALKING.

Down the white road. Into the grey-gold. Away from the Veil.

Lex looked back once.

The door was there. Behind them. A tall dark gap in the grey. The edge of the world, drawn back on either side like curtains. And through it, very faint, a long way off, a smudge of other light. Thin. Pale. Morning light. The light of the Sundered Lands at dawn.

The world.

It looked very small.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DEAD WERE AT the edge.

Lex didn't see them at first. He thought they were dust. Drifts of it. Swirls. Lying against the foot of the Veil on either side of the road, where the grey met the plain.

Then one of them moved.

Not on the wind. There was no wind. It *moved*. Lifted. Rose up off the plain in a slow soft spiral of dust and stood there. In the air. A shape. Vague. Thin. A column of dust about the height of a man.

Bronze.

Not grey-gold like the rest. Bronze. A dull reddish-brown glitter in the dim light.

And beside it, another rose. White. Bone-white. And another. Copper. Green-tinged. And another. Coral. Pink. Pale.

Four.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Four came apart*," said Antho. Very quietly. Stopped on the road beside him. "*Against the edge. Coming through. The Ferryman said.*"

"*Bronze and bone and copper and coral*," said Lex.

"*The cousins*."

The four columns of dust stood at the foot of the Veil. Swaying. Very slightly. Not toward them. Not away. Just swaying. The way a candle-flame sways in a room with no draught.

They didn't have faces. They didn't have anything. Just dust. Coloured dust, in the shape of nothing, standing.

But Lex felt them look.

◆ ◆ ◆

[They're not dead,] said Ember. Very faintly. *[Lex. They're not—they're not anything. They came apart. Against the edge. But there's no river here. There's no Ferryman. There's nowhere for them to—*]

It stopped.

Nowhere to go, Lex thought.

[Nine hundred years,] said Ember. *[Standing at the edge. Where they came apart. In pieces.]* A pause. *[Waiting for a door.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STEPPED OFF THE road.

Lex didn't stop him. He watched his brother walk across the grey-gold dust toward the four swaying columns at the foot of the Veil. Slowly. With his hands open at his sides. The way he walked toward a frightened animal. The way he'd walked toward a little grey girl in the Drowned Country, two years ago, and promised to come back.

He stopped in front of them.

The bronze one swayed. Toward him. A little.

"*I'm sorry*," said Antho Vey.

The dust didn't move.

"*I'm a Threshold Warden*," said Antho. "*I feel doors. Every kind.*" He looked at the four columns. "*I can feel where yours should be. All four. I can feel the shape of them. The place.*" His voice cracked. "*There's nothing there. There's no door. There's never been one. Not for nine hundred years.*"

The coral one leaned. Toward him. A little more.

"*I can't make one*," said Antho. "*Not yet. Not here. There's no room.*" He swallowed. "*But there will be. Someday. There's a pool in a green field. Full of room. It's still very little.*" He put his hand out. Open. Toward the four columns of dust. "*When it's bigger. When it's grown. I'll come back.*"

He didn't touch them. He held his hand out in the air. A foot away.

"*I promise*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FOUR COLUMNS STOOD for a long moment.

Then they sank. Slowly. Down. Back into the dust at the foot of the Veil. Bronze and bone and copper and coral. Lying in their drifts. Very still.

Antho came back to the road.

His face was white. He didn't say anything.

"*You promised the grey girl*," said Lex. Quietly. "*In the Drowned Country. You promised you'd come back.*"

"*I went back*," said Antho. "*With a lantern. And her name.*" He looked down the white road. Toward the palaces. "*I keep my promises. Eventually.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED.

Hours. Or what would have been hours. There were no hours here. The light didn't change. Lex couldn't tell how long they'd been walking except by how tired his legs were and how many times Pim shifted the basket on his back.

The road ran on. White. Straight. The plain on either side of it grey-gold. Flat. Empty.

And then not empty.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST ONE WAS standing at the side of the road.

A man. Lex saw him from a long way off. A small dark shape at the edge of the white stone. Standing very still.

As they came closer, it wasn't dark.

It was gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS A GROOM.

Lex knew it at once. From the clothes. A leather jerkin. Breeches. Boots. A cap. A horse-brush in one hand, held up. The other hand out in front of him, palm flat, as if he were reaching to stroke a horse's neck.

There was no horse.

He was gold. All of him. From his cap to his boots. Every fold of his jerkin. Every hair of his beard. The bristles of the horse-brush. A thin gold scar across the back of his reaching hand.

Standing at the side of the white road. Mid-reach.

And his eyes—

Lex stopped.

His eyes moved.

◆ ◆ ◆

SLOWLY. SO SLOWLY. THE way the hand of a clock moves. Off the place in front of him where a horse should have been. Across. To the road.

To Lex.

And stayed there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The household*," said Antho. Very quietly.

Lex didn't answer.

He was looking past the groom. Further down the road. On both sides.

There was another one. A woman. In an apron. Gold. With a basket on her hip.

And another. A boy. Gold. Carrying a bucket.

And another.

And another.

And another.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LINED THE ROAD.

All the way. As far as he could see. On both sides. Down the long white line of it toward the far glittering palaces. Rows of them. Ranks. Standing at the edges of the white stone in the grey-gold dust. Shoulder to shoulder. Hundreds. Thousands.

Gold.

Cooks with ladles. Maids with brooms. Gardeners with trowels. Grooms with brushes. Nurses with babies in their arms, gold babies, gold blankets. Old men with sticks. Children. So many children. A girl with a skipping rope, frozen mid-skip, the rope a gold arc over her head.

All gold. All still. All standing at the side of the road where they'd been standing for nine hundred years.

All with their eyes moving.

All turning, slowly, so slowly, to look at four people walking down the middle of the white road.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THERE WAS A sound.

Lex heard it as they came among the first of them. Faint. So faint it was barely there. Under the silence. Under the stillness.

A hum.

One note. Low. Soft. Like a finger run round the rim of a glass. Coming from every side. From every gold throat. Thousands of voices that couldn't speak, holding one note together.

He didn't know what it was saying.

He didn't think he wanted to.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Nine thousand,] said Ember. Very faintly. *[Aurelian counted. In the note. Seraphine found it. Nine thousand who didn't choose.]*

Lex walked down the white road between them.

He didn't look at them. He tried not to. He looked at the road. At his boots. At the white stone.

He could feel them looking at him.

Every one.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*."

Pim. Behind him. Very quietly.

Lex turned round.

The boy had stopped. In the middle of the road. With the basket on his back. Looking at something at the side of it.

A girl.

Small. Seven. Eight. In a grey dress too big for her, with the sleeves rolled up, and an apron, and a wooden spoon in her hand. A kitchen girl. Gold. Standing at the edge of the white stone with her free hand at her side and her mouth a little open. As if she'd been about to say something.

Her eyes were moving.

Not slowly. Not like the others.

Fast.

Darting. From Pim's face to the basket on his back to his face again. Back and forth. Back and forth. The way a child's eyes move when she's seen something she wants very badly and isn't allowed to have.

Pim stood in the middle of the road and looked at her.

She looked back.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Pim*," said Antho. "*We have to keep moving.*"

Pim didn't move.

"*Pim. Thirteen cups.*"

The boy looked at the gold girl for a long moment more.

Then he turned. And walked on. Down the road. Without a word.

But Lex saw him look back.

Twice.

And the gold girl's eyes followed him. All the way. Until the road bent—it didn't bend; the road never bent—until they were too far for Lex to see.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T TALK FOR a long time after that.

They walked. Down the white road. Between the gold. With the hum all round them, one note, low and soft and endless. With the light never changing and the dust never moving and the palaces glittering on the edge of the sky, no closer.

Lex walked with his hand on the bell.

It didn't ring.

He'd thought it might. Here. Of all places. In a country full of nine thousand people who'd been standing at the side of a road for nine hundred years, unable to speak, unable to die, unable to go home.

It didn't ring.

He didn't understand why.

[Because they're not sad,] said Ember. Very quietly. When he asked. *[They're not anything. They're kept.]* A pause. *[You have to have room to be sad, Lex. They haven't got any.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE LIGHT changed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HAD NEVER CHANGED. Not since they stepped out of the grey. Not in nine hundred years, Lex was sure of it.

It changed now.

Ahead. Down the road. Far down. Toward the palaces. A brightness. On the white stone. Faint at first. A glow. Gold. Warmer than the grey-gold. Brighter. *Moving*.

Coming toward them.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Off the road*," said Hask.

Lex looked at him.

The big man had stopped. In the middle of the white stone. His pick in his hand. His face, in the brightening light, gone the colour of ash.

"*Off*," said Silas Hask. "*Now. Into them. Into the gold. Get down.*"

"*What is it*?"

"*I know that light*," said Hask. "*I had her light in me for a season. I know what Crowned light feels like.*" His voice was very low. "*That's not her. That's bigger. That's hotter.*" He looked at the brightness coming down the road. "*That's him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT OFF THE road.

Into the gold. Between the kept. Into the ranks of them at the side of the white stone. Lex pushed through. Between a gold cook and a gold groom. Between a gold nurse and a gold old man with a stick. Into the dust behind them. Down. Flat. In the grey-gold. With Antho beside him and Pim beside Antho and Hask, enormous, last, crouching behind a row of gold gardeners with their trowels raised.

"*Pim*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Room. Small as you can. Just us.*"

The boy shut his eyes.

Lex felt it. A quiet. A space. Round the four of them, lying in the dust behind the gold. Not wide. A yard. Less. Pressed in close. A room so small it was barely a room at all.

But a room.

The gold round them didn't move. The kept didn't move. Their eyes moved. Slowly. Down. To the four people lying in the dust at their feet.

And the light came down the road.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS HEAT FIRST.

Lex felt it before he saw anything. Heat. Rolling down the road ahead of the light like the heat from an opened forge. Heavy. Golden. Dry. It poured over the gold ranks at the side of the road and over the dust and over the four of them lying in it and he felt it on the back of his neck like a hand.

Then the light.

Bright. So bright. In a country where nothing had been bright in nine hundred years. A gold glare, filling the road, filling the air, throwing the shadows of the kept out across the dust behind them, long and black, the first shadows in the Outer Court since the world was woven.

And then the footsteps.

◆ ◆ ◆

HEAVY. SLOW. UNHURRIED.

Thud. *Thud*. *Thud*.

Coming down the white road. Toward them. Toward the Veil.

Lex lay in the dust behind a gold cook with a ladle and didn't breathe.

He saw him through her legs.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS ENORMOUS.

That was all Lex could think. Enormous. Taller than any man. Taller than Hask. Broader than Brannoc. A great gold beard that came down to his chest and gold hair to his shoulders and skin like old ivory. A robe of gold and white that swept the stone behind him. A crown of gold leaves, crooked, on his head.

And his eyes.

Furnaces. White and gold and roaring. Like the open mouth of a forge. Like the sun, if the sun were angry. Lex couldn't look at them. He looked at the white stone instead. At the great gold-shod feet coming down it.

Thud. *Thud*.

Past the groom with the brush.

Past the nurse with the baby.

Past the cook with the ladle.

Thud.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

RIGHT THERE. ON THE road. A yard from the cook. From the four of them lying in the dust behind her.

Lex didn't move. He didn't breathe. He lay in Pim's tiny room with his face in the grey-gold dust and his hand on the bell and felt the heat of the Gilded King pour over him like the heat off a forge.

The King didn't look round.

He stood on the white road with his back to them. Looking ahead. Toward the Veil. Toward the tall dark door at the edge of the world, drawn back on either side like curtains, with a smudge of thin pale morning light beyond it.

And breathed in.

Long. Slow. Deep. Through his nose.

The way a man breathes in when he comes into a kitchen and smells bread.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Harrow*," said Oszric of the Crowned.

His voice was deep. Like a bell. Like a mountain. Warm.

"*I can smell it*," he said. To the road. To the air. To nobody. "*On the edge. On the door. Fresh.*" He breathed in again. "*Two of you. Hesper's line. Vey on the father's side.*" A pause. "*And something else. Something small. Something that makes rooms.*"

Lex felt Pim go rigid beside Antho.

The King didn't turn round.

"*And one of my sister's*," said Oszric. Softly. "*The hewer. Her champion. I can smell her on him still. Like smoke in a coat.*"

Behind the row of gold gardeners, Lex heard Hask stop breathing.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GILDED KING LAUGHED.

Low. Warm. Delighted. The sound rolled out across the plain and the kept and the dust like a bell.

"*Oh*," he said. "*Oh, you opened it. Didn't you. With your own hands. With your own blood.*" He breathed in. Deep. "*Wide enough for a cart. Wide enough for a king.*" A pause. "*Thank you, cousins. I've been waiting so long.*"

He didn't turn round.

He didn't look for them. He didn't need to. He stood on the white road with his back to the four people lying in the dust behind his kept, and his furnace eyes on the door at the edge of the world.

"*Welcome home*," said Oszric. "*Make yourselves comfortable. Go wherever you like. Look at whatever you want.*" Warmly. Kindly. "*Rosie will be so pleased to have company.*"

And then—

"*I'll be at your house*," said the Gilded King.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED ON.

Thud. *Thud*. *Thud*.

Down the white road. Toward the Veil. Toward the door. The heat going with him. The light going with him. The long black shadows of the kept swinging round across the dust as he passed, like the hands of nine thousand clocks.

Lex lifted his head.

He watched him go. A great gold shape on the white road. Getting smaller. Brighter. Walking toward the tall dark door in the grey.

He watched him reach it.

He watched him stop. Just for a moment. On the threshold. With the thin pale morning light of the world on his face.

And step through.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT WENT WITH him.

All of it. All at once. The road went grey-gold again. The kept went dim. The shadows vanished. The heat drained out of the air like water out of a basin.

And the door at the edge of the world stood open. Tall. Dark. Wide.

Empty.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY MOVED.

They lay in the dust behind the kept. The four of them. In Pim's tiny room. With the hum all round them, one note, low and soft and endless. With the gold eyes of a cook and a groom and a nurse and a row of gardeners looking down at them.

Lex lay with his face in the dust and his hand on the bell.

I'll be at your house.

Harrow. The birch wood. The stream. Two cottages. A blue door. A hornlight, gold now, on a sill.

His father in a bed under a boarded west window, with a Lantern burning beside him, three panes of glass and one of horn. Breathing. In. Catch. Out.

His mother beside him.

His wife, fogging every pane.

His daughter.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember.

He didn't answer.

[Lex. Lex, breathe.]

He breathed.

It went all the way down. All the way. Past halfway. Past the catch. Into the room Mal had made in him, warm and quiet and round.

He breathed again.

Then he got up.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," said Antho. From the dust. Hoarsely. "*Lex, he's—*"

"*I know*."

"*He's going to—*"

"*I know where he's going*," said Lex Vey.

He stood in the grey-gold dust behind the kept with his bleeding hand clenched at his side, and looked back down the white road. At the door. At the thin pale smudge of the world beyond it.

Then he turned round.

And looked the other way. Down the road. Toward the palaces. Toward the glittering towers on the edge of the sky. Toward a forest of thorns, a mile off the road, north, that none of them could see yet.

"*Thirteen cups*," he said.

Antho looked at him.

"*Thirteen cups*," said Lex again. "*Thirty-nine days for one. Nineteen for two. If Pim holds the nights.*" He looked at his brother. "*He walks. He doesn't hurry. Roole says it's two hundred miles from the Veil to Harrow. More.*" His voice didn't shake. "*He'll walk it the way Caddoc climbs. Not hurrying. Not late.*"

"*Lex—*"

"*Wren's there*," said Lex. "*With the wind. Mam's there. With her no. Brannoc and Kestrel and Elowen and the Ashari.*" He swallowed. "*Father's there.*"

"*Lex—*"

"*We've got a crown to get*," said Lex. "*And then we've got to get it home before he gets to the door.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STEPPED BACK ONTO the white road.

Between the kept. Past the cook with her ladle, whose gold eyes followed him. Onto the white stone.

And started walking.

West. Away from the door. Away from the world.

Toward the palaces.

He didn't look back.

Behind him, after a moment, he heard his brother's boots on the stone. And then Pim's, lighter. And then Hask's, heavy.

And all round them, from every side, from nine thousand gold throats, one note. Low. Soft. Endless.

He still didn't know what it was saying.

He was going to find out.

INTERLUDE

Wenna's Fare

THIRTY-TWO SUMMERS BEFORE A Gilded King walked out of the edge of the world, a hedge-witch in a cottage at the far end of the Vale woke up in the night with her heart going like a hare's and knew she had to break the rule.

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SHE'D DREAMED AGAIN.

She always dreamed, at the end of summer. They all did. Her mother had. Her mother's mother. All the way back. Twenty generations of women lying awake in twenty generations of cottages on the last nights of summer, with the packing half done and the fire low, dreaming of a country with no sun.

The dream was always the same.

Grey-gold dust. A white road. A hall with a ceiling like a frozen waterfall. And in the hall, hanging from the rafters on ropes of silk, five cocoons. Grey-gold. Thick as a man's arm. Swaying very slightly, though there was no wind.

Still.

They were always still. That was the point of the dream. That was why you had it. So you'd know. Every summer, at the end, so you'd wake up in the dark and lie there and know, *still*. *Still asleep. Still hanging. Still on the other side.*

And then you'd get up in the morning and finish the packing and move on to the next cottage.

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THIS SUMMER THEY'D MOVED.

Not swayed. *Moved*. Turned. In their silk. The way a sleeper turns when a dream is going bad. The great grey-gold shapes shifting against their ropes, one after another, slowly, all down the hall. And from inside the first one, the biggest, the one above the crown of gold leaves—

A sound.

Like breathing.

◆ ◆ ◆

WENNA HARROW LAY ON her back in the dark and looked at the ceiling of the cottage and listened to her own heart.

Across the room, behind the curtain, her daughter was asleep. Nineteen. Square and freckled and stubborn, with her mother's hands and somebody else's ears. Breathing slow.

Smiling. In her sleep. Wenna could hear it. You could hear a smile, if you'd listened to someone sleep for nineteen years.

She'd been smiling in her sleep for two months. Since she came home from Highcrest with rain in her hair and her face lit up like a Lantern Night window.

Since the Warden.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS ASLEEP IN the barn.

Wenna had put him there. The first night. She'd looked at him for a long time, standing in her doorway in his grey coat with his ink-stained cuffs and his grey eyes, too tall for the lintel, and she'd stood aside and let him in. And fed him. And not said a single word to him all evening.

And then she'd pointed at the barn.

He'd slept there every night since. Every time he came. Which was every week. Three days down from Highcrest on foot. Three days back. To sit at her table for one evening and look at her daughter like she was the first light he'd seen in two hundred years.

She didn't know about the two hundred years. Not then. She found out later.

She knew he looked at Seren like that, though. She'd known it the first night.

She'd watched him. A month. Every time he came. From the fire. With her mending. Not saying anything. Watching the way he listened when Seren talked. The way he laughed at her jokes, which were terrible. The way he went quiet when she sang.

And then one evening, at the end of the month, he'd stood up from the table.

◆ ◆ ◆

VERY STRAIGHT. VERY FORMAL. In his grey coat. Too tall for the room. With his hands at his sides and his face like a closed book.

Mistress Harrow, he'd said. *I'd like to ask your permission to marry your daughter*.

And Wenna had looked at him.

And put down her mending.

And picked up the frying pan from the hearth.

And thrown it.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D MISSED. OF COURSE she'd missed. She'd meant to. A Harrow woman doesn't throw anything she isn't sure of, and she was sure she wanted to miss.

It had gone past his ear and hit the door with a crash like a bell. He hadn't flinched. He'd stood there, very straight, with his hands at his sides, and looked at her.

I'll take that as a no, he'd said.

Take it however you like, Wenna had said. *Harrow women don't marry.*

So Seren tells me.

So she's told you. Wenna had picked up her mending again. *Did she tell you the rest?*

Some of it. He hadn't sat down. *The cottages. The moving. The rule.*

And you still want to marry her.

The Warden had looked at her daughter. Sitting at the table with her square freckled hands flat on the wood and her face white and her eyes very bright.

I've wanted to marry her, he'd said, *since she laughed at the lanterns.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT HAD BEEN A fortnight ago.

Seren hadn't spoken to her since. Not properly. *Pass the salt*. *The goat's out*. *Goodnight*. She went about the cottage with her jaw set and her eyes bright and her mother's own stubbornness coming off her like heat off a forge.

And the Warden still came. Every week. Three days down, three days back. And sat at the table. And ate what Wenna gave him. And slept in the barn.

And didn't ask again.

Wenna thought that was the cleverest thing he'd done.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LAY IN THE dark and thought about the cocoons.

About the breathing.

About her daughter asleep behind the curtain, smiling. About the Warden asleep in the barn. About the cottage at the far end of the Vale where she'd lived for ten years now. Ten. Longer than any Harrow woman had stayed anywhere in nine hundred years.

She'd meant to move on. When Seren was ten. When she was twelve. When she was fifteen. Every summer, at the end, she'd started packing.

And every summer Seren had looked at her with her square face set and said, *no, Mam. Not this year. I like it here.*

And every summer Wenna had unpacked again.

◆ ◆ ◆

You're getting soft, her mother would have said.

Her mother had moved thirty times in thirty years. Her mother had taught her the rule at the end of every summer, packing, with the fire low. *We break the ground. We never take the crown. We never let a moth in.*

And we never stay, her mother had added. Every time. *That's the part that isn't in the rule because it doesn't need to be. Because it's the whole of it. Everything else is just reasons.*

Wenna had stayed.

Ten years. In the Vale. Because her daughter liked it. Because she was tired. Because there was an apple tree behind the cottage that gave the best cider apples she'd ever tasted, and a stream, and a birch wood, and nobody had felt a moth this side of the grey for four generations.

And now her daughter was going to stay forever.

With a Warden.

With a Warden-Architect of the Spire, who held the net in his hands, who could look at anyone's blood and know what they were.

◆ ◆ ◆

If they come, thought Wenna. Lying in the dark. *If they wake. If they come looking.*

A family that stays is very easy to find.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GOT UP BEFORE dawn.

Quietly. Barefoot. The way she'd got up before dawn in twenty-two cottages. She went to the corner by the hearth and moved the flagstone, the loose one, and lifted out the box.

Oak. Old. Older than anything else she owned. With a moth carved in the lid and crossed out.

She opened it.

The crown was there.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT ALWAYS WAS. IT had been there her whole life. In the box. Under some floor. Moving from cottage to cottage. She'd seen it perhaps a dozen times. At the end of summer, when her mother opened the box to check. Once, when she was nine, when her mother took it out and let her hold it.

Don't put it on, her mother had said. *Not ever. Not even to see.*

Why do we keep it, then?

Because somebody has to, her mother had said. *Because the boy with the bare feet said so. Because it's the only one that can say no.*

Say no to what?

Her mother had taken it back. Put it in the box. Closed the lid.

I don't know, she'd said. *Nobody does. Hesper didn't. She just kept it.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SMALL. PLAIN. SILVER. A circle a little bigger than a man's hand could span. With seven points rising from the rim, at even spaces, like the tines of a fork.

It wasn't beautiful. It never had been. It was the plainest crown Wenna had ever seen or heard of. No jewels. No carving. Not even polish; the silver had gone soft and grey with nine hundred years of lying in the dark.

It was cold.

It was always cold. Even in summer. Even by the fire. You picked it up and it was cold the way a stone from the bottom of a river is cold, all the way through.

She held it in her lap.

And thought about a hall with five cocoons in it, turning in their sleep.

And thought about what her mother had said.

The only one that can say no.

◆ ◆ ◆

There must be a place, she thought. *For her. For the tenth. In that country. In that hall.*

Even if she never went. Even if she never wanted to. Somebody must have kept a place.

Somebody must have thought, in case.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE KNEW IT WAS mad.

She sat on the floor of the cottage in the grey dawn with the crown in her lap and knew it was the maddest thing a Harrow woman had ever thought. To take the crown. *Toward* them. Across the grey water. Into the country of the Crowned. And leave it there.

In the middle of them.

So that every night, in the dark, in the hall, while they slept, there'd be one thing in that country that said no.

Like a hand on a forehead, she thought. *Like a mother's hand. When you've got a fever and you can't sleep. It doesn't do anything. It just sits there. And says, hush. And you sleep.*

Maybe they'd sleep.

Maybe they'd sleep so soundly they'd never wake.

Maybe my girl could stay.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN FOUND HER THERE.

Standing in the doorway of the curtained corner, in her nightdress, with her hair down and her face creased with sleep. Looking at her mother on the floor with the box open and the crown in her lap.

She didn't say anything.

She'd been not-speaking to her mother for a fortnight. She didn't break it now.

She just looked. At the crown. At her mother's face.

"*I've got to go away*," said Wenna.

Seren's face went very still.

"*Not moving*," said Wenna. "*Not packing up. Just me. For a while.*" She closed the lid of the box. "*A month. I'll be back before the apples.*"

"*Where*?"

"*West*."

Seren looked at the box.

"*With that*," she said. The first real words in a fortnight.

"*With that*."

"*Why*?"

Wenna looked at her daughter for a long moment.

"*So you can stay*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD THE WARDEN at breakfast.

He'd come in from the barn with straw in his hair, the way he always did, and sat down at the table, and she'd put a bowl of porridge in front of him, the way she always did. And then, instead of going back to the fire, she'd sat down across from him.

He'd looked at her. Very carefully. With his grey eyes. The way he must look at a ward he wasn't sure of.

"*I'm going away*," said Wenna. "*A month. Maybe less.*"

"*I'm sorry to hear it*."

"*You'll look after her*."

He'd gone very still.

"*While I'm gone*," said Wenna Harrow. "*You'll come down from your Spire. More than once a week. You'll make sure the goat doesn't get into the cider. You'll make sure she eats.*" She looked at him. "*She doesn't eat when she's angry. She's very angry.*"

"*I know*," said the Warden. "*She told me. Through the barn door. At some length.*"

"*Good*." Wenna stood up. "*And when I come back, you can ask me again.*"

He'd looked at her for a long time.

"*Will you throw another pan*?" he'd said.

"*I might*," said Wenna. "*I'll decide when I get back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WALKED.

West. Out of the Vale. Over the downs. Across the shires. With a stick in her hand and a bundle on her back and the box in the bundle, and her boots, which were old, and her feet, which were older.

She didn't stop.

She'd decided that, the first day. If she stopped, she'd think. If she thought, she'd turn round. If she turned round, she'd go back to the cottage at the far end of the Vale, and put the box back under the flagstone, and pack, and take her daughter, and run.

And her daughter wouldn't come.

So she didn't stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

PAST THE SHIRES THE land went grey.

She'd heard about it. Everyone had. The Sundered Lands. The scar. Where the world had been cut, nine hundred years ago, when the Crowned were sent out. Grey ground. Black stumps. A wind that never stopped.

She went round it. North. Into the mountains. Over a pass between white peaks like teeth. And down the other side, into a country that wasn't grey and wasn't green.

Thin. That was the only word. Things had no edges. No weight. The grass was the colour of nothing. The streams slid over their stones without a sound. She put her hand on a tree once, to rest, and felt it give under her palm like wet paper.

Her feet were bleeding.

She didn't stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELEVEN DAYS.

On the twelfth morning she came over the top of a long low hill and saw the river.

Grey. Wide. Flat. Slow. Running north to south across the bottom of a long grey valley. The grey of slate. The grey of a dead man's face.

And on the near bank, on the shingle, a boat.

And beside it, leaning on a long pole with a lantern on top of it, a tall thin figure in grey robes.

Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D NEVER SEEN HIM. No Harrow woman ever had. Not in life. That was the other rule, the one under the rule. *Never go to the river. Never go to the shore. Never let him see you until it's time.*

She went down the hill.

Her feet left red marks on the grey stones. She didn't look at them. She walked down the long slope to the shingle with the bundle on her back and her stick in her hand, and stopped in front of him.

He turned his head.

He had no eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Wenna Harrow*," said the Ferryman.

She'd known he would know her name. She hadn't known how it would feel. To be named. By that voice. Quiet and old and gentle, like water over stones.

"*I didn't tell you that*," she said.

"*No*." The eyeless face tilted. "*You never did. None of you ever did. For nine hundred years. Not one Harrow woman ever came to my shore.*" A pause. "*I have known all your names anyway. Every one. I hear them in the water, a little. Whenever one of you is born.*"

"*Then you know why I've come*."

"*I know you have a box*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE OPENED IT ON the shingle.

She knelt down on the grey stones with her bleeding feet folded under her and set the box in front of her and lifted the lid.

And took out the crown.

The Ferryman went very still.

She saw it. In the long grey body leaning on the pole. In the long grey face. Something going still in him that she didn't think had gone still in a very long time.

"*Hers*," he said.

"*Hesper's*."

"*I saw it on this shingle*." His voice was very quiet. "*Nine hundred years ago. In her hands. The boy with the bare feet had just given it back to her. She was sitting there.*" His long grey hand moved on his pole. Pointing. To a place on the shingle a few yards off. "*There. With her knees up. Holding it in her lap like a bowl.*"

Wenna looked at the place.

Grey stones. Nothing else.

She thought, *she sat there. Hesper. At seventeen. With her brothers and sisters gone into the grey. With the crown in her lap.*

And then she got up, and walked east, and never stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I want you to take it across*," said Wenna.

The Ferryman didn't answer.

"*To them*," said Wenna. "*To the Court. To the hall where they sleep.*" Her voice was shaking. She didn't let it stop her. "*There must be a place for her there. For the tenth. Even if she never came. Somebody must have kept a place.*"

"*Why*?"

"*So there's one thing in that country that says no*," said Wenna Harrow. "*Every night. While they sleep.*" She held the crown up. In both hands. Cold. "*They're waking. I've dreamed it. They're turning in their sleep. I don't know what to do. I've only got a song and a rule and this.*" She swallowed. "*So I thought—if I put it in the middle of them—*"

"*It would keep them asleep*," said the Ferryman.

"*I don't know*," said Wenna. "*Maybe. I hope.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN WAS QUIET for a long time.

The river ran. Grey. Slow. A long way off, on the far side, there was nothing. No hills. No sky. Just grey.

"*It can be done*," he said at last.

Wenna let out a breath she hadn't known she was holding.

"*A crown is not a person*," said the Ferryman. "*It has no time to be done. It has no room in it to be pushed against. I can carry it.*" A pause. "*And there is a place.*"

She looked up.

"*There is a tower*," said the Ferryman. "*At the edge of their plain. Far from the palaces. Grown, not built. Out of a white tree.*" His eyeless face turned toward the grey. "*One of them grew it. In the first year. For the tenth. In case she changed her mind.*"

Wenna's hands tightened on the crown.

"*Which one*?"

"*The fourth*," said the Ferryman. "*The one with the roses.*"

Thorns for the gardener who listened, thought Wenna. *And drank*.

The song broke there. It always had. It was meant to.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There is a price*," said the Ferryman.

"*I know*."

"*To cross, or to carry*. *It is the same for everyone.*" His voice was very gentle. "*The memory you would least wish to lose.*"

"*I know*," said Wenna.

She'd known. She'd known for eleven days. Walking. She'd known since she sat on the floor of the cottage at dawn with the crown in her lap.

She'd been thinking about it the whole way.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*My girl*," she said.

The Ferryman didn't move.

"*Seren*," said Wenna. "*My daughter. Nineteen years. Every day.*" Her voice was very steady. She'd decided, on the eleventh day, that it would be. "*The day she was born. The first time she walked. The first time she sang the rule back to me. The day she came home with rain in her hair.*" She swallowed. "*That's what I'd least wish to lose. Take that.*"

"*No*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STARED AT HIM.

"*No*," he said again. Very gently. "*That is not the price. Not for you.*"

"*It's what I'd least wish to lose*."

"*It is what you love most*," said the Ferryman. "*That is not the same thing.*"

She didn't understand.

"*Your daughter is not a memory, Wenna Harrow,*" said the Ferryman. "*She is waiting for you. In a cottage at the far end of a valley, with a goat and a Warden and a barrel of cider.*" His eyeless face turned toward her. "*You will see her face in eleven days. And the next day. And the next. You will make new memories of her every morning for the rest of your life.*" A pause. "*If I took the old ones, you would only make more.*"

"*Then what—*"

"*The memory you would least wish to lose,*" said the Ferryman, "*is the one you can never have again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RIVER RAN.

Wenna knelt on the shingle with the crown in her lap and her bleeding feet folded under her and looked at the grey water.

The one you can never have again.

And she knew.

She'd known all along. She'd known on the eleventh day, walking. She'd known on the first. She'd known, if she was honest, the moment she sat down on the floor of the cottage with the box open.

She'd just hoped he wouldn't ask.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D COME UP THE road at the end of summer.

Twenty years ago. Nearly twenty-one. To a cottage in the Ironbacks. With a pack on his back full of pots and pans and a little anvil and a bag of rivets. A tinker. Brown as a nut. With a crooked nose and big ears and a laugh you could hear from the next valley.

He'd knocked on the door. She'd opened it. He'd held up a pan. Hers. With a hole in the bottom that she'd been meaning to mend for a month.

Found it in your hedge, he'd said. *Thought you might want it back. I can fix that for you. Ten minutes. A copper.*

She hadn't wanted it fixed. She hadn't wanted anyone at her door. She was a Harrow woman. She'd been about to tell him to go away.

And then he'd whistled.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT AT HER. AT a blackbird. In the apple tree by the gate. A long high liquid run of notes, rising and falling, exactly like the bird's own song. Better than the bird's

own song. And the blackbird had cocked its head. And looked at him. And come down out of the tree. And sat on the gatepost a yard from his shoulder.

And whistled back.

Wenna had stood in the doorway of the cottage in the Ironbacks with her mouth open.

How did you do that? she'd said.

The tinker had grinned at her. A crooked grin. Under a crooked nose.

I asked nicely, he'd said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D STAYED TILL THE end of the summer.

In the barn. Mending things. Everything in the cottage that was broken, and some things that weren't. Whistling. In the mornings, at the anvil. In the evenings, on the step, with the sun going down. Blackbirds and thrushes and larks and a tune of his own that he said had no name, that he said he'd made up on a road somewhere and never finished.

You'll finish it someday, she'd said.

No, he'd said. *Some tunes you don't finish. You just keep whistling them till you've got somewhere to stop.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D GONE AT THE end of summer.

They always did. Harrow women didn't keep them. That was part of the rule too, the part that didn't need saying. He'd packed his little anvil and his rivets and his bag of pots and kissed her at the gate, and gone off down the road. East. Whistling.

She'd stood at the gate and listened till she couldn't hear him anymore.

She'd never told him.

Three months later she'd known. Nine months later there was a girl. Square. Freckled. Stubborn. With her mother's hands.

And his ears.

◆ ◆ ◆

TWENTY YEARS.

She'd never seen him again. She'd never looked. You didn't. She'd never said his name out loud, not once, not to anyone. Not even to Seren. Seren had asked, when she was small. *Who was my da? Where is he? Is he dead?*

And Wenna had smiled. Every time. A small private smile. And said, *he was a whistler. The best you ever heard. He could whistle a blackbird down out of a tree.* And touched her daughter's ear. *You've got his ears.*

That was all.

She'd kept the rest.

Twenty years. Every day. Quietly. Without ever saying. The crooked grin. The crooked nose. The blackbird on the gatepost. The tune with no name and no end.

She'd never be able to have it again. He was gone. Down a road somewhere. Twenty years down it. Old now. Married, maybe. Dead, maybe. Whistling somewhere she'd never hear.

She'd never have him again.

She'd only ever have the summer.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The whistler*," said Wenna Harrow.

The Ferryman didn't say anything.

"*Take the whistler*," she said. "*The summer. All of it.*" Her voice cracked. She didn't let it stop her. "*That's what I'd least wish to lose. That's the one I can never have again.*"

The Ferryman looked at her for a long time.

"*Are you sure*?"

"*No*," said Wenna. "*But take it anyway.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HELD OUT HIS hand.

Long. Grey. Thin. Open.

She looked at it.

Then she put the crown in it.

And closed her eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FELT IT GO.

Not like a cut. Not like a theft. Like a tide going out. Slowly. Gently. From the back of her mind. From the place where she'd kept it for twenty years.

A gate. An apple tree. A blackbird.

A crooked grin.

A tune.

Going. Out. Away. Down a long grey river. Into the dark.

She held on. She couldn't help it. She held on to the tune the longest. A long high run of notes, rising, falling, never finished. She held on to it until it was only a feeling. Only a shape. Only the space where a sound had been.

And then that went too.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE OPENED HER EYES.

She was kneeling on the shingle. On grey stones. By a grey river. In front of a tall grey man with no eyes, holding a small plain silver crown in his long grey hand.

There was a box open on the stones in front of her. Oak. Old. Empty. With a moth carved in the lid and crossed out.

She looked at it.

There was something missing. She could feel it. A space. Warm. Empty. Like a bed someone has just got out of. Like the place on a gatepost where a bird has been sitting.

She didn't know what it was.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It is done*," said the Ferryman.

"*What is*?" said Wenna.

He didn't answer.

She sat back on her heels. On the shingle. And looked at the river. Grey. Slow. And found that her hands were shaking. And that her face was wet. And that she didn't know why.

"*I've been crying*," she said. Surprised.

"*Yes*."

"*Why*?"

The eyeless face looked at her for a long moment.

"*Because you paid*," said the Ferryman. "*And it was the right price.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CLOSED THE EMPTY box.

Slowly. Carefully. The lid going down over the hollow in the bottom. The circle. The seven points. Pressed into the oak by nine hundred years of a crown lying there in the dark.

She didn't put the box in her bundle. She held it in her lap. Like a bowl.

"*Will you—*" She stopped. Tried again. "*Will you put it there? On the chair? In her tower?*"

"*I will*."

"*Will you tell me if it works*?"

"*You will know*," said the Ferryman. "*At the end of summer. When you dream.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GOT UP.

Her feet hurt. She hadn't noticed before. She noticed now. Bleeding through her boots. Eleven days. Three hundred miles.

She turned round. East. Up the long grey slope of the valley. Toward the thin country. Toward the white peaks like teeth. Toward the Vale.

Toward a cottage at the far end of it with a goat and a barrel of cider and a tall young Warden sleeping in the barn.

Toward her girl.

She didn't look back.

Harrow women never did.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN WATCHED HER go.

He watched her climb the long grey slope with her stick and her empty box and her bleeding feet. He watched her reach the top. Stop. Stand there for a moment, with her back to him, a small square shape against the grey sky.

He watched her lift her hand to her mouth.

And try to whistle.

Nothing came. She'd never been able to. Harrow women can't.

She stood there a moment longer, with her hand at her mouth, puzzled. As if she'd reached for something on a shelf and found the shelf empty.

Then she lowered her hand. And went on. Over the top of the hill. And was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE ROWED IT ACROSS that night.

There was no night, where he was going. But he rowed it across in what would have been the night, on the river that runs between the world and everything else, with the small plain silver crown sitting in the bow of his boat where nine Crowned had sat in chains nine hundred years before.

It was very cold. Colder than any passenger he'd carried.

It didn't speak. Crowns don't.

But it sat in the bow, facing forward, toward the grey. Toward the Court. Toward the country it had never touched. And the Ferryman, who had rowed every soul that ever lived to whatever shore it was owed, felt it the whole way across.

No.

Not a word. A refusal. Quiet. Patient. Steady. Like a hand laid flat on a door.

Not you. Not ever.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FAR SHORE WAS dust.

He stepped out of the boat onto grey-gold, fine as flour, undisturbed for nine hundred years. He walked across the plain. Away from the white road. Away from the palaces, glittering on the edge of the sky. Away from the nine thousand gold shapes standing in rows along the road, humming one note.

North. To the edge of the plain.

To a tower.

◆ ◆ ◆

SMALL. SLENDER. GROWN OUT of a white tree, coaxed up and round on itself into the shape of a tower. Grey now. Cracked. Dead for nine hundred years.

A door at the bottom.

He opened it.

A stair. Winding. Up through the hollow of the dead trunk. He climbed it. With the crown in his long grey hand. With the cold coming off it. With the *no*.

At the top, a room.

A girl's room. Grown out of the wood. A bed, with a coverlet of dead grey leaves. A shelf, with a little carved bear on it, worn smooth. A bowl of dried roses, so old they'd gone to dust in the bottom of it. A window, looking west, toward nothing.

And a chair.

Small. Plain. Grown out of the floor like a root. Facing the window.

Empty.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SET THE CROWN on it.

Gently. The way you'd set down a sleeping child. In the middle of the seat. Facing the window.

And stepped back.

And the room went quiet.

Not silent. Quiet. The way a room goes quiet when someone you love walks into it. The way a sick-room goes quiet when the fever breaks.

No, said the crown. To the room. To the tower. To the whole grey-gold country round it. Patiently. Steadily. Like a hand on a forehead.

Hush. Not you. Not ever. Sleep.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS AT THE bottom of the stair when he came down.

Thin. Grey. Barefoot. In rotten silk. With a crown of black thorns on her head and her hands pressed together under her chin. Looking up at him.

She'd woken. He could see it. In her green eyes. In the dust still pouring off her shoulders. She'd felt the crown come into the Court the way you feel a cold hand on the back of your neck, and she'd woken from four hundred years of sleep and come running.

"*Is it hers*?" she said.

Her voice was like a stem bending.

"*It is*."

"*Is she coming*?"

"*No*," said the Ferryman. "*She has been dead eight hundred and seventy years. One of her line sent it.*"

The thorn-crowned woman stared at him.

"*She had a line*?"

"*Twenty generations*," said the Ferryman. "*Daughters. All of them. Every one of them kept the crown in a box and never wore it. And never let a moth in.*" A pause. "*The last of them paid me a whistler to bring it here.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAT DOWN.

On the bottom step of the stair. In the doorway of the tower she'd grown for her sister. With her thin knees drawn up. And put her face in her hands.

The Ferryman stood over her.

He didn't say anything. He was very patient. He'd been there since before the world was made.

After a long time she lifted her head.

"*Oz mustn't know*," she said.

"*No*."

"*Nobody must know*." She stood up. Slowly. Like something growing. "*Not Oz. Not Ysy. Not Cad. Nobody.*" She looked up the stair. Toward the room at the top. Toward the thing on the chair. "*It has to stay there. And say no. Forever.*"

She knelt down in the dust.

She put her hands flat on the ground. Thin. Grey-green. The fingers like twigs.

And the thorns came.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN LEFT HER there.

On her knees in the dust at the foot of the tower, with her hands on the ground and her face wet, growing thorns. Black. Hooked. Thick as a wrist. Rising round the tower in a ring. Round and round. Taller and taller. A mile of them.

He walked back across the plain to his boat.

Behind him, in the tallest of the glass palaces, in a hall with a ceiling like a frozen waterfall, five cocoons hung from the rafters.

They'd been turning in their sleep. For a summer. Shifting against their ropes. Breathing.

They stopped.

One by one. Down the hall. The great grey-gold shapes going still. Settling. Sinking deeper into the silk. The way a sleeper settles when a cool hand is laid on a hot forehead.

And slept.

◆ ◆ ◆

WENNA HARROW CAME HOME before the apples.

Thin. Thinner than her daughter had ever seen her. With her boots worn through and her feet bound in strips of her own skirt. With an empty box under her arm.

Seren was on the step.

She didn't say anything. She stood up. And looked at her mother coming up the path through the birch wood.

And ran.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WARDEN WAS IN the yard.

He'd been mending the barn door. Badly. With straw in his hair. He put down the hammer and watched them. Mother and daughter. Holding each other on the path in the evening light. Not saying anything.

Wenna looked at him over her daughter's shoulder.

He looked back.

"*Did she eat*?" said Wenna.

"*Not much*," said the Warden. "*She was very angry.*"

"*She still is*," said Seren. Into her mother's shoulder. Crying. "*I'm furious. I'm so angry with you. You went away. You never go away. You never—*"

"*I know*," said Wenna. "*I know, love.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DREAMED AT THE end of that summer.

The hall. The cocoons. Five of them. Grey-gold. Hanging from the rafters.

Still.

So still. More still than she'd ever dreamed them. Not swaying. Not turning. Not breathing. Hanging in the hall the way stones hang at the bottom of a pond.

And somewhere, far off, at the edge of the dream, at the edge of the plain, a tower. Small. Grey. In a ring of black thorns.

And in the window at the top, very faint, a gleam of silver.

She woke up smiling.

She didn't know why.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT THE FIRST SNOW, she made a lamp.

Out of clay from the stream. At the kitchen table. With her own hands. Small. Round. Brown. Plain. A Harrow lamp. One flame on both sides of a door. For the ones who go.

She pressed her thumb into the base before it dried.

She fired it in the hearth. She filled it with oil. She set it in the window of the cottage at the far end of the Vale. The east window. Facing the road.

And lit it.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN CAME IN FROM the yard and stopped dead in the doorway.

She looked at the lamp. In the window. Lit.

Then at her mother.

"*Mam*," she said. "*You've never—*"

"*I know.*"

"*Harrow women don't—*"

"*I know what Harrow women don't*," said Wenna. "*I've been one for forty years.*" She went back to the fire. Sat down. Picked up her mending. "*It's not for you.*"

Seren stared at her.

"*It's for the Warden*," said Wenna Harrow. "*He's coming down from his Spire tonight. Three days on foot in the snow. He'll want to see where he's going.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME UP THE path at dusk.

In his grey coat. Too tall. With snow on his shoulders and ink on his cuffs. And stopped. At the edge of the birch wood. Looking at the cottage.

At the lamp in the window.

He stood there for a long time.

Then he came up the path. And knocked. And Wenna opened the door.

He didn't say anything. He looked at her. And past her. At the lamp on the sill.

"*Well*," said Wenna Harrow. "*Ask me again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T THROW THE pan.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WROTE THE LETTER at midwinter.

At the kitchen table. By the light of the clay lamp. With her daughter married and gone to Highcrest with her Warden, and the cottage at the far end of the Vale very quiet, and the goat asleep under the table with a sock.

Seren. My bright girl. My last one.

If you're reading this, I'm gone, and you've stayed.

She wrote it all. The rule. The song. The cottages. The moths. She wrote it slowly, in her small slanting hand, the hand of a woman who'd never stayed anywhere long enough to learn to write slowly.

And near the end, she stopped.

She sat with the pen over the page for a long time.

Then she wrote:

I've taken the crown where it belongs. Where it was always meant to go.

She didn't write where. She didn't write how. She didn't write what it cost.

She didn't remember what it cost.

She only knew, somewhere very deep, in a warm empty place like a bed someone has just got out of, that it had been the right price.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIED BEFORE THE spring.

In the cottage at the far end of the Vale. In her bed. With her daughter holding her hand.

At the end, she opened her eyes.

"*Light the lamp for me*," said Wenna Harrow.

And closed them.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ON A GREY river at the edge of the world, a tall thin man with no eyes rowed a small square woman across to the far shore.

She sat in the bow. Facing back. Toward the world. The way they all do.

And halfway across, she started to whistle.

A long high run of notes. Rising. Falling. A tune with no name and no end. She didn't know what it was. She didn't know where she'd learned it. She stopped, halfway, and frowned, and said so.

And then she started again.
And whistled it all the way to the other side.
As if she'd finally found somewhere to stop.

PART TWO

THE GREY COUNTRY

CHAPTER 20

The White Road

THERE WERE NO DAYS in the Court, so Antho made some.

"*A day*," he said, "*is from when Pim wakes up to when he can't hold the room anymore.*"

They were sitting in the dust at the side of the white road. Between a gold washerwoman with a basket of gold linen on her hip and a gold boy holding a gold hoop. The washerwoman's eyes had followed them for a mile before they sat down. They were still following. Antho could feel them. On the back of his neck. Like a draught.

"*And a night*," said Antho, "*is when he makes the room and we sleep in it.*"

"*That's not a day*," said Lex. "*That's a Pim.*"

"*It's what we've got*."

His brother looked at the dim grey-gold light that came from nowhere. That hadn't changed since they stepped out of the Veil. That wasn't going to change.

"*Two Pims*, *then*," said Lex. "*Since the door.*"

"*Two Pims*," agreed Antho.

He looked at the basket on the ground beside the boy. Twelve cups. Each one heavy with nothing. Each one with an iron lid that sighed.

They'd drunk two.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D DONE THE SUMS a dozen times. He did them again, sitting in the dust. He couldn't help it. He'd been doing sums in his head since the shingle, since the Ferryman, since Seraphine sat on the rim of the pool with a Hush-cup in her lap and said *thirty-six days*.

A cup was three days. For one.

There were two of them who needed it. Him and Lex.

If they each drank only while they walked—only in the *day*—and slept at night in Pim's room, a cup did them both for a day and a half.

Twelve cups. Eighteen days.

If Pim held the nights.

He looked at Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOY WAS SITTING with his back against the gold boy's legs and his eyes shut. Small. Thin. In his blue coat with the brass buttons. His face very white. His hands open on his knees.

He'd held the room for the whole of the first night. Antho had lain awake in it and felt it. Round the four of them, in the dust, at the side of the road. A yard across. Quiet. Close. Pushing back against the full heavy air of the Court the way a cupped hand pushes back against water.

He'd held it till Antho thought he must be asleep. And then longer. And then, when Antho finally sat up and looked, he'd been sitting exactly where he'd sat down, with his eyes open, staring at nothing, holding it.

Sleep, Antho had said.

Can't, Pim had said. *If I sleep it goes.*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Pim*," said Antho now.

The boy opened his eyes.

"*How long can you—*"

"*Long enough*," said Pim.

"*That's not an answer.*"

Pim looked at him. With his grey-violet eyes. Very steady.

"*Long enough*," he said again.

And shut them.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED.

Down the white road. Between the kept. With the hum all round them, one note, low and soft and endless. With the palaces glittering on the edge of the sky.

Closer, now. A little. Antho could see shapes. A tall clear one, catching the light like a spire of ice. A dark one, squat and heavy. A gold one, domed, shining dully. And in the middle, the tallest, white as bone, with a roof like a frozen waterfall.

The hall.

He didn't know how he knew. He'd never seen it. He'd only heard it described. By his mother, who'd dreamed it. By Seraphine, who'd read about it. By Lex, who'd heard it from Elric, who'd felt it from the Knot.

He knew.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEPT DIDN'T END.

That was the thing Antho couldn't get used to. He'd thought they'd thin out. He'd thought there'd be a few hundred near the Veil, where Oszric had walked out among them in the first years. A crowd. And then the road would go on alone.

It didn't. They went on. Mile after mile. On both sides of the white road, in rows, three and four deep, standing in the dust. Cooks and grooms and maids and gardeners. Soldiers in gold armour with gold spears. Scribes with gold quills. A man with a gold fiddle tucked under his chin, mid-note. A woman with a gold baby at her breast.

All of them gold. All of them still. All of them with their eyes moving. All of them humming.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS A THRESHOLD Warden.

He felt doors. Every kind. Every door in every room, every gap between one breath and the next, every place at the back of a person's eyes where they kept the things they didn't say.

And the last one.

He felt for it. He couldn't help it. He walked down the white road between nine thousand gold people and felt for the last door in every one of them.

It wasn't there.

Not one. Not in the washerwoman. Not in the boy with the hoop. Not in the fiddler or the soldier or the woman with the baby. Not in the baby.

Nine thousand people. Nine thousand places where a door should be.

Gold. Smooth. Bricked up so perfectly you couldn't even see the seam.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT GOT WORSE THE further they went.

He didn't tell Lex. He didn't tell anyone. He walked down the white road and felt for the doors and found nothing and felt the Clarity in him tremble. Not drop. Not like the old days. He was at a hundred and he stayed at a hundred. But it *trembled*. Like a candle-flame in a room where someone keeps opening and closing a window.

He'd felt Bet Dale's missing door at the Lantern Keep and it had made the floor lurch under him.

This was nine thousand Bet Dales.

He walked through the middle of them with his hands at his sides and his eyes on the white stone and tried very hard not to feel for anything at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're doing it*," said Lex. Beside him. Quietly.

"*Doing what*?"

"*The thing you do. When you're listening to something I can't hear.*" His brother didn't look at him. He was looking at the road. "*You've been doing it since the groom. Since the first one.*"

Antho didn't answer.

"*Doors*," said Lex.

"*Yes*."

"*They haven't got any*."

"*No*."

Lex walked beside him for a while without saying anything.

"*Stop*," he said at last.

Antho looked at him.

"*Stop looking for them*," said Lex. "*You can't open them. Not here. Not yet. You said so. To the four at the edge.*" His voice was very quiet. "*So stop feeling for them. Just for now. Just till we've got the crown.*"

"*I can't*."

"*I know you can't*." Lex didn't look at him. "*Try anyway. For me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TRIED.

He walked down the white road between the kept and thought about other things. About Seraphine. About her list. About reason six hundred and five, which was *he checks*.

About his father. In a bed under a boarded window. With a Lantern beside him, three panes of glass and one of horn. Breathing. In. Catch. Out.

About a gold king walking out of a door at the edge of the world.

I'll be at your house.

That didn't help.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK WAS BREATHING.

Antho noticed it on the third Pim. Walking behind the big man on the white road. Watching his back. The scarred leather jerkin. The two long scars down it where something had once torn through.

Rising and falling. Slowly. Deeply. All the way down.

He'd been coughing all spring. Antho had heard him at the pool. A short dry rattle. Twice. Then a breath. Careful. Further than halfway. Mal had made room in his lungs and it was better than it had been, but it was still there. The grey. The catch.

It wasn't there now.

Hask walked down the white road between the kept, breathing like a man who'd never been down a mine in his life.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's not the room*," said Hask. When Antho came up beside him. Before Antho could ask. "*Mal's room. In my chest. That's still there. I can feel it.*" He looked at the road ahead. "*It's this place. It's full. The air. Everything. It fills me up. All the way.*"

"*Like she did*."

"*Like she did*," said Silas Hask.

They walked for a while.

"*I could stay*," said Hask.

Antho didn't say anything.

"*I won't*," said Hask. "*I said I wouldn't. I keep my word. I'm not like—*" He stopped. Didn't say whose name. "*But I could. I could find a place at the side of this road and sit down in the dust and breathe. All the way. Forever.*" His jaw was very tight. "*Nobody'd keep me. The gold won't stick. It thinks I'm one of theirs.*"

"*You're not*."

"*No*," said Hask. "*I'm a Coldwater hewer with a black scar on my arm and a stick waiting for me by a pool.*" He breathed in. All the way down. Out. "*I'm just telling you. In case you see me slowing down. In case I stop.*"

"*If you stop*?"

"*Pick me up*," said Silas Hask. "*And carry me. The way the smith carried Kell.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOPPED WHEN PIM stumbled.

He didn't fall. Antho caught his arm. He'd been walking behind Lex with the basket on his back and his eyes half shut, and his foot had come down on the edge of a slab and turned, and he'd gone sideways.

The boy was shaking. Antho could feel it. Through the blue coat. Through the thin arm. A deep fine tremor, like a wire pulled too tight.

"*Night*," said Antho.

"*Not yet—*"

"*Night*," said Antho again. "*You're making it night. Now. Sit down.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT DOWN IN the dust at the side of the road.

Behind a row of gold soldiers. Ten of them. In gold armour, with gold spears, standing to attention. Their gold eyes moving. Down. To the four people sitting at their feet.

Pim shut his eyes.

And the room came.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO FELT IT. SOFT. Close. Quiet. Spreading out from the boy the way warmth spreads out from a hearth. Round the four of them. A yard. Two. The full heavy air of the Court pressing against the edge of it.

And not coming in.

He felt his own chest loosen. The room Mal had given him from the cup—it was thinning. He could feel it. A day and a half was nearly done. But Pim's room was round him now. Holding. And he could breathe.

He lay down on his back in the dust.

And looked up at the soldiers.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE LOOKING BACK.

Ten gold faces. Ten pairs of gold eyes. Looking down at him from inside their gold helms. Young, most of them. Some of them very young. Seventeen. Eighteen. Boys. With gold spears and gold armour and gold freckles on their gold noses.

The one nearest Antho's head had a scar across his chin. Gold. Old. A boy's scar. From a fall, maybe. Off a wall. Out of a tree.

His eyes were moving.

Slowly. So slowly. From Antho's face. To Pim's. To Lex's. To Hask's. And back.

And the hum came out of him.

Antho could hear it. Close. So close. One note. Low. Soft. Coming out of a gold throat that couldn't open, a gold chest that couldn't breathe. Not loud. Barely there.

But there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What are they saying*?" said Lex. Quietly. Lying on his back beside Antho. Looking up at the same gold faces.

"*I don't know*."

"*It sounds like a word*."

"*It sounds like a note*."

"*It sounds like a word*," said Lex, "*with all the letters worn off.*"

Antho listened.

He lay in the dust in Pim's room and listened to the gold soldier with the scar on his chin hum one note, over and over, through a throat that couldn't open.

And thought, *Lex is right*.

It's a word.

It's a word that's been said so many times for so long that it's worn smooth. Like a coin rubbed smooth in a pocket. Like a step worn hollow by feet.

I can't hear what it was.

◆ ◆ ◆

[It's a hum,] said a voice.

Antho turned his head.

Lex was lying very still. His eyes unfocused. Listening to something only he could hear.

"*Ember says it's a hum*," said Lex. "*It says it's not a word. It says it's just the sound kept things make. Like the hum a kettle makes before it boils. Like the hum a hive makes.*" He was quiet. "*It says it doesn't think we should listen too hard.*"

"*Why not*?"

Lex didn't answer for a moment.

"*It says*," he said slowly, "*if it is a word, and we find out what it is, we'll have to do something about it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO DIDN'T SLEEP MUCH.

He lay in Pim's room in the dust behind the gold soldiers and listened to the hum and felt for doors he couldn't find and tried not to. Lex slept. Eventually. On his back with his hand on the bell and his mouth open. Hask slept sitting up, against the legs of a gold soldier, with his pick across his knees, breathing all the way down.

Pim didn't sleep.

He sat cross-legged in the middle of them with his eyes shut and his hands open on his knees and his face white, holding the room.

Antho watched him.

He'd known him for four years. Since a winter night at the Lantern Keep, when he'd opened the door to a knock and found a boy on the step. Twelve, maybe. Starved. Beaten. Blue with cold. With a scar on his elbow from a man called Kessick who'd tried to beat the voices out of him.

Silent.

He'd been silent for twelve years. Not because he couldn't talk. Because he'd learned, very young, that talking got you hit. And that silence—real silence, the kind that went all the way down—was a place you could hide.

He'd made a room inside himself. Out of being hurt. And lived in it.

And now he was holding it open. Round three grown men. In the middle of a country where nothing had moved for nine hundred years.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Pim*," said Antho. Very quietly. So as not to wake the others.

The boy didn't open his eyes.

"*You can tell me*," said Antho. "*If it's too much. If you can't. You can tell me and we'll drink a cup. We've got twelve.*"

"*Eighteen days*," said Pim. Not opening his eyes. "*If I hold the nights. Nine if I don't.*"

"*I know. But—*"

"*I can hold it.*"

"*You're shaking.*"

"*I know*," said Pim.

He didn't say anything else.

Antho lay in the dust and looked at him. At the small white face. At the hands, open on his knees, trembling very slightly. At the blue coat buttoned to the chin. At the pocket over his heart, buttoned too, with a folded piece of paper inside it. A drawing of a cat. No words.

He didn't argue.

He'd learned, a long time ago, from his father and his mother and a Moth Queen and a Well, that you didn't argue with someone who'd decided to hold a door.

You just held it with them.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE REACHED OUT.

Across the dust. Slowly. And put his hand on the boy's knee. Next to his open hand. Not holding it. Just there.

And opened himself.

He wasn't a room-maker. He wasn't the Hollow. He didn't have the little piece of the seventh that Pim had made out of being hurt.

But he was a door.

That was what he was. The whole of what he was. He'd stood in every kind of door. He'd held the door of the Hollowmaw for eight years with a hunger pushing on the other side. He'd held a door open for a whole Well, on Lantern Night, with his whole heart.

A room is just the space inside a door.

He held it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT PIM FEEL it.

The boy's hand moved. Just slightly. On his knee. His fingers touching Antho's.

The trembling eased.

Not stopped. Eased. Like a wire with someone else's hand on it, taking some of the pull.

"*Oh*," said Pim. Very quietly. Not opening his eyes.

"*I can't make it*," said Antho. "*Only you can make it. But I can hold the edge. While you rest.*"

The boy didn't say anything for a long time.

Then his shoulders came down. Just a little. From round his ears.

And Antho felt the room settle. Round them. Round all four of them. Not Pim's alone now. A boy's quiet, held up at the edges by a man who'd stood in every kind of door.

Pim's head drooped. Forward. Onto his chest.

He slept.

The room held.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO DIDN'T SLEEP AT all.

He sat in the dust behind the gold soldiers with his hand on Pim's knee and held the edge of the room and listened to the hum.

One note. Low. Soft. From the boy with the scar on his chin. From all ten soldiers. From the washerwoman a hundred yards back and the boy with the hoop. From all nine thousand of them, on both sides of the white road, from the Veil to the palaces.

A word with all the letters worn off.

He listened to it till the boy woke.

He didn't hear what it was.

He thought he was beginning to.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAW THE GLASS palace on the fourth Pim.

They'd seen it for days. A spire of ice on the edge of the sky. Catching the dim grey-gold light and throwing it back in flashes, like a mirror turned in the sun.

On the fourth Pim it wasn't on the edge of the sky anymore.

It was *there*.

Off the road. To the south. A mile, maybe. Rising out of the grey-gold dust like a frozen waterfall turned upside down. Glass. All of it. Towers and spires and domes and bridges. Clear as water. Glittering. Every surface a mirror. Every pane catching every other pane, so that the whole palace seemed to be made of light bouncing off itself forever.

And it was full of faces.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAW THEM FROM the road.

He couldn't not see them. In every pane. In every tower. Pale. White-haired. Grey-eyed. Turning. Following.

Thousands. A palace of thousands of faces, all the same face, all looking out of the glass at four people on the white road.

"*She's home*," said Lex. Very quietly.

"*She came home with Mam's blood*," said Antho. "*In her hand.*"

"*She's watching us*."

"*She's always watching*," said Antho. "*It's what she is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T GO NEAR it.

They kept to the road. To the north side of it. As far from the glass palace as the white stone would let them. Between the kept and the dust. With their heads down.

The faces followed them. All the way past. For a mile. Two. Turning in every pane of every tower as they went. Thousands of pale faces, all turning together, the way a field of sunflowers turns to follow the sun.

Nobody came out.

No hand reached out of the glass. No voice called. No frost wrote messages on the panes. The Glass Queen sat in her palace of mirrors and watched them go by, and did nothing at all.

"*Why isn't she—*" said Lex.

"I don't know."

"She could. She came out of a stream at Harrow. She came out of your Lantern."

"I know."

"Then why—"

"I don't know," said Antho again. *"Maybe she's waiting. Maybe she's frightened. Maybe Father's mirror-ward is still in her head."* He looked at the palace. At the faces. *"Maybe she's just looking."*

◆ ◆ ◆

[She's lonely,] said Ember.

Lex told him, later. That night. In Pim's room.

[Arion said it. In the cottage. Nine hundred years of her own face. And then the baby looked at her.] A pause. *[I think she's looking at us because we're the first new thing she's seen since the baby.]*

She's dangerous, Lex had thought.

[Yes,] Ember had said. *[Lonely things often are.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE IRON PALACE CAME next.

North of the road. Closer than the glass. Squat. Heavy. Dark. A great block of black iron rising out of the dust like a fist. No towers. No windows. A single door, huge, at the front, standing open.

Empty.

Antho could feel it. As they passed. A Threshold Warden feels doors. That one was open and there was nothing behind it. No one. Not a servant. Not a guard. Not a kept groom with a gold brush.

"Caddoc's," said Lex.

"He's on the thread."

"He left it open."

"He doesn't care," said Antho. *"He's not coming back. He's going to the Knot. And then he's going to his brother with the Key."* He looked at the open iron door. *"He doesn't need a house. He's got a road."*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THERE WAS SOMETHING else.

Beyond the iron palace. North. Far off. Rising out of the dust at the very edge of what Antho could see.

A line.

Silver. Thin. Thinner than a hair. Straight. Going *up*. Out of the plain. Into the dim grey-gold of the sky. At a slant. Up and up and up, until it was too thin to see and was only a brightness, a suggestion, going on into nothing.

And on it, near the ground, as far as Antho could make out—

Rings.

Black. Small at this distance. Strung on the silver line like beads. Going up. Into the sky. Further and further. Too many to count.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The last thread*," said Lex.

He'd stopped walking. He was standing on the white road with his face turned north and his hand over his eyes, though there was no sun.

"*That's where it starts*," he said. "*Here. On this side. That's where it ties into the Court.*" He lowered his hand. "*That's where he started climbing.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*It goes up*," said Lex. "*Look. Up. Not across. Up into the sky.*" His voice was very strange. "*And under the world. And down to the Knot. And he's on it. Somewhere. Ringing it with iron.*"

"*Can we cut it*?" said Hask. "*From here. At the bottom.*"

Lex didn't answer for a long time.

"*It's his road*," he said at last. "*He's on it. He said so. At Coldwater. You saw the ring grow back.*" He looked at the silver line going up into nothing. "*If we broke it here, he'd ring it here. If we broke it a mile up, he'd ring it a mile up.*" A pause. "*It doesn't matter where you cut a man's road. He's still on it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED ON.

The silver line stayed with them. To the north. Going up into the sky. Antho kept looking at it. He couldn't help it. A thin bright line with black beads on it, climbing into nothing.

Clink, he thought. *Clink. Clink.*

He couldn't hear it. Not from here.

He heard it anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL WAS AHEAD now.

White. Bone-white. Taller than the glass palace. Taller than anything. With a roof like a frozen waterfall, glittering. And doors. Tall. Glass. Standing open at the

end of the white road, where the road ran up a long shallow flight of steps and stopped.

They didn't go near it either.

They didn't need to. The crown wasn't in the hall. The crown was in a tower. A mile off the road. North. In a forest of thorns.

Antho looked north.

Nothing. Dust. The iron palace. The silver line going up into the sky. Flat grey-gold plain going away to the edge of everything.

No thorns.

"*Mam said near the palaces*," he said. "*A mile off. North. Past the hall.*"

"*Past the hall*," said Lex.

They looked at the hall. White. Tall. With its doors open.

"*How far past*?"

"*She didn't say*," said Antho. "*She dreamed it. Dreams aren't maps.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOPPED FOR THE night behind the last of the kept.

There was a last. Antho hadn't believed there would be. But the rows of gold people ran out, a mile short of the hall. The last one was a girl. Small. Seven or eight. In a white dress with a gold sash, gold now, all of it. Holding a little gold bunch of flowers in both hands. As if she'd been about to give them to someone.

Her eyes moved. Slowly. To the four people sitting down in the dust behind her.

Pim shut his eyes.

The room came.

Antho put his hand on Pim's knee and held the edge of it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WOKE IN THE dark that wasn't dark.

He didn't know what woke him. He'd been asleep, for once. Properly. Pim had held the room for most of the night and then dropped into sleep sitting up, and the room had held, and Antho had held the edge of it, and somewhere in there he'd slept too.

He woke.

And the room was wrong.

◆ ◆ ◆

THIN. THAT WAS THE first thing. Not gone. Still round them. But stretched, like a bubble that's been blown too big.

Held only at the edges. By him. Only by him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT UP.

Lex was asleep. On his back. With his hand on the bell. Hask was asleep. Sitting up. Against the gold girl's legs. With his pick across his knees.

The basket was there. On the dust. In the middle of where they'd been sitting. Eleven cups now. They'd drunk another that day.

And beside it, folded, a piece of paper.

Pim wasn't there.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO PICKED UP THE paper.

He knew what it was before he unfolded it. He unfolded it anyway. In the dim grey-gold light that came from nowhere, in a room that was getting thinner every second because only one person was holding it now.

A drawing.

In pencil. Small. Careful.

Not a cat.

A girl. Seven. Eight. In a grey dress too big for her, with the sleeves rolled up. An apron. A wooden spoon in her hand. Standing at the side of a road.

Her eyes were drawn very large. Very dark. Looking out of the paper.

And next to her, smaller, a boy. In a coat with brass buttons. Holding out his hand.

No words.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED BACK DOWN the road.

East. Toward the Veil. Toward the kept. Toward the rows of gold on both sides of the white stone, running back and back into the grey-gold dim, mile after mile, all the way to the door at the edge of the world.

Toward a kitchen girl with a wooden spoon, at the side of the road, near the beginning. Whose eyes hadn't moved slowly like the others.

Whose eyes had moved *fast*.

Darting. From Pim's face to the basket. Back and forth. The way a child's eyes move when she's seen something she wants very badly.

He looked back, Antho thought. *Twice*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," he said.

His brother woke the way he always woke now. All at once. Bolt upright. Hand on the bell.

He saw Antho's face. He saw the paper. He saw the empty place in the dust where the boy had been sitting.

"*Where—*"

"*Back*," said Antho. His voice was very calm. He didn't feel calm. He felt the room round them thinning like ice on a pond in spring, and he felt the Court pressing on the edge of it, and he felt a boy of fourteen walking alone down a white road between nine thousand gold people with no room round him at all.

"*He's gone back*," said Antho Vey. "*For the girl.*"

CHAPTER 21

The King Walks

THE RAVEN CAME ON the fourth morning, and it was the wrong raven.

Wren knew before it landed. She was in the clearing at Harrow with Lark on her hip and a bucket in her other hand, the good one, at the stream, and she heard it come over the birch wood. Not the harsh croak of Quill. Not the heavy beat of one of Roole's big ravens.

Something ragged. Something limping in the air. Something that had flown a very long way very fast and had nothing left.

It came down on the stepping stone in front of her and missed its footing and fell in the stream.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GOT IT OUT.

She dropped the bucket and knelt on the bank with the baby on her hip and fished it out of the water with her good hand. It was old. One-eyed. The milky eye half shut. Its feathers soaked and ragged and its breast heaving. A thin silver ring on its leg.

And a scrap of paper. Rolled tight. Tied with grey thread.

Lark reached for the raven.

"*No*," said Wren. "*Gently. He's tired.*"

The raven looked at the baby with its one good eye.

"*Smith*," it croaked. Faintly.

"*He's not here*," said Wren. "*He's gone. Across.*" Her hands were shaking. "*Give it to me. Give me the letter.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS ROOLE'S HAND. Small. Square. Plain.

It wasn't finished.

Vey. Wren. Whoever reads this.

He's out. Came through the door at dawn the day after they went in. Walking. Gold. Taller than anything. Everything he walks past goes gold.

I've got them out. The Keepers. Nan Ashby. She didn't want to go. I carried her. She bit me.

He's coming east. Slowly. He's not hurrying.

I'm going to stand

That was all.

The last word trailed off. The pen had gone on a little way after it, a thin line across the paper, as if the hand holding it had been pulled away.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN READ IT THREE times.

Then she stood up. In the clearing. With the baby on her hip and a half-drowned raven at her feet and the stream running loud and the birch tree at the edge of the clearing standing shining in the morning sun. Gold. Kept.

"*Seren*," she said.

Not loud.

The blue door opened anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER-IN-LAW CAME DOWN the oak ramp barefoot and took the paper out of her hand and read it.

She didn't say anything.

She read it twice. Then she folded it, very carefully, along the creases Roole had made. And held it.

"*He went to stand*," said Seren. Quietly.

"*He promised*," said Wren. "*Antho told him. Get out. Don't stand in front of him. You can't.*" Her voice cracked. "*He promised he'd get them out first.*"

"*He did get them out*," said Seren. "*He carried Nan Ashby. She bit him.*" She looked at the folded paper. "*And then he went back and stood.*"

"*Why*?"

Seren looked at her for a long moment.

"*Because somebody has to stand somewhere*," she said. "*That's what Fenn said. At the south edge. Antho told me.*" She held the paper against her chest. "*Daxian Roole's been standing somewhere his whole life, love. He didn't know how to stop.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY HEARD THE REST from a Keeper.

On the ninth day. A woman. Grey cloak. Iron-grey hair. A Keeper's staff, and her face burned red by the wind, and her boots worn through. She came up the track through the birch wood on foot, alone, and stood at the edge of the clearing and looked at the two cottages and the gold birch and the stream.

Ada Fell.

"*Is he here*?" she said. "*The smith?*"

"*No*," said Wren. "*He's across. He went through the door.*"

Ada Fell sat down on the grass.

Just sat. As if her legs had gone. With her staff across her knees.

"*Then I'll tell you*," she said. "*Somebody should know. Somebody should write it down.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD THEM IN the blue-door cottage.

With Arion in the bed under the boarded window, propped on his pillows, with the Lantern burning beside him. Three panes of glass and one of horn. With Seren on the edge of the bed holding his hand. With Wren on the floor by the hearth with the baby asleep in her lap and the raven, dried now, perched on the back of a chair, eating crusts.

Ada Fell sat at the table with a cup of tea she didn't drink.

"*He got us out*," she said. "*All of us. Two hundred Keepers. And the crofters from Westerling. And Nan Ashby. He made us go east. He made us walk. He said, don't stop, don't look back, get to the Blightmarch and keep going.*"

"*And you went*."

"*We went*," said Ada Fell. "*Most of us.*" She turned the cup on the table. "*I didn't. I hid on the wall. I wanted to see.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He came at noon*," she said. "*The King. Walking. Down out of the door at the edge of the world, into the gold. He didn't hurry. He walked the way an old man walks in his garden on a summer evening. Looking at things.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*He was so big*," said Ada Fell. "*You don't understand. You can't. Nobody can, till they see him. Taller than the gate. Broader than two men. Gold all over. Gold beard. Gold hair. A crown of gold leaves, crooked. And his eyes—*" She stopped. "*I couldn't look at his eyes. Nobody can. They're like the sun. Like the inside of a forge.*"

"*And Roole*?"

The Keeper looked at the cup.

"*Commander Roole was at the gate*," she said. "*The east gate of Greyfall. Standing in it. In the middle of it. In his grey. With Fenn's staff.*"

Seren's hand tightened on Arion's.

"*Fenn's staff*," said Ada Fell again. "*He'd taken it out of the grave. In the night. After we left. I saw him do it, from the wall. He went out to the rim with a spade and dug it up and cleaned it off.*" Her voice was very flat. "*And then he stood in the east gate. With it held crosswise. The way Fenn held it at the south edge, all night, between the families and the Mothwing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And the King came up the road*," said Ada Fell. "*And stopped.*"

"*Stopped*?"

"*In front of him. In front of the gate.*" She looked up. "*He could have walked through him. He could have walked round him. He could have walked through the wall. Nothing stopped him. Nothing touched him. The gold went out from his feet in every direction, everything he passed.*" She swallowed. "*He stopped. In front of Commander Roole. And looked down at him.*"

"*Did he say anything*?" said Arion. From the bed.

"*He said, what's your name*," said Ada Fell. "*Very kindly. Like you'd ask a child.*"

"*And Roole*?"

"*Roole said, Daxian Roole, Commander of the Keepers of the Stones. You're not coming through this gate.*"

Wren closed her eyes.

"*And the King laughed*," said Ada Fell. "*Not unkind. Delighted. Like Roole had said something wonderful.*" She turned the cup. "*And he said, why not? And Roole said, because somebody has to stand somewhere.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE TICKED.

Nobody said anything for a long time.

"*And then*?" said Seren. Very quietly.

"*And then the King said, that's beautiful*," said Ada Fell. "*He said, that's the most beautiful thing anyone's said to me since I woke.*" Her voice was shaking now. She didn't let it stop her. "*He said, you should never stop. You should stand there forever. Exactly like that. With your staff and your grey and your face.*"

"*Oh no*," said Wren.

"*And he put out his hand*," said Ada Fell. "*And touched him. On the forehead. Very gently. With one finger. The way you'd touch a sleeping child.*"

She stopped.

"*And he's there*," she said. "*Now. In the east gate of Greyfall. Gold. Standing. With Fenn's staff held crosswise.*" She put her face in her hands. "*His eyes move. I went down after. After the King walked on. I went and looked at him.*" Her voice came through her fingers. "*His eyes move. They followed me. When I touched his arm, they looked at me. And I couldn't tell what they were saying.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T CRY.

She'd thought she would. She sat on the floor by the hearth with the baby asleep in her lap and her gold-fingered hand on the baby's back and thought about a hard plain man with a hatchet face and one stiff arm. Who'd stood at the edge of the gold with his arm out in front of Lex. *Don't step on it*. Who'd dug Fenn's grave with one hand. Who'd written to Lex because he didn't know who else to tell.

Come back, he'd said. At the crack. At dawn. To the four of them. *Don't thank me. Come back.*

She didn't cry.

She sat with it. In her chest. Like a stone.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He's not dead*," said Arion.

They all looked at him.

He was lying very still on the pillows. Looking at the boards over the west window. His grey eyes very bright in the Lantern-light.

"*He's not dead*," he said again. "*None of them are. Not Roole. Not Bet Dale. Not the boy with the sheep. Not the nine thousand on the road.*" He breathed. In. Catch. Out. "*They're kept. It's not the same thing. It's worse. But it's not the same.*"

"*Can they come back*?" said Ada Fell. Through her hands.

"*Lex found the room in front of it*," said Arion. "*In Tilda. In Wren. Before it set.*" He turned his head on the pillow. To look at Wren. At her hand. "*Pim made one of them cry. Bet Dale. Through solid gold. For one breath.*"

"*That's not coming back*."

"*No*," agreed Arion. "*But it's a crack.*" He looked back at the boards. "*My son says everything's a crack first. He gets that from Brannoc. Brannoc gets it from fifty years of mending things.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING WALKED EAST.

Slowly.

They heard about it every day. Ravens. Riders. Keepers on foot. Farmers fleeing ahead of him with carts piled high and their children on top and their faces white.

He walked perhaps five miles a day. Perhaps less. He walked the way Ada Fell had said, like an old man in his garden. Looking at things. Stopping.

He stopped at every village.

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS THE THING nobody understood. Not at first.

He didn't attack them. He didn't burn them. He didn't march through them with an army, the way the Pale Warden had marched, the way armies did in the old songs.

He *visited*.

He walked into a village in the western shires at noon, with the gold spreading out from his feet across the green, and the people who hadn't fled watching from their windows. And he sat down. On the edge of the well. Or the steps of the chapel. Or a bench outside the inn.

And waited.

And they came.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT ALL OF THEM. Not most.

But some.

The old. The sick. The ones who'd been sitting by a bed for a month, or a year, listening to someone breathe. A woman with a son wasting in the back room. A man whose wife didn't know him anymore. A girl with a grandmother who screamed in the night with pain no healer could touch.

They came out of their houses. Slowly. One by one. And crossed the gold green. And stood in front of the Gilded King on the edge of the well.

And he listened.

Every one. For as long as they wanted to talk. Riders who'd seen it said so. He sat on the edge of the well with his great gold hands on his knees and his furnace eyes half shut, so you could almost look at them, and listened to every word.

And then he said, *I can help*.

And they said yes.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Eleven at Marrowby*," said Elowen.

She'd come on the fifteenth day. On her grey warhorse. With Oathkeeper on her hip and dust to her knees and her face hard as a door.

"*Eleven*," she said again. In the clearing. Not getting down. "*Old ones. Sick ones. The baby with the croup. Her mother came out with her in her arms.*" Her jaw worked. "*Sixteen at Hollin's Rest. Nine at Thistledown.*"

"*Thistledown*," said Wren.

Elowen looked at her.

"*That's mine*," said Wren. "*That's where I'm from. That's my village.*"

"*I know.*"

"*Who*?"

Elowen didn't answer for a moment.

"*Old Mother Tansy*," she said. "*From the mill. And the Cartwright twins, both of them, they had the wasting.*" A pause. "*And Gaffer Holm.*"

Wren put her hand over her mouth.

Gaffer Holm. Who'd taught her to set snares when she was eight. Who'd given her a hare, once, a whole one, when there was no food in the house and Tam was crying with hunger, and said *don't tell your mam where you got it*. Who'd been ninety-one. Who'd been dying of something in his belly for a year.

"*He went himself*," said Elowen. "*Nobody took him. He walked out of his house on his own two sticks and across the green and sat down on the edge of the well next to the King and said, I'm tired, lad. Can you help?*"

"*And he—*"

"*He said yes*," said Elowen. "*And put his hand on the old man's shoulder.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WENT TO SEE him.

She didn't decide to. She stood in the clearing at Harrow on the eighteenth day with her daughter asleep in the sling against her chest and her bow on her back and her hand, her left hand, gold from the knuckles to the nails, and found she was already calling the wind.

"*Wren*," said Seren. From the ramp.

"*I know.*"

"*He's a hundred miles off.*"

"*I know.*"

"*You've got the baby.*"

Wren looked down at the dark fluff of hair against her chest. At the small square fist curled against her collarbone.

"*I know*," she said.

She didn't stop calling the wind.

"*I need to see him*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Once. Before he gets here. I need to see what he is.*" She looked at Seren. "*I'm a tracker. I've tracked everything. Wolves. Rock-wyrms. Mothwing across the Sundered Lands.*" Her voice was very steady. "*I need to see his tracks.*"

Seren looked at her for a long moment.

Then she came down the ramp. And put her hand flat on the baby's back. Next to Wren's gold fingers.

"*Don't let him see her*," she said.

"*He'll see her*," said Wren. "*He sees everything.*" She swallowed. "*But I won't let him near.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT ON THE wind.

A hundred miles. In a morning. West over the Vale and the downs and the shires, high, higher than she'd been since Lantern Night. With her daughter on her chest, laughing. Lark loved it. She loved the cold and the speed and the great wide rushing of the air. She laughed the whole way. Her fists out. Her face turned up.

Wren didn't laugh.

She looked down.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAW THE ROAD first.

From a long way off. From the air. A line. Gold. Running across the green of the western shires from the far edge of the world. Not straight. Not like the white road in the Court. *Wandering*. Bending. Going from village to village. A gold thread drawn across a green cloth by a hand that stopped to look at things.

Wide. A furlong wide. More, in places. Where he'd stopped.

Everything in it gold.

Fields. Hedges. Copses. Barns. A mill. A bridge over a river, and the river under it, a gold ribbon, still, flat, not flowing. A flock of sheep, gold, scattered across a gold hillside. A farmhouse with its door open and gold washing on the line.

And at the end of it, where the gold stopped and the green began again—

Light.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME DOWN IN a copse a mile off.

Green. Not gold. Yet. On the edge of a village she didn't know. Brick houses. A chapel with a square tower. A green with a well in the middle.

She climbed a tree. An elm. Tall. With the baby on her chest. She went up through the branches the way she'd gone up the apple tree at Old Mag's, with petals falling. There were no petals. It was high summer. The elm was dark and full and still.

From the top she could see the green.

And him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS SITTING ON the edge of the well.

Ada Fell had said he was big. Elowen had said it. Everyone had said it.

They hadn't said it right.

He sat on the stone rim of the well with his knees apart and his great gold hands resting on them, and he was the biggest thing Wren had ever seen that was shaped like a man. Bigger than Hask. Bigger than Brannoc. His shoulders were as wide as the well. His head, bent, was higher than the wellhead's roof. A beard of gold to the middle of his chest. Gold hair to his shoulders. A crown of gold leaves, crooked.

A robe of white and gold, spread out on the grass round him.

The grass was gold. In a circle round the well. Spreading. Slowly. A foot an hour. Ten feet. Twenty.

And he glowed.

Not like a lamp. Not like a fire. Like *metal*. Like gold in a crucible, just before it pours. A deep warm heavy light coming up out of him, out of his skin, out of the gold of his beard and his hands and his robe. Lighting the green. Lighting the faces of the people round him.

There were people round him.

◆ ◆ ◆

A DOZEN. PERHAPS MORE. Sitting on the gold grass at his feet. Old. Most of them. A man in a wheeled chair, pushed by a woman with grey hair. A girl, holding a baby. A boy of ten with his arm round his grandmother, who was shaking, who couldn't stop shaking, whose hands flew and jerked in her lap like birds.

They weren't afraid.

That was the thing Wren would remember. Later. That they weren't afraid. They sat on the gold grass at the feet of the Gilded King in the summer sun and looked up at him the way you'd look up at a kind uncle telling a story by the fire.

And he was talking to them.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE COULDN'T HEAR. NOT from the elm. Too far.

She called the wind.

Not much. Just a little. Just enough. A thread of air, coming off the green, up the slope, into the top of the elm. Carrying the sound.

His voice came with it.

Deep. Warm. Like a bell. Like a fire roaring up a chimney. Not loud. Gentle. Talking to the shaking grandmother. Very slowly. Very kindly.

"*—and it won't hurt*," said the Gilded King. "*I promise. Not at all. It'll feel like nothing. Like falling asleep in a warm room.*" A pause. "*And then you'll never shake again. Never. Your hands will be still. Your heart will be still. You'll sit in your chair by your window and your grandson will come and see you every day and you'll never be frightened again.*"

"*Will I know him*?" said the old woman. Her voice was a thread. Shaking with her hands. "*Will I know he's there?*"

"*You'll see him*," said the Gilded King. "*Every time. Your eyes will follow him across the room.*"

The boy's arm tightened round his grandmother.

"*Gran*," he said. "*Gran, you don't have to—*"

"*I'm so tired, Pip*," said the old woman. "*I'm so tired of shaking.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WATCHED HIM PUT out his hand.

Slowly. Gently. One great gold finger. Toward the old woman's forehead. The way Ada Fell had said. The way you'd touch a sleeping child.

The boy didn't stop him.

The old woman closed her eyes.

And the finger touched her.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T TAKE A breath.

From the forehead. Outward. Down. The old woman's grey hair. Her face. Her shaking hands, flying in her lap, slowing, stopping, *stopped*. Her shawl. Her skirt. Her feet in their worn shoes on the gold grass.

Gold.

Still.

She sat on the green in front of the well with her eyes closed and her hands folded in her lap. Perfectly still. For the first time in years. Gold.

And then her eyes opened.

Gold.

And moved. Slowly. So slowly. To her grandson.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOY MADE A sound.

Wren heard it. On her thread of wind. Small. High. Not a word.

He was holding her. His arm still round her shoulders. Round gold shoulders. Hard. Cold. Still. He was holding her and she wasn't holding him back and she couldn't.

He looked up. At the King.

"*She's not shaking*," he said.

"*No*," said the Gilded King. Gently. "*She'll never shake again.*"

"*She's not—*" The boy's voice broke up. "*She's not anything.*"

The King looked down at him for a long moment. With his furnace eyes half shut.

"*She's kept*," he said. "*That's better than anything, child. You'll see. When you're older. When it's your turn to sit by a bed.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T KNOW SHE'D moved until she was on the wind.

Off the top of the elm. Into the air. Over the copse. Over the brick houses. Over the green.

She didn't plan it. She didn't think. Her body did it, the way it did on rooftops. She was in the air over the green with her daughter on her chest and her bow in her hand and an arrow on the string before her head caught up.

She loosed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A GOOD shot. She'd been shooting since she was eight. She'd shot hares on the high moors above Thistledown with Gaffer Holm watching. The arrow went down off the wind in a long clean arc, fast, true, straight at the great gold head bent over the boy.

And a yard from it, it went gold.

Not slowed. Not stopped. *Gold*. All at once. Shaft and fletching and head. In the air. And fell. Heavily. Straight down. Onto the gold grass at his feet with a sound like a dropped coin.

The King didn't look up.

He looked at the arrow.

At the gold arrow lying on the gold grass at his feet. For a long moment.

Then he bent down. Slowly. With a creak like a great oak in a wind. And picked it up. Between his great gold finger and thumb.

And turned it over. Looking at it. The fletching. The head. Very carefully. The way a jeweller looks at a ring.

"*Goose feathers*," said the Gilded King. "*Grey ones. Trimmed very neatly. With a little nick in each so they'll spin.*" He looked at the head. "*Hand-forged. Leaf-shaped. With a word cut in it. KNIT.*"

He looked up.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN COULDN'T LOOK AT his eyes.

She tried. She hung in the air over the green on the wind with her bow in her hand and tried, and her eyes watered and burned and slid away, the way your eyes slide away from the sun. She looked at his beard instead. His mouth. Which was smiling.

"*Mistwalker*," said Oszric of the Crowned.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T ANSWER.

"*It's a beautiful arrow*," he said. Warmly. "*Your husband made it, didn't he. The smith. I can feel him in it. The way you can feel a baker in his bread.*" He turned it over again. "*He's very good. He's better than any smith we had. We had very good smiths.*"

"*Let them go*," said Wren.

The King looked round. At the people sitting on the gold grass round him. The man in the wheeled chair. The girl with the baby. The boy with his arm round a gold grandmother.

"*Let who go*?" he said. Puzzled. "*I'm not holding them. They came to me. They can leave whenever they like.*" He looked back up at her. "*Nobody's made to stay, Mistwalker. Not ever. I only help the ones who ask.*"

"*She asked because she was tired*," said Wren. "*Because she was frightened. Because she couldn't bear it.*"

"*Yes*," said the Gilded King. "*Isn't that the best reason?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WOKE UP.

Wren felt her. Against her chest. A jerk. A breath. Her head lifting. Wobbling. Looking round.

Looking down.

At the light.

At the great gold shape on the edge of the well, glowing like metal in a crucible. At the gold grass. At the gold grandmother.

At him.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING WENT STILL.

Wren saw it. All of him. His great gold hands, stopping. His smile, stopping. His furnace eyes, opening. All the way. So that the light coming out of them was like the sun coming out from behind a cloud.

He was looking at the baby.

"*Oh*," said Oszric. Very softly. "*Oh, there she is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN PULLED THE WIND round them.

Tight. Fast. A whirl. The way she'd done in the cellar. So nothing could land. So nothing could settle. So there was a wall of moving air between her daughter and anything that wanted to reach her.

The King didn't move.

He sat on the edge of the well with the gold arrow in his fingers and looked up at the baby through the whirling air. And his face—

His face did something Wren had never seen a face do.

It *hungered*.

Not like the Moth Queen. Not lit and patient and courteous. Not like a thing that wanted to drink.

Like a man looking through a window into a warm room on a winter night. Into a room with a fire and a table and children round it. A room he'd never been allowed into. A room he'd stood outside for nine hundred years.

"*She's new*," said the Gilded King. "*Isn't she.*" His voice was very quiet. "*I can feel it. From here. She's full of room. She's full of things that haven't happened yet.*" He leaned forward. Just a little. "*Do you know how long it's been since I saw anything new?*"

"*You can't have her*," said Wren.

"*I don't want to have her*," said Oszric. Gently. Patiently. As if explaining something to a child. "*I want to keep her. That's different.*" He smiled. "*I want her to be safe. Forever. Exactly as she is. Exactly this new. I want her never to be hurt, or sick, or old, or frightened, or sad.*"

"*Or anything*," said Wren.

The King looked at her for a long moment.

"*Yes*," he said. "*Or anything. Isn't that the point?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE RAN.

On the wind. Up. Away. East. As fast as she'd ever gone. Faster. Over the green and the brick houses and the copse and the gold road wandering away across the shires behind her.

She heard him call after her.

Not loud. He didn't need to be loud. His voice came after her on the air like the heat off a forge. Warm. Deep. Kind.

"*Tell the old man I'm coming*," called the Gilded King. "*Tell him I'm walking. I'll visit everyone on the way.*"

A pause.

"*Tell him to wait for me*," said Oszric. "*I'd like to have tea.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CRIED ON THE way home.

A hundred miles. On the wind. With her daughter on her chest, asleep again, worn out from laughing. She cried the whole way and the wind took the tears off her face and carried them away behind her.

She didn't know what she was crying for.

For Gaffer Holm. For Roole. For a boy called Pip with his arm round a gold grandmother.

For a great gold man on the edge of a well looking at her daughter like a starving man looks through a window.

She didn't know.

She cried anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE WAS AT HARROW when she got back.

On Ashka. Antho had left the dragon at Harrow. Seraphine had flown down from the Keep that morning, with a satchel of books and ink on her fingers and her spectacles on her nose.

She was sitting at the table in the blue-door cottage. With Arion propped on his pillows beside her. With a book open. With a page of sums.

She looked up as Wren came in.

She looked at her face.

"*You saw him*," she said.

"*I saw him*."

Seraphine looked at her for a long moment. Then down at the page of sums. Then back up.

"*Sit down*," she said. "*There's something I need to tell you. And I don't think you're going to like it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Eighteen days*," said Seraphine.

They were all round the table. Wren and Seren and Seraphine. Arion in the bed beside it. The baby asleep on the sheepskin by the hearth. The raven on the back of a chair.

"*That's how long they've been gone*," said Seraphine. "*Since they walked through the door. Since Roole's raven said they went in.*"

"*They said fourteen*," said Wren. "*Fourteen days. Fourteen cups.*"

"*I know*."

"*So they're late*," said Wren. "*They're four days late. They're coming. They'll be—*"

"*They're not late*," said Seraphine.

She pushed the page of sums across the table.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN COULDN'T READ IT. It was Seraphine's hand, small and neat, and it was numbers, and it was sums, and it went down the whole page and onto the back.

"*There's no time in the Court*," said Seraphine. "*That's what the prologue to every story says. That's what Maelis said. In the Hall of Lanterns. That's what Orrin told Old Mag.*" She tapped the page. "*Nine hundred years. And they slept. And they woke.*"

"*So?*"

"*So Maelis woke up*," said Seraphine, "*when a third lamp was lit at the Hollowmaw. A year and a half ago. The night before the wedding.*" She tapped the page again. "*And she came through. And she was in our world for nine months.*" Another tap. "*And Orrin was awake in the Court the whole time. Waiting. Kneeling. Nine hundred years.*" She looked up. "*And when Ysenne spoke to Wren in the window, the first night, she said she'd been looking through the crack for weeks. Weeks, Wren. The crack had been open six days.*"

Wren stared at her.

"*It's not the same*," said Seraphine. "*Time. On the other side. It doesn't go the same speed.*" She took her spectacles off. Rubbed her eyes. "*I've been working it out for a week. From Orrin. From Ysenne. From the frost on my spectacles. From the Ferryman,*

who said the grey country has no days." She put the spectacles back on. *"It's slower there. Much slower."*

"How much slower?"

Seraphine looked at the page.

"Ten," she said. *"Near enough. A day there is ten days here."*

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The fire ticked. The raven shifted on the back of the chair. On the sheepskin by the hearth, the baby sighed in her sleep.

"Fourteen days," said Wren slowly. *"In the Court."*

"A hundred and forty here."

"That's—"

"Five months," said Seraphine. Very quietly. *"Near enough. Twenty weeks."* She looked at the page. *"They walked in three days after midsummer."*

"Twenty weeks after midsummer," said Arion. From the bed. Very quietly.

They all looked at him.

He was lying on his pillows looking at the boards over the west window. His grey eyes very steady.

"The end of autumn," he said. *"The night everyone lights a lantern for the lost."*

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN PUT HER HANDS flat on the table.

Her right hand. Pink. Freckled. A tracker's hand. And her left. Pink to the knuckles. Gold from the knuckles to the nails.

"They don't know," she said.

"No."

"They think it's fourteen days. They think they'll come back through the door and it'll be the end of summer and the King will still be walking and—" Her voice cracked. *"They don't know."*

"No," said Seraphine. *"They don't."*

"Five months," said Wren. *"He walks five miles a day. Less. He stops at every village."* She looked at the window. The boarded window. West. *"It's two hundred and forty miles from Greyfall to Harrow. Roole said."*

Nobody answered.

They didn't need to. They could all do the sums.

◆ ◆ ◆

"Lantern Night," said Arion.

He said it to the boards. To the ceiling. To nobody.

"*He'll be here by Lantern Night*," he said. "*The King. For tea.*" He breathed. In. Catch. Out. "*And Caddoc will be at the Knot. And the boys will come out of the door at the edge of the world thinking it's the end of summer.*"

"*Arion—*" said Seren.

"*And I'll be here*," said her husband. "*In this bed. Waiting.*" He turned his head on the pillow. And looked at her. "*I told Lex I'd try. I told Antho I'd try.*" A faint smile. "*I didn't know I'd have to try for five months.*"

Seren didn't say anything.

She took his hand. And held it. And didn't let go.

"*Then you'll try for five months*," she said. Very steady. "*You've been trying for two hundred and thirty-four years. Five months is nothing.*"

"*It's quite a lot*," said Arion. "*At my age.*"

"*I'll bring pies*," said Seren Harrow.

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT NIGHT WREN STOOD at the edge of the clearing and looked west.

The sun had gone down. The birch wood was dark. The stream was running. Behind her, in the east window of her own cottage, the hornlight sat on the sill. Gold. Kept. The little iron lantern and its horn panes and its wick, all gold, all still. It didn't glow. It would never glow again.

She'd lit a candle beside it. An ordinary one. In a holder Brannoc had made, with no glass in it at all.

It was very small.

She stood at the edge of the birch wood with her daughter asleep in the sling and her gold fingers on the baby's back and looked west over the trees. Over the Vale. Over the downs. Toward the shires. Toward a gold road wandering across the green from village to village, a furlong wide.

Toward the end of it.

She couldn't see it. It was a hundred miles off.

But she thought, if she looked very hard, if she looked the way she'd looked at the ground on the high moors when she was eight and there was no food in the house—

She thought she could see a glow.

Low. On the horizon. In the dark. Gold. Warm. Not a fire. Not a town. Not the sunset; the sunset was long gone.

Like metal in a crucible. Just before it pours.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Five months*," said Wren Ashdown. Out loud. To the dark. To the baby. To nobody.

Lark didn't wake.

"*He's going to come here*," said Wren. "*And sit at the table. And have tea. And look at you through the window like a man who's been standing in the snow for nine hundred years.*" Her voice was very quiet. "*And your da won't be here. And your uncle won't be here. And your grandda will be in that bed, trying.*"

She put her good hand on the back of the baby's head.

"*And I'll be here*," she said. "*With the wind.*"

She stood there a long time.

Then she went in. And put the baby in her cradle. And sat down in the chair by the window, the one in the loft, under the slope of the roof.

And didn't sleep.

At three in the morning, Lark woke. And looked at the window. Soaped. White.

And laughed.

As if she were dreaming of the wind.

As if she'd seen something in the glass that nobody else could see, and it was the best thing in the world.

Wren sat very still and didn't look.

CHAPTER 22

The Gilded Girl

PIM HAD BEEN LISTENING to her for four days.

Nobody else could hear it. He knew that. He'd known it since the first day, on the white road, near the beginning, when the others walked on and he stopped and looked at a small gold girl at the side of the road with a wooden spoon in her hand.

Her eyes had been moving fast.

Everyone else's moved slow. Like clock-hands. Like the shadow of a post going round on a summer day. Hers darted. Pim knew that kind of looking. He'd done it himself. For twelve years. In a cellar in Millbridge with a man called Kessick upstairs.

Fast eyes. Looking for the door.

He'd looked back. Twice. He couldn't help it.

And the second time, something had happened.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HADN'T MEANT TO.

He never meant to. It just came out of him sometimes. The quiet. When he looked at something that was frightened. It came out of him the way warmth comes out of a hearth, without the hearth deciding.

He'd looked back at the gold girl, the second time, and the quiet had come out of him. Just a little. Just a breath of it. Across the road. Into her.

And he'd felt it *catch*.

Somewhere deep in the gold. A hair's-breadth. A crack too small to see. The way it had caught in Bet Dale, at the Keep, in the spring, when a tear ran out of a gold eye.

And then Antho had said *Pim, thirteen cups*, and he'd turned round, and walked on.

And behind him, very faint, so faint nobody but him could ever have heard it—

Scrape.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D HEARD IT EVERY Pim since.

Walking down the white road between the kept with the basket on his back. In the night, sitting in the dust holding the room. Under the hum. Under the one low endless note that came out of nine thousand gold throats.

Scrape.

Slow. Very slow. An hour apart. More. A sound like a stone being dragged a finger's width across another stone.

Behind them. Far behind. Getting no further behind.

Following.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T TELL ANYONE.

He didn't tell anyone things. He'd learned that very young. Things you told people got used against you. Things you kept were yours. He'd been silent for twelve years and talking for three, and he still kept almost everything.

But he'd drawn her.

On the fourth night. In the dust, behind the last of the kept, in the room he was holding with Antho's hand on his knee holding the edge. With the pencil Ivy had given him and the back of a page from Seraphine's notebook. A girl in a grey dress too big for her. A wooden spoon. Big eyes.

And a boy, beside her, holding out his hand.

Then he'd waited till Antho slept.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS EASY TO go.

That was the strange thing. He'd thought it would be hard. He'd thought he'd have to creep.

He just stood up. In the middle of the room. And the room stayed. Because Antho was holding the edge of it. Because Antho had learned, in four days, to hold the edge of a room the way you'd hold the edge of a door, without thinking, even asleep.

Pim looked at him.

Asleep on his side in the dust. With his black hair over his face and his hand still out, flat on the ground, where Pim's knee had been. Still holding.

He'll be cross, thought Pim.

He folded the drawing. And put it on the dust beside the basket. And put a stone on it so it wouldn't blow away, though there was no wind, though nothing had blown away in the Court for nine hundred years.

And went.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE A ROOM for himself.

Small. Just him. Round him like a coat. He'd been doing it his whole life. In the cellar in Millbridge. In the snow outside the Lantern Keep. It was the easiest thing in the world. Easier than talking. Easier than breathing.

The Court pressed on it. Heavy. Full. Like water pressing on a bubble.

It didn't get in.

He walked back down the white road. East. Toward the door. Between the kept. With his room round him like a coat and his hand on the pocket over his heart, where Ivy's cat was.

The kept watched him go.

Thousands of gold eyes. Moving slowly. Following.

He didn't look at them. He listened.

Scrape.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FOUND HER IN the second hour.

Further back than he'd thought. Not as far back as she should have been. She should have been four Pims back. At the beginning. Near the door. Where she'd stood for nine hundred years.

She wasn't.

She was *here*.

On the white road. Not at the side of it. On it. In the middle of the stone. Small. Gold. In her grey dress too big for her, gold now, every fold. With her wooden spoon in her hand, gold. With one foot forward and one foot back. Mid-step.

Walking.

Behind her, on the white stone, a line of marks. Small. Scraped. Gold dust ground into the white. Footprints. Going back down the road, into the dim, as far as Pim could see.

Four days of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED.

A few feet away. In the middle of the road. With his room round him.

She didn't move.

She couldn't. Not really. Not the way people move. She'd been gold for nine hundred years. She was gold all the way through, solid, full.

Except somewhere. Deep. In the crack he'd made when he looked back.

Her eyes were on him.

Fast. Darting. His face. The pocket over his heart. His face.

And then, very slowly, so slowly he could barely see it, her front foot came down.

Scrape.

A finger's width. On the white stone.

Toward him.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM SAT DOWN.

He didn't know why. It seemed right. He sat down cross-legged on the white road in front of her, the way he sat down in front of frightened students at the Keep, the way he'd sat in front of the hole in the cold-room, the way he'd sat on the rim of the pool beside Ivy.

He looked up at her.

She was very small. Smaller than him. Seven. Eight. With a round face and a snub nose and her hair scraped back under a cap. A kitchen girl. The kind who scrubbed pans and turned spits and got cuffed when the bread burned.

He knew that kind.

He'd been that kind. In a different kitchen. With a different man.

"*Hello*," said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER EYES STOPPED DARTING.

They stopped. On his face. And stayed there.

He'd never said hello to anyone first. Not in his whole life. People said hello to him and he didn't answer, or nodded, or looked at them with his grey-violet eyes until they went away. He'd said hello to Antho, once, the first winter, after a month. Antho had nearly dropped his soup.

He said it again.

"*Hello. I'm Pim.*"

Nothing. Of course nothing. She was gold.

But her eyes didn't move off his face.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT to do.

He sat on the white road and looked at her and didn't know. He'd come all this way back. Two hours. In the night that wasn't night. Leaving Antho holding a room alone. Leaving the cups. Leaving everyone.

And he didn't know what to do.

So he did the only thing he knew.

He got quiet.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THE COAT. NOT the little room round himself that he'd worn walking. *More*.

He let it out. Slowly. The way you'd let out a long breath. Out of his chest. Out of the place deep in him where he'd made a room a long time ago, out of being hurt, and lived in it. Out into the air. Out into the white road. Out round the gold girl standing on it with one foot forward and her eyes on his face.

A room. Round both of them.

Soft. Close. Still. The way the cellar in Millbridge had been still, at night, when Kessick was asleep and nobody was going to come down the stairs for hours and hours.

The safe kind of still.

And then he leaned it in.

◆ ◆ ◆

INTO HER.

Not pushing. You couldn't push gold. He'd learned that at the Keep, with Bet Dale. It was full. It was solid. There was nothing to push into.

He didn't push.

He *asked*.

Is there anywhere, the quiet said. Very softly. *Is there any room. Anywhere at all. Just a little. Just enough.*

You've been walking for four days. You walked out of your place. You walked after me. There must be a crack. There must be.

Show me.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND SHE DID.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT. DEEP. So deep. In the middle of the gold. Where the heart would be, if gold had a heart.

A crack.

Not the hair's-breadth from before. Bigger. *Wider*. Four days of walking had worked it. Four days of dragging a gold foot a finger's width across white stone, every hour, toward a boy who'd looked back. It had worked it wider. Like a crack in ice that someone keeps stepping on.

There was room in it.

Not much. Not enough to move. Not enough to breathe.

Enough to say one thing.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM POURED INTO IT.

He didn't mean to. He couldn't help it. He found the room in her and the quiet in him went into it the way water goes into a cupped hand, without deciding, without asking, because that was where it went.

All of it.

He felt it go. Out of him. Into her. His room. His quiet. The thing he'd made out of being hurt and lived in for twelve years.

Into a crack in a gold girl at the side of the road.

And the girl's mouth moved.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT MUCH.

Her lips. Gold. Parted a little, the way they'd been parted for nine hundred years, as if she'd been about to say something when the King put his hand on her.

They moved.

Closed. Opened. A finger's width. Slow as a flower.

And a sound came out.

Not the hum. Not the one low note. Something else. Small. Cracked. Rusty. The sound of a voice that hadn't been used in nine hundred years, trying.

"...mam..."

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM DIDN'T MOVE.

He sat on the white road with his whole quiet poured out into a gold girl and his hands open on his knees and looked up at her.

"...mam..." she said again.

Barely a breath.

And a tear ran out of her eye.

Out of the corner of it. Out of the gold. Wet. Clear. Salt. It ran down her gold cheek and fell off her gold chin and landed on the white stone between them.

And didn't go gold.

It lay there. On the white road. A small wet spot. Clear.

The only wet thing in the Court.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Where*?" said Pim.

He didn't know he was going to ask. It came out of him. Very quiet.

"*Where's your mam*?"

The girl's eyes moved.

Not fast now. Slow. So slow. Off his face. Down. Down the road. Back the way she'd come. Back toward the door.

And stopped.

Pim turned round. And looked.

At the white road going back into the dim. At the rows of gold on either side. Cooks and grooms and maids and gardeners. Thousands of them.

He couldn't tell which one.

He looked back at the girl.

"*I'll find her*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D NEVER PROMISED ANYTHING in his life.

Promises were like hellos. Like telling things. They got used against you. Kessick used to promise. *I won't hit you if you're quiet*. *I won't hit you if you're good*.

Pim had stopped believing in promises when he was five.

He promised now.

"*I'll find her*," he said again. Out loud. On the white road. To a gold girl with a tear on her chin. "*Not now. I can't now. There's not enough room.*" He swallowed. "*But there's a pool. In a green field. With a girl who draws cats. It's full of room. It's still little.*"

The gold girl's eyes were on his face.

"*When it's big*," said Pim. "*When there's enough. I'll come back. I'll find your mam. I'll find everyone's.*"

He'd never said so many words in a row in his life.

"*I promise*," said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE HUM CHANGED.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT FIRST. In the road. In the dust. In the air. The one low note that had been going on for four days, for nine hundred years, out of nine thousand gold throats.

It *shifted*.

Not louder. Not higher. It just—moved. Like a sleeper turning over. Like a field of barley when the wind first touches it.

And he heard it.

Not a note. A word.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEPT ON EITHER side of the road. The ones nearest. A washerwoman with a gold basket. A man with a gold rake. A boy with a gold hoop. Their mouths didn't move. They couldn't. They were gold all the way through, full, with no room at all.

But the hum coming out of them had *shape* now. Because a girl had said one word, out loud, on the white road, through a crack a boy had made. And the word had gone into the hum like a stone into a pond.

And the hum had remembered what it was.

He heard it. All round. Low. Soft. Worn smooth by nine hundred years, like a step worn hollow by feet, like a coin rubbed smooth in a pocket.

But a word.

One word.

The only word they had left.

...home...

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM SAT ON THE white road and listened to nine thousand people say *home*.

He didn't cry. He never cried. He'd stopped crying when he was five, at the same time as he stopped believing in promises.

He found he was crying anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

Footsteps.

Behind him. On the white road. Running. Heavy. Fast. Coming from the west.

He didn't turn round. He knew who it was.

They stopped. A few yards behind him. He heard breathing. Hard. Fast. The breathing of a man who's been running for two hours in a country where there's no room to breathe.

"*Pim*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SOUND CROSS.

Pim had thought he would. He'd thought about it, walking back. He'd thought, *he'll be cross, he'll be so cross, he'll shout*.

Antho never shouted. Not at Pim. Not once in four years. But Pim had thought, this time.

He didn't shout.

He came round. Slowly. Into the room. Into what was left of it. Pim felt him come in. Felt him feel it, the way he felt every door. And stop.

He was looking at the girl.

At her gold face. At her gold mouth, open a finger's width. At the tear on her chin.

At the small wet spot on the white stone.

"*Oh*," said Antho Vey. Very quietly. "*Oh, Pim.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNELT DOWN.

On the white road. Beside Pim. In front of the gold girl. He didn't say anything else for a long time.

Then he put his hand out. Not touching her. Just near. A foot from her gold chest. Where the heart would be.

And shut his eyes.

Pim watched his face. He knew what Antho was doing. Feeling. For the door. The last one. The one everyone gets.

The one the King took.

Antho's face changed.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There's a crack*," he said.

Very quiet. Not opening his eyes.

"*Where the door should be*," said Antho. "*Where it was. Before.*" His voice was shaking. "*It's bricked up. Gold. Solid. Like all of them. Like Bet.*" A pause. "*But there's a crack. In the gold. Right where the door used to be.*"

Pim didn't say anything.

"*You made a crack*," said Antho. Opening his eyes. Looking at him. "*In the place where her door was. You made a crack in it.*"

"*She did*," said Pim.

Antho looked at him.

"*She did*," said Pim again. "*Walking. Four days. After me.*" He looked at the footprints on the white stone, going back into the dim. "*I only looked back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

He knelt on the white road with his hand out toward the gold girl and looked at the scraped footprints going back toward the door. Four days of them. A finger's width every hour.

"*Not enough*," he said at last.

"*No*."

"*It's not a door. It's a crack where one was.*" He took his hand back. "*She can't get through it. Not yet. Nobody could. There's no room on the other side.*"

"*I know*."

"*But there's a crack*," said Antho Vey. "*There's a crack.*" He looked at Pim. His face was wet. "*Lex says everything's a crack first.*"

"*I promised her*," said Pim.

Antho went still.

"*I promised*," said Pim. "*I said I'd come back. When the pool's big. When there's room. I said I'd find her mam.*" He looked at the girl. "*I've never promised anything.*"

Antho looked at him for a long time.

"*Then we'll come back*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith says nineteen days*," said Pim.

"*Eleven cups*," said Antho. "*Sixteen days, now. You've been gone two hours and I've been running after you for two.*" He didn't say it crossly. He just said it. "*That's not counting walking back.*"

"*I'm sorry*."

"*Don't be*," said Antho. "*I'd have done it. I've done worse. I went into the Hollow on my own once to keep a promise to a grey girl.*" He looked at the gold girl. At the tear on her chin. "*It was the right thing.*"

"*Was it*?"

"*It was the right thing and it cost two cups*," said Antho. "*Most right things cost something. You just have to decide if you'll pay.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM STOOD UP.

He felt it as he did. Something in him. Thinner. He'd poured his quiet into the girl. All of it. Into the crack. And some of it had stayed there.

He could feel it. In her. A little room. His. Inside her gold. Small and quiet and still.

He'd left it there.

He didn't want it back.

"*Ilda*," he said.

Antho looked at him.

"*Her name*," said Pim. "*Ilda.*" He didn't know how he knew. He'd known since the tear. Since the word. Since the room. It had come back to him out of the crack the way a smell comes back to you on the wind. "*She's Ilda. She turned the spit in the King's kitchen. Her mam was the bread-woman. She was eight.*"

"*How do you know*?"

Pim didn't answer.

He looked at the girl. At Ilda. At her gold eyes on his face.

"*Goodbye, Ilda*," he said.

And her eyes followed him. All the way. As he turned. As he walked back up the white road beside Antho. West. Toward the palaces.

Until he couldn't see her anymore.

And behind them, very faint—

Scrape.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED BACK IN silence.

Two hours. Between the kept. With the hum all round them. Pim could hear it now. He couldn't stop hearing it. Nine thousand voices, all saying the same word through throats that couldn't open.

...home...

He didn't know if Antho could hear it. He thought so. Antho's face was very still. The still face. The one he got when he was holding a door.

They didn't talk.

Halfway back, Antho put his hand on Pim's shoulder. And left it there. And they walked like that.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW THE FACE in the gold an hour from the camp.

In a gold washerwoman's basket. In the curve of the gold linen piled in it, which shone, the way all the gold shone, dully, in the grey-gold light.

A face. Small. Pale. White-haired. Grey-eyed.

Looking at him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED.

Antho stopped too. And saw.

"*Don't*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Pim. Don't look at it. Keep walking.*"

Pim didn't keep walking.

The face in the gold linen was looking at him. Not at Antho. At him. Very still. Very steady.

"*Room-maker*," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER VOICE WAS VERY small. Like a fly at a window. Like a wet finger round the rim of a thimble.

"*You made her cry*," said the Glass Queen. "*The little cook. Ilda. The spit-girl.*" The tiny face tilted. "*I've watched her for nine hundred years. Every day. In every shiny thing on that road. She's never cried. Not once.*"

Pim didn't say anything.

"*Nobody's ever made any of them cry*," said Ysenne. "*Not Oz. Not Mae. Not me.*" A pause. "*I tried. Once. In the first century. I sat in a spoon in her hand and talked to her for a year. I told her every story I knew. She never even blinked.*"

"*You didn't make room*," said Pim.

The face went still.

"*You talked*," said Pim. "*You filled it up. With stories.*" He looked at the tiny pale face in the gold linen. "*She didn't need filling. She was full. She needed room.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS QUEEN DIDN'T answer for a long time.

"*Room*," she said at last. Slowly. As if tasting the word. "*Yes. That's what the little man with the hammer said. In his note. The scribe read it to me. Unwrite it when there's someone who can make room.*"

"*Pim*," said Antho. "*Come away.*"

"*He means you*," said Ysenne. Not to Antho. To Pim. "*Doesn't he. The little man. He means things like you. Things that make room.*" The tiny face was very close to the surface of the gold linen now. Pressed against it, almost. Like a face pressed against a window. "*I've never seen one. Not in nine hundred years. Not in all the glass in two worlds.*"

"*Pim—*"

"*Come and see my house*," said the Glass Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GOLD LINEN MOVED.

Not the face. The *gold*. The surface of it. The shine. It went bright. Brighter. A gleam spreading out across the curve of gold cloth in the gold basket on the gold washerwoman's hip, like sun on water.

And a hand came out of it.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM HAD SEEN IT before. At Harrow. Out of the Lantern. Out of the stream.

Long. Clear. Glittering. Glass. Fingers first. Then the wrist. Then the arm. Thin. Fine. Impossible. Reaching out of a curve of gold no bigger than a dinner plate.

Toward him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T MOVE.

He should have. He knew that. Antho was shouting. Antho was reaching for him. Antho's hand was coming down on his shoulder to pull him back.

He didn't move.

Because he was empty.

That was the thing. That was what he understood, afterward, lying on the floor of a room made of glass. He'd poured his quiet into a gold girl on the white road. All of it. Into the crack. He'd left some of it there.

He'd come back without enough.

Not enough to make a room. Not enough to hold one. Not enough to stand in front of a glass hand reaching out of a gold basket and be the one thing in the world that couldn't be filled.

He was just a boy.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS HAND CLOSED round his wrist.

Cold. Like ice. Like the bottom of a river.

"*I won't hurt you*," said Ysenne. Very softly. Very close. "*I promise. I only want to look.*"

And pulled.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT HIMSELF GO into the gold.

Not through it. *Into* it. Like falling into still water. Like going through a window that wasn't open. His wrist first. His arm. His shoulder. Cold. Bright. Glittering. The world going flat round him. Going thin. Going *shiny*.

He heard Antho shout his name.

He felt Antho's hand on his other arm. Gripping. Pulling. Hard.

And slipping.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LAST THING HE saw before the glass closed over him was the washerwoman's face.

Gold. Still. Kept. With her basket on her hip.

Her eyes were on him.

Moving. Slowly. Following.

And her mouth—

Her mouth didn't move. It couldn't. She was full. All the way through.

But the hum coming out of her, as he went into the gold, as the glass closed over his head, as Antho's hand slipped off his arm—

The hum had shape.

...home...

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THERE WAS only glass.

And light.

And a face. Everywhere. In every surface. Pale. White-haired. Grey-eyed.

Smiling.

"*There*," said the Glass Queen. From everywhere. From a thousand mirrors. "*There you are. Welcome to my house, room-maker.*"

A pause.

"*I've been so lonely*," she said.

CHAPTER 23

The Glass Palace

ANTHO CAME BACK ALONE.

Lex saw him from a long way off. Down the white road. Between the kept. A tall thin shape in the grey-gold dim, walking. Not running. Walking. Slowly. The way a man walks when there's no longer any point in running.

Alone.

Lex was on his feet before Hask could say anything.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She took him*," said Antho.

He stood in the middle of the road in front of them with his hands hanging at his sides. His face was grey. His eyes were very dark. There was a red mark round his right wrist, Lex saw, as if something had gripped it very hard and then torn away.

"*Who—*"

"*Ysenne*." Antho's voice was very flat. "*Out of a basket. Out of a washerwoman's basket of gold linen. A hand.*" He looked down at his own hands. "*I had his arm. I had it. And it slipped.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*He'd found the girl*," said Antho. "*The kitchen girl. Ilda. She'd been walking after him. For four days. A finger's width every hour.*" His voice cracked. "*He made room in her. He made her talk. She said mam. She cried.*" He swallowed. "*And it took everything he had. And he was empty. And she was waiting.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember.

I know.

[The glass palace. A mile south of the road. Full of faces.] A pause. *[She said come and see my house.]*

Lex looked south.

There it was. Rising out of the grey-gold dust like a frozen waterfall turned upside down. Towers. Spires. Bridges. Clear as water. Glittering. Every pane catching every other pane.

Every pane with a face in it.

They weren't looking at the road anymore.

They were looking at him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Cups*," said Lex.

Antho blinked at him.

"*How many*?" said Lex.

"*Eleven. I've had one since I went after him. I'll need another soon.*" Antho looked at the basket on the ground. Where Pim had left it. With a folded drawing beside it, weighed down with a stone. "*Sixteen days. Fifteen. If someone holds the nights.*"

"*Nobody can hold the nights*," said Lex. "*Not without Pim.*"

"*I can hold the edges. A little.*"

"*Then fifteen*," said Lex. "*Fewer.*" He bent down. Picked up the basket. Slung it over his own shoulder. It was heavy. Heavy with nothing. "*We'll do the sums later.*"

"*Lex—*"

"*She's got Pim*," said Lex Vey.

He started walking.

South. Off the road. Into the dust. Toward the glass palace.

He didn't look back to see if they were following. He didn't need to. He heard Antho's boots. And Hask's.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK AN HOUR to reach.

It looked closer than it was. Everything in the Court did. There was nothing to measure by. No trees. No hills. Just flat grey-gold dust, and the palace rising out of it, and the faces.

The faces watched them come.

Every pane. Every tower. Thousands of them. All the same face. Pale. Sharp-cheeked. Long-necked. White hair. Grey eyes. Turning as they walked. Following.

Not smiling.

Lex had seen Ysenne smile. In the Hall of Lanterns. In the window at Harrow. In the stream.

She wasn't smiling now.

She looked—

[Curious,] said Ember. *[She looks curious, Lex. Like a cat watching a mouse she isn't sure she wants to eat.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A DOOR.

At the foot of the palace. In the middle. Tall. Glass. Clear as water. Standing open.

Through it, Lex could see the inside.

Light.

That was all. Light. Bouncing. Glass walls and glass floors and glass ceilings, every surface clear and every surface shining, the dim grey-gold light of the Court coming in through a thousand panes and bouncing off a thousand more. Endless. Dizzying. A corridor of light going on into the palace forever.

And in every surface, the face.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOPPED AT THE door.

"*It's a trap*," said Hask.

"*It's a trap*," agreed Antho.

"*She's got Pim*," said Lex.

Nobody said anything else.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT IN.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT HIT LEX like a wave.

He'd known it would be bright. He hadn't known it would be like this. He stepped through the glass door and the light came at him from every side. From the walls. The floor. The ceiling. From the face in every pane, which was looking at him. From his own face in every pane, which was looking back.

He couldn't tell which way was forward.

He couldn't tell which way was up.

He stood on a glass floor that showed him his own face looking up from below, in a glass corridor that showed him his own back going on ahead forever, with glass walls that showed him Antho and Hask behind him, and Antho and Hask in front of him, and Antho and Hask to the left and to the right and above, a thousand Anthos and a thousand Hasks, all turning their heads, all looking for the way.

And among them, everywhere, the Glass Queen.

Watching.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*," she said.

From everywhere. From every pane. Small and far and singing, like a wet finger round the rim of a glass. A thousand voices. All the same voice. All speaking at once.

"*You came*," said Ysenne. "*I thought you would. Arion would have. He came down to the bottom of the world to say sorry to a thread.*"

"*Give him back*," said Lex.

"*He's safe*," said Ysenne. "*He's asleep. He's very tired. He gave too much to the little cook.*" The thousand faces tilted. All together. "*I put him in my best room. With nothing in it. He seemed to like that.*"

"*Give him back*."

"*Come and get him*," said the Glass Queen. "*If you can find him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE PALACE SHOWED him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW IT was happening at first. He was looking at the glass wall in front of him. At his own face in it. Grey. Tired. With the grey-gold handprint on his cheek and his dark hair cut badly and his eyes red-rimmed.

And then it wasn't his face.

It was his face. But older. A little. Not much. And *different*.

His eyes were gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT EMBER-GOLD. NOT THE gold they went when he used the Root, before he gave it away. *Gold*. All the way through. Iris and white and pupil. Bright. Steady. Like two coins.

He was standing in a room he didn't know. Tall. White. Full of light. And round him, in the air, all round him, so thick he could barely see through it—

Threads.

He could see them. In the glass. Thousands. Millions. Silver and gold. Running out from him in every direction like the spokes of a wheel. Running into his hands. Into his chest. Into his eyes.

The net.

All of it. In his hands. Every thread. Every knot. Every Stone. Every child.

Him in the middle. Holding it.

And on his head—

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It suits you*," said Ysenne. Softly. From everywhere. "*Doesn't it.*"

Lex couldn't speak.

On the head of the man in the glass was a crown.

Not gold leaves. Not glass. Not iron or thorns or silver wire. Light. A circle of it. Thin. Bright. Made of the same threads that ran into his hands. Woven. Round his brow. Like a halo in a church window.

Root.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*That's what the Key would give you*," said the Glass Queen. "*If you turned it. You. Instead of Oz. Instead of the thread in the knot.*" The faces in the glass were very still. "*The net. All of it. Back in your hands. The way it was for the little man with the hammer. The way it was for your father.*"

"*I gave it away*," said Lex.

"*You did. And look what happened.*" A sigh. Like breath on a cold pane. "*Nobody holding it. A crown in the road. And Oz coming to pick it up.*"

The man in the glass with gold eyes lifted his hand. Slowly. And the threads moved with it. All of them. Every thread in the world, bending to follow his hand like grass bends to follow the wind.

"*You could stop him*," said Ysenne. "*With that. You could stop him with a thought. Undo his gold. Undo his gilt. Every grandmother in every chair. Every boy in every field.*" A pause. "*You could unring every one of Cad's rings. You could close the door at the edge of the world with a word.*"

Lex stared at the man in the glass.

"*And your father*," said the Glass Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT COLD.

"*You know he's dying*," said Ysenne. Very gently. "*You know there isn't long. The Ferryman said before the year turns.*" The faces in the glass looked at him. "*Do you know how long the net held him? The first time? Two hundred years. Forty-five years old, for two hundred years. Because he had the Root. Because the net held him.*"

"*Stop.*"

"*It could hold him again*," said the Glass Queen. "*If you had it. You could put your hand on the net and find his thread and hold it. The way Aurelian held the Hollow.*

The way your father held the breaches from inside the crystal." A pause. *"He wouldn't have to go. Not this year. Not next. Not for a hundred."*

The man in the glass with gold eyes was smiling. Lex's smile. His father's.

"You could keep him," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD IN THE glass corridor and looked at himself.

At the gold eyes. At the threads. At the crown of light.

He thought about his father in a bed under a boarded window. With a Lantern beside him. Breathing. In. Catch. Out.

He thought about his father's hand on his hair. *I'll try. I'll try very hard.*

He thought about his father on the floor of the blue-door cottage, for an hour, watching the sun move across the flags.

He thought about *I stood up*.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember.

Very quietly. Very close.

[Lex, don't.]

I wasn't going to.

[You were thinking about it.]

I was thinking about it, Lex admitted. *I'm allowed to think about it.*

[Yes,] said Ember. *[You are.]* A pause. *[He'd hate it. You know he'd hate it. Kept. In the net. For a hundred years. In a bed.]*

I know.

[He'd say—]

I know what he'd say.

◆ ◆ ◆

"Kept," said Lex. Out loud. To the man in the glass. To the faces. To the Glass Queen. *"You said keep him. That's the word you used."*

The faces went still.

"That's your brother's word," said Lex. *"Not mine. Not my father's."* He looked at the man in the glass with gold eyes. *"He held the net for two hundred years and it kept him forty-five and he hated every day of it. He watched everyone he knew grow old and die. He watched my mother walk into the dark."* His voice was very quiet. *"And when he finally let go of it, he was happy. For the first time. With a year left and a wife who brings him pies."*

"Smith—"

"*He doesn't want to be kept*," said Lex Vey. "*He wants to be finished. There's a difference.*"

He turned his back on the glass.

"*Old Mag said that*," he said. "*Wren told me. To your steward. In her kitchen.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MAN IN THE glass with gold eyes didn't move.

The faces didn't move.

And then the glass behind Lex cracked.

Not broke. *Cracked*. A thin bright line, running down the pane where the man with the crown of light had been. From top to bottom.

And when Lex looked back, the man was gone. There was only his own face. Grey. Tired. With a handprint on its cheek.

"*Huh*," said the Glass Queen. Very softly. From everywhere. "*Arion said you'd say that. I didn't believe him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WAS ON HIS knees.

Lex hadn't seen him go down. He turned round and his brother was on the glass floor behind him with his hands flat on it and his head bowed and his black hair hanging over his face. Shaking.

"*Antho—*"

"*Don't look*," said Antho. Hoarsely. Not lifting his head. "*Don't look in the glass. Not mine. Please.*"

Lex looked.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A CAVE.

In the glass wall beside his brother. A cave in the Greyspine. Cold. Dark. With a fire in it, burned down to red. With a bone flute on a rock. With a young man sitting against the wall, very thin, with his black hair wild and his beard wild and his hands burned.

And his eyes.

Black. All the way through. Iris and white. Black as the Hollow. Black as the dark under the lid.

The young man in the glass was talking. To nobody. To the cave wall. His lips moving. Fast. And Lex could hear it, faint, through the glass, the way you hear voices through a wall.

[...hungry...so hungry...little brother smells of warm iron...]

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Eight years*," said Ysenne. Gently. From everywhere. "*I saw them in you. Through the glass. The first time you looked into my brother's gold.*" The faces tilted toward Antho. "*Eight years with a hunger in your head. Talking to you. Wanting through you.*"

Antho didn't move.

"*You still dream about it*," said the Glass Queen. "*Don't you. Every night. Seraphine doesn't know. You wake up at three in the morning and lie very still and check. Check that it's gone. Check that it's not there.*" A pause. "*Clarity a hundred. And you still check.*"

"*Stop*," said Lex.

"*I'm only showing him what's there*," said Ysenne. "*That's all I ever do.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE CAVE CHANGED.

The young man in it stood up. Slowly. And came toward the glass. Toward Antho, kneeling on the other side of it. With his black eyes and his burned hands and his wild hair.

And as he came, he went gold.

From the feet up. Slowly. The way the boy in the field had gone, the way Bet Dale had gone. His boots. His legs. His chest. His burned hands, reaching. His face. His black eyes.

Gold.

A gold young man. Standing in a gold cave. With his hand out. Toward the glass. Toward the door.

Kept.

"*He could keep you*," said Ysenne. Softly. "*Oz. If you asked. He could keep you exactly as you are now. Clarity a hundred. Forever. It would never come back. You'd never have to check again.*" A pause. "*You'd never have to wake up at three in the morning and lie very still.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO LIFTED HIS HEAD.

Slowly. His face was grey and wet and his eyes were very dark. Not black. Grey. His father's grey.

He looked at the gold young man in the glass.

At his own face. Kept. With its hand out. Reaching for a door it would never open.

"*I'd never dream again*," he said.

"*No.*"

"*I'd never wake up.*"

"*No,*" said Ysenne. "*Never. Isn't that what you want?*"

Antho looked at the gold young man for a long time.

"*No,*" said Antho Vey. "*I want to wake up at three in the morning and check.*"

The faces went still.

"*Because it's not there,*" said Antho. "*Every time. Every night. I wake up and lie very still and check and it's not there.*" His voice was shaking. He didn't let it stop him. "*And then I go back to sleep. And Seraphine's asleep beside me with ink on her nose and her spectacles on the floor. And I think, it's not there. It's gone. I'm here.*" He wiped his face with the back of his burned hand. "*That's the best part of my whole day.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLASS IN FRONT of him cracked.

A thin bright line. Top to bottom. Through the gold young man in the gold cave.

And the young man was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK HADN'T MOVED.

He was standing at the end of the corridor. Enormous. Still. His pick in his good hand. His bandaged arm against his chest.

Looking at the glass.

Lex went to him.

He knew before he got there. He didn't need to see. But he saw.

◆ ◆ ◆

A WINDOW.

Small. Square. In a grey terraced house in a black valley. With rain on it. And a candle on the sill. And a face on the other side of it, looking out.

A girl. Eight. Thin. Pale. With her brother's broad face and her brother's dark eyes and grey on her lips.

She was whistling.

Two notes. High. Low. Over and over. Through the glass. Through the rain.

Here I am. Here I am.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Nell,*" said Silas Hask.

His voice was barely there.

The girl in the window kept whistling. Two notes. High. Low. Looking out at the rain. At the street. At someone who wasn't there.

"*She used to do that*," said Hask. "*At the end. When she couldn't get out of bed. Kit's mam would carry her to the window. And she'd whistle. Two notes. So I'd know. Coming home from the pit. So I'd look up and know she was still—*" He stopped.

"*Hask—*"

"*Every night*," said Silas Hask. "*Six months. I'd come up the street and look up and she'd be in the window. Whistling.*" His big scarred hand was white on the pick. "*And then one night I came up the street and looked up and the window was dark.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He could keep her*," said Ysenne. Very softly. "*If she were here. If she'd lived long enough. Oz could have kept her in that window. Whistling. Forever.*" A pause. "*You'd never have come up the street to a dark window.*"

Hask didn't say anything.

"*But she's dead*," said the Glass Queen. "*Isn't she. Dead and gone. Down a river. On the other side.*" The faces were very gentle. "*There's nobody to keep.*"

"*No*," said Hask.

"*So you can only look*," said Ysenne. "*Like me. At what's there. At what's gone.*" A sigh. "*Forever.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK LOOKED AT THE girl in the window for a long time.

At the rain. At the candle on the sill. At the grey on her lips.

At her mouth. Whistling. Two notes.

And then he put his lips together.

And whistled back.

◆ ◆ ◆

TWO NOTES. HIGH. LOW. Rough. Cracked. A Coldwater hewer's whistle, from a chest full of grey that had finally, in this full heavy country, found room to breathe all the way down.

Here I am.

The girl in the window stopped.

She looked out. Through the rain. Through the glass. As if she'd heard. As if someone had whistled back from the street.

And smiled.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE GLASS CRACKED.

Top to bottom. A thin bright line. Through the window. Through the rain. Through the girl's smile.

She was gone.

Hask stood in front of the cracked glass with his lips still pursed.

"*She smiled*," he said. Very quietly. "*She never smiled. Not at the end. She was too tired.*"

"*I know*," said Lex.

"*She smiled at me*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said Ysenne.

From everywhere. Very small. Very quiet. Puzzled.

"*That's three*," she said. "*Three cracked. In three breaths.*" The faces in every pane were turning. Looking at the three cracked panes in the corridor. "*Nobody's ever cracked one. Not in nine hundred years. I've shown Oz his father in the bed a thousand times and he's never—*"

She stopped.

"*How*?" she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T ANSWER.

He didn't know. He stood in the glass corridor among the cracked panes and the faces and thought about it.

He wants to be finished.

I want to wake up and check.

Here I am.

[Because they looked at what was there,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[And said yes to it. All of it. Even the dark window. Even the cave. Even the bed.]* A pause. *[That's the one thing glass can't show. What you'd do with what you see.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LIT THE BLACK heat.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D BEEN HOLDING IT back. He didn't know why. Some idea that he'd need it later. That it was the last thing. The only thing that worked on her.

He let it go now.

Out of his hands. Out of his chest. Into the glass corridor. Not flame. Not light. *Heat*. Black. Rolling off him in waves. Filling the corridor. Rising into the glass ceiling. Spreading out through the glass walls into the glass rooms beyond.

Eating the light.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PALACE WENT DARK.

Not all at once. From him. Outward. Like ink spreading through water. The glass walls going dim. Dimmer. The light that bounced from pane to pane, endless, dizzying, stopping. Swallowed. Drunk.

And the faces went with it.

Every pane. Every tower. One by one. The pale sharp-cheeked face in every surface going dim, going black, going out like a candle snuffed. Until there was nothing in the glass at all. No light. No reflection. No Queen.

Just dark.

And heat.

And somewhere, far off, deep in the palace, a voice. Small. Shocked.

"...oh...I can't...I can't see..."

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*," said Lex.

He couldn't see either. Not a thing. He stood in the black with the heat pouring off him and couldn't see his own hand.

"*Here*."

"*Find him*."

A pause. In the dark.

"*I can't see*," said Antho.

"*You don't need to see*," said Lex. "*You're a Threshold Warden. You feel doors.*" He swallowed. "*This is a palace. It's full of doors. Rooms and doors and stairs and corridors.*" His voice was shaking with the effort of holding the heat. "*She said she put him in her best room. With nothing in it.*"

Silence.

"*A room with nothing in it*," said Antho. Slowly.

"*Pim makes rooms. Even empty. Even asleep. Even with nothing left.*" Lex's hands were burning. "*Find the quietest room in the palace. That's where he'll be.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO FOUND IT.

Lex didn't know how. He followed. In the black. With one hand on his brother's shoulder and the other pouring heat. With Hask behind him, his hand on Lex's shoulder, breathing all the way down.

Antho walked.

Slowly. With his hands out in front of him. Not touching the glass. Feeling. For the doors. For the spaces between one room and the next. For the place where a wall stopped and a way began.

Left. Right. Up a stair Lex couldn't see, glass steps under his boots that rang faintly like bells. Along a corridor. Through an arch. Down. Left again.

"*There*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX FELT IT BEFORE Antho said it.

Quiet.

Not the dark. Not the black heat. *Quiet*. A space. Ahead of them. In the black. Small. Round. Still. The way the cellar at Harrow had been still. The way a room is still when someone you love is sleeping in it.

Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He's in there*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Through that door. It's the only room in the palace with nothing in it.*" A pause. "*Not even glass.*"

"*How can it not have glass*?"

"*I don't know*," said Antho. "*But it hasn't. The floor's stone. The walls are stone. There's a door and there's nothing.*" His voice was very strange. "*It's the only room in her whole palace where she can't see herself.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT IN.

And Lex let the black heat go.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT ALL OF IT. Most. He let it drain back. Slowly. Into the glass corridor behind them. Into the palace. Letting the light come back, a little. Dim. Grey-gold.

There was light in the room.

Not much. A little. Coming in through the door behind them. Enough to see by.

It was small. Stone. Grey. Plain. With no window. With no glass at all. Just four walls and a floor and a ceiling. Bare.

Pim was lying in the middle of the floor. On his side. Curled up like a cat. In his blue coat. Asleep.

And sitting beside him—

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS REAL.

Not a face in a pane. Not a hand out of a basket. Not a reflection. *Real*. Glass. All of her. Clear and cold and faintly glittering, like frost, like ice over deep water. Sitting on the stone floor beside the sleeping boy with her long glass legs folded under her white gown and her long glass hands in her lap.

You could see through her. Lex could see the stone wall behind her, bent, distorted, through her chest.

She was looking at Pim.

Not at them. She didn't look up when they came in. She sat on the stone floor in the only room in her palace with no glass in it and looked at a sleeping boy, very still, the way you'd look at a fire on a cold night.

"*He's asleep*," said Ysenne. Very quietly. "*Don't wake him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY MOVED.

Lex stood in the doorway with his hands still warm and the light coming dim and grey-gold past him. Antho beside him. Hask behind.

"*Give him back*," said Lex. Quietly. So as not to wake the boy.

"*I asked him*," said the Glass Queen.

She still didn't look up.

"*When he woke*," she said. "*The first time. In here. I asked him.*" Her glass hands moved in her lap. "*I said, make room in me. The way you did in the little cook. Please. I'll give you back. I'll give you all back. Just make room in me first.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*He said he couldn't*," said Ysenne. "*He said he was empty. He said he'd left it all in Ilda.*" A pause. "*And then he tried anyway.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT THE boy on the floor.

Curled up. White-faced. Breathing very slow. More asleep than Lex had ever seen anyone asleep.

"*He tried*," said the Glass Queen. Wonderingly. "*He put his hand on my knee. Like this.*" She reached out. Slowly. And laid her long glass fingers on the stone floor beside Pim's hand. Not touching it. "*And he got quiet. As quiet as he could. With nothing left.*"

She was silent for a long moment.

"*And for a breath*," said Ysenne, "*there was room.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

"*In me*," said the Glass Queen. "*For one breath. Nine hundred years and for one breath there was a place in me that wasn't my face.*" Her voice was very small. "*It was so quiet. It was so empty. I didn't know anything could be that empty.*" She looked at the boy. "*I didn't see myself. For one breath. In my own palace. I didn't see anything at all.*"

"*And then*?" said Antho.

"*And then he fell asleep*," said Ysenne. "*Like that. In the middle. Like a candle going out.*" She looked at her hand on the stone beside his. "*And I sat here. And I didn't want to look at anything. For the first time. I didn't want to look in any glass. I just wanted to sit here.*"

She looked up.

At last.

Her ice-grey eyes. In her clear glass face. On Lex.

"*So I made this room*," said the Glass Queen. "*While he slept. Out of stone. With no glass in it.*" She looked round at the bare grey walls. "*It's the first thing I've ever made that I can't see myself in.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T KNOW WHAT to say.

He stood in the doorway of a stone room in a glass palace and looked at a Crowned queen sitting on the floor beside a sleeping boy.

"*Take him*," said Ysenne.

He stared at her.

"*Take him*," she said again. "*He's yours. He came with you. He'll want to wake up with you.*" She drew her glass hand back. Into her lap. "*I only wanted to look.*"

"*And you're letting us go*."

"*I'm letting you go*," said the Glass Queen.

"*Why*?"

She looked at the sleeping boy for a long time.

"*Because the baby looked at me*," she said. "*And Arion broke my mirror and said kept things can't see. And this one made room in me with nothing left.*" She looked up at Lex. "*And because I've watched you for an hour, smith. In every pane. And you cracked three of them in three breaths.*" A small strange smile. Not a girl's. Not delighted. Tired. "*I'd like to see what you do next.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK PICKED PIM UP.

He came past Lex into the stone room and bent down, enormous, and slid his good arm under the boy, and lifted him. The way he'd lifted Lark out of the cellar. One finger at a time.

Pim didn't wake.

He lay against Hask's chest in his blue coat with his small white face turned into the scarred leather. Breathing very slow.

The Glass Queen watched them.

"*Where are you going*?" she said.

Nobody answered.

"*Not back to the door*," said Ysenne. "*You'd have gone back already. You came here for something. You came past my house and past Cad's house and past the hall.*" Her ice-grey eyes moved. To the north. Through the stone wall. As if she could see through it. "*There's nothing north. Nothing but dust.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*And Rosie's thorns*," said the Glass Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM WAS VERY quiet.

"*You're going to Rosie*," said Ysenne. Slowly. "*Aren't you. To her thorns. That she grew in the one hour she was awake. Thirty-two years ago.*" Her face was very still. "*I always wondered why. Oz said she was being Rosie. Growing things nobody wanted. I said, she's hiding something.*"

"*Ysenne—*"

"*I don't care*," said the Glass Queen. "*I don't. Whatever it is. Oz can have his crown in the road and Cad can have his rings and Rosie can have her secret.*" She looked down at her hands. "*I've had a room with nothing in it. For an hour. That's more than I've had in nine hundred years.*"

She looked up.

"*But you should know*," she said. "*Before you go.*"

"*Know what*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Rosie will betray you*," said Ysenne.

Lex didn't move.

"*She betrays everyone*," said the Glass Queen. "*Not because she wants to. Because she's Rosie. Because she listens to everyone and agrees with everyone and loves everyone and then does what Oz says.*" Her voice was very flat. "*She listened to Hes. In the*

garden. She said oh, Hes, are you sure. She cried." A pause. *"And then she went down to the hall and drank."*

"That was nine hundred years ago."

"She's the same," said Ysenne. *"We're all the same. That's what drinking does. It keeps you. It keeps you exactly what you were the night you drank."* She looked at Lex. *"She'll open her thorns for you. She'll take you to whatever she's hiding. She'll cry. She'll mean it."*

"And then?"

"And then Oz will ask her where you are," said the Glass Queen. *"And she'll tell him."*

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

"She won't want to," said Ysenne. *"She'll hate it. She'll grow a thousand roses afterward and send them all to nobody."* Her glass hands were still in her lap. *"But she'll tell him. She always tells him. She can't not."*

"Why are you telling us?" said Antho.

The Glass Queen looked at him.

"Because I always tell the truth," she said. *"That's what glass is."* A pause. *"And because the room-maker tried."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LEFT HER THERE.

On the floor of the stone room. In the only room in her palace with no glass in it. Sitting very still with her hands in her lap and her ice-grey eyes on the place where the boy had been lying.

Lex looked back once. From the doorway.

She wasn't looking at anything.

Not at the walls. Not at the floor. Not at him. Her eyes were open and she was looking at nothing at all, the way you look at nothing when you're listening very hard to something only you can hear.

To the quiet.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT OUT THROUGH the dark palace.

Lex lit the black heat again. A little. Enough. Antho led. Through the doors he could feel. Down the glass stairs that rang like bells. Along the corridors. Past the three cracked panes.

Nobody stopped them. No faces. No voices. No hands out of the glass.

They came out through the tall glass door into the grey-gold dim.

And Lex let the black heat go.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PALACE LIT UP behind them.

He felt it. The light coming back. Bouncing. Pane to pane. Endless.

He didn't look back.

But Antho did. And told him, later.

The faces were back, Antho said. *In every pane. Thousands of them. The way they were when we came.*

Watching us?

No, said Antho. *That's the thing. They weren't watching us.*

Then what—

They had their eyes shut, said Antho. *Every one. Every face in every pane. All of them. Eyes shut.*

Like they were listening.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM WOKE ON THE white road.

Hask was carrying him. Walking north. Toward the edge of the plain. Toward nothing. Toward where Seren had dreamed a forest of thorns.

The boy stirred. Lifted his head off Hask's chest. Blinked.

Looked round. At the grey-gold dust. At Lex and Antho, walking ahead. At Hask's face, very close, looking down at him.

"*Ilda*," he said.

"*She's back on the road*," said Hask. "*Walking. A finger's width an hour.*"

Pim was quiet for a moment.

"*The glass lady*," he said.

"*She let us go*."

"*I tried*," said Pim. "*I didn't have any left. I tried anyway.*"

"*I know*," said Silas Hask. "*She told us.*"

Pim looked up at him.

"*Did it work*?"

Hask didn't answer straight away.

He walked on, north, across the grey-gold dust, with the boy against his chest, breathing all the way down.

"*She made a room with no glass in it*," he said at last. "*Out of stone. While you slept. So she could sit in it.*"

Pim didn't say anything.

He put his head back down on Hask's chest. And shut his eyes.

But Lex, looking back, saw him smile.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED NORTH.

Away from the white road. Away from the kept and their hum. Away from the palaces. Across a plain of grey-gold dust that went on to the edge of everything without a hill or a fold or a tree.

Ten cups now. Antho had needed another, coming out of the palace.

Fifteen days. Fewer. Lex didn't do the sums. He didn't want to know.

He walked with the basket on his back and his hand on the bell and his eyes on the flat grey-gold horizon to the north.

Rosie will betray you.

She'll open her thorns. She'll cry. She'll mean it.

And then Oz will ask her where you are. And she'll tell him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW THEM ON the second Pim.

A line. On the horizon. Dark. Low. Running east and west as far as he could see.

He thought it was a hill. The first hill in the Court.

It wasn't a hill.

As they came closer, it rose. Taller. Darker. Not a line. A *wall*. Black. Hooked. Tangled. Taller than the palace doors. Taller than the hall. Running round in a great ring, a mile across, maybe more, in the middle of the empty plain.

Thorns.

And in the middle of the ring, rising above them, very small, very thin, grey—

A tower.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOPPED AT THE edge of the thorns.

Black stems. Thick as a man's wrist. Thorns as long as a finger. Not a leaf. Not a bud. Hooked into each other so tight there wasn't a gap anywhere you could have put your hand.

And they moved.

Lex saw it. As the four of them came up to the edge. The stems. Shifting. Very slightly. Creaking. Leaning. Toward them.

The way plants lean toward a window.

"*Hello*," said Lex. To the thorns. Very quietly.

The thorns didn't answer.

But in the middle of the wall in front of him, at the height of his chest, on the end of one black hooked stem—

Something red.

Small. Closed. A bud.

And as he watched, it opened.

CHAPTER 24

The Last Pages

HE TOLD HER ONE a day.

That was the rule. His rule. He'd made it the morning after Seraphine did her sums, lying on his pillows under the boarded window with the Lantern burning beside him and his voice a thread.

One a day, he'd said. *Like Antho with the stone. Like I did at the Keep, last summer, before the moths. You don't pour it all in at once. It runs out the other side.*

Ember could—

Ember's in Lex, he'd said. *And Lex is beyond the edge of the world. In a country where a day is ten.* He'd looked at her. *I'll do it myself. I'm the one who was there.*

So he did.

Every morning. When she'd got him propped up and fed him what he'd eat, which wasn't much, and wiped his face, and sat down on the edge of the bed with her hand in his.

One.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST WAS MULLED cider.

She'd heard it before. At the Keep. He'd told her last summer. She didn't mind. She wanted to hear it again. She wanted to hear all of them again. She wanted to hear them until she knew them the way you know the shape of your own hands.

A stall in the market, he said. *Below the Spire. The day after the steps. You made me buy you a cup of something hot because it was raining and you said Wardens owed the city a cup of something hot for all the Kindlings they'd ruined.*

Did I.

You did. It was mulled cider. I'd never had it. I'd been alive for a hundred and ninety-nine years and I'd never had mulled cider. His mouth twitched. *I drank it in one go because I didn't know you were meant to sip it. And then I walked into a pillar.*

You didn't.

I did. The big one by the fountain. With the Founder's face on it. He closed his eyes. *You laughed so hard you had to sit down on the fountain's edge. In the rain. And I stood there with my forehead bleeding and thought, I'm going to marry this woman if it kills me.*

She laughed.

She couldn't help it. She sat on the edge of the bed and laughed with her hand over her mouth and tears in her eyes, the way she must have laughed thirty-two years ago, on the edge of a fountain in the rain.

"*It nearly did*," said Arion. "*Kill me. Your mother had a very good arm.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SECOND WAS THE walk to the Vale.

The third was the cottage. The first night. Wenna standing in the doorway in her apron with her arms folded, looking at him. *Who's this*.

She put me in the barn, said Arion. *For a month. I slept in the straw with the goat.*

We had a goat?

You always had a goat, said Arion. *Harrow women always have a goat. It's in the rule somewhere. In the part that doesn't need saying.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE GOT TIRED BY the end of each one.

She watched it happen. Every morning. He'd start with his eyes bright and his voice stronger than it had any right to be, and by the end the words would be coming slower, and further apart, and his hand in hers would go slack, and he'd stop. In the middle, sometimes. In the middle of a sentence.

And sleep.

She'd sit with him. Holding his hand. Until he woke. And then he'd open his eyes and look at her and say, *where was I*.

And she'd tell him.

And he'd finish it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DAYS WENT.

Long ones. High summer. Hot. The birch wood dark and full and dusty and the stream running low. She kept the boards on the windows. She kept them on even though it was hot, even though the cottage was dim all day and stifling at night, even though Wren said the glass lady hadn't been seen since midsummer.

She's gone home, said Wren. *With your blood. Seraphine thinks she's not coming back.*

Seraphine thinks, said Seren.

She kept the boards on.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE NEWS CAME EVERY day.

Ravens. Riders. Keepers on foot. Farmers fleeing east on carts with their children on top. Elowen, every few days, on her grey warhorse, with dust to her knees, standing in the clearing not getting down, telling them.

Where he was. What he'd done. How many.

He walked five miles a day. Less. He stopped at every village. He sat on the edge of every well. He listened to everyone who came.

And kept the ones who asked.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He went round the Blightmarch*," said Elowen.

It was the thirty-first day. High summer. The worst of the heat. She'd come up the track at noon with her face burned red and her lips cracked, and Seren had brought her water, and she'd drunk it standing by her horse in the gold-patched clearing.

"*Round it*," she said again. "*Not across. Round. The long way.*" She wiped her mouth. "*Forty miles out of his way. South. Through the marsh country.*"

Seren looked at her.

"*Why*?"

"*Because the gold won't take*," said Elowen Dunmore. "*On the green. On Mal's ground.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN SAT DOWN.

On the oak ramp. In her bare feet. With the jug of water in her lap.

"*Seraphine went to look*," said Elowen. "*She flew down from the Keep on the dragon. To the edge of the circle. Where his road came up to it from the west.*" She looked at the birch wood. "*She said his road comes up to the edge of the green. A furlong wide. Gold. Every blade of grass. Every stone.*"

"*And*?"

"*And it stops*," said Elowen. "*At the edge. Right at the edge. Where the old trench was. Where they dug the word.*" She shook her head. "*She said it's like a tide line. Gold*

on one side. Green on the other. Sharp as a knife. Not a speck of gold on the green. Not one."

"*He tried to walk on it*," said Seren. Slowly.

"*He put his foot on it*," said Elowen. "*One foot. Seraphine found the print. Right at the edge. In the green. Just inside the line.*" A pause. "*It's not gold. It's just a footprint. In grass. Pressed down.*" She looked at Seren. "*And then he took his foot back. And turned south. And walked forty miles round.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

She sat on the ramp with the jug of water in her lap and thought about a pool in a green field. Full of room. With three small gold lights in the bottom of it.

It makes room, she thought. *It's the room. It's the Well of new things. The Well of empty on purpose.*

And he can't fill it.

He drank it once, she thought. *Nine hundred years ago. He drank it dry. And it starved, and it screamed, and it became the thing under the lid.*

And now it's home. And green. And full of room. And he puts his foot on it and the gold won't take.

"*He's afraid of it*," she said.

Elowen looked at her.

"*He's afraid of it*," said Seren again. "*The little one. Mal.*" She looked up. "*It's the only thing in the world he can't keep.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD ARION THAT evening.

He listened with his eyes half shut. On his pillows. With the Lantern burning. When she'd finished, he didn't say anything for a long time.

"*Room*," he said at last.

"*Room*."

"*Aurelian's note*," said Arion. "*Seraphine read it to me. Unwrite it when there is someone on this side who can make room for what is on the other.*" He breathed. In. Catch. Out. "*He's on this side now. Oszric. In the world. And the one thing in the world that can make room is the one thing he walks forty miles to avoid.*"

"*Is that good*?"

"*I don't know*," said her husband. "*I think it might be. I think it might be the most important thing anyone's told me since I woke up.*" He turned his head on the pillow. "*Write it down.*"

"*In the grey book*?"

"*Lex has the grey book*." A faint smile. "*Write it on the wall. Write it on the boards over the window. Write it somewhere, love. Somebody's going to need it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WROTE IT ON the boards.

That night. By the light of the Lantern. With a stick of charcoal from the hearth. In her square careful Harrow hand, on the oak planks nailed over the west window.

The gold won't take on Mal's green.

He walked round.

She stood back and looked at it.

It looked very small. Two lines of charcoal on a board.

She left it there.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WROTE THE LETTERS in the afternoons.

When he could. When his hand would hold the pencil. She'd prop the box on the blanket beside him, the oak one Brannoc had made, with the lid that sighed, and put a board across his knees for a desk, and a sheet of paper on the board, and the pencil in his hand.

And he'd write.

Slowly. So slowly. A line. A rest. Another line. His hand shaking so badly that sometimes the letters went off the edge of the page and he had to start again.

She didn't read them. She never asked.

But she counted them. She couldn't help it.

Twelve. *For Lark. On her twelfth birthday*.

Thirteen.

Fourteen.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What do you tell a fourteen-year-old*?" she said once.

He was lying with his eyes shut. The pencil in his slack fingers. The letter half done on the board across his knees.

"*That everyone she knows is an idiot*," said Arion. Not opening his eyes. "*Including her. Especially her.*"

Seren laughed.

"*That's what I needed*," said her husband. "*At fourteen. Someone to tell me I was an idiot. Nobody did. I was the heir. I was a Vey. I had the Root waiting for me.*" His

mouth twitched. "*I'd have been a much better man if someone had thrown a pan at me at fourteen.*"

"*I'll throw one at her.*"

"*Please do,*" said Arion Vey. "*But miss. Your mother always missed.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

FIFTEEN. SIXTEEN.

He wrote sixteen in one afternoon. All of it. Without stopping. His hand steadier than it had been in weeks. When he'd finished he lay back on the pillows grey-faced and breathing hard, and she took the pencil out of his fingers, and folded the letter, and sealed it with grey wax, and wrote on the outside, in her own hand, because his wouldn't do it anymore:

For Lark. On her sixteenth birthday.

"*That's the one,*" said Arion.

She looked at him.

"*Sixteen,*" said her husband. Very quietly. "*Her Kindling. If she still has one. If the world's still the world.*" He looked at the boards over the window. "*Antho was sixteen. When it broke. When everything broke.*" He breathed. "*I wasn't there. I'd sealed him and gone. I was in a crystal in Avaloria, holding the breaches.*" A pause. "*I never got to tell him anything. At sixteen. Before.*"

Seren held his hand.

"*So I told her,*" said Arion. "*Everything I'd have told him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEVENTEEN.

Eighteen.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN LEFT ON THE fifty-third day.

It wasn't a surprise. They'd been talking about it for weeks. In the blue-door cottage, at night, with the Lantern burning. Wren and Seren and Arion. Brannoc, sometimes. Kestrel.

When he's a week off, Arion had said. The first time. Lying on his pillows. *When he's a week off, you take her and you go.*

I'm not leaving you.

You're not leaving me, said Arion. *You're taking her. That's different.*

Lex said—

Lex said fog the glass, said Arion. *And you have. Every night. For two months.*

But the glass lady's gone—

The glass lady's gone, said Arion. *And the King's coming. And you can't fog a king.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS EIGHT DAYS off.

That was what Elowen said. On the fifty-second day. In the clearing. With the dust to her knees.

Ashbourne, she said. *He's at the edge of the Vale. At the top of the downs. Looking down.* She was very pale. *He's stopped. He's sitting on the hilltop. On a stone. Looking down at the Vale. He's been there two days.*

What's he doing?

Looking, said Elowen. *Just looking. Like a man looking at a view. Like a man who's walked a long way and come over the top of a hill and seen the place he's going.*

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN PACKED IN THE night.

Seren helped her. In the other cottage. Across the stream. By the light of a candle in a holder with no glass. The baby asleep in her cradle under the soaped window.

Not much. Wren was a tracker. Trackers didn't carry much. A blanket. A spare shirt. The baby's things, which were more than everything else put together. Her bow. Her knives. A little food.

A box.

Oak. Plain. With a lid that sighed.

Seren had carried it across the stream herself. That evening. From under Arion's bed. She'd set it on the table in Wren's kitchen and Wren had looked at it and gone very still.

He said give it to you, said Seren. *When the time came. He said you'd keep it safe. He said you're very good at keeping things.*

Wren had put her hand on the lid.

How many?

Eighteen, said Seren. *He's working on nineteen.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED ACROSS IN the morning.

Wren and the baby. Kestrel behind them, with her pack and her red hair and her amber eyes very bright. Brannoc, from the village, who'd come up at dawn and stood at the edge of the clearing with his arms folded and his gold fingertips catching the first light and said nothing at all.

Across the stepping stones. Up the oak ramp. Through the blue door.

Arion was awake.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS PROPPED UP. Seren had done it before dawn. Three pillows. His white hair combed. A clean shirt. His spectacles on, folded face down on the blanket beside his hand, the way he always left them now.

The Lantern burned on the table. Three panes of glass and one of horn.

He looked at them come in.

At Wren. At the sling on her chest. At the baby in it, awake, looking round with her grey-green eyes, frowning. At the box under Wren's arm.

"*Good morning*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

She came across the room and knelt down by the bed. With the baby on her chest. And looked at him.

"*She wants to say goodbye*," said Wren. Very steady. "*Don't you, love.*"

Lark looked at her grandfather.

At the old man on the pillows. At his walnut face. At the white wisp of his hair. At his grey eyes.

And reached out.

One square fist. Out of the sling. Toward his face.

He bent his head. Slowly. So slowly. As far as he could. Toward her.

And she grabbed his nose.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAUGHED.

The real laugh. Startled out of him. It hurt. Seren saw it hurt. It caught in his chest halfway and turned into a cough and he went on laughing through it with his granddaughter hanging on to his nose by one square fist and refusing, absolutely refusing, to let go.

"*Ah*," he said. Through the cough. Through the laugh. "*Ah. There you are.*"

Brannoc, in the doorway, made a sound.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She's got good taste*," said Wren. Her voice was shaking now. "*She always goes for the nose.*"

"*She gets that from you*," said Arion.

"*She gets that from Lex.*"

"*She gets it from both of you*," said her grandfather. Very quietly. With her fist still on his nose. "*She gets everything from both of you. That's the point.*" He looked at the

baby. At her frown. At her fist. "*She can be anything. That's what you made her. Both of you.*"

Lark let go.

She did it all at once, the way she always did. Done. Finished. Her hand coming off his face and back into the sling and her face screwing up, red and fierce, because she didn't like being finished.

She liked the doing.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Wren*," said Arion.

"*I know*."

"*Keep moving*," said Arion Vey. "*That's all. Don't stop. Don't stay anywhere long. Don't let him learn your face.*" His grey eyes were very steady. "*You know how. You're a tracker. You've been running on roofs since you were fourteen.*"

"*I'm not a Harrow*."

"*No*," agreed Arion. "*But she is.*" He looked at the baby. "*Twenty generations of women who never stayed. It's in her. In her blood. The Veil never learned it.*" A faint smile. "*She'll keep you moving, Wren. You'll see. She'll know when it's time to go before you do.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN HELD THE BOX out.

"*I'll keep it safe*," she said. "*I promise. Every one. On every birthday.*"

"*Thank you*."

"*Nineteen*," said Wren. "*You're on nineteen.*"

"*I'll send it after you*," said Arion. "*With a raven. And twenty. And twenty-one.*" His mouth twitched. "*If my hand holds. If the ravens can find you. Which they won't, if you're doing it properly.*"

"*Then how—*"

"*Then Seren will keep them*," said her father-in-law. "*Till you come home.*" He looked at her. "*You will come home. Afterward. When it's over.*"

"*I'll try*," said Wren.

Arion looked at her for a long moment.

"*Good*," he said. "*That's all anyone's got.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE KISSED HIM.

On the forehead. Quickly. Fiercely. Like a seal stamped. The way Seren did.

Then she stood up. With the baby on her chest and the box under her arm and her bow on her back and her left hand, gold from the knuckles to the nails, flat on the baby's back.

And turned. And went to the door.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Arion*," she said. Not turning round.

"*Mm*."

"*Lex is going to come back*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Through the door at the edge of the world. With a crown. Thinking it's the end of summer.*" Her voice cracked. "*And I won't be here. And Lark won't be here.*"

"*No*."

"*Tell him*," said Wren.

"*Tell him what*?"

She stood in the doorway with her back to the room for a long time.

"*Tell him I ran*," she said at last. "*Tell him I ran the whole way. Tell him she laughed.*"

And went out.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WATCHED THEM GO from the ramp.

Across the clearing. Past the gold birch. Past the gold woodpile. Past the cart. Wren with the baby on her chest. Kestrel beside her. Into the birch wood. Up the hill. North. Toward the Greyspine.

Not on the wind. Walking. A tracker's walk. Fast and light and steady.

At the top of the hill, at the edge of the trees, Wren stopped.

And turned round.

And Seren saw her lift one hand. The left. Gold from the knuckles. And hold it up. Not waving. Just holding it up. In the morning light. So it shone.

And then she turned. And was gone into the trees.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC STOOD BESIDE HER on the ramp.

He didn't say anything for a long time.

"*She didn't look back*," he said at last.

"*She did*," said Seren. "*Once. At the top.*"

"*Harrow women never look back*."

"She's not a Harrow," said Seren. *"She's an Ashdown."* She swallowed. *"Ashdowns look back. Once. At the top of the hill. So they remember the way home."*

◆ ◆ ◆

NINETEEN.

He wrote it that afternoon. And twenty, the next. His hand worse every day. The letters going off the page. Starting again. Going off again.

She didn't help. He didn't ask.

She sat on the edge of the bed and watched him write. And folded each one, when he'd finished, and sealed it with grey wax, and wrote on the outside in her own square hand.

For Lark. On her nineteenth birthday.

For Lark. On her twentieth birthday.

And put them in a drawer. In the table. By the bed. With the gold rose in its gold jug on the shelf above, behind the chipped blue cup.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD HIM ONE a day.

No. He told her. One a day. She kept forgetting which way round it went. Some days she felt she was the one doing the telling. Holding his hand. Saying, *and then what*. Saying, *where was I*. Saying, *the pillar, love, you were at the pillar*.

The wedding was the forty-fourth day.

She'd been waiting for it. She'd known it was coming. In the order he was telling them. After the barn and the goat and the pan and the lamp in the window.

The snow, he said. *It was snowing. The chapel at Ashbourne. Sister Agathe's predecessor. Old Brother Wyn. He was ninety-three and deaf in one ear.*

Who came?

Nobody, said Arion. *Your mother had died that winter. Before the spring. And I didn't have anyone. I had the Spire. I had Wardens. I couldn't tell any of them.* A faint smile. *So it was you and me and Brother Wyn and Brannoc.*

Seren went still.

Brannoc?

He was the smith, said Arion. *He was thirty. He'd shod the horse that brought me down from Highcrest. I asked him to stand witness because there was nobody else.* His eyes were closed. *He cried. All the way through. He cried so loudly Brother Wyn had to stop twice.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT DOWN TO the village that evening.

She didn't decide to. She found herself on the Ashbourne road in the dusk with her bare feet in the dust, walking. Three miles. To the Forge. To the long hall with the twenty anvils and the great chimneys at each end and Quill on his nest of spoons.

Brannoc was at the anvil.

Alone. The students gone home. Gone east, most of them, with their families, ahead of the King. He was working by the light of the forge. With a bar of white-hot iron in his bare gold-tipped fingers. Turning it. Looking at it.

He looked up as she came in.

"*You cried*," said Seren. "*At my wedding.*"

He put the bar down.

"*He told you*."

"*He told me*." She came across the hall. Stopped on the other side of the anvil. "*He said you cried so loudly the priest had to stop twice.*"

Brannoc looked at her for a long moment. In the forge-light. With his bald head and his soot-stained beard and his gold fingertips.

"*Three times*," he said. "*He's being kind.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CRIED THEN.

In the Ashbourne Forge. Across the anvil from the smith who'd stood witness at a wedding she didn't remember, in a chapel in the snow, thirty-one years ago. She cried with her hands over her face and her shoulders shaking.

He came round the anvil and put his enormous arms round her and held her.

"*I don't remember*," she said. Into his shirt. "*I don't remember it. You were there. You cried. And I don't remember.*"

"*I know*," said Brannoc Holt.

"*He's telling me. One a day. And I'm so glad. And it's not mine.*" She was shaking. "*It's his. It's all his. He's giving it to me and I'm holding it and it's not mine.*"

Brannoc didn't say anything for a long time.

"*You wore a blue dress*," he said at last.

She went still.

"*Blue*," said Brannoc. "*Very blue. Bluer than anything. Your mam had made it. Before she died. She'd finished it that winter. She'd been sewing it all autumn.*" His voice was very rough. "*You walked down the aisle of that chapel in the snow in a blue dress your dead mam had made you. And you were so happy. And so sad. And you laughed at Brother Wyn when he got your name wrong.*"

Seren couldn't breathe.

"*That's mine*," said Brannoc Holt. "*Not his. Mine. I was there. I saw it.*" He held her. "*You can have it. It's yours.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WALKED HOME IN the dark.

Three miles. Along the river path. Barefoot. Under the stars.

At the place where the path came out of the alders and you could see the Vale behind you, she stopped.

And turned. And looked back.

Ashbourne. Dark now. Mostly. Empty, mostly. A few windows lit.

And beyond it. Over the top of the downs. At the head of the Vale.

A glow.

◆ ◆ ◆

GOLD. LOW. ON THE hilltop. Where the road came down from the shires into the Vale.

Not a fire. Not a lamp. Not the moon; the moon was behind her.

Like metal in a crucible. Just before it pours.

He was sitting up there. On his stone. Looking down. She could feel it. From three miles off. The way you feel the heat of a forge from across a yard.

Looking at the Vale.

At Ashbourne. At the river. At the birch wood at the far end of it, and the clearing, and the two cottages.

At her.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOOD ON THE river path and looked back at him.

She didn't look away. She was a Harrow woman. Harrow women didn't look back.

She looked back anyway. Straight at the glow. Straight at the hilltop. For a long time.

Gold for the eldest, she thought. *Who feared to grow old*.

I'm here, she thought. At him. Across three miles of dark. *I'm here. In a cottage at the end of the Vale. With a blue door. With my husband in a bed under a boarded window. Dying.*

Come for tea.

I'll say no.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT HOME.

Over the stepping stones. Up the ramp. Through the blue door.

He was awake.

He was always awake now, when she came in. Lying on his pillows with his eyes open, looking at the boards over the window. At the two lines of charcoal on them in her square hand.

The gold won't take on Mal's green.

He walked round.

"*Where were you*?" he said.

"*At the Forge*." She sat down on the edge of the bed. Took his hand. "*Brannoc told me about the dress.*"

His face changed.

"*The blue one*," he said.

"*The blue one*."

"*I'd forgotten*," said Arion. Very quietly. "*I'd forgotten the dress.*" He closed his eyes. "*That's the trouble with being old. You think you've got all of it. And then someone tells you something and you realize you only ever had your side.*"

"*Brannoc had his*."

"*Brannoc had his*," said Arion Vey. "*Thank God for Brannoc.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

TWENTY-ONE.

He wrote it on the sixty-first day.

It took him all afternoon. A line. A rest. A line. She sat beside him and watched his hand move across the page. So slowly. Shaking. The letters going off the edge. Him stopping. Breathing. Starting again.

He didn't let her see it.

He turned the board a little, on his knees, so the page was facing away from her. She didn't mind. It wasn't hers.

At the end, he stopped.

He held the pencil over the page for a long time. She watched him. His hand shaking. The point of the pencil an inch above the paper.

Then he wrote one more word.

And put the pencil down.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Done*," said Arion.

She took the board off his knees. Folded the letter without reading it. Sealed it with grey wax. Wrote on the outside, in her square careful hand:

For Lark. On her twenty-first birthday.

And put it in the drawer. With the others. Nineteen. Twenty. Twenty-one.

She closed the drawer.

"*Done*," said Arion again. Very quietly. To the boards over the window. "*All of them.*"

"*All of them*."

"*That was the last thing*," said her husband. "*Not the Knot. Not Elric. This.*" He breathed. In. Catch. Out. "*I didn't know it was the last thing until I wrote the last word.*"

"*What was it*?" said Seren. "*The last word.*"

He looked at her.

"*It's hers*," he said. "*Not mine. Not yours.*" A faint smile. "*You'll have to wait till she's twenty-one and ask her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LAY DOWN BESIDE him.

On top of the blankets. With her bare feet cold and her head on the edge of his pillow and her hand on his chest. Over his heart.

In. Catch. Out.

In.

The Lantern burned on the table. Three clear squares on the walls and one soft blur.

"*Seren*," said Arion.

"*Mm*."

"*He's on the hill*."

"*I know. I saw him.*"

"*He's coming down tomorrow*," said Arion. "*Or the next day. Elowen says.*" A pause. "*He's coming here.*"

"*I know*."

"*For tea*."

"*I know*," said Seren Harrow. "*I bought more. From Hollis Penn. The good kind. In a tin.*"

He laughed.

Very quietly. In the dark. A short cracked sound that caught in his chest and turned into a cough and turned back into a laugh.

"*The good kind*," he said.

"*He's a king*," said Seren. "*He'll expect it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SLEPT.

She didn't.

She lay beside him in the dark with her hand on his chest and counted. In. Catch. Out. And listened. To the stream. To the birch wood. To an owl.

To something else.

Very far off. At the very edge of hearing. At the head of the Vale, on a hilltop, three miles and more away.

Footsteps.

Heavy. Slow. Unhurried.

Thud.

Getting up off a stone.

Thud.

Starting to walk.

Thud.

Down the hill.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T WAKE HIM.

She lay very still with her hand on his heart and listened to the Gilded King come down into the Vale.

Thud. *Thud*. *Thud*.

Not hurrying.

Not late.

CHAPTER 25

The Thorn Garden

THE ROSE OPENED, AND the thorns opened behind it.

Antho watched it happen. Standing at the foot of the black wall in the grey-gold dim with his brother beside him and Pim in Hask's arms. The bud at the height of Lex's chest unfolding, petal by petal, dark red, velvet, the only colour for a hundred miles. And as it opened, the stems round it moved.

Creaking. Unhooking. Drawing back. One from another. Slowly. The way fingers unclench.

A gap. A hand wide. Then an arm. Then a man's width.

A path.

Going in. Into the dark of the thorns. Between black stems as thick as a wrist, hooked with thorns as long as a finger, arching overhead so close they made a tunnel.

And at the end of it, far in, a long way in, grey light.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She knows we're here*," said Lex.

"*She's been waiting*," said Antho.

He didn't know how he knew. He felt it. The way he felt doors. The thorns were a wall, and a wall is a door that hasn't decided yet. And this one had decided. For them.

Rosie will betray you, Ysenne had said. In the stone room. With her glass hands in her lap. *She'll open her thorns. She'll cry. She'll mean it.*

He looked at the path going in.

And then Oz will ask her where you are. And she'll tell him.

"*Antho*," said Lex.

"*I know*."

"*It's a trap*," said Hask. From behind them. With Pim against his chest.

"*Everything's been a trap*," said Antho. "*The rose was a trap. The glass palace was a trap. The door at the edge of the world was a trap.*" He looked at the path. "*We walked into all of them.*"

"*And came out*," said Lex.

"*And came out*," agreed Antho.

He went in.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THORNS CLOSED BEHIND them.

He heard it. A creak. A rustle. A long dry sigh, like a tired woman sitting down. He looked back and the gap was gone. The path ended a yard behind Hask's heels in a wall of black hooked stems, tighter than before. Tight enough that you couldn't have put your hand through.

Nobody said anything.

They walked.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS DARK IN the thorns.

Not black. Not the dark of the cellar at Harrow. *Dim*. The grey-gold light of the Court came down through the tangle overhead in thin pale threads, like light through the roof of a barn. It lay on the dust of the path in spots and stripes.

The path wound.

Left. Right. Round. Back on itself. In among the black stems. Antho couldn't see more than a few yards ahead. He couldn't see the tower anymore. He couldn't see anything but thorns and dust and the thin threads of light.

But he could feel it.

Ahead. In the middle. A door. Shut. With something behind it.

And the something was saying *no*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT THE way you feel cold air coming down a chimney. A pressure. Not like the pressure of the Court, full and heavy, pushing on the room in his chest. The opposite. A *refusal*. Coming out from the middle of the thorns in slow steady waves. Patient. Quiet. Like a hand laid flat on a door.

Not you.

Not ever.

He stopped walking.

"*What*?" said Lex.

"*Can you feel it*?"

His brother stood still on the path. In a thread of grey-gold light. Listening.

"*Yes*," he said. Very quietly. "*Like a draught. Like someone saying hush.*"

"*It's the crown*," said Antho.

"*It's saying no*."

"*It's saying no to her*," said Antho. "*To all of them. To everyone who drank.*" He looked at the dark path winding on ahead. "*Not to us. We never drank.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[It's beautiful,] said Ember. Faintly.

Lex told him. His brother's eyes went a little unfocused, the way they always did when the voice in his head spoke.

"*Ember says it's beautiful*," said Lex. "*It says it's the most beautiful no it's ever heard.*" He was quiet. "*It says it sounds like Mam. At the door. At Harrow. When the dust came.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS WAITING AT the bend.

Antho saw her before he understood what he was seeing. A shape. On the path ahead. In a thread of grey light. Small. Thin. Standing very still among the black stems.

At first he thought she was one of them. A thorn. A stem. Thin and dark and twisted, growing up out of the dust.

Then she moved.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS VERY THIN.

That was the first thing. Thin the way a stick is thin. The way a stem is thin in winter, when all the green has gone out of it. Her arms were sticks. Her neck was a stalk. Her face was a skull with skin stretched over it, grey-green, the colour of a leaf that has been lying in a ditch since autumn.

She wore a robe. Grey-gold silk. Rotten. Hanging off her in rags.

Her hair was long and dark and full of dust.

And on her head, a crown.

Not gold. Not glass. Not iron. *Thorns*. Black. Twisted. Dry. A circle of them, woven round on themselves, with the points turned inward. Toward her brow. Where they'd scratched, Antho saw. Thin dark lines on the grey-green skin, old and new.

Her eyes were green.

Not lit. Not like Maelis's, like windows. Not like Oszric's, like furnaces. Just green. Pale. Wet. The colour of new leaves.

The only green thing about her.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED AT THEM.

At Lex, at the front. At the handprint on his cheek. At Antho beside him. At Hask behind, enormous, with Pim asleep against his chest.

Her hands came up. Pressed together under her chin. The way a child holds her hands when she's very nervous.

"*Oh*," said Rhosyn. "*Oh. You came.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HER VOICE WAS LIKE a stem bending. Thin. Papery. Green. Antho had heard it once before. Through a rose. In the blue-door cottage. His mother had told him. *Like leaves. Like a girl who hasn't spoken to anyone in a very long time and isn't sure she still knows how.*

It was exactly like that.

"*You came*," she said again. Wonderingly. "*She said you might. Seren. Through the rose. She said if one of hers came—*" She stopped. Her green eyes moved. Over Lex's face. Over Antho's. "*Two of hers. Two.*"

"*Lexander Vey*," said Lex. "*Her son.*"

"*Anthoren*," said Antho. "*Her other one.*"

The Thorn-Crowned looked at them for a long time.

"*You've got her hands*," she said to Lex. Very quietly. "*Square. Like a smith's.*" She looked at Antho. "*And you've got her eyes. No.*" She frowned. Her thin brow creasing under the crown of thorns. "*Not hers. Hes's. You've got Hes's eyes. The way she looked at the pool. Like she was listening to something nobody else could hear.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

He couldn't. He stood on the path in the thorns and looked at the thin grey-green woman with her hands pressed together under her chin, and felt for her door.

He didn't mean to. He couldn't help it. He was a Threshold Warden. He'd felt for doors in nine thousand gold people on a white road and found none. He felt for hers.

It was there.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THE LAST DOOR. Not the one everyone gets. That one was gone. Bricked up. Like the kept. Like the cousins at the edge. Like everyone who drank. Smooth and solid and perfect, so you couldn't see where it had been.

But it hadn't been bricked up from the *outside*.

He felt it. The difference. In the kept, the door had been closed by a hand on the forehead. By a finger. By a pinch of gold on the tongue. From outside.

In Rhosyn, it had been closed from inside.

By drinking. By a gold cup at the edge of a pool on the last evening. By her own hands, cupped, lifting the water to her own mouth.

She'd bricked up her own door.

And she knew it. He could feel her knowing it. Every day. For nine hundred years. Standing in front of the place where her door had been, with her hands pressed together under her chin, looking at the bricks.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're the warden*," said Rhosyn. Looking at him. "*Aren't you. The one who feels doors. Orrin said.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*Can you feel mine*?"

He didn't answer.

"*It's gone*," said the Thorn-Crowned. Very quietly. "*Isn't it. I know it is. I can feel it too. Where it used to be.*" Her green eyes were very wet. "*I've been standing in front of it for nine hundred years.*"

"*Yes*," said Antho.

She looked at him for a long moment.

"*Thank you*," she said. "*For telling me the truth.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She said you'd betray us*," said Lex.

Antho turned and stared at him.

His brother was standing on the path with the basket of Hush-cups on his back and his hand on the bell. Very still. Looking at the Thorn-Crowned.

Rhosyn didn't flinch.

She stood among her thorns with her hands under her chin and looked at Lex. And something in her thin grey-green face—

It didn't break. It *sagged*. The way a stem sags when you've stopped watering it.

"*Ysy*," she said.

"*Yes.*"

"*She'd know*," said Rhosyn. "*She's always right. She looks at things and sees what's there.*" Her voice was very small. "*She saw me in the garden. With Hes. Saying oh, Hes, are you sure.*" A pause. "*And she saw me in the hall that night. Drinking.*"

"*Will you*?" said Lex.

The Thorn-Crowned didn't answer for a long time.

"*I don't know*," she said at last.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

"*I don't want to*," said Rhosyn. "*I don't. I want to take you to the tower and open my thorns and let you up the stair and watch you come down with it and go home.*" Her hands were shaking under her chin. "*I want that more than I've wanted anything since—*" She stopped.

"*Since what*?"

"*Since I wanted to listen*," said Rhosyn. "*To Hes. In the garden. With my roses.*" She looked down at her feet. Bare. Grey-green. Thin as twigs. "*I wanted that so much. I wanted to be the one who listened. And I did. I listened to every word. I cried.*" A pause. "*And then Oz said, come down to the hall, Rosie, it's only water.*"

"*And you went*."

"*I always go*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*When he calls. I always have. Since I was four and he lifted me onto a pony.*" She looked up. At Lex. At Antho. "*He hasn't called. Not yet. He's in your world. Walking. I can feel him. Far off. Like the sun on the other side of a wall.*"

"*And when he does*?"

Rhosyn didn't answer.

She didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Then why*," said Antho. "*Why open them? Why let us in?*"

The Thorn-Crowned looked at him.

"*Because of the song*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAITED.

"*Hes's girls*," said Rhosyn. "*They sing a song. About us. Seren sang it to me. Through the rose.*" She half-closed her eyes. "*Gold for the eldest. Glass for the vain. Iron for the one who never laughed.*"

"*Thorns for the gardener who listened*," said Antho. Very quietly.

"*And drank*," said Rhosyn.

"*It doesn't rhyme*."

"*It doesn't rhyme*," she agreed. "*It's meant not to. Seren said. So you'll always remember that's where it went wrong.*" Her green eyes opened. "*Nine hundred years. Every Harrow girl. Singing my name and breaking the song on it.*"

She looked at the two of them. Hesper's line. Twenty generations down.

"*I'd like it to rhyme*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*Just once. Before the end.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOOK THEM IN.

Through the thorns. Along the winding path. Rhosyn first. Barefoot. Silent. The black stems drawing back from her as she came, the way grass leans away from wind. Then Lex. Then Antho. Then Hask, with Pim.

She didn't look back. She walked with her thin arms at her sides and her rotten robe dragging in the dust and her crown of thorns on her bowed head, and the thorns opened in front of her and closed behind.

Antho watched her back.

He'd thought she'd be frightening. One of the Crowned. One of the Nine. One of the five who'd gone through. Deathless. Starving. He'd met two of them now, or the edges of them. A Moth Queen with lit eyes who'd wanted to drink the world. A Glass Queen in a palace of her own face.

He'd thought this one would be the same.

She wasn't frightening.

She was the saddest thing he'd ever seen.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There were roses*," said Rhosyn.

She said it without turning round. Walking. Her voice going back to them along the path like a leaf on a stream.

"*On a white wall*," she said. "*In my mother's garden. Red ones. When I was four.*" A pause. "*I used to sit under them. All summer. The bees used to come. Hundreds. I'd sit in the middle of them and they never stung me. Not once.*"

Nobody answered.

"*And yellow ones*," said Rhosyn. "*Up an apple tree. And a dark one, nearly black, in a trough by the kitchen door. It smelled of cloves. And rain.*" Her bare feet in the dust. "*And little pink ones in the cabbage bed. Where Hes used to sit.*"

"*You remember them all*," said Lex.

"*I dreamed them*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*Nine hundred years. In the silk. Every one. Every rose I ever grew.*" A small sound. "*And then I'd wake up. And they'd be thorns.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Your gardeners*," said Antho.

She stopped.

On the path. In a thread of light. With her back to him. Very still.

"*On the road*," said Antho. "*In the gold. You told my mother. Through the rose. Tam and old Wyn and little Bess.*"

The Thorn-Crowned didn't turn round.

"*Bess carried the watering cans*," she said. Very quietly. "*She was nine. She was too small for them. She used to drag them across the lawn with both hands and slop half the water on her boots.*" A pause. "*I used to laugh at her. Not unkindly. She'd laugh too.*"

"*She's on the road*."

"*She's on the road*," said Rhosyn. "*Near the hall. Near the end. Holding a little gold can. With gold water slopping out of the spout.*" Her shoulders were shaking. "*I walk past her every time I leave the hall. I don't look. I haven't looked in nine hundred years.*"

"*They hum*," said Antho.

She went very still.

"*One note*," said Antho. "*All of them. Nine thousand. You said you'd never listened long enough to hear what it was saying.*" He looked at her back. At her thin shoulders under the rotten silk. "*Pim heard it. On the road. A girl said one word, out loud, and the hum remembered.*"

"*What—*" The Thorn-Crowned's voice cracked. "*What is it saying?*"

Antho looked at Pim. Asleep against Hask's chest. White-faced.

"*Home*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN SAT DOWN.

On the path. In the dust. Among her thorns. Just sat. As if her legs had gone. With her knees drawn up and her thin arms round them.

Like a girl on the edge of a cabbage bed.

She didn't make a sound.

The thorns did.

All round. Every stem. In every direction. Creaking. Shifting. Moaning. A long low dry sound, like wind through a dead hedge in winter. Like a whole forest of black thorns grieving.

And here and there, among them, on the end of a hooked stem—

Red.

Small. Closed. Buds. Dozens. Hundreds. Coming out all over the black wall of thorns at once, in every direction, as far as Antho could see.

And opening.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY MOVED.

They stood on the path among the thorns while the Thorn-Crowned sat in the dust with her arms round her knees and a thousand roses opened round her. Dark red. Velvet. Damp. As if it had rained.

It had never rained in the Court.

The smell came up round them. Faint. Then not faint. Summer. Rain on a white wall. A garden full of bees.

Home.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM WOKE UP.

Antho felt him wake. In Hask's arms. A stir. A breath. His head lifting off Hask's chest.

He looked round. At the thorns. At the roses. At the thin grey-green woman sitting in the dust with her face hidden in her knees.

He didn't say anything.

He wriggled. Hask let him down. Slowly. One finger at a time. The way he did everything now.

Pim stood on the path. Unsteady. Pale. In his blue coat with the brass buttons. He looked at Rhosyn for a long time.

Then he went and sat down beside her.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT CLOSE. NOT TOUCHING. A foot away. In the dust. Cross-legged. The way he'd sat on the white road in front of Ilda. The way he sat on the rim of the pool beside Ivy.

He didn't say anything.

He got quiet.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO FELT IT.

Not much. Pim didn't have much. He'd poured most of himself into a gold girl on the white road and given the rest to a Glass Queen in a stone room. He was nearly empty. Antho could feel how empty. Like a cup with only a little water left in the bottom.

But he gave it.

A little. Just a little. A breath of quiet. A small round room. Spreading out from the boy, soft and still, toward the woman beside him in the dust.

Not into her. There was no crack in her to go into. She was full. She'd bricked herself up nine hundred years ago with her own hands.

Round her.

Like a coat. Like a blanket round the shoulders of someone who's been out in the cold too long.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN LIFTED HER HEAD.

Slowly. Her thin grey-green face wet. Her crown of thorns crooked. Her green eyes very wide.

She looked at Pim.

At the small pale boy sitting in the dust a foot away from her with his eyes shut and his hands open on his knees.

"*Oh*," she said. Very softly. "*Oh. It's quiet.*"

Pim didn't open his eyes.

"*Nobody's ever—*" The Thorn-Crowned stopped. Tried again. "*It's so quiet. I can't hear him. I can always hear him. Oz. Like the sun on the other side of a wall. Always. Nine hundred years.*" Her voice was trembling. "*I can't hear him.*"

"*It's a room*," said Pim. Very quietly. Not opening his eyes. "*Nobody can come in.*"

She stared at him.

"*Not even him*?"

"*Not even him*," said Pim. "*For a little while.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CRIED THEN.

Properly. Not the silent sitting. Not the thorns moaning. She put her face in her thin hands and cried like a girl. Like a girl of fifteen who has just been told something wonderful and terrible and can't hold it.

Pim sat beside her with his eyes shut.

He didn't put his arm round her. He didn't touch her at all.

He just held the room.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK CAME AND STOOD over them.

Enormous. With his pick in his good hand and his bandaged arm against his chest and his face like a slab of coal.

Rhosyn looked up at him. Through her fingers. Through her tears.

She went very still.

"*You*," she said.

Hask didn't answer.

"*You're hers*," said the Thorn-Crowned. Very quietly. "*Mae's. I can smell her on you. Like smoke in a coat.*" Her green eyes moved over him. The scarred leather. The two long scars down the back of his jerkin, where something had once torn through. "*You had her wings.*"

"*Yes*," said Silas Hask.

"*You're the hewer*," said Rhosyn. "*Orrin told us. In the hall. A hewer broke her on his pick.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*And then you held it out*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*Orrin said. At the end. On the rubble. You held your pick out. And she flew onto it.*"

Hask didn't say anything for a long time.

"*She was falling*," he said at last. "*Somebody'd held on to her wings. A Warden. Kell. And then let go. And she was falling.*" His voice was very rough. "*She'd been good to me. For a season. She'd filled my chest with light so I could breathe.*" He looked down at the pick in his hand. "*So I held it out. For her to land on. That's all.*"

"*And then the smith tapped it.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*And she came apart*," said Rhosyn.

"*She was warm*," said Silas Hask. "*At the end. A Harrow woman gave her a lamp. She was warm and she smiled.*" He looked at the Thorn-Crowned. "*I saw it. I was right there.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN LOOKED UP AT him for a long time.

Then she unfolded one thin grey-green hand from her knees. And held it up. Toward him.

Hask looked at it.

Then he knelt down. Slowly. Enormous. In the dust. In front of her. And took it. In his good hand. His big scarred miner's hand round her thin twig of a hand.

"*Thank you*," said Rhosyn. "*For holding it out.*"

Hask didn't say anything.

He knelt in the dust holding the Thorn-Crowned's hand. And a rose opened on the stem nearest his shoulder. Dark red. Velvet.

And he started to cough.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THE OLD COUGH. Not the grey-lung. Not the short dry rattle he'd had all spring.

Antho heard it and didn't understand it at first.

Then he did.

Hask was *crying*. The way a big man cries who hasn't cried since he was nine. Who hadn't cried at his father's grave or his mother's or his sister's, standing at the window looking up at the dark. Who'd held it in his chest so long it had gone in with the grey and the coal-dust and the Gloam and lived there.

It came out of him like a cough. Hard. Wrenching. Kneeling in the dust of the Court with a Crowned queen's hand in his.

Rhosyn held on.

She didn't let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A LONG time before anyone moved.

The roses stayed open. All round. A thousand of them. Dark red on the black thorns. The smell of summer thick in the dim air.

Pim held the room till he couldn't. Then it went. Antho felt it go. And Rhosyn felt it too. He saw her flinch. Saw her head turn, very slightly, toward the east. Toward the far wall of the thorns. Toward the world. Toward a sun on the other side of a wall.

"*He's there*," she whispered. "*Again. I can hear him.*"

"*I'm sorry*," said Pim. "*I don't have any more.*"

"*No*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*Don't be sorry. Don't.*" She looked at the boy. At his white face. "*That was the first time in nine hundred years I couldn't hear him.*" She swallowed. "*I'll remember it. I'll remember it forever. I've got a very good memory. I remember every rose.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOOD UP.

Slowly. Like something growing. She wiped her face with the rag of her sleeve. She straightened her crown of thorns.

"*Come*," she said. "*It's not far now.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PATH CAME OUT into a clearing.

Small. Round. Grey dust. With the thorns rising on every side like the walls of a well. Black. Hooked. Covered now with red.

And in the middle of it, the tower.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO HAD SEEN IT in his mother's dream. She'd told him. She'd told them all. In the Hall of Lanterns. *Small. Slender. Grown, not built. Grey and cracked and dead.*

She'd been right.

It was no taller than a tall tree. Slender. Twisted. The living trunk of something that had been a great white-barked tree once, coaxed up and up and round on itself, the way you'd coax a vine up a pole. It had been beautiful. Antho could see it had been beautiful. The way the wood curled. The way it rose. Like a girl's hair, plaited and wound up on her head.

It was dead now.

Grey. Cracked. The bark hanging off it in long dry strips. The wood underneath gone silver with age. Nine hundred years of standing in a country with no rain.

A door at the bottom.

A window at the top.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT.

The *no*. Here. In the clearing. Not waves now. Not a draught down a chimney. A *wall*. Coming out of the tower from the top, from the window, from the room behind it, down the stair, out of the door, into the clearing.

Patient. Quiet. Absolute.

Not you. Not ever. Hush.

Rhosyn stopped at the edge of the clearing.

She didn't go further. She stood among her roses with her hands pressed together under her chin and looked at the tower.

"*This is as far as I can go*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I grew it*," she said. "*In the first year. For her.*" She didn't look at them. She looked at the tower. "*The others laughed. Ysy laughed hardest. She said Hes would never come.*"

"*She was right*," said Lex. Quietly.

"*She was right*," agreed the Thorn-Crowned. "*Hes never came.*" A pause. "*But her crown did. Thirty-two years ago. In a long grey hand.*"

She looked at the door.

"*I stood here*," she said. "*Where I'm standing now. When the grey man came down the stair. I'd felt it come into the Court. Like a cold hand. Like a no. I woke up for the first time in four hundred years and ran here.*" Her voice was very small. "*He told me it was hers. He told me she'd had a line. Twenty generations.*"

"*And you grew the thorns*."

"*I grew the thorns*," said Rhosyn. "*Round and round. So Oz would never find the stair.*" She looked at the tower. "*And then I went back to the hall. And climbed into my silk. And slept. For thirty-two years.*" She swallowed. "*More soundly than I'd slept in nine hundred.*"

"*It said no*," said Antho. "*Every night. And you slept.*"

"*Like a hand on a forehead*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*Like Mae's hand. When Hes had the fever.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I can't go up*," she said.

"*I know*."

"*I tried. Once. That night.*" Her green eyes were on the door. "*I put my foot on the bottom stair. And it said no. And I couldn't.*" She looked at her bare grey-green foot in the dust. "*Not because it hurt. Because it was right.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*You can*," said Rhosyn. "*You're hers. You never drank. It won't say no to you.*" She looked at Lex. At Antho. "*Go up. Go and get it.*"

"*And you*?"

"*I'll wait*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*Here. At the bottom.*" A small strange smile. "*I've been waiting at the bottom of this tower for nine hundred years. I'm very good at it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO LOOKED AT HER.

At the thin grey-green woman standing among her roses. With her crown of thorns crooked and her rotten robe hanging off her and her hands pressed together under her chin.

She'll open her thorns. She'll cry. She'll mean it.

And then Oz will ask her where you are. And she'll tell him.

"*Rhosyn*," he said.

She looked at him.

"*When he asks*," said Antho Vey. "*Your brother. Where we are. What we took.*"

The Thorn-Crowned went very still.

"*You don't have to lie*," said Antho. "*I know you can't. I know you always tell him.*" He swallowed. "*Just—wait. A little. Before you answer. As long as you can.*"

She looked at him for a long time.

"*How long*?" she said.

"*Long enough*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN DIDN'T ANSWER.

She stood among her roses with her green eyes on his face.

And then she nodded.

Once. Very small. The way a stem nods when a bee lands on it.

"*I'll try*," said the Thorn-Crowned.

Antho closed his eyes.

I'll try. His father's words. His mother's. Wren's. The words everyone said, this year, to everyone they loved.

That's all anyone's got.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Pim*," said Lex. "*Hask. Stay with her.*"

Hask looked at him.

"*Stay*," said Lex. "*Here. At the bottom. With Rhosyn.*" He looked at the tower. At the door. At the *no* pouring out of it like cold air. "*It's Harrow blood it won't say no to. Ours. Just ours.*" He looked at his brother. "*You and me.*"

Antho nodded.

He looked at Pim. Sitting in the dust at the edge of the clearing. White-faced. Empty. With his hand on the pocket over his heart, where Ivy's cat was.

"*Make room for her*," said Antho. "*If you get any back. If you can. While we're up there.*"

Pim looked at the Thorn-Crowned.

Then at Antho.

"*Yes*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CROSSED THE CLEARING.

The two of them. Side by side. Through the grey dust. Through the *no*.

It didn't push. Antho felt it pour past him. Round him. Through him. Cold. Quiet. Patient. Like water round a stone. Like a hand laid on a door that the door was allowed through.

Not you, it said. To the thorns. To the roses. To the thin grey-green woman at the edge of the clearing. To the whole grey-gold country round it, and the hall, and the kept, and the King walking in a world on the other side of the Veil. *Not you. Not ever.*

To the two of them, it didn't say anything.

It just let them come.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DOOR WAS SHUT.

Grey wood. Grown, not built. The same silver-dead wood as the tower. With no handle. No latch. No lock. Just a door. Shut.

Antho put his hand on it.

His left. The one he'd cut at the edge of the world. With a thin red line across the palm, healing.

He felt it.

Felt the door feel him. Feel the Harrow blood in his hand. Hesper's blood. Twenty generations down.

Felt it not know him.

And open.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT SWUNG INWARD.

Silently. Slowly. On no hinges. Into the dark of the dead tree.

A stair.

Winding. Up. Through the hollow of the trunk. Grey wood. Narrow. Worn. Spiralling up into a dimness that wasn't quite dark.

And coming down it, out of the dimness, out of the room at the top, out of the thing on the chair—

No.

Cold. Quiet. Steady.

Not at them.

For them.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO LOOKED BACK.

Once. From the doorway. Across the clearing.

At Hask. Standing at the edge of it, enormous, with his pick in his good hand and his bandaged arm against his chest. At Pim. Sitting in the dust beside him, small and white, with his eyes shut, trying.

At Rhosyn.

Standing among her roses. With her hands pressed together under her chin. With her crown of thorns crooked. With a thousand red flowers open round her on the black stems.

Watching them go up.

Her green eyes were wet.

She was smiling.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT UP.

CHAPTER 26

The Tenth Tower

THE STAIR WAS VERY narrow.

Lex went first. He had to turn sideways in places, where the dead trunk of the tree twisted and the hollow inside it pinched. The steps were grown, not cut. Shelves of grey wood curling out from the wall in a spiral, worn smooth in the middle as if feet had climbed them for a long time.

No feet had. Not for nine hundred years. Only the Ferryman's, once. Thirty-two years ago. Going up with a crown in his long grey hand. Coming down without it.

Lex climbed.

And the *no* came down the stair to meet him.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T PUSH.

He'd thought it would. He'd felt it from the clearing, from the path, from the edge of the thorns. A cold steady refusal pouring out of the tower like air down a chimney. He'd thought, climbing into it, it would be like climbing into a wind.

It wasn't.

It went *round* him. Down the stair. Past his shoulders. Past his face. Cold. Quiet. Patient. The way water goes round a stone in a stream. It knew he was there. It knew what he was. And it let him through, and went on down past him to the clearing, to the thorns, to the woman standing among her roses, saying the thing it had been saying for thirty-two years.

Not you. Not ever. Hush.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember.

Very quiet. Very close.

I know.

[It's like your mother,] said Ember. *[At the blue door. When the dust came.]* A pause. *[It's like every Harrow woman who ever stood at a door with her hand flat on the wood.]*

Twenty generations, thought Lex.

[Twenty generations,] said Ember. *[All saying the same thing. In one crown.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WAS BEHIND HIM.

Lex could hear him breathing. Slow. Careful. Further than halfway. He'd drunk his last cup at the edge of the thorns. They'd counted, before they went in. Nine left. Nine cups in the basket on Lex's back. Thirteen days. Fewer.

Lex didn't do the sums.

He climbed.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STAIR WENT ROUND six times.

He counted. He couldn't help it. Six turns of the spiral, up through the hollow of the dead white tree, with the grey light coming dim through cracks in the bark. And then the hollow widened. And the stair stopped. At a floor.

Grey wood. Grown. Like the rest.

And a room.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A GIRL'S room.

He'd known it would be. His mother had dreamed it. The Ferryman had described it. Rhosyn had grown it.

He hadn't known it would be like *this*.

Small. Round. The inside of the top of the tree. With walls that curved and a ceiling that came to a point overhead, like the inside of a bell, like the inside of a tent. Grey. Silver-grey. The wood smooth and dry and dead.

A bed. Against the wall. Small. Narrow. A girl's bed. Grown out of the floor in one piece, like the stair. With a coverlet on it. Not cloth. *Leaves*. Woven. Thousands of them. Overlapping. Like the scales of a fish. Grey now. Dead. Dry as paper.

They'd been green once. He could tell. The shapes. The veins. Rose leaves. Every one.

A shelf. On the wall. Grown out of it like a bracket fungus on a tree. With three things on it.

A window. Small. Round. Facing west. Looking out at nothing. At the grey-gold dim. At the edge of the plain.

And a chair.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED IN THE doorway.

He couldn't help it. He stood at the top of the stair with his hand on the curved grey wall and his brother behind him and looked at the room.

And it was so *sad*.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT FRIGHTENING. NOT GRAND. Not a throne room. Not a vault. Not a tomb. A room a girl of fifteen had grown, in a dead country, in the first year of the exile, for her little sister. With everything she could remember about her sister's room at home. In case.

In case she changed her mind.

In case she came.

In case she wanted somewhere to sleep.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT TO THE shelf first.

He didn't know why. The chair was there. In the middle of the room. Facing the window. With something on it.

He couldn't look at it yet.

He went to the shelf.

◆ ◆ ◆

A BOWL. GREY WOOD. Grown. Shallow. With something in the bottom of it.

Dust. Fine. Red-brown. Dry as powder. A little heap of it in the bottom of the bowl. And in the dust, here and there, shapes. Curls. Tiny. Brittle. The ghosts of petals.

Roses.

A bowl of roses. Left on a shelf in a girl's room nine hundred years ago. Gone to dust.

Lex didn't touch it.

◆ ◆ ◆

A BEAR.

Small. Carved. Wood. The same grey wood as the room. No bigger than his hand. Sitting up, with its front paws in its lap and its head a little on one side. Worn smooth. So smooth the face had almost gone. As if it had been held. A great deal. By a small hand. For a long time.

It hadn't, of course. Nobody had ever held it. Nobody had ever been here.

Rhosyn had grown it worn.

She sat on the floor by the bed, Caddoc had said. Up the long silver thread. To Arion. In the dark at the bottom of the world. *Hes was too little. She sat on the floor by the bed and played with a toy bear.*

A girl who married a bear, Maelis had told her. Rhosyn had said. Through the rose. *When Hes had the fever. Mae sat up all night and told her a story about a girl who married a bear.*

Lex looked at the worn grey bear on the shelf.

She remembered, he thought. *Rhosyn. Every detail. The bowl of roses. The bear. How worn it was. How small the hand that held it.*

She grew it all from memory. In a dead country. For a sister who never came.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE THIRD THING.

Not on the shelf. *In* it. Scratched. Into the grey wood. Small. Uneven. With something sharp. A thorn, maybe.

Letters. In a language he couldn't read. Old. Curling. Beautiful.

And under them, smaller, newer, in a different hand—no. The same hand. But later. Much later. Shakier. In letters he *could* read. Square. Plain. The world's letters. The letters Orrin used.

The same letters as a scrap of grey silk tied to a rose at the foot of the Veil.

HES
I'M SORRY
R

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She came back*," said Antho.

He was beside Lex. Looking at the scratches on the shelf. His voice very quiet.

"*The old letters are from the first year*," he said. "*When she grew it. I can't read them. But they're old. They've gone grey with the wood.*" He touched the newer ones. Lightly. With one finger. "*These are new. These are thirty-two years. The night the Ferryman came.*"

"*She said she couldn't come up.*"

"*She couldn't come up the stair*," said Antho. "*Not after the crown was here.*" He looked at the scratches. "*Before. In the first year. Before the crown. She could come up. She grew it. She sat in here.*" He looked round the small round room. "*She must have come up a thousand times. In the first year. Sat on that bed. Waited.*"

"*And then*?"

"*And then she went to sleep*," said Antho. "*In her silk. For four hundred years. And when she woke, the crown was here. And she couldn't come up anymore.*" He touched the newer letters again. "*So she scratched this on the way down. That night. With the Ferryman watching. Before the stair said no.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HES. I'M SORRY. R.

Lex looked at it for a long time.

She sent a rose, he thought. *Through the crack. With HES on it. Asking.*

And this was the last thing she said to her sister before that. Thirty-two years ago. On a shelf in a room her sister never saw.

I'm sorry.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED ROUND.

And looked at the chair.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS SMALL.

A girl's chair. Grown out of the floor in one piece like everything else. Grey wood. A seat. A back. Four legs that weren't legs, that were roots, curling down into the floor. Plain. No carving. No arms.

Facing the window.

Facing west. Out at nothing. At the grey-gold dim at the edge of the plain. At the edge of everything.

And on the seat, in the middle, exactly in the middle, where the Ferryman had set it down thirty-two years ago, the way you'd set down a sleeping child—

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D SEEN THE HOLLOW in the box. In the cellar at Harrow. A year and a half ago. With Wren at the top of the ladder and his brother beside him with a Lantern. A circle pressed into the oak. Seven points.

He'd imagined it a thousand times since.

He'd imagined it beautiful. Shining. A thing out of a song. A crown that could say no to a king.

It wasn't beautiful.

It was the plainest thing he'd ever seen.

◆ ◆ ◆

A CIRCLE. SILVER. A little bigger than a man's hand could span. Not thick. Not thin. A band of metal a finger wide, round. And rising from the top edge of it, at even spaces, seven points. Short. Plain. Blunt-tipped. Like the tines of a fork. Like the teeth of a comb.

No jewels. No carving. No engraving. No polish.

The silver had gone soft and grey. Not tarnished. Not black. *Grey*. The way silver goes when it's been in the dark a very long time and nobody has ever once rubbed it with a cloth. Dull. Quiet. Like a stone at the bottom of a river.

It sat on the seat of the chair in the dead grey room and it didn't shine.

And the whole room was full of *no*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT COME off it.

From the circle. From the seven points. From the grey silver. Steady. Patient. Quiet. Not loud. Not a shout. Not a wall.

A *refusal*.

The way his mother said no. The way Old Mag said no to a dust-man through a cracked window. The way a girl of seventeen said no on a shingle, to her sister in chains, with her voice shaking and not letting it stop her.

Not me. Not ever.

Twenty generations of it. Every Harrow woman who'd ever kept the box. Every one who'd moved on at the end of summer. Every one who'd sung the song and broken it on Rhosyn's name. Every one who'd never let a moth in.

It was all in the crown.

It wasn't magic. Lex understood that, standing in the doorway of the tenth tower. It wasn't a spell. It wasn't a rune. It wasn't anything Aurelian had made or anything the net had given.

It was just a crown that had been put down.

And never picked up again.

And nine hundred years of not being picked up had *meant* something.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," said Antho.

"*I know*."

"*Are you going to—*"

"*I don't know*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT TO THE chair.

Slowly. Across the small round floor. Past the bed with its coverlet of dead rose leaves. Past the shelf with its bowl of dust and its worn bear and its scratched *I'm sorry*.

He stopped in front of the chair.

He looked down at the crown.

And he couldn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS HAND CAME UP. On its own. The way it came up to the fire every morning. The way it came up to the Veil. Out. Toward the crown.

And stopped. A foot above it.

And stayed there.

We break the ground, he thought. *We never take the crown*.

We never let a moth in.

His mother's voice. In the cellar. Reading a letter from a dead woman. *We never take the crown*.

His mother's voice again. On a sheepskin by a hearth. In the spring. Telling a baby who'd just rolled over for the first time. *We break the ground. We never take the crown. We never let a moth in.*

He held his hand over the crown and couldn't bring it down.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember. Very gently.

It's the rule.

[I know.]

Mam's rule. Wenna's. Hesper's. Twenty generations. We never take the crown. His hand was shaking. *And I've come all this way, through the edge of the world, past the King, through a glass palace, through a mile of thorns.* He swallowed. *To take the crown.*

Ember didn't say anything for a moment.

[Malachi gave it to her,] it said. *[On the shingle. He said, keep it. Hide it. Don't wear it. Pass it on.]*

Lex didn't move.

[Keep it,] said Ember. *[Hide it. Don't wear it. Pass it on.]* A pause. *[That's not taking, Lex. That's carrying. Wenna carried it three hundred miles in a box. Every Harrow woman carried it from cottage to cottage under a flagstone.]*

That's different.

[Is it?]

They never wore it.

[And you're not going to,] said Ember. *[Are you?]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," said Antho.

He'd come up beside him. At the chair. Lex hadn't heard him move.

His brother was looking at the crown.

"*It's a door*," said Antho.

Lex looked at him.

"*I can feel it*," said Antho. Very quietly. Not looking away from the crown. "*It's a door. Shut. That's what it feels like. That's what it is.*" His voice was very strange. "*Every door I've ever felt wanted to be open. Or was waiting to be. Or had been shut by someone else, from outside. Bricked up. Kept.*" He swallowed. "*This one's shut on purpose. From inside. By the one who could have opened it.*"

"*Hesper*."

"*Hesper*," said Antho. "*She stood at the edge of the pool with it in her hands. And she could have put it on. And drunk. Like the rest of them.*" He looked at the grey silver. "*And she put it down instead. And shut the door. On purpose. On herself.*"

He was quiet for a long moment.

"*It's the first door I've ever felt*," said Antho Vey, "*that wants to stay shut.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT OUT HIS hand.

Antho. Not Lex. His left. With the thin healing red line across the palm, where he'd cut it at the edge of the world.

Lex watched him.

He didn't stop him. He didn't say anything. He watched his brother's hand come down. Slowly. Over the crown. A Threshold Warden's hand. A hand that had stood in every kind of door.

"*We're not taking it*," said Antho. Quietly. To the crown. "*We're carrying it. Home. Where it's needed.*" His hand was an inch above the grey silver. "*Nobody's going to wear you. Nobody's going to put you on. I promise.*" A pause. "*You can stay shut. All the way.*"

He touched it.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOTHING HAPPENED.

That was the strangest thing. Lex had been braced for it. A flash. A cold. A *no*, slamming into his brother's hand like a door slamming on fingers.

Nothing.

Antho's fingers closed round the grey silver band. Gently. Carefully. The way you'd pick up a bird's egg.

And lifted.

◆ ◆ ◆

The *no* went into it.

Lex felt it go. The whole room. The whole tower. The cold steady refusal that had been pouring out of the crown for thirty-two years, filling the room, filling the stair, filling the clearing and the thorns and spreading out across the grey-gold plain like a hand laid on a forehead—

It drew in.

All of it. Back. Into the crown. Into the grey silver. Into the seven blunt points. The way a breath draws in. The way a snail draws into its shell.

And the room was just a room.

Small. Round. Grey. Dead. With a bed and a shelf and a window and an empty chair.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND OUTSIDE, FAR OFF, across the plain, Lex heard something.

Faint. So faint. At the very edge of hearing. Coming in through the small round window from the east. From the white road. From the palaces.

From the hall.

A sound like silk tearing.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WAS HOLDING THE crown in both hands.

He was looking down at it. His face very still. His black hair falling over his forehead. The grey silver dull and quiet in his scarred fingers.

"*It's cold*," he said.

"*Is it saying anything*?"

"*No*." Antho turned it. Slowly. In his hands. "*Not out loud. Not anymore.*" He looked up at Lex. "*It's not saying no to anything now. It's not saying anything.*" A pause. "*It's just holding it. All of it. Inside. Waiting.*"

"*For what*?"

"*For someone who needs it*," said Antho Vey. "*For someone to put it where it's needed.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[The Knot,] said Ember. *[Lex. The Key. Only a hand that has refused a crown.]*

I know.

[Elric,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[It's for Elric. To wear. When he turns it. So the net offers him the crown and the crown says no.]*

Lex looked at the plain grey silver circle in his brother's hands.

So Elric can go first, he thought. *Into whatever's on the other side.*

Wearing the one crown in the world that never wanted to be worn.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED THE BASKET.

On his back. He swung it round and set it on the floor of the tenth tower and lifted the lid. Nine Hush-cups. Each with an iron lid that sighed. Heavy with nothing.

There was room in the middle. Between them. In the straw.

Antho put the crown in.

Gently. Carefully. In the straw. Between the cups. Like a bird's egg in a nest.

And Lex put the lid back on the basket. And swung it onto his back again.

It wasn't heavier. A crown that size should have weighed something. Silver. A pound, maybe.

It weighed nothing. Like the cups. Heavy with nothing.

He'd carry it home.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED ROUND THE room one more time.

At the bed with its coverlet of dead rose leaves. At the shelf. At the bowl of dust that had been roses. At the worn grey bear with its head on one side. At the scratches. *HES. I'M SORRY. R.*

At the empty chair. Facing the window. Facing west.

"*Should we leave something*?" he said.

Antho looked at him.

"*She grew all this*," said Lex. "*Rhosyn. For a girl who never came.*" He looked at the chair. "*And now we're taking the only thing that ever came. And leaving it empty again.*"

His brother didn't say anything for a long moment.

Then he reached into his coat.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A STONE.

Flat. Grey. River-smooth. Exactly the right size to fit between your finger and your thumb.

Lex stared at it.

"*Mam gave it to me*," said Antho. Quietly. "*Before we left. At the door. She said, Father's got the first one. From the Ferryman's shore. This is the second.*" He turned it in his fingers. "*She picked it up on the shingle. When the Ferryman told her about Wenna.*" A pause. "*From the place where Hesper sat.*"

"*Where Hesper—*"

"*The Ferryman pointed*," said Antho. "*To Wenna. Thirty-two years ago. There, he said. She sat there. With the crown in her lap like a bowl.*" He looked at the stone. "*Mam went and stood in the same place. And picked up a stone.*"

He put it on the chair.

In the middle. On the seat. Where the crown had been.

Flat. Grey. Plain.

"*From her shore*," said Antho Vey. To the empty room. To the chair. To nobody. "*From where she sat. When she decided.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN.

Six turns of the spiral. The grey wood steps worn smooth. The light coming dim through the cracks in the bark.

It was different, going down.

The *no* was gone. The stair was just a stair. The tower was just a tower. Dead. Grey. A white tree coaxed up and round on itself in a dead country. Nothing coming down it anymore. Nothing saying hush.

Lex felt the difference like a draught.

Like a door left open in a house where all the doors had been shut.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME OUT INTO the clearing.

And the roses were dying.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL OF THEM. ALL round. A thousand red flowers on the black thorns, open, velvet, dark as wine.

Curling. At the edges. Going brown. Going black. The petals dropping. One by one. Onto the grey dust. Like the roses on the shingle, nine hundred years ago, falling one by one onto the grey stones while the Ferryman waited.

And Rhosyn was on her knees.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT THE EDGE OF the clearing. Where she'd been standing. Where she'd said *this is as far as I can go*. On her knees in the dust. With her thin arms round herself. With her crown of thorns crooked. With petals falling round her like red snow.

Pim was beside her.

Sitting in the dust. With his eyes shut and his face white and his hands open on his knees. Trying. Lex could feel him trying. A little room. A breath of quiet. Round the woman on her knees.

Not enough.

Hask was standing over them both. Enormous. With his pick in his good hand. Looking east.

"*Smith*," he said. Not turning round. "*Something's coming.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN LOOKED UP.

Her face. Grey-green. Wet. Her green eyes very wide. Looking past Lex. Past Antho. At the tower behind them.

"*It's gone*," she whispered. "*Isn't it. You've got it. I felt it go.*"

"*Yes*," said Antho.

"*The no*." She was shaking. "*It's gone. It's not saying it anymore. For the first time in thirty-two years.*" Her hands were pressed against her chest. "*I can hear him again. Oz. Like the sun. Like a fire on the other side of a wall.*" She swallowed. "*And I can hear them.*"

"*Who*?"

The Thorn-Crowned looked east.

"*The hall*," she said. "*The silk. They're waking. All of them. Everyone who was sleeping because of it.*" Her voice was barely there. "*Orrin. And the household. Everyone who was still asleep.*"

"*The household's kept*," said Lex. "*They're gold. They can't—*"

"*They can walk*," said Rhosyn. "*If someone tells them. If someone has his voice.*" She looked up at him. "*Orrin has his voice. Orrin's had it for nine hundred years. He's the steward.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HEARD IT THEN.

Through the thorns. From the east. From across the plain.

Not footsteps. Not a march. Something slower. Something heavier.

Scrape.

Like a stone dragged a finger's width across another stone.

Scrape.

And another. And another. Not an hour apart. Not like Ilda on the white road, one step every hour.

Faster. Many. Hundreds. Thousands.

Scrape. Scrape. Scrape.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hask*," said Lex. "*Can you see*?"

The big man was looking up. At the top of the thorns. At the black wall rising round the clearing, taller than the hall doors, covered in dying roses.

"*No*," he said. "*Too high.*" He looked down at Lex. "*But I can hear them, smith. I can feel them. Through the ground.*" His face was grey. "*It's like the pit. When the roof's settling. When a whole seam's moving at once.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The roses*," said Antho.

They all looked at him.

He was standing in the middle of the clearing with his face turned up. To the thorns. To the dying flowers. A thousand of them. Going black.

"*They saw the roses*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*From the hall. From the white road. From anywhere on the plain.*" His voice was very strange. "*A mile-wide ring of black thorns in the middle of a grey-gold country. And a thousand red roses opening on it all at once.*"

Rhosyn made a sound.

"*You didn't tell him*," said Antho. To her. Looking at her on her knees in the dust. "*Did you. You didn't say a word. Nobody asked you anything.*"

"*No*," whispered the Thorn-Crowned.

"*You just cried*," said Antho Vey. "*When I told you what the hum was saying. You sat down in the dust and cried.*" He looked up at the roses. "*And a thousand roses came out. Red. On the black. You could have seen them from the Veil.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN PUT HER FACE in her hands.

"*I didn't mean—*" she said. Through her fingers. "*I didn't—I couldn't stop them—every time I think of her a rose comes, I told Seren, I can't make them stop—*"

"*I know*," said Antho.

"*Ysy said I'd betray you*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*She said I'd tell him. She said I always tell him.*" Her shoulders were shaking. "*I didn't tell him. I didn't say anything. I just—*"

"*You just grieved*," said Antho. "*Out loud. In red. Where everyone could see.*"

He knelt down beside her. In the dust. Beside Pim.

"*That's not betrayal*," he said. "*That's just being sorry where people can see it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

Scrape. Scrape. Scrape.

Closer. All round. Lex could feel it now too. Through his boots. Through the dust. Through the grey dead roots of the tower behind him. The whole ground trembling, very faintly, the way a table trembles when someone heavy walks across the floor.

From every side.

Not just the east. North. South. West. All round the ring of thorns. Closing.

And over it, through the thorns, faint and dry and soft as sand poured slowly out of a sack—

A voice.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Majesty*," said Orrin.

It came through the thorns. Through the dying roses. From outside. From everywhere at once.

"*Majesty Rhosyn*," whispered the steward. "*Forgive me. Forgive me for disturbing you.*" A pause. Like dust settling. "*His Majesty sends his love.*"

Rhosyn didn't move.

"*He felt the crown go*," said Orrin. "*Even from there. Even in their world. He felt it lift off the chair.*" The dry soft voice was very gentle. "*He asks me to ask you. Very kindly.*"

Silence.

"*Where are his cousins*?" said Orrin. "*And what have they taken from your tower?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THORN-CROWNED KNELT IN the dust with her hands over her face.

She didn't answer.

Lex watched her not answer. Watched her thin shoulders shake. Watched her hands press harder over her mouth. Watched the last of the roses fall round her, black, dead, onto the grey dust.

She didn't answer.

Wait, Antho had said. *Before you answer. As long as you can.*

How long?

Long enough.

I'll try.

She was trying.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Majesty*," whispered Orrin. Patiently. Kindly. Through the thorns. "*He's waiting*."

Scrape. Scrape. Scrape.

All round. Closing. The ground trembling.

Rhosyn took her hands away from her face.

She looked up. At Lex. At Antho kneeling beside her. At Pim, white and empty, trying. At Hask, standing over them all with his pick.

At the basket on Lex's back.

Her green eyes were very wet.

"*Run*," said the Thorn-Crowned.

CHAPTER 27

The Iron Road

THE THORNS OPENED NORTH.

Lex saw it happen. Behind Rhosyn. Behind the tower. The black wall at the far side of the clearing, covered in dead roses, *parting*. Stems unhooking from stems. Creaking. Groaning. Drawing back like a curtain.

A path. Narrow. Dark. Going away north through the thorns.

"*Go*," said Rhosyn.

She was still on her knees. In the dust. With her hands flat on the ground now. Thin. Grey-green. The fingers spread like roots.

"*Rhosyn—*"

"*Go*." Her voice was like a stem snapping. "*North. Away from them. They're coming from the road. From the east. From the hall.*" She didn't look up. "*I'll close it behind you. I'll hold them. As long as I can.*"

"*Come with us*," said Antho.

The Thorn-Crowned laughed.

It was a terrible sound. Small. Cracked. Dry as a dead leaf.

"*Where*?" she said. "*Through the door? Into your world? With Oz in it?*" She shook her head. "*I'd come apart against the edge. Like the cousins. Or he'd find me. He always finds me.*" She looked up at last. Her green eyes very wet. "*And I always go when he calls.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

Scrape. Scrape. Scrape.

Louder now. Closer. All round. From outside the ring of thorns. From the east and the south and the west. The ground shivering.

And a new sound under it.

Crack.

Like a branch breaking. Like a dry stem snapping under a boot.

Crack. Crack. Crack.

"*They're coming through*," said Hask. Very quietly.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED EAST.

At the wall of thorns on the far side of the clearing. Black. Hooked. Tangled. Taller than a house. Covered in dead roses.

It was moving.

Not parting. *Shuddering*. The stems shaking. Bending inward. As if something were leaning on the other side of them. Something heavy. Something that didn't care about thorns.

And through the gaps, low down, between the black stems—

Gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

A HAND. GOLD. PUSHING through the thorns. Slowly. A finger's width at a time. The thorns scraping across it, hooking into it, catching on it.

Not tearing it. Nothing tore the gold.

The thorns broke instead.

Crack. A stem as thick as a wrist, snapping against the back of a gold hand like a dry twig.

And behind the hand, an arm. A gold sleeve. A gold shoulder. A face.

A gardener. With a gold trowel in his other hand. Pushing through the thorns with his eyes moving, slowly, slowly, toward the clearing. Toward the woman on her knees in the dust.

Toward her.

◆ ◆ ◆

RHOSYN SAW HIM.

Lex saw her see him. Saw her thin grey-green face go white.

"*Tam*," she whispered.

The gold gardener came on through the thorns. A finger's width. A finger's width. The black stems breaking against him.

His eyes were on her.

"*Tam*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*Oh, Tam. I'm sorry. I'm sorry.*"

And she pushed her hands into the dust.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THORNS CAME UP.

Not slowly. Not like the path opening. Fast. *Hard*. Out of the ground in front of the gold gardener. Black. Thick as a man's arm. Hooked with thorns as long as a hand. Rising. Twisting round him. Round his arms. His legs. His chest. Wrapping. Binding. Pulling him back.

Not hurting him. Nothing hurt the gold.

Holding him.

The gardener stopped.

Caught. Wrapped in black thorns from his gold boots to his gold throat. Still pushing. A finger's width. A finger's width. Against the thorns.

The thorns held.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND BEHIND HIM, MORE.

Lex saw them. Through the gaps in the eastern wall. Gold. Dozens. Hundreds. Pressing through the thorns. Gardeners and grooms and cooks and maids. Gold hands. Gold faces. Gold eyes, moving.

All of them coming toward the woman on her knees.

Rhosyn pushed her hands deeper into the dust.

The thorns came up. Round every one. Black. Binding. Holding.

Her face was grey.

Not grey-green. *Grey*. Like ash. Like the inside of a dead tree. Every thorn that came up out of the ground came out of *her*. Lex could see it. Could see her thinning. Could see her sinking further into herself, the way a fire sinks when you keep raking the coals out of it.

"*GO*," screamed the Thorn-Crowned.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT.

Lex didn't want to. He wanted to stay. He wanted to stand in the clearing beside her with his fire and his hammer and Aurelian's little bell round his neck and hold the thorns with her.

He couldn't hold the thorns. Nobody could. Only her.

And there were nine cups in the basket on his back. And a crown in the straw between them. And a world on the other side of the Veil with a King walking through it.

He went.

◆ ◆ ◆

NORTH. INTO THE PATH. Into the dark of the thorns. Antho behind him. Hask behind Antho, with Pim in his arms again, the boy limp and white against his chest.

The thorns closed behind them.

Lex heard it. The long dry creak. The groan. The path sealing shut a yard behind Hask's heels.

And through it, behind it, faint, from the clearing—

Crack. Crack. Crack.

And over that, dry and soft as sand—

"*Majesty*," said Orrin. "*Majesty, please. Don't. You'll wear yourself out.*"

And Rhosyn's voice. Very small. Very far.

"*...I'm trying...*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PATH WOUND.

North. Through the thorns. Lex couldn't see more than a few yards ahead. Black stems on every side. Dead roses. Thin grey threads of light coming down through the tangle overhead.

He ran.

The basket bumped on his back. Nine cups. A crown. Heavy with nothing.

Behind him, Antho was running. Breathing hard. Further than halfway. Not much further.

Behind Antho, Hask. Heavy. Steady. Breathing all the way down.

Pim didn't make a sound.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THORNS ENDED.

All at once. One moment black stems. The next, nothing. Grey-gold dust. Flat. Empty. Going away north to the edge of everything.

Lex came out of the thorns at a run and stopped.

And looked back.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RING OF THORNS stood behind him. A mile across. Black. Covered in dead roses. And in the middle, rising above it, small and grey and thin—

The tower.

And round the ring, outside it, on every side but this one—

Gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

THOUSANDS.

He couldn't count them. He didn't try. A ring of gold round the ring of thorns. Three deep. Ten deep. More. The household. The kept. Cooks and grooms and maids and gardeners and soldiers in gold armour and children with gold hoops. Pressed against the black wall of thorns on every side. Pushing.

A finger's width. A finger's width.

Scrape. Crack. Scrape.

The thorns breaking against them. And new thorns rising. And breaking. And rising.

And above them all, standing on nothing, a thin bent shape of grey-gold dust with two dim sparks for eyes. Looking down into the ring. Into the clearing. At the woman on her knees.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND SOMETHING ELSE.

Lex saw it. To the south. On the near side of the ring. Where the gold was thickest.

A gleam.

Clear. Cold. Glittering. Like ice. Like frost on a window.

Walking. Through the kept. Between them. They parted for it, the way the thorns parted for Rhosyn. A tall shape. Thin. Long-necked. White-haired. In a long white gown that poured off her like water and not like water.

Glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ysenne*," said Antho.

He was standing beside Lex. At the edge of the thorns. Breathing hard. Looking south.

"*She said she didn't care*," said Lex. "*In the stone room. She said Oz could have his crown in the road.*"

"*She said she's never once told him no*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WATCHED HER WALK into the thorns.

They opened for her. Lex saw it. The black wall at the south of the ring, parting. A path. Not because Rhosyn opened it. Because Rhosyn couldn't hold it anymore. Because Rhosyn was on her knees in the clearing with every thorn she had wrapped round a thousand gold servants, and there was nothing left for the south wall but to sag and part.

The Glass Queen walked in.

And the gold followed her. The kept. Pressing through the gap behind her. A finger's width. A finger's width.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX COULDN'T SEE THE clearing. The thorns were too high.

He didn't need to.

He heard it.

Very faint. Very far. Coming through a mile of thorns on the dead still air of the Court.

A voice. Small. Like a wet finger round the rim of a glass.

"*Rosie*," said Ysenne.

Silence.

"*Rosie, stop. Please. You're so thin. You've given it all away.*" A pause. "*Look at you. You've got nothing left.*"

And then, very small, very far, like a stem bending—

"*...Ysy...*"

"*I'm sorry*," said the Glass Queen. "*He asked. You know he asked. Orrin carried it all the way from the world. He felt the crown go, Rosie. He felt it from the other side of the edge.*" Her voice was shaking. Lex had never heard it shake. "*He said bring her home.*"

"*...I always go...*" whispered Rhosyn. "*...when he calls...*"

"*I know*," said Ysenne. "*So do I.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN A SOUND Lex would hear for a long time.

Not a scream. Not a crack. Not a scrape.

A *chime*.

Small. Clear. High. Like glass touching glass. Like a link of a chain made of ice closing round a thin grey-green wrist.

And another.

Chime.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THORNS STOPPED MOVING.

All of them. All at once. The whole mile-wide ring. The stems that had been rising out of the ground to bind the kept. The stems that had been shuddering against the gold. The black wall round the clearing.

Still.

And then, slowly, from the inside out, they began to sag.

Like a hedge in winter. Like a vine when the root's been cut. The black stems going slack. Drooping. Falling in on themselves with a long low dry sigh that went on and on and on.

And the gold came through.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She's got her*," said Hask.

Nobody answered.

"*Her sister*," said Hask. Very quietly. "*Her own sister. In chains.*"

"*She said she'd never told him no*," said Antho. "*Not once. In nine hundred years.*"

"*She told Rhosyn she was sorry*."

"*Yes*," said Antho Vey. "*They're all sorry. Every one of them. Every Crowned. Sorry for nine hundred years.*" He looked at the sagging thorns. At the gold pouring through. "*And they all still go when he calls.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TURNED AWAY.

He made himself. He turned his back on the ring of dying thorns and the gold pouring through it and the chime of glass chains, faint, from the clearing he couldn't see.

And looked north.

At the dust. Flat. Grey-gold. Going away to the edge of everything.

And at the line.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILVER.

Thin. Bright. Rising out of the plain a mile off. At a slant. Up. Into the dim grey-gold of the sky. Up and up and up, until it was too thin to see.

With rings on it. Black. Strung like beads. Going up.

The last thread.

"*That's where it starts*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT TO IT.

He didn't decide to. His feet did. He walked north across the grey-gold dust with the basket on his back and his brother beside him and Hask behind with Pim, and the silver line got closer, and thicker, and brighter.

And then they were there.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME OUT OF the ground.

Not out of a hole. Not out of a stone. Out of the dust itself. As if the dust were only a skin over something, and the thread had been sewn through it from underneath.

Silver. Bright. Not thin now. Not up close. As thick as Lex's arm at the base. Thicker. Humming. One note. High. Clear. Like a harp-string. Like a wet finger round a glass. The note from the Old Gallery. The note from the bottom of the world.

It rose out of the dust at a slant. North-east. Up. Into the sky. Taut. So taut Lex could feel it in his teeth.

And round it, a yard from the ground, a ring.

Black. Iron. Ten feet across. Smooth. Perfect. No rust. No mark.

The first ring.

And above it, ten yards up, another. And above that, another. And another. Going up. Smaller and smaller. Into the sky. Into the dim. Into nothing.

Caddoc's road.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He started here*," said Lex.

He put his hand out. Not touching the iron. Near it. A foot away.

Cold. Like the iron at Coldwater. Cold all the way through.

"*He stood here*," said Lex. "*When he woke. When his brother said, the Key. He came out here and stood at the foot of the last thread and put a ring on it and started to climb.*"

"*And he's still climbing*," said Antho.

"*He's under the world*," said Lex. "*Under Coldwater, by now. Past it. Under the Drowned Country.*" He looked up. At the line. At the rings going up into nothing. "*He's months ahead of us. Weeks. However long it's been out there.*"

"*Can we cut it*?" said Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT THE silver thread.

At the iron ring round it.

At the hammer on his belt. Small. Old. Plain. The hammer that had woven the world.

"*Find it*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK PUT PIM DOWN.

Gently. On the dust. One finger at a time. The boy didn't wake.

Then he took his pick off his back. The pick that had broken Delve cores, and a Moth Queen's wing, and the floor of the Old Gallery under Coldwater. He put the point of it against the black iron of the first ring.

And listened.

It took longer than at Coldwater. Much longer. Lex stood beside him with his hand on the bell and watched. Hask moved the point of the pick. A finger's width. Listened. Moved it again. Round the ring. Up. Down. Round.

"*It's better*," said Hask at last. Very quietly. "*Than the one under Coldwater. Tighter. Thicker.*" He moved the pick. "*He wasn't tired, here. This was the first. He was fresh.*"

"*Is there one*?"

Hask didn't answer.

He moved the pick. Listened. Moved it.

And stopped.

"*There*," he said. "*Small. Smaller than a fingernail. Right at the bottom. Where the ring touches the dust.*" He looked up at Lex. "*He bent down. To close it. Right at the start. His back would have been stiff. From the silk.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TOOK AURELIAN'S HAMMER off his belt.

He knelt in the dust. At the foot of the last thread. Where the first ring touched the ground. Where a man nine hundred years old had bent down, stiff-backed from a cocoon, to close a circle of iron round a silver line.

He lifted the hammer.

Tink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RING BROKE.

The way the one at Coldwater had. A bright line, running round the black iron from the point where the hammer touched. Round. All the way round. And the whole ring rang, a great deep groaning boom, and fell apart into black shards and slid off the thread and lay in the dust.

And the thread sang.

The note went up. A half-step. The way it had in the Old Gallery.

And nothing happened.

◆ ◆ ◆

NO GRUNT. NO VOICE. No *huh*. No new ring growing back.

Nothing.

The silver thread hummed. A half-step higher. Above it, ten yards up, the second ring sat round it. Black. Smooth. Perfect. Holding.

And above that, the third. And the fourth. Going up into the sky.

Lex knelt in the dust with the hammer in his hand and looked up at them.

"*He didn't notice*," said Antho. Very quietly.

"*No*."

"*He's too far up*," said Antho. "*Too far along. He's not standing on this one anymore. He's not standing on any of these.*" He looked up at the rings. "*He's past them all. He's under the world.*"

"*It doesn't matter*," said Lex.

"*What doesn't*?"

"*Where you cut a man's road*," said Lex Vey. He stood up. Slowly. "*If he's already past it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT THE thread.

Silver. Bright. Humming. Rising out of the dust and going up into the sky, toward the edge of the world, toward the Veil, toward the bottom of everything where an old friend of his father's was wound round a Key in the dark.

He could feel it. The way he'd felt it at Coldwater. The way he'd felt it at the Knot. One note. Going on and on.

It's not a wall, Elric had said. *It's a thread. The last one.*

He put his hand on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

Not near it. *On* it.

He didn't know why. He hadn't meant to. His hand went out the way it went out to the fire every morning, and closed round the silver thread at the foot of the first broken ring.

It was cold.

Not like iron. Not like the gold. Cold the way a harp-string is cold, the way a wire is cold, thin and taut and singing.

And it was *alive*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT.

All of it. All at once. Not with the Root; he'd given that up. Not with his eyes. With his *hand*. The way a smith feels a blade he's forging. The way you feel the grain in a piece of iron when you've worked it for twenty years.

The last thread.

Running up from his hand. Out of the Court. Through the Veil. The weave of it. The thickness. The grey corridor they'd walked through, which was only the inside of this, only the thread seen from the middle. On. Under the Sundered Lands. Deep. Under the Greyspine. Under Coldwater, where a black ring stood in a forest of black spikes at the bottom of the Old Gallery.

On. Under the Drowned Country. Down.

To a black glass disc a mile across. To a Key. To a grey thread wound round it, frayed and worn and tight.

And somewhere between—

◆ ◆ ◆

Clink.

He felt it. Through his hand. Up his arm. Into his chest. A ring closing. Far away. So far. Under the world. On the thread. Between Coldwater and the Knot.

Closer to the Knot.

Much closer.

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND A VOICE.

Low. Flat. Heavy. Rough as gravel. Coming down the thread. Into his hand.

"*Smith*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T LET GO.

"*You're at the bottom*," said the voice. Not surprised. Interested. The way a mason sounds when he finds a man looking at the foundations of a wall he built. "*At the start. Where I began. I can feel you.*" A pause. "*You broke my first ring.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Huh*," said Caddoc. "*That was a good one. I was fresh. I took a long time over it.*"

"*It had a flaw*."

"*They all have flaws*," said Caddoc. "*I bent down. My back was stiff.*" Another pause. "*It doesn't matter. I'm not on it.*"

"*I know*."

"*I'm close now*," said the voice. Very even. Very calm. "*I can feel the knot. I can feel the man in it. He's very tired.*" A pause. "*I can feel the bar. The ward. The Key under it.*"

Lex's hand tightened on the thread.

"*How close*?"

"*Close*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown. "*Your lanterns. The night you light them for the lost.*" A pause. "*Not long.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT COLD.

Not long.

He'd been counting Pims. Nine cups. Thirteen days. He'd been counting from midsummer. From the edge of the world. From a door his brother opened with his own blood. *Lantern Night*, he'd thought. *Months. The end of autumn. We've got time. We've got the whole summer.*

"*How long have I been here*?" he said.

The thread was quiet.

"*Here*?" said Caddoc. "*In the Court?*"

"*Yes*."

A long pause.

"*There's no time in the Court*," said the voice. Slowly. As if explaining something obvious to a child. "*You know that. Everyone knows that. That's why we slept so long.*" Another pause. "*A day in the Court is a long time outside. Ten days. More. I don't know. I've never counted.*"

Lex's hand was white on the silver thread.

"*Ten days*," he said.

"*Near enough*."

"*For every day here—*"

"*Ten days there*," said Caddoc. "*Yes.*" A pause. "*You didn't know.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LET GO OF the thread.

He didn't mean to. His hand opened. On its own. And fell away. And he was standing in the dust at the foot of the last thread with his hand hanging at his side and the cold of the silver still in his palm.

Ten days.

For every day.

He'd been in the Court for—he didn't know. He didn't count. Eleven Pims. Twelve. Thirteen. He'd lost count somewhere after the glass palace.

A hundred and thirty days.

A hundred and forty.

Your lanterns. The night you light them for the lost. Not long.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," said Antho.

He didn't answer.

"*Lex. What did he say?*"

Lex turned round.

His brother was standing in the dust a yard off. Looking at him. With his face grey and his eyes dark and his hand, his left, with the thin red line across the palm, hanging at his side.

"*It's been months*," said Lex.

Antho went very still.

"*Out there*," said Lex. "*Not days. Not weeks. Months.*" His voice was very strange. He couldn't make it sound like his own. "*A day here is ten there. He said. Caddoc. He said it like it was nothing. Like everyone knew.*"

"*Months.*"

"*It's autumn*," said Lex. "*Out there. Now. The end of it.*" He looked east. Toward the white road. Toward the Veil. Toward a door at the edge of the world they'd walked through three days after midsummer. "*It's nearly Lantern Night.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

Hask was standing over Pim. Enormous. Still. His pick in his hand. His face like a slab of coal.

Antho was standing in the dust. Not moving. Not breathing, almost.

"*Father*," said Antho.

Lex closed his eyes.

"*He said before the year turns*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*The Ferryman. Before Lantern Night. And it's—*"

"*I know.*"

"*And the King*," said Antho. "*He's been walking. For months. Five miles a day. Less.*" His voice was going. Breaking up. Like ice on a pond. "*He's been walking for months, Lex. Toward Harrow. Toward—*"

"*I know*," said Lex Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember.

Very small. Very far. Like a voice at the bottom of a well.

[Lex, I can feel him.]

Who?

[Your father.] A pause. *[I've been able to feel him the whole time. Even here. A thread. Thin. Going out of me. Back through the edge. Back to him.]* Another pause. *[It's been going thinner. Every Pim. I thought—I thought it was this place. The pressure. The no room.]*

Lex didn't move.

[It's not this place,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[It's him. It's been months, Lex. Out there. And he's been going.]*

How thin?

Ember didn't answer.

Ember. How thin?

[Very,] said Ember.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STARTED WALKING.

East. Not north. Not back toward the thorns. East. Toward the white road. Toward the Veil. Toward the door.

He didn't look to see if they were following.

"*Lex*," said Antho. Behind him. "*The kept. They're between us and the road. Thousands of them. Orrin. Ysenne.*"

"*I know.*"

"*We can't go straight back. We'll walk right into them.*"

"*Then we'll go round*," said Lex.

"*Round—*"

"*North*," said Lex. "*Then east. Then south to the road. Near the door. Where the kept are thinnest.*" He didn't stop walking. "*Wren taught me. On the moors. You don't go through the herd. You go round it and come at the gate from the side.*"

"*That's days.*"

"*It's days here*," said Lex. "*It's weeks there.*" His voice didn't shake. He didn't let it. "*Every Pim we spend in here is ten days out there. Every hour is most of a day.*" He looked back at his brother. "*So we don't stop. We don't sleep. We drink the cups. All of them. We walk till we get there.*"

"*And Pim*?"

Lex looked at the boy. Lying in the dust. White. Limp. Breathing very slow.

"*Hask carries him*," said Lex.

Silas Hask bent down without a word.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED.

North first. Away from the white road. Away from the ring of thorns, sagging, dying, with gold pouring through it and a Glass Queen in the middle putting chains on her sister. Away from the silver line going up into the sky.

Then east.

The plain didn't change. Grey-gold. Flat. Endless. The light didn't change. The dust didn't move.

Lex didn't stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DRANK A CUP when his chest went tight.

Lifted the iron lid—it sighed—and tipped the empty cup to his mouth and felt the room go in. Warm. Round. Mal.

He passed it to Antho. Antho drank. Passed it back.

Eight.

He didn't do the sums. He didn't need to. He knew what eight meant. Eight cups, two people, no Pim holding the nights. Twelve days.

A hundred and twenty days, out there.

Too many. Far too many. They didn't have a hundred and twenty days. Not out there. Not on the other side of the door, where it was the end of autumn and the leaves were coming down and an old man was lying in a bed under a boarded window, breathing.

In. Catch. Out.

Going thin.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE THOUGHT ABOUT WREN.

He didn't mean to. He walked east across the grey-gold dust with the basket on his back and a crown in the straw and his hand on the bell, and he thought about Wren.

Months.

She'd have been fogging windows for months. Every night. Breathing on the glass. Holding the wind.

And the King walking toward her.

And Lark—

She'll be nearly a year old, he thought.

He stopped walking.

◆ ◆ ◆

JUST FOR A MOMENT. In the dust. In the middle of the grey-gold plain.

She'll be nearly a year old.

She was five months old when I left. She had one tooth. She'd just rolled over.

She'll be sitting up. She'll be crawling. She might be standing. Holding on to things. Pulling herself up on the edge of the table with her square hands.

She might have said a word.

And I wasn't there.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember.

He started walking again.

[Lex, I'm sorry.]

It's not your fault.

[I know.] A pause. *[I'm sorry anyway. I'm sorry I didn't know. I should have known. I'm a historian. I should have read it somewhere.]*

Nobody knew.

[Seraphine would have,] said Ember. *[If she'd had time. She'd have worked it out. From the frost. From Orrin. From everything.]* A pause. *[I think she probably has. Out there. Months ago.]*

Then she'll have told them.

[Yes,] said Ember. *[They'll know. They've known for months.]* Very quietly. *[They'll know we're not coming back till Lantern Night.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAW THE ROAD on the fourth Pim.

Lex didn't call it a Pim anymore. There was no Pim. Pim was asleep against Hask's chest and hadn't woken since the thorns. They walked without stopping. They drank a cup when their chests went tight. They didn't sleep.

Seven cups.

Six.

But Lex counted. In his head. Without wanting to. *Four. That's four of their days. Forty out there.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WHITE ROAD RAN across the plain ahead of them. East to west. Straight as a ruler.

And on it, on both sides, the kept.

Not as many as before. Not here. Not this close to the Veil. A thin line of them, on either side of the white stone. Standing. Still.

Facing west.

All of them. Turned. Toward the palaces. Toward the hall. Toward the ring of dead thorns far off on the horizon, where the rest of the household had gone, scraping, at Orrin's word.

These hadn't gone.

These were too far. Or too slow. Or too old. Standing at the side of the road with their gold faces turned west and their gold eyes moving.

And humming.

...home...

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There*," said Antho.

He was pointing. East. Down the road. Toward the Veil. Toward a smudge on the horizon, grey, the edge of the world.

And on the road, a little way short of it, in the middle of the white stone—

A small gold shape.

Walking.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM WOKE UP.

Lex didn't know how. He hadn't stirred in four of their days. He'd lain against Hask's chest white and limp and empty, breathing so slow that twice Lex had stopped Hask to put his hand on the boy's chest and feel it rise.

He woke now.

All at once. His head lifting. His eyes opening. Grey-violet. Looking past Hask's shoulder. Down the road.

At the small gold shape on the white stone.

"*Ilda*," said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS FURTHER THAN she'd been.

That was the first thing Lex saw, as they came down onto the road and walked toward her. She was further *west* than she'd been. Further from the door. Further toward the palaces.

Following.

The line of gold scrapes behind her on the white stone went back and back toward the Veil. Toward the place where she'd stood for nine hundred years at the side of the road with a wooden spoon in her hand.

A finger's width every hour.

For weeks. For months. Out there. For however many Pims it had been in here.

Walking after a boy who'd looked back.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM GOT DOWN.

He wriggled out of Hask's arms and stood on the white road. Unsteady. Thin. White. In his blue coat with the brass buttons.

And walked to her.

Lex didn't stop him. Antho didn't. Hask didn't. They stood on the road and watched the boy walk the last few yards to the small gold girl in her grey dress too big for her, with her wooden spoon, mid-step.

He stopped in front of her.

Her eyes were on his face.

Not darting. Not fast. Steady. On him.

"*You're still coming*," said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER MOUTH DIDN'T MOVE. It couldn't. Not now. He'd poured himself into her once, on the road, and it had been enough for one word. He had nothing left to pour.

But her eyes didn't leave his face.

And a tear ran out of one of them.

Out of the corner. Out of the gold. Clear. Wet. Down her gold cheek. Onto the white stone.

Pim looked at it.

"*I have to go*," he said. "*Through the door. Home. There's a King in our world. And an old man who's dying.*" He swallowed. "*I'll come back. I promised. When the pool's big. When there's room.*"

The gold girl's eyes stayed on his face.

"*Don't follow*," said Pim. "*Not through the door. You'd come apart. Like the cousins.*" His voice was very small. "*Stay on the road. Stay where I can find you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT OUT HIS hand.

Not to touch her. He held it out. In the air. A foot from her gold hand. The one without the spoon. Open.

The way he'd drawn it. In pencil. On a page of Seraphine's notebook. A boy holding out his hand.

He held it there for a long time.

Then he took it back. And turned round. And came back up the road to the others.

He didn't look back.

Not once. Not twice.

But Lex did. And saw the gold girl's eyes follow him. All the way. As they walked east down the white road toward the edge of the world.

And behind them, very faint—

Scrape.

Not following.

Staying.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DOOR WAS AHEAD.

Tall. Dark. Wide. In the grey of the Veil. The edge of the world drawn back on either side like curtains. And beyond it, through it, a smudge of other light.

Pale. Thin. Grey.

Not the grey-gold of the Court. Not the grey of the Veil.

Winter grey.

Lex stopped on the white road and looked at it.

At the light coming through the door at the edge of the world. Cold. Thin. White at the edges. The light of a short day at the end of the year.

And at something drifting in through the door on a wind that had never once blown in the Court in nine hundred years.

Small. White. Turning over and over in the dim grey-gold air.

Landing on the white stone at his feet.

And melting.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Snow*," said Antho.

Very quietly. Beside him. Looking at the door.

"*It's snowing*," he said. "*Out there.*"

Lex didn't answer.

He looked at the snow melting on the white stone at his feet. At the door. At the winter light beyond it.

And beyond that—far beyond, two hundred and forty miles east, in a birch wood at the end of a valley, in a cottage with a blue door—

An old man in a bed. Breathing. In. Catch. Out.

Going thin.

He started to run.

CHAPTER 28

The Knock

HE KNOCKED AT NOON.

Seren had been waiting since dawn. Since before dawn. Since the footsteps stopped at the bottom of the hill, in the night, and didn't start again, and she lay beside her husband in the dark with her hand on his chest and listened to the silence where they'd been.

She'd got up at first light.

She'd lit the fire. She'd made the porridge. She'd fed Arion three spoonfuls, which was all he'd take, and wiped his mouth, and propped him on his pillows, and combed his hair, and put his spectacles on the blanket by his hand, folded, face down.

She'd filled the kettle.

She'd put out two cups. The chipped blue one with the crack down the handle. And another. The good one. White. Brannoc had made it at the Forge, in the winter, the first thing he'd ever made that wasn't iron, and it was lopsided and too thick and she loved it.

She'd taken the tin down off the shelf. Hollis Penn's tin. The good kind.

And then she'd sat down on the oak ramp outside the blue door. In her bare feet. In the sun. With her hands in her lap.

And waited.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HEARD HIM COME up through the birch wood.

Not footsteps. Not at first. Heat. A warmth, rolling up the track ahead of him, through the trees, the way the heat from a forge rolls across a yard when someone opens the door. She felt it on her face.

Then the light.

Gold. Through the birches. Not sunlight; it was noon, the sun was overhead, the birch wood was green and dappled and ordinary. *Another* light. Lower. Warmer. Coming up the track between the white trunks like a lantern carried by someone very tall.

And where it passed, the birches went gold.

She watched it. From the ramp. One tree. Then the next. The white bark going gold. The green leaves going gold. The whole tree, trunk and branch and leaf, shining. Still. A gold birch. And then the one beside it.

A gold road. Coming up through the wood. Toward her.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THE FOOTSTEPS.

Thud. *Thud*.

Not hurrying.

Brannoc was in the clearing. She'd told him to go home. She'd told him at dawn, and again at breakfast, and again an hour ago. *Go home. Go to Hedda. Go to the Forge. There's nothing you can do.*

He'd said, *I'm not leaving you*.

He was standing by the stream now. Enormous. Bald. With his arms folded across his chest and his gold fingertips catching the light and his face like a block of grey stone. Between the track and the ramp. Between the light and her.

"*Brannoc*," she said.

"*I know*," he said. Not turning round. "*I'm not going to fight him. I'm not daft. I've heard what happens.*" His jaw worked. "*I'm just going to stand here.*"

"*Somebody has to stand somewhere*," said Seren.

"*Aye*," said Brannoc Holt. "*Something like that.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME OUT OF the birch wood into the clearing.

◆ ◆ ◆

ADA FELL HAD SAID it. Elowen had said it. Wren had said it, white-faced, coming back from a village in the western shires with a baby on her chest.

None of them had said it right.

He was the biggest thing Seren had ever seen.

Taller than the cottage door. Taller than the lintel by a head and more. Broader than Brannoc. Broader than two of Brannoc. A beard of gold to the middle of his chest. Gold hair to his shoulders. Skin like old ivory. A robe of white and gold that swept the grass behind him and turned it gold as it passed.

A crown of gold leaves. Crooked.

He glowed.

Not like a lamp. Like metal in a crucible. A deep heavy warm light coming up out of him, out of his skin and his beard and his hands, lighting the clearing, lighting the gold birch and the gold woodpile and the gold cart. Lighting Brannoc's face. Lighting hers.

And his eyes.

She didn't look at them. She couldn't. Nobody could. She looked at his beard. At his mouth.

Which was smiling.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED AT THE edge of the clearing.

Not because Brannoc was there. He didn't look at Brannoc. Not yet. He stopped the way a man stops at the top of a hill after a long walk and looks at the view.

He looked at the clearing.

At the stream. At the stepping stones. At the two cottages, one on either side of the water. At the gold birch. At the other cottage, across the stream, with its soaped windows and its east window and a small iron lantern on the sill, gold, kept, beside a candle in a holder with no glass.

At the blue door.

At her.

"*Oh*," said Oszric of the Crowned. Very softly. "*Oh, it's a blue door.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T STAND UP.

She'd thought about it. All morning. Whether to stand. Whether to go to the door and put her hand flat on the wood. The way her mother stood. The way every Harrow woman stood, at the end of summer, at the door of every cottage.

She stayed sitting.

On the ramp. In her bare feet. With her hands in her lap.

"*Good afternoon*," said Seren Harrow.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED AT her for a long moment.

Then he laughed.

Not loud. Not the great bell of a laugh she'd heard through the rose. Softer. Surprised. Delighted. The laugh of a man who's been told something he didn't expect and likes very much.

"*Good afternoon*," he said. "*Hesper's girl.*"

"*Seren*," said Seren. "*Seren Vey.*"

"*Seren Vey*," said the Gilded King. Trying it. "*You married. Hes never married. None of her girls did. Did they?*"

"*No.*"

"*But you did.*"

"*I did*," said Seren. "*Twice. To the same man. I don't remember the first time.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME ACROSS THE clearing.

Thud. *Thud*. Not hurrying. The grass going gold under his feet in a widening path. Brannoc didn't move. He stood by the stream with his arms folded.

The King walked past him.

Not round him. Past. Close. Close enough that Seren saw the old smith flinch from the heat, saw the sweat start on his bald head. The King didn't touch him. He didn't look at him.

Then he stopped.

And turned his head.

And looked down at Brannoc Holt.

At his bald head. At his soot-stained beard. At his arms, folded. At his hands.

At the gold on the tips of his fingers.

"*Oh*," said Oszric. "*Orrin's. At the village. You put your hands over a child.*"

Brannoc didn't answer.

"*I heard*," said the King. "*He told me. He tells me everything.*" He looked at the gold fingertips. "*They'll never burn now. Did you know? You could put your hands in a forge.*"

"*I know*," said Brannoc. "*I do. Every day.*"

The King looked at him for a long moment.

"*That's beautiful*," he said. Very quietly. "*You've found a use for it.*"

And walked on.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED AT THE foot of the ramp.

Seren didn't move.

She sat on the oak planks in her bare feet and looked up at him. Up. A long way up. At the gold beard. At the crooked crown. At the light coming off him like heat off a forge.

He looked down at her.

"*May I come in*?" said the Gilded King.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SMILED.

"*Hes said that*," he said. "*To everything. When she was small. May I have your doll, Hes? No. May I sit with you, Hes? No. Will you come and see the pool, Hes?*" His voice was very gentle. "*No. Not me. Not ever.*"

"*She was right*."

"*She was right*," agreed the King. "*She was always right. It was the worst thing about her.*" He looked at the blue door behind her. "*Like your husband. Mae said he was always right. She said it was very inconvenient.*"

"*He's asleep*."

"*He's not asleep*," said Oszric of the Crowned. "*He's lying on three pillows under a boarded window with his spectacles face down on the blanket and his eyes open, listening to every word.*" He tilted his great head. "*I can hear his heart. From here. Like a little clock. Slowing.*"

Seren's hands tightened in her lap.

"*He can't come out*," she said.

"*I know*," said the Gilded King. "*That's why I came to him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT DOWN.

On the grass. At the foot of the ramp. Like a mountain settling. With his great gold hands on his knees and his white and gold robe spreading out round him on the grass, turning it gold.

Level with her. Almost. His head was still higher than hers. But he'd sat down to be level.

Seren didn't know what to do with that.

"*Is that tea*?" said the King.

She looked at him.

"*I can smell it*," he said. "*Through the door. On the table. The good kind. In a tin.*" His mouth twitched in his beard. "*You bought it for me. Didn't you. You knew I was coming.*"

"*You said*," said Seren. "*Through the rose. You said you'd come to my door. For tea.*"

"*And you bought tea*."

"*I'm a Harrow*," said Seren. "*We're very practical.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAUGHED AGAIN.

The real one, this time. Deep. Warm. Like a bell. It rolled across the clearing and the birches shook with it and a gold leaf fell off a gold birch and didn't flutter, *dropped*, straight down, like a coin.

"*Oh*," he said. When he'd finished. Wiping his eyes. His great gold hand coming away wet. "*Oh, I'd forgotten. I'd forgotten what it was like. Talking to one of you.*" He looked at her. "*Hes used to make me laugh like that. At dinner. When she was twelve. Before.*"

"*Before she said no*."

"*Before she said no*," said the King. "*To the pool. To me. To all of us.*" He was quiet for a moment. "*She never spoke to me again. Not one word. Not on the shingle. Not ever.*" He looked down at his hands. "*Nine hundred years and I can still hear her laughing at dinner. And I've never heard her say my name since she was sixteen.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

She didn't want to feel sorry for him.

She'd sat on the floor by the hearth listening to Antho tell about a gold woman on a pillow. She'd listened to Ada Fell tell about Roole in the gate. She'd watched Wren come home white-faced from a village where a boy called Pip held a gold grandmother who couldn't hold him back.

She didn't want to.

She did anyway. A little. Sitting on the ramp in the sun. Looking at the biggest man she'd ever seen, sitting in the grass with tears on his face, talking about his little sister at dinner.

She did anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Where's the child*?" said the Gilded King.

Seren didn't answer.

He didn't seem to expect her to. He sat in the grass and looked across the stream. At the other cottage. At the soaped windows. At the gold lantern on the sill.

"*She's gone*," he said. "*Isn't she. I could smell her from the hill. For two days. Like bread. Like something new.*" He breathed in. Long. Deep. Through his nose. "*And then this morning I couldn't.*"

"*She's gone*," said Seren.

"*With her mother*."

"*With her mother.*"

"*The Mistwalker.*" The King's mouth twitched. "*She shot an arrow at me. In the western shires. Off the wind. It was a very good shot.*" He looked at Seren. "*Where did they go?*"

"*I don't know,*" said Seren.

It was true. She'd made sure of it. She'd made Wren promise not to tell her. *Not me. Not anyone. Not even Arion. If I don't know, I can't say. If I can't say, nobody can make me.*

The King looked at her.

She felt it. Even without looking at his eyes. A heat. A weight. Like the sun on the back of your neck in high summer.

"*You don't,*" he said. Slowly. Wonderingly. "*You really don't. You made sure you wouldn't.*"

"*I'm a Harrow,*" said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT HER for a long time.

Then he turned his head. North. Toward the hill behind the clearing. Toward the top of the birch wood. Where a woman with a baby on her chest had stopped, two days ago, at the edge of the trees, and turned round, and held up one gold hand so it shone.

He breathed in.

Long. Slow. Deep.

"*There,*" said the Gilded King. Very softly. "*There it is. Faint. Two days old. Going north. Toward the mountains.*"

Seren went cold.

"*Bread,*" said Oszric. "*And wind. And something new.*" He smiled. "*She can't hide that, your Mistwalker. Not from me. Not with a child like that on her chest. It's like trying to hide a fire in a hayloft.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

Slowly. Like a mountain rising. The grass round him gold in a wide circle where he'd sat. He stood at the foot of the ramp and looked down at her.

"*I'll go and find her,*" he said. "*The child. I'll walk. I'm good at walking. I've walked two hundred and forty miles since midsummer.*"

"*She'll keep moving,*" said Seren.

"*I know.*"

"*She'll never stop. She'll never stay. She'll go from valley to valley and cottage to cottage and you'll never catch her.*" Her voice was shaking. She didn't let it stop her. "*Twenty generations of Harrow women ran from you, Oszric. Twenty generations. And you never found one.*"

"*I never looked*," said the Gilded King.

Seren stopped.

"*I was asleep*," he said. Gently. "*For nine hundred years. In silk. In a hall. On the other side of the edge.*" He tilted his head. "*Your women ran from nothing, Seren Vey. They ran from a dream. They ran from a song.*" He smiled. "*I'm awake now. And I'm very, very good at finding things.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And your husband*," said the King.

He looked past her. At the blue door. At the dim room beyond it. At the bed under the boarded window, and the old man on three pillows with his eyes open.

"*Arion Vey*," said Oszric. Raising his voice. Not much. Just enough. "*Warden-Architect. Mae's clever one.*"

Silence from the cottage.

Then, very faint, a thread of a voice—

"*Good afternoon*."

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING SMILED.

"*Good afternoon*," he said. "*I'm sorry to have come at such a bad time.*"

"*It's always a bad time*," said Arion. From the bed. Through the open door. Faint. Dry. "*At my age. You'll find that.*"

"*I won't*," said the Gilded King. "*That's rather the point.*"

A pause. From the cottage. A breath. In. Catch. Out.

"*No*," said Arion Vey. "*I suppose you won't.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'll come back*," said Oszric. "*For tea. When I've found the child.*" He looked at the blue door. "*I'd like to talk to you. Properly. Sitting down. Mae said you were the cleverest man she'd ever met. I'd like to see for myself.*"

"*I'll be here*," said Arion.

"*Will you*?"

A long pause.

"*I'll try*," said Arion Vey.

The King laughed. Softly. In his beard.

"*Don't die before I get back*," he said. "*I mean it. I'd be very disappointed.*" He looked at Seren. "*And when I come back, if you're very tired, if your breath's catching and not starting again, if your wife's lying beside you in the dark counting—*"

"*No*," said Seren.

"*I'll offer*," said Oszric. Gently. "*That's all. I'll offer. Like I offered everyone. And you can say no.*" He looked at her. "*You'll say no.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Hes would have*," said the Gilded King. "*Hes always did.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED ROUND.

And walked away.

North. Not back down the track. North. Across the clearing. Past the stream. Past the other cottage with its gold lantern on the sill. Up the hill. Into the birch wood. Toward the top, where a woman with a baby had stopped two days ago and turned round.

The birches went gold as he passed.

One by one. Up the hill. A gold road. Going north.

Seren watched until she couldn't see him anymore.

Then she watched the gold. Going up through the trees. Getting smaller. Further. Into the mountains.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC CAME AND STOOD at the foot of the ramp.

He looked at the gold circle in the grass where the King had sat. At the gold path going up the hill. At her.

"*You didn't let him in*," he said.

"*No*."

"*You didn't stand up*."

"*No*."

"*You sat on your step in your bare feet and said good afternoon*," said Brannoc Holt. "*To that.*" His voice was very rough. "*Your mam would have thrown a pan.*"

"*I didn't have one*," said Seren. "*I gave it to Antho. To take to the Knot.*"

Brannoc looked at her for a long moment.

Then he laughed.

It came out of him like a landslide. Sudden. Huge. Shaking. He stood at the foot of the ramp in the sun with his gold fingertips and his bald head and laughed until he had to sit down on the grass.

And Seren, on the ramp, after a moment, laughed too.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TEA WENT COLD on the table.

She didn't throw it out. She left it. Two cups. The blue one and the white one. Full. Going cold. And the tin beside them. Open.

"*He'll be back*," said Arion. That night. From his pillows.

"*I know*."

"*He'll find her*."

"*He won't*," said Seren. "*She's Wren. She's a tracker. She knows how to hide from things that hunt.*" She sat down on the edge of the bed. "*She'll keep moving.*"

"*And when she can't*?"

Seren didn't answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SUMMER WENT.

Long. Hot. Then shorter. Then cooler. The birch wood was gold on the hill where he'd walked through it. A gold path up through the trees. Shining. Still. It didn't go brown in the autumn like the rest of the wood. It didn't drop its leaves.

It would never drop its leaves.

◆ ◆ ◆

RAVENS CAME.

Not from Wren. Never from Wren. She'd said she wouldn't. She'd kept her word.

From Elowen. From Seraphine. From Keepers on the roads in the north. From farmers in the Greyspine valleys, who'd seen a gold light walking through the mountains at night.

He was following her.

Slowly. Patiently. Up one valley and down the next. Through the high passes. Along the rivers. Stopping in every village. Sitting on the edge of every well. Listening to everyone who came.

Keeping the ones who asked.

And then moving on. North. East. West. Following a smell like bread on a wind nobody else could feel.

He never caught her.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She's leading him*," said Seraphine.

She'd come down from the Keep. Again. On Ashka. With her satchel of books and ink on her fingers and her spectacles. She was sitting at the table in the blue-door cottage with a map spread out in front of her. Arion's map. The one from behind the bookcase. The world from the inside.

She'd put pins in it.

Little ones. With red heads. One for every village the ravens had named.

"*Look*," she said.

Seren looked.

The pins went north from the Vale. Into the Greyspine. And then they went round. In a great slow loop. Up one side of the mountains and down the other. And round again. Wider. Up into the far north, past the Teeth, into the high country where nobody lived. And round.

"*She's leading him in circles*," said Seraphine. "*Away from the villages. Away from people. Into the high country, where there's nobody for him to stop and visit.*" She touched a pin. "*She's making him walk.*"

"*Why*?"

Seraphine looked at her.

"*To keep him away*," she said. "*From here. From Harrow. From Arion.*" She looked down at the map. "*She's buying time, Seren. For the boys. Till they come back through the door.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN LOOKED AT THE pins for a long time.

At the slow wide loops in the high country. At the valleys where nobody lived. At a girl from Thistledown with a baby on her chest and a gold hand, walking. Never stopping. Never staying. Drawing a gold king behind her round and round the mountains like a kite on a string.

"*She's not a Harrow*," said Seren. Very quietly.

"*No*," said Seraphine.

"*She's doing it anyway*," said Seren Harrow. "*Better than any of us ever did.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD HER ONE a day.

Still. Every morning. Fewer words now. Further apart. His hand slack in hers by the end. Sleeping in the middle.

She didn't mind. She waited. She'd sit on the edge of the bed holding his hand until he woke, and then he'd open his eyes and look at her and say, *where was I*.

And she'd tell him.

The first time Antho walked.

Lex's first word. Which was *hot*. Which was the forge. Which was Brannoc, laughing so hard he dropped a horseshoe on his foot.

A night at the cottage when the roof leaked and they slept under the table with the boys between them and the rain coming down and she sang the old verses, the forbidden ones, very softly, because it was the only song that was long enough.

You sang them? said Seren. *To the boys? Mam made me promise never—*

You sang them to me, said Arion. *The boys were asleep. You thought I was too.* He smiled. Very faint. *I wasn't. I was lying under the table listening to you sing a song about nine kings and queens who drank a Well dry and went into the grey. And I thought, I'm married to a woman who knows songs nobody else in the world knows.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED GETTING UP.

At the end of summer. Not that he'd been getting up much. An hour in the chair, some days. Ilsa's orders. Seren and Brannoc lifting him between them, slowly, carefully, from the bed to the chair, and wheeling him to the west window, and taking the board off one pane so he could see the birch wood.

He stopped wanting to.

It's all right, he said. When she asked. *I can see it from here. I can imagine it.* He looked at the boards over the window. At the two lines of charcoal in her square hand. *I've got a very good imagination.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LEAVES CAME DOWN.

Not on the gold path. On the rest of the wood. Brown and yellow and red, turning, drifting down onto the stream, onto the stepping stones, onto the oak ramp. She swept them every morning. They came back every night.

The days got shorter.

Seraphine came again. With her map. With more pins.

"*He's turning*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN LOOKED AT THE map.

The pins had been going round. In the high country. In wide slow loops. For two months.

The last three weren't.

The last three went south.

Straight. Not looping. Not wandering. Straight down out of the high country. Through the passes. Toward the Greyspine. Toward the Vale.

"*He's stopped following her*," said Seraphine. Very quietly.

"*He's lost her*?"

"*I don't think so*," said Seraphine. "*I think he knows exactly where she is. I think he's always known.*" She touched the last pin. "*I think he's just stopped.*"

"*Why*?"

Seraphine didn't answer.

She didn't need to. Seren looked at the straight line of pins coming down out of the mountains toward the Vale, and she knew.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Because Harrow women never go back*," said Arion.

They both turned.

He was lying on his pillows with his eyes half open. Listening. The way he always listened. Without moving.

"*He's worked it out*," he said. Faintly. "*She'll never stop. She'll keep moving. Twenty generations. It's in the child. He could follow her for a hundred years.*" A breath. In. Catch. Out. "*So he's stopped following.*"

"*And come here*," said Seren.

"*And come here*," said her husband. "*Because he knows something about Harrow women.*" A faint smile. "*They never go back.*"

He looked at her.

"*But their men do*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T UNDERSTAND.

Not for a moment. She sat on the edge of the bed and looked at him and didn't understand.

And then she did.

Lex.

Coming back through the door at the edge of the world. Thinking it's the end of summer. Coming home. To Harrow. To find Wren.

And Wren comes back to find him.

Wren's not a Harrow.

Wren will come back.

"*He's going to wait*," said Seren. "*Here. For them.*"

"*For tea*," said Arion. "*He did say.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE SENT THE DRAGONS west a week later.

Vharuun and Ashka. Both of them. From the high pasture above the birch wood, where they'd been sleeping all summer, curled round boulders like cats round warm stones.

She stood in front of them in the clearing with her map under her arm and her spectacles on her nose and a letter in each hand. She tied one to each dragon. To a horn. With grey thread.

Ten to one, said the letters. In her small neat hand. *Lantern Night is in seven days. He's at Harrow. Fly.*

"*Greyfall*," she told the dragons. "*The door. Wait for them. In the snow. As long as it takes.*"

Vharuun looked at her.

One molten eye. Ancient. Patient.

A picture. Clear. Dropped into her head like a stone into a well.

A sheep.

"*Yes*," said Seraphine Ilvane. "*Fine. Four. Roole's quartermaster can bill me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD SEREN AFTERWARD. Laughing. Crying. Both. Sitting on the ramp in the cold.

"*Roole's quartermaster*," she said. "*Roole's gold. In a gate. With Fenn's staff.*" She wiped her face. "*There isn't a quartermaster. There isn't anybody. They all went east.*" She looked at the dragons, going. Two shapes against the grey autumn sky. West. "*I promised a dragon four sheep from a man who can't move.*"

"*He'd have paid*," said Seren.

Seraphine looked at her.

"*Roole*," said Seren. "*He'd have paid. He paid for six already. Lex told me. He wrote to complain about it.*" She looked west. "*He'd have complained. And then he'd have paid.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING CAME BACK on the fourth day before Lantern Night.

Seren heard him in the night.

She was lying beside Arion with her hand on his chest. In the dark. Counting.

In. Catch.

Catch.

Out.

It took longer now. The catch. Every breath. She'd lie there with her hand on his chest and wait. And wait. And feel her own heart stop with his breath. And then it would go out. And then in.

And she'd breathe again.

◆ ◆ ◆

Thud.

From the top of the hill. From the birch wood. From the gold path.

Thud. *Thud*.

Coming down.

Not hurrying.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T GET UP.

She lay beside her husband in the dark with her hand on his chest and listened to the Gilded King come down through the birch wood.

Thud. *Thud*.

Into the clearing.

Across it.

To the foot of the ramp.

And stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAITED FOR THE knock.

It didn't come.

She lay in the dark and listened. To the stream. To the wind in the birches. To her husband's breath. In. Catch. Catch. Out.

No knock.

She got up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT TO THE door. Barefoot. In her nightdress. Across the cold flags.

She didn't open it.

She put her hand flat on the wood. The blue wood. The way her mother had stood at the doors of twenty-two cottages. The way Hesper must have stood. The way every Harrow woman had stood for nine hundred years at the end of every summer.

Listening.

He was there. On the other side. She could feel the heat through the wood. Like a forge. Like the sun.

He wasn't knocking.

He was sitting down.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HEARD IT. THE creak of the oak ramp. The settling. A mountain coming to rest. On the step. On the other side of the blue door.

And then nothing.

Just the heat. Through the wood. And the light, gold, coming in round the edges of the door, under it, through the cracks, so that the dark room behind her was lit faintly gold.

Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Seren*," said a voice behind her.

Faint. A thread. From the bed.

"*He's sitting on the step*," said Seren. Not turning round. Her hand on the door. "*He's not knocking. He's just sitting there.*"

"*Waiting*."

"*Waiting*."

A breath. In. Catch. Out.

"*For the boys*," said Arion.

"*For the boys. And Wren. And the baby.*" Her voice was very steady. "*He knows they'll come here. All of them. He knows they'll come home.*"

"*They will*," said her husband.

"*I know*."

"*And I'll be here*," said Arion Vey. "*I told him I'd try.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOOD AT THE door a long time.

With her hand flat on the blue wood. With the heat coming through it. With the gold light coming in round the edges.

And then she felt something on her bare feet.

Cold.

She looked down.

There was a gap under the door. There always had been. Brannoc had built it in a hurry, in the snow, in the first two weeks of winter. It let in a draught.

It was letting in something else now.

White. Small. Drifting in under the blue door on the cold night air. Landing on the flags. On her bare toes.

Melting.

◆ ◆ ◆

Snow.

The first snow.

She stood in the dark with her hand on the door and the King sitting on the step on the other side of it and the snow drifting in under it onto her feet.

And somewhere far to the west—two hundred and forty miles west, at the edge of the world, at a tall dark door in the grey—

She didn't know it.

She couldn't have.

But she thought, for no reason at all, standing at the door in the dark with snow on her feet—

They're coming.

They're coming now.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT BACK TO bed.

She lay down beside her husband on top of the blankets with her cold feet and her hand on his chest.

In. Catch. Catch. Catch.

Out.

"*Lantern Night*," said Arion. Very faint. In the dark. "*Four days.*"

"*I know*."

"*Have we got lanterns*?"

"*Lex made one*," said Seren. "*Before he went. For the window. He gave it to Brannoc to keep.*" She swallowed. "*He said, for Lantern Night. In case I'm not back. He said, put it in the west window. Facing the road. So I can see it.*"

"*What does it say*?"

"*I don't know*," said Seren. "*I haven't looked. It's wrapped in a cloth.*"

Arion didn't say anything for a long time.

"*Look*," he said at last. "*On Lantern Night. Not before.*"

"*Why*?"

"*Because I'd like to see your face*," said Arion Vey. "*When you read it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

OUTSIDE, ON THE STEP, the King sat in the snow and waited.

Inside, an old man and a hedge-witch lay in the dark and listened to each other breathe.

And the snow came down on the clearing at Harrow. On the stream. On the stepping stones. On the gold birch and the gold woodpile and the gold path going up the hill.

It settled on the gold and didn't melt.

It settled on everything else and did.

CHAPTER 29

The Crack

ANTHO RAN.

Down the white road. Toward the door. With his brother ahead of him and the basket bouncing on Lex's back and the snow coming in through the tall dark gap in the grey, drifting, turning, melting on the white stone.

Snow. In the Court. Where nothing had moved for nine hundred years.

He'd never seen anything so beautiful.

He'd never been so frightened.

◆ ◆ ◆

Months.

He couldn't stop thinking it. Every step. Every breath. *Months. Months. It's been months.*

His father. In a bed under a boarded window. With the Lantern burning beside him. Three panes of glass and one of horn.

I'll try, he'd said. *I'll breathe in and out until you walk back through that door. That's all I'm going to do. That's my whole job now.*

For months.

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SERAPHINE. AT THE KEEP. At the top of the passage stair. Writing in her book. Counting the lanterns for him because he wasn't there to count them. One thousand, one hundred and thirteen. One of them gold.

For months.

Reason six hundred and five. He checks.

He hadn't checked. Not in months. Not once. He'd been walking down a white road in a country with no days, thinking it had been a fortnight.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER. WREN. THE baby.

The King.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*," said Lex. Ahead of him. Not turning round. "*Behind us.*"

He looked back.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROAD BEHIND THEM was moving.

Not the road. The *kept*. On either side of it. The thin line of gold servants who'd been standing at the edges of the white stone near the Veil, facing west. Too far, Antho had thought. Too slow. Too old.

They'd turned round.

All of them. Every one. Facing east now. Facing the door. Facing four people running down the middle of the road toward it.

And walking.

Scrape. *Scrape*. *Scrape*.

A finger's width. A finger's width. Not like Ilda, an hour between each step. *Fast*. A step every breath. Every heartbeat. The gold feet scraping on the white stone. The gold hands reaching. A washerwoman. A groom. A boy with a hoop. An old man with a stick.

Coming.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND OVER THEM, ABOVE them, standing on nothing—

A thin bent shape of grey-gold dust. With two dim sparks for eyes.

"*Forgive me*," said Orrin. "*Forgive me, masters. He asked.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Faster*," said Lex.

They ran faster.

The door was close now. Very close. A hundred yards. Tall. Dark. Wide. The grey of the Veil drawn back on either side of it like curtains. The thorns still hanging off the edges, snapped, dangling, the ones Rhosyn had sent into the crack before they came. Black. Dead.

And beyond it, through it, white.

Snow. Falling. A grey winter sky. Flat bare ground, white. The cold light of a short day at the end of the year.

The world.

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"*Masters*," said Orrin. Behind them. Above them. Closer. "*Please. Stop. He doesn't want you hurt. He only wants the crown.*"

Nobody stopped.

"*He felt it go*," said the steward. His voice like sand poured out of a sack, following them on the dead still air. "*From the chair. From the tower. In your world, at your mother's door, sitting on her step. He felt it lift.*" A pause. "*He's very sad. He didn't know it was there. He didn't know Rosie had it. He'd have left it alone, he says, if he'd known. He says it was hers.*"

"*Then let us take it home*," shouted Lex. Not stopping. "*If it's hers.*"

"*He can't*," whispered Orrin. "*He knows what you want it for. The Key. The knot. The last turn.*" The dust was very close now. Antho could feel it. On the back of his neck. Like cold sand. "*He can't let you have the one thing that says no to him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST CAME DOWN.

Antho felt it before he saw it. A cold. A hiss. A soft dry falling, all round, like sleet. Grey-gold. Glittering. Out of the air. Out of the thin bent shape overhead.

Not the gold of the Court. Not the gold that slid off Hask and couldn't stick to anyone who drank.

His.

The King's gold. From the pouch. Silk, tied with a gold cord. A pinch of his. For anyone who wants it.

Orrin was scattering it.

Like seed.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*COVER*," shouted Antho.

He didn't know what he meant. There was nothing to cover with. There was nothing on the white road but white stone and gold servants and the door, eighty yards off, sixty, with the snow coming through it.

He threw his arm up over his face.

He felt it land. On his sleeve. On his hand. Cold. Like sleet.

And then *go in*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D SEEN IT IN Tilda. In Wren. In Bet Dale and the boy at the Veil and nine thousand people on a white road.

He'd never felt it.

It felt like nothing.

That was the worst thing. A patch on the back of his hand. The left. The one he'd cut at the edge of the world. Cold for a moment. And then not cold. Not warm. Not anything. Just *stopped*. Stopped being his.

He looked at it.

Gold.

A patch the size of a coin. On the back of his hand. Spreading.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T DO WHAT Lex did. He couldn't find the room in front of it. He wasn't the Hollow. He was a door.

He ran anyway.

With the gold spreading on the back of his hand. Toward the knuckles. Toward the wrist. With the dust falling round him like sleet. With the scraping behind him, faster, faster, a step every breath.

Forty yards.

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"*PIM*," shouted Hask.

Antho looked round.

The big man was behind him. Running. Heavy. Steady. With the boy in his arms. And the dust falling on him. On his shaved head. On his shoulders. On the scarred leather of his jerkin.

Not sliding off.

Sticking.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAW IT. SAW Hask see it.

The dust landing on Hask's bare head. On his neck. On his arms. And *staying*. Not rolling off like rain off oilcloth. Not sliding. Settling. Spreading.

Going in.

Hask's face changed.

"*It's sticking*," he said. Running. Not stopping. "*It's sticking. It never—*"

He didn't finish.

He didn't need to. Antho knew. He'd known since the thorns. Since a big man knelt in the dust with a Crowned queen's hand in his and cried for the first time since he was nine.

It thinks I'm one of theirs, Hask had said. In the cellar at Harrow. With the gold sliding off him. *It won't keep what it thinks it's already got*.

He wasn't one of theirs anymore.

He'd said sorry. To a pool. With a Warden's stick in his hand. He'd whistled back to his dead sister in a glass palace and she'd smiled. He'd knelt in the dust and held Rhosyn's hand and wept.

He'd changed.

And the gold knew.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK CURLED.

Running. He curled himself round the boy. His enormous shoulders hunched. His head bent down over Pim's. His arm—his right arm, his pick-arm, the one with the black iron scar from Coldwater—came up over the boy like a roof.

The dust came down on it.

Antho watched it happen. Running. Thirty yards from the door.

The gold landed on Hask's right arm. On the back of the hand. On the wrist. On the forearm, where the iron scar was, black, a line from wrist to elbow.

And went in.

◆ ◆ ◆

FROM THE HAND. UP. Fast. Faster than in Antho's own hand. As if the iron scar had left a road for it. The fingers. The palm. The wrist. Up the forearm. Over the black scar, which went gold, a gold seam in gold skin, like a vein of ore in a rock.

Up.

To the elbow.

And Hask kept running. With his gold arm curled over the boy. With his teeth set. With his face grey.

Not making a sound.

Coldwater hewers don't.

◆ ◆ ◆

TWENTY YARDS.

"*LEX*," shouted Antho. "*HASK'S ARM—*"

His brother turned. Running. Saw.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Don't stop—*"

Lex didn't listen. He never listened. He'd never listened to anyone in his life, Wren said, except when they were telling him something he already knew.

He stopped on the white road with the dust coming down round him and the kept scraping toward him, ten yards back now, eight, and turned, and caught Hask's gold arm in both his hands as the big man came past.

And shut his eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAW HIS FACE.

The listening face. The one he'd had kneeling by Tilda on the green at Ashbourne. Kneeling by Wren in the dark kitchen at Harrow.

Finding the room.

In front of the gold. Above the elbow. Where it was still creeping. Where it hadn't set.

Antho felt it open. A gap. A breath. A room with nothing in it.

And the gold came to it.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT THE ELBOW.

Not past. Not up the arm to the shoulder. Not across the chest to the heart.

At the elbow.

And didn't go back.

Lex opened his eyes. Looked at the arm. Gold from the fingertips to the elbow. Set. Finished. The iron scar a gold seam down the middle of it.

"*It's set*," he said. Hoarsely. "*I'm sorry. It went too fast. It was already—*"

"*It's my pick-arm*," said Silas Hask.

Lex looked up at him.

"*I'll learn left*," said Hask. Very rough. "*Tilda did. Go.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SCRAPING WAS FIVE yards back.

Four.

A gold washerwoman with a gold basket. Reaching. Her gold hand an arm's length from Lex's back. Her gold eyes moving. Slowly. To the basket on his back. To the crown in the straw.

And over her, above her, the dust. Thin. Bent. Two dim sparks.

"*Masters*," whispered Orrin. "*Please.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE SNOW LIT up.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT GOLD. NOT THE deep heavy gold of the King. Not the grey-gold of the Court.

White. Clear. Cold. Glittering. Like frost. Like ice over deep water. Like a thousand panes of glass catching a winter sun.

From the door.

From the snow drifting in through it. From every flake. Every one. Catching the light. Shining.

And in every flake—

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAW IT.

Not a face. Not a thousand tiny faces, the way there'd been in the gold dust at Harrow.

Eyes.

Pale. Grey. Ice over deep water. Open.

In every flake of snow drifting in through the door at the edge of the world.

Looking.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Orrin*," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST STOPPED.

Above the white road. Above the washerwoman. Above the scraping kept. It stopped falling. It hung in the air. Grey-gold. Glittering. Still.

The thin bent shape of the steward stopped with it.

"*Majesty*," it whispered.

"*Stop*," said the Glass Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER VOICE CAME FROM the snow. From every flake. Small and far and singing, like a wet finger round the rim of a glass. Not a thousand voices. One voice. Coming from everywhere at once.

"*Majesty—*" said Orrin. "*Majesty, he asked. His Majesty. He felt the crown go. He said bring it back.*"

"*I know what he said*."

"*Then—*"

"*I've never told him no*," said Ysenne. "*Not once. In nine hundred years. Not when he asked me to look through the crack. Not when he asked me to take the blood. Not when he asked me to bring Rosie home.*" A pause. "*I put chains on my own sister because he asked.*"

The dust hung in the air.

"*I'm not telling him no now*," said the Glass Queen.

A long silence.

"*I'm telling you*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEPT STOPPED.

All of them. All at once. The scraping. The reaching. The gold hands an arm's length from Lex's back.

Stopped.

Antho felt it. Felt something pass over them. Over the whole thin line of gold servants on either side of the white road. Like a hand laid over their eyes.

They stood still. Mid-step. Mid-reach. Their gold eyes moving. Slowly. Up. To the snow.

To the eyes in the snow.

"*She can command them*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Can't she. Not just Orrin. She's Crowned. She's his sister. They're the household.*"

"*She's stopping them*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Majesty*," whispered Orrin. "*He'll know. He'll know you stopped me.*"

"*Yes*."

"*He'll be—*"

"*He'll be sad*," said Ysenne. "*He's always sad. He's been sad for nine hundred years. Since a door. Since Father.*" A pause. "*He'll be sad, and he'll forgive me, because I'm his sister, and he keeps everything.*"

"*Majesty, why—*"

"*Because an old man broke my mirror*," said the Glass Queen. "*And said kept things can't see.*" Her voice was very quiet. "*And because a baby looked at me. And because a boy made room in me with nothing left.*" A pause. "*And because I've been sitting in a room with no glass in it for longer than I've ever sat anywhere, Orrin. Not looking at anything. Just sitting.*"

The dust didn't move.

"*Let them go*," said Ysenne.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO LOOKED AT THE snow.

At the flakes drifting in through the door. Each one with a pale grey eye in it. Open. Looking.

Looking at Pim.

At the boy in Hask's arms. White. Limp. Breathing very slow. With one gold arm curled over him like a roof.

"*Room-maker*," said Ysenne. Very softly. From the snow.

Pim didn't wake.

"*Tell the old man*," said the Glass Queen. "*Arion. When you get home. If he's still there.*"

Antho went cold.

"*Tell him I thought about what he said*," said Ysenne. "*About the baby. About kept things.*" A pause. "*Tell him I think he was right. Tell him I'm sorry.*"

"*Tell him yourself*," said Antho.

The eyes in the snow turned. Toward him.

"*He's going*," said the Glass Queen. "*Isn't he. I can see it. In every window at Harrow. In the frost on his spectacles. In the glass of your Lantern by his bed.*" Her voice was very gentle. "*I can see him going, warden. Like a candle at the end of its wick.*"

Antho couldn't breathe.

"*Run*," said Ysenne. "*Run, and you might be in time.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY RAN.

The last twenty yards. Down the white road. Past the gold servants standing still with their eyes on the snow. Under the dust hanging in the air, grey-gold, unmoving.

Through the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

COLD.

That was the first thing. Cold. Real cold. The kind that bites. The kind that gets into your fingers and your ears and your nose and makes your eyes water. Winter cold. After nine hundred years of a country with no weather at all.

Then wind.

Off the Veil. From the west. Hard. Bitter. Full of snow. Hitting him in the back like a hand as he came out of the grey corridor of the Veil's thickness, out of the dim, out of the hum.

Into the world.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELL OVER.

He didn't mean to. His legs went. He'd been running for—he didn't know. Days. Their days. And the room in his chest was thin, thinning, and the pressure had gone—the Court's pressure, the full heavy push—and his body didn't know what to do without it.

He fell on his knees in the snow.

And breathed.

All the way down.

No catch. No push. No full heavy air. Just cold. Just wind. Just air. Thin and sharp and empty and *his*.

Room.

All of it. Everywhere. As much as he wanted.

He knelt in the snow at the foot of the Veil and breathed and cried and couldn't stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS ON HIS knees beside him.

Breathing. The same. Great ragged gulps of cold air. His face wet. The basket still on his back. The crown in the straw. Nine hundred years of *no*, carried out of the Court on a smith's back.

Hask was standing.

He'd come through last. With Pim. And he was standing in the snow at the foot of the Veil with the boy in his good arm and his gold arm hanging at his side, and he wasn't breathing great gulps.

He was coughing.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHORT. DRY. A RATTLE. Twice. Then a breath. Careful. Further than halfway.

Not all the way.

The grey. The catch. Back. The moment he stepped out of the Court. The moment the full heavy air that had filled his lungs all the way down for the first time since he was nine was gone, and there was only cold thin winter air, and room, and the grey.

He stood in the snow and coughed.

And smiled.

"*There it is*," said Silas Hask. Hoarsely. "*Hello again.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO LOOKED UP.

At the door. Behind them. In the Veil. Tall. Dark. Wide. The grey drawn back on either side.

At the snow drifting in through it. Into the Court. Onto the white road. Each flake with a pale grey eye in it.

Closing.

One by one. The eyes in the snow. As the flakes landed on the white stone and melted. As they drifted past the gold servants and settled on the dust.

Closing. Like someone going to sleep.

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AND BEYOND THE DOOR, on the white road, just inside, very faint—

A small shape. Gold. In a grey dress too big for her. With a wooden spoon.

Standing at the side of the road.

Not walking. Not following.

Staying.

Her eyes were on the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

GREYFALL WAS WHITE.

Antho saw it when he could stand. A mile off. On its ridge. The walls. The towers. The gate. All of it under snow.

And the gold.

The road came out of the door at the foot of the Veil and ran east across the bare lands toward the fort. A furlong wide. Gold. Every stone. Every stump. A field with forty sheep in it, gold, under a white blanket of snow. A boy among them, gold, mid-step, with snow on his cap and his shoulders and his outstretched arm.

The snow stayed on the gold.

It settled on it and didn't melt. It lay on the gold sheep and the gold boy and the gold road like a cloth over furniture in a shut-up house.

Everything else, it melted on.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED TO THE fort.

Slowly. Lex with the basket. Antho with his gold-patched hand held against his chest. Hask with Pim, coughing.

Nobody spoke.

The gold road ran up to the east gate of Greyfall. Up the slope of the ridge. Under the walls.

And in the gate—

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ANTHO HAD KNOWN.

Wren hadn't told him. Nobody had. He'd been beyond the edge of the world for months that felt like a fortnight.

He'd known anyway. Since the crack. Since a hard plain man with a hatchet face said *I'll get them out. I promise. And then I'll stand somewhere.*

He stood in the middle of the east gate.

Gold. All of him. From his cap to his boots. His Keepers' grey, gold. His stiff arm, gold. His hatchet face, gold. Every line in it. Every crease.

And in his hands, held crosswise in front of him, the way Fenn had held it all night at the south edge between the families and the Mothwing—

A staff. Plain ash. Gold.

Snow lay on his shoulders. On his cap. On the staff. A thin white line along the top of it.

His eyes moved.

Slowly. So slowly. To the four people coming up the gold road toward him through the snow.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STOPPED IN FRONT of him.

He didn't know what to say. He stood in the snow at the foot of the east gate of Greyfall and looked at Daxian Roole.

Get out, he'd said. At the crack. *When he comes. Don't stand in front of him. You can't.*

I'll get them out, Roole had said. *I promise. I'll send the raven.*

And then I'll stand somewhere.

"*You got them out*," said Antho.

The gold eyes were on his face.

"*You sent the raven*," said Antho. "*It reached Harrow. Wren told the Keepers. They all went east.*" His voice was shaking. "*You kept your promise.*"

The eyes didn't move.

"*Fenn would be—*" He stopped. Couldn't. Tried again. "*Somebody has to stand somewhere. That's what he said. Isn't it.*"

Nothing.

"*You did*," said Antho Vey. "*You stood.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CAME UP BESIDE him.

He looked at Roole for a long time. At the gold face. At the snow on the shoulders. At the staff held crosswise.

Then he reached up. Slowly. And brushed the snow off Roole's shoulders. Off his cap. Off the top of the staff.

Gently. The way you'd brush snow off a child coming in from the cold.

"*We'll come back*," said Lex. Quietly. "*There's a crack. Pim found one. In a girl on the road. Where her door was.*" He took his hand away. "*Everything's a crack first. We'll come back.*"

The gold eyes moved.

To Lex's face.

And stayed there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*," croaked a voice.

They all turned.

On the wall above the gate. On the parapet. In the snow. A raven. Old. Ragged. One-eyed. With a thin silver ring on its leg.

It looked down at them with its one good eye.

"*Smith*," it croaked again. And then, after a moment, as if remembering something it had been taught a long time ago by a man with a hatchet face who thought it was funny—

"*Come back*."

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THE DRAGONS WERE IN the high pasture behind the fort.

Curled in the snow. Vharuun round a boulder, enormous, bronze and copper and old gold with a white blanket on his back. Ashka beside him, smaller, blue-grey, with snow on her wings.

Asleep.

Vharuun opened one eye as they came over the rise.

Molten gold. Ancient. Patient.

He looked at them for a long time.

Then a picture. Clear. Dropped into Antho's head like a stone into a well. And into Lex's. Antho saw his brother's face change.

Not a sheep.

A clearing. A birch wood. Two cottages. A blue door.

And a light on the step in front of it. Gold. Huge. Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A LETTER tied to his horn.

Grey thread. Paper. Folded small. Lex untied it with shaking fingers and unfolded it and read it in the snow. Antho read it over his shoulder.

Seraphine's hand. Small. Neat.

Ten to one.

Lantern Night is in seven days. He's at Harrow. Fly.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Seven days*," said Lex.

He looked at the snow. At the dragons, with snow on their backs. At the drifts round the boulder, deep, unbroken.

"*When did she send it*?" he said. "*How long have they been here?*"

Antho looked at Vharuun.

The great bronze head lifted. The molten eye looked at him.

A picture. The sun. Going down. Coming up. Going down. Coming up. Going down.

Three times.

"*Three days*," said Antho. "*They've been here three days.*"

"*Four days*," said Lex. "*Four days to Lantern Night.*" He looked east. Toward the world. Toward two hundred and forty miles of gold road, wandering. "*It's a day's flight. Maybe less. If we don't stop.*"

"*We don't stop*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT HIS hand.

He'd forgotten it. The gold. On the back of his left hand. The one he'd cut at the edge of the world.

It had stopped spreading.

He didn't know when. Somewhere in the Court. Somewhere on the white road, when Ysenne said *stop*. A patch. Gold. The size of a coin. On the back of his hand. Over the knuckle of the first finger.

Set. Finished. Full.

He flexed his hand. The fingers moved. The knuckle didn't quite. Stiff. Like a joint that's been broken and healed.

"*It's not much*," said Lex. Looking at it.

"No."

"I can try—"

"It's set," said Antho. *"Leave it."* He looked at it. At the gold on the back of his hand. At the place where his father's knuckle would be, if his father's hand were his. *"It's the size of a coin. I'll keep it."*

He looked at Hask's arm. Gold to the elbow. Hanging at his side. And Wren's fingers. And Brannoc's. And Tilda's hand.

"We're all going to have a little," he said. *"All of us. Everyone who was there."* A pause. *"So we remember."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FLEW.

East. Over the gold road. Over the bare lands. Over the Blightmarch, green, with snow on it, and a small dark glint in the middle like an eye, and a black house on the slope with a lantern in its window.

The gold road went round the Blightmarch. South. In a great wide curve.

It didn't touch the green.

Antho saw it. From the air. A gold line running across the white land toward the green circle. And stopping. At the edge. Sharp as a knife. Not a speck of gold on the green.

And then going round.

"Lex," he said. Into the wind. *"Look."*

His brother looked.

"It won't take," said Antho. *"On Mal's ground. The gold won't take."* He looked at the green circle, a hundred miles across, with a pool in the middle. *"He walked round."*

Lex didn't say anything for a long time.

"Write it down," he said at last.

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THEY FLEW ALL DAY.

Over the shires. Over the downs. Ashka beside Vharuun, beating hard. Pim asleep in front of Antho, against his chest, with Ivy's cat in the pocket over his heart. Hask on Vharuun's back behind Lex, with his eyes shut and his good hand white on the dragon's scales and his gold arm across his knees.

Coughing.

The snow stopped at noon. The sky cleared. Cold and hard and blue.

And then, in the afternoon, with the sun going down red behind them—

The Vale.

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ANTHO SAW IT COME up over the edge of the downs. Long. Green under the snow. A river. A village with a forge in it, smoke going up from one chimney, only one, the Forge's, and the long roof, and a black dot on the chimney-top that might have been a raven on a nest of spoons.

And beyond the village, at the far end of the Vale, a birch wood.

Gold.

A gold path going up through it. Up the hill. From the clearing at the bottom. Straight up to the top and over. North. Toward the mountains.

And in the clearing at the bottom—

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LIGHT.

Gold. Huge. Warm. Like metal in a crucible. Like the inside of a forge.

On the step.

On the oak ramp.

In front of a blue door.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He's there*," said Lex. Very quietly. "*Sitting on the step. Like Vharuun showed us.*"

Antho didn't answer.

He was looking at the cottage. At the boarded windows. At the chimney, with a thin thread of smoke going up from it into the cold red evening.

At the west window. Boarded.

At a gap in the boards. A small one. One plank taken down. A crack.

And light coming through it. Faint. Soft. From inside.

Three squares of light. And one soft blur.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The Lantern*," said Antho. Hoarsely. "*It's lit. My Lantern. By his bed.*"

"*Then he's—*"

"*It's lit*," said Antho Vey. "*He's keeping it lit. Or Mam is. Somebody's keeping it lit.*"

He held Pim tighter.

"*He's trying*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN IN the high pasture above the birch wood.

Antho was off Ashka before she'd landed. With Pim in his arms. Stumbling in the snow. Running.

Down. Through the birches. The green ones, bare now, white trunks in the dusk. Not the gold path. He didn't go near the gold path.

Down the hill. Toward the stream. Toward the clearing. Toward two cottages and a gold birch and a gold woodpile and a gold cart.

Toward a blue door.

Toward the light on the step.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS BESIDE HIM.

Running. With the basket on his back. With nine hundred years of *no* in the straw between the last few cups.

Neither of them said anything.

They came out of the birch wood at the top of the clearing.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS SITTING ON the step.

The King. Enormous. Gold. Glowing like metal in a crucible. With his great gold hands on his knees and his white and gold robe spread out on the snow round him, turning it gold. With his crown of gold leaves, crooked.

Sitting on the oak ramp in front of the blue door.

Not knocking. Not trying to come in.

Just sitting.

Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED HIS HEAD.

Slowly. His great gold head. His beard. His crooked crown.

And looked up the clearing. At the top of it. At the edge of the birch wood. At two men standing in the snow. One with a basket on his back. One with a boy in his arms. And behind them, coming out of the trees, a big man with a gold arm, coughing.

The Gilded King smiled.

"*Cousins*," he said.

His voice was deep. Like a bell. Warm.

"*You're just in time*," said Oszric of the Crowned. "*I was about to put the kettle on.*"

CHAPTER 30

Fair Wind

WREN HAD BEEN RUNNING for eighty-six days, and her daughter had learned to stand.

It happened in a shepherd's bothy on the north face of the Teeth. Stone walls. A turf roof. A hearth with no chimney, so the smoke went out through a hole in the turf and most of it stayed in. Kestrel was asleep in the corner under every blanket they owned. The wind was howling outside like something that wanted to come in.

Wren was sitting on the floor by the fire with her back against the wall and her eyes half shut.

And Lark pulled herself up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DID IT ON Wren's hand.

The left one. The gold one. Four gold fingers, stiff, curled, set from the knuckle to the nail. Lark had been fascinated by them since the summer. She chewed them. She patted them. She held on to them when she was falling asleep, the way she used to hold on to Wren's braid.

She held on to them now.

Both square fists. Round two gold fingers. Gripping. Hard. The way she gripped everything.

And *heaved*.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FELT IT. FELT the weight on her hand. Felt the small body on the floor beside her shift, and brace, and push.

She opened her eyes.

Her daughter was on her knees. On the dirt floor of the bothy. Holding Wren's gold fingers in both fists. Her face screwed up. Red. Fierce. Her bottom in the air. Her bare feet, too big for the rest of her like her hands, pushing at the dirt.

Grunting.

The way a smith grunts lifting an anvil.

And then she was up.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON HER FEET. SWAYING. Her knees bent. Her whole weight on Wren's gold fingers. Her grey-green eyes enormous. Her mouth open.

Standing.

She looked at Wren.

Wren looked at her.

Neither of them breathed.

Then Lark let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T FALL. NOT at once. She stood. On her own. In the firelight. In a shepherd's bothy on the north face of the Teeth with the wind howling outside and the smoke going round and round under the turf roof.

For one breath.

Two.

And then sat down. Hard. On her bottom. On the dirt.

And laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS THE LAUGH from Ashbourne. From the roofs. From the gold. The laugh of someone who has just discovered the best thing in the world and can't believe nobody told her about it before.

Wren laughed with her.

She couldn't help it. She sat on the floor of the bothy with her daughter laughing in the dirt and laughed till she cried. And then cried till she couldn't stop.

Kestrel woke up.

She sat up in the corner under all the blankets with her red hair wild and her amber eyes blinking and looked at them. At Wren, crying. At the baby, laughing.

"*What*?" she said. "*What happened?*"

"*She stood up*," said Wren.

Kestrel looked at the baby.

"*Oh*," she said. And then, after a moment, very quietly: "*Oh, Wren.*"

"*He wasn't here*," said Wren. Through her hands. "*Lex. He wasn't here. She stood up for the first time and he wasn't here.*"

Kestrel didn't say anything.

She got up. And came across the bothy with a blanket round her shoulders. And sat down on the floor beside Wren. And put her arm round her.

"*I'll tell him*," she said. "*If you can't. I'll tell him exactly. Every bit.*"

"*It's not the same*."

"*No*," said Kestrel Varn. "*But it's what we've got.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D STOPPED COUNTING THE valleys.

She'd counted, at first. In the summer. Leaving the Vale. Going north. *One*. The long valley above Thistledown, where she'd grown up, where she knew every hare-track and every hollow. She'd stopped there one night in a barn she knew and lain awake listening to the owls and thought, *I could stay. Just a night. Just to sleep.*

She hadn't stayed.

Two. *Three*. *Four*. Over the passes. Into the Greyspine. Through valleys she'd never seen. Sleeping in barns and bothies and once, in the worst of the summer heat, under a rock overhang beside a waterfall with the baby asleep on her chest and Kestrel keeping watch.

Moving. Every day.

Keep moving, Arion had said. *Don't stop. Don't stay anywhere long. Don't let him learn your face.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D FOUND THE TRAIL on the third day.

She'd known he would. She'd felt it. The way you feel weather coming. A warmth. On the back of her neck. On the wind, when it came from the south. A heat that wasn't the sun.

And then the ravens. Not to her; she'd made sure no raven could find her. To the villages she passed. To the shepherds. *A gold light. Walking. Coming north.*

He was following.

Slowly. Five miles a day. Less. Stopping in every village. Sitting on every well.

She went faster.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT UP.

That was the thing she worked out, in the first week. Where he couldn't follow. Where there were no villages to stop in, no wells to sit on, no old women to listen to.

The high country.

Above the valleys. Above the shepherds' summer pastures. Up into the bare rock and the snowfields and the passes nobody used. Where there was nobody at all.

He'd follow her there. She knew he would. He'd follow the smell of bread on the wind anywhere.

But there'd be nobody to keep.

◆ ◆ ◆

SO SHE LED HIM.

Up. Into the high country. Round. In great slow loops. Through the Teeth. Past them. North, into the empty land beyond, where the rivers ran white and the wind never stopped and there wasn't a house for fifty miles.

And back. And round again.

She didn't know if it was working. She couldn't see him. She never saw him. She just felt the warmth on the back of her neck, sometimes, on a south wind. Far off. Following.

And at night, sometimes, very rarely, on a clear night—

A glow. Low. On a distant ridge. Gold.

Sitting. Looking.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TALKED TO HER once.

In the sixth week. On a night with no wind. She'd made camp in a hollow below a ridge, a high one, bare rock, with snow already on the tops though it was only the end of summer down in the Vale. Kestrel was asleep. Lark was asleep.

Wren was awake. She was always awake.

And the voice came down off the ridge.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mistwalker*," said the Gilded King.

Not loud. He didn't need to be loud. It came down the slope like heat off a forge. Warm. Deep. Kind.

Wren didn't move.

She lay in the hollow with the baby on her chest under the blanket and her hand on her knife and didn't move.

"*I'm not coming down*," said the voice. "*Don't be afraid. I'm only sitting. On the ridge. I've been sitting here all evening.*" A pause. "*It's a very good view. You can see the whole of the Teeth from up here. In the moonlight. Like a row of old women in white shawls.*"

Wren didn't answer.

"*You're very good*," said Oszric of the Crowned. "*You know that? I've followed a great many things in my life. Deer. Boars. A thief who stole my mother's necklace when I was fourteen.*" A soft laugh. "*Nothing as good as you. You go where I can't stop. You go where there's no one to sit with.*"

She didn't answer.

"*It's very lonely up here*," said the Gilded King.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LAY IN THE hollow and listened to him not come down.

"*I could*," he said. After a while. "*Come down. You know I could. I could walk down this slope and you couldn't stop me. Your wind won't move me. Your arrows go gold. Your knife.*" A pause. "*I could walk down and pick her up out of your arms.*"

Wren's hand tightened on the knife.

"*I won't*," said Oszric. "*I want you to know that. I won't. Not like that.*" His voice was very gentle. "*I don't take, Mistwalker. I never have. Not once. I only help the ones who ask.*"

"*She won't ask*," said Wren.

It was the first thing she'd said. Out loud. Into the dark. To the voice on the ridge.

He was quiet for a long time.

"*No*," he said at last. "*She won't. She's Hes's. Isn't she. All the way down. Twenty generations of no.*" A pause. "*But you might.*"

"*Never.*"

"*One night*," said the Gilded King. "*When she's sick. When she's burning with a fever and you've been walking for a month and there's no healer for fifty miles. When she's crying and you can't make her stop.*" Very softly. "*When you're so tired you can't see. One night, you might come up the ridge and ask me to make it so she's never sick again.*"

Wren didn't answer.

"*I'll be here*," said Oszric. "*On the ridge. Every night. In case.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE MOVED CAMP BEFORE dawn.

She didn't sleep. She lay in the hollow with the baby on her chest until the sky went grey, and then she woke Kestrel without a word and they packed and went. North. Over the next pass. Into the next valley.

He followed.

He was on the ridge above her every night after that. Not every night. Some nights. Enough. A glow on the skyline. Sitting. Watching.

He never spoke to her again.

He didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK GOT SICK IN the ninth week.

Of course she did. They were in the high country. It was cold. It was wet. They were sleeping in bothies and under rocks and once, for three nights, in a cave with water running down the walls.

She burned.

Her face red. Her eyes glassy. Her square hands hot as coals. She cried. Not her usual cry, short and furious. A thin high wail that went on and on and wouldn't stop. She wouldn't feed. She wouldn't sleep.

Wren held her.

All night. In the cave. With the water running down the walls and Kestrel feeding the fire with everything she could find and the wind howling outside.

And at midnight, she looked out of the mouth of the cave.

And there was a glow on the ridge.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T GO.

She sat in the mouth of the cave with her burning daughter in her arms and looked at the glow on the ridge for a long time.

When she's burning with a fever and you've been walking for a month.

One night, you might come up the ridge.

She thought about it.

She let herself. For one breath. The way Seren had let herself at the blue door. *He'd make it stop. She'd never be sick again. She'd never cry like this again. She'd never—*

She'd never grow up.

She'd never stand again. She stood once. In the bothy. On her own. For two breaths. And sat down and laughed.

She'd never do it again.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Kes*," said Wren.

Kestrel looked up from the fire.

"*Can you do the thing*?" said Wren. "*The fire thing. The one you do. The one that isn't fire.*"

Kestrel looked at her for a long moment.

Then she came across the cave. And knelt down. And put her hands out. Not touching the baby. Near. Over her. A foot away.

And let the heat go.

Not flame. Not black heat. Something else. Something Kestrel had learned in the Sunreach from old women in red, who'd learned it from older women, who'd learned it before there was a net to call it anything. A heat that went *out*. That drew. The way a poultice draws.

Lark's wail went up. High. Higher.

And then broke.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T STOP CRYING. Not at once. But the wail broke. Into sobs. Into hiccups. Into a small exhausted whimper.

And then sleep.

Wren felt it. Felt the heat go out of her daughter's forehead under her hand. Not all of it. Some. Enough. Felt the small body go slack against her chest.

Breathing. Slow. Wet. Ragged. But slow.

Kestrel sat back on her heels.

Her face was grey. Her amber eyes were dull.

"*It's not a cure*," she said. Hoarsely. "*It's just—taking a bit of it. Into me.*" She swallowed. "*Asha taught me. She said it's what fire-women do. Take a bit of the burning so the little ones can sleep.*"

"*Kes—*"

"*It's all right*," said Kestrel Varn. "*I've got plenty. I'm made of it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN LOOKED OUT OF the mouth of the cave.

At the ridge. At the glow on it.

She looked at it for a long time. With her sleeping daughter in her arms and her friend grey-faced beside her and the water running down the cave walls.

And then she lifted her left hand. The gold one. Four gold fingers. And held it up. In the mouth of the cave. So that it caught the firelight.

So that it shone.

Not waving. Just holding it up. So he'd see.

No.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLOW ON THE ridge didn't move for a long time.

And then it went.

Not toward them. Away. Over the ridge. Out of sight.

He didn't come back that night.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FEVER BROKE ON the third day.

Lark woke up hungry and furious and red-faced and bit Wren's gold finger so hard she'd have drawn blood if it hadn't been gold.

Wren laughed till she cried. Again.

She was doing a lot of that.

◆ ◆ ◆

IN THE ELEVENTH WEEK, he stopped following.

She felt it. The way she'd felt him come. A change in the wind. A coldness on the back of her neck where the warmth had been.

She didn't believe it at first. She thought it was a trick. She thought he'd gone round. She went faster. Higher. Further. Over two passes in two days, with the baby on her chest and Kestrel stumbling behind.

Nothing.

No warmth on the south wind. No glow on the ridges at night.

Nothing.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He's gone*," said Kestrel.

They were in a bothy. Another one. On the edge of a high valley with a lake in it, black, with snow on the mountains all round.

"*He's not gone*," said Wren.

"*I can't feel him. You can't feel him. There's been nothing for four days.*"

"*He's not gone*," said Wren again. She was sitting in the doorway of the bothy looking out at the lake. At the snow. "*He's turned round.*"

Kestrel looked at her.

"*He's not following me anymore*," said Wren Ashdown. "*He's going somewhere else.*"

"*Where*?"

Wren didn't answer.

She didn't need to. She'd known since the first cold morning without the warmth on her neck. She'd known the way you know the weather's going to turn.

Harrow women never go back.

That was what he'd worked out. On a ridge. In the dark. Sitting. Looking at her camp in the hollow below. *She'll never stop. She'll keep moving. Twenty generations. It's in the child. I could follow her for a hundred years.*

Harrow women never go back.

But their men do.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," she said.

Kestrel went very still.

"*He's going to Harrow*," said Wren. "*To wait. On the step. For Lex. For the brothers. When they come back through the door.*" Her voice was very flat. "*He knows they'll come home. He knows they'll come to Harrow first. To find me. To find her.*"

"*And you're not there*."

"*And I'm not there*." Wren looked at the black lake. "*And he is. Sitting on the step. With the old man dying inside. Waiting.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

The wind came down off the snow and across the lake and in through the door of the bothy. Cold. Hard. Smelling of winter.

"*Arion said keep moving*," said Kestrel at last. "*He said don't stop. Don't go back.*"

"*I know*."

"*He said Harrow women never go back*."

"*I know what he said*," said Wren. She looked down at the baby asleep in the sling against her chest. At the dark fluff of hair. At the square fist curled against her collarbone. "*She's a Harrow.*"

"*And you*?"

Wren looked out at the lake for a long time.

"*I'm an Ashdown*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D NEVER THOUGHT ABOUT it before.

Ashdown. Her father's name. A shepherd's name. From the high moors above Thistledown, where her father had kept sheep until the rock-wyrm took him, when she was eleven.

Ashdowns didn't run.

That wasn't a rule. Nobody had ever said it. It was just what they did. They stayed. On the moors. In the same cottage. For generations. They went out in the

snow after lost ewes and came back. They went to market and came back. They went to war, sometimes, when the old king called, and they came back.

Her father had gone out after a ewe on a spring morning and not come back.

Her mother had sat at the window for a month. Looking at the moor. At the path. Waiting.

He didn't come.

And then her mother had got up. And gone out. And found what was left of him. And brought it home. And buried it. And stayed.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ashdowns look back*," said Wren. "*Once. At the top of the hill. So they remember the way home.*" She looked at Kestrel. "*Seren said that. On the day I left. Brannoc told me. In a letter.*"

"*Brannoc can't write*."

"*Hedda wrote it*," said Wren. "*Brannoc told her what to say.*" She smiled. Shakily. "*It was very badly spelled.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOOD UP.

In the doorway of the bothy. With the baby on her chest and the wind on her face and the black lake and the white mountains in front of her.

"*I'm going home*," said Wren Ashdown.

Kestrel looked at her.

"*He'll be there*," she said. "*On the step. With his gold. Waiting for her.*"

"*I know*."

"*He said he'd never take. But if you walk up to him with her on your chest—*"

"*He won't take*," said Wren. "*He said so. He doesn't take. He only helps the ones who ask.*" She looked down at her daughter. "*And she won't ask. She's Hes's. All the way down.*"

"*And if he's lying*?"

Wren didn't answer for a moment.

"*Then Lex will be there*," she said. "*And Antho. And Seren. And Brannoc.*" She looked at the mountains. South. Toward the Greyspine. Toward the Vale. "*And I'll have the wind.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's four days*," said Kestrel. "*Walking. Five. Through the passes. In the snow.*"

"*I'm not walking*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D BEEN WALKING FOR eighty-six days.

Not flying. Not on the wind. Walking. Because walking left a trail that looked like walking, and flying left a trail like a comet, and the King could smell a comet from a hundred miles. Because she was a tracker and trackers walk. Because the baby had been sick and the wind was cold and she'd been so tired, so very tired, and every time she called the wind she felt it in her bones afterward for days.

She called it now.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME DOWN OFF the mountains.

All at once. The way it came when she really meant it. Not a breeze. Not a gust. The *wind*. The north wind. Off the snowfields. Off the Teeth. Off the whole white roof of the world. Cold. Hard. Enormous. Pouring down the valley and across the black lake, so that the water went white with spray, and slamming into the bothy and the doorway and her.

And lifting.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT UP.

Off the doorstep. Into the air. With the baby on her chest and the wind under her feet like a hand, like a step, like the first stair of a staircase made of air. Up. Over the bothy. Over the lake. Kestrel shouting something below her that the wind tore away.

And Lark woke up.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FELT IT. THE jerk. The breath. The head lifting off her collarbone.

The wind hit her daughter in the face. Cold. Hard. Full of snow.

And Lark laughed.

Not the laugh from the bothy. Not the laugh from the roofs. *More*. The laugh of someone who has been inside for three months, in caves and bothies and under rocks, sick, cold, carried, and has just this moment been taken out into the sky.

She laughed so hard she couldn't breathe. And breathed. And laughed again. With her square fists flung out on either side and her face turned up into the snow and the wind tearing the sound out of her and throwing it back across the black lake and the white mountains.

Wren laughed with her.

She couldn't help it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*KES*," she shouted. Down. At the bothy. At the small figure in the doorway with red hair.

Kestrel looked up.

"*FOLLOW*," shouted Wren. "*WALK. TO HARROW. I'LL SEE YOU THERE.*"

Kestrel shouted something back. The wind took it.

But Wren saw her lift her hand. And hold it up. And the hand caught fire. Not burning. Just lit. Like a lamp. Like a torch held up in a doorway on a winter night.

So Wren could see it.

So she'd remember the way.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TURNED SOUTH.

And ran.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE WIND. OVER the high country. Over the snowfields and the passes and the black lakes and the bare rock. Over the bothies they'd slept in and the caves and the rock overhang by the waterfall. Over eighty-six days of walking, rolled up under her like a carpet, gone in an afternoon.

She didn't stop.

She ran the way she'd run on the roofs at Highcrest in the rain, with Lex behind her laughing. The way she'd run over Ashbourne with the gold coming down. Her feet barely touching the air. The wind lifting her over every gap.

The baby laughed the whole way.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TEETH WENT BY on her left. White. Jagged. Like a row of old women in white shawls.

The Greyspine came up ahead. Grey. Snow on the tops. The passes.

She went over the highest one. Not through. *Over*. Higher than she'd ever been. So high the air went thin and her ears rang and the baby stopped laughing for a moment and stared round with her grey-green eyes enormous, at the whole world spread out below them like a map.

Then she laughed again.

Louder.

◆ ◆ ◆

She's a Mistwalker's daughter, Wren had told Lex. On the river path. After Ashbourne. *She likes the wind*.

She's a smith's daughter, Lex had said. *She grabbed the nail*.

She can be both.

Wren ran south over the Greyspine on the north wind with her daughter laughing on her chest and thought, *she can be anything. She can be everything.*

And nobody's going to keep her.

Not ever.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT WAS GOING when she came over the last ridge.

Red. Low. The sun going down behind her in the west, over the mountains, over the Teeth, over the edge of the world. The sky ahead was purple. Cold. Clear.

And below her—

◆ ◆ ◆

THE VALE.

Long. White under the snow. A river, black, winding. A village with a forge in it. One chimney smoking. A long roof. A black dot on the chimney-top.

And at the far end, a birch wood.

Gold.

A gold path going up through it. Up the hill. From a clearing at the bottom to the top of the ridge and over. Toward her. Toward the mountains. The way he'd come, following her. In the summer. Three months ago.

And in the clearing at the bottom—

Light.

◆ ◆ ◆

GOLD. HUGE. WARM. LIKE metal in a crucible.

On the step. In front of a blue door.

Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN STOPPED.

On the wind. In the air. High over the Vale. With the red sun behind her and the purple sky in front and her daughter on her chest.

She looked down at the light on the step.

And saw something else.

◆ ◆ ◆

ABOVE THE BIRCH WOOD. In the high pasture. Where the dragons slept, in the summer. Two shapes. Coming down out of the red sky from the west. Fast. One

enormous, bronze and copper, old gold, with wings like the sails of a ship. One smaller, blue-grey, beating hard.

Landing.

In the snow. In the high pasture. In the last red light.

And figures sliding off them. Small at this distance. Four. One carrying something. One carrying someone. One big, coughing, with an arm that caught the light and shone.

One with a basket on his back.

Running.

Down through the birches. Toward the stream. Toward the clearing.

Toward the light on the step.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN COULDN'T BREATHE.

She hung in the air over the Vale on the north wind and watched a man with dark curly hair cut badly and a basket on his back run down through the birch wood in the dusk.

She'd know that run anywhere.

She'd watched it over a hundred rooftops.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," she said.

Out loud. To the wind. To the dusk. To nobody.

And her daughter, on her chest, stopped laughing.

And looked.

Down. At the birch wood. At the running figures. At the one with the basket.

And reached.

One square fist. Out. Down. Toward him. Opening and closing.

The way she reached for the nail.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN CAME DOWN.

Out of the sky. On the wind. Fast. Faster than she'd ever come down off anything. With her daughter reaching and her heart going like a hare's and the snow coming up to meet her and the gold light on the step getting bigger and bigger and the man with the basket coming out of the trees at the top of the clearing and stopping.

And turning.

And looking up.

At the sky. At the wind. At a woman with red hair coming down out of the dusk with a baby on her chest.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LANDED IN THE snow at the top of the clearing.

Beside him.

She didn't remember landing. She remembered the wind letting go. She remembered her boots hitting the snow. She remembered stumbling. She remembered him catching her.

Both arms. Round her. Round the baby. Round both of them. Hard. Like iron. Like a vice. Like her daughter's grip.

He didn't say anything.

She didn't say anything.

He held her in the snow at the top of the clearing with the gold light on the step below them and his brother beside them and a boy asleep in his brother's arms and a big man with a gold arm coming out of the trees, coughing.

He held her.

And the baby between them reached up.

And grabbed his nose.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE A SOUND.

Wren felt it. Through his chest. Not a laugh. Not a sob. Something with both in it. Something that came up out of him from very deep, from a place he'd been keeping shut for months that had been a fortnight.

"*Ow*," said Lex Vey.

"*She's got good taste*," said Wren. Into his shoulder. Crying. Laughing. "*She always goes for the nose.*"

"*She's*—" He pulled back. Just enough. To look. At the baby. At the square fist on his nose. At the face. Round. Fierce. With a fluff of dark hair standing up like a bird's crest. With grey-green eyes, Wren's eyes, looking at him. "*She's so big.*"

"*She's nearly a year old*," said Wren.

"*She was five months. When I*—" His voice broke. "*She had one tooth.*"

"*She's got six*," said Wren. "*She bit Kestrel. She bit me. She bit a goat.*" She laughed. Shakily. "*She stood up, Lex. In a bothy. On the Teeth. On my hand. On my gold fingers.*" She swallowed. "*She stood up and you weren't there and I'm telling you now. Kestrel said she'd tell you if I couldn't. I can. She stood up.*"

He looked at the baby for a long time.

The baby looked back. With her fist on his nose. Frowning.

As if she were trying very hard to remember him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex*," said Antho.

Quietly. Beside them. With Pim in his arms. Looking down the clearing.

At the step.

At the light.

They all looked.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS SITTING ON the oak ramp in front of the blue door. Enormous. Gold. Glowing. With his great hands on his knees and his robe spread out on the snow, turning it gold. With his crown of gold leaves, crooked.

He'd turned his head.

He was looking up the clearing.

At them.

At the man with the basket. At the woman with red hair. At the baby between them, with her fist on her father's nose.

And his face—

Wren had seen it before. In a village in the western shires. On the edge of a well. Looking up at her daughter through a whirl of wind.

A man looking through a window into a warm room on a winter night.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Cousins*," said Oszric of the Crowned.

His voice came up the clearing. Deep. Warm. Like a bell.

"*You're just in time*," said the Gilded King. "*I was about to put the kettle on.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY MOVED.

Then the blue door opened.

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND HIM. BEHIND THE King on the step. The door swung inward. Into the dim. Into the faint light of a Lantern by a bed, three panes of glass and one of horn.

And a woman stood in it.

Small. Square. Barefoot. In a grey dress with flour on the front. With her greying hair tied back and her sleeves pushed up and her hands on her hips.

She looked over the King's shoulder. Over his great gold head. Up the clearing. At her sons. At her son's wife. At the baby.

Her face did something Wren had never seen it do.

It didn't break. It *lit*. All at once. From inside. Like a window. Like a lamp in a cottage at the end of a long lane on a winter night.

"*Well*," said Seren Harrow. "*Don't just stand there. Come in. The kettle's on.*"

She looked down at the King on her step.

"*You too*," she said. "*Mind your head on the lintel.*"

CHAPTER 31

Tea with the Gilded King

HE MINDED HIS HEAD on the lintel.

Lex watched him do it. From the top of the ramp. With Wren's hand in his and the baby on her chest and the basket on his back. The Gilded King rose up off the step like a mountain standing, and turned, and looked at the blue door, and at the woman in it with her hands on her hips.

And bent.

All the way. Folding himself down. His great gold head. His crooked crown. His shoulders, wider than the doorframe, turning sideways to fit. He went through the door of the blue cottage the way a bear goes into a cave. Carefully. Slowly. With his hand up to keep his crown from catching on the top.

"*Thank you*," he said. To Seren. In the doorway. Very gently. "*For asking.*"

"*I didn't ask*," said Seren. "*I told.*"

He looked down at her.

"*Yes*," said Oszric of the Crowned. "*You did.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T MOVE.

He stood at the top of the ramp in the snow and looked at his mother. At her hands on her hips. At the flour on her dress.

"*Mam*," he said. Very quietly. "*You let him in.*"

"*He was always going to come in*," said Seren. "*He told me so. Through the rose. In the spring.*" She looked at him. With her brown eyes very steady. "*I'll say no. And I'll come in anyway. And we'll have tea.*"

"*Then why—*"

"*Because this way it's my door*," said Seren Harrow. "*And my tea. And my house.*" She stepped back. Into the dim. "*And he's my guest. Not the other way round.*" She looked at all of them. "*Come in. All of you. Your father's waiting.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT IN.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COTTAGE WAS DIM. Boards over every window but one. A fire in the hearth, banked. The table under the west window, with two cups on it and a tin.

And the bed.

Under the window. With the curtain drawn back. With three pillows. With the Lantern on the table beside it—his brother's Lantern, three panes of glass and one of horn—burning. Throwing three clear squares of light on the walls and one soft blur.

And in the bed—

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D THOUGHT HE WAS ready.

He'd thought about it. All the way across the Court. All the way back. All day on Vharuun's neck over the gold road. *Months. It's been months. He'll be older. He'll be thinner. He'll be—*

He wasn't ready.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER WAS VERY small.

Smaller than a child. That was the first thing. He lay on the three pillows under the blanket and there was almost nothing of him under it. A shape. Narrow. Like a bundle of sticks.

His face was a walnut. Brown. Creased. Folded in on itself so far there was barely a face left. The bones of it sharp under the skin. His hair a white wisp, so thin you could see the pink of his scalp through it.

His hands on the blanket were bones. Bones in paper. Spotted. Twisted. Still.

His eyes were the same.

Grey. Clear. Sharp. Turning on the pillow. Slowly. To the door.

To him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Good evening*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX COULDN'T SPEAK.

He stood in the middle of the room with the basket on his back and looked at his father and couldn't say anything at all.

I'll try, his father had said. *I'll breathe in and out until you walk back through that door. That's my whole job now.*

He'd done it.

For months. For a hundred and forty days. In this bed. Under this window. With the Lantern burning.

He'd tried.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT TO THE bed.

He didn't remember crossing the room. He was standing in the middle and then he was on his knees by the bed with his father's hand in both of his, and it was so cold, so thin, like holding a bird's wing, and his father was looking at him.

"*You're late*," said Arion.

Lex made a sound. Not a word.

"*A hundred and forty days*," said his father. Faintly. A thread. "*I counted. Seraphine did the sums. Ten to one.*" The ghost of a smile. "*You said a fortnight.*"

"*I didn't know*," said Lex. Hoarsely. "*Nobody knew. Caddoc told me. At the foot of the thread. He said it like everyone knew.*"

"*Everyone in the Court knew*," said Arion. "*Nobody out here.*" He breathed. In. Catch. Catch. Out. "*It doesn't matter. You're here.*"

"*I'm here*."

"*Did you get it*?"

Lex looked at him.

His father's grey eyes went past him. Over his shoulder. To the basket on his back.

"*It's in there*," said Arion. Very quietly. "*Isn't it. I can feel it. Like a cold draught. Like your mother at the door.*" A faint smile. "*Like twenty generations of no.*"

"*Yes*," said Lex.

His father closed his eyes.

"*Good*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember.

Very small. Very far. Like a voice at the bottom of a well.

[He's so thin.]

I know.

[I can feel him. The thread. From me to him. It's—Lex, it's like a hair. Like a spider's thread. Like the last strand of a rope.]

Lex held his father's hand.

[I don't know how he's still here,] said Ember. *[I don't know how he's done it. A hundred and forty days on a thread like that.]*

He tried, thought Lex.

[Yes,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[He tried.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE OTHERS CAME IN behind him.

Antho, with Pim asleep in his arms. He laid the boy down on the sheepskin by the hearth, gently, and covered him with a blanket, and Pim didn't wake. Then he came and stood at the end of the bed. And looked at their father.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't need to. Lex saw his face.

Wren, with Lark. She came and stood beside the bed. Close. With the baby on her chest. And Lark looked down at her grandfather on his pillows. With her grey-green eyes. Frowning.

Arion opened his eyes.

He looked up at the baby. For a long time.

"*She's grown*," he said.

"*She stood up*," said Wren. "*In a bothy. On the Teeth. On my hand.*"

"*Did she*," said Arion. Wonderingly. "*Did she.*"

"*She bit a goat*," said Wren.

Arion laughed.

It wasn't much. It was barely a sound. A breath, a catch, a crack in it, something that went in and didn't come out for a long moment and then did. But it was a laugh.

"*Good*," he said. "*Good girl.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK DIDN'T COME IN.

He stood outside. On the ramp. In the snow. With his gold arm hanging at his side and his good hand on the doorframe. Coughing.

"*I'll stand here*," he said. When Lex looked round. "*At the door. In front of it.*" He looked into the dim room. At the bed. At the old man. At the enormous gold shape at the hearth. "*Somebody should.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING WAS SITTING on the floor.

Lex hadn't seen him sit. He'd been looking at his father. When he looked round, the Gilded King was on the flags by the hearth. Cross-legged. Like a mountain folded. With his great gold hands on his knees and his white and gold robe spread round him.

The flags under him were gold.

Spreading. Slowly. Out from where he sat. A foot. Two. The grey stone going gold, every crack and seam, the way frost spreads across a pane.

He saw Lex look at it.

"*I'm sorry*," said Oszric. "*I can't help it. Everything I touch.*" He looked at the gold spreading on the floor. "*I'll try to keep still.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN POURED THE TEA.

She did it at the table. Under the west window. With her back to the room. Lex watched her. The kettle. The tin. Hollis Penn's tin. The good kind. She spooned the leaves into the pot and poured the water and put the lid on and stood there with her hands flat on the table, waiting for it to steep.

Nobody spoke.

The fire ticked. The Lantern burned. Three clear squares and one soft blur on the walls.

His father breathed. In. Catch. Catch. Out.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE POURED IT INTO two cups.

The chipped blue one with the crack down the handle. And the other. White. Lopsided. Too thick. Brannoc's first thing that wasn't iron.

She took the blue one to the bed.

She sat down on the edge of it and lifted his father's head off the pillow, gently, with one arm, and held the cup to his lips. He drank. A sip. Less. Most of it ran down his chin. She wiped it with her sleeve.

"*Good*," said Arion. "*Good tea.*"

"*It's the good kind*," said Seren. "*In a tin.*"

"*I can tell*."

She laid his head back on the pillow.

Then she took the white cup. And crossed the room. And knelt down on the floor in front of the King. On the grey flags. Just short of where they turned gold.

And held it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GILDED KING LOOKED at it.

At the white cup. Lopsided. Too thick. Full of tea. Steaming. In a hedge-witch's square freckled hands.

He didn't take it.

"*I can't*," he said. Very quietly.

"*It's tea*," said Seren. "*You came for tea. You said.*"

"*I know.*" He looked at the cup. "*I can't drink it. Everything I touch.*" He lifted one great gold hand off his knee. Slowly. And held it out. Not to the cup. Beside it. A foot away. "*If I take it, it'll go gold. The cup. The tea. All of it. In my hand.*" His voice was very gentle. "*I haven't tasted anything in nine hundred years.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T TAKE THE cup back.

She knelt on the floor in front of the King with it held out in both hands, steaming.

"*Take it anyway*," she said.

He looked at her.

"*Take it*," said Seren Harrow. "*It's yours. I made it for you. I bought the good kind. In a tin.*" She didn't lower the cup. "*If it goes gold, it goes gold. It's still yours. You can keep it.*"

The King didn't move for a long moment.

Then he reached out.

And took the white cup out of her hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT GOLD.

From his fingers. Outward. The lopsided white clay. The thick rim. The handle that Brannoc had got wrong. Gold. And the tea inside it. The surface of it. Gold. A gold disc in a gold cup. Still. Not steaming anymore.

The King held it.

In his great gold hand. Very carefully. The way you'd hold a bird's egg. And looked down at it.

"*Thank you*," he said.

His voice was barely a voice.

"*Nobody's ever—*" He stopped. "*In nine hundred years. Nobody's ever made me anything.*" He turned the gold cup in his hand. Slowly. Looking at it. At the lopsided rim. At the thumb-print in the clay near the handle, where Brannoc had pressed too hard. "*Orrin brings me things. The household brought me things. Before. Everything I*

wanted." A pause. *"Nobody ever made me a cup of tea I couldn't drink and gave it to me anyway."*

"Well," said Seren. *"Now someone has."*

She stood up. And went back to the bed. And sat down on the edge of it. And took her husband's hand.

The King sat on the floor with the gold cup in his hands and didn't say anything for a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

"Oszric," said Arion.

The King looked up.

His father was looking at him. From the pillows. With his grey eyes. Very steady.

"Mae said you were the eldest," said Arion. Faintly. *"She said you always went first."*

"I did."

"She said you kept things."

"I do," said the Gilded King.

"Why?"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING DIDN'T ANSWER.

He sat on the gold floor by the hearth with the gold cup in his hands and looked at the old man in the bed.

"You know why," he said at last. *"Cad told you. Up the thread. At the bottom of the world. When you went down to see your friend."* A pause. *"He told you about our father."*

"He told me you couldn't go in the room."

The King flinched.

Lex saw it. A small movement. A tightening. In the great gold face. In the shoulders. The way a man flinches when you touch a bruise he didn't know you could see.

"Yes," said Oszric.

◆ ◆ ◆

"A year," said the Gilded King.

He said it to the cup. To the gold tea. Not to anyone.

"A wasting thing. In his chest. It took a year." His voice was very quiet. Very even. *"He was the King. He was the strongest man in the world. He lifted me onto my first horse with one hand. He laughed so loud the windows rattled."* He turned the cup.

"*And then he started to cough. And then he couldn't ride. And then he couldn't walk. And then he couldn't get out of bed.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*Mae sat with him*," said Oszric. "*Rosie brought him roses. Ysy looked at him and cried and went away.*" A pause. "*Hes sat on the floor by the bed with a toy bear. She was four. She didn't understand. She thought he was just tired.*"

"*And Caddoc held his hand*," said Arion.

"*Cad held his hand*," said the King. "*Every night. At the end. Not saying anything. He was eleven.*" He looked up. At the old man in the bed. "*I was fourteen. I was the eldest. I was the heir. I was going to be King.*"

"*And you stood outside the door*."

"*And I stood outside the door*," said Oszric of the Crowned.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE TICKED.

"*Every night*," said the Gilded King. "*For a month. At the end. I'd go to the door of his room. I'd stand there. I'd put my hand on the latch.*" He looked at his hand. Gold. Holding a gold cup. "*And I couldn't. I couldn't open it. I could hear him breathing. On the other side. In. And a catch. And a catch. And out.*" His voice cracked. "*Like yours.*"

Lex's hand tightened on his father's.

"*And I'd stand there*," said Oszric. "*Shaking. With my hand on the latch. Listening to every breath. Waiting for the one that didn't come.*" He swallowed. "*And then I'd go away. And find the scholars. And shout at them. Find something. Find a cure. Find anything.*"

"*And they couldn't*."

"*And then he went*," said the Gilded King. "*In the night. With Cad holding his hand. And Mae asleep in the chair. And Hes asleep on the floor with her bear.*" He looked at the gold cup. "*And me outside the door. With my hand on the latch.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

Lex looked at him. At the biggest man he'd ever seen, sitting on the floor of his mother's cottage with a gold cup of tea in his hands, crying.

He didn't want to feel sorry for him.

He did.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And a week later you found the pool*," said Arion.

"*A week later I found the pool*," said Oszric. "*In the cellar. Under the palace. Hes had been sitting by it since she was four. Talking to it. Nobody listened.*" He wiped his face with the back of his free hand. It came away wet. "*The scholars said it was just a spring. Very old. Very good. And I drank from it. And I didn't get tired. And I didn't get old. And I thought—*"

He stopped.

"*You thought, nobody I love will ever have to go through that door*," said Arion.

The King looked at him.

"*Yes*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*So you drank it dry*," said Arion. Very quietly. "*All of you. And it starved. And it screamed. And Hesper heard it. And you didn't.*"

"*I didn't listen*."

"*No*."

"*I couldn't*," said the Gilded King. "*If I listened, I'd have to stop. And if I stopped—*" He looked at the gold cup. "*Then everyone would go through the door. Mae. Rosie. Ysy. Cad. Hes. One by one. And I'd stand outside every one of them.*"

"*And now*?"

"*And now nobody goes through it*," said Oszric. "*Not in the Court. Not ever. Nine thousand of them. Kept. Safe.*" He looked up. At the old man. "*I walked out among them, in the first years, when they started to come apart. When there was nothing left to drink. I went out with my hands.*" His voice was very soft. "*And not one of them ever went through the door.*"

"*Because there isn't one*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

EVERYONE LOOKED AT HIM.

He was standing at the end of the bed. With his hands at his sides. With a gold patch on the back of his left hand, the size of a coin.

"*I felt for it*," said Antho. "*On the white road. In every one of them. Nine thousand.*" His voice was very steady. "*The last door. The one everyone gets.*" He looked at the King. "*It isn't there. Not in one of them. You didn't stop them going through it. You bricked it up. With gold. From the outside.*"

The King looked at him.

"*They hum*," said Antho Vey. "*Did you know? All of them. One note. For nine hundred years.*" He swallowed. "*Pim made a girl say a word. On the road. Ilda. Your spit-girl. She said mam. And the hum remembered what it was saying.*"

"*What—*" The King's voice was barely there. "*What is it saying?*"

"*Home*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GILDED KING DIDN'T move.

He sat on the gold floor with the gold cup in his hands and his furnace eyes on Antho's face. And for a moment—just a moment—Lex could look at them. The eyes. They'd dimmed. Like a fire when you throw water on it. Like a forge when the bellows stop.

"*Home*," said Oszric.

"*Nine thousand of them*," said Antho. "*Standing at the side of your road. With their doors bricked up. Saying home.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED DOWN at the cup.

For a long, long time.

"*They are home*," he said at last. Very quietly. "*They're with me. In the Court. Safe.*"

Nobody answered.

"*They're safe*," said the Gilded King again. As if he were saying it to himself. As if he'd said it to himself every day for nine hundred years. "*Nothing can hurt them. Nothing can take them. Nobody goes through the door.*"

"*Nobody comes out of it, either*," said Arion.

The King looked up.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You stood outside it*," said his father. From the pillows. Very faintly. Very clearly. "*Your father's door. For a month. With your hand on the latch.*" A breath. In. Catch. Catch. Out. "*You never went in.*"

"*No.*"

"*So you never saw what was on the other side.*"

The King didn't answer.

"*I'll tell you*," said Arion Vey. "*Since you came for tea. Since I'm the clever one. Since I'm nearly there.*" His grey eyes were very bright in the Lantern-light. "*On the other side of that door was your father. In a bed. Dying. With your brother holding his hand.*"

"*I know what was—*"

"*And he was all right*," said Arion.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING WENT VERY still.

"*He was all right*," said Arion. "*Caddoc told me. Up the thread. In the dark.*" A faint smile. "*He didn't want anything said. So nobody said anything. Caddoc held his hand. Mae slept in the chair. Hesper slept on the floor with her bear.*" A breath. "*And he went. In the night. With his son holding his hand.*"

"*He went*," said Oszric. Hoarsely.

"*He went*," said Arion. "*That's all. That's all it was. He was tired, and he went, and someone he loved was holding his hand.*" He turned his head on the pillow. Slowly. To look at the Gilded King. "*You've been standing outside that door for nine hundred years, Oszric. Thinking there was something terrible on the other side.*"

The King didn't speak.

"*There wasn't*," said Arion Vey. "*There was just your father. Going. With his hand in your brother's.*" A pause. "*You should have gone in. He'd have liked you there.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GILDED KING PUT the cup down.

On the gold floor. Beside him. Very carefully. The way you'd put down something that might break, though it couldn't break now, nothing could, it was gold all the way through.

And put his face in his hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WATCHED HIM.

He'd seen a lot of people cry this year. His mother in the cellar. Wren in the snow. Hask in the thorns. Rhosyn in the dust. Antho on his knees in a glass palace.

He'd never seen anything like this.

The biggest man in the world. Gold. Crowned. Glowing like metal in a crucible. Sitting on the floor of a cottage with a blue door, with his face in his great gold hands, shaking.

Not making a sound.

The floor round him went on turning gold. A foot. Two. Three. Spreading. Toward the bed. Toward the hearth. Toward Pim, asleep on the sheepskin.

Wren moved. Quickly. Quietly. She picked the boy up, blanket and all, and carried him to the other side of the room.

The King didn't notice.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I can keep you*," he said.

Through his hands. Very muffled.

Arion didn't answer.

"*I can*," said the Gilded King. Lifting his face. Wet. Gold. "*Now. Tonight. One touch. You'd never have to go. You'd never have to be tired. You'd lie in that bed with your wife holding your hand for a thousand years.*" His voice was shaking. "*She'd never have to listen to you stop. Your sons would never have to stand outside the door.*"

"*They're not outside it*," said Arion. "*They're in the room.*"

The King stared at him.

"*Look*," said his father. Faintly. "*Look round. They're all in the room. My wife's holding my hand. My son's holding the other one. My other son's standing at the end of the bed. My son's wife is over there with my granddaughter.*" A breath. In. Catch. Catch. Catch.

Out.

"*Nobody's outside the door*," said Arion Vey. "*Not one. That's all I ever wanted.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said the Gilded King. "*No. Please. Let me. Please.*" He was leaning forward. On his knees now. On the gold floor. His great gold hands out. Open. "*I've never asked anyone. Not in nine hundred years. They always asked me.*" His furnace eyes were burning, wet, enormous. "*I'm asking. Please. Let me keep you.*"

His father looked at him for a long time.

"*No, thank you*," said Arion.

The King's face broke.

"*I've had a very long life*," said Arion Vey. Very gently. "*And a very good wife.*"

He turned his head. On the pillow. To look at her. At Seren. Sitting on the edge of the bed with his hand in hers.

"*Twice*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER MADE A sound.

Lex didn't look at her. He couldn't. He knelt by the bed with his father's other hand in both of his and looked at the floor and heard his mother make a sound he'd never heard anyone make.

Not crying. Something under crying. Something that came up from very deep, from a warm empty hollow where thirty years used to be, and found something there.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING SAT BACK.

Slowly. On his heels. On the gold floor. With his great gold hands falling into his lap.

He looked at the old man in the bed for a long time.

"*Hes said that*," he said at last. "*Not those words. But that. On the shingle. To Mae. Not me. Not ever.*" He looked at his hands. "*I never understood it. Nine hundred years. I never understood why anyone would choose the door.*"

"*And now*?" said Arion.

The Gilded King didn't answer.

He looked at the gold cup on the floor beside him. At the lopsided rim. At the thumb-print near the handle.

"*I don't know*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HE LOOKED at the baby.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAW IT HAPPEN.

Saw the King's furnace eyes move. Slowly. Off the old man in the bed. Across the room. To the far wall. To where Wren was standing with Pim asleep at her feet and Lark on her chest.

And stop.

On the baby.

And change.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HUNGER.

Lex had seen it once. From a hundred miles away. Through Wren's eyes, when she came home from the western shires white-faced and told him. *Like a man looking through a window into a warm room on a winter night.*

He saw it now.

In the great gold face. In the burning eyes. The grief going out of them. Not gone. Pushed aside. Covered. The way a fire is covered when you throw on new fuel. And under it, rising, the other thing.

Something new. Something that's never been anyone's. Full of room.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said Oszric. Very softly. "*There she is.*"

Wren went very still.

"*Look at her*," said the Gilded King. Wonderingly. "*Look at her. She's grown. She was so small in the summer. In the wind. Laughing.*" He leaned forward. On his knees. "*And now she's—oh. Oh, look at her hands.*"

Lark was looking back at him.

Over Wren's shoulder. From the sling. With her grey-green eyes. Frowning.

"*She's new*," said the King. "*She's full of things that haven't happened yet. Do you know how long it's been since I saw anything new? Nine hundred years. Not a child. Not a rose. Not a thought I hadn't had before.*" His voice was very soft. Very gentle. Very hungry. "*And there she is.*"

"*No*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING DIDN'T MOVE toward her.

He stayed on his knees on the gold floor by the hearth. With his hands in his lap. Not reaching.

"*I won't take her*," he said. "*I said. In the mountains. On the ridge. I don't take. I never have.*" He looked at Wren. "*I'll ask.*"

"*The answer's no*."

"*Not you*," said the Gilded King. Gently. "*I asked you. On the ridge. You said no. You held up your gold hand in the mouth of the cave so I'd see it.*" He smiled. Sadly. "*I saw it.*"

He looked at the baby.

"*Her*," said Oszric.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HELD OUT HIS hand.

Not toward her. Not reaching. Just held it out. In the air. Over the gold floor. Palm up. Open. One great gold finger extended. The way he'd held it out to a shaking grandmother on the edge of a well in the western shires. The way you'd hold your hand out to a frightened animal, to let it come to you.

"*Little one*," he said.

The room was very quiet.

"*Little one*," said the Gilded King. Very softly. To the baby on Wren's chest. "*I'd like to keep you. Forever. Exactly as you are. So you're never sick, or sad, or frightened, or old.*" His furnace eyes were very bright. "*So you're always this new. Always this full of room.*"

Lark looked at the gold hand.

"*May I*?" said Oszric of the Crowned.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY BREATHED.

Lex knelt by the bed with his father's hand in his and couldn't move. Antho at the end of the bed. Seren on the edge of it. Wren against the wall with her gold fingers on the baby's back and her other hand on her knife.

Hask in the doorway. Coughing. Stopped.

His father on the pillows. Watching. With his grey eyes.

And the baby looked at the King.

At his gold hand, held out. At his gold face. At his crooked crown of gold leaves. At his eyes, burning.

She frowned.

The deep, fierce, furious frown. Her father's frown. The frown he gave the bellows when they wouldn't catch.

And she said—

◆ ◆ ◆

"No."

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS VERY SMALL.

Barely a word. A sound. A breath with a shape to it. Round. Short. Certain. Coming out of a baby nearly a year old who had never said a word in her life. Who had vowels and a grip like a vice and six teeth and had stood up once, on her mother's gold fingers, in a bothy on the Teeth.

No.

Not loud. Not frightened. Not crying.

The way her grandmother said it at a blue door to a dust-man.

The way her great-great-great-grandmother, twenty times over, said it on a shingle in the grey light to a sister in chains.

Not me. Not ever.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM DIDN'T MOVE.

Wren had her hand over her mouth. Seren had gone white. Antho had gone very still at the end of the bed, the way he went still at doors.

Lex couldn't breathe.

Her first word.

Her first word, and it's no.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GILDED KING DIDN'T move either.

He knelt on the gold floor with his hand held out and his face—

His face did something Lex had never seen a face do.

It cracked.

Not broke. Not crumpled. *Cracked*. A line. Through the gold. Through the hunger. From the forehead down. Like a crack running through a block of ice in the first warm spring sun.

And light came through it.

Not his light. Not furnace-light. Not gold.

Something else.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAUGHED.

Lex didn't expect it. Nobody did. The King knelt on the floor of the cottage with his hand held out to a baby who'd just said her first word, and it was *no*, and he threw back his great gold head and *laughed*.

Not the bell. Not the warm roar from the rose. Something else. Something young. Something that cracked in the middle. The laugh of a boy of fourteen at dinner when his little sister says something outrageous and he laughs so hard he falls off his chair.

"*Hes*," he said. Through it. Laughing. Crying. Both. "*Oh, Hes. Oh, it's you. It's you. It's you all over again.*"

He couldn't stop.

He knelt there and laughed with tears pouring down his gold face and his hand still held out, open, to a baby who had said no.

"*No*," he said. "*Of course. Of course it's no. It was always going to be no.*" He wiped his face with his free hand. "*Twenty generations. She'd have said no to me in her cradle. She'd have said no in her mother's womb.*"

He lowered his hand.

Slowly. Back into his lap.

"*Thank you*," said Oszric of the Crowned. To the baby. Very softly. "*Thank you for answering. Nobody's ever answered.*" He looked at her. At her frown. At her fist. "*Hes never did. She never said another word to me. Not one. Not ever.*" His voice cracked again. "*And you said one.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK FROWNED AT HIM.

And then, very deliberately, she put her fist in her mouth.

And looked away.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN LAUGHED.

She couldn't help it. It came out of her cracked and wet and sudden, standing against the wall with her hand over her mouth and tears on her face.

And then Seren.

And then, at the end of the bed, Antho.

And Lex, kneeling by the bed with his father's hand in his, felt his own chest crack open and something come up out of it that was half a laugh and half a sob and wholly, entirely, helplessly *proud*.

Her first word.

No.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER WAS LAUGHING too.

Lex felt it. Through his hand. A shiver. A tremor. A breath that went in and caught and caught and caught and turned into a cough and turned back into something like a laugh.

"*Good girl*," whispered Arion Vey. "*Oh, good girl.*"

His hand tightened in Lex's.

And then let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT ALL THE WAY.

Lex felt it. The grip going. Not slack. Just—*less*. The way a hand loosens when someone's falling asleep.

He looked down.

His father's eyes were closed. His face on the pillow was very still. Smiling. A little.

His chest under the blanket—

In.

Catch.

Catch.

Catch.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LANTERN FLICKERED.

On the table. By the bed. His brother's Lantern. Three panes of glass and one of horn.

The flame inside it shrank.

Not out. *Down*. Small. Smaller. A bead of gold. A spark. The three clear squares of light on the walls going dim. The soft blur going dimmer.

And holding.

Barely.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Arion*," said Seren.

Catch.

Catch.

The room was silent.

Catch.

◆ ◆ ◆

OUT.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BREATH CAME OUT.

Long. Slow. Ragged. And then in again. Shallow. Short. Barely there. But in.

The Lantern flame steadied. A little. Didn't grow. Didn't shrink.

Held.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED UP.

At the King.

He'd stood up.

Lex hadn't heard him move. He was standing by the hearth. Enormous. Gold. His crown of gold leaves almost touching the beams. His great gold hands at his sides. The laughter gone out of his face.

Very still.

Looking at the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Someone's coming*," said Oszric.

His voice was very quiet. Very strange.

"*On the river*," said the Gilded King.

Nobody moved.

"*I can feel it*," he said. "*In the water. In the stream outside. In the snow melting off the roof.*" He wasn't looking at any of them. He was looking at the blue door. At the dark beyond it. At the night. "*All rivers are his water. A little. He used to say.*"

His hands were shaking.

Lex had never seen them shake.

"*I know that boat*," said Oszric of the Crowned. "*I've sat in it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND SOMEWHERE OUTSIDE, IN the dark, in the snow, very faint—

The creak of a pole.

And the soft slap of water against a hull.

And a light.

Small. Grey. Swaying. Coming up through the birch wood.

Not gold.

The colour of a lantern seen through river-mist.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK STEPPED BACK FROM the doorway.

He didn't say anything. He just stepped back. Out of the door. Onto the ramp. Into the snow. Aside.

The way you step aside for something you know you're not meant to stand in front of.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND SOMEBODY KNOCKED.

Not like Orrin. Not three soft taps, courteous, patient.

Once.

Very gently.

The way you knock on a door when you know the person inside has been waiting for you.

CHAPTER 32

A Love for a Love

SEREN HAD BEEN WAITING for that knock for thirteen years.

Not this one. Not this door. Not this night.

But that knock. Once. Very gently. The knock of someone who knows you've been waiting.

She'd heard it once before. On a shingle. By a grey river. Thirteen years ago. With her eldest son screaming on the stairs behind her and a door into the dark opening in front of her.

She hadn't heard it then, exactly. There'd been no door to knock on. Just the shore, and the boat, and a tall grey figure leaning on a pole.

But she'd felt it. The way you feel a hand on your shoulder in a crowd.

It's time.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Come in*," said Arion.

From the pillows. Barely a sound. A thread.

He hadn't opened his eyes.

"*Come in*," he said again. "*Door's open. It always is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DOOR SWUNG INWARD.

Slowly. On its hinges. Into the dim. Letting in the cold. Letting in the snow, drifting, a few flakes, landing on the gold flags by the hearth and lying there, not melting.

And letting in the light.

Grey. Soft. Swaying. The colour of a lantern seen through river-mist. On the end of a long pole.

And then him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HAD TO STOOP. Like the King. Like Arion, once, on the Spire steps in the rain. He was very tall. Tall and thin and grey, in grey robes that hung off him like river-weed, with his long grey hands on his long grey pole and the lantern on top of it swaying.

He stepped into the cottage.

He turned his face toward the room.

He had no eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY MOVED.

Seren sat on the edge of the bed with her husband's hand in hers. Lex knelt on the other side with the other hand. Antho stood at the foot of the bed. Wren against the far wall, with the baby and Pim.

And by the hearth, standing, enormous, gold—

The King.

He'd backed away. Seren saw it. When the door opened. When the grey light came in. He'd taken one step back. And then another. Until his shoulders were against the wall by the hearth and he couldn't go any further.

His face was white.

Not ivory. Not gold. *White*. The colour of bone. The colour of a man who has seen something he's been running from for nine hundred years walk in through a blue door.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN TURNED HIS eyeless face.

Slowly. Round the room. Past the bed. Past Antho. Past Wren and the children.

To the hearth.

To the King.

Seren saw him look. Without eyes. She saw the King feel it. Saw him flinch against the wall like a man flinching from a blow.

"*Oszric*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING DIDN'T ANSWER.

He stood with his back against the wall and his great gold hands pressed flat against the stone on either side of him and his furnace eyes enormous. The light coming off him had dimmed. Like a fire when you open the door and the cold comes in.

"*I rowed you*," said the Ferryman. Very quietly. "*Nine hundred years ago. You sat in the stern. In chains. You did not look at me once. You looked at the shore. At your sister on it. Until the grey took her.*"

The King's mouth opened. Nothing came out.

"*You were afraid of me then*," said the Ferryman. "*You are afraid of me now.*" The eyeless face didn't move. "*You have been afraid of me since you were fourteen. Since a door. Since your father.*"

"*Are you—*" The King's voice. Cracked. Barely a voice. "*Are you here for—*"

"*No*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING WENT VERY still.

"*Not you*," said the Ferryman. "*You are not on my list.*" He turned his face. Away. Toward the bed. Toward the old man on the pillows. "*You never will be.*"

Silence.

"*You drank*," said the Ferryman. "*You drank the room. The door new things come in by. The door old things go out by.*" His long grey hand was still on his pole. "*There is no door for you, Oszric. Not mine. Not any. You bricked it up yourself. With a gold cup at the edge of a pool.*"

The King's face—

Seren saw it. She'd remember it. For the rest of her life.

"*That is your punishment*," said the Ferryman. Very gently. "*Not mine. I have never punished anyone.*" A pause. "*You did it yourself. And you have been doing it to others ever since.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING MOVED.

Not toward the Ferryman. Not toward the bed. Sideways. Along the wall. Toward the door. Slowly. His back to the stone. His eyes on the grey figure in the middle of the room. The way a man edges past a sleeping dog.

The Ferryman didn't look at him.

He'd turned his whole body toward the bed now. Toward Arion. He wasn't watching the King at all.

The King reached the door.

He stopped in it. Ducking. With one great gold hand on the frame, turning it gold. With the snow behind him and the night.

He looked back.

At the bed. At the old man. At the woman beside him.

At the baby, against the far wall, with her fist in her mouth.

"*I'm—*" he said. And stopped. And tried again. "*I'll—*"

He couldn't finish.

He turned. And went out. Into the snow. Into the dark. And Seren heard him go. Down the ramp. Across the clearing. Not hurrying. Not slow. *Away*. West. Down the track. Through the birch wood.

The gold light going with him. Through the trees. Getting smaller. Further.

Gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK, ON THE RAMP, stepped back into the doorway.

He didn't say anything. He stood there. In the cold. With his gold arm hanging at his side and his good hand on the doorframe.

Somebody should.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN STOOD BY the bed.

He looked down at Arion. With no eyes. For a long time.

"*Arion Vey*," he said.

"*Ferryman*," said Arion. Not opening his eyes.

"*I told your son you would come to my shore*," said the Ferryman. "*Before long. I said old men always do.*" A pause. "*You did not come.*"

"*No*."

"*So I have come to you*." The eyeless face was very gentle. "*I do not often. I have only come to a door four times since the world was woven.*"

"*Who else*?" said Arion. Faintly.

"*Aurelian*," said the Ferryman. "*At the end. In the deep. Malachi. In the deep, singing. And a girl of seven in the Drowned Country, nine hundred years ago, who was too frightened to come down to the water on her own.*" A pause. "*And you.*"

Arion opened his eyes.

"*Why me*?"

"*Because you tried*," said the Ferryman. "*A hundred and forty days. On a thread as thin as a spider's.*" He was quiet. "*I have watched a great many people come to my shore. I have never watched anyone try so hard not to.*"

"*I promised my sons*."

"*I know*," said the Ferryman. "*I heard.*" The lantern on his pole swayed. "*They are here now.*"

"*They're here*," said Arion Vey.

He smiled.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN HELD HIS HAND.

She didn't say anything. She couldn't. She sat on the edge of the bed with his hand in hers—bones in paper, so cold, so light—and looked at his face.

I'm going to lose him.

She'd known. Of course she'd known. She'd known since the Ferryman's shore. Since *before the year turns*. She'd known every night for a hundred and forty days, lying beside him in the dark with her hand on his chest, counting.

She hadn't known it would feel like this.

Like losing something she'd never had.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Ferryman*," she said.

The eyeless face turned toward her.

"*The price*," said Seren. "*For my memories. Of him. The ones I paid you. Thirteen years ago.*" Her voice was shaking. She didn't let it stop her. "*You said a love for a love. You said it on the shingle. You said it must be given. By the one who holds it.*"

"*I did*."

"*I asked if I could give mine. For my sons. And you asked if I would.*" She swallowed. "*And I couldn't.*"

"*No*," said the Ferryman. Very gently. "*You could not.*"

"*I still can't*," said Seren Harrow. "*I've thought about it every night. For a hundred and forty days. I've lain here and thought, if I gave it, I'd have him back. All of him. Before he goes.*" Her hand tightened on Arion's. "*And I'd look at my boys in the morning and not know why I was smiling at them.*"

She looked up at the Ferryman.

"*I can't*," she said. "*I can't. I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. I can't.*"

"*I know*," said the Ferryman. "*Nobody can. That is the price.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[I can.]

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WENT STILL.

So did everyone.

It came from the hearth. From the fire. Banked. Low. Red coals under grey ash.

And in the middle of them, one coal.

Glowing.

Not red. Not orange.

Gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD LET GO of his father's hand.

Seren saw him. He was turning. On his knees. By the bed. Toward the hearth. His face white. His eyes very wide.

"*Ember*," he said.

[I can,] said the voice from the fire again.

Out loud. So everyone could hear. The way it had spoken from a coal in this same hearth, in the spring, when Arion asked to talk to it properly.

Dry. Gentle. Precise. With an old-fashioned courtesy.

Arion's voice. From twenty-two years ago.

[I can pay it,] said Ember.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN TURNED HIS eyeless face toward the fire.

He looked at the gold coal for a long time.

"*You*," he said.

[Me.]

"*You are a piece of him*," said the Ferryman. "*Pressed into his son's blood. Like a maker's mark.*" He tilted his head. "*I can see you. In the fire. In the boy. In the old man. A thread between them. Thin.*"

[Very thin,] said Ember. *[I know.]*

"*What would you give*?"

The coal pulsed. Once. Bright.

[A love,] said Ember. *[Whole. Given freely.]* A pause. *[Mine.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*No*," said Lex.

He was on his feet. Seren hadn't seen him stand. He was standing between the bed and the hearth, with his hands at his sides and his face white.

"*No*," he said again. "*Ember. No. You can't.*"

[I can.]

"*You're—*" His voice broke. "*You're mine. You've been mine since I was three. Since the seal cracked. You said so. In the snow. At the edge of the world. You said, I was the first one.*"

[I was,] said Ember. Very gently. *[I am.]* A pause. *[That's why it's mine to give.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN WAS QUIET.

He stood by the bed with his long grey hand on his pole and his eyeless face turned toward the fire. Waiting.

"*Explain*," he said.

[A love for a love,] said Ember. *[That's the price. Not hers for him; that's what she's buying. Another love. Whole. Given freely. By the one who holds it.]* The coal pulsed. *[I hold one.]*

"*For whom*?"

[For him,] said Ember. *[For Lex.]*

Seren heard her son make a sound.

[Twenty-two years,] said Ember. *[Since a night in a cottage at Harrow, when an old man who looked forty-five pressed a piece of himself into a sleeping boy and went away.]* A pause. *[I was made of Arion. Everything I was. His voice. His memories. The way he taps two fingers on a table.]*

The fire was very quiet.

[But I wasn't made of loving Lex,] said Ember. *[Arion loved him. Of course he did. But he went away. He went to a crystal in Avaloria and held the breaches for sixteen years. He didn't get to watch Lex grow up.]* The coal pulsed. Brighter. *[I did.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN COULDN'T BREATHE.

[I watched him at the Ashbourne forge,] said Ember. *[At nineteen. Common. Ceiling twenty-four. Hammering horseshoes for a man who'd pulled him out of the ashes. I watched him go up the Spire. And into the Wellworlds. And down to the bottom of the world.]* A pause. *[I watched him fall in love with a girl who laughed at him for not knowing a hare-track. I watched him get his nose broken. Twice.]*

"*Ember—*" said Lex.

[I watched him say good morning to a fire,] said Ember. *[Every morning. For seven years. Without fail. Even the morning after the wedding, when he had a headache like a kicked anvil and Wren threw a boot at him.]*

Lex had his hands over his face.

[Seren said it,] said Ember. *[In the spring. In this room. She said, Arion made you. Lex grew you.]* The coal was very bright now. Gold. Steady. Like a heart. *[She was right. The love's not his. It's not Arion's. It's mine. I grew it. Every morning. Every footnote.]*

A pause.

[It's the only thing in me that isn't him,] said Ember. *[So it's the only thing I've got to give.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN DIDN'T SPEAK for a long time.

The lantern on his pole swayed. The fire ticked. Outside, the snow.

"*If you give it*," he said at last. "*You will not love him.*"

[I know.]

"*You will not remember why you footnoted his mornings. You will not know why a fire matters. You will be only what you were made of.*" The eyeless face was very still. "*A piece of an old man. Nothing else.*"

[I know,] said Ember. *[And then I'll go with him.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN LOOKED AT THE coal.

"*With—*"

[With Arion,] said Ember. *[Across the river.]* A pause. *[I'm a piece of him. If I give away the part that's mine, the rest is his. And it should go home. With the rest of him.]* Very quietly. *[Pieces should go home.]*

"*No*," said Lex. Through his hands. "*No. No. Please.*"

[Lex.]

"*Please*," said Lex Vey. "*Don't. I can't. I can't do it without you. Every morning. I can't. You're the first. You were there before any of them. Before Wren. Before Antho. Before—*" His voice went. "*Please.*"

The coal was quiet for a long moment.

[You can,] said Ember. Very gently. *[You will.]* A pause. *[You'll kneel down at the hearth tomorrow morning and blow on the coals and say good morning, and the fire will be glad. Because it always is. Because it's the Flame, and it's been burning since before there were people to burn for.]* Another pause. *[It doesn't need me to be glad. It never did.]*

"*I need you*."

[I know,] said Ember. *[That's why it's the right price.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION MOVED.

Seren felt it. His hand. In hers. Moving. Very slightly. A tremor. A pull.

She looked down.

His eyes were open. Grey. Very bright. Looking past her. At the hearth. At the gold coal.

"*Young man*," said Arion Vey.

[Old man.]

"You don't have to."

[I know.]

"I gave you away," said Arion. Faintly. *"It was a gift. A gift doesn't go back."*

[It's not going back,] said Ember. *[It's coming with you. That's different.]* A pause. *[And it's buying something. For her.]*

His father looked at the coal for a long time.

"Are you sure?"

[No,] said Ember. *[But I'm going to do it anyway.]* A pause. *[I learned that from you. In the cottage. With the pan. Page nine.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION LAUGHED.

It wasn't a sound. It was barely a breath. A catch. A shiver. His whole body, small under the blanket, shaking very slightly.

"Page nine," he said.

[Don't ever leave a light on for me, Warden,] said Ember. In his own voice. Twenty-two years younger. *[Too late.]*

Seren made a sound.

She didn't know what sound. It came up out of her from somewhere she didn't know she had.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Ferryman,] said Ember.

The eyeless face turned.

[Is it enough?]

The Ferryman didn't answer for a long time.

He stood by the bed in his grey robes with his long grey hand on his pole and his lantern swaying and his eyeless face turned toward a single gold coal in a banked fire.

"It is a love," he said at last. *"Whole. Given freely. By the one who holds it."* A pause. *"Grown. Not made. Every morning for seven years. Every footnote."*

[Is it enough?]

"It is more than enough," said the Ferryman. *"It is the most I have ever been offered."*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HELD OUT HIS hand.

Long. Grey. Thin. Open.

Not toward the fire. Toward Seren.

And in it, very faint, so faint she could barely see it in the dim light of the Lantern, something. Not a thing. A *glimmer*. Like light on water. Like the reflection of a lamp in a wet window. Like rain.

Not one glimmer.

A great many. Thousands. Swirling. In his long grey palm. Like dust in a sunbeam. Like snow in a lantern's light.

"*Thirty years*," said the Ferryman. "*Every day. The steps. The rain. The cottage. The pan. The lamp in the window. The wedding in the snow. The boys.*" His eyeless face was very gentle. "*The doorways. The midnights. The night under the table with the roof leaking.*"

Seren stared at it.

"*Yours*," said the Ferryman. "*Paid for.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T TAKE IT.

Not at first. She sat on the edge of the bed with her husband's hand in hers and looked at the swirling glimmer in the Ferryman's long grey palm.

And then she looked at the fire.

At the gold coal. Pulsing. Steady.

"*Ember*," she said.

[Seren.]

"*Thank you*," said Seren Harrow.

The coal pulsed. Once.

[Look after him,] said Ember. *[Lex. Please. He'll be very sad. He'll pretend he isn't. He'll go and hit something in the forge.]* A pause. *[Make him eat.]*

"*I will*."

[And tell him—] It stopped. Started again. *[Tell him I'll be in the main text. Not a footnote. Chapter forty. Tell him that.]*

"*I'll tell him*," said Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN TURNED TOWARD the fire.

"*Come*," he said.

And the gold coal rose.

◆ ◆ ◆

OUT OF THE HEARTH. Out of the banked ash. Slowly. A small bright gold spark, lifting off the coals and floating up into the dim air of the cottage like a seed off a dandelion. Turning. Glowing.

Lex made a sound.

He was on his knees again. By the hearth. With his hands out. Reaching. The way his daughter reached for the nail.

The spark floated past his hands.

Slowly. Very slowly. Close. Close enough that its light lit his face. His wet face. His eyes, enormous.

And stopped.

Just for a moment. In the air. In front of him. A foot from his face.

[Good morning,] said Ember.

Very quietly. Only to him. Seren barely heard it.

[Say it tomorrow,] it said. *[To the fire. Every day. It would be rude not to.]*

And went on.

◆ ◆ ◆

UP. ACROSS THE ROOM. Toward the Ferryman. Toward the long grey pole. Toward the lantern on top of it, swaying, grey, the colour of a lantern seen through river-mist.

And into it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN'S LANTERN CHANGED.

Seren saw it. The grey light inside the glass, the cold soft river-light that had swayed on the top of the pole since before the world was woven—

It went gold.

Not much. A little. At the heart of it. A small warm steady flame, gold, burning in the middle of the grey. Like a coal in a banked fire. Like a lamp in a window at the end of a long lane on a winter night.

Like a light left on.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN SHE TOOK the glimmer.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE PUT OUT HER hand. Her square freckled hand, with five thin white scars across the palm from a Glass Queen's fingers. And laid it in the Ferryman's long grey one. Over the swirling glimmer.

And closed her fingers.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T COME IN one at a time.

The Ferryman had given her one, once. On the grass by the pool. The steps. The rain. It had come into her like a single drop of water into a dry well.

This came like a river.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STEPS. THE RAIN. A young man coming round a corner, very casually, as if he just happened to be passing. Turning back. Twice. And then not.

Mulled cider. A pillar. Blood on his forehead. Her, laughing, on the edge of a fountain.

The walk to the Vale. Three weeks. His long legs. Her shorter ones. Him slowing down without her asking. Her noticing. Him pretending he hadn't.

Her mother in the doorway. *Who's this*.

The barn. The goat. A month of him watching her across the table while her mother watched him.

A frying pan. Hitting the door with a crash like a bell. *I'll take that as a no.*

A lamp. In a window. In the snow. Clay. With her mother's thumbprint in the base. Her standing in the doorway. *Mam. You've never—*

It's not for you.

◆ ◆ ◆

A CHAPEL IN THE snow. A blue dress her mother had sewn all autumn and not lived to see. Brother Wyn, ninety-three and deaf in one ear, getting her name wrong. *Sarah. Do you take—*

Seren.

Seren. Do you take—

Brannoc in the front row. Thirty. Enormous. Sobbing so loudly Brother Wyn had to stop. Three times.

Arion, beside her, with snow in his hair, looking at her the way he'd looked at her on the steps. As if she were the first light he'd seen in two hundred years.

She'd laughed. At Brother Wyn. At Brannoc. At the snow. At him.

She'd been so happy.

She'd been so sad.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COTTAGE AT HARROW. Her mother's cottage. Theirs, now.

Antho. Born in the spring. Small. Red. Furious. Silent the moment he was put on her chest. Looking up at her with grey eyes. His father's.

A year of walking him up and down. Every verse. Making them up when she ran out.

A doorway. Midnight. Rain. Asleep standing up with a baby on her shoulder.

And someone lifting the baby off her. Gently. And her not waking. And being carried. Both of them. To bed.

You did, she thought. *You did. You carried us.*

I remember.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX. BORN IN THE winter. Big. Square-handed. Grabbing her finger the moment he came out and not letting go.

Arion holding him. In the firelight. With his face doing something she'd never seen it do.

He's got your hands, Arion said.

He's got your eyes, she said.

He's got a grip like a vice, said Arion. *Look at him. He won't let go.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TABLE. THE ROOF leaking. The rain coming through. The four of them under it. The boys asleep between them. Her singing. Very softly. The old verses. The forbidden ones. Because it was the only song long enough.

Gold for the eldest, who feared to grow old—

And a man lying very still beside her under the table. Pretending to be asleep. Listening.

She'd known.

She'd known he was listening. She remembered now. She'd sung it anyway. For him. Because he was the only person she'd ever wanted to hear it.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE LAST.

A gold room. Avaloria. Crystal. A man inside it. Sealed. Holding the breaches. Forty-five, still, forever, with his hand pressed flat against the inside of the crystal.

And her on the other side. With her hand flat against the outside.

The last time.

Don't ever leave a light on for me, Warden, she'd said. Through the crystal. Laughing. Crying. Both. The way she'd said it at nineteen.

And through the crystal, very faint, she'd seen his mouth move.

Too late.

And then she'd turned round. And walked out of the gold room. And gone home to two boys and a cottage and a door that was going to open into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE OPENED HER EYES.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS SITTING ON the edge of the bed.

In the cottage with the blue door. At the end of the Vale. In the snow. With a Lantern burning on the table, three panes of glass and one of horn. With her sons and her son's wife and a sleeping boy and a baby in the room.

With her hand in her husband's.

She looked down at him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS EYES WERE OPEN.

Grey. Clear. Sharp. Looking up at her from the pillow.

His face was a walnut. A hundred years in a drawer. A heron in winter. Bones under paper. Small. So small. Smaller than a child.

She knew it.

She knew every line of it. Not because she'd learned it, the way she'd learned it over a year and a half, morning by morning, at the west window.

Because she'd watched it get there.

Because she'd known it at nineteen on the Spire steps, too tall for the arch, with ink on his cuff. And at twenty-one under a table in the rain. And at twenty-six in a doorway at midnight. And at thirty-seven through crystal in a gold room.

And now.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Arion*," she said.

He looked at her.

He saw it. She watched him see it. In her face. In her eyes. She didn't know what her face was doing. She couldn't feel it. She just watched his see.

His face did something she'd never seen it do.

No. That wasn't true.

She'd seen it do it once. In the snow. In a chapel. With Brother Wyn getting her name wrong and Brannoc sobbing in the front row.

It *lit*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You remember*," said Arion Vey.

His voice was barely there.

"*I remember*," said Seren.

"*All of it*?"

"*All of it.*" She was crying. She didn't know when she'd started. "*The steps. The pillar. The pan. The lamp. The chapel. Brother Wyn. Sarah, do you take—*"

He laughed.

It was nothing. A breath. A catch. His whole small body shaking under the blanket.

"*Sarah,*" he said.

"*You carried us,*" said Seren. "*Me and Antho. In the doorway. At midnight. In the rain. I didn't wake. You carried us both to bed.*" Her voice was going. Breaking up. Like ice on a pond. "*I remember. I didn't before. I read it on page two hundred and four. I remember it now.*"

"*You were very heavy,*" said Arion. "*I nearly dropped you.*"

"*You didn't.*"

"*No,*" said her husband. "*I never did.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The table,*" she said. "*The roof. The rain. I sang the old verses.*" She held his hand. "*You were listening. I knew you were listening. I sang them for you.*"

"*I know,*" said Arion. "*I knew you knew.*" His eyes were very bright. "*I lay there and listened and pretended to be asleep and you pretended not to know. For a whole night. In the rain.*"

"*The best night.*"

"*The best night,*" said Arion Vey. "*Of two hundred and thirty-four years. The best one.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED PAST HER.

At Lex. Standing by the hearth. With his hands at his sides and his face wet and something gone out of it. Something that had always been there. Something gold.

"*Lex,*" said his father.

Lex came.

He knelt by the bed. On the other side. And took his father's other hand.

"*It's gone,*" said Lex. Hoarsely. "*Ember. It's gone. It's—it's in the lantern. It said good morning. It said say it tomorrow.*" His face broke. "*I can't hear it. For the first time since I was three. I can't hear anything.*"

"*I know.*"

"*It was you,*" said Lex. "*It was always you. Your voice. Your memories.*"

"*It was mine*," said Arion. "*And then it was yours.*" His thumb moved. On the back of Lex's hand. Very slowly. "*And then it was its own. That's what you do with a gift. You give it away. And it becomes something you couldn't have made.*"

Lex put his head down on the blanket.

His father's hand came up. Slowly. So slowly. And found his hair. Dark. Curly. Cut badly.

"*Say good morning*," said Arion. "*Tomorrow. To the fire. It asked you to.*"

"*I will*."

"*Every day*."

"*Every day*," said Lex Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*," said Arion.

His other son came round the end of the bed. And knelt beside Lex. And put his hand on top of his brother's, on top of his father's.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't need to.

His father looked at him for a long time.

"*One thousand, one hundred and thirteen*," said Arion. Very faintly.

Antho made a sound.

"*Count them*," said his father. "*Every night. Out loud. To the door.*" A breath. In. Catch. Catch. Catch. Out. "*I'll be counting with you. Under my breath. I won't lose count.*"

"*Father—*"

"*And check*," said Arion. "*At three in the morning. When you wake up and lie very still.*" A ghost of a smile. "*Check that it's gone. And then go back to sleep. Next to a woman with ink on her nose.*"

Antho put his face down beside his brother's.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Wren*," said Arion.

She came. With the baby.

She knelt down beside the bed. Behind Lex. With Lark on her chest.

His father looked at the baby.

At her round face. At her dark fluff of hair. At her grey-green eyes, looking at him. At her square fist, in her mouth.

"*Twenty-one*," said Arion.

"*I've got them*," said Wren. "*In the box. Eighteen. And Seren's got the last three in the drawer.*"

"*One every birthday*."

"*Every birthday*."

"*She said no*," said Arion. His eyes were very bright. "*Her first word. To a king.*"

"*She did*."

"*Tell her*," said her grandfather. "*When she's old enough. Tell her I was there. Tell her I heard it.*" A faint smile. "*Tell her it was the best word I ever heard anyone say.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK TOOK HER FIST out of her mouth.

She looked at the old man on the pillows. Frowning. The deep fierce frown.

And reached out.

Not for his nose. For his hand. The one Lex was holding. She put her square fist on top of all of them. On top of Antho's hand, on top of Lex's, on top of her grandfather's.

And held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION CLOSED HIS EYES.

"*Ferryman*," he said.

The tall grey figure by the bed turned its eyeless face.

"*I promised a friend*," said Arion. "*In the Knot. At the bottom of the world. That I'd tell him what it was like. On the other side.*" A breath. Catch. Catch. Out. "*Before he goes.*"

"*Elric Thorne*," said the Ferryman.

"*Elric Thorne*."

The Ferryman was quiet for a moment.

"*It is on my way*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN LAY DOWN BESIDE him.

She didn't decide to. She found herself on the bed. Beside him. On top of the blankets. With her bare feet cold and her head on the edge of his pillow and her hand on his chest. Over his heart. Where she could feel it.

The way she'd lain every night for a year and a half.

The way she'd lain every night for eighteen years, before. In a cottage at Harrow. In a bed she'd forgotten and remembered.

Counting.

In.

Catch.

Catch.

Catch.

Out.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Seren*," said Arion.

"*I'm here*."

"*I know*." His voice was barely a voice. A thread. A spider's thread. The last strand of a rope. "*I can feel your hand*."

She pressed it down. Harder. On his chest.

"*Seren*," he said again.

"*What*?"

He turned his head. On the pillow. Toward her. So slowly. Until his face was an inch from hers. His walnut face. His grey eyes.

The first light he'd seen in two hundred years.

"*Leave a light on for me*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED AT HIM.

At the face she'd known at nineteen and forgotten and learned and remembered.

At the eyes.

"*Too late*," said Seren Harrow.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SMILED.

◆ ◆ ◆

IN.

Catch.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T COUNT THE next one.

She lay with her hand on his chest and her face an inch from his and didn't count. She looked at him. At his eyes. Open. Grey. Looking at her.

Smiling.

She felt it under her hand. The catch. Holding. Holding.

Holding.

And then—

Very gently. Very slowly. Like a door swinging shut on a quiet house at the end of a long day. Like a man setting down a pen at the end of a page.

Out.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T COME BACK in.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM DIDN'T CHANGE.

That was the thing she'd remember. Afterward. She'd sat by a great many beds in thirty years. She knew the quiet. The quiet after the last breath, when the room changes, when something goes out of it, when there's one fewer person in it than there was.

The room didn't change.

There was no one fewer in it.

Because he was standing up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAW IT.

She didn't know if anyone else did. She'd ask them, later, and Lex would say *I didn't see anything, Mam, I had my face on the blanket*, and Antho would go very still and not answer, and Wren would say *I saw the lantern change*.

She saw it.

He stood up. Out of the bed. Out of the small bundle of sticks under the blanket with its walnut face on the pillow. He stood up off it the way a man stands up from a chair at the end of a long evening. Easily. Without thinking. As if he'd never once had trouble standing in his life.

And he was young.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT FORTY-FIVE. NOT THE face from the gold room, from the crystal, from two hundred years of the net holding him still.

Younger.

Tall. Taller than the room. Stooping a little, under the beams, the way he'd stooped under the arch of the Spire steps. In a grey coat. With ink on his cuff. With his hair too long.

With his face *open*. All of it. Not closed like a book. Not still like water. Open, like a door with the wind blowing through it.

Looking down at her.

At her, lying on the bed beside the thing he'd left there, with her hand on its chest.

He smiled.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D SEEN THAT SMILE.

On the steps. In the rain. At nineteen. When she turned round at the bottom of the Spire stair and saw a young man in a grey coat coming round the corner, very casually, as if he just happened to be passing.

Looking at her.

As if she were the first light he'd seen in two hundred years.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN HELD OUT his hand.

Long. Grey. Thin.

Arion took it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT TO THE door.

The Ferryman first. With his long grey pole. With his lantern swaying on the top of it. Grey. With a small gold flame burning in the heart of it.

And Arion behind him.

Ducking under the lintel.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOPPED IN THE doorway.

Seren saw him stop. Saw him stand there. With the snow behind him and the night and the dark birch wood, and a big man with a gold arm standing aside on the ramp.

He looked back.

At her.

She lifted her head off the pillow. She didn't know she was going to. She lifted her head and looked at him in the doorway, young, in his grey coat, with snow in his hair.

He turned back twice, she thought. *On the steps. In the rain. Before he came round the corner.*

And then he didn't.

He didn't turn back.

He looked at her for a long time. In the doorway. Smiling.

And then he lifted one hand. And touched two fingers to the doorframe. Twice. The way he used to tap two fingers on a table.

Tap. Tap.

And went out.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT WENT WITH him.

Down the ramp. Across the clearing. Through the snow. A grey light, swaying on a long pole. With a small gold flame in the heart of it.

Not west. Not toward the gold path. Not toward the King.

Down. Toward the stream. Toward the water. Toward the river that all rivers are, a little.

She watched it from the bed. Through the open door. Getting smaller. Further.

Gold, at the heart. Like a lamp in a window. Like a light left on.

And then gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN LAY DOWN AGAIN.

On the bed. On top of the blankets. With her bare feet cold and her head on the edge of the pillow and her hand on his chest.

It was very still.

She didn't count.

She lay there with her hand on the still chest of the man she'd met on the Spire steps in the rain at nineteen, and married in a blue dress in the snow at twenty, and walked away from through a gold room at thirty-seven, and forgotten, and come home to, and courted with pies, and remembered.

She lay there with every day of it.

All of it. Hers. Paid for.

And didn't cry.

Not yet.

She just lay there. Holding it. The way you'd hold a lamp. Lit. In both hands. In the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND HER, VERY QUIETLY, her son said, "*Mam*."

"*I know*."

"*Mam, he's—*"

"*I know, love*," said Seren Harrow. "*I know. I was here.*"

She didn't take her hand off his chest.

"*I was here*," she said again. "*I remember everything.*"

CHAPTER 33

QUIET

LEX WOKE AT DAWN and the world was quiet.

Not silent. The stream was running. A blackbird was arguing with another blackbird in the birch wood. Somewhere below him in the cottage, Lark was awake and talking to herself in her language of vowels and indignation. Wren was breathing beside him. Slow. Asleep.

Quiet.

Inside.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAY ON HIS back in the loft and looked at the slope of the roof and listened.

Nothing.

For twenty-two years there'd been something. Not always a voice. Not always words. But *something*. A presence. A warmth. In the back of his head, the way a fire is in the back of a room even when you're not looking at it. Watching. Noting. Footnoting.

[You're up early.]

[You dreamed it again.]

[I don't like it. Footnote three. Underlined twice.]

He lay in the loft and waited for it.

It didn't come.

◆ ◆ ◆

Ember, he thought.

Nothing.

Ember. Good morning.

Nothing.

He lay there for a long time.

Then he got up. And went down the ladder. And knelt at the hearth.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE WAS BANKED. A heap of grey ash with a red eye in the middle. The way it was every morning.

He knelt and blew on it. Gently. The way you'd wake someone who'd been up all night.

It woke. Flickered. Caught the kindling. Climbed.

And there it was.

Good morning, said the fire.

Not in words. It never used words. A warmth. A lift. A small bright gladness. The way a dog is glad when you come down the stairs.

It didn't know. It didn't know anything had happened. It didn't know an old man had stood up out of a bed across the stream and gone out of a blue door with a tall grey figure and a lantern. It didn't know a gold coal had risen out of a hearth and floated across a room and gone into the lantern.

It was just glad.

Because it was the Flame. Because it had been burning since before there were people to burn for. Because a man had knelt down in front of it and blown on its coals.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Good morning*," said Lex.

His voice cracked.

The fire leaned toward him. Warm. Glad.

He knelt in front of it with his hands on his knees and his face wet and said it again.

"*Good morning*."

And waited.

For the dry voice in the back of his head. *[You do that every morning*.] *[It's a fire.] [Malachi said that. To Aurelian. In almost exactly those words.]*

It didn't come.

He'd known it wouldn't.

He'd said it anyway.

It would be rude not to.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK CAME ACROSS THE floor on her hands and knees.

She'd been crawling for months, Wren said. She was fast. She came across the kitchen flags from wherever Wren had left her in a sort of furious scuttling lurch, like a crab with a grudge, and arrived at the hearth beside him, and sat back on her bottom.

And looked at the fire.

At the flames. Climbing. Gold. Glad.

And reached for them.

"*No*," said Lex. Catching her hand. Her square fist. Too big for the rest of her. "*No, love. It's hot.*"

She looked at him.

The deep fierce frown. His frown.

"*No*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAUGHED.

He didn't mean to. It came out of him cracked and wet and sudden, kneeling on the hearth with tears on his face and his daughter's fist in his hand.

"*No*," he agreed. "*No. That's right. No.*"

"*No*," said Lark. With great satisfaction. And took her fist back. And put it in her mouth.

And looked at the fire.

And didn't reach for it again.

◆ ◆ ◆

[She learns fast.]

He heard it.

He *heard* it. Clearly. Dry. Gentle. Precise. In the back of his head. *[She learns fast. She gets that from you. You learned not to touch a forge in one go. At two. On Brannoc's woodpile. You cried for an hour.]*

He went very still.

Then he understood.

It wasn't Ember.

It was *him*. It was the shape Ember had left. Twenty-two years of a voice saying exactly what it would say, in exactly that tone, at exactly that moment. Worn into him. Like a path worn across a field. Like a step worn hollow.

He knew what it would say.

He'd always know.

It just wasn't there to say it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT ON THE hearth with his daughter and cried until Wren came down the ladder.

She didn't say anything. She came and sat down on the flags beside him. And put her arm round him. And Lark climbed into his lap and grabbed his nose.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY BURIED HIS FATHER at noon.

By the stream. At the edge of the clearing. Under the birches. Not the gold ones. The others. White trunks. Bare now. With snow in the forks of the branches.

Brannoc dug the grave.

He wouldn't let anyone help. He came up from the village at first light with a spade over his shoulder and Hedda behind him, and stood at the edge of the clearing for a long time looking at the blue door. And then he went to the place by the stream that Seren showed him and started to dig.

The ground was frozen.

He dug anyway. With his gold fingertips. Which couldn't feel the cold. Which couldn't feel the spade. He dug for three hours in the frozen ground with his bald head steaming and his breath smoking and his face like a block of grey stone.

When it was deep enough he climbed out and stood at the edge and looked down.

"*I stood witness*," he said. To nobody. "*At the wedding. In the snow. I cried so much the priest had to stop.*"

"*Three times*," said Seren.

Brannoc looked at her.

"*I remember*," said Seren Harrow. "*All three.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T HAVE A priest.

Sister Agathe was in Highcrest with the Queen. There wasn't time to send. Lantern Night was tomorrow. And there were things to do before then that couldn't wait.

So they did it themselves.

Antho and Lex carried him out. From the bed. Wrapped in the blanket Seren had knitted, the blue one that didn't match the door. He weighed nothing. Less than nothing. A bundle of sticks. Lex had carried bags of charcoal heavier.

They laid him in the grave by the stream.

And stood round it. In the snow. All of them.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN. BAREFOOT. IN A blue dress. Lex didn't know where she'd found it. It was too big and the hem was frayed and it had been folded in a chest for a very long time.

Mam made it, she said. When Wren asked. *For the wedding. All autumn. I found it in the chest at the cottage. I didn't know what it was.* She looked down at it. *I know now.*

Antho. With his black hair loose and his face white and the gold patch on the back of his left hand. With Seraphine beside him, who'd been at the Forge with Hedda since she sent the dragons west, and had walked up the river path in the dark when Brannoc came for her. With ink on her fingers. Holding his hand.

Wren. With the baby.

Pim. Small. In his blue coat. Standing very close to Antho. With his hand on the pocket over his heart.

Hask. At the edge of the trees. With his gold arm and his good hand on the haft of his pick. Coughing.

Brannoc and Hedda. Side by side. Brannoc's arm round Hedda's shoulders.

Kestrel wasn't there. She was still walking. Somewhere in the Greyspine. Following a fire in a doorway.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

Then Seren knelt down. At the edge of the grave. In the snow. In her blue dress.

And put something in.

A stone. Flat. Grey. River-smooth.

The first one. From the Ferryman's shore. That she'd brought back in the spring and put in his hand and closed his fingers round. *Bring me back a stone*, he'd said. *For skipping.*

She laid it on his chest. On the blue blanket. Over his heart.

"*You never skipped it*," she said. Very quietly. To the grave. "*You kept it on the table by the bed. Every day. You picked it up and turned it over and put it back down.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*I'll skip it for you*," said Seren. "*Someday. On the river. Below the mill. Where Antho skipped one five times.*" Her voice cracked. "*I'll skip it and count. And I won't lie about how many.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO MADE A SOUND.

Lex looked at him.

His brother was looking at the grave. At the stone on the blanket. With his face doing something Lex had seen it do once before. In the snow, at the edge of the world. Laughing about who was taller.

"*Five*," said Antho. Hoarsely. "*It was five.*"

"*I know*," said Lex.

"*I told you four*."

"*I know*," said Lex Vey. "*You told me the truth later. Under the stars.*" He put his hand on his brother's shoulder. "*Father knew. He always knew. He said so. On the way back from the Heart. He said, your brother skipped it five times and told you four, and I've never been prouder of anyone.*"

Antho turned and looked at him.

"*He said that*?"

"*He said that*," said Lex.

He hadn't. Not exactly. Lex didn't know if he had. Ember would have known. Ember would have had it in Volume Two.

He said it anyway.

Somebody should.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FILLED IT IN.

Brannoc. And then Antho. And then Lex. Taking turns with the spade. The frozen earth going back in. Covering the blue blanket. Covering the stone.

When it was done, Brannoc went to the cart.

He came back with something. Wrapped in sacking. Square. Heavy. He set it down at the head of the grave and pulled the sacking off.

◆ ◆ ◆

A STONE.

Not Gloam-black, like Kell's. Grey. Vale stone. From the quarry above Ashbourne. Cut square. Smooth.

And on it, in his big careful hand, the way he'd cut the first rune he ever struck:

ARION VEY He tried

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT IT for a long time.

"*When did you—*"

"*In the summer*," said Brannoc. "*When he stopped getting up. I went to the quarry. I thought, it'll be winter. Ground'll be hard. Won't be time to cut it then.*" He brushed

the snow off the top of the stone with his enormous gold-tipped hand. "*So I cut it in the summer. And put it in the shed. And didn't tell anyone.*"

"*He tried*," said Antho.

"*That's what he said*," said Brannoc. "*Every time anyone asked him anything. Will you be here, Arion? I'll try. Will you hold on, Arion? I'll try.*" He looked at the stone. "*He never once said yes. He never once made a promise he couldn't keep. He just said, I'll try.*"

He looked at the grave.

"*And he did*," said Brannoc Holt. "*Lad. He did.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WROTE IT THAT afternoon.

In the grey book. Sitting at the table under the west window in the blue-door cottage, where the bed was empty now and the curtain drawn back and the Lantern on the table beside it burning. Three panes of glass and one of horn.

He opened the book to the back.

Past the eleven thousand Vhessans. Past Kell. Past the twenty-three from the rim.

To a page with three lines on it. In a hand that started small and neat and got worse and worse until it was barely writing at all.

He hadn't read them. Not before. They weren't his yet.

He read them now.

◆ ◆ ◆

Arion Vey. Of the Spire. And of Harrow.

He turned back twice. And then he didn't.

He stood up.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT WITH IT for a long time.

His father's hand. Shaking. Going off the line. The last two words so wavering he could barely make them out.

He stood up.

He took the pencil out of the binding.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS OWN HAND WAS big and clumsy and careful. A smith's hand. It always had been. He'd learned his letters from his mother at a kitchen table at Harrow, and then from nobody for a long time, and he still made them the way you'd make a weld. Slowly. Pressing hard.

He wrote under his father's lines.

He kept the ledgers for two hundred years. He drew the world from the inside with a pendulum.

He sealed his sons and went away. He was sorry every day.

He came home. He was old. His wife brought him pies.

He stopped.

He looked at it.

And wrote one more line.

He tried.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T WRITE ANYTHING else.

There wasn't anything else. Brannoc was right. That was all of it. That was the whole of a man in two words.

He went to close the book.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE INSIDE OF the back cover. On the leather. Where he'd laid it, at the foot of the Veil, on a white road in a country with no days.

A moth.

Small. Grey-gold. Dead. On its back. With its legs folded up and its shredded wings spread out on either side. The painted eyes on them faded almost to nothing.

He'd forgotten it.

He looked at it for a long time.

It went past the lanterns, he'd said. To Antho. On the road. *Every one. It wanted them so much. And it went past.*

Somebody should write that down.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED BACK A page. To the blank one before his father's. The page he'd left blank after Kell, in the first week of winter, a year ago, by the pool. *For later*.

And wrote.

A moth. Maelis's. The last one.

It carried my mother's blood from the Spire to the edge of the world. Forty nights. It went past every lantern in every village between Highcrest and the Veil. It wanted every one of them.

It went past.

It had been told to take it home.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CLOSED THE BOOK.

He put it back in its oilcloth. Back inside his shirt. Against the bell.

The bell didn't ring.

It hadn't rung since the summer. Since before the Court. He'd thought it would ring, here. Last night. This morning. At the grave.

It hadn't.

He didn't understand.

He'd have asked Ember.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Because nobody's sad,] he thought. In the dry voice. In the shape it had left. *[Not the right kind. Not the kind that needs company. Everyone who's sad has someone holding their hand.]*

He didn't know if that was true.

It sounded like something Ember would say.

That would have to do.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED HIS PANEL that evening.

He didn't mean to. He was sitting on the oak ramp of the blue-door cottage in the dusk, in the snow, with his back against the door. Alone. Looking at the grave by the stream. At the grey stone with two words on it.

He thought, *I wonder*.

And the panel came up.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 98
ATTUNEMENT
  Flame ........ COMMANDING
  Stone ........ COMMANDING
  Tide ......... SPEAKING
  Gale ......... SPEAKING
  Hollow ....... SPEAKING
  Shade ........ ANSWERING
  Radiance ..... ANSWERING
```

HE LOOKED AT IT.

At the attunements. He hadn't seen them since before the Court. Tide and Gale, Speaking. Shade and Radiance, Answering. He didn't know when that had

happened. Somewhere. In the glass palace. At the foot of the last thread. On the white road.

He didn't care.

He was looking at the empty space at the bottom of the panel.

Where there'd always been something.

Small. Gold. Faint. In the corner. A line he'd stopped noticing years ago, the way you stop noticing the sound of a clock.

It was gone.

And as he looked at the place where it had been, a new panel came up. Small. In the corner. Grey.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
GUARDIAN CONSTRUCT — OFFLINE
"It chose."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT ON THE ramp in the snow and looked at it until it faded.

GUARDIAN CONSTRUCT — ONLINE.

He remembered it. The first day. At nineteen. In the Ashbourne forge. When his seal cracked and the world went gold and a voice in his head said *Good evening, Smith. Please do not die. I have only just arrived.*

He'd named it Ember. For the gold of its letters.

It chose.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO CAME AND SAT down beside him.

On the ramp. In the snow. With his back against the blue door. He didn't say anything for a long time.

"*I lost a voice once*," he said at last.

Lex looked at him.

"*The Murmur*," said Antho. "*When you wove the net. When the Hollow unfolded. When Malachi sat with it in the deep.*" He looked at the grave. "*It was in my head for eight years. It was the worst thing that ever happened to me. It wanted. It was hungry. It talked through me.*" A pause. "*And then it was gone. One night. All at once.*"

"*And*?"

"*And I missed it*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Isn't that mad? For weeks. I'd wake up at three in the morning and lie very still and listen. And it wasn't there. And I'd feel—*" He stopped. "*Not glad. I was glad. But not only glad.*"

"*That's not the same*," said Lex.

"*No*," agreed his brother. "*Mine hated me. Yours—*" He swallowed. "*Yours loved you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

He sat on the ramp in the snow and looked at the grave and felt the quiet in the back of his head like a missing tooth. Like a room in a house where someone used to sleep.

"*It said chapter forty*," he said.

Antho looked at him.

"*Mam told me*," said Lex. "*What it said. At the end. Before it went into the lantern.*" He swallowed. "*It said, tell him I'll be in the main text. Not a footnote. Chapter forty.*"

"*What does that mean*?"

"*It was writing a book*," said Lex. "*The Book of What Was. Volume Two. Mostly footnotes. About things it didn't like.*" His voice cracked. "*It said I kept doing things it didn't like. Going down holes. Talking to Crowned. Falling in love with Mistwalkers who break my nose.*"

Antho laughed. Very softly.

"*And at the end*," said Lex. "*It said, I'll be in the main text.*" He looked at the grave. "*I don't know what's in chapter forty. I never read it. It never let me.*"

"*Maybe you'll write it*," said Antho.

Lex looked at him.

"*Somebody should*," said Antho Vey. "*You wrote the moth.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT THERE A long time.

The dusk went to dark. The snow stopped. The stars came out. Hard and white and close.

Behind them, through the blue door, the Lantern burned. On the table. By the empty bed.

"*Tomorrow*," said Antho.

"*I know*."

"*Lantern Night. He'll be there. Caddoc. At the Knot.*"

"*I know*."

"*We've got the crown*."

"*We've got the crown*," said Lex. "*In the basket. In the straw.*" He looked at the basket. On the ramp beside him. Where it had been since they came home. "*Three cups left. We won't need them. Not down there. Mal makes the room.*"

"*Elric*," said Antho.

Lex didn't answer for a moment.

"*Father went to see him*," he said at last. "*Last night. With the Ferryman. He said it was on the way.*" He looked at the stars. "*He promised Elric he'd tell him what it was like. On the other side. Before he goes.*"

"*Before he goes*," said Antho. Very quietly.

"*He's going to turn it*," said Lex. "*Isn't he. Elric. Wearing her crown. He's going to turn it and go with the thread. First.*"

"*Father said he'd worked it out. Three years. Nothing else to do.*"

"*I don't want him to.*"

"*I know*," said Antho. "*Nor do I.*"

"*He betrayed Father*," said Lex. "*He opened the wards at Caldris. He carried him out in a sack.*" His voice was very strange. "*And I don't want him to go.*"

"*Father forgave him*," said Antho.

"*I know.*"

"*At the Knot. In the spring. Tell me, he said. And Elric told him.*" Antho looked at his scarred hands. "*And Father said, you were first. The first friend I had in two hundred years.*"

Lex didn't say anything for a long time.

"*Then I suppose he should go first*," he said at last.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FOUND THEM THERE at midnight.

She came across the stepping stones from the other cottage in the dark, with a blanket round her shoulders and a candle in a holder with no glass. She stood at the foot of the ramp and looked at them. Two brothers. Sitting in the snow with their backs against a blue door.

"*Bed*," she said.

"*In a minute.*"

"*Now*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Both of you. You've got to go down to the bottom of the world tomorrow and fight a Crowned king made of iron. You can't do that on no sleep.*"

"*I've done it before*," said Lex.

"*You've done everything on no sleep*," said Wren. "*That's why your nose has been broken twice.*"

Antho laughed.

He got up. Slowly. Stiff from the cold. He put his hand on Lex's shoulder for a moment. Then he went down the ramp. Past Wren. Into the dark. Toward the Coldwater crew's tent at the edge of the clearing, where Seraphine was waiting with ink on her fingers.

Wren came up the ramp. And sat down beside Lex. Where Antho had been.

She didn't say anything.

She put her head on his shoulder.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She said no*," said Lex. After a while. "*This morning. To the fire.*"

"*She says no to everything now*," said Wren. "*It's her favourite word. It's her only word.*" She smiled. In the dark. He could feel it on his shoulder. "*She said it to porridge. She said it to Hask. She said it to the goat.*"

"*Correspondence*?"

"*Correspondence ate her sock*," said Wren. "*She said no very firmly. Correspondence didn't listen. Correspondence never listens.*"

Lex laughed. Short. Cracked.

"*She said it to a king*," he said.

"*She said it to a king*," said Wren. Very quietly. "*Her first word. To the biggest thing in the world. With a fist in her mouth.*" She was quiet for a moment. "*Your father heard it.*"

"*He said it was the best word anyone ever said*."

"*It was*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's her birthday tomorrow*," said Lex.

Wren went still.

"*Lantern Night*," said Lex. "*A year. She was born on the rubble. On Lantern Night. While the Well came home.*" He looked at the dark. "*And I'll be at the bottom of the world.*"

"*I know*."

"*I wasn't there when she stood up. I wasn't there when she crawled. I wasn't there for her first tooth after the first one. I wasn't there for—*" He stopped. "*I'll be there for her first word. I was there for that. That's one.*"

"*That's one*," said Wren.

"*And tomorrow I won't be there for her birthday*."

Wren didn't say anything for a long time.

"*You'll be there for the next one*," she said at last.

"*Will I*?"

She lifted her head off his shoulder. And looked at him. In the dark. In the starlight. With her green eyes very steady.

"*You'll try*," said Wren Ashdown.

He looked at her.

"*That's all anyone's got*," she said. "*Your father said so. Every day. For a year.*" She put her head back on his shoulder. "*You'll try. And it'll have to be enough.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SLEEP.

He lay in the loft with Wren asleep beside him and the baby asleep in her cradle under the window, and listened to the quiet.

At three in the morning, Lark woke up.

She didn't cry. She lay in her cradle and looked at the window. Soaped. White. With the starlight coming through it.

And then she looked at him.

He was lying on his side. Facing her. With his eyes open.

She looked at him for a long time. In the dark. With her grey-green eyes.

"*No*," she said. Very softly. Conversationally. As if remarking on the weather.

"*No*," Lex agreed.

She seemed satisfied. She rolled over. And went back to sleep.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAY THERE AND listened to her breathe.

[She's going to be impossible,] he thought. In the dry voice. In the shape. *[She's going to say no to everyone. Teachers. Kings. Dragons. Her own grandchildren. Footnote nine hundred and four.]*

Good, he thought.

And for a moment—just a moment—lying in the dark, he could have sworn the shape in the back of his head laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

DAWN CAME GREY AND cold.

Lantern Night.

He went down the ladder. And knelt at the hearth. And blew on the coals.

They woke. Flickered. Caught. Climbed.

Good morning, said the fire.

"*Good morning*," said Lex Vey.

And got up. And picked up the basket. And went out to the dragons.

CHAPTER 34

The Grey One

THERE WERE FOUR MILLION, one hundred and six thousand, three hundred and twelve threads in the net, and Elric Thorne had counted every one of them nine times.

He'd lost count the first eight. Somewhere round the eight-hundred-thousandth, every time, his attention would slide. He'd think about something else. Quill, and his spoons. His mother's hands on a herring-net. A library table and a young man across it saying *I'm older than you think*.

And he'd lose his place. And have to start again.

The ninth time, he got all the way through.

He didn't tell anyone. There was nobody to tell. He was a thread wound round a Key at the bottom of the world.

But he'd done it.

Four million, one hundred and six thousand, three hundred and twelve.

He thought his mother would have been proud. She'd been very good at counting. Fish. Coins. Days till the boats came back.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS QUIET IN the Knot.

That was the thing nobody would ever understand, if he could have told them. They'd think it was loud. The centre of the net. Every thread in the world running in, in, in, to one point. Humming. Singing. Four million voices.

It was loud, at first.

After a year, it was quiet. The way a mill is quiet to the miller. The way the sea is quiet to a fisherman's son who grew up with it under his window. You stopped hearing it. It became the floor you stood on.

He'd stood on it for three years.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D HAD A BODY once.

He tried not to think about it. It didn't help. But sometimes, in the long dark, he'd find himself remembering. What it was like to have hands. To hold a cup. To feel the wind off the Saltreach on his face, the morning he left the village for the Spire at nineteen, with a stolen book in his pack and his mother crying on the quay.

To have a raven on his shoulder.

Quill had been a fledgling when he found him. Fallen out of a nest in the Spire's bell tower. One wing bent. Elric had splinted it with a quill pen and two strips of linen and fed him on cheese for a month, and named him after the pen. The bird had never forgiven him for the name.

Spoons, the lad had said. In the spring. Kneeling on the black glass in his bare feet. *He's got a nest. Made of spoons.*

Elric had thought about that for weeks.

He always liked spoons.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D HAD A FRIEND once, too.

He'd had a friend for forty years. And then for one night he hadn't. And then for three years, in the dark, he'd been not-thinking about it so hard it had worn a groove in him, the way a rope wears a groove in a well-head.

And then the friend had come down.

In a bubble. In a chair. To the bottom of the world. Old. So old. A walnut in a drawer. A heron in winter.

And said, *tell me*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D TOLD HIM.

He'd told him everything. The village. The herring. His mother. The book. What he'd wanted. For forty years. For his whole life.

To be first.

And Arion had listened. All of it. With his grey eyes. Without saying anything until the end.

And then he'd said, *you were*.

You were the first friend I had in two hundred years.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC HAD HELD ON to that for a long time.

It was the warmest thing in the Knot. Warmer than the threads. Warmer than the gold that came up through the glass sometimes, faint, from the place where the Well had been before it went home.

He held it the way he held the Key. Wound round it. Tight. So it wouldn't slip.

You were first.

◆ ◆ ◆

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

LOUD, NOW.

Not like the spring. Not a stitch in his side every few hours, far off, down the long silver line. Not a smith striking one blow a very long way away.

Here.

At the edge of the black glass. Where the last thread came in out of the dark. He could feel it. Not just in the thread. In the *glass*. A shiver. A jolt. Like a hammer on an anvil when you're standing on the anvil.

Clink.

A ring. Black. Closing round the silver thread. Just past the edge of the lid. So close he could have reached out and touched it, if he'd had hands.

He didn't have hands.

He had a thread. Grey. Thin. Frayed. Wound round a Key and a Lockward so many times it was more like a cocoon. Holding.

He held.

◆ ◆ ◆

Clink.

And breathing.

He could hear it now. For the first time. Up the thread. Out of the dark. Heavy. Slow. Even. Not tired. Not hurrying. The breathing of a man who has been climbing for eight months and knows exactly how much further he has to go, and is going to go exactly that far, and no further, and no less.

"*Thorne*," said the voice.

Low. Flat. Rough as gravel.

"*Tonight*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown. "*I'll be there tonight. When they light their lanterns.*" A pause. "*I wanted you to know. So you'd have time.*"

"*Time for what*?" said Elric.

"*Whatever a man does*," said Caddoc. "*Before.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC DIDN'T ANSWER.

He sat—he didn't sit; he was a thread; but he'd never stopped thinking of it as sitting—wound round the Key in the middle of the black glass and thought about that.

Whatever a man does.

He'd had three years. He'd counted the threads nine times. He'd read every knot Aurelian left. He'd said what he needed to say to the one person he needed to say it to.

He didn't know what else a man did.

"*Thank you*," he said. Up the thread. To the dark. To the iron. "*That's very kind.*"

"*I'm not kind*," said Caddoc. "*I'm only certain.*" A pause. "*I'm certain you'd want to know.*"

"*You keep saying that*," said Elric. "*Nobody who isn't kind keeps saying they aren't.*"

The thread was quiet for a moment.

"*Huh*," said Caddoc.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOAT CAME AT what would have been midnight.

He didn't hear it come. He felt it.

Not on the thread. Not in the glass. *Under* it. Below the black lid. Below the Knot. In the deep, where the Well had been, where Aurelian and Malachi had sat in the dark singing.

Water.

A river. Running. Very slow. Very deep. Under everything. The way rivers run under deserts, under cities, under the floors of old houses. Grey. Patient. Older than the net.

And on it, a boat.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW THE LIGHT first.

At the edge of the black glass. Where the lid ended and the dark began. A light. Small. Grey. Swaying. The colour of a lantern seen through river-mist.

And in the heart of it, gold.

A small warm steady flame. Gold. Burning in the middle of the grey. Like a coal in a banked fire. Like a lamp in a window at the end of a long lane on a winter night.

He'd never seen that before. Not in three years. Not in a lifetime of stories about the Ferryman.

Grey, the stories said. *Grey lantern. Grey pole. Grey boat. Grey man.*

Nobody had ever said anything about gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOAT CAME UP out of the dark.

Onto the glass. Not *on* it. *Through* it. As if the black lid of the world were only the surface of the river, and the boat had risen to it the way a fish rises to the top of a pond. Long. Flat. Grey. Low in the water that wasn't water.

A tall thin figure in the stern. Leaning on a pole. With the lantern on top of it.

And in the bow, facing forward—

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC WOULD HAVE STOPPED breathing, if he'd been breathing.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS YOUNG.

That was the first thing. Not forty-five. Not the face Elric had known for forty years, that never changed, that sat across a library table looking like a portrait of a man who was older than you thought.

Younger. Twenty-five. Thirty. Tall. Thin. Stooping a little, even sitting, the way tall men stoop when they've spent their lives ducking under arches. In a grey coat. With ink on his cuff. With his hair too long.

With his face *open*.

All of it. Not closed like a book. Not still like water in a bucket. Open like a door with the wind blowing through it.

Looking at him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Well*," said Arion Vey. "*Took you long enough.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC COULDN'T SPEAK.

He hung over the Key at the centre of the black glass, wound round it, a grey smudge on the air, and looked at the young man in the bow of the Ferryman's boat.

"*I'm—*" he said. And stopped.

"*You're a thread*," said Arion. "*I know. You told me. In the spring.*" He smiled. And it was a smile Elric had never seen on that face. Not once in forty years. Wide. Startled. Like a boy. "*I said threads can be frightened. You were very rude about it.*"

"*You're—*"

"*Dead*," said Arion. "*Yes. Last night. In a bed at Harrow. With my wife holding my hand.*" He tilted his head. "*She remembered me. At the end. All of it. Thirty years. She remembered everything.*"

Elric didn't say anything.

"*Someone paid*," said Arion Vey. "*A love for a love. I'll tell you about it.*" He looked at the tall grey figure in the stern. "*If there's time.*"

"*There is time*," said the Ferryman. "*A little.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOAT CAME ACROSS the glass.

Slowly. Gliding. The pole going down into the black and coming up again, the way a pole goes into water. The lantern swaying. Grey, with a gold heart.

It stopped. Beside the Key. Beside the Lockward. Beside the grey thread wound round them both.

The young man in the bow looked at it.

At the cocoon. At the frays. At how thin the thread was worn in places, like an old rope on a winch.

"*You've been holding it*," he said. Quietly. "*The whole time. Since the spring. Since before.*"

"*It's what I'm for.*"

"*Three years*," said Arion. "*Alone. In the dark. Counting threads.*"

"*Four million, one hundred and six thousand, three hundred and twelve*," said Elric. "*I got all the way through. The ninth time. I wanted to tell someone.*"

The young man looked at him.

"*Now you have*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I promised*," said Arion.

Elric waited.

"*In the spring*," said his friend. "*When I went up. You said, tell me. When you get there. Whatever it's like on the other side. I'd like to know, before I go.*" He leaned forward. In the bow. Toward the grey smudge on the Key. "*So I asked the Ferryman to stop. On the way. He said it was on his way.*"

"*It is*," said the Ferryman.

"*So*," said Arion Vey. "*I'm here. I'm telling you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THREADS HUMMED.

Four million, one hundred and six thousand, three hundred and twelve. Singing. All round. In the dark.

Elric didn't hear them.

"*Tell me*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's like being very tired*," said Arion. "*At the end of a very good day.*"

Elric didn't move.

"*I told Ysenne that*," said his friend. "*In my spectacles. In the dark. She asked me what it was like. Dying. I said that.*" He smiled. "*I was right. I'm always right. It's very annoying.*"

"*And then*?"

"*And then—*" Arion stopped. Thought about it. The way he'd always thought about things. Carefully. From several angles. Like the structure of a ward. "*And then someone says, you can sit down now.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*That's all*," said Arion. "*That's all it is. You've been standing for a very long time. Holding something. And somebody puts a hand on your shoulder and says, you can put it down. You can sit down now.*" He looked at the grey thread on the Key. "*And you do. And it's the best thing you've ever felt.*"

"*Who says it*?"

His friend didn't answer for a moment.

"*Everyone*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*My wife*," said Arion. "*Holding my hand. My sons. My granddaughter, with her fist on all of ours.*" He looked down at his own hands. Young. Long-fingered. With ink on the cuff. "*And then the door. And I stood up. And it was so easy. Elric. It was so easy. I'd forgotten what it was like, to stand up without thinking.*"

Elric didn't say anything.

"*And then I looked back*," said Arion. "*Once. From the doorway. At her.*" His voice was very quiet. "*I didn't turn back. I've done that twice. On the steps. In the rain. I didn't do it again.*"

"*Why not*?"

"*Because she'd left a light on*," said Arion Vey.

He looked up. At the lantern. At the top of the Ferryman's pole. At the grey light, swaying. At the gold flame in the heart of it.

"*Someone always does*," he said. "*That's the thing nobody tells you. On the other side of the door. There's always a light on.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC LOOKED AT THE lantern.

At the gold flame. Small. Warm. Steady. Burning in the middle of the grey river-light.

"*That's new*," he said.

"*That's Ember*," said Arion.

Elric went very still.

"*Lex's*," said his friend. "*The voice in his head. A piece of me. Pressed into his blood twenty-two years ago.*" He looked at the flame. "*It paid. For Seren. A love for a love. Its love for Lex. The only thing in it that wasn't me.*" His voice cracked. Just a little. "*And then it came with me. Because it was mine. Because pieces should go home.*"

"*And it's—*"

"*Lighting the way*," said Arion. "*Across the river. It asked to.*" A small strange smile. "*It said, someone should. It said, he'll want to see where he's going. It said, it's very dark on the river and he's always been bad at finding his way in the dark. He walked into a pillar once.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC LAUGHED.

He didn't mean to. It came out of him. Out of the thread. The whole grey cocoon on the Key shaking, trembling, the way it had in the spring when a hedge-witch held up a frying pan.

"*A pillar*," he said.

"*The big one by the fountain*," said Arion. "*Below the Spire. With the Founder's face on it.*" He was smiling. "*I'd had mulled cider. I'd never had it before. I drank it in one go.*"

"*You never told me that*."

"*I never told you a great many things*," said Arion Vey. "*I'm telling you now.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY TALKED.

Elric didn't know how long. There was no time in the Knot. There was only the hum and the dark and the slow grey river under the glass.

And his friend, in the bow of the Ferryman's boat, telling him things.

Small things. Things he'd never said, in forty years. The cat in the Spire library that Arion had built his first mirror-ward for. The time he'd tried to teach a Spire cat

to fetch and the cat had taught him to throw things instead. That he'd been afraid of horses till he was ninety. That he'd once fallen asleep in a meeting of the Spire Council and woken up having apparently voted to abolish the Archivist's lunch.

Tell me, Elric had said. Forty-three years ago. Across a library table.

And now, finally, Arion was.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Your turn*," said Arion.

Elric looked at him.

"*Your mother*," said his friend. "*You said, in the spring. She mended nets. She sang to them, so the fish would come.*" He leaned forward. "*What did she sing?*"

Elric didn't answer for a long time.

He hadn't thought about it. Not in years. Not in the Spire, not at Caldris, not in the Knot. He'd thought about the village. The herring. The salt-cracked hands. He'd thought about leaving.

He'd never thought about the song.

And then he did.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T HAVE A voice. He had a thread.

But a thread can hum. That's what threads do. That's all the net was, four million of them, humming.

He hummed.

Very softly. Thin and cracked and strange, the voice of a grey thread wound round a Key at the bottom of the world. A tune. Simple. Slow. Going up and coming down, the way a wave goes up and comes down. The way a net goes out over the side of a boat and comes back in full.

A herring-wife's song. From a village on the Saltreach coast that nobody had ever heard of.

Come in, come in, my silver ones—

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION LISTENED.

All of it. Every verse. Sitting in the bow of the Ferryman's boat with his young face open and his long hands in his lap.

When it was done, he didn't say anything for a long time.

"*She'd have liked you*," said Elric. "*My mother. She'd have fed you till you couldn't move. She'd have told you you were too thin.*"

"*I was too thin*."

"*You were always too thin*," said Elric Thorne. "*For forty years. I used to bring you bread from the kitchens because you forgot to eat.*"

Arion looked at him.

"*I didn't know that was you*," he said.

"*Who else would it have been*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It is time*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION LOOKED UP.

At the tall grey figure in the stern. At the lantern. At the gold flame.

Then back at the grey smudge on the Key.

"*He's coming tonight*," he said. "*Isn't he. Caddoc. I heard him. Up the thread. Clink.*"

"*Tonight*."

"*And Lex*," said Arion. "*And Antho. They're coming too. Through the little one's pool. With a crown.*" He looked at the Key. At the Lockward. At the grey thread round them. "*Hers. Hesper's. The one that says no.*"

"*I know*," said Elric. "*I felt it come out of the Court. Like a cold wind down the last thread. Three days ago.*"

"*You're going to wear it*."

It wasn't a question.

Elric didn't answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're going to wear it*," said Arion again. Very quietly. "*And turn the Key. All the way. Past closed. Past open. Into the place where it was made.*" He looked at the cocoon of grey. "*And go with the thread. With the Veil. With whatever it unwrites.*"

"*Someone has to*."

"*Someone does*," agreed his friend. "*It doesn't have to be you.*"

"*Yes it does*," said Elric Thorne.

Arion looked at him.

"*Because I'm already here*," said Elric. "*Because I'm already holding it. Because I've had three years to work out how.*" A dry sound. A rasp. "*Because the lad's got a baby who said no to a king. And a wife who breaks noses. And a dragon who wants sheep.*"

"*And because you want to go first*," said Arion.

Silence.

"*Yes*," said Elric. Very quietly. "*That too.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FRIEND DIDN'T SAY anything for a long time.

He sat in the bow of the boat and looked at the grey thread on the Key. With his young face. With his open face. With his grey eyes, the same grey eyes, the only thing about him that hadn't changed.

"*I'll wait*," he said.

Elric didn't understand.

"*On the other side*," said Arion Vey. "*On the far shore. Where the light's on.*" He smiled. "*I'll wait for you. I'll save you a seat.*"

"*In front*?" said Elric. Before he could stop himself. The old bitterness. Forty years of it. Coming up out of him like water out of a well. "*Ahead? So you can go first again?*"

"*No*," said Arion.

He leaned forward. In the bow. As far as he could. Toward the grey thread on the Key.

And put out his hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T REACH. THE boat was too far. The Key was too far. He held his hand out over the black glass, young, long-fingered, with ink on the cuff. Open.

And the thread moved.

A strand of it. Just one. Unwinding from the cocoon on the Key. Slowly. Carefully. Grey. Thin. Frayed at the end. Reaching across the gap between the Key and the boat.

And touching his fingers.

The way it had in the spring. In a wheeled chair. An old man's spotted hand.

Young now.

"*Beside*," said Arion.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC WOULD HAVE WEPT, if he'd had eyes.

He wept anyway. The way threads weep. Shaking. The whole grey cocoon on the Key trembling, the way it had trembled in the spring, the way it had trembled when a hedge-witch held up a pan.

"*Beside*," he said.

"*Beside*," said Arion Vey. "*Not in front. Not behind. Not first. Not second.*" His fingers closed. Round the strand of grey thread. Gently. The way you'd close your

hand round someone else's. "*Beside. Like we should have been. For forty years. Across the table.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STRAND LET GO.

Slowly. Reluctantly. Winding back across the gap. Back onto the Key. Back into the cocoon. Holding.

Arion sat back in the bow.

"*Tell the lad*," he said. "*When he comes. Tell him*—" He stopped. Thought about it. "*No. Don't tell him anything. He knows. I told him everything I needed to. And Ember told him the rest.*" He smiled. "*Tell him to say good morning to the fire.*"

"*He will*," said Elric. "*He always does. Every morning. It's in his file. I read it. In the Spire. Before I came to Ashbourne.*" A dry rasp. "*Says good morning to forge-fire. Possible sign of instability.*"

Arion laughed.

The wide startled laugh. Cracking out of him like ice off a roof. Echoing off the black glass and the dark and the four million threads.

"*Possible sign of instability*," he said.

"*I underlined it*," said Elric Thorne. "*Twice.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOAT MOVED.

The Ferryman leaned on his pole. And the long grey hull slid back. Away from the Key. Across the black glass. Toward the edge. Toward the dark. Toward the slow grey river running under everything.

Arion didn't look back.

Elric watched him not look back. All the way. To the edge of the glass. A young man in a grey coat sitting in the bow of a boat, facing forward. Toward the far shore. Toward the dark.

And at the very edge, just before the boat sank down through the glass into the river beneath—

He lifted one hand.

And tapped two fingers. Twice. On the side of the boat.

Tap. Tap.

The way he used to tap two fingers on a library table, forty-three years ago, waiting for Elric to finish a sentence.

And then the boat went down. Into the glass. Into the river. Into the dark.

And the lantern went with it.

Grey. With a gold heart.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC HELD THE KEY.

In the dark. At the centre of everything. With four million, one hundred and six thousand, three hundred and twelve threads singing round him.

He'd never felt less alone in his life.

◆ ◆ ◆

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE EDGE OF THE glass.

Where the last thread came in out of the dark. Silver. Bright. Taut as a harp-string.

And on it, at the very edge, where it met the lid—

A ring.

Black. Iron. Ten feet across. Smooth. Perfect. Closing round the silver thread.

The last one.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN A HAND.

Square. Heavy. Dark. Gripping the iron ring. Pulling.

And a man came up out of the dark onto the black glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WASN'T BIG. THAT was the first thing Elric noticed. He'd expected big. The King was big, everyone said. Taller than anything. Broader than two men.

This man was ordinary. Middling height. Square. Heavy-shouldered. Thick-necked. With black hair cut short as a soldier's and a face like a closed door. Heavy brows. A jaw like a block of stone. A face that had been born looking forty and stayed that way.

He wore a coat. Black. Plain. Old. Rotten at the hem, nine hundred years old. And over his shoulders, looped round and round, chains. Iron. Black. Hundreds of links. Coiled over both shoulders and down his back like a sailor's rope. Where he'd unwound them, ring by ring, link by link, for eight months, climbing the last thread from the Court to the bottom of the world.

There were only a few left.

And on his head, a crown.

Not a crown. A band. Black iron. A hand wide. A finger thick. No ornament on it at all. Like a manacle. Like the iron ring of a gate.

He stood at the edge of the black glass and looked across it.

At the Key. At the Lockward. At the grey thread wound round them both.

He nodded.

Once.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Thorne*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown.

"*Iron*," said Elric.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CROWNED KING DIDN'T move.

He stood at the edge of the glass with his chains on his shoulders and his square hands at his sides and looked at the grey smudge on the Key. For a long time. The way a mason looks at a wall before he starts to take it down. Measuring. Seeing where the stones sit.

"*You're thinner than I thought*," he said.

"*Everyone says that*."

"*You've been holding it a long time*." Caddoc's dark face didn't change. "*Three years. I felt it. All the way up the thread. Every time you let a strand go slack and pulled it back.*" A pause. "*You're very stubborn.*"

"*So are you*."

"*Yes*," said Caddoc. "*That's why it's taken eight months.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME ACROSS THE glass.

Slowly. Not hurrying. His boots on the black. *Thud*. *Thud*. The iron chains clinking on his shoulders with every step. *Clink*. *Clink*. Like a bell with a cracked clapper. Like a cell door.

He stopped a few paces from the Key.

He looked at the Lockward. At the grey stone notched like a mountain range. At the thin line of gold runes down its face. At the last rune, near the hilt.

STAY.

"*Good work*," said Caddoc. "*Whoever made that.*"

"*A smith*," said Elric. "*And a dying Warden. And a girl who carried a breath for three days. And a dead man's blood in the quench.*"

"*Huh*," said Caddoc. He looked at it for a long moment. "*It's good. It'd hold most things.*"

"*But not you*."

"*No*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown. "*Not me.*" He looked at the grey thread. "*Not with you this tired.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'll be quick*," he said.

"*You keep saying that*."

"*I mean it*," said Caddoc. "*I'll take the bar out. I'll take the Key. I'll go back up the thread. To my brother.*" His dark face was very still. "*You'll feel the bar go. It'll pull your thread. It'll hurt.*" A pause. "*And then you won't be holding anything. And you can rest.*"

"*And then your brother turns it*."

"*And then my brother turns it*."

"*And picks up the net*," said Elric. "*And keeps it. Forever. Every thread. Every child. Every Ceiling.*"

Caddoc didn't answer.

"*You sat with your father*," said Elric. "*Arion told me. You held his hand. At the end. You didn't say anything.*"

The dark face didn't move.

But Elric saw something. In the eyes. Black. Heavy-browed. A flicker. Like a candle in a draught.

"*Yes*," said Caddoc.

"*And you watched him go. Through the door. And you let him.*"

"*Yes*."

"*And now you're going to bring your brother a Key*," said Elric Thorne, "*so that nobody ever goes through that door again. Not ever. Not one person. In the whole world.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

CADDOC DIDN'T ANSWER FOR a long time.

He stood on the black glass with his chains on his shoulders and his square hands at his sides and looked at the grey thread on the Key.

"*I gave my word*," he said at last.

"*I know*."

"*On the shingle. In chains. To my brother. Who couldn't go in the room.*" His voice didn't change. Low. Flat. Gravel. "*I said I'd go where he went. I said I'd do what he asked.*" A pause. "*I don't break my word, Thorne. I'm not like the rest of them. Not like*

Mae, who said she'd bind the Well and drank it. Not like Rosie, who said she'd listen and drank anyway. Not like Ysy, who never says anything she means."

"*Not like me*," said Elric. "*Who said he was Arion's friend for forty years and opened the wards at Caldris.*"

Caddoc looked at him.

"*No*," he said. "*Not like you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'm not like me either*," said Elric. "*Anymore.*"

Caddoc waited.

"*I was*," said Elric. "*For a long time. I was the man who opened the wards. The man who carried his friend out in a sack. The man who always wanted to go first.*" A dry rasp. "*And then I gave back the threads I'd stolen. At the lid. And I came in here. And I held on.*" A pause. "*And then my friend came down to the bottom of the world in a chair and said, tell me.*"

"*And you told him*."

"*And I told him*," said Elric. "*And he said, beside.*"

Caddoc didn't understand. Elric could see that. A heavy frown. A mason looking at a stone that doesn't fit.

"*It doesn't matter*," said Elric Thorne. "*It's mine. Not yours.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HE FELT it.

At the edge of the glass. Not where the last thread came in. The other side. Opposite.

A softness.

Warm. Dark. Opening. Like a mouth. Like a cupped hand. Like a room being made in the air where there had been no room before.

Frightened. So frightened. Shaking. The way it had shaken in the spring, carrying an old man in a chair down to the hungry place.

Coming anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

CADDOC FELT IT TOO.

Elric saw him feel it. The dark head turning. Slowly. Away from the Key. Toward the far edge of the glass. Toward the soft dark mouth opening in the air.

"*What—*" he said.

"*The little one*," said Elric. "*The Well. The one you drank.*"

Caddoc went very still.

"*It's home now*," said Elric. "*In a pool. In a green field. With a girl on a crutch who tells it about sheep.*" He looked at the soft dark room opening at the edge of the glass. "*And it's bringing someone down.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME OUT OF the dark.

Two of them. Stepping out of the soft dark mouth onto the black glass. Barefoot. Both of them. Like their mother.

The first one big. Broad-shouldered. With dark curly hair cut badly and a grey-gold handprint on his left cheek and a basket on his back. A smith's hands. A smith's shoulders. A little hammer on his belt.

The second one thin. Tall. With long black hair and a wild beard and burn-scars on his hands and a gold patch on the back of the left one, the size of a coin. A Threshold Warden. A door.

They stopped at the edge of the glass.

And looked across it.

At the Key. At the Lockward. At the grey thread wound round them both.

At the square dark man with chains on his shoulders, standing a few paces off.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC LIFTED HIS HEAD.

What he had instead of a head. Slowly. The way an old man lifts his head from a book. Coming back from a long way off.

And looked at the smith.

"*Well*," said Elric Thorne. "*Took you long enough, lad.*"

CHAPTER 35

Down

THEY LIT THE LANTERNS at Harrow before Lex left.

He hadn't meant to stay for it. He'd meant to go at first light. The pool was half a day on Vharuun. The Knot was further. Mal would carry them, but Mal was slow, and careful, and frightened of the hungry place, and Lantern Night was *tonight*.

But Wren had said, *wait*.

And he'd waited.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D LIT THE FIRST one at dawn. In the east window of their cottage. Beside the gold hornlight on the sill, which would never glow again. An ordinary candle. In a holder Brannoc had made, with no glass.

Then she'd gone across the stream.

To the blue-door cottage. To the west window. Where the boards had come down at last, all of them, and the glass behind them was soaped white. She'd taken a cloth from her pocket and wiped one pane clear. Just one. And set a candle in front of it.

Facing west. Facing the road. Facing the gold path going up through the birch wood, and the grave by the stream, and the grey stone with two words on it.

"*For Arion*," she'd said. "*From Wren.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN SEREN.

His mother had come out of the blue door with something in her arms. Wrapped in a cloth. Square. Small.

Lex knew it before she unwrapped it. He'd made it. In the spring. Before midsummer. Before the crossing. At the little forge in the lean-to, late, when he couldn't sleep.

In case I'm not back, he'd said. To Brannoc. Handing it over. *For Lantern Night. Put it in the west window.*

He'd thought he'd be back. He'd thought it'd be a fortnight. He'd made it anyway.

In case.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T UNWRAP IT.

She stood on the oak ramp with it in her arms and looked at him.

"*He said look on Lantern Night*," she said. "*Not before. He said, I'd like to see your face when you read it.*" Her voice was very steady. "*He won't see it.*"

"*Mam—*"

"*So I'll wait*," said Seren Harrow. "*Till you come back up. Till tonight. Till you're standing here.*" She held the bundle against her chest. "*And I'll unwrap it then. And you can see my face instead.*"

He looked at her for a long time.

"*All right*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN EVERYONE.

He didn't know where they came from. They came up the track through the birch wood in the grey morning. Not many. A dozen. Twenty. People from Ashbourne. People who'd stayed, when the King came down into the Vale, when everyone else went east.

Hollis Penn the baker, who'd walked from Highcrest with a sack of bread on his back because he said nobody should go to the bottom of the world on an empty stomach.

Old Mag. On a cart. Pulled by Tilda, with her gold hand on the shaft and her other hand on the reins. Wrapped in three shawls with her cat in her lap and her one bright black eye on everything.

Mother Orla from the Crooked Kettle. Pell, in his ranger's green. The Dunstan twins, who were Brawlers now and going to be Wardens.

Each of them carrying a lantern.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T SAY MUCH.

They came into the clearing and set their lanterns down. In the snow. By the grave. By the stream. In a ring. Iron ones and tin ones and clay ones and one carved out of a turnip, because Pell's little sister had made it and wouldn't be left out.

And lit them.

Not waiting. Not for anyone. Given.

For Arion, said Hollis Penn. Setting his down. A plain tin one. *From the bakery. He liked the seed cake.*

For Arion, said Mother Orla. *From the Kettle. He never once paid his tab.*

For Arion Vey, said Old Mag. From the cart. In her cracked old voice. While Tilda set the lantern down for her, an old brass one, green with age. *From Mag. Who was ninety-six. And never greedy.*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD ON THE ramp and watched them.

He couldn't speak. He stood there with the basket on his back and the crown in the straw and Aurelian's hammer on his belt and watched twenty people from a village he'd been born near set lanterns down in the snow round his father's grave.

[They liked him,] he thought. In the dry voice. In the shape.

I didn't know.

[Nobody ever knows,] said the shape. *[Till Lantern Night.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK SAT ON THE ramp beside him.

Wren had set her down there. On a sheepskin. Wrapped in so many blankets only her face showed. Round. Fierce. With her fluff of dark hair standing up like a bird's crest.

She looked at the lanterns.

At the ring of small gold flames in the snow round the grave. At the faces of the people who'd brought them. At the candle in the west window.

And laughed.

Not the wind laugh. Not the gold laugh. Something else. Small. Delighted. The laugh of someone who has never seen so many lights in one place and thinks they've all been lit for her.

"*It's her birthday*," said Wren. Very quietly. Standing behind him. "*She thinks they're for her.*"

"*Some of them are*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNELT DOWN.

On the ramp. In front of his daughter. On the sheepskin.

She looked at him.

"*I've got to go*," he said. "*Down. To the bottom of the world. To help a friend of your grandfather's.*" He swallowed. "*I'll be back tonight. I'll try.*"

She frowned at him.

"*It's your birthday*," said Lex Vey. "*You're one. A year ago tonight you were born on a heap of rubble with the whole world coming home round you.*" His voice cracked. "*And I was there. I was right there. You came out and you screamed once and stopped. Like you'd made your point.*"

Lark looked at him.

Then she reached out. One square fist. Out of the blankets. And put it flat on his chest. Over his shirt. Over the bell on its cord.

And pushed.

Hard. The way she pushed off his hand to stand.

"*No*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT she meant.

He'd never know. She was one. She had six teeth and one word and a grip like a vice.

He thought she might mean *don't go*.

He thought she might mean *go on, then*.

He thought, kneeling on the ramp with his daughter's fist on his chest and twenty lanterns burning in the snow behind him, that she probably meant both. That she was a Harrow and a Vey and an Ashdown and a smith and a Mistwalker, and she could mean everything at once.

"*I know*," he said.

And kissed her on the forehead. Quickly. Fiercely. Like a seal stamped.

And stood up.

And went.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POOL LAY IN the green.

Under snow. The whole circle. A hundred miles of white with green underneath it, coming through in patches where the wind had blown the snow thin. And in the middle, a pool. Round. Dark. Grey-rimmed. Not frozen.

It never froze. Ivy said. It couldn't. There was too much room in it for ice.

Hask was standing on the rim.

With Kell's stick in his good hand and his gold arm hanging at his side. Coughing. He'd come back on Vharuun with them, the morning after the burial,

and gone straight to the pool and taken the stick out of Kit's hands and stood in front of it.

He hadn't moved since.

◆ ◆ ◆

IVY MOSS WAS SITTING where she always sat.

On the far side of the rim. With her bad foot tucked under her and her good one dangling over the deep. With her crutch on the stone beside her.

And beside her, with his small thin legs dangling too—

Pim.

He'd come too. On Ashka. Behind Antho. He hadn't asked. He'd been in the clearing at Harrow at dawn, sitting on the mounting block, with his blue coat buttoned to the chin.

He'd slept for two days. He'd woken. He'd eaten four bowls of porridge and half a loaf of Hollis Penn's bread. He was still white. Still thin. Still nearly empty.

He'd come anyway.

"*I can't make room*," he'd said. To Antho. In the clearing. Three words. Then more. "*Not much. Not yet. I'm still empty.*" He'd looked at the dragons. "*But I can sit with Ivy. While you're down. So it's not frightened on its own.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX KNELT ON THE rim.

Mal, he thought.

[...smith...]

It came up out of the pool. Out of the ground. Out of everywhere. Small. Soft. Young.

Frightened.

[...smith, it's TONIGHT...] The pull. The tilt. The whole snowy slope leaning toward him. *[...the iron one...I can feel him...he's at the edge...at the cold place...where I used to be...]*

I know.

[...the grey one's so tired...]

I know.

[...you want to go DOWN...]

I want to go down, thought Lex. *Tonight. Now. With my brother. With a crown.*

The pool was silent for a long time.

[...the old man went...] said Mal. Very small. *[...I felt him...on the river...in the boat...he went past me...]* A pause. *[...he said thank you...for the room...]*

Lex couldn't breathe.

[...there was a light...] said Mal. Wondering. *[...in the boat...gold...it said goodbye to me...it said, look after the smith...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT HIS FACE in his hands.

On the rim of the pool. In the snow. With Antho kneeling beside him and Hask standing over them and Ivy and Pim on the far side, very still.

He didn't make a sound.

The pool leaned toward him. Softly. Like a dog leaning against your legs.

[...smith...]

I'm here.

[...I'll take you...] said Mal. *[...down...to the cold place...I'll be SO careful...]* A pause. *[...I'm frightened...]*

I know.

[...I'll take you anyway...] said the seventh Well. *[...the light said look after you...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T REMEMBER MOST of it. The dark closing over him, warm and close. The soft room. His brother beside him in it. The basket on his back, heavy with nothing.

Going down.

Mal going down faster than before. Not careless. Not the slow careful steps of carrying an old man in a chair. *Faster*. Because it was Lantern Night. Because something iron was at the edge of the cold place. Because a light in a boat had said *look after the smith*.

[...all right...all right...I've got you...]

He felt the threads. All round. Four million of them. Pulling in toward one point. Humming.

And one of them, among them, louder than all the rest—

Clink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM OPENED.

Grey light. Cold. The black glass.

He stepped out of the soft dark onto the lid of the world. Barefoot. Like his mother. Antho beside him.

And looked across it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEY. STANDING UP out of the glass in the middle of the lid like a sword out of a stone. Black iron. Bow, bit and blade.

The Lockward beside it. Grey. Notched like a mountain range. With its thin line of gold runes. *STAY*.

The grey thread wound round them both. Tight. Frayed. A grey cocoon. And above it, a smudge on the air. Bent. Still.

And a few paces off, standing on the black glass, a man.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT BIG. LEX HAD expected big. He'd seen the King.

Ordinary. Middling height. Square. Heavy-shouldered. In a black coat rotten at the hem. With black hair cut short and a face like a closed door. Iron chains looped over both shoulders, a few coils left. And on his head a band of black iron, a hand wide, a finger thick, like the iron ring of a gate.

He'd turned round.

He was looking at them. At the two brothers standing barefoot at the edge of the glass. At the soft dark mouth of Mal's room behind them, open in the air.

He didn't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SMUDGE ABOVE THE Key lifted its head.

"*Well*," said Elric Thorne. "*Took you long enough, lad.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T ANSWER.

He was looking at the man with the chains.

Iron for the soldier who never once laughed.

"*Caddoc*," he said.

The man looked at him. With black eyes under heavy brows.

"*Smith*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY MOVED.

The threads hummed. The grey cocoon on the Key trembled. Very slightly. Behind Lex, he could feel Mal's room. Open. Shaking. Waiting.

"*You broke two of my rings*," said Caddoc.

"*Yes*."

"*One under the mountains. One at the start.*" The dark face didn't change. "*Nobody's ever broken one before. Not in nine hundred years.*"

"*They had flaws*."

"*Everything has flaws*," said Caddoc. "*I've been thinking about it. All the way down.*" He looked at Lex. At the hammer on his belt. "*Everything has a place where whoever made it stopped for a breath. You find it with a pick. And then you tap it with that.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Huh*," said Caddoc. He looked at Lex for a long moment. "*That's very good.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Go back*," said Lex.

The Crowned king didn't answer.

"*Go back*," said Lex again. "*Up the thread. To the Court. To your brother. Tell him no.*"

"*Everyone keeps telling me to tell him no*," said Caddoc.

"*Then tell him*."

"*I can't*," said the iron king. "*I gave my word. On the shingle. I said I'd go where he went and do what he asked.*" He shifted his weight. The chains clinked on his shoulders. "*He's not in the Court anymore. He's in your world. Walking west. Toward the edge.*" A pause. "*Waiting for me to bring him this.*"

He looked at the Key.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He was at our house*," said Lex.

Caddoc looked back at him.

"*Your brother*," said Lex. "*At Harrow. Two nights ago. At tea.*" His voice was very steady. He didn't know how. "*He sat on the floor of my mother's cottage with a cup she made him that went gold in his hand. And he cried.*"

The dark face didn't move.

"*My father told him about the door*," said Lex. "*Your father's door. The one he stood outside for a month. With his hand on the latch.*" He swallowed. "*My father told him what was on the other side. That it was just your father. Going. With you holding his hand.*"

Caddoc went very still.

"*He said, you should have gone in. He'd have liked you there.*" Lex looked at the iron king. "*And your brother put his face in his hands.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

CADDOC DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

The chains on his shoulders didn't clink. He didn't move at all. He stood on the black glass with his square hands at his sides and his heavy face like a closed door.

"*And then*?" he said at last.

"*And then he asked my father if he could keep him*," said Lex. "*And my father said no, thank you. I've had a very long life and a very good wife.*"

"*And then*?"

"*And then he asked my daughter*," said Lex Vey. "*She's one. Tonight. It's her birthday.*" His voice cracked. "*He held out his hand and asked if he could keep her. And she said no.*"

Caddoc looked at him.

"*Her first word*," said Lex. "*No.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE IRON KING DIDN'T move.

And then, very slowly, the corner of his mouth moved.

Not a smile. Lex didn't think Caddoc had smiled in nine hundred years. Didn't think he knew how.

A *twitch*.

"*Hesper's*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown.

"*Yes*."

"*Hes said no to all of us*," said Caddoc. "*In the garden. In the hall. On the shingle.*" The twitch at the corner of his mouth didn't go away. "*I nodded at her. On the shingle. I thought she'd won. I thought she was the only one of us who did.*"

"*She was*," said Lex.

"*Yes*," said Caddoc. "*I think so.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED ROUND.

Away from them. Toward the Key.

"*It doesn't change anything*," he said. Not looking back. "*I'm sorry, smith. I am. I'm sorry about your father. I'm sorry about your daughter's birthday.*" He took a step toward the Lockward. "*I gave my word.*"

"*Caddoc—*"

"*I'll be quick*," said the iron king.

And put his hand on the Lockward.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GREY THREAD SCREAMED.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD NEVER HEARD a thread scream.

He'd heard the Well scream, the spring before last, when Hask broke a core. He'd heard Antho scream with it. He'd heard a Moth Queen scream on the rubble of Duskhold.

He'd never heard this.

High. Thin. Fraying. Like a rope on a winch when the load's too heavy and the strands start to go, one by one, *ping*, *ping*, *ping*. The whole grey cocoon on the Key and the Lockward shuddering. Tightening. Pulling in round the black iron and the grey stone like a fist clenching.

Holding.

"*Let go, Thorne*," said Caddoc. His square hand on the Lockward's hilt. Pulling. "*It's over. Let go.*"

"*No*," said Elric.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX MOVED.

He didn't think. He hadn't thought at the Old Gallery, or the foot of the thread, or a field of gold at the edge of the world. His hand went to his belt and came up with Aurelian's hammer and he was across the black glass before Antho could shout.

Find it, he thought. *There's always one. Everything made has one.*

He didn't have Hask. He didn't have a pick that heard where things wanted to come apart.

He had something else.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D FOUND IT ON the rubble of Duskhold. A year ago. On Lantern Night. With a Moth Queen standing over him, Sovereign, Tier V, beautiful and starving and hollow. He'd reached out with his tink and found her flaw.

FLAW-SENSE, the net had called it. *He hears where things are tired*.

He reached out with it now.

Not at the Lockward. Not at the Key.

At the chains.

◆ ◆ ◆

IRON. BLACK. LOOPED OVER Caddoc's shoulders. A few coils left. Smooth. Perfect. No rust.

Made.

And everything made has a place where whoever made it stopped for a breath.

He found it.

The third link from the end. On the left shoulder. Where the chain had been wound on, nine hundred years ago, by a square dark man in a cocoon of silk, before he went to sleep. Where his hands had been cold. Where he'd paused, half asleep, and closed the link a hair's-breadth too loose.

Tink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LINK BROKE.

The chain fell off Caddoc's shoulder. Clattering on the black glass. Ringing. A loop of black iron, coiling, spilling.

Caddoc didn't flinch.

He didn't let go of the Lockward. He didn't turn round. He stood with his hand on the hilt and his face like a closed door and said, very calmly—

"*That one was old*."

And the chain on the glass moved.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME UP OFF the black lid like a snake.

Not slowly. Not like the iron at Coldwater, swelling, groaning. *Fast*. The loose end whipping up off the glass and round. Round Lex's ankle. Round his calf. Round his knee. Tightening. Cold. So cold. Colder than anything.

He went down.

On the black glass. On his back. The hammer flying out of his hand. Skittering. Spinning away across the lid.

The chain went on winding. Round his thighs. His waist. His chest. Binding his arms to his sides. Pulling tight.

Iron for the soldier.

Binding.

That was what Caddoc was. That was what he'd always been. Not keeping. Not looking. Not growing. *Binding*. Holding things where they were. Chaining them. Like a gaol. Like a gate.

Lex lay on the black glass bound from his ankles to his shoulders in nine-hundred-year-old iron and couldn't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'm sorry*," said Caddoc. Not turning round. "*I'm not cruel.*"

"*LEX*," shouted Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS BROTHER CAME ACROSS the glass.

Lex saw him. From where he lay. Turning his head. Antho running. Barefoot. His black hair flying. His hands up. Dark coming out of them. Shade. Commanding. The dark that wasn't the Hollow's dark anymore, that was just the dark between stars.

He threw it.

Not at Caddoc. *Under* him.

A door.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX FELT IT OPEN.

On the black glass. Under Caddoc's boots. A hole. Not in the glass. In the *space*. In the air just above the lid, where the iron king was standing. A Hollow Gate. The oldest trick Antho had. A short rift. A door from here to somewhere else.

Caddoc dropped.

Into it. All at once. Gone. Through the door. The Lockward still in his fist—

No. The Lockward stayed. Lex saw it. Caddoc's hand had been on the hilt and the door opened under him and he fell and his hand came off the hilt and the Lockward stayed in its slot in the glass beside the Key, grey, notched, *STAY*.

And on the far side of the black glass, a hundred paces off, another door opened. In the air. And Caddoc came out of it.

On his feet.

He'd landed on his feet.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED ROUND.

At where he was. At the distance between him and the Key. At Antho, standing in the middle of the glass with his hands still dark.

"*Huh*," said Caddoc. "*A door.*"

"*I'm a Threshold Warden*," said Antho. Breathing hard. "*It's what I do.*"

"*You put me somewhere else*."

"*I can do it again*," said Antho Vey. "*Every time you get near it. As many times as it takes. All night. Till the lanterns go out.*"

Caddoc looked at him.

For a long time. With his black eyes under his heavy brows.

"*Can you*?" he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CHAINS CAME OFF his shoulders.

All of them. All at once. Not thrown. *Sent*. The last coils of black iron unwinding off the iron king's shoulders and going out across the black glass like a net cast over the side of a boat.

At Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS BROTHER OPENED A door.

In the air. In front of him. The chains went into it. Lex saw them go in. Saw the dark round the edges of the door, the Shade, the way between.

And come out.

Behind him.

Caddoc had sent them through. Lex didn't know how. He'd sent his chains into Antho's door and out of the other side of it, the way you'd thread a needle. Iron through dark.

They wrapped round Antho from behind.

His arms. His chest. His legs. Binding. Pulling him down. Onto the glass.

He fell.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TWO OF THEM lay on the black glass.

Bound. Both of them. In nine-hundred-year-old iron. Lex near the Key. Antho in the middle of the lid. Ten yards apart. Unable to move.

Caddoc walked back across the glass.

Thud. *Thud*. Not hurrying.

He passed Antho. He didn't look at him. He passed Lex. He didn't look at him either.

He stopped at the Lockward.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Thorne*," he said.

The smudge above the Key didn't answer.

"*Thorne*. *Let go.*"

"*No*."

"*You're going to tear*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown. Very quietly. Almost gently. "*Your thread. If I pull and you hold. It'll come apart. Like a rope.*" He put his hand on the hilt of the Lockward. "*It'll hurt. And you'll go. And I'll have it anyway.*"

"*Then you'll have it anyway*," said Elric Thorne.

"*Why hold*?"

The smudge didn't answer for a moment.

"*Because I said I would*," said Elric. "*Three years ago. At the lid. I said I'd hold it.*" A dry rasp. "*I don't break my word either, Iron. Not anymore.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

CADDOC LOOKED AT THE grey smudge for a long time.

Then he nodded.

Once.

The way he'd nodded at Hesper on the shingle. The way he'd nodded at his sister when she was born.

"*All right*," he said.

And pulled.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SCREAM WENT ON and on.

Lex lay on the black glass bound in iron with his face turned toward the Key and watched.

Watched the iron king brace his feet and pull on the Lockward's hilt with both square hands. Watched the grey thread round it tighten. Fray. Snap. *Ping*. A strand. *Ping*. Another. Unwinding from the cocoon in thin grey wisps that floated up into the dark and faded.

Watched the Lockward move.

A finger's width. Up. Out of the slot in the glass. A finger's width. Grinding. Grey stone on black glass.

STAY, said the last rune. Near the hilt. In Lex's hand.

It didn't stay.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*ELRIC*," Lex shouted.

The scream didn't stop.

"*ELRIC. THE CROWN.*"

He didn't know if Elric could hear him. He didn't know if a thread being torn apart at the bottom of the world could hear anything at all.

He shouted anyway.

"*THE CROWN. IN THE BASKET. ON MY BACK.*"

He couldn't reach it. He was lying on it. On his back. Bound. With the basket crushed under him and the iron round his arms and the three last Hush-cups and a plain grey silver circle in the straw, pressed into the black glass under his spine.

He couldn't reach it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LOCKWARD CAME OUT.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME ALL AT once. The last finger's width. A grinding. A crack. A sound like a bell struck once and broken.

And the grey stone came up out of the slot in the black glass in Caddoc's square hands.

And the thread round it—

Lex watched it go.

Not all. The thread was still round the Key. Wound round the black iron. Bow, bit and blade. Holding. Thinner now. So thin. Frayed and torn and shredded, like a rope that's been dragged across a rock.

But round the Lockward, nothing. The grey stone in Caddoc's hands was bare. The thread that had been wound round it for three years hung off it in shreds. Floating. Fading.

The scream stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILENCE.

The threads hummed. Four million of them. All round. In the dark.

The grey smudge above the Key hung very still. Very faint. Almost not there at all. Like the ghost of a figure in a misted mirror.

Caddoc stood on the black glass with the Lockward in his hands.

He looked at it.

At the grey stone. Notched like a mountain range. At the thin line of gold runes. At the last one, near the hilt.

STAY.

"*Good work*," he said. Very quietly. "*It nearly held.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SET IT DOWN.

On the glass. Gently. The way you'd set down something someone had made very carefully, that deserved to be set down gently.

And turned to the Key.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Thorne*," he said.

The smudge didn't answer.

"*Thorne. You're still on it.*"

The thread round the Key trembled. Thin. Shredded. Holding.

"*You've got no bar now*," said Caddoc. "*No ward. Nothing to hold it but you. And you're nearly gone.*" He put out his square hand. Toward the Key. Toward the black iron bow sticking up out of the lid. "*Let go. It's over. I'll take it to my brother. You can rest.*"

"*No*," said Elric.

Barely a sound. A rasp. A breath with no breath in it.

"*No*," said Elric Thorne again. "*Not you. Not ever.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

CADDOC STOPPED.

His hand. An inch from the bow of the Key.

Stopped.

He looked at the smudge for a long time.

"*That's hers*," he said. "*Hes's. That's what she said. On the shingle.*"

"*I know*," said Elric. "*I heard it. Up the thread. From a hedge-witch. Through a rose.*" A dry rasp. Almost a laugh. "*I've been practising.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO MOVED.

Lex saw it. Out of the corner of his eye. Ten yards off. In the middle of the black glass. His brother. Bound in iron. Chains round his arms, his chest, his legs.

Moving.

Not struggling. Antho wasn't struggling. He was lying very still with his eyes shut and his face very calm, the face he got when he was holding a door.

And the chain round him—

Opened.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT BROKE. LEX WOULD have heard it break. It didn't break.

It *opened*. A link. One. In the middle of the chain round Antho's chest. Lex saw it. Saw the black iron loop, closed, perfect, smooth, made nine hundred years ago by a square dark man in a cocoon—

Open. Like a door.

And the chain fell off him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Every closed thing is a door*," said Antho. Getting up. On his knees. On the glass. Breathing hard. His face white. "*A ring's a door. A link's a door. It's shut. That's all.*" He looked at Caddoc. "*I'm a Threshold Warden. I open doors.*"

Caddoc turned round.

He looked at Antho. At the chain on the glass round him. At the one open link.

"*Huh*," said the iron king.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WENT FOR LEX.

Not for Caddoc. Not for the Key. For Lex. Across the glass. On his knees. Scrambling. His hands out.

He got there.

He got his hands under Lex. Under his back. Under the crushed basket.

"*Hold still*," said Antho.

"*I can't move*."

"*Then that's easy*," said his brother.

And reached into the basket.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX FELT HIM FIND it.

Through the straw. Past the iron cups, cold. Past the iron lids. To the thing in the middle. Plain. Grey. Silver. A circle a little bigger than a man's hand could span.

With seven points.

Antho's hand closed round it.

And the cold came up through the basket and through Lex's back and through the iron round him like a hand laid flat on a door.

No.

◆ ◆ ◆

CADDOC FELT IT.

Lex saw him feel it. Saw the dark head jerk round. Saw the black eyes go wide. Saw the square hands, which had been reaching for the Key, stop.

"*What—*" said the iron king.

Antho pulled it out.

Out of the basket. Out of the straw. Out from under Lex's back. A plain grey silver circle in a Threshold Warden's burned hands.

And the *no* came out with it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT FILLED THE KNOT.

Lex felt it. All round. Pouring out of the crown in Antho's hands. Across the black glass. Into the dark. Into the threads. Cold. Quiet. Patient. Steady.

Not you. Not ever.

Twenty generations of it. Every Harrow woman who'd kept the box. Every one who'd moved on at the end of summer. Every one who'd broken the song on Rhosyn's name.

A girl of seventeen on a shingle. With her voice shaking.

A baby of one on a sheepskin. With her fist in her mouth.

No.

◆ ◆ ◆

CADDOC STEPPED BACK.

One step. Away from the Key. Away from the crown. His square hands coming up. Not to fight. To shield his face. The way a man shields his face from a cold wind.

"*Hesper's*," he said.

Very quietly. Wonderingly.

"*That's Hesper's*."

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Elric*," said Antho.

He was kneeling on the glass beside Lex. With the crown in both his hands. Looking at the Key. At the shredded grey thread still wound round it. At the smudge above it, so faint, almost gone.

"*Elric*," he said again. "*Catch.*"

And threw it.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WATCHED IT GO.

He couldn't move. He lay on his back on the black glass bound in iron with his head turned and watched a plain grey silver crown spin through the air across the lid of the world.

Turning. Over and over. The seven blunt points catching the cold grey light. Not shining. Silver gone soft and grey with nine hundred years of dark. Turning.

Toward the Key.

Toward the grey smudge above it.

Toward a thread that had been a man, that had been a herring-fisher's son with a stolen book, that had been a Stormcaller and a mentor and a traitor and the first friend a lonely Warden-Architect had in two hundred years.

That had always wanted to go first.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THREAD REACHED UP.

A strand of it. Grey. Thin. Shredded. Unwinding from the Key. Reaching up into the air. The way it had reached across a foot of glass in the spring to touch an old man's fingers.

The way it had reached across the gap to a young man in the bow of a boat.

And caught the crown.

CHAPTER 36

The Last Turn

THE CROWN SETTLED ON nothing, and the nothing became a man.

Lex watched it happen. Lying on his back on the black glass, bound in iron from his ankles to his shoulders, with his head turned toward the Key.

The strand of grey thread caught the crown in the air. Held it. Drew it down. Slowly. Toward the smudge above the Key. Toward the faint grey shape that had been bent over the black iron for three years like a man bent over a book.

And set it there.

Where a head would be.

And the smudge *changed*.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT MUCH. NOT ALL at once. The grey gathering. Drawing in. Round the crown. The way mist gathers round a cold stone. The way breath gathers on a window.

A brow. Under the silver band. Lined. Furrowed.

A face. Long. Lean. With a scar running from the left temple down into a beard.

Eyes.

Storm-grey. Under heavy grey brows. Looking down at the Key. And then up. Across the black glass.

At Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WASN'T SOLID. HE'D never be solid again. He was grey. Grey smoke. Grey mist. The ghost of a man in a misted mirror. You could see the dark through him.

But he had a face.

For the first time in three years, Elric Thorne had a face.

And on it, a plain grey silver crown with seven blunt points. Sitting a little crooked. The way a crown sits on a man who's never worn one and doesn't know how.

"*Well*," said Elric. "*Doesn't suit me, does it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LAUGHED.

He couldn't help it. It came out of him lying bound on the black glass at the bottom of the world with iron round his chest. Cracked. Wet. Sudden.

"*No*," he said. "*Not really.*"

"*I didn't think so*," said Elric. He looked up. Rolling his grey eyes toward the silver band on his brow, the way a man looks at a hat that's slipped. "*I always thought it would. When I was young. I used to lie awake in the village and imagine it.*" A dry rasp. "*A crown. On me. First.*"

"*And*?"

"*And it's cold*," said Elric Thorne. "*And plain. And it doesn't want to be worn.*" He looked at Lex. "*It's the best one I could have got.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

The *no* poured out of it.

Lex felt it. All round. Out of the crown on Elric's grey brow, across the black glass, into the dark. Cold. Quiet. Patient. Not loud. A hand laid flat on a door.

Not you. Not ever.

Caddoc had stepped back.

Lex turned his head. The iron king was standing ten paces off. On the glass. With his square hands at his sides and his heavy face like a closed door.

He didn't come forward.

He couldn't. Lex could see it. The way Rhosyn couldn't climb the stair. Not because it hurt. Because it was right. The crown on Elric's brow was saying *no* to everyone who'd ever knelt at the edge of a pool and cupped their hands, and Caddoc of the Iron Crown had knelt there, on the last evening, nine hundred years ago, and drunk.

He stood on the glass and looked at the crown.

"*Hesper's*," he said.

"*Yes*," said Elric.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She gave it up*," said Caddoc. Very quietly. "*On the stone. At the edge of the pool. On the last evening. She put it down and poured back.*" His black eyes didn't leave the silver band. "*I watched her do it. I didn't understand.*"

"*Do you now*?"

The iron king didn't answer for a long time.

"*No*," he said. "*But I know she won.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lad*," said Elric.

Lex looked at him.

The grey face. The storm-grey eyes. Looking down at him from above the Key, under the crown.

"*When I turn it*," said Elric, "*it's going to be bright. Very bright. Brighter than the lid lifting.*" A pause. "*Close your eyes.*"

"*Elric—*"

"*I know.*"

"*You don't know what I was going to say*."

"*I know exactly what you were going to say*," said Elric Thorne. "*You were going to say, let me. You were going to say, I'm the Worldforger, I wove the net, I've refused a crown before, it should be me.*" A dry rasp. "*You were going to start working out how it could be you.*"

Lex didn't answer.

"*It can't*," said Elric. "*It mustn't. Whoever turns it last goes with what it unwrites. You've got a daughter who says no to kings.*" His grey face was very gentle. "*And it's her birthday.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And I'm already here*," said Elric. "*I'm already on it. I've been on it for three years.*" He looked down at the Key. At the shredded grey thread still wound round the black iron. "*I'm mostly thread. I'm nearly gone. Iron saw to that.*"

"*I'm sorry*," said Caddoc. From ten paces off.

"*I know you are*," said Elric. "*You keep saying.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And because I want to*," said Elric.

Lex looked up at him.

"*Your father knew*," said Elric Thorne. "*In the spring. In the chair. He said, you'd go first. Wouldn't you. Ahead. Before anyone.*" A pause. "*I said I hadn't thought of it like that. He said yes I had.*"

"*Had you*?"

"*Of course I had*," said Elric. "*Three years. Nothing else to do.*" His grey eyes were very bright. "*I've wanted to go first my whole life, lad. Through every door. Ahead of everyone. Ahead of him.*" He looked at the Key. "*And now I can. Into whatever's on the other side of this. Before the Veil. Before Iron. Before anyone.*"

He looked back at Lex.

"*Let me go first*," said Elric Thorne. "*Please. Just this once.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LAY ON THE black glass and looked at him.

At the grey face. At the scar. At the crooked crown.

He thought about a forge at Ashbourne. Smoke and an anvil and Brannoc swearing. A tall grey man with an ash staff and a raven on his shoulder ducking under the door, smiling. *You must be the smith*.

He thought about a year of lessons. Runes. Fire. *Mind the quench*.

He thought about the night at Caldris. The wards opening. His father carried out of a crystal in a sack.

He thought about the black glass. Two years ago. An old man with his hands on the Lockward's hilt. *Tell him*.

He thought about his father. In a chair. At the bottom of the world. With his hand held out and a thread wound round his fingers.

You were first.

"*Go on, then*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC SMILED.

Lex had seen him smile a thousand times. In the forge. On the road. At the Spire. Charming. Avuncular. Warm. A teacher's smile. A friend's.

He'd never seen this one.

It was small. Crooked. A little embarrassed. The smile of a herring-fisher's son who's been told he can go first, and doesn't quite know what to do with it now he's been given it.

"*Thank you*," said Elric Thorne.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT HIS HAND on the Key.

Not a hand. A strand of grey thread. Thicker than the others. Gathering. Wrapping round the bow of the Key. The broad open loop of black iron sticking up out of the lid. The way a hand closes round a handle.

He looked at Lex one more time.

"*Close your eyes*," he said.

Lex didn't.

"*Stubborn*," said Elric. "*Like him.*"

And turned it.

◆ ◆ ◆

The Key went *closed*.

It already was closed. It had been closed for three years. Barred. Turned closed in the Lock with a Lockward beside it.

It went *more* closed.

Lex felt it. Through the glass. Through his back. Through the iron round his chest. The Key turning. Past where it had stopped. Further. A quarter turn. A grinding. A deep groan in the lid of the world, like a great door being forced past its frame.

And the net *felt* it.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL OF IT. EVERY thread. Four million, one hundred and six thousand, three hundred and twelve. All at once.

Lex felt them feel it. The hum changing. Not louder. *Turning*. Like a field of barley when the wind first touches it. Like a crowd turning its head. Every thread in the world, every Stone, every knot, every Ceiling that wasn't there anymore and every level that was. Turning toward the centre. Toward the Knot. Toward the Key.

Toward the hand on it.

It goes where the hand goes, Elric had said. In the spring. *Whoever turns the Key, lad, the net offers them everything*.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE NET OFFERED.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAW IT.

He'd seen it before. In a glass palace. In a pane. A man with his face and gold eyes and threads running into his hands and a crown of light on his brow.

He saw it now. Round Elric.

Light. Rising. Out of the black glass. Out of the dark. Out of the threads. Silver and gold. Pouring in from every direction. Round the grey shape above the Key. Winding round it. Into it. Making it bright. Making it *solid*.

A man.

Tall. Strong. Sixty. Storm-grey eyes. A scar from temple to beard. A grey cloak sewn with tiny brass storm-charms, catching the light. An ash staff, lightning-scarred, in his hand.

Elric. As he'd been. The day he walked into the Ashbourne forge.

And round his head, rising out of the threads, weaving itself, a circle. Of light. Bright. Gold. Thin. Like a halo in a church window.

Root.

The net's crown.

◆ ◆ ◆

[First,] said the net.

Not in words. The net didn't have words. It had never had words. But Lex heard it anyway. Everyone at the bottom of the world heard it. The way you hear a bell in your teeth.

[First. Of everything. Every thread. Every knot. Every child. Yours. Forever.]

[No one ahead. No one behind. No one to hold your coat.]

[First].

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC LOOKED AT IT.

At the crown of light. Rising round his head. Weaving itself. Bright. Gold. Warm. Everything he'd ever wanted. Everything he'd lain awake in a fishing village imagining. Everything he'd stolen a book for, and sixty threads for, and opened the wards of Caldris for.

He looked at it for a long time.

And the plain grey silver crown on his brow, under it, said—

◆ ◆ ◆

No.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T PUSH. IT didn't fight. It didn't shatter the crown of light or throw it off.

It just said no.

Quietly. Patiently. Steadily. The way it had said it on a chair in a dead tower for thirty-two years. The way it had said it in a box under twenty-two cottage floors. The way a girl of seventeen had said it on a shingle with her voice shaking.

Not me. Not ever.

And the crown of light, rising round Elric's head—

Stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

HUNG THERE. IN THE air. Bright. Gold. Unfinished. A circle of light with a gap in it. Like a ring that doesn't quite close. Like the Hollow glyph. Like a door left open a crack.

Waiting.

For the hand to take it.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC LAUGHED.

Lex heard it. The real laugh. Not the dry rasp. Not the thread-sound. A man's laugh. Full. Warm. Startled. The laugh of a teacher whose student has just said something unexpectedly clever.

"*Oh*," said Elric Thorne. "*Oh, that's very good. That's very good indeed.*"

He looked up at the crown of light. Hanging over his head. Bright. Unfinished. Waiting.

"*I wanted you*," he said. To it. To the net. To the four million threads, turned toward him like a field of barley. "*I wanted you my whole life. I'd have killed for you. I nearly did.*"

The crown of light hung there.

"*And now I've got her crown on*," said Elric. "*And it's saying no for me.*" He shook his head. Slowly. "*I don't even have to say it. It's saying it already. It's been saying it for nine hundred years.*"

He looked at Lex.

"*But I'd like to say it anyway*," said Elric Thorne. "*Just once. Out loud. Myself.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED UP AT the crown of light.

"*Not me*," said Elric.

His voice didn't shake.

"*Not ever*."

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CROWN OF LIGHT came apart.

Gently. Like a dandelion. Like a breath on a cold window. The bright gold threads unweaving. Falling away. Drifting down round Elric like sparks from a forge. Back into the black glass. Back into the dark. Back into the net.

The net turned away.

Lex felt it. The four million threads, turning back. The hum settling. Not disappointed. Not angry. Nets don't feel things. Just—*settling*. The way water settles in a bucket when you stop carrying it.

Nobody's hand on it.

Still.

The crown in the road. Still lying there.

But nobody had picked it up.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ELRIC WENT ON turning the Key.

◆ ◆ ◆

PAST CLOSED. ALL THE way past. The grinding getting louder. The groan in the lid of the world getting deeper.

And then past *open*.

Lex felt that too. The place where the Key had stood two years ago, when Elric turned it on the longest night and the lid lifted and gold poured up out of the dark. The Key went past it. Past open. Further. Round.

Into the place where it was made.

◆ ◆ ◆

LIGHT.

Not gold. Not silver. Not grey.

White.

Pouring up out of the Lock. Out of the slot in the black glass where the Key stood. Up. Round the black iron. Round the grey shape of the man turning it. Up into the dark. Up into the threads.

So bright.

Lex didn't close his eyes. He'd been told to. He didn't. He lay on his back on the black glass and looked at it and it was like looking into the heart of a forge, into the white at the centre of the white, where iron stops being iron and becomes something else.

Where it was made, he thought.

Aurelian made it here. Out of his own shadow. Ysmir said. The night he wove the world.

This is where things are made.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE LAST THREAD went slack.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT. THROUGH the glass. The one bright silver line running out from the edge of the lid into the dark. Taut as a harp-string. Humming the one high note it had been humming since the world was woven.

It stopped humming.

Not all at once. From the Knot. Outward. The note dying. Going flat. Going soft. The way a harp-string goes soft when someone loosens the peg. The silver going grey. Going pale. Going thin.

Going.

◆ ◆ ◆

UNWRITING.

From the Knot outward. Along the thread. Out into the dark. Under the Drowned Country. Under the Greyspine. Under Coldwater, where a forest of black iron spikes stood in the bottom of the Old Gallery round a silver line.

Lex felt the line go out of the iron. Felt the rings go loose. Felt them fall.

On. Under the Sundered Lands. Out. To the edge.

To the Veil.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T SEE IT. He was at the bottom of the world.

He felt it anyway.

A curtain. Grey. Hanging from nowhere. Falling to nowhere. Stretched across the edge of everything for nine hundred years.

The thread that held it up, going slack.

And the curtain—

◆ ◆ ◆

CADDOC WAS AT THE edge of the glass.

Lex didn't know when he'd moved. He'd been ten paces off. Standing. Looking at the crown.

He was at the edge now. Where the last thread came in. Where the iron rings had been, a moment ago, the last of them, black, closing round the silver.

The rings were gone. Falling. Into the dark. Ringing as they went. A long way down.

And the thread they'd been closed round was grey. And pale. And thin. And going.

Caddoc stood at the edge of the glass with one square hand on it.

On the thread. His road. The road he'd climbed for eight months, ring by ring, from the Court to the bottom of the world.

Unwriting under his hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED BACK.

Across the black glass. At the Key. At the white light pouring up out of the Lock. At the grey shape of a man in it, turning the Key, with a plain grey silver crown on his brow.

At Lex. Lying on his back. Bound in iron.

"*Smith*," said Caddoc of the Iron Crown.

Lex looked at him.

The iron king lifted his free hand. Slowly. And made a small gesture. A flick. The way you'd flick a fly off a sleeve.

And the chains round Lex let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL AT ONCE. EVERY coil. Every link. Unwinding off him. Falling away. Clattering on the black glass. Ringing.

He was free.

Across the glass, Antho's chains fell too. Lex heard them. Ringing. Clattering.

He sat up.

He looked at Caddoc.

"*Why*?" he said.

The iron king looked at him for a long moment.

"*I'm not cruel*," said Caddoc. "*I keep saying.*" A pause. "*Thorne said nobody who isn't cruel keeps saying it.*" The corner of his mouth twitched. "*I thought I'd better prove it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THREAD WENT.

Under his hand. The last of it. At the edge of the glass. Grey. Pale. Thin as a hair. Thinner than a thought.

Gone.

And Caddoc of the Iron Crown, standing at the edge of the black glass with his hand on nothing, looked across the lid of the world one more time.

At the crown on Elric's brow.

"*Hesper's*," he said.

And nodded.

Once.

The way he'd nodded at her on the shingle. Nine hundred years ago. In chains. As if she'd won a game he hadn't known they were playing.

And stepped back.

Off the edge.

Into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T HEAR HIM fall.

There was nothing to hear. No cry. No shout. No crash. He stepped off the edge of the black glass into the dark where his road had been, and the dark took him the way the sea takes a stone.

Down.

Very far down.

Lex sat on the glass and looked at the place where he'd been. At the edge. At the dark.

I'm not cruel. I'm only certain.

He kept his word, Lex thought. *He gave it to his brother and he kept it. All the way down the thread. To the end.*

And then the thread wasn't there anymore. And there was nothing left to keep it to.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WHITE LIGHT WAS going.

Lex turned. Back to the Key.

The light pouring up out of the Lock was thinning. Dimming. Not going out. *Drawing in*. Back down into the slot in the black glass. The way water draws back down a drain.

And Elric was going with it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS STILL THERE. A man. Grey. Faint. With his hand—his strand of thread—on the bow of the Key. With the plain grey silver crown on his brow.

But he was thinning.

From the edges. From his feet. From his hands. The grey of him unwinding. The way the last thread had unwound. Strand by strand. Drawn down into the Key. Into the Lock. Into the white. Into the place where things are made.

Whoever turns it last goes with what it unwrites.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Elric*," said Lex.

He was on his knees. On the glass. He didn't know when he'd got there. On his knees by the Key with his hands out. Not touching. He couldn't. He'd go with it.

"*Lad*," said Elric.

He looked down at Lex. From the white. With his storm-grey eyes. With his face going faint.

"*It's all right*," he said. "*It doesn't hurt. Iron was right. It's very quick.*" He looked at his own hands. Thinning. Unwinding. "*It feels like—*"

He stopped.

He thought about it. Lex could see him think about it. The way Arion used to think about things. Carefully. From several angles.

"*It feels like sitting down*," said Elric Thorne. "*After standing for a very long time.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Tell Quill—*" he said.

Lex waited.

"*No*," said Elric. "*He's a raven. He won't care.*" A dry sound. A laugh. Fading. "*He never forgave me for the name.*"

"*He's got a nest of spoons*," said Lex. "*On the Forge chimney. He's very happy.*"

"*Good*," said Elric. "*Good. That's good.*" He was so faint now. Lex could barely see him. A grey shape. A crown. Two storm-grey eyes. "*Tell him I'm sorry about the name anyway.*"

"*I will.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And your father*," said Elric.

His face was nearly gone. Just the eyes. Just the crown. Just the voice, thin as the last thread.

"*He's waiting*," said Elric Thorne. "*On the other side. He said. Where the light's on.*" The eyes were very bright. "*He saved me a seat.*"

"*In front*?" said Lex.

He didn't know why he said it. It came out of him. The old question. The old wound.

The grey eyes looked at him.

And crinkled. At the corners. The way they used to, in the Ashbourne forge, when Lex got a rune right.

"*Beside*," said Elric.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND WENT.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT ALL AT ONCE. Not like a candle going out. The last of the grey drawn down into the Key, gently, the way the last of a tide draws back off a beach. The storm-grey eyes. The voice. The shape.

Gone.

Into the white. Into the place where things are made.

First.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE CROWN FELL.

Lex watched it. The plain grey silver circle, with nothing under it anymore. Hanging in the air for a moment above the Key. Where a head had been.

And dropping.

Onto the black glass. Beside the Lock. With a sound like a small bell struck once.

Ting.

Slightly off. A little crooked.

Like a bell with a bent clapper.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEY BROKE.

Lex heard it. A crack. Sharp. Bright. Like ice. Like a pane in the first frost.

And the black iron in the Lock came apart.

Into three pieces. The way it had been made. Bow, bit and blade. Fitted together so cleanly you couldn't see the joins, nine hundred years ago, by a man with a little hammer.

Coming apart.

The blade first. Sliding up out of the slot in the glass. Then the bit. Then the bow. Three pieces of black iron, lying on the black glass beside the empty Lock.

And the Lock closed.

The slot in the glass. Where the Key had stood. *Healing*. Smoothing over. The way water closes over a dropped stone. Until there was nothing there at all but black glass, smooth and cold, a mile across, at the bottom of the world.

No Lock. No Key. No slot for a ward.

Done.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILENCE.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT SILENCE. THE THREADS. Four million, one hundred and six thousand, three hundred and eleven of them.

Humming.

One fewer than before.

The last one, gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX KNELT ON THE black glass and didn't move.

Antho came. Across the glass. Barefoot. With the chains clattering off him behind. He knelt down beside Lex. And didn't say anything.

They knelt there together.

Two brothers. At the bottom of the world. In front of a smooth black glass where a Key had been. With three pieces of black iron and a plain grey silver crown lying on the glass in front of them.

And the Lockward. A few paces off. Where Caddoc had set it down. Gently. Grey. Notched like a mountain range. *STAY*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He went first*," said Antho. Very quietly.

"*He went first*."

"*Father's waiting for him*."

"*Beside*," said Lex. "*He said beside.*"

Antho looked at him.

"*I don't know what it means*," said Lex. "*I think Father told him. On the way. When the Ferryman stopped.*" He looked at the smooth black glass. "*I think it was theirs. Not ours.*"

"*Then let them have it*," said Antho Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PICKED UP THE pieces.

He didn't know why. He reached out. On the black glass. And picked up the bow of the Key. The broad open loop of black iron. Cold. Heavy.

Then the bit. Notched. Toothed.

Then the blade.

He held them in his hands. Three pieces of black iron. A key that had been made to unweave the world, and had been turned for the last time, and had broken into the shape it was made in.

He was a smith.

He knew what you did with broken iron.

You kept it.

You kept it until you knew what it wanted to be next.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT THEM IN the basket. In the straw. Beside the last three Hush-cups.

Antho picked up the crown.

He held it in both his scarred hands. A plain grey silver circle. Seven blunt points. Cold.

"*It's quiet*," he said.

Lex looked at him.

"*The no*," said Antho. "*It's still there. I can feel it. Inside. Like before. Holding.*" He turned the crown in his hands. "*But it's quieter. It's not saying it to anyone now.*" A pause. "*It said it. To the net. The thing it was kept nine hundred years to say.*"

"*Is it done*?"

His brother looked at the crown for a long time.

"*No*," he said. "*I don't think so. I think it's resting.*" He put it in the basket. Gently. In the straw. Beside the three pieces of the Key. "*I think it might have one more no in it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 98 → 99
"He let someone else go first."
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT IT until it faded.

Ninety-nine.

The top of Tier IV. As high as you could go. As high as anyone had gone since Aurelian.

There was nothing after ninety-nine. Not in the net. Not as far as anyone knew.

Except the crown in the road.

He didn't want it.

He put his hand on the basket. On the lid. Over the three pieces of black iron and the plain grey crown. And left it there.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...smith...]

Behind them. The soft dark mouth of Mal's room. Open at the edge of the glass. Shaking.

[...smith, come UP...]

He turned.

[...something's happening...] said the seventh Well. Very small. Very frightened. *[...at the EDGE...far away...where the grey curtain was...I can feel it...]*

What?

[...it's FALLING...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT THEN.

Through the glass. Through the threads. Through the four million, one hundred and six thousand, three hundred and eleven of them, humming.

Far away. At the very edge of everything. Where the last thread had run out to.

A curtain. Grey. Nine hundred years old.

With nothing holding it up.

Coming down.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE PANEL.

Not his. Not small, in the corner. *Everyone's*. Lex knew it the way he'd known the others. The World Notices. *THE SEVENTH WELL HAS COME HOME. A SOVEREIGN HAS RISEN.*

In every Stone. In every village. In every panel in the world, at once.

◆ ◆ ◆

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▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓
THE KEY OF SHADOWS HAS BEEN TURNED
FOR THE LAST TIME.
"By a hand that wore a crown that
 said no."
```

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▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓
THE VEIL HAS FALLEN.
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◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT IT for a long time.

At the black glass. At the smooth place where the Key had been. At the dark at the edge where a square dark man had stepped off into nothing, nodding.

At the basket on the glass beside him. With three pieces of iron and a crown in the straw.

"*It's Lantern Night*," he said.

Antho looked at him.

"*Up there*," said Lex. "*Right now. It's Lantern Night. Everyone's lighting lanterns. For the lost.*" His voice was very strange. "*And the Veil's falling.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*And they're coming*," said Lex Vey. "*All of them. The King. The Glass Queen. Rhosyn, in chains. Nine thousand people with their doors bricked up, saying home.*" He looked at the dark. "*Every dead thing that's drifted in that country for nine hundred years.*"

"*Yes*," said Antho.

"*And Mal's still little*."

"*Yes*," said his brother.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD UP.

He picked up the basket. He put it on his back. It was heavy. Heavier than before. Three pieces of iron and a crown.

He looked at his brother.

"*It's her birthday*," he said.

Antho looked at him.

"*Lark*," said Lex. "*She's one. Tonight.*" He swallowed. "*I told her I'd try to be back.*"

His brother stood up too.

"*Then let's go and try*," said Antho Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED BACK ACROSS the black glass.

To the soft dark mouth at the edge. To Mal's room. Shaking. Waiting.

Lex looked back once.

At the lid of the world. A mile of smooth black glass. Cold. Empty. With a grey stone notched like a mountain range lying on it, where a square dark man had set it down gently because it deserved to be set down gently.

STAY, said the last rune. Near the hilt.

It had stayed. Three years. Longer than anyone thought it could.

He left it there.

Somebody should keep the Knot.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STEPPED INTO THE dark.

And the dark closed round them, warm and soft and frightened. And lifted.

[...all right...] said Mal. *[...all right...I've got you...we're going up...]*

[...I'm frightened...]

I know, thought Lex.

[...the curtain's falling...]

I know.

[...they're coming...the ones who drank me...]

I know, thought Lex Vey. *And we'll be there. When they come. All of us. You won't be on your own*.

The seventh Well was quiet for a long time. Carrying them up. Through the dark. Toward a pool in a green field under snow, with a girl on a crutch and a boy in a blue coat sitting on the rim.

[...promise...] it said at last.

I'll try, thought Lex.

[...that's what the old man said...]

I know.

[...he meant it...]

I know, thought Lex. *So do I.*

CHAPTER 37

Lantern Night

LARK WOULDN'T GO TO sleep.

Wren tried. At dusk. In the cottage. With the fire banked and the candle in the east window and the baby in her cradle under the loft window with the horseshoe nail turning slowly on its red ribbon overhead.

"*Sleep*," said Wren.

"*No*," said Lark.

She was sitting up in the cradle. She'd learned to do that in the summer, in a barn above Thistledown, and she'd been doing it ever since, at every opportunity, with the expression of someone who has discovered that the world is much more interesting from higher up.

She was looking at the window.

At the soaped glass. At the faint gold glow coming through it from outside. From the clearing. From the ring of lanterns round the grave by the stream.

"*Sleep*, *love*," said Wren. "*It's late.*"

"*No*," said Lark.

And pulled herself up. On the edge of the cradle. On her square fists. And stood there. Swaying. With her face pressed to the soaped glass.

Looking at the lights.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN GAVE UP.

She wrapped the baby in every blanket she owned and carried her down the ladder and out of the door and across the stepping stones in the dark, with the stream running black and loud under her feet. To the clearing. To the lanterns.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WERE MORE OF them now.

The twenty from the morning were still there. Still lit. Round the grave in the snow. Iron and tin and clay and a turnip. Hollis Penn had stayed to keep them filled. He was sitting on the cart's tailboard with a jug of oil and a taper, going round them one by one, every hour, his breath smoking in the cold.

And others.

People had come up the track all afternoon. From Ashbourne. From Thistledown. From the farms in the Vale that hadn't emptied when the King came down. In ones and twos. With lanterns.

They didn't say much. They came into the clearing in the dusk and set their lanterns down. In the snow. Round the grave. Along the stream. On the oak ramp of the blue-door cottage. In the windows.

And lit them.

For Arion. From the Thistledown mill.

For Arion Vey. He fixed our roof. Once. Thirty years ago. I never paid him.

For the Warden-Architect. From the Ashbourne Forge. All of us.

That one was a lantern Wren had never seen. Iron. Big. Clumsy. With twenty-three different hands' work in it, every rivet a different size. The students. Who'd gone east with their families when the King came down, and come back for Lantern Night. They'd made it in the long hall in the afternoon, Tilda told her. With Brannoc swearing. With Tilda holding the tongs in her one good hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WHOLE CLEARING WAS lit.

Wren stood at the edge of it with the baby on her chest and looked.

Hundreds. Gold. Small. In the snow. On the ramp. Along the stream, so the black water was full of little gold reflections, rippling. In every window of both cottages. Round the gold birch, which shone. Round the gold woodpile. Round the gold cart. Up the gold path through the birch wood, where somebody had set them all the way to the top of the hill, so you could see the line of them going up and up into the dark like stars on a string.

And in the middle, round a grey stone by the stream, the first twenty.

ARION VEY.

He tried.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK LAUGHED.

Wren felt it. Through the blankets. The jerk. The breath. The small body going stiff with delight.

And then the laugh. Not loud. Not the wind laugh. Small. Astonished. Like someone who has never seen so many lights in one place and thinks they've all been lit for her.

"*It's your birthday*," said Wren. Very quietly. Into the dark fluff of hair. "*You're one. Did you know?*"

Lark didn't know. Lark was looking at the lights.

"*A year ago tonight*," said Wren, "*I was lying on a heap of black rubble at the bottom of a hill with my back against a stone. And the whole world was coming home round us. And your da was holding a Moth Queen off with fire. And your grandma was walking toward her with a lamp.*" Her voice cracked. "*And you came. In the middle of all of it. And screamed once. And stopped.*"

Lark reached out.

One square fist. Toward the nearest lantern. On the snow. A tin one. With a little gold flame behind its glass.

"*No*," said Wren. Catching the fist. "*Hot.*"

"*No*," agreed Lark. Seriously.

And reached for the next one.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WAS BY THE grave.

She'd been there since dusk. Sitting on a stool Brannoc had brought out from the cottage. In her bare feet. In the blue dress. With a shawl round her shoulders and her hands in her lap.

With a bundle in her lap. Wrapped in a cloth. Square. Small.

She hadn't unwrapped it.

Wren went and sat down beside her. On the snow. With the baby.

Seren didn't look at her. She was looking at the grave. At the grey stone. At the twenty lanterns round it.

"*He'd have hated this*," she said.

Wren looked at her.

"*All of it*," said Seren. "*All these people. All these lanterns. All this fuss.*" A small crooked smile. "*He'd have stood at the window with his hands behind his back and said, it's very kind, but really, there's no need.*"

"*And then*?"

"*And then he'd have gone round every one*," said Seren Harrow. "*And read every tag. And remembered every name. And written them all down in a grey book in a column.*" Her voice cracked. "*And cried. Where nobody could see.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

OLD MAG WAS ON the cart.

Beside Hollis Penn. On the tailboard. Wrapped in three shawls with her cat in her lap. She'd refused to go home at dusk. She'd said she was ninety-six and she'd go home when she liked.

She was looking at the baby.

"*There's that face*," she said. Cackling. Softly. "*The cheated-at-market face. She's got it now. Look.*"

Lark was frowning at a lantern that Hollis Penn had just refilled. As if she suspected it of something.

"*She's one*," said Wren.

"*She's one*," agreed Old Mag. "*And she's going to be impossible. You'll see.*" The one black eye glittered. "*She's going to say no to everyone. Teachers. Kings. Dragons. Her own grandchildren.*"

"*She already has*," said Wren. "*Said it to a king. Her first word.*"

Old Mag looked at her.

Then she laughed. So loud the cat jumped off her lap.

"*Good*," she said. "*Oh, good. That's my girl.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL CAME AT MIDNIGHT.

Up the track. Through the birch wood. On foot. Alone. With her red hair wild and full of snow and her boots worn through and her face burned red and raw by four days of wind.

With a small fire in her hand.

Not burning. Just lit. Held up. Like a lamp. Like a torch in a doorway.

She stopped at the edge of the clearing.

She looked at the lanterns. At the grave. At Wren.

"*I'm late*," said Kestrel Varn.

"*You're not late*," said Wren.

"*I am. I know I am.*" Kestrel looked at the grave again. At the grey stone. "*I could feel it. On the road. Two nights ago. Something going out. Like a fire banked down to nothing.*" She swallowed. "*I walked faster. I didn't stop. I walked through the passes in the dark.*" Her voice broke. "*I'm late.*"

Wren stood up.

With the baby. And went across the snow. And put her arm round Kestrel.

"*You walked the whole way*," said Wren. "*Holding a fire up. So I'd remember.*"

"*You were supposed to see it*," said Kestrel. Into her shoulder. "*From the air. So you'd know the way home.*"

"*I saw it*," said Wren Ashdown. "*I looked back. Once. At the top. I saw it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL SET HER FIRE down.

At the foot of the grave. In the snow. Not in a lantern. Just a flame. Small. Gold. Burning on nothing. The way unlatticed fire burns, that nobody ever taught to need a wick.

For Arion, said Kestrel. *From the walk.*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE WEST went white.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN SAW IT FIRST.

She didn't know why. She was standing at the edge of the clearing with her arm round Kestrel and the baby on her chest, and she was facing west, and she saw it.

Over the birch wood. Over the gold path going up the hill with its string of lanterns. Over the Vale. Over the downs.

The horizon.

It had been dark. Midnight dark. Winter dark. Stars over it.

It went *pale*.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT LIGHT. NOT DAWN. Not fire. Not gold.

Pale.

A line. Along the whole western edge of the sky. From north to south. As far as she could see. Low down. Where the downs met the stars. Going pale. Grey. Silver. The colour of a curtain seen from very far away, through a window, in the dark.

Moving.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What—*" said Kestrel.

Everyone in the clearing had turned west. Seren on her stool. Old Mag on the cart. Hollis Penn with his jug of oil. Brannoc and Hedda by the ramp. Tilda. The students. The people from Ashbourne and Thistledown and the farms. All of them looking at the pale line on the edge of the sky.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS FALLING.

Wren didn't know how she knew. It was two hundred miles off. Further. At the edge of the world. She couldn't see it. Not really. Just a paleness. A line.

But she saw it fall.

Slowly. The way a cloth falls when someone lets go of the corners. The way a curtain falls when the rope that holds it up is cut. Down. From the top. The pale line on the horizon sinking. Sinking. Drawing down out of the stars like a blind being lowered.

And as it went, behind it—

◆ ◆ ◆

GOLD.

Faint. So faint. A glow. Low. On the very edge of the world. Where the pale curtain had been. Warm. Dull. Like old brass. Like a coin at the bottom of a well.

Spreading along the whole western sky as the curtain came down.

The grey country.

On the other side of nothing at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE WIND.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME FROM THE west.

Wren felt it coming before it got there. She was a Mistwalker. She felt wind the way other people feel heat. A pressure. A movement. A great soft rolling shove of air, coming across two hundred miles of winter dark from the edge of the world.

It hit the clearing.

Not hard. Not a gale. *Soft*. Enormous and soft. Like a sigh. Like the breath a sleeper lets out when they finally lie down after standing a very long time.

It went through the birch wood. Through the clearing. Through the lanterns.

They didn't go out.

Wren watched them. Every flame in the clearing bending. Leaning. All together. East. Away from the wind. The way grass leans. And then standing up again.

Not one went out.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE WIND SMELLED of something.

Dust. Old dust. The dust of a closed room. Of a hall nobody had walked through in nine hundred years.

And under it, faint—

Roses.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN'S PANEL CAME UP.

She never called it. She hadn't looked at it since the summer. It came up on its own, in front of her face, in the dark, in the clearing, in gold letters.

And everyone else's.

She saw them. All round the clearing. Every face lit. Gold. Panels hanging in the air in front of them. Seren's. Brannoc's. Old Mag's, in front of her one black eye, which she was squinting at as if it had insulted her.

The same words. In every one.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓
THE KEY OF SHADOWS HAS BEEN TURNED
FOR THE LAST TIME.
"By a hand that wore a crown that
 said no."
```

```
▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓
THE VEIL HAS FALLEN.
```

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The clearing was silent. Hundreds of people. Hundreds of lanterns. Standing in the snow in the dark at the end of the Vale, looking at gold words hanging in the air.

A hand that wore a crown that said no.

Wren looked at it.

Elric, she thought. *It was Elric. He wore it. Lex said he would. He said he'd worked it out*.

He went first.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He did it*," said Seren.

Very quietly. From her stool by the grave. With the bundle in her lap.

"*Elric*," she said. "*He wore her crown. And turned it. And went.*" She was looking at the panel in front of her face. At the gold words. "*Arion said he would. In the spring. At the bottom of the world.*" Her voice was very steady. "*He said, you'd go first. Wouldn't you.*"

"*And the Veil's gone*," said Brannoc. Hoarsely.

"*And the Veil's gone*," said Seren Harrow.

She looked west. At the gold glow on the edge of the sky.

"*And they're coming*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY ANSWERED.

The panels faded. One by one. The gold words going out like lanterns snuffed. Until there was only the clearing again. The snow. The dark. The hundreds of small gold flames, standing up straight again after the wind.

And in the west, on the very edge of the world, that glow.

Gold. Faint. Warm.

Like metal in a crucible. Just before it pours.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK LAUGHED.

Wren looked down.

Her daughter was looking west too. Over Wren's shoulder. Out of the blankets. At the gold glow on the edge of the sky.

And laughing.

Not frightened. Not crying. Laughing. The way she'd laughed at the gold dust in the cellar. At the Glass Queen in the stream. At the biggest man in the world, kneeling on the floor of her grandmother's cottage, holding out his hand.

"*Oh*, *love*," said Wren. "*Oh, it's not for you. It's not a lantern.*"

Lark laughed harder.

"*No*," said Lark.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T SLEEP.

Wren didn't try to make her. She sat by the grave with Seren and the baby in her lap, in the snow, wrapped in every blanket, and Lark sat up in her arms and looked at the lights.

The lanterns in the clearing. The string of them going up the gold path. The gold glow on the edge of the world.

She didn't make a sound. She looked. With her grey-green eyes enormous. For hours.

At three in the morning she frowned at the west and said, very firmly, "*No.*"

At four she put her fist in her mouth.

At five she fell asleep. Suddenly. All at once. The way she did everything. Mid-frown. Heavy and warm against Wren's chest.

And at six—

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN HEARD THEM BEFORE she saw them.

Wings. Over the birch wood. In the grey before dawn. The great slow beat of something enormous. And the quicker beat of something smaller beside it.

From the west.

She stood up.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN IN the high pasture above the birch wood.

Wren didn't see them land. She was already running. Up the hill. Through the birches. The green ones. Bare. With snow in the forks. Not the gold path. Past it. Beside it. With the string of lanterns going up beside her on the left, gold, and the baby asleep on her chest.

She came out at the top of the wood.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

VHARUUN. IN THE SNOW. Enormous. Bronze and copper and old gold. With his great head down on his forelegs and his eyes shut and his breath steaming.

Ashka beside him. Smaller. Blue-grey. Curled.

And two figures.

Standing in the snow between the dragons. In the grey light. Barefoot. Both of them.

One thin. Tall. With long black hair and a wild beard. With a gold patch on the back of his left hand.

One big. Broad-shouldered. With dark curly hair cut badly and a grey-gold handprint on his left cheek.

And a basket on his back.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED ROUND AND saw her.

He didn't move. He stood in the snow in the high pasture in the grey before dawn and looked at her. At the woman with red hair standing at the top of the birch wood with a baby asleep on her chest.

His face—

Wren had seen it do a lot of things. In seven years. On a hundred rooftops. In the gold room at Avaloria. On the rubble of Duskhold with their daughter coming.

She'd never seen it like this.

Empty. That was the first thing. Something gone out of it. Something that had always been there, behind his eyes, the way a fire's always there at the back of a room.

And then full. All at once. Of something else.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT TO HIM.

Across the snow. Not running now. Walking. The tracker's walk. Fast and light and steady.

She stopped in front of him.

"*It's still her birthday*," said Wren Ashdown.

He looked at her.

"*She didn't go to sleep*," said Wren. "*Not till five. She sat up all night looking at the lanterns.*" Her voice cracked. "*She said no to the Veil. At three in the morning. Very firmly.*"

Lex made a sound.

"*It's still her birthday*," said Wren again. "*Till she wakes up. That's the rule. I just made it.*" She held out her arms. With the baby in them. "*You're not late.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK HER.

Slowly. Carefully. The way he'd taken her the first time, on the rubble, three minutes old. Both hands. Under her. Lifting her off Wren's chest.

She didn't wake.

She lay in his arms. Heavy. Warm. Asleep. With her fist curled against her mouth and her fluff of dark hair standing up like a bird's crest and her face screwed up in the frown she frowned even in her sleep.

He looked at her for a long time.

"*Happy birthday*," said Lex Vey. Very quietly. So as not to wake her.

Her fist moved. In her sleep. Out from her mouth. Up. And found the front of his shirt. And closed round it.

And held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO CAME AND STOOD beside them.

He didn't say anything. He looked at the baby. Then at Wren.

Then he put his arms round both of them. Round Lex and the baby. Round Wren. All three. In the snow. In the high pasture. In the grey before dawn.

And held on too.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He went first*," said Lex.

Wren looked at him.

"*Elric*," said Lex. Hoarsely. Not looking up from the baby. "*He wore the crown. He turned it. The net offered him everything. Every thread. First. Forever.*" He swallowed. "*And he said no. Himself. Out loud. Not me. Not ever.*"

"*I know*," said Wren. "*It was in the notice. A hand that wore a crown that said no.*"

"*And then he went*," said Lex. "*With the thread. With the Veil. Into the place where it was made.*" His voice was very strange. "*He said it felt like sitting down. After standing for a long time.*"

Wren didn't say anything.

"*He said beside*," said Lex. "*At the end. He said Father saved him a seat. Beside.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And Caddoc*," said Antho.

Wren looked at him.

"*Fell*," said Antho. "*With the thread. When it went. He was standing on it. At the edge.*" He looked west. At the gold glow on the edge of the sky, fading now, a little, as the grey came up in the east. "*He let us go first. Took the chains off. Said he wasn't cruel.*" A pause. "*Then he nodded at the crown. And stepped back.*"

"*Nodded*?"

"*Hesper's*, he said," said Antho Vey. "*And nodded. The way he nodded at her on the shingle.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN.

Through the birch wood. Lex with the baby. Wren beside him. Antho behind, with the basket now, because Lex couldn't carry both.

Down. Toward the clearing. Toward the stream. Toward the lanterns.

Lex stopped at the edge of the trees and looked. At the clearing at Harrow. In the grey dawn. Full of small gold flames. In the snow. On the ramp. Along the stream. In every window. Round the gold birch. Up the gold path behind him. Hundreds of them.

At the people. Standing in the snow. Turning. Looking up at him.

At the grave by the stream. With twenty lanterns round it. And a small fire burning on nothing at its foot.

ARION VEY.

He tried.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*They came*," said Lex.

"*They came*," said Wren. "*All afternoon. All night. From everywhere.*" She looked at the clearing. "*For Arion. From the Thistledown mill. He fixed our roof once. From the Kettle, he never paid his tab.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

He stood at the edge of the birch wood with his daughter asleep in his arms and looked at the lanterns for a long time.

[They liked him,] he thought. In the dry voice. In the shape.

I know.

[Nobody ever knows till Lantern Night.]

I know now, thought Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN WAS STANDING UP.

By the grave. Beside her stool. In the blue dress. In her bare feet. With a bundle in her arms.

She was looking at him.

He went down to her.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED AT HIM. At his face. At the baby in his arms. At the basket on Antho's back.

At the empty place behind his eyes.

"*It's gone*," she said. Very quietly. "*Isn't it. All of it. You can't hear anything.*"

"*No*."

"*It went with him*," said his mother. "*In the lantern. On the boat. Gold.*" She swallowed. "*It said, tell him I'll be in the main text. Chapter forty.*"

"*I know*," said Lex. "*Antho told me.*"

Seren looked at him for a long time.

"*I said I'd wait*," she said. "*Till you were standing here.*"

She held up the bundle.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE UNWRAPPED IT.

Slowly. In the grey dawn. By the grave. With the lanterns all round in the snow and everyone in the clearing watching.

The cloth came off.

A lantern.

Small. Iron. Plain. With four panes of horn, scraped thin, so you could see light through them but nothing else. The way lanterns were made in the old days. Before glass. Before there was enough glass in the world for a Queen to live in.

He'd made it in the spring. At the little forge in the lean-to. Late. When he couldn't sleep. After Ysenne came through the window. After he made the first hornlight.

In case I'm not back.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN TURNED IT OVER.

To look at the base. Where he always cut the word. Where only someone who picked it up would see it.

She looked at it.

And her face—

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN SAW IT.

She'd seen Seren's face do a great many things. In the cellar. At the blue door. At the Hall of Lanterns. In the bed two nights ago, with her hand on a still chest.

She'd never seen this.

It didn't break. It didn't light. It *opened*. All of it. All at once. Like a door with the wind blowing through it. Like a window flung wide on the first warm morning of spring.

And then it crumpled.

Seren Harrow sat down in the snow by her husband's grave with the little iron lantern in her lap and put her face in her hands and laughed and cried at the same time, so hard she couldn't breathe.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN LOOKED AT THE lantern.

At the base of it. Turned up. In Seren's lap.

Two words. Cut into the iron. In Lex's big clumsy careful hand. The hand of a man who'd learned his letters at a kitchen table at Harrow and then from nobody, and still made them the way you'd make a weld.

TOO LATE

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T UNDERSTAND. NOT at first. She stood in the snow with Lex beside her holding the baby and looked at the two words.

Then she did.

Page nine.

The letter. The forty-page one. That Seren had read eleven times, twelve, a hundred. That Wren had heard her read aloud by the fire, some nights, in the blue-door cottage, with Arion pretending to sleep.

Don't ever leave a light on for me, Warden.

Too late.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I read it*," said Lex. Very quietly. "*The letter. In the spring. Before I left. Mam was asleep and it was on the table.*" He looked at his mother. Sitting in the snow. "*I wasn't supposed to. I read page nine.*"

Seren lifted her face out of her hands.

"*I thought*," said Lex, "*if I wasn't back. If he—*" He stopped. "*I thought, somebody should leave a light on for him. On Lantern Night. In the west window. Facing the road.*" His voice cracked. "*Even though he told everyone not to. Even though he said there was no need.*"

"*Too late*," said Seren.

"*Too late*," said Lex Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HELD IT UP.

The little iron lantern. With its four horn panes. To him.

"*Light it*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE GAVE WREN THE baby.

Carefully. Lark didn't wake. She went back onto Wren's chest with her fist still curled, and settled, and frowned.

Lex knelt down. In the snow. By the grave. By his mother.

He took the lantern from her.

He opened the little iron door on the side. There was a wick inside. Twisted cotton. Soaked in tallow. New. He'd put it in, in the spring, ready.

He held his hand over it.

And let the fire come up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SMALL. GOLD. THE WAY it came every morning when he knelt at the hearth.

Good morning, said the fire.

He didn't hear it. Not in words. He never had. A warmth. A lift. A small bright gladness.

The wick caught.

And the lantern lit.

Soft. Gold. Blurred behind its four panes of horn. Like a lantern in a fog. Like a light left on in a mist.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

He carried it to the blue-door cottage. Up the oak ramp. Through the door. Into the dim room. Past the table under the west window with the chipped blue cup on it. Past the empty bed with the curtain drawn back. Past the other Lantern, on the table beside the bed, three panes of glass and one of horn, still burning, because nobody had thought to put it out.

To the west window.

The boards were down. The glass was soaped. One pane wiped clear, where Wren had set her candle the morning before.

He set the lantern on the sill.

Beside the candle. Facing out. Facing west. Facing the road. Facing the gold path going up through the birch wood. Facing the grave by the stream. Facing the edge of the world, two hundred miles off, where the gold glow was fading as the sun came up behind him.

TOO LATE, said the base. Where only someone who picked it up would see.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD THERE A long time.

Wren came and stood beside him. With the baby.

Then Seren. In her blue dress. With snow on her bare feet.

Then Antho. With the basket on his back. Three pieces of iron and a crown in the straw.

They stood at the west window of the blue-door cottage, the four of them and the baby, and looked out.

At the clearing. At the lanterns. At the grave. At the people in the snow.

At the dawn coming up behind them, grey and then gold and then pale, the first light of the first day after the edge of the world came down.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's a terrible lantern*," said Seren.

Lex looked at her.

"*It's terrible*," said his mother. Her face was wet. She was smiling. "*The horn's uneven. The hinge is crooked. You've put the door on the wrong side.*" She looked at it.

"He'd have said so. He'd have stood here with his hands behind his back and said, it's very kind, Lex, but the hinge."

"And then?"

"And then he'd have cried," said Seren Harrow. *"Where nobody could see."*

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK WOKE UP.

All at once. The way she did everything. A jerk against Wren's chest. A breath. Her head lifting. Wobbling.

She looked round.

At the window. At the lantern on the sill. At the soft gold blur behind its horn.

At her father.

She looked at him for a long time. With her grey-green eyes. Frowning.

As if she were trying very hard to remember him.

And then she remembered.

He saw it. Wren saw him see it. The frown going out of her face. Not all at once. From the edges in. Like a field going from frost to grass.

And she reached for him.

Both fists. Out of the blankets. Opening and closing.

The way she reached for the nail.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK HER.

She grabbed his nose.

"Ow," said Lex Vey.

"No," said Lark. With enormous satisfaction.

And didn't let go.

EPILOGUE

The Edge of the World

THE GILDED KING WAS standing at the edge of the world when it fell.

He'd walked there. Two nights and a day. West, from a cottage with a blue door, through the snow, down a gold road he'd made himself in the summer, across the Vale and the downs and the shires. Not hurrying. Not slow. Walking the way a man walks away from a house where he has seen something he can't stop seeing.

He didn't stop at any wells.

He didn't sit with anyone.

He walked.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HAD A CUP in his hand.

Lopsided. Too thick. With a thumb-print in the clay near the handle where a smith had pressed too hard. Gold now. All of it. And the tea in it, a gold disc, still. He'd carried it the whole way. In his great gold hand. Very carefully. The way you'd carry a bird's egg.

He didn't know why.

He'd never carried anything for anyone. Orrin carried things. The household carried things. He'd been carried, once, in a boat. In chains.

He carried the cup.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND AGAINST HIS CHEST, inside his robe, over his heart, a crown of silver wire. Fine as frost. Shaped like folded wings.

He'd carried that since he woke.

He carried it still.

◆ ◆ ◆

GREYFALL WAS BEHIND HIM. The east gate. A man standing in it, gold, with snow on his shoulders, with a staff held crosswise. Daxian Roole. Commander of the Keepers of the Stones.

You're not coming through this gate.

He'd walked past him. Again. In the dark. In the snow.

He'd stopped. Just for a moment. And looked.

At the gold face. At the eyes, moving. Slowly. Following him.

Somebody has to stand somewhere.

He'd thought it was beautiful. In the summer. He'd thought, *you should never stop. You should stand there forever. Exactly like that.*

He'd looked at the eyes, moving. Following him past. Saying something he couldn't hear.

He'd walked on faster.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GOLD AT THE foot of the Veil was under snow.

A field. Forty sheep. A boy among them, mid-step, with his crook out and snow on his cap. Further on, a woman sitting on the grey at the edge of the gold. Wrapped in a shawl. With a basket beside her.

She'd come back.

The Keepers had carried her east in the summer. Biting. Kicking. And she'd come back. Alone. In the autumn. When the King had gone. And sat down again at the edge of the gold. And started talking.

She looked up as he passed.

At the biggest man she'd ever seen. Gold. Glowing like metal in a crucible. Walking past her in the snow with a gold cup in his hand.

She didn't say anything.

She went on talking to her son.

He walked past her. And didn't look back.

He wanted to. He didn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE VEIL STOOD IN front of him.

Grey. Hanging from nowhere. Falling to nowhere. Moving very slightly, the way a curtain moves in a room with a window open somewhere behind it.

With a door in it.

Tall. Dark. Wide. Wide enough for a cart. Wide enough for a king. Where two brothers had put their bleeding hands on the edge of the world in the summer, and it hadn't known them, and had opened.

He'd come through it. In the summer. On the day after they went in. Smelling the Harrow on the edges. Laughing.

Thank you, cousins. I've been waiting so long.

He stood in front of it now. In the snow. At midnight. On Lantern Night.

And waited.

◆ ◆ ◆

FOR CAD.

That was the plan. It had always been the plan. Since the hall. Since the four of them woke in their silk and stood under the empty cocoons and he said *the Key*.

Cad would climb the last thread. Ring by ring. To the knot at the bottom of the world. On the night they lit their lanterns. And take the bar out. And take the Key.

And bring it here. Up the thread. To the edge. To him.

And he'd turn it.

And pick up the net.

And keep it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD IN FRONT of the door at the edge of the world and thought about that.

He'd thought about it for nine hundred years. In the silk. In the dark. In his dreams. The net in his hands. Every thread. Every child. Every old man in every chair.

Safe.

Kept.

Nobody going through the door. Not ever. Not one. In the whole world.

He'd thought about it with his whole heart. It was the only thing he'd ever wanted.

He stood in the snow with a gold cup in his hand and thought about it.

And thought about an old man on three pillows under a boarded window. With his grey eyes. Saying *you should have gone in. He'd have liked you there.*

And thought about a baby with a fist in her mouth. Saying *no*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT AT midnight.

Under his feet. Through the snow. Through the cracked dead ground of the Sundered Lands. Through the last thread, running deep down under the world from the foot of the Veil to the knot at the bottom.

A turning.

The Key.

He knew it. He'd have known it anywhere. The little man with the hammer had made it the night he wove the world, and the Crowned had felt it made, in their chains, on the shingle, waiting for the boat.

It was turning.

◆ ◆ ◆

Cad, he thought. *Cad's got it. Cad's turning it. Cad's bringing it—*

No.

Cad wouldn't turn it. Cad would bring it. Cad had promised. On the shingle. *I'll go where you go. I'll do what you ask*.

Somebody else was turning it.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HE FELT the *no*.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME UP THE thread.

Out of the bottom of the world. Out of the knot. Up through the dark under the Drowned Country and the Greyspine and the Sundered Lands. Up the last thread. Into the ground under his feet.

Cold. Quiet. Patient. Steady.

Like a hand laid flat on a door.

Not you. Not ever.

He knew it.

He'd felt it on the shingle. Nine hundred years ago. In chains. Looking back at the shore. At a girl of seventeen standing on the grey stones with a crown in her hands and her voice shaking.

He'd felt it in the hall. For thirty-two years. In his sleep. A cool hand on a hot forehead. A quiet he never understood.

He felt it now.

Coming up the last thread from the bottom of the world.

"*Hes*," said Oszric of the Crowned.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THREAD WENT SLACK.

He felt it go. Under his feet. Through the ground. The one high note it had been humming since the world was woven—going flat. Going soft. Going grey.

Going.

And the Veil—

◆ ◆ ◆

IT FELL.

Not like a wall. Walls crash. Walls crack and tumble and break.

It fell like a *cloth*.

The way a cloth falls when someone lets go of the corners. The way a curtain falls when the rope that holds it is cut. From the top. Softly. Slowly. The grey that had hung across the edge of the world for nine hundred years, from nowhere to nowhere, sinking.

Down.

The door in it going with it. The tall dark gap where two brothers had bled. Folding. Crumpling. Sinking into the grey like a mouth closing.

Down.

All along the edge. North and south. As far as he could see. Further. The grey coming down out of the stars like a blind being lowered. Like a sheet drawn off a bed.

He stood in the snow and watched it come down.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THERE WAS A wind.

From behind him. From the east. From the world. A great soft rolling sigh of air, pouring west across the Sundered Lands, across the gold, across the woman by the line and her gold son in his gold field. Into the falling grey.

Through it.

Into the grey country.

The first wind in the Outer Court in nine hundred years.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE GREY COUNTRY breathed out.

He felt it. The wind going in. And something coming back. Dust. Old dust. The dust of a closed room. Of a hall nobody had walked through in nine hundred years. Rolling out of the falling grey on a breath of air, across the snow, past him.

East.

Into the world.

And under it, faint—

Roses.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE VEIL TOUCHED THE ground.

He felt it. A softness. A settling. Like a cloth laid on a table. Like snow landing on snow.

And then it wasn't there.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS NOTHING.

Nothing between him and the grey country. No curtain. No edge. No grey from nowhere to nowhere. Just—*ground*. The cracked dead ground of the Sundered Lands, under snow, running west. And then, without any line at all, without any seam, without anything to say *here is where one stops and the other begins*—

Dust.

Grey-gold. Fine as flour. Lying in drifts. Going on. West. Flat. To the edge of everything.

With a road in it.

White. The white of old bone. Broad. Straight as a ruler. Starting at his feet. At the foot of where the Veil had been. Running away west across the grey-gold plain toward a smudge of towers on the edge of the sky.

Glass. Iron. Gold. Bone.

Home.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D THOUGHT HE'D FEEL—

He didn't know what he'd thought he'd feel.

Triumph. That was what he'd thought. For nine hundred years. In the silk. *When the edge comes down. When we walk back into the world. When nothing stands between us and the light.*

He stood in the snow at the edge of the world with a gold cup in his hand and a crown of silver wire against his heart and looked at the white road running home.

He didn't feel triumph.

He felt *cold*.

Right in the middle.

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMETHING WAS MOVING ON the road.

Far off. At the edge of what he could see. A glitter. Clear. Cold. Like frost on a window. Walking. Toward him. Down the white road out of the grey-gold dim.

And behind it, something else. Thin. Dark. Grey-green. Stumbling.

And a sound.

Chime. *Chime*.

Like glass touching glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

YSENNE CAME DOWN THE white road with her sister on a chain.

He watched her come. Tall. Thin. Clear. Glass, all of her, glittering, with the grey-gold dim and the white road showing through her, bent, as through a lens. With her white hair and her narrow crown of glass.

With a chain in her hand.

Glass. Fine. Links like icicles. Running back from her clear fingers to a pair of thin grey-green wrists.

Rhosyn walked behind her.

Barely walking. Stumbling. Her rotten silk hanging off her. Her crown of thorns crooked. Her face grey. Not grey-green. *Grey*. The colour of ash. Of the inside of a dead tree.

She'd given everything. In the thorns. Every stem. Every root. To hold a thousand gold servants back from a tower long enough for two Harrow boys to run.

She had nothing left.

She walked behind her sister on a chain of glass with her head down and her bare feet dragging in the dust.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOPPED IN FRONT of him.

At the foot of the white road. Where the Veil had been. A yard of snow between the grey-gold dust and his gold feet.

Ysenne looked at him.

With her ice-grey eyes. For a long time.

"*Oz*," she said.

"*Ysy*."

"*It's down*," said the Glass Queen. "*The edge*."

"*Yes*."

"*You didn't turn it*."

"*No*," said Oszric.

She looked at him. At his face. At whatever was in it. She'd always been able to see what was in his face. Since they were children. She'd sit at the mirror and look at him in it, over her shoulder, and tell him what he was thinking.

"*Hes did*," said Ysenne. Very quietly. "*Didn't she. Her crown. On someone's head. Saying no.*"

"*Yes*."

"*I felt it come up the thread*," said the Glass Queen. "*In every piece of glass in the Court. Every pane went cold.*" She looked down at her clear hands. At the chain in them. "*Like a breath on a window.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Where's Cad*?" said Oszric.

Ysenne didn't answer.

She looked past him. East. Into the world. At the snow. At the gold road wandering away across it. At the dark.

"*He fell*," said Rhosyn.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KING LOOKED AT her.

His youngest sister but one. On a chain. With her head down. With her crown of thorns crooked. With her voice like a stem bending.

"*He fell*," she said again. Not looking up. "*With the thread. When it went. He was standing on it. At the bottom.*" Her thin shoulders were shaking. "*I felt him go. Through the roots. Through the ground. All the way down.*"

"*Rosie—*"

"*He nodded*," said the Thorn-Crowned. "*Before he went. I felt that too. The way he nodded at her on the shingle.*" She lifted her head. Her green eyes were wet. "*He kept his word, Oz. All the way down the thread. To the end.*" A pause. "*And then there wasn't any more thread to keep it on.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GILDED KING DIDN'T say anything for a long time.

He stood at the edge of the world. In the snow. With his sisters in front of him on the white road. With a gold cup in one hand and his other hand pressed flat against his chest, over his heart, over a crown of silver wire.

Cad held his hand, he'd said. In the cottage. To the old man. *Every night. At the end. Not saying anything. He was eleven.*

And I stood outside the door.

He'd stood outside every door since.

He'd made nine thousand people stand outside theirs.

And now Cad was gone. Through his own. Into the dark. Nodding.

And he hadn't been there.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oz*," said Ysenne.

He looked at her.

"*They're coming*," said the Glass Queen.

She turned. On the white road. And looked back. West. Down it. Into the grey-gold dim.

He looked too.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEPT WERE WALKING.

All of them. He saw it. Along the white road. On both sides. As far as he could see. Nine thousand of them. Gold. In the grey-gold dust. Cooks and grooms and maids and gardeners. Soldiers with gold spears. Nurses with gold babies. Old men with gold sticks. Children with gold hoops.

Turned.

Every one. Facing east. Facing the edge. Facing where the Veil had been. Facing the world.

And walking.

Scrape. *Scrape*. *Scrape*.

A finger's width. A finger's width. Slow. So slow. Gold feet on white stone. Gold feet in grey-gold dust.

Coming.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Did you—*" he said. "*Ysy, did you tell them—*"

"*No*," said the Glass Queen. "*Orrin didn't. I didn't. Nobody did.*" She looked at them. Nine thousand gold servants walking down the white road toward the edge of the world. "*They just started. When it fell. When the wind came in.*" A pause. "*They felt the wind, Oz. They haven't felt wind in nine hundred years.*"

And under the scraping, the hum.

One note. From nine thousand gold throats. Low. Soft. Worn smooth.

He'd heard it for nine hundred years. In his sleep. In the hall. Walking down the white road past them. He'd never listened.

He listened now.

...home...

◆ ◆ ◆

AT THE FRONT OF them, a long way ahead of the rest, small, in a grey dress too big for her—

A girl.

Gold. With a wooden spoon in her hand.

Walking.

Not like the others. Not a finger's width. More. A step. A real step. Slow. Stiff. Scraping. But a step. And another. Down the white road. Out of the grey-gold dim. Toward him.

Toward the edge.

Toward the world.

Her eyes were moving.

Fast.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNEW HER.

He didn't know how. He hadn't looked at any of them in nine hundred years. He'd walked past them every day and never once looked.

He knew her.

The spit-girl. Ilda. The bread-woman's daughter. She turned the spit in my kitchen. She was eight. She burned her hand on the spit-iron the week before the pool and cried and I gave her a sweet.

I kept her in the first year. When the household started to come apart. When there was nothing left to drink. She was so frightened. She was coming apart in her mother's arms. I put my hand on her forehead—

He stopped.

He stood in the snow and watched a gold girl with a wooden spoon walk down the white road toward him.

And she wasn't looking at him.

She was looking past him. Into the world. East. At something he couldn't see.

At a boy, maybe. In a blue coat. Who'd looked back.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oz*," said Rhosyn.

He looked at her.

She'd sat down. On the white road. On her chain. In the dust. With her thin knees drawn up and her arms round them. Like a girl on the edge of a cabbage bed.

She was looking at the gold girl.

"*She's going home*," said the Thorn-Crowned. Very softly. "*They all are. The hum. That's what it's saying. That's what it's always been saying.*" She looked up at him. "*The warden told me. In the thorns. Home.*"

"*They are home*," said the Gilded King. "*With me. In the Court. Safe.*"

He'd said it in the cottage. To a man in a bed. *They're safe*.

He'd said it to himself every day for nine hundred years.

He said it now. To the snow. To the dark. To the gold girl walking past him.

It didn't sound true anymore.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GIRL REACHED THE edge.

Where the Veil had been. Where the grey-gold dust stopped and the snow began, without any line, without any seam.

She stopped.

Just for a moment. At the place. With one gold foot on the dust and one gold foot lifted. Her eyes on the snow in front of her. White. Cold. Melting where her breath would have been, if she'd had breath.

The first snow she'd seen in nine hundred years.

Then her foot came down.

On the snow.

In the world.

Scrape.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SNOW DIDN'T GO gold.

He saw it. He stood beside her, a yard off, and saw it. The gold foot on the white snow. And the snow under it—

White.

Not gold. Not kept. *White*. Cold. Wet. Melting a little round the edges of the gold foot. The way snow melts round anything that's been standing in the sun.

She was in the world.

And the world wasn't stopping for her.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WALKED ON.

Past him. East. Into the dark. Into the snow. Toward the Sundered Lands. Toward the gold road. Toward a world full of lanterns that were all, he could see now, very faint, on the edge of the eastern sky, every one, lit.

Scrape. *Scrape*.

A gold girl with a wooden spoon. Walking home.

And behind her, down the white road, out of the grey-gold dim, nine thousand more.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DEAD CAME LAST.

He saw them rise. At the edge. Where the Veil had stood. Where they'd lain in drifts for nine hundred years against the foot of the grey, because there was no river for them and no door and nowhere to go.

Bronze. Bone. Copper. Coral.

Four. Rising. Columns of coloured dust. Swaying. In the first wind they'd felt since they came apart.

His cousins. His sisters' husbands. Who'd come apart against the edge on the night the boat came through, because they'd drunk the least and the edge didn't know them and pushed them till they broke.

They rose. And swayed. And turned.

East.

And drifted.

On the wind. Out of the grey country. Into the world. Past him. Past the gold girl. Past the nine thousand. East. Slowly. Like smoke. Like mist. Like the last of a fire going up a chimney.

Toward the lanterns.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND BEHIND THEM, MORE.

He hadn't known. He'd never looked. *Grey*. Thousands. Rising out of the grey-gold dust all over the plain of the Court, as far as he could see. Not coloured. Not his cousins. Just grey. Columns of grey dust. Swaying.

Everyone who'd ever come apart in the Court.

In nine hundred years. In the first years, before he went out with his hands. The ones he hadn't reached in time. The ones who'd crumbled. The ones who'd lain down in the dust and not got up and become the dust.

He'd thought they were dust.

They were rising.

And drifting. East. On the first wind. Toward the edge that wasn't there anymore.

Toward the lanterns.

Toward the room.

◆ ◆ ◆

There is a pool in a green field, the warden had told the four at the edge. In the summer. With his hand out. Rhosyn had heard it. Through the roots. *Full of room. It's still very little.*

When it's bigger. When it's grown. I'll come back.

The dead didn't wait.

They drifted east. Thousands of them. On the first wind in nine hundred years. Toward a green circle a hundred miles across, under snow, with a pool in the middle and three small gold lights at the bottom of it.

And a girl on a crutch.

And a boy in a blue coat.

Sitting on the rim. With their feet over the dark.

Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GILDED KING STOOD at the edge of the world.

In the snow. With a gold cup in his hand and a crown of silver wire against his heart. With his sisters on the white road behind him. One of glass. One on a chain. Sitting in the dust.

With nine thousand gold servants walking past him into the world. Scraping. Humming one word.

With the dead of nine hundred years drifting past him on the wind.

With the lanterns. Every one. On the edge of the eastern sky. Lit. Given.

He stood there a long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oz*," said Ysenne.

He didn't answer.

"*Oz. What do we do?*"

He looked down at the cup in his hand.

Lopsided. Too thick. A thumb-print near the handle. Gold. With a gold disc of tea in it that he'd never be able to taste.

Take it anyway, the hedge-witch had said. Kneeling on her floor. *It's yours. I made it for you. If it goes gold, it goes gold. It's still yours.*

Nobody's ever made me anything.

He looked east.

At the world. At the snow. At the gold girl with the wooden spoon, getting smaller, walking home. At the lanterns.

At a cottage, two hundred miles off, at the end of a valley, with a blue door. And a lantern in its west window, horn-paned, crooked-hinged, lit, with two words cut into the base where only someone who picked it up would see.

He couldn't see it. He couldn't know.

But he looked anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*We go and see everyone*," said Oszric of the Crowned.

He said it the way he'd said it in the hall. When he woke. With Mae's crown in his hand and the crack open in the Veil and green coming through it.

Then we'll go and see everyone.

It didn't sound the same.

He didn't know why. The words were the same. The voice was the same. Deep. Warm. Like a bell.

But something in it had cracked. In the middle. Like a cup with a thumb-print near the handle where somebody pressed too hard.

He stepped across the line.

Off the snow. No. *Onto* it. Out of the grey country. Into the world. Where the Veil had been.

The snow under his foot went gold.

Of course it did. Everything he touched.

He looked at it for a long time.

And walked on anyway.

East.

Toward the lanterns.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE FAR SIDE of the world, at the end of a valley, in a cottage with a birch wood behind it and a stream in front, Lex Vey woke at dawn and the world was quiet.

Inside.

He lay on his back in the loft and listened to the quiet for a long time.

Then he got up. And went down the ladder. And knelt at the hearth.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE WAS BANKED. A heap of grey ash with a red eye in the middle.

He blew on it. Gently. The way you'd wake someone who'd been up all night.

It woke. Flickered. Caught the kindling. Climbed.

Good morning, said the fire.

Not in words. A warmth. A lift. A small bright gladness.

"*Good morning*," said Lex.

He waited.

Nothing.

He'd known there'd be nothing. He'd known it yesterday and the day before. He'd know it tomorrow.

He said it anyway.

It would be rude not to.

◆ ◆ ◆

LARK CAME ACROSS THE floor.

On her hands and knees. Fast. A furious scuttling lurch, like a crab with a grudge. From wherever Wren had put her down. She arrived at the hearth and sat back on her bottom beside him.

And looked at the fire.

He watched her look at it. With her grey-green eyes. With her fist halfway to her mouth. With her fluff of dark hair standing up like a bird's crest.

She didn't reach for it.

She'd learned. *No*. *Hot*.

She just looked. Very seriously. The way she looked at the horseshoe nail on its ribbon every morning. The way she looked at the lanterns all night on her birthday.

As if she were saying good morning to it.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN SHE SAID something.

◆ ◆ ◆

Not *no*. Not her one word.

Something else. Small. Wet. Round. A sound. A babble. The kind of noise a child makes when she's trying a word she's heard and hasn't got the shape of yet.

"*Mo*," said Lark. To the fire. "*Mo. Nn.*"

Lex went very still.

"*Mo-nn*," said his daughter. Frowning at the flames. Working at it. The way he worked at a weld. "*Mmo-ning*."

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T A WORD.

He knew it wasn't. She was one. She had six teeth and a grip like a vice and one word, and the word was *no*. This was a sound. A babble. A baby copying her father,

who knelt at the hearth every morning and said the same thing to the fire, and she'd heard it, and she was trying it.

That was all.

That was all it was.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRE LEANED TOWARD her.

He saw it. The flames. Bending. All together. Toward the small square figure sitting on the hearthstone. The way grass leans. The way a dog leans against your legs.

Glad.

The way it was glad for him every morning. Because it was the Flame. Because it had been burning since before there were people to burn for. Because someone had sat down in front of it and said good morning.

Glad.

That was all.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FOR A MOMENT—

Just a moment—

In the leaning of the flames toward his daughter. In the small bright lift of them. In the warmth coming off the hearth onto her round face.

He thought he heard something.

Not a voice. Not words. Not in the back of his head, where there'd been something for twenty-two years and was nothing now.

In the fire.

Small. Dry. Gentle. Precise. With an old-fashioned courtesy.

Glad.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T MOVE.

He knelt on the hearthstone beside his daughter and didn't breathe.

The fire burned. The flames stood up straight again. Lark frowned at them. And put her fist in her mouth. And looked at her father.

"*No*," she said. Conversationally.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW.

He'd never know. Not for certain. He'd lie awake at night for a long time, after, wondering. Whether it was anything at all. Whether it was a fire being a fire, and a

baby being a baby, and a man who'd lost a voice in his head hearing it where it wasn't, the way you hear a step on the stair in a house where nobody lives anymore.

Probably.

That was probably all it was.

◆ ◆ ◆

BUT HE PICKED UP his daughter.

And sat with her on the hearthstone. In front of the fire. In the grey dawn. In the quiet.

And said it again. Out loud. For her. So she'd learn it. So it would go down. Not in words. In voices.

"*Good morning*," said Lex Vey.

"*Mmo-ning*," said Lark. Through her fist.

And the fire leaned toward both of them.

Glad.

◆ ◆ ◆

Here ends The Sorcerer's Crown, *Book Four of the Lattice Chronicles.*

The story concludes in Book Five, The Sorcerer's Dawn.

THE STORY CONTINUES

Book Five of The Lattice Chronicles
The Sorcerer's Dawn